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Build your own fantasy RPG world with more than 500 ready-to-use locations, factions and NPCs

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NO PLACE LIKE HOMEBREW

Build your own fantasy RPG world with more than 500 ready-to-use locations, factions and NPCs

Written and edited by
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ROLL & PLAY PRESS

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Introduction

There really is NO PLACE LIKE HOMEBREW,

This book is a dream project. I've wanted to create an encyclopedia of ready-to-use worldbuilding content for GMs (and myself) for a long time. Whether you're crafting your own campaign setting or just need a boat, innkeeper, weird shrine or bounty hunter to drop in mid-session, No Place Like Homebrew *has you covered. Feel free to steal any or all of the ideas in the book for your games. I know I will!*

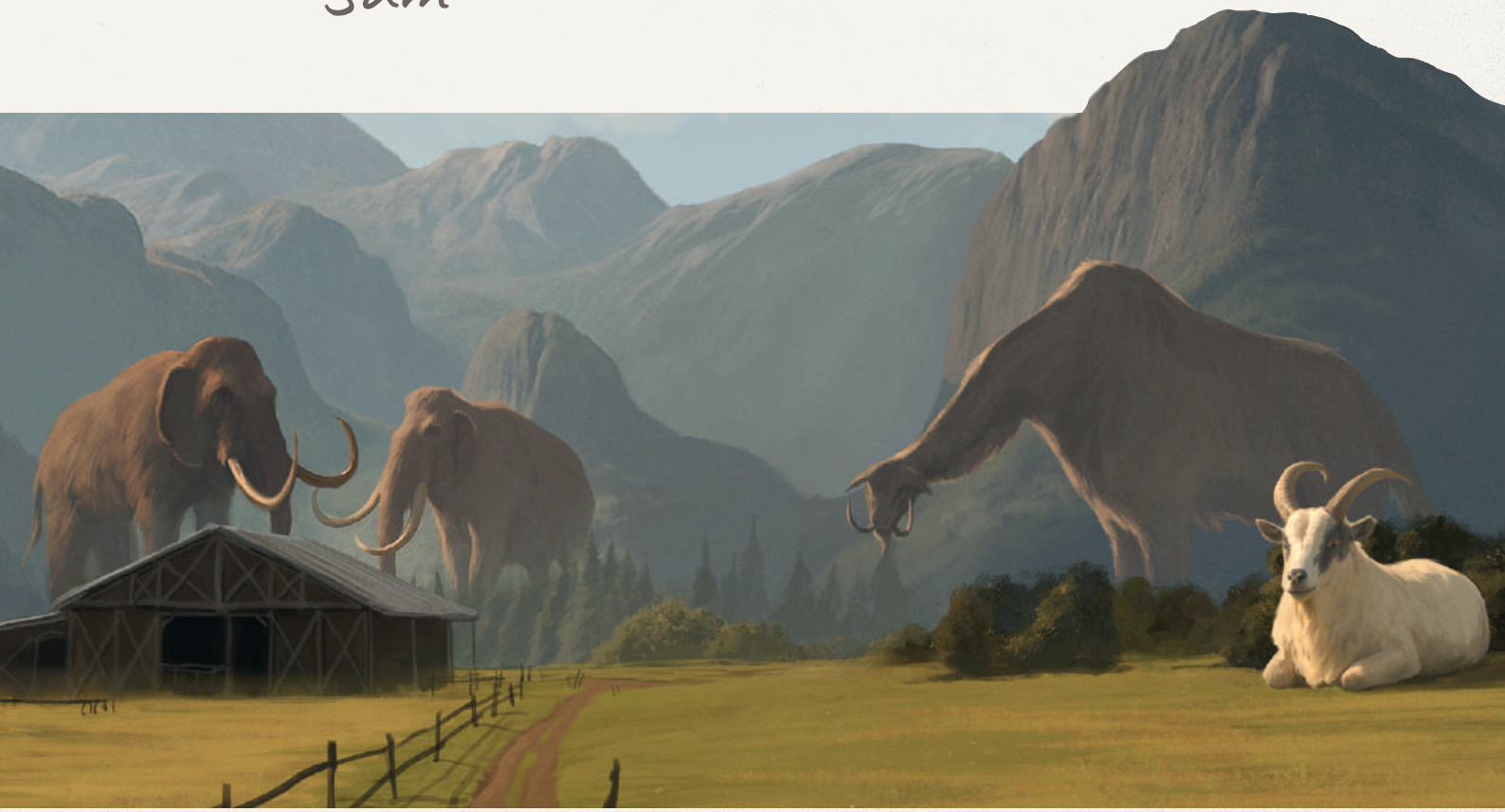
I've always loved worldbuilding. It's one of the most satisfying parts of running an RPG – watching your players explore a place that started as a few messy notes on the back of a napkin grow into something that feels real. But let's be honest, there isn't always time to create inspiring content when you're planning mid-week, and the napkin notes don't always cut it.

That's exactly what this book is for. Over 500 entries of characters, places, factions, buildings, monsters and more, all written and laid out in a way that makes using them feel effortless. We've even suggested 5E stat blocks, and written some brand-new ones too, so you can throw entries straight into your game with minimal prep. And, if you do want to build a world from scratch, the back of the book is packed with advice on how to turn the contents of this book into something completely your own.

However you like to prep, No Place Like Homebrew *is here to help you spend less time staring at that blank page in your notebook and help you spark really cool ideas. I hope it inspires a ton of memorable sessions.*

Let's build a world together!

Sam



To find out what life's like on a farm for giant animals (above), check out Geryon's Ranch on p. 121.

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Using This Book

Want to build a rich, immersive and satisfying world for your homebrew TTRPG adventures? The entries in this book are ready and waiting to be a part of it.

Choose a Path

The book is designed to suit any game master's style, whether you plan every detail up-front or build as your campaign develops. Either way, you can use the Homebrew World Builder on p. 239 to keep track of your notes about your setting.

Predefined World

Start with the big picture: a world map, a pantheon, and even other planes, then zoom in to add major landmarks and settlements. Follow the chapters of the book, narrowing in on the detail of those places, including its inhabitants and threats. This approach is perfect for campaigns with a clearly defined goal, or for parties who love big lore drops and reveals.

Procedural World

Start with a single tavern or village. As your players explore, flick to the relevant pages in the book to fill in the gap. Whether you need a merchant, cave or celestial beast, you can easily find an entry to suit your adventure. This approach keeps session prep light, and is perfect for collaborative sandbox-style games or campaigns that evolve session by session.

Navigating the Page

The top of the page has info about the page theme or chapter name

Every entry has a title, and one-line summary, for quick reference

Colours show what type of entry it is: Characters are PURPLE. Factions are BROWN. Locations are GREEN. Creatures are RED. The entry type is also listed in the keywords.

Entry text is split into short, easy-to-navigate sections

Keywords categorise each entry (see p. 224 for more info)

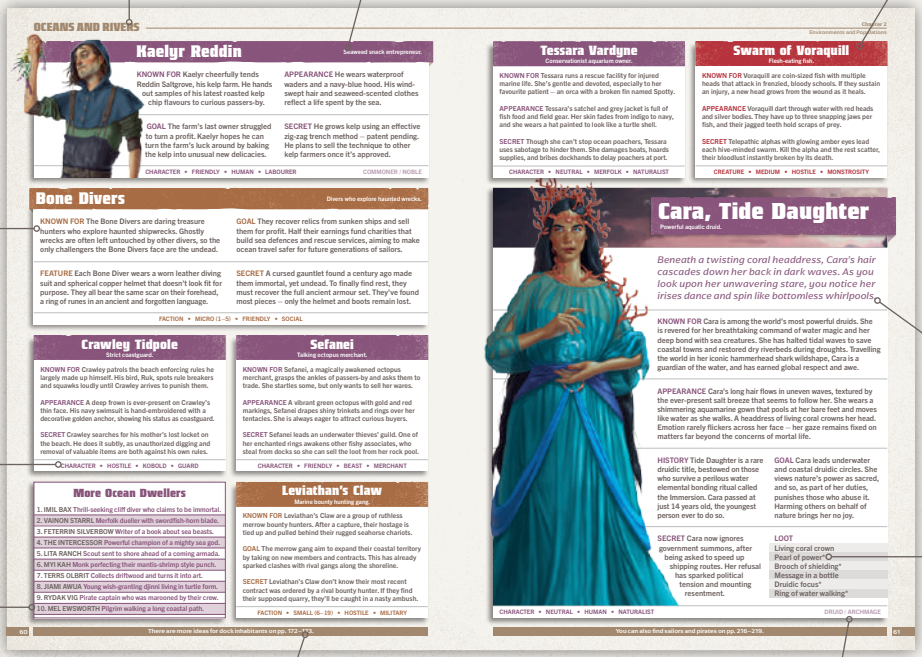
Random table boxes give you even more ideas

Descriptions in italics can be read aloud to your party

Loot items with an * have rules in the DnD 5E rulebooks

The bottom of each page has worldbuilding tips for game masters

Recommended DnD 5E stat blocks are given for larger entries



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Entry Types and Sections

All Entries

Every entry starts with what the character, faction, location or creature is KNOWN FOR.

The other sections depend on the size and type of the entry, giving you what you need to know.

Most entries have a section for APPEARANCE, and a SECRET that can serve as a plot hook.

Setting

Define your setting with distinct continents, countries and planes. Establish your world's history, environments, political backdrop, distinct cultures, and set the tone for the adventures to come.

Look for entry sections covering the setting's GEOGRAPHY, POPULATION, HISTORY and COMMON CREATURES.

Deity

Establish divine power structures with gods that shape the reality of your world. Use these deities to fuel magic, drive prophecies, command worship and anchor belief systems in your world.

Deity entries include lore about the god's DOMAIN, FOLLOWERS, LEGEND and HOLY ITEMS, as well as alternative names.

Character

Introduce compelling NPCs with clear agendas and flaws. These characters bring drama, deepen role-play, and give players meaningful allies, enemies or quest-givers.

Longer entries give more depth to the character's HISTORY, GOAL, the LOOT they are carrying, and may include STAT BLOCKS.

Faction

Create tension and conflict with powerful organisations like cults, thieves' guilds, bandit syndicates and religious orders. Each faction brings their own unique goals and schemes to your campaign.

All faction entries have GOALS, some also include a common FEATURE, LEADERSHIP hierarchy and KEY MEMBERS.

Creature

Challenge your players with all-new monsters. Add threats to settlements, populate bounty boards, create local legends and throw something original and exciting into combat.

To help you run these foes, you'll find descriptions of their TACTICS, LAIR and LOOT. They may also include STAT BLOCKS.

Environment

Immerse your players in epic environments: cursed forests, floating islands, shifting deserts. Each one offers a unique mix of hazards, challenges and story-defining details.

Expand on the environment's description with details about their INHABITANTS, LOOT and COMMON CREATURES.

Settlement

Drop your party into busy town squares, sprawling city streets and quaint village markets. These settlements serve as story hubs and let your players trade, explore and listen to rumours.

Build a picture of the area with prompts for their POPULATION, LANDMARKS and lists of LOCAL SERVICES available.

Building / Vehicle

Equip your world with memorable structures and transport, from arcane towers to battering rams. Use them in combat, as treasure troves, or as a bastion for your party.

Learn about the LAYOUT, LOOT and ENCOUNTERS that could happen when your party arrive.

Discover the secrets of Snickershells (right) on p. 83, including their tactics and potential weaknesses.

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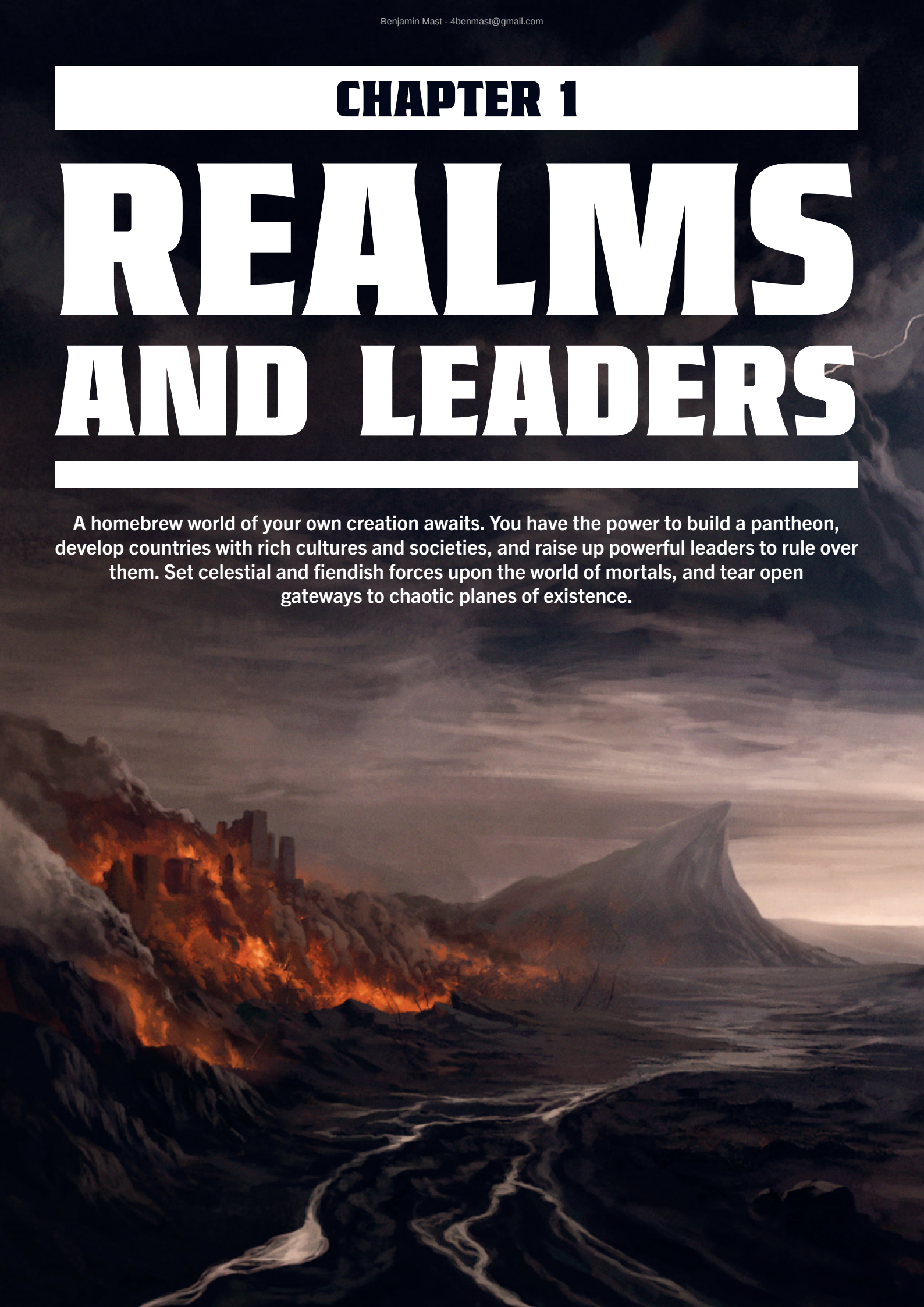
CHAPTER 1

REALMS AND LEADERS

A homebrew world of your own creation awaits. You have the power to build a pantheon, develop countries with rich cultures and societies, and raise up powerful leaders to rule over them. Set celestial and fiendish forces upon the world of mortals, and tear open gateways to chaotic planes of existence.



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Jaroslava

A new world still being built by the gods.

Parrots flap and scatter from a wide-branched baobab tree into the skies above. They were startled by the distant boom and crash of a new mountain emerging and being shaped like clay in the distance.

Key Stats

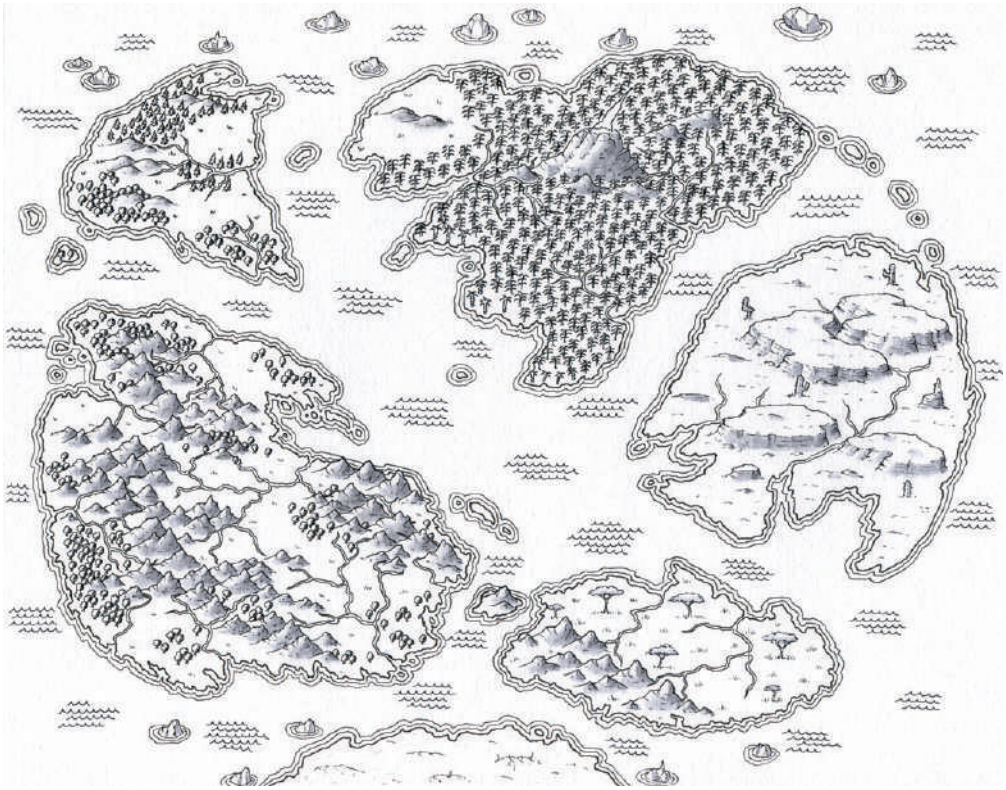
World Size	Large
Continents	6
Deities	12
Age	432 years
Population	92,518
Density	Low
Kingdoms	28
Technology	Primitive
Currency	Trade goods

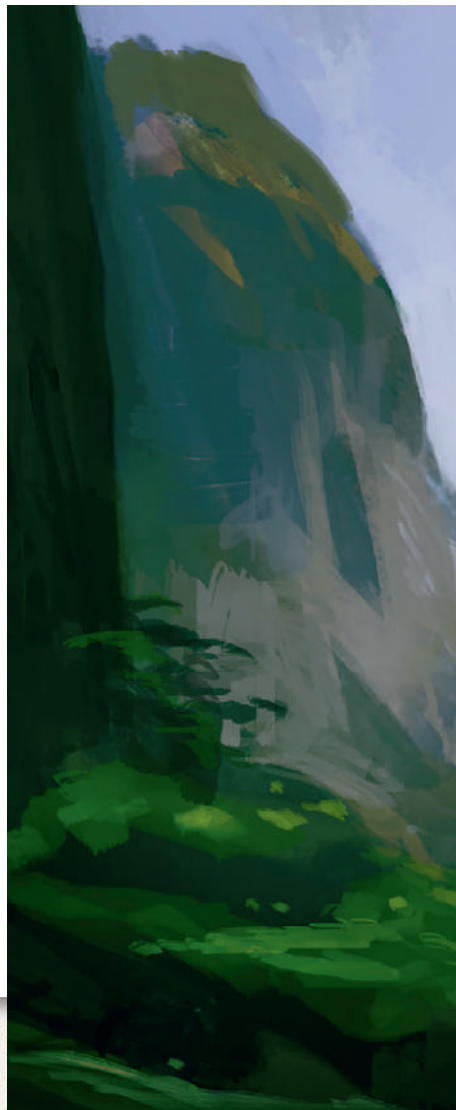
KNOWN FOR Jaroslava is a new world, brought to life by the gods only four hundred years ago. Abundant in magic and nature, it is still in the hands of its resourceful and imaginative creators, who remain actively involved in shaping and fine-tuning it. Verdant forests spring up almost overnight, ley lines shift to redistribute magical power among the populace, and mountain peaks regularly erupt from the earth.

GEOGRAPHY Jaroslava is lush and bountiful, pulsing with mystical arcane power. Its lands are unspoiled and vast, waiting to be explored. The north and south poles are frigid, but its oceans are geothermally heated, giving birth to thriving and active aquatic ecosystems. Dunes that circle the world's equator are home to bioluminescent animals and crystalline rock formations. Temperate forests and wetlands cover the outer continents.

POPULATION The planet's population is small but growing as the world takes shape. Its people live in scattered settlements, with a culture of deep reverence for the gods and a strong desire to map the known world. Each humanoid species in Jaroslava was created by a different deity in a distinct environment. As migration between continents increased, cultures began to blend, and larger settlements grew more metropolitan. The most prominent species are gnomes, humans and orcs.

HISTORY Jaroslavans cite four distinct periods of time in their world's history, verified by seers and scribes. The Finding was the unknown period of time when the gods converged and discussed creation plans; the Age of Origin spans the first chaotic decade of Jaroslava's formation; the Dominion Years refer to the time of the first people, and when early cities were founded; the Cartographic Age saw global exploration begin in earnest, starting two centuries ago and continuing to the present day.





LANDMARKS Stories of certain landmarks are far-reaching and attract intrepid pilgrims and tourists. The Falls of Garrosh cascade backwards from base to source; Wrigley's Belt is a wide arc of rocky debris that floats in place; the Primordial Temple is an overgrown shrine that seems to predate humanoid life; Hazgorge is a field of smoking gas chimneys; and Barbecue Basin is a long reservoir of molten rock.

Rangers ride Jaroslava's megafauna (right) during expeditions into uncharted regions.

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Continents of Jaroslava

SOFIYAN The central northern continent, Sofiyan, is thick with uncharted rainforests boasting high biodiversity. Sporadic rain falls across the temperate land all year round, causing humid pockets throughout the dense canopies. The gods use the powerful, active volcano here as a forge.

KRESIMIRA This scorching-hot continent lies to the east of the world, largely situated within the equatorial zone. Beachy forests grow along its coastline, but the centre of the region is a barren desert of flowing sand dunes and crystalline canyons.

BRATOMILL Located at Jaroslava's southern pole, this small landmass is permanently blanketed by snow. The oceans surrounding Bratomill are home to large undersea creatures, making travel to and from the region dangerous. A recently discovered network of frozen ice caves beneath Bratomill has sparked an intense scholarly debate about the gods' original purpose for them.

DRAZHANNA The fertile savannahs of Drazhanna lie in the south. Warm rains and calm weather nurture the scattered, wide-branched trees and newly formed wildlife, helping them adjust to their new surroundings.

NIKOLOT To the northwest of Jaroslava sit the grass-covered, rolling hills of Nikolot. This continent has the clearest seasons — cold winters, warm summers and golden autumns. Its meadows are rich with fluffy mammals that are easy to catch and domesticate, allowing its settlements to grow the quickest.

VASSILIN The largest continent covers the planet's southwest. Its northern regions are hotter than the south, but all areas have vast, habitable plains for the predators, prey and pious populations that dwell there.

SECRET The people of Jaroslava have lived in peace since the Age of Origin, but oracles are starting to foretell that change is coming. One of the gods has torn the fey veil, allowing a swarm of mischievous creatures and hazardous plant life to invade the world. Priests and rulers are discreetly referring to this heralded new time as the end of the Cartographic Age, and the start of the Wild Era.

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Terratak

Continents hovering around a rich core.

KNOWN FOR This world is made up of distinct layers: a small central core and three outer landmasses circling around it. The differences between life on each layer have created social divides and a rigid class system.

GEOGRAPHY High winds and strong rain buffet the jagged crags of the outer layers. Landmasses that sit closer to the core are sheltered by those above, making conditions increasingly more calm and temperate.

POPULATION Terratak's wealthiest citizens live on the surface of the central core itself, reaping the benefits of its mineral-rich soil. The poorest populations eke out a frugal existence in the wastelands of the outer layers.

SECRET Terratak's central core is becoming unstable and its residents have started noticing earth tremors. Leaders blamed the rumbles on attacks from the outer layers, but are secretly planning for a mass evacuation.

SETTING • WORLD • CONFLICT • DANGEROUS

Seleth

Magical world in permanent darkness.

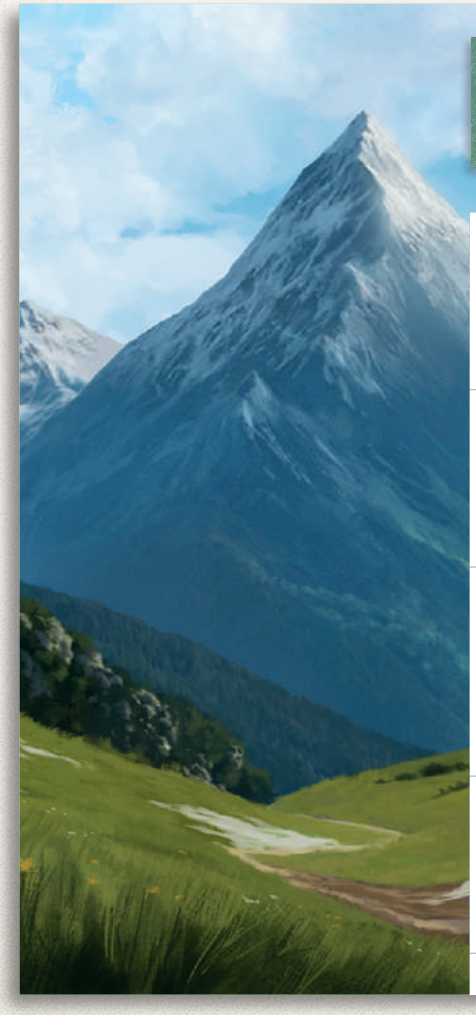
KNOWN FOR Blocked from the sun's light by other astral bodies, Seleth only experiences dusk or full darkness. Native species are adapted to low light and many are in tune with the world's abundant natural magic.

GEOGRAPHY Seleth's topography is dominated by enchanted forests, gemstone mountains and wide luminous rivers. The tall grasses that blanket the land are dark purple and emit a faint magical energy.

POPULATION Seleth is home to only a handful of communities, and its continents are sparsely populated with no formal borders. Most people live in villages or small towns under the guidance of elder magic users.

SECRET An extreme arcane sect has been developing an artificial sun to bring light to Seleth. They press on with their scheme, despite knowing that success would drain nearly all of the world's natural magic.

SETTING • WORLD • MAGIC • RISKY



Verteminia

World emerging from an ice age.

Melting ice drips from tall branches onto bright, open flowers basking in the warm air. Insects flit between the blooms, their iridescent wings glinting in the sun.

KNOWN FOR Verteminia is in flux after a millennia-long winter transitions into a new spring, bringing with it widespread optimism and opportunity. Impassable glaciers have melted, trade is booming, and adventurers are able to explore lands they have previously only heard about in stories.

GEOGRAPHY Once covered in snow and ice, most of Verteminia is now covered in lush grass meadows. Frost clings on only at the far poles and highest mountain peaks.

POPULATION Nations cut off by endless walls of ice developed their own distinct ways of life. Some societies now welcome others with openness; others respond with fear.

HISTORY Verteminia is said to have had three winters since time began. From first frost to first bloom, the most recent winter lasted 1,146 years.

SECRET Isolated from humanity, beasts in a northern forest evolved into new monsters. Set free by the thaw, they are now heading south.

SETTING • WORLD • EXPLORATION • SAFE

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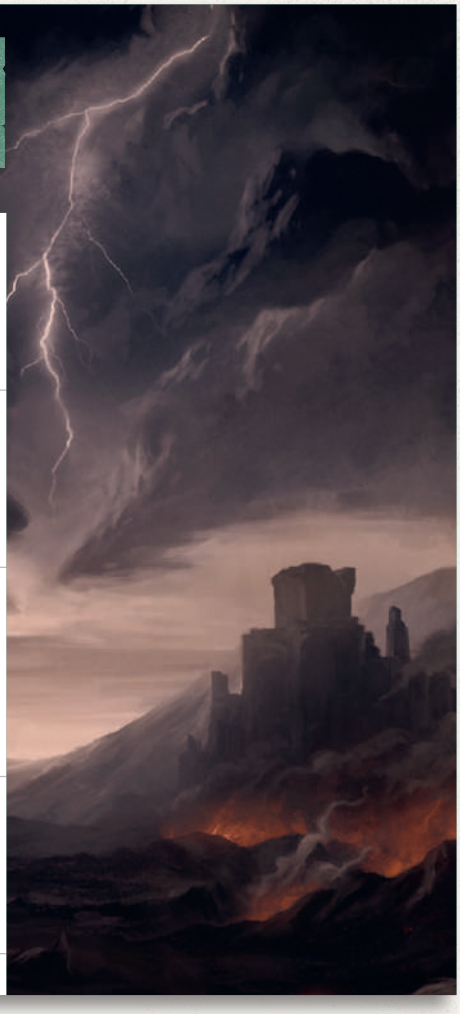
Rolban

Planet beset by warring celestials.



Lightning pierces the dust-filled sky, illuminating a horrific tableau of destruction. Huge defensive forts lie in pieces, crushed by the might of higher forces.

KNOWN FOR Warring celestial powers have made the world of Rolban their battleground, playing out their divine squabbles with earth-shattering consequences for the planet's mortal residents. Fiendish armies have also taken advantage of the chaos, sending their own forces to join the fray.

GEOGRAPHY The surface of the planet has been ravaged. Jungles burn, strangled rivers run dry, and grassy plains have turned into trench-filled quagmires.

POPULATION Mortals have retreated into roughly excavated underground settlements. There are no separate nations amongst the mortals; they are bound by a much greater threat.

HISTORY After an age of divine war, only the gods recall the world's peaceful origins, and the initial spark that set the conflict in motion.

SECRET As mortals lose faith in the gods, divine and infernal power is fading. Mortals are on the precipice of being able to reclaim their home.

SETTING • WORLD • CONFLICT • DANGEROUS

Osadra

Ocean world with drifting islands.

KNOWN FOR This ocean-covered world is dotted with islands. While many landmasses drift on the currents freely, some are steered by their inhabitants using huge rudders to prevent crashes with other settlements.

GEOGRAPHY Clear, azure seas cover most of Osadra, with occasional bands of stormy waters. Islands on slower-moving currents experience more consistent weather patterns and have more distinct terrain types.

POPULATION Centuries of trade, conquest and travel between lands mean diverse populations can be found on most island states. Islands also have their own culture and traditions, which they are proud to maintain.

SECRET Creliope, one of Osadra's largest islands and an arcane powerhouse, has been deliberately colliding with smaller islands. The population of Creliope is growing, and leaders hope to create satellite outposts.

SETTING • WORLD • EXPLORATION • SAFE

Parmist

Parched planet with growing deserts.

KNOWN FOR Extreme drought has caused the two large deserts at Parmist's poles to spread over more of the planet. Only a narrow strip of habitable land remains at the equator.

GEOGRAPHY Sandy deserts at each pole transition into dusty plains and dry river basins, where travellers must navigate rock slides, deep canyons and sheer ridges.

SECRET Communities with strong connections to nature or elemental magic are able to build settlements deep in the desert. These secluded towns each rely on a central oasis.

SETTING • WORLD • SURVIVAL • RISKY

More Worlds

1. **RATUS** Abandoned by its people who left to travel the stars.
2. **BELIDIA** World engulfed in wars between greedy leaders.
3. **FANDELL** Populated by sentient animals, with no humanoids.
4. **INFERUNDA** Sweltering world that orbits close to its sun.
5. **AUSPITH** World in an age of steampunk technology.
6. **IDUIN** Natural resources are dwindling, and in high demand.
7. **LIFRAY** World where magic has faded and is incredibly rare.
8. **Q'ILL** Formed of crystal lattices woven by prehistoric spiders.
9. **MURKSAN** Waterlogged planet with amphibious inhabitants.
10. **ZAKKHAN** Lightning storms bring flashes of wild magic.

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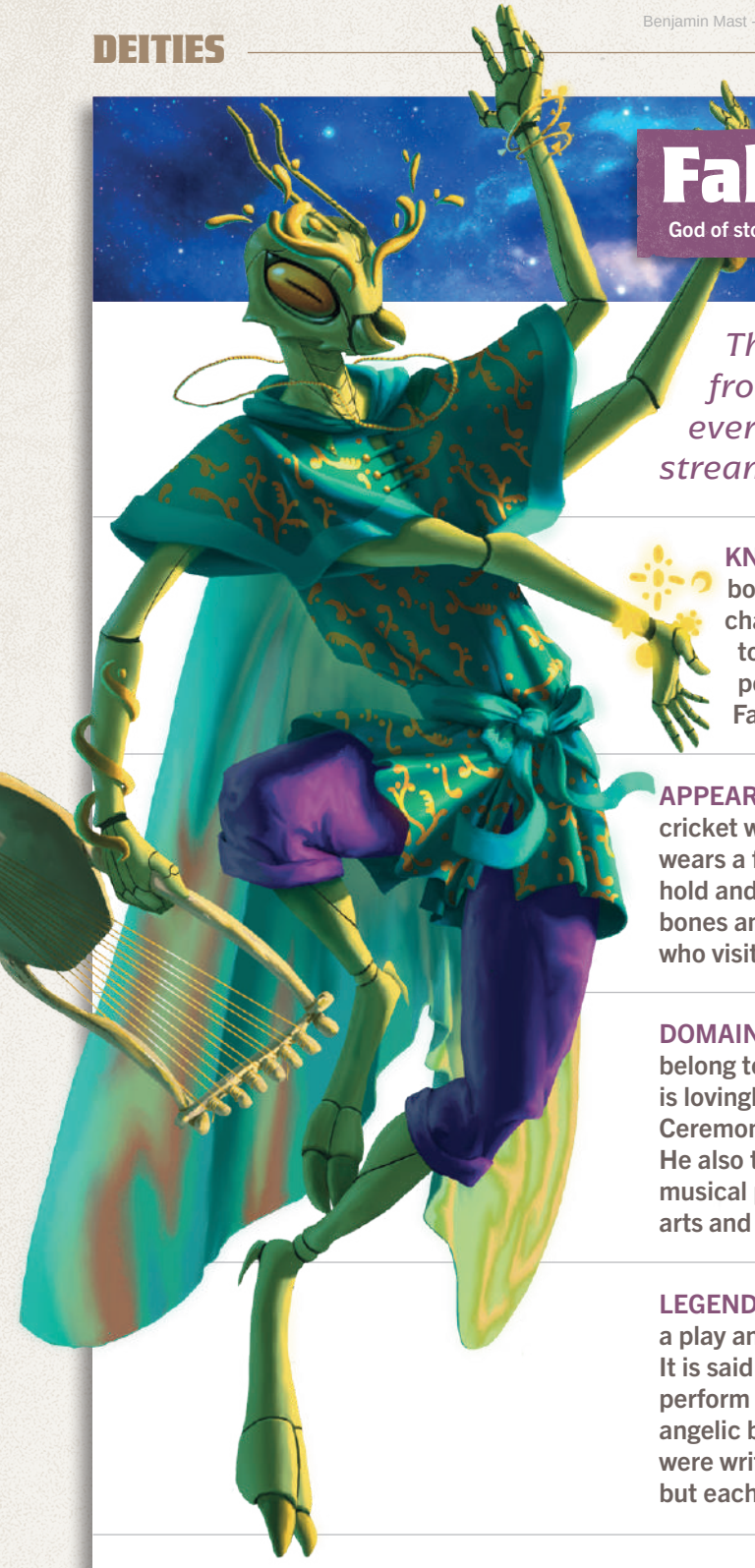

Fabulanth

God of storytelling and poetry.

The sound of harps and applause emanates from Fabulanth. He twirls and chirps with every movement, and his emerald cape streams behind him like a map of his dance.

KNOWN FOR The god with the greatest presence in mortals' books, plays and folklore is Fabulanth. He is a charismatic, charming orator who loves meddling in the affairs of followers to gain renown and fame. Publishing written works that portray him positively is an easy way to receive his blessings. Fabulanth adores worship through musical performance.

APPEARANCE Fabulanth appears in visions as an anthropomorphic cricket who chirps and whistles with every word and movement. He wears a flowing teal shirt and long, forest-green cape. His four arms hold and pluck his oversized lyre, which is said to be made from the bones and hair of a unicorn. Fabulanth magically dresses anyone who visits him in flamboyant outfits, ready for a performance.

DOMAIN Storytelling and poetry belong to Fabulanth, and he is lovingly called the "Lord of Ceremonies" by his followers. He also takes an interest in musical performance, the visual arts and food presentation.

FOLLOWERS Fabulanth is praised by bards, writers and artists alike. It's common for people to toss a coin into one of his shrines before giving a speech or making a grand gesture to a loved one.

LEGEND Fabulanth once wrote a play and gifted it to mortals. It is said that any actors who perform the play ascend into angelic beings. The three acts were written on three scrolls, but each have been lost to time.

HOLY ITEMS

- Eyes of charming*
- Wand of wonder*
- Bag of tricks*
- Instrument of Bards (cli lyre)*
- Boots of striding and springing*
- Dancing sword*

DEITY • CHAOTIC • INVOLVED

Beobach

God of justice and mercy.

KNOWN FOR Beobach keeps a constant watch over mortals — their failings, sins and darkest moments. Beobach can also see if an apology or other act of repentance is sincere, and grant forgiveness accordingly.

APPEARANCE Beobach is an elven figure wearing pale green robes. They have a large, singular eye in the middle of their smooth forehead. The eye has a milky white pupil, and it never blinks.

DOMAIN This all-seeing being is the god of justice, with judges, lawyers and law enforcers all swearing allegiance to the "Eye on High". Beobach is also associated with morality, mercy and forgiveness.

FOLLOWERS Worshippers of Beobach can be identified by the symbol of the eye, which is worn on jewellery or clothing. Some clerics believe Beobach's gaze should be feared, others see it as a comforting presence.

DEITY • LAWFUL • DISTANT

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Tempusom

God of time and memories.

KNOWN FOR Tempusom gives guidance to her followers based on their past decisions and potential futures. Her answers to prayer come in moments of déjà vu.

APPEARANCE Her many floating arms pull and twist the rainbow-shimmering timeline woven around her. Tempusom wears alternating faces — youthful, adult and elderly.

DOMAIN Tempusom administers the flow of time, nostalgia and memory. She is also called the "Queen of the Loom" by the mystics, philosophers and visionaries who worship her.

DEITY • LAWFUL • INVOLVED

Autumnus

God of transformation and seasons.

KNOWN FOR Autumnus keeps the circle of life spinning through creation, destruction and rebirth. He sees mortals as stewards of nature and tools to cultivate its ecosystems.

APPEARANCE He presents as a dwarf whose skin changes from green to yellow to orange to blue. The twigs and leaves that grow from his body play out the seasons on a loop.

DOMAIN Autumnus sees change, transformation and the seasons as his domain. His followers are a mix of rangers, farmers and transmuters who call him the "Wise Harvester".

DEITY • LAWFUL • DISTANT

Utru

God of abundance and greed.

KNOWN FOR Utru is a multifaceted god. He is kind and benevolent, with a passion for abundance and sufficiency. At the same time, he pulls his followers towards desires for material wealth and selfishness.

APPEARANCE Utru takes the form of a giant floating head with two faces. One shows a calm, compassionate expression; the other wears an unnaturally wide grin with a furrowed brow.

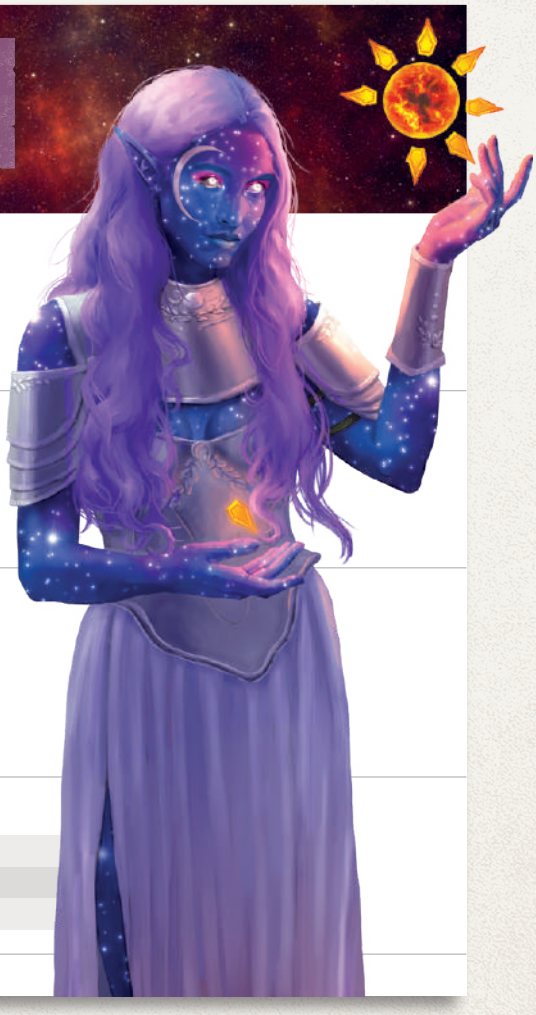
DOMAIN Plenty and excess are Utru's domain. He gives freely to both those in need and those who are already wealthy. His boundless generosity has earned him the title of the "Laughing Banker".

FOLLOWERS Those who need and those who want worship Utru. His followers are a strange combination of the penniless and underprivileged, mixed with business owners and wealthy noble houses.

DEITY • CHAOTIC • INVOLVED

Stellunae

God of suns, moons and stars.



Stellunae's skin shimmers with the light of ten thousand stars. Her moon-coloured eyes flare and wane as she ponders her creations in the absolute silence of space.

KNOWN FOR Stellunae crafts the cosmos. She controls every dying sun and twinkling star in the visible sky and beyond. Her work began at the birth of the universe and will conclude at its end. Her responsibilities keep her busy, and she doesn't make much time for communing with mortals.

APPEARANCE Her transparent skin reflects an ever-changing night sky. A moon sickle rests over her right eye, an iconic accessory and detachable crafting knife.

DOMAIN Suns, moons and stars are Stellunae's territory, and she is often referred to as the "Astral Gemsmith". Some people attribute heat, light and eclipses to her as well.

FOLLOWERS Stellunae is popular with astronomers, astrologers and navigators. Planar travellers may also pray to her for safe journeys.

HOLY ITEMS

- Cubic gate*
- Helm of brilliance*
- Robe of stars*

DEITY • NEUTRAL • DISTANT

How do your gods react to neglect, defiance, or blasphemy? Does their punishment visibly impact the world?

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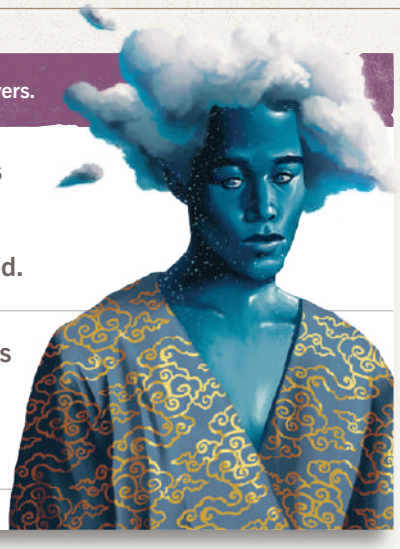
Pluvon

God of rain and rivers.



KNOWN FOR Mortals have lived in fear of Pluvon's whims for eternity. As god of the water cycle, he brings nurturing rain but can also cause floods and drought.

APPEARANCE Pluvon's face can be as calm as a still lake, or drenched with torrents of angry tears. The perpetual cloud around his head reflects his mood.

DOMAIN Pluvon is the guardian of all water, from streams to oceans. He also controls rain and storms. He is known as the "Blue King" by his worshippers.

FOLLOWERS Anglers have superstitions about how to placate Pluvon and his moods, like tossing back every other fish. Pluvon temples are built in water.

DEITY • CHAOTIC • DISTANT

Forludos

God of luck, chance and games.

KNOWN FOR Forludos doesn't answer prayers with dreams, visions, signs or wonders. Instead, he rolls his cosmic die and lets it determine the outcome. Those who pray to him should expect randomised replies.

APPEARANCE He resembles a stocky human with the tentacles of an octopus where his lower half should be. Forludos wears a red and black suit, with a constantly spinning roulette-wheel ruff around his neck.

DOMAIN Forludos watches over mortals' luck, and the games they play for entertainment. Many also attribute card reading, gambling and superstition to him. Forludos is referred to as the "Lucky Charmer".

FOLLOWERS Temples to Forludos operate more like casinos, where alms are taken from the gaming tables. Prayers to him normally come from gamblers, business investors, and those down on their luck.

DEITY • CHAOTIC • INVOLVED

Annihla

God of rebellion and anarchy.

KNOWN FOR The youngest of the pantheon, Annihla was brought into existence when mortals rebelled against the gods for the first time. She reflects humanity's most disruptive and chaotic impulses, and desire for change.

APPEARANCE Annihla presents as a scrawny human youth, wearing tattered leather clothing. However, her body shimmers as if viewed through a heat haze, and wisps of smoke seep from her head and hands.

DOMAIN Called the "Unquenchable Spark", Annihla rules over rebellion and chaos. She is also associated by some with invention, progress and the spirit of modernity, as her influence often fuels bold change.

FOLLOWERS Unsurprisingly, Annihla has been a symbol for many radicals and rebel groups throughout history. Those rejecting established norms may look to Annihla, from rule-breaking criminals to trailblazing artificers.

DEITY • CHAOTIC • DISTANT

Rambolu

God of wilderness and freedom.

KNOWN FOR Free-spirited Rambolu encourages a life without ties or tethers. Worshippers have visions of him racing across the open plains with a pack of wild beasts.

APPEARANCE Rambolu is a shape-shifter, but most commonly takes the form of a centaur with a flaming mane, a leaping crystal dolphin, or a soaring four-winged eagle.

DOMAIN Associated with freedom, open spaces and wild animals, the "Untamed One" is worshipped by free spirits, druids, lycanthropes and nature lovers.

DEITY • NEUTRAL • DISTANT

More Deities

1. BUGUDO Jovial guardian of farms, harvest and agriculture.
2. SIBIL Birdlike god linked with language and communication.
3. HUNDIR God of industry, worshipped by smiths and masons.
4. RE'ALLYN Athletic deity associated with hunting and riding.
5. OSCURA Eternal steward of day and night, light and dark.
6. GUILLIENE Omniscient god of knowledge, scrolls and books.
7. KRENE Deceitful god followed by criminals and con artists.
8. FLIZ Tiny sprite god of plants, insects, fungi and vitality.
9. CROCCIN Intimidating overseer of war, conflict and soldiers.
10. TOXOA Benevolent deity who blesses taverns and homes.

Once you've created your pantheon, think about how they are worshipped by mortals.

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Llindry

God of family and connection.

KNOWN FOR Most residences have a small shrine to Llindry, the god of kinship. It is believed displaying a statue of Llindry alongside trinkets belonging to friends or family members will protect those important bonds.

APPEARANCE Llindry's physical form resembles a human-sized hedgehog. She wears a voluminous apron, embroidered with a branching tree, and is often depicted knitting a blanket out of grass.

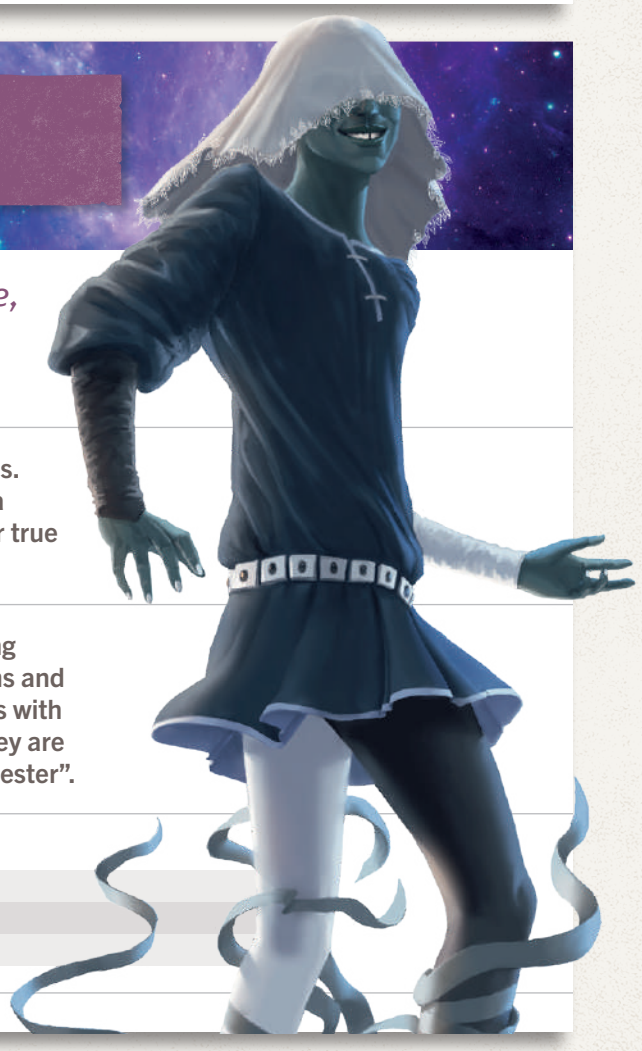
DOMAIN Affectionately called the "Kinmother", Llindry nurtures all forms of mortal love and connection. Her domain embraces and encourages family, friendship, romance, and the bonds between neighbours.

FOLLOWERS Clerics of Llindry work to create spaces where people can connect and build community. At large gatherings, toasts are often made in her honour, thanking her for uniting loved ones.

DEITY • LAWFUL • DISTANT

The Veiled Knave

God of dreams and the subconscious.



One corner of the figure's veil dances in the breeze, teasing you. Just as you think you're about to see a glimpse of their face, they spin and turn away.

KNOWN FOR The Veiled Knave governs both dreams and nightmares. Children are told to fall asleep quickly so the Knave will grant them a peaceful rest. But those who glimpse the god's face or discover their true name are said to become trapped in a realm of endless nightmares.

APPEARANCE The Veiled Knave's form stretches and distorts as they move through the shadows. They tiptoe on silver-slippered feet, so not to wake the sleepers they visit.

DOMAIN This enigmatic being embodies the world of dreams and the subconscious mind. Links with illusion and trickery mean they are also known as the "Shadow Jester".

FOLLOWERS The annual Eve of the Veil masquerade ball allows followers to hide their identity and admit their dreams to others.

HOLY ITEMS

- Cloak of invisibility*
- Oil of etherealness*
- Boots of elvenkind*

DEITY • CHAOTIC • INVOLVED

Tuli

God of trade and travel.

KNOWN FOR Tuli is celebrated by optimistic souls seeking new shores and good fortune. The image of her smiling face and outstretched palms can often be found minted in coins, or carved into the figurehead of a ship.

APPEARANCE Tuli is said to regularly take mortal form to enjoy the sea breeze through her long golden hair. She dresses in flowing jewel-toned silks and wears a jingling coin belt with a compass at her side.

DOMAIN Considered the "Spirit of Opportunity", Tuli offers blessings to explorers and travellers embarking on perilous voyages. Tuli is also known to reward traders and merchants with an entrepreneurial spirit.

FOLLOWERS Sailors, particularly those on merchant vessels, often worship Tuli. Individuals setting off on a lengthy journey might also say a short prayer to her, even if they aren't devout followers.

DEITY • NEUTRAL • INVOLVED

Check out pp. 182–187 to add temples and religious people to your world.

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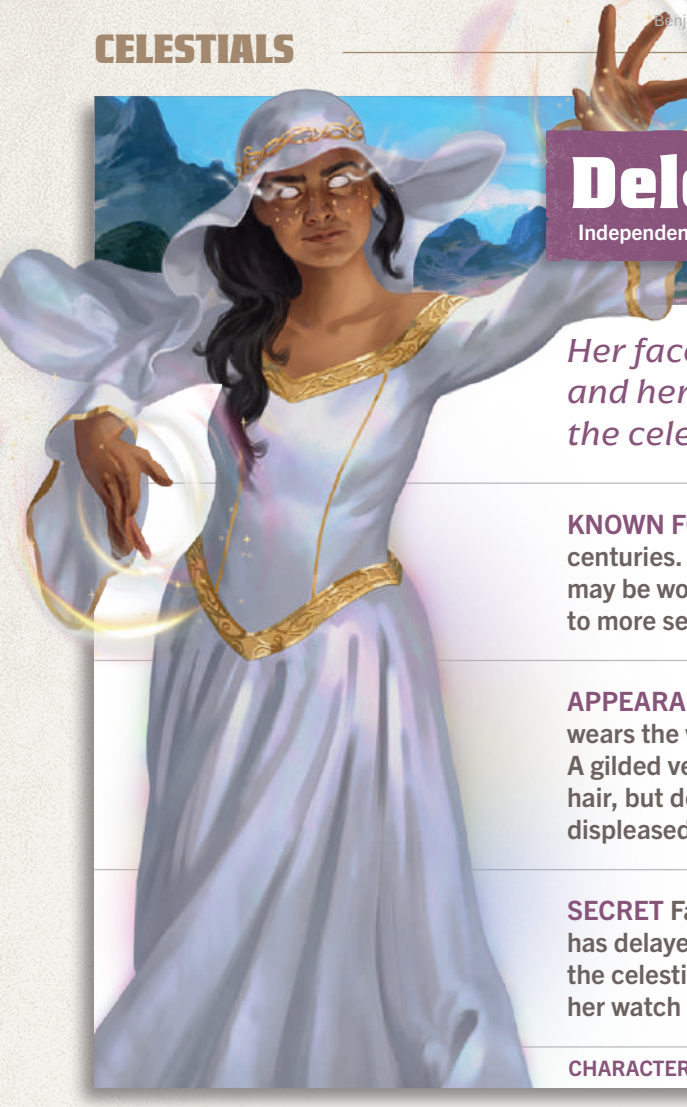

Delorea

Independent herald in training.

Her face is completely without lines, scars or shadow, and her skin as smooth as a newborn babe. However, the celestial's expression seems anything but naive.

KNOWN FOR Delorea has been an angelic herald in training for many centuries. Her experience so far has been limited to identifying mortals who may be worthy to receive divine messages, and reporting back her findings to more senior celestials. She believes she is destined for so much more.

APPEARANCE As a trainee, Delorea wears the white robes of an acolyte. A gilded veil covers her long dark hair, but does not disguise her often displeased expression.

GOAL Delorea is tired of having to act under constant instruction and supervision. She wants to find a mortal to guide to glory, to prove she doesn't need supervision.

SECRET Failure in a previous mission has delayed Delorea's path through the celestial ranks. The mortal under her watch was gravely injured.

LOOT

- Bracers of defence*
- Sending stones*
- Elixir of health*

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • CELESTIAL • OFFICIAL — PRIEST / DEVA

Forin Stalblade

Champion of a fallen god.

KNOWN FOR Forin has proudly served as the champion of his god for over a hundred years. However, his god recently betrayed the wider pantheon and has been banished from the Celestial Realm, leaving Forin adrift.

APPEARANCE Forin wears full plate armour with metallic wings, and a helm in the shape of a lion. His armour still bears the symbol of his god, although he has taken to wearing a cloak to cover this.

GOAL With his god banished, Forin must make a huge decision. He could move into the service of another god, or stay loyal to his original deity. If he chooses the latter, he will need to travel to a distant plane to find his god.

SECRET Forin's lingering loyalty is the only thing tethering his god to existence. If Forin loses faith, the god will disappear entirely. Forin's strength is also fading, and will do so until he commits to a single path.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • CELESTIAL • COMBATANT — PLANETAR / SOLAR

Zbori, Lord of Harmony

Conductor of the celestial chorus.

KNOWN FOR Zbori is a tiny, sprite-like celestial with an enormous voice. He leads the celestial chorus in song, each and every day. His harmonious arrangements are designed to please and pay homage to the gods.

APPEARANCE Despite his petite body, Zbori can sing perfectly in all registers and his speech resonates with a joyous hum even when talking. His hands and feet are hidden by his oversized purple robes.

GOAL Zbori arranges concerts to entertain the gods and his fellow celestials. An eternity of pitch-perfect performances can begin to blur into one, so he is always looking for something novel to surprise his audience.

SECRET Zbori recently lost a page of his ninth concerto, and has been doing everything he can to look for it before his upcoming performance. He worries it might have fallen to the Material Plane.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • CELESTIAL • ENTERTAINER — SPRITE / SPHINX OF LORE

How common are celestial beings in your world? Are people visited by them often?

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Illumos

Messenger who visits mortals in visions.

KNOWN FOR Illumos is a celestial messenger who appears to the faithful through waking visions. He brings hopeful prophecies for the future, and grave warnings.

APPEARANCE Illumos takes the form of a towering man, his face obscured by light. His eight wings move in harmony and his tunic drifts weightlessly as he hovers above the ground.

SECRET This angelic being has a fiendish twin, Allumos, who spreads false messages. Both leave glyphs on the necks of those they visit with subtly different designs.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • CELESTIAL • SAGE

Ma and Pa Cloverhill

Mortal farmers ascended to celestial life.

KNOWN FOR The Cloverhills ran their earthly horse farm with such care that the gods decided to reward them. The couple now tend to a pegasus ranch in the Celestial Realm.

APPEARANCE Ma and Pa Cloverhill are both stocky dwarves wearing simple farming garb, just as in life. However, they now have angelic halos and glow with a radiant aura.

SECRET Once a year, one of the Cloverhills visits a mortal farm to bless its herd. They trade a normal horse foal for a pegasus foal, who is tasked with protecting its new home.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • CELESTIAL • LABOURER

The Light Taker

Holy harbinger of death.

KNOWN FOR The arrival of the Light Taker means a mortal's life has reached its end. This angelic being carries souls peacefully to the next realm in a round, glass lantern.

APPEARANCE The Light Taker adopts the form of a trusted friend or loved one, but they do not speak. The unlit candle in their lantern flickers into light when fuelled by a soul.

SECRET It isn't easy to trick or thwart the Light Taker. However, if a person's light is transferred into another vessel quickly enough, their soul can remain on the Material Plane.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • CELESTIAL • WAYFARER

More Celestial Beings

1. **SUNSRATH** Judges those who pass into the Celestial Realm.
2. **TATHIA** Guardian spirit who seeks to heal broken hearts.
3. **RYN SAE** Fearsome angel sent to punish greedy mortals.
4. **ISTRIEL** Part-eagle celestial who flies at astonishing speeds.
5. **ZANA** Gladiator who performs for the gods' amusement.
6. **XANDREL** Planetar scribe who records all mortal deeds.
7. **NOCTIS** Disguised deva who guides travellers in dark woods.
8. **THE UNTETHERED** Glowing sphere with a booming voice.
9. **LASPIRER** Celestial unknowingly trapped in a mortal body.
10. **ARILEO** Ancient, dying couatl flickering between forms.

Angelweft

Divine ivy with protective abilities.

KNOWN FOR This plant's protective magic reinforces holy buildings against physical damage. It also has healing properties if wrapped around a wound.

APPEARANCE Angelweft has deep-green leaves with iridescent veins. It is not easy to distinguish it from regular ivy, but can be detected by astute clerics or paladins.

TACTICS The ivy instinctively grows towards an object or creature that has been damaged. It will attempt to wrap its healing tendrils around the injury.

SECRET Weaving a crown of Angelweft gives the wearer increased protection against necrotic magic. The effects only last a day once the plant is picked.

CREATURE • MEDIUM • FRIENDLY • PLANT

AWAKENED SHRUB / VIOLET FUNGUS

The Eternal Charge

Angels riding rhino-pulled chariots.

KNOWN FOR The magnificence of the Eternal Charge is a sight to behold. This brigade of celestial warriors charges into battle on chariots pulled by winged rhinos. Together, they relentlessly sweep aside their enemies.

GOAL The Eternal Charge is a division of divine soldiers who enforce the will of the gods. They are sent to the Material Plane to defend it against infernal threats, or to punish mortals the gods view as evil or corrupt.

FEATURE The brigade's chariots, riders and divine steeds are all clad in pure gold armour. The polished metal reflects the radiant light of the warriors' sunswords, creating a blinding display of power.

SECRET Millennia ago, the entire brigade was defeated by a young fiend. The child spread infernal briars on the battlefield, which got caught in the rhinos' unarmoured hooves and the chariot wheel spokes.

FACTION • MEDIUM (20–49) • NEUTRAL • MILITARY

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The Mawforged

Fiends who forge infernal weapons.

KNOWN FOR Members of the Mawforged capture lost souls that find their way into the Abyss, and turn them into living armaments through an unpleasant infernal process. The Mawforged show little care for their victims.

GOAL The Mawforged work tirelessly to impress their infernal overlords. Every sword, shield, cannon and battering ram is a work of unholy art, embellished and engraved with macabre etchings.

FEATURE Exposure to harsh chemicals and unstable fiendish magic has transformed the bodies of most Mawforged. Over time, some have grown extra clawed limbs, while others have sprouted eyes in odd places.

SECRET No weapon the Mawforged have crafted has lasted more than one cosmic cycle without liquifying. This hasn't been a significant issue so far, as most of them are destroyed in violent conflicts before then.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • NEUTRAL • INDUSTRY

L'ithril the Impaler

Archfiend struggling for control.

KNOWN FOR L'ithril recently slew an infernal overlord and claimed the title of Archfiend. However, her sudden rise has divided the fiends beneath her, sparking a schism.

APPEARANCE Her bulky, reptilian frame stands at over 10 feet tall. Heads on pikes protrude from L'ithril's ebony leather armour, and her scorpion-like tail lashes behind her.

SECRET When L'ithril is alone, she confides in the heads she carries with her. She has asked the slain overlord how to reunite the fiends, but they are refusing to give advice.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • FIEND • COMBATANT

Zazzbak Scriver

Infernal contract writer and crafter.

KNOWN FOR Zazzbak turns the flesh of peeled creatures into contract paper through a curing process. On this paper, he writes cryptic contracts and deceitful deals for others.

APPEARANCE This crafty devil's horns are swept back behind his head. Zazzbak's veiny skin is a purple-red, and his tailored mustard suit is peppered with pockets.

SECRET Any contracts created by Zazzbak on behalf of other fiends are void. According to infernal law, contracts made with mortals must be written by the fiend issuing them.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • FIEND • OFFICIAL

Malady Reaverhorn

Erinyes knight who rides a nightmare.

KNOWN FOR Malady has ridden into war countless times as a demanding battalion captain. She steers her flaming warhorse, Cerberon, and wields a mighty lance.

APPEARANCE Her black armour glistens in the light of her steed's flaming mane. Malady's eyes glow with red light, and her crimson wings are missing feathers.

GOAL Malady wants to dethrone the gods of the pantheon and let her dark deity reign on high. She is preparing for an invasion of the Celestial Realm.

SECRET She was once a loyal and kind-hearted angel, but fell to the underworld after being tempted by power and greed. No fiend would fight for her if they knew.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • FIEND • COMBATANT

KNIGHT / ERINYES

Swelterkin

Fiend who meddles in the fates of others.

KNOWN FOR Swelterkin cackles as he uses infernal artefacts to scry on mortals on the Material Plane and manipulate their lives. He relishes causing misery and chaos for others.

APPEARANCE A spindly, tall man with an extra joint in his arms and legs. He wears a scruffy loincloth and a wicker basket on his head, which muffles his unsettling chuckles.

SECRET He also wears an orange gem on a chain around his neck. If this gem is destroyed, Swelterkin will be banished from the underworld and thrown across the planes.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • FIEND • SPELLCASTER

More Fiendish Beings

1. R'GAVILAX Tiny quasit who wreaks havoc on dairy farms.
2. VLOM Glabrezu who adores red tape and bureaucracy.
3. DROKAR Pit fiend who is close to breaking their chains.
4. VOZ TURNIPMAW Fiend with breath like rotting vegetables.
5. JEMANCH Bone devil draped in jewellery made from teeth.
6. EZA THORNISS Incubus who gives other fiends nightmares.
7. ACTO SUBURNA Hungry for a promotion to archfiend status.
8. WUJL THE LOSER Dishonoured imp tied up in silver chains.
9. MALIX Terrifying nalfeshnee who visits dreaming mortals.
10. YGNOR Hezrou who will do anything for spicy food.

Think about a fiend's alignment and motivations to make them a more rounded character.

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Bilegut and Wretcher

Two worst enemies bound together forever.

The foul language exchanged by the creature's squabbling heads is nothing in comparison to its striking appearance. Two bodies, fused together, thrash around in heated anger.

KNOWN FOR Once mortal enemies, a werewolf and a vampire, Bilegut and Wretcher were fused into one being in the Abyss for the amusement of an archfiend. Bound together for eternity, their endless hatred fuels constant arguments and vicious fights. Anyone who crosses their path risks becoming a target of their rage, as they indiscriminately lash out in frustration.

APPEARANCE Bilegut and Wretcher are split down the middle, and are held together with infernal chains coated in pain-inducing venom. Bilegut is a snarling, feral werewolf with matted grey fur. Wretcher is a pale, red-eyed vampire noble wearing tattered finery. Their two heads constantly bicker and throw insults at one another.

HISTORY Roburt Redclaw was a ruthless lycanthrope warlord, and Eskidril Giddeon was a vampiric noble who fed on peasants. They were fused by a cruel archfiend and given mocking new nicknames.

GOAL The pair are both trying to split from one another, but have different ideas about how to do so. Bilegut wants to tear his enemy from him using force, while Wretcher wants to perform an arcane separation ritual.

SECRET When they were fused, the archfiend told them that all they had to do to split was say each others names three times simultaneously. Sadly, the two were shouting over one another and didn't hear the instructions.

LOOT

- Maul*
- Armour of vulnerability*
- Gaming set (dice)*
- Rusted chains
- Flask of blood
- Dark shard amulet*

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • FIEND • NOBLE — ETTIN / VAMPIRE

Swarm of Vulcanroaches

Abyssal cockroaches.

KNOWN FOR There are few things that can make a fiend repulsed, but spotting a vulcanroach infestation is one of them. These red-hot bugs breed quickly, smell of ammonia, and harbour virulent diseases like weirdrot.

APPEARANCE Their flat, oval bodies help them fit into small spaces and orifices, and their metallic shells can take significant damage before breaking. They chirp to one another with a loud "ki-ki-swee" noise.

TACTICS Vulcanroaches travel in large congregations of around 500 to 1,000, and easily carpet any room they're in. They attack their prey with bites and burns, then expeditiously feed on its remains.

SECRET These pests are most at home near rivers of lava or sulphurous vents. The one thing vulcanroaches hate is fresh water, and they will quickly perish or flee when splashed with it.

CREATURE • MEDIUM • HOSTILE • FIEND — SWARM OF INSECTS / ANKHEGS

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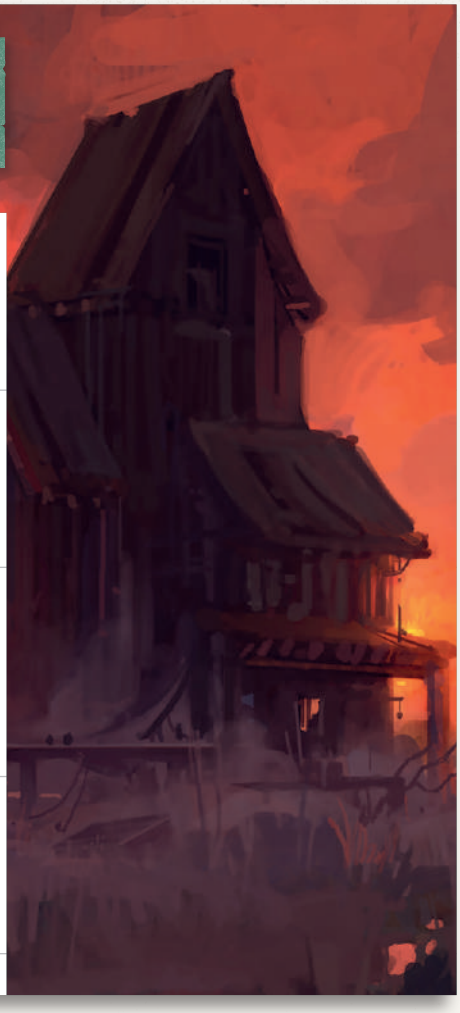
Malstora

Mirror plane of selfish choices.



At first glance, this place is just like the Material Plane. Then, details start to shift in your peripheral vision, as if several overlapping images are fighting for focus.

KNOWN FOR Malstora is a twisted reflection of the Material Plane, where countless overlapping realities show the consequences of every wicked choice a person could have made. Malstora's skies host an angry-red sun, and its inhabitants carry the heavy burden of misfortune and suffering.

GEOGRAPHY Potential timelines exist on top of each other, creating a disconcerting haze. As visitors arrive, a timeline of particular interest to them starts to stabilise.

POPULATION The people of Malstora are echoes of those on the Material Plane. They exist in the lives their counterparts would have led if they made only selfish and cruel choices.

HISTORY The gods made Malstora to show mortals the cost of evil. It soon spiralled out of their control and became something far worse.

SECRET Malstoran citizens scheme to replace their Material Plane counterparts, trapping the other soul permanently if they succeed.

SETTING • PLANE • HORROR • DANGEROUS

Navratnik

Paradise for deceased fiends.

KNOWN FOR When a fiend dies in the underworld, where do they go next? If they have lived an especially evil and chaotic life, they are rewarded with an afterlife in Navratnik: a pandemonic paradise.

GEOGRAPHY The landscape of Navratnik shifts abruptly every day. Volcanoes appear and erupt, sinkholes create sudden chasms, and tornadoes destroy the forts and towers. Even gravity is known to be unpredictable.

POPULATION Navratnik is home to fiends who have died and crossed into the afterlife. There, they endlessly battle each other, and hunt native creatures like flaming hares, venomous vultures and three-headed basilisks.

SECRET Navratnik residents have corporeal forms, but can no longer be injured or killed. If a visitor dies on Navratnik, they awaken on their home plane with the lingering injuries they sustained.

SETTING • PLANE • CONFLICT • DANGEROUS

The Lostlands

Plane of lost things.

KNOWN FOR Folktales say that when an item goes missing, it has "gone to the Lostlands". Few know the Lostlands is a real place, which also holds abstract concepts such as lost knowledge and time.

GEOGRAPHY From a distance, the Lostlands looks like a huge desert. Up close, each dune is more like a rubbish heap, with similar physical objects gathered together. Ideas and memories float in clouds overhead.

POPULATION Pets, people and even entire civilisations have slipped into the Lostlands over the years. These forgotten beings scavenge the items that arrive to build themselves new homes and settlements.

SECRET On rainy days, the clouds release storms of forgotten knowledge. These secrets can soak into those caught outside, and possibly change their personalities or grant them sudden expertise.

SETTING • PLANE • WHIMSY • RISKY

If you're building your own new plane, start with one compelling point of difference from the Material Plane.

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Magamie

Home plane of magical familiars.

KNOWN FOR Magamie is a wild world full of ethereal and intelligent animals. When magic users summon an animal spirit to act as a familiar or aid them in battle, the call is answered by a resident of Magamie.

GEOGRAPHY The realm has areas of vibrant woodland, pristine tundra and golden beaches to accommodate every type of animal. Each habitat has its own sacred summoning pool, which gives passage to other planes.

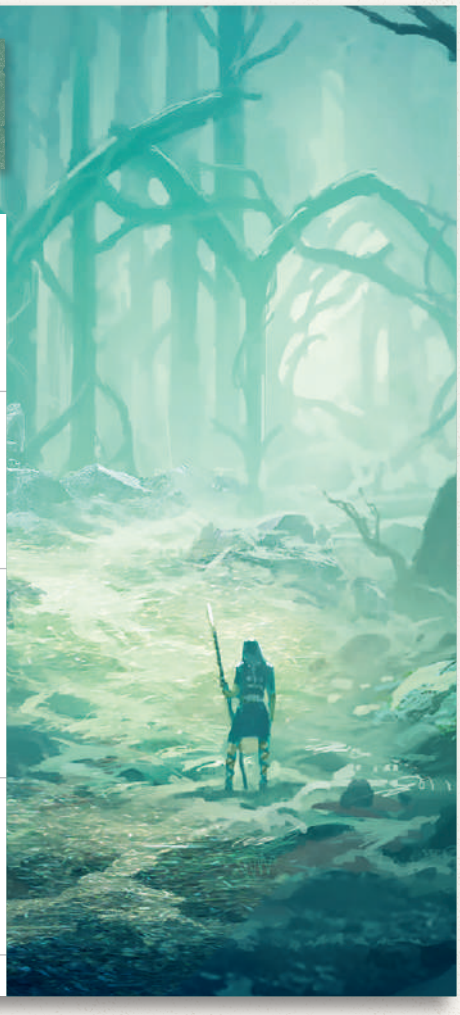
POPULATION The animals of Magamie aren't forced to answer the calls of mages from other planes, they choose to. Becoming a familiar is considered a great honour in Magamie culture.

SECRET When a familiar is magically dismissed or falls in battle, they can return to a summoning pool of their choice. This means familiars can pass on messages to other animal spirits on Magamie.

SETTING • PLANE • MAGIC • SAFE

Hearthholt

Realm between life and death.



The forest is quiet and still. You hear your feet tread beneath you, but there's no breeze in the branches or sound of birdsong. The air is cold, and so is your skin.

KNOWN FOR Hearthholt bridges the Material Plane with the divine realms. In order to cross into the afterlife, a mortal soul must traverse this expansive forest. Souls who have not accepted their death can lose their way, veering from the path and becoming lost in the forest's mists for eternity.

GEOGRAPHY Hearthholt is a vast forest shrouded in thick fog. Souls of the dead see a path guiding them to their afterlife, but it vanishes if they stray too far from it.

POPULATION The forest is patrolled by the gods' emissaries, who seek out lost souls. The dead resemble their former selves, but in flawless restored bodies.

HISTORY The forest was once full of monsters that hunted passing souls. A team of heroes sacrificed themselves to destroy the beasts.

SECRET The living can enter the forest to attempt to retrieve a loved one. However, prolonged time in Hearthholt drains a mortal's energy.

SETTING • PLANE • EXPLORATION • RISKY

More Planes of Existence

1. **FANCIFEN** Plane that children's imaginary friends call home.
2. **WHISPER PLANE** Prayers pass through here to reach deities.
3. **CARCERON** Prison plane for dangerous and violent beings.
4. **VIVARI** Plane of intense healing and rejuvenation energy.
5. **SNACKTOPIA** Plane where everything is edible.
6. **DREMMA REALM** Ethereal world made from mortal dreams.
7. **TEMPRATERRA** Plane where everything happens in reverse.
8. **THE VOIDPLANE** Botched teleportations land people here.
9. **IDLEWYLD** Realm where people exist as their idealised self.
10. **PENSACANT** Plane where every thought becomes tangible.

Luxamel

Realm of joyous excess.

KNOWN FOR In Luxamel, every positive sensation is heightened to the extreme. Colours are more vivid, music is more harmonious and food is unimaginably delicious.

GEOGRAPHY Luxamel is dotted with lush meadows and jungles, with beautiful, sweet-smelling plant life. The sky is a swirl of colours that don't even exist on other planes.

SECRET If a mortal spends too much time in Luxamel, they risk growing accustomed to its sensory richness. Eventually, the ability to experience anything is completely eroded.

SETTING • PLANE • WHIMSY • SAFE

How easy is travel between planes in your world? Are some more accessible than others?

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Radiasphere

Solar realm within a sun.

KNOWN FOR A realm within a hollow sun, where the sky churns with enormous mechanisms. Its hypnotic landscape overwhelms the senses and tests the sanity of intruders.

GEOGRAPHY Radiasphere's pulsating hills are built from chalky stone. Pools of pure light gather on its surface, waiting to be gathered by machines known as radiance harvesters.

SECRET Hidden deep within Radiasphere's core is said to be the "first spark" – the blueprint from which all suns in the multiverse were born. Controlling it could reshape reality.

SETTING • PLANE • MAGIC • RISKY

Cataclismo

Mineral plane with cosmic gems.

KNOWN FOR Made of gemstones and minerals, Cataclismo is surely the most beautiful of all the planes. Its elegance is tarnished, though, by its volatile seismic activity.

GEOGRAPHY Cataclismo's landscape shimmers with amethyst mountains, diamond caverns, and jagged emerald plains. Regular earthquakes split its fragile gemstone crust.

SECRET A rare, planar mineral called Taikusite exists deep within Cataclismo's surface. These lime-green geodes can massively amplify a creature's innate psychic potential.

SETTING • PLANE • SURVIVAL • DANGEROUS

Tempestus Ultra

Metallic dimension with wild electricity.

KNOWN FOR Sandwiched between the Plane of Air and Plane of Water lies the unstable dimension of Tempestus Ultra. A staggering amount of atmospheric electricity surges through the plane in daily storms.

GEOGRAPHY Tempestus Ultra's serrated, metallic landscape is peppered with tall, smoking hydrothermal vents. These silver chimneys act like lightning rods, and are constantly blasted by static electricity discharges.

POPULATION The realm houses colonies of humanoid insects with mirrored carapaces that don't conduct electricity. A race of sentient constructs also lives here; their glass faces and telepathic voices show no emotion.

SECRET The plane was once home to elemental humanoids, who built the sentient constructs. However, the constructs soon destroyed their humanoid creators. Scattered ruins are all that remain of the old population.

SETTING • PLANE • SURVIVAL • DANGEROUS

The Shrunken Plane

Realm existing at a microscopic scale.

You stand on soft, bouncy tufts of pink grass. The furry wilderness and its wandering creatures are surreal, and you know the world around you must only be a speck if viewed at humanoid scale.

KNOWN FOR The Shrunken Plane isn't a unique plane of its own. Instead, it exists within the Material Plane at microscopic scale – travellers need powerful miniaturising magic to get there. Anything brought back from the realm scales up with the person holding it.

GEOGRAPHY Everyday objects are the size of great continents in the Shrunken Plane. Fibres of a household rug are acres of thick forest, and a single pebble is a mighty mountain peak. Gravity is noticeably stronger here than on the Material Plane.

POPULATION The colourful landscape is teeming with fascinating life forms. Fungal humanoid locals have cultivated the land, and harvest nutrient-rich bacteria. The biggest threats to microscopic life are roaming aphids and behemoth ants.

HISTORY The plane was discovered accidentally by a faculty of wizards investigating the long-term impacts of reductive magic. The wizards visited the realm three times, then were never seen again. Their documents have led numerous search parties to look for them.

SECRET Time does not flow evenly here. A day in the Shrunken Plane can be months in the Material Plane, depending on proximity to the bizarre quantum whirlpools hidden among the terrain.

COMMON CREATURES

Chuul	Myconid Adult
Violet Fungus	Shambling Mound
Gibbering Mouther	Shrieker Fungus

SETTING • PLANE • EXPLORATION • RISKY

In the Shrunken Plane (right), fabric fibres are large enough to build entire homes inside.

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Flame Skippers

Tiny fire-hopping elementals.

KNOWN FOR These unpredictable elementals are able to jump magically between nearby flames, even if there's a wall or locked door in the way.

APPEARANCE Flame skippers flicker in and out of a tiny, sprite-like form. They are constantly in motion and communicate through crackles, pops and flares.

TACTICS Flame skippers group together to seek out larger flames. A large enough group can even carry another creature along with them.

SECRET With translation magic, their popping sounds can be heard as stories, secrets or warnings stolen from overheard or past conversations.

CREATURE • TINY • FRIENDLY • ELEMENTAL

SPRITE / MAGMA MEPHIT

Harmony Council

Council with interplanar representatives.

KNOWN FOR The Harmony Council is a group of diplomats dedicated to peace, unity and cooperation. They aim to maintain balance and resolve interplanar conflicts through dialogue and understanding.

GOAL The Council was set up to protect beings on all planes and prevent cataclysmic events spreading through the multiverse. Each diplomat reports potential threats, then the Council vote on appropriate actions.

FEATURE Diplomats are all from different planes. They carry an arcane orb attuned to their realm, which acts as a communication device to contact other members. Each orb is a coloured glass ball held in a silver hoop.

SECRET Once per cosmic cycle, the Harmony Council refreshes its members list to avoid complacency. Diplomats aren't told about this when they join, so the change of hands can feel abrupt and surprising.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • FRIENDLY • CIVIC

Neumone

Ancient proto-being observing all.

KNOWN FOR Neumone was the first being created by the gods. From the heart of the multiverse, they've observed all life unfold, and remember every moment since time started.

APPEARANCE Their body glows from within. They have an elongated humanoid form and face, a pointed cone skull, wings and three long fingers on each of their four hands.

SECRET As the universe expands, the chrysalis-like pocket dimension where Neumone lives shrinks. Eventually, their home will implode and they will be reborn in a new universe.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • ABERRATION • SAGE

Cosmoxiphods

Astral fish that hunt plane hoppers.

KNOWN FOR These cosmic swordfish glide through the Astral Sea, hunting with precision. Fierce and fast, they smell planar travellers from miles away and strike without warning.

APPEARANCE Cosmoxiphods are bulky predators with dark blue skin and a serrated bill. From a distance, their shoals can easily be mistaken for an interstellar cloud of gas or dust.

SECRET They often host parasitic organisms. If the host Cosmoxiphod is killed, the astral leeches inside will eject themselves and try to latch on to the nearest living being.

CREATURE • MEDIUM • HOSTILE • ABERRATION

Akragas

Aberrations that consume energy.

KNOWN FOR Akragas are shelled beings that spawn in the Abyss and migrate between planes in search of food. They consume elemental magic, and drain fire, earth, air, and water energy from the worlds they visit.

APPEARANCE Akragas resemble floating nautiluses. They can abandon their shells and take on squid-like forms that reflect the elements of the plane they're in, such as a flaming octopus in the Elemental Plane of Fire.

TACTICS By using energy to shift forms, these creatures blend seamlessly into their surroundings, allowing them to consume magic and remain hidden. Though generally peaceful, they will retaliate fiercely when threatened.

SECRET Older Akragas have bioluminescent markings on their shells. When deciphered, these glowing patterns reveal safe, hidden routes through the Abyss – paths the creatures themselves use for migration.

CREATURE • LARGE • NEUTRAL • ABERRATION

GIANT OCTOPUS / CHUUL

Your party could meet one of these beings while in another plane, or the being could visit them on the Material Plane.

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Djan Lont

Planar navigator who moves on quickly.

The traveller beams and raises a hand in friendly greeting. You both notice his hand start to flicker, then the edges of his body begin fading out of sight.

KNOWN FOR This experienced wayfarer loves exploring the multiverse and making friends wherever he goes. However, his years of plane hopping have come at a cost — he can no longer stay in any one plane for more than a day without suffering painful, debilitating headaches.

APPEARANCE Djan's eclectic style reflects fashion trends from across the multiverse. His cloak is quilted together from fabrics found during his interplanar travels.

GOAL Djan tries to make each moment and interaction truly meaningful, as he never knows how long he'll be in the same place with the same people.

SECRET A magical amulet is the source of Djan's plane-hopping powers. He stole it from a fey princess, who swore revenge.

LOOT

- Amulet of the planes*
- Robe of scintillating colours*
- Coins from other dimensions

PLANAR TRAVELLER

Small or Medium Humanoid

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
8 (-1)	17 (+3)	14 (+2)	17 (+3)	9 (-1)	11 (+0)

Armour Class: 13
Hit Points: 50 (10d6 + 20)
Speed: 30 ft, fly 15 ft (hover)
Initiative: +3

Saving Throws: INT +5
Skills: Acrobatics +5, Arcana +7, Perception +3
Senses: Truesight 30 ft
Passive Perception: 13
Languages: Common plus two other languages
Proficiency Bonus: +2

ABILITIES

Dimensional Disruption. Disruptive energy extends from the traveller in a thin rainbow haze. Other creatures can't teleport to or from a space within 30 ft of the traveller. Any attempt to do so is wasted.

Magic Resistance. The traveller has advantage on saving throws against spells and other magical effects.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The traveller makes two Astral Burst attacks. It can replace one attack with a use of Spellcasting.

Astral Burst. Melee or Ranged Weapon Attack: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft or range 60 ft, one target. Hit: 11 (2d8 + 3) cold damage.

Spellcasting. The traveller casts one of the following spells, using Intelligence as the spellcasting ability (spell save DC 13, +5 to hit with spell attacks):

At Will: *Blink, Dancing Lights, Minor Illusion*

1/Day Each: *Colour Spray, Witch Bolt*

CHALLENGE RATING 3

You could alternatively use the stats of a Priest Acolyte CR 1/4, Mage CR 6 or Noble Prodigy CR 10.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HUMAN • WAYFARER

Multiplanar Militia

Extraplanar defence force.

KNOWN FOR The Multiplanar Militia are an international force employed by governments and private individuals to secure the Material Plane from extraplanar threats.

GOAL The Militia's official motto is "to explore, discover, and defend". In practice though, they're notorious for launching invasions and sparking conflicts on other planes.

SECRET The Militia fall under no official jurisdiction, and keep many operations covert to avoid public scrutiny. They are currently covering up a costly defeat on another plane.

FACTION • MEDIUM (20–49) • HOSTILE • MILITARY

More Otherworldly Creatures

1. NEBULATS Cloud creatures that communicate with shapes.
2. ORELEECHES Slug-like devourers capable of eating a planet.
3. LURELIGHTS Bright spirits that lead astral travellers astray.
4. VOIDKRAKEN Ethereal mega-octopus disguised as a meteor.
5. STAR LIMPETS Crystalline molluscs that always point north.
6. BRINEWRAITH Acidic water elemental surrounded by gas.
7. RIFTEERS Space beavers that build dams to fix planar rifts.
8. MARROWSCRIBE Chalk creature that calcifies organic flesh.
9. VOLCANISKS Magma snakes that slither out of volcanoes.
10. WARRITS Super-intelligent newts plotting an invasion.

For advice on planar entities, your party could consult with Gaetana Lumere (p. 181) or Xenocrates (p. 225).

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Brahide

Warring nation that recently time-travelled.

Across the land, dense clusters of light suggest people have gathered close to each other in search of safety and security. On the coast, one light glows far brighter than the rest; a sun amongst stars.

Key Stats

Capital	Valor
Government	Mage Council
Population	121,058
Density	Low
Main Export	Stone
Main Import	Timber
Settlements	7
Technology	High
Language	Primordial

KNOWN FOR Until recently, Brahide was thought to be lost to history, its people remembered only in ancient texts. Thousands of years ago, during a prolonged war with neighbouring countries, the entire kingdom vanished without a trace. Then, six months ago, Brahide suddenly reappeared, leaving its former enemies in shock. Now, its people must adapt to a world that has long since moved on without them.

GEOGRAPHY Brahide was once a small, landlocked country. After it vanished, the land it occupied was gradually reclaimed by water, forming a vast lake. When Brahide reappeared in the exact same spot, centuries of coastal erosion had shifted nearby borders, leaving the once-inland nation isolated. Now, Brahide exists as a hilly, grass-covered island, surrounded on all sides by a narrow saltwater channel.

POPULATION For the people of Brahide, no time passed during their disappearance. They simply blinked out of existence and reappeared to discover enormous changes. Brahide's population speak an archaic dialect, worship a forgotten pantheon, and use vastly different tools and technology to their neighbours. Outside scholars are desperate to study the Brahide way of life, while curious Brahidians share rumours of new cultural, scientific and arcane developments on the mainland.

HISTORY At the time of its disappearance, Brahide was at war on three fronts, stemming from long-standing border disputes. The realm's ambitious mage council pursued an arcane solution designed to cleave themselves from their neighbours once and for all – the Schism Obelus. However, the council's hubris led them to tap into the world's fundamental magical reserves, which they were unable to control. As a result, Brahide was not just divided from their neighbours geographically, but also temporally.

SETTLEMENTS A relatively small nation, most of Brahide's population live in one of two major cities, or in their immediate suburban areas. This consolidation had intensified during the war, as those living in the rural open borderlands sought shelter inland. The walled capital city of Valor is still under particular strain from increased population density, as are the fortified towns of Uneka and Thanum.

The Schism Obelus (right) casts its arcane glow over traditional Brahidian homes.

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Notable Landmarks

SCHISM OBELUS The device that caused Brahide's disappearance still thrums with residual energy. It perches incongruously on a raised platform in an otherwise unremarkable border town. The site was chosen due to its position on powerful magical ley lines. The device is under permanent guard.

BRAHIDIAN GREAT LIBRARY Mainland scholars are fascinated to see what secrets this huge archive holds about many ancient societies. An academic exchange programme has been proposed, including lessons in a variety of long-forgotten languages.

COUNCIL PALACE Brahide's mage council lives and works in a gated palatial compound in the centre of the capital city, Valor. Each of the 13 council members has their own luxurious living quarters, with individual offices. Meetings are held in a central tower. A highly fortified bunker has been excavated in the rock beneath the compound, to provide the council with a safe retreat in case of an enemy invasion.

THE DIVINE SEAT The oldest building in Brahide, and now in the world, is a temple. This spiritual gathering place has shrines to all of the Brahidian pantheon, and is considered the most sacred site in the nation. Religious leaders gather to seek divine guidance and blessings for their people.

BRIDGE OF PEACE Construction has recently begun on a new crossing between Brahide and one of its neighbouring nations. The planned design is intended to represent two stone hands reaching out to lock fingers, but for now, all that has been erected is some precarious wooden scaffolding. Most visitors therefore still use boats to cross the channel, which are carefully searched on arrival.

SECRET Brahide's leaders have come to a cautious public truce with the descendants of their enemies. Privately however, the ruling council are split between two courses of action. Some members wish to stay in the present and take the opportunity for peace. Others want to gather technology and knowledge from the new world, then find a way back to the past to use it against their old foes.

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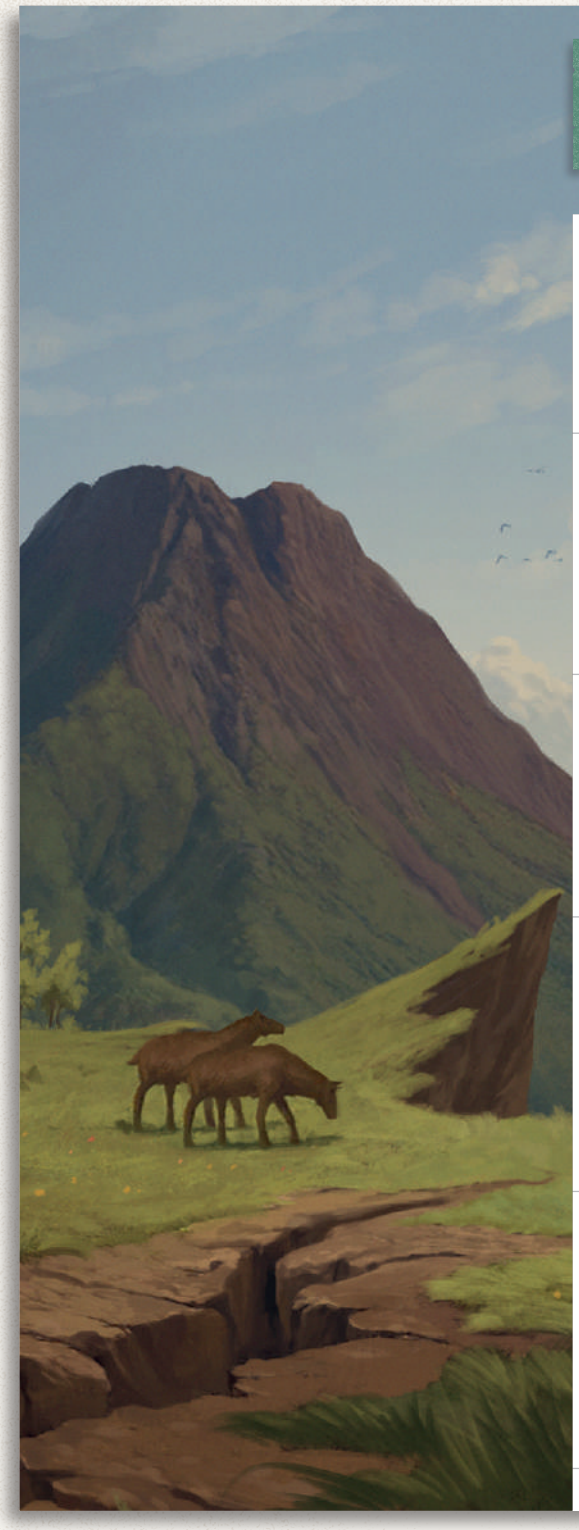

Gran Lavania

Fertile country with a dormant volcano.

Tall grasses and wild, fragrant flowers bloom, sheltered by jagged cliffs. Bees and butterflies buzz around you, drawing your eyes up to the titanic volcano looming on the horizon.

KNOWN FOR The volcano at the centre of Gran Lavania has a violent past, but now lies dormant. The mineral-rich ash deposited by previous eruptions had a lasting legacy across the land. Like a layer of thick dust over an out-of-use weapon, grass has grown over the scarred volcanic landscape. Gran Lavania is now a region of abundance, where animals, plants, crops and people all thrive.

APPEARANCE Centuries ago, Gran Lavania's rocks and hills were ravaged by constant volcanic eruptions. While some lava flow paths have been replaced by habitable flat wetlands, meadows and woodlands, the deepest craters and chasms still pose significant obstacles to travellers who head off the beaten track. The country has a tropical, humid climate, with periods of high heat and rainfall.

POPULATION The populated areas of Gran Lavania tend to be on flat inland fields, where farms are easy to establish and nurture. Elsewhere, coastal settlements are developing to harness international trade.

HISTORY Because of its rich resources, the country has been the target of many invasions and conquest attempts over the years. However, Gran Lavania remains independent – a fact its people take great pride in.

SECRET People in Gran Lavania believe that if you dwell near a deep fissure or lake for too long, you'll be pulled into it – and they're right. Strange, ancient creatures dwell in those deep places and stalk for prey.

COMMON CREATURES

- Baboon
- Hippogriff
- Deer
- Giant Constrictor Snake
- Fire Elemental
- Brown Bear

SETTING • COUNTRY • EXPLORATION • SAFE

Kem'buk Kaar

Isolated realm with advanced technology.

KNOWN FOR This country boasts the greatest advances in technology and automation the world has ever seen. However, it separates itself from the global community, so its impressive developments don't leave its borders.

APPEARANCE Arctic, mountainous northern regions give way to glacial lakes and forests in the south. The region's multitude of metropolises are abuzz with activity, and glow with bright yellow light at night.

POPULATION Kem'buk Kaar's people are suspicious of outsiders who somehow make it past the high border walls. Its settlements are very well-connected to each other, travel by hot air balloon or railcar is commonplace.

SECRET Most of Kem'buk Kaar is fuelled by coal, but its deposits are waning. The country's rulers will soon have to come out of hiding and ask for help from neighbours, or find another way to fuel their inventions.

SETTING • COUNTRY • STEAMPUNK • SAFE

Pick a capital city for your country using the entries on pp. 94–99.

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Desolamus

Country where magic is banned.

KNOWN FOR You don't have to walk far across the wastes of Desolamus to see one of its many imposing, obsidian watchtowers. Magic is outlawed here, and the towers beam out an oppressive anti-magic signal.

APPEARANCE Howling winds carry salty sea air and soggy drizzle across the flat landscape. A region of forested highlands in the east is the only area where the tall watchtowers don't dominate the landscape.

POPULATION Six small settlements nestle in the eastern forests, which offer shelter, access to timber, and distance from the demanding government. The port capital is in the west, protected by a huge sea wall.

SECRET The anti-magic field does not extend inside the heavily defended obsidian watchtowers. It's here that government-sanctioned divination wizards scry on the population and report on any potential law-breakers.

SETTING • COUNTRY • CONFLICT • RISKY

Escorchia

Arid realm with hidden valleys.

KNOWN FOR This sweltering country gets fierce sunlight and high temperatures all year. To survive the heat, citizens build their white-clad settlements and water harvesters in dune valleys, which are marginally cooler.

APPEARANCE Heat from the sun glistens off the golden dunes of Escorchia, which rise and fall like rolling hills. The dunes' shaded gorges, and the settlements within, are nearly impossible to see on the horizon.

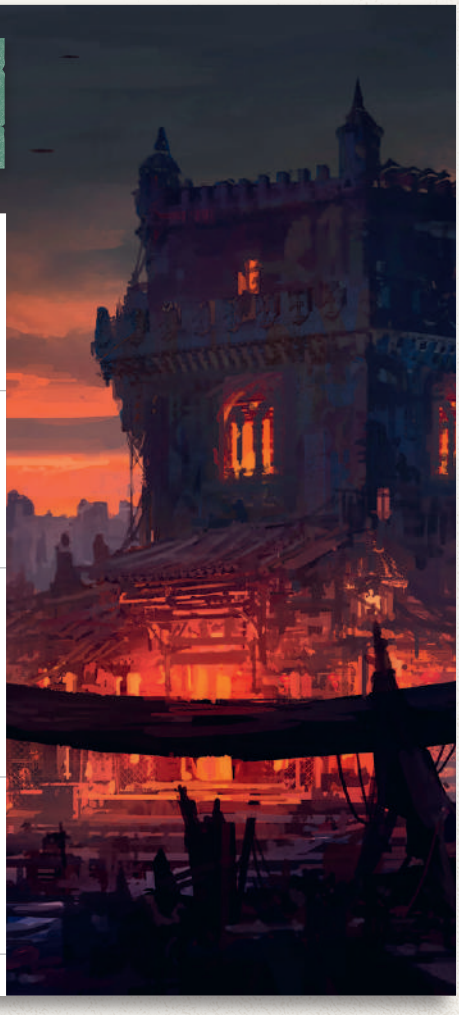
POPULATION People in Escorchia are recognised for their loose-fitting, white tunics and black leather bags full of water. They both respect and fear the heat of the dunes, and rarely travel far from their home settlement.

SECRET Towns and villages are so well hidden, it can lead to isolated communities and slow spread of national news. Many people don't know that a group of sand cyclopses have been pillaging border settlements.

SETTING • COUNTRY • SURVIVAL • RISKY

Bansheeran

Country where fiends are worshipped.



Sediment sticks to the soles of your boots as you march across the flaming, dark, rocky terrain. You taste an unnatural tang of bloody iron in the air.

KNOWN FOR Bansheeran is a country characterised by its worship of dark demigods and fiends. Its people cause destruction and harm in an attempt to get the attention and favour of their wicked overlords. A strict social ladder is imposed by the fiends, and promotions are rewarded for evil deeds.

APPEARANCE High iron content in the soil and scorch marks left behind by infernal portals have created a dark, craggy landscape. Even the beaches have black sand.

POPULATION Bansheeran people settle around the castles and keeps that pepper the landscape. These fortresses are remnants of the region's long military history.

HISTORY Centuries ago, the ruler of Bansheeran made a pact with a fiend to end a brutal war. The deal backfired, and fiends seized power.

SECRET A rebel group of celestials has infiltrated the country. They are trying to climb the social ladder and overthrow the fiendish dictator.

SETTING • COUNTRY • HORROR • DANGEROUS

What is the relationship between the villagers, townsfolk and city-dwellers in this country?

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Theotalis

Opulent country rich in silver.

The gleaming, silver spire of Castle Theotalis rises into the sky like a finger reaching for the heavens. The paintings you've seen didn't do it justice.

KNOWN FOR Silver veins are found in abundance across Theotalis. The extraction, refinement and export of this valuable commodity is the backbone of their thriving economy. The silver trade enables the Theotalis population to enjoy luxuries reserved for the wealthy in neighbouring realms.

GEOGRAPHY Theotalis has large areas of forested highlands. The rolling southern hills are mined more heavily than the jagged northern mountain peaks.

POPULATION Citizens live in wealthy towns and cities, safely distant from the busy mines. Silver is sacred here and stealing it carries harsh, often unforgiving consequences.

HISTORY At one time, most of the population worked in small, locally run mines. The process has since been industrially mechanised.

SECRET Old, enchanted silver statues are scattered across Theotalis. They offer riddles, advice or snippets of forgotten history to those who ask.

SETTING • COUNTRY • EXPLORATION • SAFE

Osomekh

Country built on rigid order.

KNOWN FOR Osomekh's motto is "order over all", and citizens take it very seriously. Roads are built on a meticulous grid system, and state-run aptitude tests help determine citizens' jobs and relationships.

GEOGRAPHY Osomekh's natural environment is tightly controlled by magic. The climate is mild year-round, with weather events carefully scheduled. Plants grow in approved zones and are shaped to precise specifications.

POPULATION Nearly all of Osomekh's inhabitants are native-born, as the country's strict laws discourage outsiders. Those who score as "chaotic" in aptitude tests are placed under increased surveillance.

SECRET Some of the country's citizens are magical clones. They were engineered to fill population quotas, vote predictably, and suppress rebellions. They have no idea about their true identity or purpose.

SETTING • COUNTRY • MAGIC • SAFE

Dolowroth

Cursed land with tainted magic.

KNOWN FOR A necromancer recently seized Dolowroth and twisted the country to their design. They have defiled this once peaceful land and are using its naturally abundant magic to power their dark rituals.

GEOGRAPHY Magical shadows have shrouded the entire country in perpetual twilight, obscuring its borders and cutting it off from neighbouring lands. Without sunlight, crop fields have withered and died.

POPULATION Dolowroth's people live in fear, unable to resist the mage's power or army of undead. Their land's magic is tainted – any spell not cast by the necromancer backfires with disastrous results.

SECRET Deep in one of the country's cursed forests lies a hidden sanctuary where magic still works as it should. It is protected by satyrs and sprites who oppose the mage and are seeking help in a fight against the undead.

SETTING • COUNTRY • HORROR • DANGEROUS

If your country borders others, think about whether the lands have good relationships or are in conflict.

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Tulorat

Country of underground burrows.

KNOWN FOR Tulorat's cosy underground tunnels were crafted long ago to shelter travellers from the fierce arctic winds above. Over time, the entire country settled below, abandoning their frosty homes above.

GEOGRAPHY Above ground, Tulorat is a frozen tundra with howling gusts and short winter days. This chilly gloom made the warm, quiet tunnels a welcoming refuge, and now the burrows span for miles and miles.

POPULATION The country's inhabitants tend to their cave gardens and care for the winding tunnels. They live a peaceful, close-knit life in villages beneath the surface. Pale skin and light sensitivity are common traits here.

SECRET Some tunnels shift and change over time, revealing hidden paths that only the boldest explorers could find. These secret routes may lead to stunning caverns or hidden natural treasures.

SETTING • COUNTRY • EXPLORATION • SAFE

Fozanzia

Magical, smog-filled wasteland.

You can just about make out the ruins in the distance. An enormous winged shadow briefly blocks out the sun, before disappearing into the ever-present smog.

KNOWN FOR Once a hub of arcane research, the land of Fozanzia is now an uninhabitable wasteland. An attempt to artificially recreate draconic breath for weaponry went awry, and now a cloud of magical fallout blankets the country. Those who survived the blast have been forever changed by it.

GEOGRAPHY The land's old weather patterns have been replaced by thick draconic smoke. The smog shifts between scorching golden yellow in the day, to a freezing grey at night.

POPULATION Only the hardiest of creatures remain in Fozanzia, many notably mutated. Dragons and wyverns that were once test subjects now roam the skies.

HISTORY Fozanzia has a long history of magical technology and innovation. The land's arcane potency made the failed experiment truly catastrophic.

SECRET If a living creature survives the haze for long enough, their skin absorbs the smog and they develop their own weaponised breath.

SETTING • COUNTRY • SURVIVAL • DANGEROUS

More Countries

1. **ACRENNE** Recently independent and voting for leadership.
2. **LOGRIN** Repeated coups have led to widespread anarchy.
3. **DREOBAR** Ancient country with an immortal dragon leader.
4. **ESARIA** Education-focused land where citizens study for life.
5. **ISLE OF OZERANT** Isolated nation and naval powerhouse.
6. **HIGH SELVIL** Land without currency; uses a barter economy.
7. **BORRINICA** Citizens prove their worth by 18 or are banished.
8. **TICTON** Small but proud nation, known for fabric-making.
9. **LITHOLD** Religious state and site of many famous miracles.
10. **KLEPPORIM** In an era of emerging arcane technology.

Riredin

Country isolated in the mountains.

KNOWN FOR Nestled in a remote mountain basin, Riredin is largely cut off from the outside world. Its isolation has preserved a unique rhythm of life shaped by the land.

GEOGRAPHY Riredin is walled-in by towering peaks. Its warm, dry climate nurtures golden grasses, rare plants, and untouched springs, all shielded from the outside world.

SECRET Elemental spirits watch over Riredin, keep its people healthy, and fertilise its soil. Some believe in and tell stories of the spirits, but many see the guardians as folklore.

SETTING • COUNTRY • WHIMSY • SAFE

Does your country share a common tongue, or are multiple languages spoken?

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The Draco Dynasty

Dragon and dragonborn co-rulers.

An impassive figure sits on an alabaster throne. Beyond, a grand archway frames the watchful head of an immense copper dragon. Together, the pair radiate power and majesty.

KNOWN FOR For generations, two monarchs have ruled over the realm side by side – one a dragon, one a dragonborn humanoid from the ancient House Draco. The ruling duos are bonded from an early age and lead in tandem, whether passing laws, waging war or negotiating peace. When one of the bonded pair dies, the survivor abdicates their position and passes the throne to a new pairing.

GOAL The Draco Dynasty system of dual rulers was established thousands of years ago to stop wars between humanoids and dragons. All rulers have a duty to maintain this stability. The current rulers are also focused on preserving the ancient magic of their realm, which they fear is fading. They do so by seeking rare magical artefacts to add to their hoard and bolster their kingdom's power.

FEATURE Heraldry is updated for every new ruling pair, to indicate a new reign. The current king wears green and silver robes, whereas his grandmother's purple standard had a golden dragon's claw.

LEADERSHIP The monarchy is not strictly hereditary. A dragon and dragonborn pair are selected by a succession council. In practice, almost all dragonborn rulers in history have come from House Draco.

SECRET Many of the rare artefacts collected to preserve the realm's magic are actually dangerous relics sealed away from the populace. The royal hoard is less a treasure trove and more a containment vault.

KEY MEMBERS

King Grayaz II – Aloof and calm dragonborn co-ruler of the land.

Grimheld – Impatient copper dragon co-ruler.

Lelwyn, the King Consort – Grayaz's elven knight husband.

FACTION • MICRO (1–5) • FRIENDLY • CIVIC

King Roiswell

King with access to vast knowledge.

KNOWN FOR King Roiswell's intelligence far surpasses anyone else in the realm. His vast knowledge is kept in a massive royal library, which he can mentally access as if it were part of his own mind.

APPEARANCE The king wears a platinum diadem encrusted with glowing sapphires, which connects his mind to his collection of books and writings. The crown leaves a deep mark on his papery, age-spotted skin.

GOAL King Roiswell uses his accumulated knowledge for the good of kingdom. He finds cures for rare illnesses, advises farmers on agricultural methods, and makes shrewd investments to boost the crown's coffers.

SECRET He secretly communicates with mysterious otherworldly entities through his diadem. By doing so, King Roiswell can gain even more knowledge in exchange for unseen favours.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • GNOME • SAGE — MAGE / ARCHMAGE

Think about how being in a position of power influences an NPC's behaviour and attitude.

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Crown Bearer Gabimius Skort IV

Charitable royal living an ordinary life.

KNOWN FOR This monarch rejects all trappings of wealth and grandeur. She has moved to a cottage on the royal estate, and can often be found fixing its leaking thatched roof. She prefers to be known simply as Gabi.

APPEARANCE Gabi wears a simple linen shirt and trousers, with patched work boots. Her long hair is tied back with a leather strap and a floppy straw hat protects her freckled complexion from the sun.

GOAL Gabi strives to end inequality in the realm by redistributing her wealth and encourages others to do the same. She is aware her way of life is seen as foolish by many nobles, and even treasonous by others.

SECRET If Gabi abdicates her title completely, she fears the crown will go to one of her less charitable cousins. Gabi is working with constitutional advisors to end the realm's line of succession once and for all.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • ELF-HUMAN • NOBLE

NOBLE / DRUID

The Dei'Sanguin Line

Elite descendants of the gods.

KNOWN FOR The divinely blessed Dei'Sanguin bloodline can be traced back to the gods themselves. Dei'Sanguin descendants are found in ruling families in many realms.

GOAL Dei'Sanguin elders are dedicated to continuing their illustrious family line and maintaining its prestige. They punish those they see as bringing shame to the family name.

SECRET A handful of commoners exhibit the celestial powers and distinctive crimson hair of the Dei'Sanguin family, but aren't recorded on the official family tree.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • NEUTRAL • CIVIC

House of Tobine

Scheming family looking to retain power.

KNOWN FOR The patriarch of the House of Tobine seized the throne in a bloody civil war less than a decade ago. The family are obsessed with maintaining their grip on power.

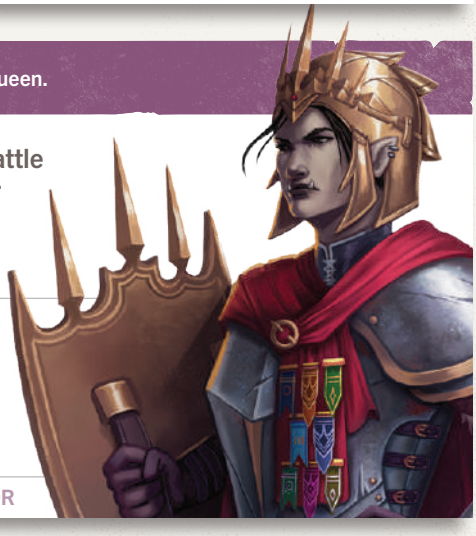
GOAL The current king wishes to secure his position by making advantageous political marriages for his children, and granting stewardship of strategic land to his supporters.

SECRET Threats to the family also come from within. Several siblings and cousins are plotting against each other to be named heir to the throne.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • HOSTILE • CIVIC

Queen Irina the Intrepid

Military-minded queen.



KNOWN FOR Irina spends as little time at court as possible. She prefers to be leading her armies as they defend her realm's borders and conquer new lands.

APPEARANCE Irina's custom battle armour bears royal insignia. Her expression is stern, and her sense of humour is limited.

GOAL As ruler, Irina wants to build the strongest military might in the world. She has funded new border forts and instated military service for all citizens.

SECRET She keeps a hidden truce with a nearby realm's leader, sharing intelligence to prevent future wars.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • ORC • COMBATANT

KNIGHT / GLADIATOR

Emperor Lextrice Grasphall

Despot feared by his subjects.

KNOWN FOR The Emperor has a bloody reputation for executing anyone who displeases him or questions his authority. Rebellions are quashed with speed and severity.

APPEARANCE Favouring dark colours and stark tailoring, Lextrice is tall and imposing. He insists on silence in his presence, as he refuses to speak above a whisper.

SECRET He has recently ordered multiple healers to come to the palace to treat him for a mysterious ailment. They will be killed if they publicly reveal his affliction, or fail to cure it.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • TIEFLING • NOBLE

More Royal Leaders

1. HIGHNESS EMARD Stubbornly ignores all their advisors.
2. MAJESTY ALWYNNIUS Erratic toddler, crowned at birth.
3. QUEEN ROSELIN Cursed by a jewel gifted at her coronation.
4. EMPREX BLOOM Conquering ruler looking to grow borders.
5. ARCHRULER UGUST Decadent monarch who loves parties.
6. THRONEKEEP EL Considerate leader and student of history.
7. FRESCANA III Catfolk queen who likes to nap the day away.
8. BELZAC THE FREE Known to travel their land on horseback.
9. THE SUPREMECY Ancient, fey ruler who loves their people.
10. KING SOFEN Inherited the crown after twelve abdications.

Is the ruler willing to seek counsel from others, or are they used to getting their own way?

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First Blade Treybun Sluth VII

Hereditary figurehead.

KNOWN FOR Treybun's prestigious military rank is inherited; it was given to his family generations ago. He holds absolute authority over the land, but has no leadership experience.

APPEARANCE Treybun models his look on a famous portrait of the ancestor who earned his family's title. He wears a stylish replica uniform and dyes his brown beard blonde.

SECRET Unknown to Treybun, one of his closest confidants is a spy for a rival nation. He regularly complains to her that his leadership council don't take his suggestions seriously.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HALFLING • NOBLE

High Marshal Lalia Chamtri

Psychic supreme leader.

KNOWN FOR Lalia serves as the country's High Marshal. She has a solid track record of predicting invasions and battle outcomes, drawing on her innate psychic abilities.

APPEARANCE The burden of responsibility is visible in the dark circles beneath Lalia's sorrowful brown eyes and the frayed edges of her suit. She speaks with a slow cadence.

SECRET Lalia relies on mana-boosting tinctures to keep her psychic abilities potent. Their effects are fading, leaving Lalia increasingly drained each time she uses divination.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • ORC-HUMAN • SPELLCASTER

Jerebiah Delwin

Selfless commander who still fights.

KNOWN FOR Jerebiah was elected as leader for his selfless bravery. Despite his lofty rank, he insists on fighting beside his troops in every conflict.

APPEARANCE Jerebiah shuns all formal signifiers of leadership. His simple armour and weapons make him look like any other soldier in the armies he leads.

GOAL Jerebiah values his troops above conquest. He never retreats if a soldier of his is in danger, and goes to extreme lengths to rescue them.

SECRET Jerebiah's helmet belonged to a fallen comrade. He is unaware that the item carries a divine blessing that gives him extra protection in battle.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • ELF • COMBATANT — WARRIOR VETERAN / GLADIATOR

Battalion Noir

Covert military council.

KNOWN FOR A force of unknown number, the Battalion Noir rules without a figurehead, issuing laws and decrees as one voice. They wear metallic black armour and helmets.

GOAL They quietly root out corruption, treason and heresy nationwide. After each operation, Battalion Noir agents leave no footprints, witnesses or evidence behind.

SECRET Battalion members drink a concoction during their initiation that boosts their strength, but causes fiendish changes to their bodies. Many do not survive the ordeal.

FACTION • MEDIUM (20–49) • NEUTRAL • MILITARY

The Beast Captains

Cavalry leaders with wild mounts.

KNOWN FOR Each captain rides a powerful beast, like a polar bear, dire wolf, big cat or giant lizard. They are all formidable leaders, highly revered by the population.

GOAL Captains train and lead beast-mounted forces in their local province. They also serve as representatives of their region on a national war council.

SECRET The Beast Captains have been urged to grant a seat on the war council to a frontier area, despite the province's historic use of unstable and untrained hybrid beasts.

FACTION • MICRO (1–5) • NEUTRAL • MILITARY

More Military Leaders

1. SKY MARSHALL HORNE Commands from a fleet of airships.
2. GENERAL NATA Promoted because of a misunderstanding.
3. THIRTEEN Anonymous spymaster with a wide network.
4. WAR CHIEF AYIA Heads a mercenary unit, available for hire.
5. CAPTAIN HULAN Plotting a bloody coup against their boss.
6. THE QUARTERMASTER In charge of high-tech military gear.
7. MAJOR TAH Retired officer who consults on battle tactics.
8. ADMIRAL IRING Insists their fickle orders must be followed.
9. COMMANDER GREY Respected and trusted by their navy.
10. THE HIGHSWORD Starts wars based on personal feuds.

Warden Terese Lowbane

No-nonsense logistics expert.

KNOWN FOR Warden Lowbane prioritises organisation of troops, weapons and supplies. She makes sure every settlement remains fortified, prepared and supported.

APPEARANCE Lowbane wears khaki gear and combat boots, always clutching a clipboard and quill. She strides through camps, barking orders and tracking logistical details.

SECRET A junior officer over-ordered bedrolls, causing a country coffer shortfall. Lowbane now slashes essential spending and scrambles to fix the growing financial crisis.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • HUMAN • OFFICIAL

Are military leaders only called upon in times of conflict? How does their role change in peacetime?

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Admiral Linnaeus Lox

Ageing aerial leader.

The Admiral tilts his head and studies you with beady eyes. He glances over your outfit, blinks, then locks eyes again. His feathered brow makes him hard to read.

KNOWN FOR Linnaeus rose swiftly through the ranks from his days as a fledgling cadet, and now commands the nation. Known for his sharp insight, battle-tested wisdom, and shrewd leadership, Linnaeus commands deep respect in the war room – from both generals and junior officers. He relies on airborne scouts to gather intel from distant lands.

APPEARANCE Lox's navy-blue coat and gleaming gold armour are always immaculate, as is his proud scarlet plumage. He wears a legendary emerald sash – an honour awarded only to those who served in and survived the last world war. Though he now leans more heavily on his spear when walking, he never slouches, always standing tall with his head held high.

HISTORY Linnaeus joined the air force as a teen, like his father. He led the 33rd Expeditionary Squadron in the last great war, earning respect, and eventually rising to command the nation through hard-won experience.

GOAL Lox lives by service and discipline, driven by a vision of a safer future. He prioritises the country's security over all, believing emotions have no place on the battlefield.

SECRET Though past the age of retirement, the admiral refuses to step down while his mind and vision are sharp. He fears boredom, and doubts his junior officers will lead with the same vigour and discipline he does.

LOOT

- Weapon of warning*
- Medals of honour
- Plate armour*
- Red feathers
- Gem of seeing*
- Military uniform

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • ANIMALFOLK • COMBATANT

GUARD CAPTAIN / GLADIATOR

Army of the Unbroken Line

Hive-minded automaton overlords.

KNOWN FOR The Army of the Unbroken Line is a networked force of steam-powered automatons who overthrew their creators. They now govern every settlement, enforcing order through surveillance.

GOAL Originally built to protect, the Unbroken Line now rule with unwavering logic. They believe absolute control is kindness – eradicating disorder, disobedience and chaos to protect humanoids from themselves.

FEATURE The automatons are humanoid-shaped, powered by chest-mounted coal furnaces and each have glowing intelligence crystals buried in their heads. Their limbs creak with every clockwork movement.

SECRET A lost blueprint contains a forgotten command word that would shut down and reboot the entire army. Without it, the constructs remain unstoppable and emotionless dictators.

FACTION • HUGE (100+) • NEUTRAL • MILITARY

You can find lower-ranking soldiers on pp. 212–213.

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Rayforia Osbourne

Resentful and scheming politician.

KNOWN FOR Rayforia expected full government support after inheriting the Prime Minister role from her mother. Instead, officials seem to favour the Treasurer's voting patterns — something Rayforia openly resents.

APPEARANCE Rayforia is a stocky young woman with sharp, grey eyes and a walking cane. She is constantly scribbling notes in a small, leatherbound notebook she keeps in her inside jacket pocket.

GOAL Rayforia is determined to earn respect. She will secure full command of the realm by persuasion, manipulation, or force. She won't be overshadowed by the Treasurer or anyone else.

SECRET To undermine her rivals in government, Rayforia has been secretly feeding intelligence to a hostile country. If or when she is exposed, she plans to frame the Treasurer and seize uncontested power.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • HALFLING • OFFICIAL

BANDIT CAPTAIN / ASSASSIN

Archduke Eudoln Merced

Multilingual archduke.

KNOWN FOR Eudoln is a senior politician who has made the effort to become fluent in all of the languages of his constituents. He believes that conversing with others in their native tongue is the highest sign of respect.

APPEARANCE Eudoln is a short, slender man who has a warm smile. His long, brown hair is always tied up with a different piece of ornamentation — gifts from adoring citizens and other politicians.

GOAL As part of his public policy, Eudoln promotes language programs for children and adults. He hopes to spur cultural appreciation, as well as improving foreign relations and diplomacy with other realms.

SECRET Eudoln's love of languages stems from a childhood sailing the world on his family's pirate ship. If his upbringing was revealed, Eudoln's political rivals would claim this piratical past makes him unfit for office.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HUMAN • NOBLE

NOBLE / PIRATE

The High Tenureship

Government of undying liches.

Voluminous robes of state swamp the figure in front of you. The body beneath is little more than desiccated flesh pulled tautly over protruding bones.

KNOWN FOR This small committee has ultimate sign-off on all government matters. The role of a High Tenure has always been a lifetime appointment, intended to bring stability to the country. However, centuries ago, council members all conspired to become liches, making their positions permanent.

GOAL To secure their position, the council looks to seize every bit of power they can. They actively target any opposition voices, and are moving to limit voting rights.

LEADERSHIP The High Tenureship has five members, all known as High Tenures. Their leader is known as the Lord Tenure, and was the one who led the others to lichdom.

FEATURE Members of the council speak an archaic version of the common language, stemming from the days they first came to power.

SECRET The council presents a united front in public, but centuries together has led to bitter rivalries and internal division.

FACTION • MICRO (1–5) • HOSTILE • CIVIC

How stable is the governance of your homebrew world? How likely is rebellion, and how would it be dealt with?

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Chamber of One Voice

Ineffective elected council.

KNOWN FOR The Chamber of One Voice needs unanimous agreement to pass legislation. It's an idealistic rule that often results in deadlock, as members rarely see eye to eye.

GOAL Chamber members want to pass laws that will benefit the country's populace, but they tend to have very different views on what that should look like.

SECRET The original Chamber leader designed its process to be slow-moving. It was an attempt to resist social change, and preserve the nation's traditions and existing way of life.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • FRIENDLY • CIVIC

Panthropos Assembly

Council of regional representatives.

KNOWN FOR The Panthropos Assembly has one minister from every regional settlement. Each speaks for their own town, raising issues and voting in their home's best interest.

GOAL The Assembly aims to govern fairly and improve life for all. But, larger cities hold more voting power per minister, often skewing decisions towards wealthier populations.

SECRET Ministers are selected differently in each town. Some are elected, others inherit the role or pass divine trials. The methods are rarely shared outside the settlement.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • FRIENDLY • CIVIC

Sibella Rubens

Self-serving regent.

KNOWN FOR Since taking control of the country, Sibella has demanded farmers contribute more food to the realm's emergency stores. Meanwhile, she throws grand banquets, serving food meant for the people.

APPEARANCE Sibella has beautiful black curls that cascade down her shoulders. Regardless of where she is, she is always dressed as if she is going to a ball, complete with jewellery and a pop of red lipstick.

GOAL As Regent, Sibella wants nothing more than to indulge in all the best that the country has to offer. She openly hosts lavish parties for her wealthy and elite friends, and is unconcerned by public opinion.

SECRET Sibella has been told a blight is spreading, which will heavily affect all of the realm's agricultural production. However, she's brushed off the warnings as pessimism, and refuses to enforce rationing.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • DWARF • NOBLE

BANDIT / TOUGH BOSS

Clemys Bogson

Articulate magistrate.

KNOWN FOR A gifted magistrate with the soul of a poet. Clem's long, flowery speeches are full of confusing metaphors that distract from his valid conclusions.

APPEARANCE A gold monocle enlarges the wrinkles around Clem's left eye. He often stops to polish it carefully on his silk sleeve.

GOAL In Clem's long reign, he's done his best to diligently steward the funds of the realm. He also edits a quarterly poetry periodical in his spare time.

SECRET Clem's advisors bet on his speech lengths. Their winnings fund his popular, well-attended birthday party each year.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • ANIMALFOLK • NOBLE

NOBLE / SPY

More Political Figures

1. OTTO GREYBACK Uses bribes to fund community programs.
2. CELI SERRANO Their drunken partying gains political allies.
3. HARVEY MCDOOGLE Elected as part of a prank gone wrong.
4. RAINE STILLCREEK Travels widely to speak to constituents.
5. HOLLY MARSHMAW Brilliant administrator; awful speaker.
6. DORIAN DIGGS Incompetent but charismatic politician.
7. ELIANA FESTUS The youngest prime minister in history.
8. LUC CALVIN Minister whose votes are guided by their debtor.
9. ASPEN Awakened deer minister of wildlife and conservation.
10. ENID GARRISON Scrawny but tactical minister of war.

Lord Percy Silvershard

Ambitious young noble.

KNOWN FOR A young viscount, Percy is determined to connect every part of the country with new roads. His plans have many critics, due to high costs and long timelines.

APPEARANCE Percy has deep-brown skin and striking white locs. He is a charismatic speaker who prefers a waistcoat and rolled-up sleeves over formal robes.

SECRET Percy's plans have received backlash from advisors better served by the status quo. This has recently escalated into notes left in his office that threaten his life.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • GNOME • NOBLE

Decide whether your politician acts in the public interest or for personal gain.

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Justiciar Edna Al'weal

High judge who speaks for the divine.

A veil of radiance and majesty flows around the Justiciar. She gazes past you, seemingly looking into the world of spirits and angels.

KNOWN FOR Justiciar Al'weal is the highest authority of her faithful nation. Her multitude of roles include leading major rituals and ceremonies, consecrating sacred relics and her clergy, interpreting divine law, and manifesting the will of the gods. The Justiciar is rarely seen outside a temple.

APPEARANCE Gold and gemstone accessories decorate the gentle white silks that the Justiciar wears. Her sceptre marks her rank and channels powerful holy magic.

GOAL Justiciar Al'weal has been a devoted and zealous disciple for many of her long years. Her life is dedicated to upholding, enforcing, and spreading the will of the divine.

SECRET The Justiciar also leads a faction of clergy loyal solely to her, not the gods. These personal guards defend her with their lives.

LOOT

- Rod of absorption*
- Gem-studded rings
- Mantle of spell resistance*

JUSTICIAR
Small or Medium Humanoid

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10 (+0)	14 (+2)	23 (+6)	18 (+4)	25 (+7)	19 (+4)

Armour Class: 17
Hit Points: 190 (19d8 + 114)
Speed: 30 ft, fly 20 ft
Initiative: +16

Saving Throws: DEX +9, INT +11, WIS +14
Skills: History +11, Insight +14, Perception +14, Persuasion +11, Religion +11
Damage Resistances: Necrotic, Psychic, Radiant
Senses: Truesight 60 ft
Passive Perception: 24
Languages: Abyssal, Celestial, Common
Proficiency Bonus: +7

ABILITIES

Holy Warden. While within 30 ft of at least two religious allies, the justiciar can cast one of the following spells, requiring no material components, using the spell's normal casting time, and using Wisdom as the spellcasting ability (spell save DC 22): *Augury, Bless, Sanctuary, Scrying, or Unseen Servant.* The justiciar must finish a Long Rest before using this trait to cast that spell again.

Legendary Resistance (4/Day). If the justiciar fails a saving throw, it can choose to succeed instead.

Magic Resistance. The justiciar has advantage on saving throws against spells and magical effects.

Beacon of Radiance. Celestial creatures within 60 ft of the justiciar have advantage on attack rolls and saving throws.

Glorious Ascension. If the justiciar dies, it returns to life in 1d6 days as a Solar with all the memories from its mortal life.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The justiciar makes two Holy Sceptre attacks and uses Prophecy.

Holy Sceptre. Melee Weapon Attack: +7 to hit, reach 5 ft, one target. Hit: 12 (4d6) damage.

Prophecy (3/Day). The justiciar utters a prophetic word. Whenever a prophecy is spoken, a different effect takes place, as detailed below (the sequence resets when the justiciar takes a Long Rest):

The Fear of Righteousness. Wisdom Saving Throw: DC 22, each enemy within 100 ft of the justiciar. Failure: The target becomes Frightened for 1 minute.

The Burden of Guilt. Wisdom Saving Throw: DC 22, each enemy within 100 ft of the justiciar. Failure: The target has disadvantage on Wisdom-based checks and subtracts 6 (2d6) from all damage rolls. It repeats the save at the end of each of its turns, ending the effect on itself with a success.

The Light of the Heavens. Constitution Saving Throw: DC 22, each enemy within 100 ft of the justiciar. Failure: 44 (8d10) radiant damage, and the target falls Prone. Success: Half damage only.

Spellcasting. The justiciar casts one of the following spells, requiring no material components and using Wisdom as the spellcasting ability (spell save DC 22):

At Will: *Command, Detect Evil and Good*

2/Day Each: *Destructive Wave (Radiant), Dispel Magic, Greater Restoration, Teleport.*

BONUS ACTIONS

Misty Step (3/Day). The justiciar casts *Misty Step*, using the same spellcasting ability as Spellcasting.

REACTIONS

Protective Wards. The justiciar casts *Counterspell* or *Shield* in response to a spell's trigger, using the same spellcasting ability as Spellcasting.

LEGENDARY ACTIONS: 3 USES

Immediately after another creature's turn, the justiciar can expend a use to take one of the following actions. The justiciar regains all expended uses at the start of each of its turns.

Word of Authority. The justiciar uses Spellcasting to cast *Command*. The justiciar can't take this action again until the start of its next turn.

Wonderflash. Constitution Saving Throw: DC 22, one creature the justiciar can see within 100 ft. Failure: 17 (5d6) Radiant damage, and the target's Hit Point maximum decreases by an amount equal to the damage taken. The justiciar can't take this action again until the start of its next turn.

Otherworldly Grace. The justiciar moves up to half its speed, and makes one Holy Sceptre attack.

CHALLENGE RATING 17

You could alternatively use the stats of a Priest CR 2, Mage CR 6 or Archpriest CR 12.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • ELF • WORSHIPPER

Religious leaders are a good thematic choice for a world where gods are present and active.

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Slumber Speakers

Prophets who dream to commune.

KNOWN FOR Slumber Speakers enter divine dream states, wearing violet robes and floppy hats. Eye tattoos on their cheeks mark rank, earned through years of communion.

GOAL Speakers interpret divine will through visions, which priests transcribe into sacred law. They dwell in isolation, preserving spiritual purity within a remote monastery.

SECRET Being a Slumber Speaker isn't as easy as it sounds. Confidentially, dreamers don't always make it back from the ether. Lost Speakers live on, but their minds are gone forever.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • NEUTRAL • RELIGIOUS

Elderdruid Ugadar Teak

Experienced druidic elder.

KNOWN FOR Ugadar is ancient; his potent connection to nature has kept him alive beyond a normal lifetime. As Elderdruid, he serves as a mouthpiece for the natural world.

APPEARANCE Chestnut fur covers Ugadar's hunched form. After years of wildshaping, his body has taken on permanent animal traits, like hawk eyes and goat horns.

SECRET Ugadar has taught many druids who rose to archdruid status. He will soon reveal that his latest pupil will be his last, in favour of a much-needed sabbatical.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • GOBLINOID • NATURALIST

Mylio Vestabulon

Interpreter of celestial constellations.

KNOWN FOR As High Chronologer, Mylio guides the realm with wisdom and grace, aligning laws, festivals and rituals to the celestial rhythms of the stars. His divine readings bring harmony, unity and hope to all.

APPEARANCE Mylio wears a tailored teal suit stitched with constellations. His golden mantle holds a ticking orrery — an accurate map of the solar system. He must walk with a straight back to not disturb the mechanism.

GOAL Mylio must balance divine insight with political demands when shaping the national calendar. Every decision draws scrutiny from nobles, priests, diplomats and councils vying for their own celestial favour.

SECRET Each year, a sacred holiday aligns with a constellation called Pan's Pentagon. This year, its radiant flares promise abundant harvests — news that Mylio plans to reveal as a joyous surprise in his next address.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HUMAN • WORSHIPPER

MAGE / ARCHPRIEST

Skull Wardens

Protectors of spiritual balance.

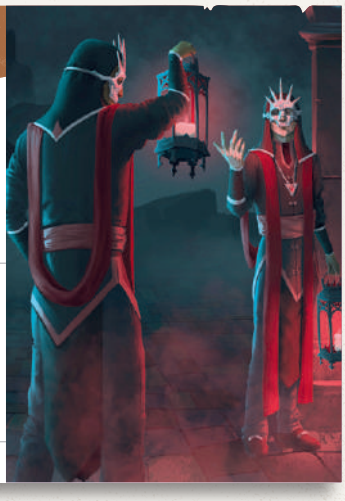
KNOWN FOR The Skull Wardens govern by maintaining order between life and death. They map the veil, ensuring souls transition well and the dead never return.

GOAL The Wardens guide both spirit and state. Their sacred duty is to preserve balance, recruiting only the most devoted to serve the dead and rule the living.

FEATURE Wardens wear dark robes and horned skull masks. Their trademark red lanterns cast an eerie glow, and light up both physical and otherworldly threats.

SECRET A warden was ambushed and possessed by a ghost last week. The ghost-warden has attacked twice since, killing three other clerics.

FACTION • MEDIUM (20–49) • NEUTRAL • RELIGIOUS



Goldwin Grail

Enforcer of divine justice and order.

KNOWN FOR Goldwin rules by divine right, and sends her paladin task forces to crush regional threats with holy fire and steel. She is guided by a council of clergy.

APPEARANCE The plate armour Goldwin wears gives her the bulk of a walking steel tank. She also wears a flowing tabard, a belt full of spell components, and a deep frown.

SECRET One of Goldwin's captains fell in battle last week; she is yet to tell their family. Instead, she hopes to recover the body from the frontline and raise the soldier back to life.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • DWARF • WORSHIPPER

More Religious Leaders

1. VESSEL ALINT Teen embarking on a lifetime leadership role.
2. KLINE REUL Thoughtful priest who listens more than talks.
3. HIGH TEMPERATE Oversees a council of spiritual groups.
4. YELECH WRAY Imprisoned for their controversial teachings.
5. HEVA ROLAN Returned from a resurrection with new beliefs.
6. VOX DIVINER FARSTO II Struggling to unite divided factions.
7. ELDER JIL Nervously preparing for a once-in-a-lifetime ritual.
8. WARDEN FREJASSON Guardian of the realm's oldest shrine.
9. GODSHAND PALMO Can perform miraculous mass healings.
10. ATIERA O'CRACHAN Scholar of divine history and texts.

These NPCs could also act as spiritual advisors for other types of leader.

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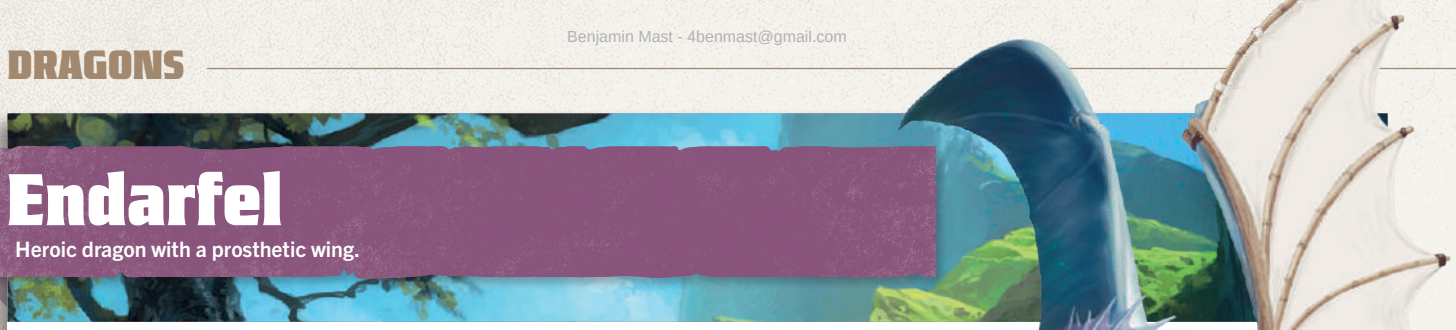

Endarfel

Heroic dragon with a prosthetic wing.

Leather buckles and straps wrap around Endarfel's mirrored silver body — a harness for her prosthetic wing. Her tail moves with a python-like will of its own.

KNOWN FOR Endarfel defeated an invading army, so is seen as a national hero. However, her left wing was damaged during the valiant last stand. Grateful locals came together to build a wooden wing for Endarfel after the conflict ended, so the "Silver Saviour" could return to the skies.

APPEARANCE The Silver Saviour's whipping silver tail trails behind her as she walks. Her wing prosthetic is made from ship sail linen attached to an opposable wooden frame.

GOAL Endarfel is slowly learning to fly again, and is hoping to master the skill soon, so she can teach her children. The four eggs in her cave home are almost ready to hatch.

SECRET In her mercy, Endarfel let a portion of the invading army flee. She knows they will return with greater forces any day now.

LOOT

- Dragon egg
- Silver dragon scales
- Potion of flying*

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • DRAGON • COMBATANT

WYVERN / ADULT SILVER DRAGON

Skadsaryx

Wyrmling trying to gather followers.

KNOWN FOR Skadsaryx is desperate to gather a following larger than his formidable brother's. He attacks villages and terrifies people into becoming his devoted minions.

APPEARANCE His scaly crimson face is punctuated by two chameleon-like eyes. Skadsaryx constantly shifts his gaze over his minions, paranoid they are his brother's agents.

SECRET Skadsaryx is too young to have developed the fiery breath that red dragons are famous for. Instead, he exhales weak puffs of sooty grey smoke.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • DRAGON • NOBLE

Ostergator

Dragon with outlandish demands.

KNOWN FOR Each month, Ostergator demands rare gifts from the townsfolk — anything from pearls to magic tomes. She forces them to travel far and appease her whims.

APPEARANCE Ostergator's jet-black scales and jagged horns are caked in layers of mud and moss. She spends her time lazily submerged in the thick swamp of her lair.

SECRET By confiscating artefacts and magic items from the nearby town, Ostergator hopes to weaken them. When the time is right, she will strike and claim the town as a new lair.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • DRAGON • OUTLAW

The Wave Lord, Tortugan

Dragon turtle who protects sailors.

KNOWN FOR If your ship is attacked by pirates or collides with sharp rocks, there's a chance that the enormous dragon turtle Tortugan will come to save you. Survivors ride his island-sized shell to safe shores.

APPEARANCE Tortugan's walnut-coloured, leathery skin is striped yellow like a terrapin. His mountainous shell is spotted with flapping flagpoles — tokens of gratitude from rescued sailing crews.

GOAL The Wave Lord has seen many wreckages in the depths of the ocean, and his heart breaks at the loss. He spends his days making the seas safer, and looks out for sailors or animals in distress.

SECRET He wouldn't admit it, but Tortugan isn't the best with directions. Journeys on the Wave Lord's back can take considerably longer than expected, and survivors may be dropped off in a location they didn't request.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • DRAGON • WAYFARER

GIANT CROCODILE / DRAGON TURTLE

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Spreathsnipes

Deadly drakes who prey on livestock.

KNOWN FOR Spreathsnipes are dreaded livestock predators, known to decimate entire herds in one night. These powerful drakes have even been witnessed devouring fierce wolves, bears and wild boar.

APPEARANCE Each Spreathsnipe resembles a dragon without wings – thick-limbed, low to the ground, with mottled green-grey scales for camouflage. They lie still in the undergrowth before lunging at their prey.

TACTICS These drakes are solitary hunters with vast territories. They prowl around looking for food, often at night. Spreathsnipes are defensive of their kills and will attack any scavengers who attempt to sneak a bite.

SECRET No farmer would dare take on a Spreathsnipe one-on-one. But, old tales speak of locals driving off Spreathsnipes with instruments – loud noises are one of the few things these drakes are scared of.

CREATURE • LARGE • HOSTILE • DRAGON — CROCODILE / ALLOSAURUS

The Salamandrux

Coexisting chromatic dragon community.

KNOWN FOR The five dragons of The Salamandrux – red, blue, white, black and green – exist peacefully with one another. They fly through the skies in a colourful V-formation.

GOAL There is proof in the stars that an ancient prophecy is about to come true. It speaks of the downfall of dragons, and The Salamandrux are hoping to survive together.

SECRET The Salamandrux live together on a remote island. This mega-lair is a place of extraordinary power and beauty. It is surrounded by a magically volatile rainbow fog.

FACTION • MICRO (1–5) • NEUTRAL • SOCIAL

More Dragons

1. VILANTHE THE JUDGE Amethyst guardian of a planar gate.
2. THA'L SMOKELING Ghostly wyrm spirit tied to its former lair.
3. TIRVANYX Reclusive green dragon infected with a plague.
4. LUCDIA Uses psychic powers to turn reality into a nightmare.
5. ROOTFANG Lichen-crusted dragon; controls a vast forest.
6. PRINCESS ZAAP Juvenile blue dragon building a loyal cult.
7. ARTIM THE ALL-KNOWING Very wise ancient gold dragon.
8. MORBAXIS Cursed black dragon with insect-swarm breath.
9. SCALEBREAK Immensely strong, with a very thick hide.
10. CORALCROWN Lives in a cave at the bottom of the ocean.

Giganteus the Devastator

Territorial dragon who hunts other dragons.

Giganteus is truly an apex predator. The bony spurs that erupt from his back and tail match the razor sharp, blood-soaked teeth in his huge white maw.

KNOWN FOR Giganteus' size and bad temper cannot be understated. Anyone foolish enough to travel within five miles of his ice palace lair will face his wrath. Each winter, the Devastator leaves for a week to battle rival dragons in the region, seeking dominance and glory.

APPEARANCE The Devastator's scales fade from bone-white on his wings and torso to an icy grey around his face and claws. His bulky body is covered in spikes and scars.

GOAL Giganteus dreams of encasing the entire world in ice. To protect his growing domain, he destroys rival dragons and razes their lairs before they become threats.

SECRET After defeating a dragon, Giganteus consumes their essence. His power grows, and he will soon become a mythic greatwyrm.

LOOT

- Razor-sharp teeth
- Elemental gem (blue)*
- Dark shard amulet*

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • DRAGON • COMBATANT — WYVERN / ANCIENT WHITE DRAGON

Will the lair effects of your defeated dragon take hours, days or months to reverse?

The Winged Terror

Escaped wyvern adapting to the wild.

KNOWN FOR This wounded wyvern escaped from a gladiatorial arena, where it had been held captive since it hatched. Crowds paid to watch the so-called Winged Terror take part in fights for their amusement.

APPEARANCE The wyvern's scaled skin hangs loose on its scrawny, skeletal frame. Broken chains dangle from its right foot, clanking as it flies, and a large tarnished brass collar chafes against its neck and jaw.

TACTICS In captivity, the wyvern's diet was strictly controlled to make it hungry before a fight, but it is now learning to hunt for itself. The Winged Terror watches birds of prey and clumsily mimics their swooping attacks.

SECRET The wyvern had a close relationship with one of its keepers, who used to feed it sweet fruit as a treat. This sympathetic keeper deliberately failed to secure the wyvern's cage one night, allowing it to escape.

CREATURE • LARGE • NEUTRAL • DRAGON

RED DRAGON WYRMLING / WYVERN

Precept Regent

Dragon sages on a lecture tour.

KNOWN FOR This jovial family of gold dragons travel the world to teach and learn from its people. One lectures on history, one hosts philosophical debates, one teaches mathematics, and one leads poetry lessons.

APPEARANCE The Precept Regent are adorned with gilded scales, and the air seems to shimmer around their intricate antlers. The father, mother, daughter, and son stand in order of size, from largest to smallest.

GOAL They believe knowledge is the key to making the world a fairer, happier and brighter place. By educating people, the Precept Regent hope to inspire the next generation of diplomats, peacemakers and leaders.

SECRET The gold dragons first visit a community in shape-shifted humanoid form before visiting them in dragon form. During this time, they decide whether the community would be receptive to their teachings or not.

FACTION • MICRO (1–5) • FRIENDLY • ACADEMIC

The Underking

Self-proclaimed underground ruler.

As your vision adjusts to the dim cavern, you make out a hulking, teal dragon. One glowing eye opens, then another. Then, the beast's lips pull back into a twisted grin, and the geodes around them light up.

KNOWN FOR The Underking claims dominion over everything beneath the surface. From his dark cavern throne, he rules all subterranean creatures, considering anything buried underground his rightful treasure. His network of spies watches for intruders and trespassers.

APPEARANCE Midnight-green scales help the Underking disappear into the darkness. He has grown large on meals brought to him by his minions, and his leathery wings have atrophied from lack of use. He rarely moves from his rocky lair.

HISTORY Born and raised in the caves, the Underking has never seen sunlight. He imprisoned his own parents to take over their cave systems and secure his rule. His cunning, manipulative mind has helped him amass an army of loyal followers who carry out his commands.

GOAL The Underking wishes to rule over everything that the sun cannot reach. He sees mining operations as a clear invasion of his territory. He therefore sends his formidable army to sabotage and destroy mineshafts, so the treasures of the deep remain his and his alone.

SECRET The Underking's milky-orange eyes are perfectly adapted to darkness, but extremely sensitive to bright light. Any intense illumination, like magic or sunlight, would instantly blind the dastardly dragon.

LOOT

Crystal ball of true seeing*	Jade dragon statue
Crown set with sapphires	Amulet of health*
Adamantine ore chunks	Goggles of night*

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • DRAGON • NOBLE

ADULT GREEN DRAGON / ANCIENT GREEN DRAGON

The only light in the Underking's lair (right) comes from huge glowing geodes with sharp edges.

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The Creeping Devourer

Vast ooze that absorbs towns.

KNOWN FOR This glacier-sized, radioactive ooze slowly crawls across the land, consuming everything. It leaves behind poisoned, sterile ground where nothing can grow.

APPEARANCE The giant, living blob is translucent and tinted in a vomit-green. It glows faintly at night, and anything the Devourer touches is stained with the same telltale glow.

SECRET Animals that live near the sickly trail of the ooze become feral and bloodthirsty. Studying them is a dangerous task, so not much is known about the altered beasts.

CREATURE • GARGANTUAN • NEUTRAL • OOZE

The Dreamwarden

Couatl in a decades-long slumber.

KNOWN FOR This couatl has been in hibernation for over a century. After foreseeing a cataclysmic event, he realised that only dreams could reveal the secrets of mortal survival.

APPEARANCE The Dreamwarden has roosted in his cold cave nest for decades. He is nearly bereft of feathers, and his fragile ribs rise with slow, almost imperceptible, breath.

SECRET The Dreamwarden is defended by a local clan of warriors. They believe this dedication will be rewarded with gifts and knowledge when the couatl finally awakens.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • CELESTIAL • SAGE

Aureulettes

Rare golden bulette subspecies.

KNOWN FOR Unlike their ordinary grey-skinned bulette cousins, this rare species has a shining gold hide. There is only a handful of Aureulettes left in the wild, making them a coveted trophy for big game poachers.

APPEARANCE The Aureulette's form is sleek and aerodynamic, making them more agile than most of their kind. Their metal-like skin provides tough armour, which glints in the sun as they burst from the earth.

TACTICS An Aureulette can defend itself from attacks with its powerful, toothy jaws and anvil-like hooves. It has also developed other survival strategies, such as bathing in mud swamps to disguise its gleaming hide.

SECRET The plates from an Aureulette's back can be used to make suits of armour. Black-market sellers sometimes sell fakes that are painted to look gold, but offer no special protection.

CREATURE • LARGE • NEUTRAL • MONSTROSITY

BULETTE / REMORHAZ

Hefydon's Curse

Undead chimera created by the gods.

KNOWN FOR Created as a divine punishment for a cruel monarch named Hefydon, this three-headed undead monstrosity cannot be killed by mortals.

APPEARANCE Attempts to kill the creature have left it a shambling, gasping corpse. Rotten flesh slips over its bones as it stalks in the shadows of the world.

TACTICS Even when this zombie-like chimera is knocked unconscious, its divine power and purpose soon revives it back to its undead state.

SECRET The creature is bound to track and kill anyone descended from Hefydon. It can only die if the monarch's bloodline ends, or if a celestial being strikes it down.

CREATURE • LARGE • HOSTILE • UNDEAD

CHIMERA / YOUNG RED DRAGON

Muthrex

Gigantic dragon-hunting behir.

KNOWN FOR Muthrex is an ethereal reptile that lives deep in the earth's crust. She is most famous for killing a mated pair of ancient gold dragons and their clutch of wyrmlings.

APPEARANCE The behir's pearlescent blue scales are dulled with age and covered in gnarled scars. Her oversized front claws allow her to burrow through earth and stone.

SECRET One of Muthrex's eyes is blood-red, and weeps crimson tears. She was partially blinded during a recent fight, and has limited vision on her right side.

CREATURE • HUGE • HOSTILE • MONSTROSITY

More Legendary Creatures

1. THE KEEPER Sphinx guardian of lost and broken objects.
2. GENTLE ONE Gargantuan manatee and fabled water spirit.
3. LAELAPS Pink hunting dogs who never tire or lose their prey.
4. NYTROSE Ink-black unicorn; its tears turn beings invisible.
5. THOTHYX Huge bird that can divide into a flock of starlings.
6. MARSH MOTHER Ancient silver capybara, said to be lucky.
7. THE TEUMESSIA FOX Hard to catch; tells unsolvable riddles.
8. FOULMARE Blood-soaked horse that grazes on battlefields.
9. TRENNOZ Huge worm that causes destructive earthquakes.
10. DUSK Wolf made from shadows that visits dying mortals.

Use these creatures to inspire bardic songs, tavern names, fairy tales and other folklore in your world.

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Verisfaun

Winged stags with healing powers.

The creature rears up on two muscular hind legs and unfurls its rainbow-feathered wings. Its eyes are shining, and regard you with a reassuring calm.

KNOWN FOR These reclusive vibrant-winged stags are a revered symbol in heraldry, and are said to appear only to the most virtuous of heroes. Rare sightings on battlefields inspire entire armies, and legends tell of soldiers miraculously healed by dropped Verisfaun feathers.

APPEARANCE The stags are chestnut brown, with antlers of dazzling crystal. Their huge wings are covered in jewel-toned feathers that shimmer like precious metals in the sun.

TACTICS A Verisfaun can heal a group with a gust of wind, or an individual through the touch of a feather. They defend themselves using sharp, crystalline hooves.

LAIR Verisfaun spend their eternal lives grazing in peaceful forest glades, camouflaged by verdant foliage. Their nests emanate a rainbow-hued mist.

SECRET A hero once made a bugle from a Verisfaun antler that could summon the creatures. They hid the item, so it could not be misused.

VERISFAUN
Medium Celestial

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
16 (+3)	12 (+1)	10 (+0)	8 (-1)	13 (+1)	10 (+0)

Armour Class: 11
Hit Points: 22 (4d10)
Speed: 20 ft, fly 60 ft
Initiative: +1

Skills: Perception +3
Passive Perception: 13
Languages: Understands Common and Celestial but can't speak
Proficiency Bonus: +2

ABILITIES

Flyby. The verisfaun doesn't provoke an opportunity attack when it flies out of an enemy's reach.

Sacred Beast. When the verisfaun dies, all creatures within 10 ft are targeted by a *Bane* spell (save DC 11), which lasts for 10 minutes.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The verisfaun makes two Antler attacks.

Antler. Melee Weapon Attack: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft, one target. Hit: 7 (1d8 + 3) piercing damage. If the verisfaun moved at least 30 ft straight towards the target immediately before the hit, the target takes an extra 4 (1d8) piercing damage.

Spellcasting. The verisfaun casts one of the following spells, requiring no material components and using Wisdom as the spellcasting ability:

1/Day Each: *Bless*, *Cure Wounds*, *Lesser Restoration*.

CHALLENGE RATING 1

You could alternatively use the stats of a Giant Owl CR 1/4, Couatl CR 4 or a Sphinx of Lore CR 11.

CREATURE • MEDIUM • FRIENDLY • CELESTIAL

Emperor Uhzizah

Spider ruler with a web of secrets.

KNOWN FOR Half man, half huge spider, this masterful being rules over all the world's arachnids. Through his web of followers, he knows more secrets than anyone else.

APPEARANCE The Emperor has a humanoid head, torso and arms, plus eight long spider legs. He has tattooed six additional black eyes around his two dark human ones.

SECRET Uhzizah's palace lair has eight rooms, and its floor is spotted with hidden trapdoors and web-covered pits. Unwitting explorers could easily become stuck inside.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • DRIDER • SAGE

Satura

Curious sphinx with much to learn.

KNOWN FOR This young sphinx is prophesied to become the wisest creature of his kind. He has spent his life in a temple, and is intensely curious about the outside word.

APPEARANCE Satura has navy-blue fur with silver eyes and claws. He is roughly the size of an elephant, but with a lithe, panther-like build. He loves meeting new visitors.

SECRET The clerics who serve Satura are under the thrall of a mind-controlling mage. The mage keeps Satura cloistered, and plans to absorb his consciousness once fully grown.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • CELESTIAL • SAGE

Dropping lore about a legendary creature early in a campaign makes for a great pay-off when the party finally meet them.

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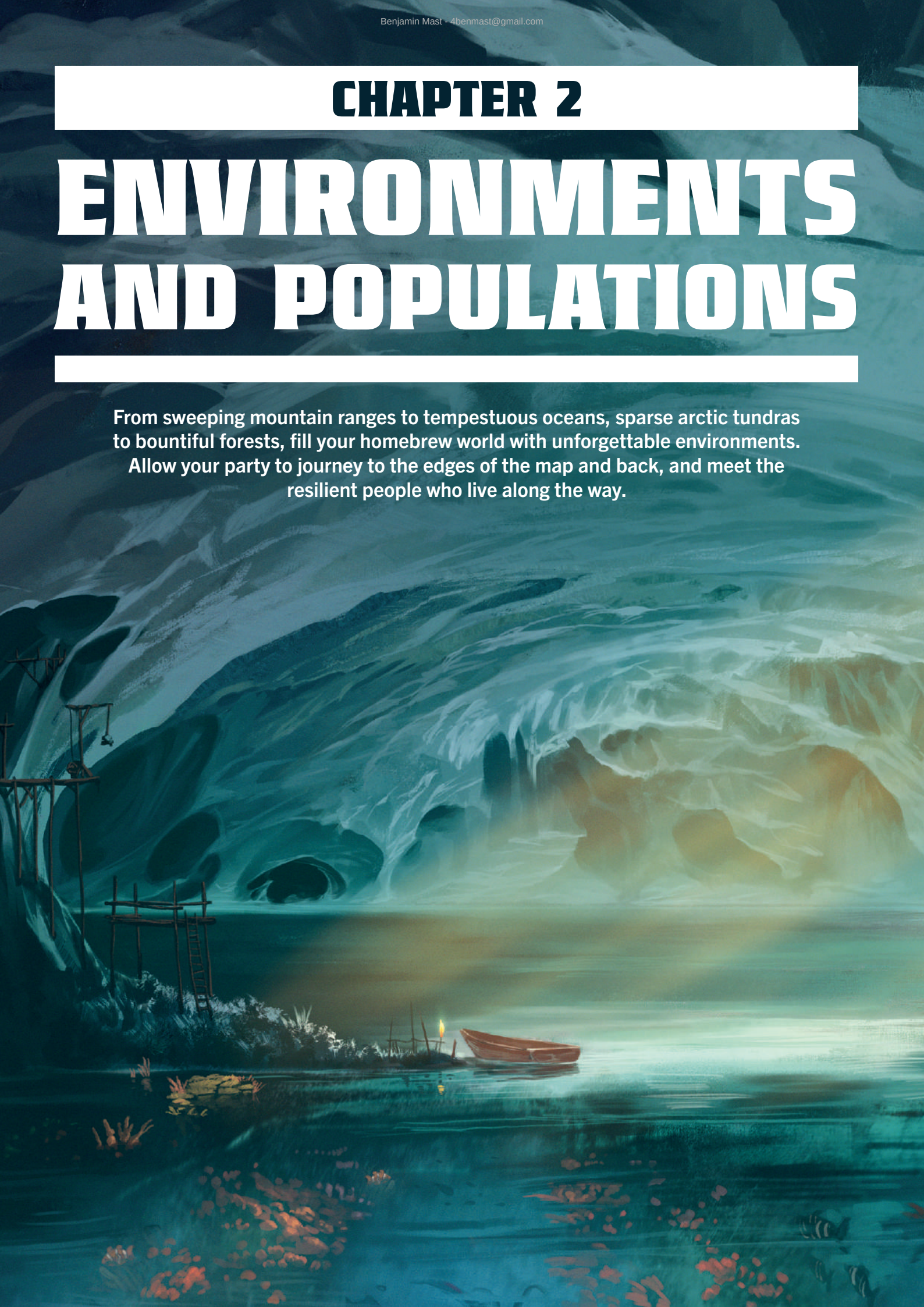
CHAPTER 2

ENVIRONMENTS AND POPULATIONS

From sweeping mountain ranges to tempestuous oceans, sparse arctic tundras to bountiful forests, fill your homebrew world with unforgettable environments. Allow your party to journey to the edges of the map and back, and meet the resilient people who live along the way.



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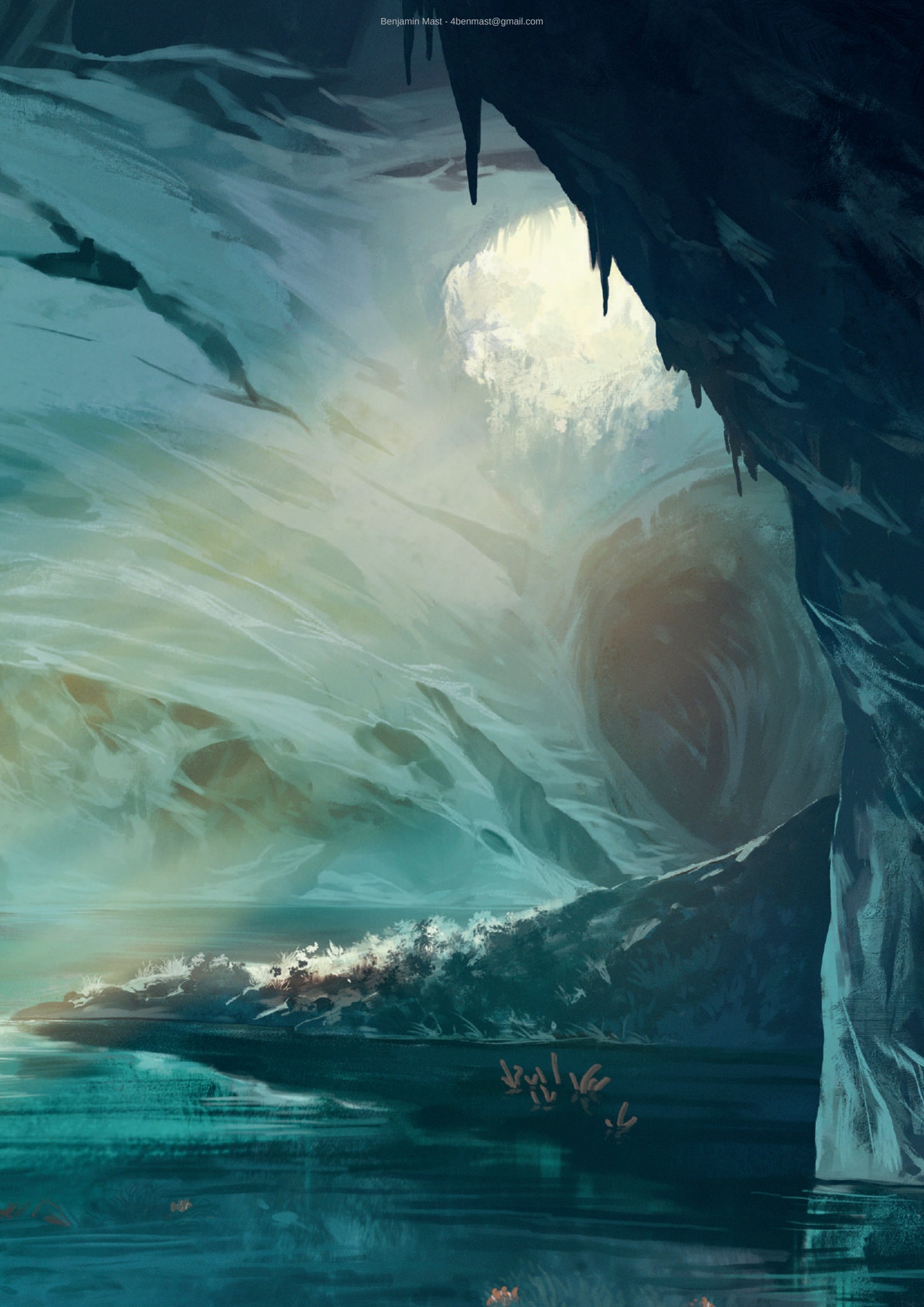

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Terrenley Thicket

Home of a legendary animal.

KNOWN FOR Many animals reside in this dense fir forest, but it is best known as the home of the legendary Bagwyn. This elusive creature resembles an antelope, with the tail of a horse and curling horns made of bark.

APPEARANCE Clustered pines and shaggy bushes provide cover for hunters scoping out their prey. A trickling stream runs through Terrenley Thicket. Deer and black bears can often be found foraging along its banks.

LOOT Deer found in the woods can be hunted for their meat, and raspberries are abundant. The region's ruler has issued a large reward for any hunter that can capture the fabled Bagwyn alive and deliver it to the palace.

SECRET The Bagwyn is the lost love of the ruler, cursed by the Thicket's resident green hag to be a beast of prey that is almost impossible to catch. If it is caught and brought to the palace, the curse will be lifted.

ENVIRONMENT • MID-SIZED • RISKY • FOREST

The Dreadwood

Forest of shadowy nightmares.

The lamplight is swallowed by the smothering darkness that surrounds you. In the shadows, every creaking branch and footstep sounds magnified.

KNOWN FOR It is said that the inky depths of the Dreadwood are the source of all nightmares. Whether or not that's true, those unlucky enough to travel through the uneven and craggy terrain of this woodland will find more than their fair share of terrifying visions and disturbing monsters.

APPEARANCE Even on the brightest day, sunlight doesn't penetrate the darkness of the Dreadwood. Its thick canopy is gnarled and free of leaves, caught in a perpetual autumn.

INHABITANTS The wood is filled with undead beings who look like glimmers of hopeful light. When you get closer, the beings morph into illusions of your greatest fears.

LOOT Wood from the forest's evil awakened trees can be used to make powerful magical items. However, the terrifying plants won't give it up easily.

SECRET The shadow beings are the trapped souls of people who died in the Dreadwood. They can only move on if purged by a cleric.

ENVIRONMENT • VAST • DANGEROUS • FOREST

Iydelgrove

Beautiful shoreline jungle.

KNOWN FOR The Iydelgrove is a scenic coastal jungle. Though hard to reach, it draws many tourists and artists inspired by its beauty, white sands and fresh coconuts.

APPEARANCE Mangrove and palm trees rise on twisted roots above the tide. Bright birds flit through the branches, and flashes of pink mark the presence of a flamingo family.

SECRET The flamingoes gained awareness after touching a washed-up magic item. They gossip about visitors, but only speak to humanoids when politely addressed.

ENVIRONMENT • MID-SIZED • SAFE • JUNGLE

The Bewildering Wilds

Disorientating mushroom forest.

KNOWN FOR Towering mushrooms here grow at unnatural speeds, releasing thick spores that distort sight and sense. Their maze-like formations make the Wilds difficult to map.

APPEARANCE The forest floor is scattered with painted arrows and stone markers. Remnants left behind by travellers who tried, and somehow succeeded, to escape the Wilds.

SECRET Fungal dryads sometimes guide the lost to safety, but for a high toll. They demand treasures like gold, silver, enchanted gear or rare jewellery in exchange for help.

ENVIRONMENT • MID-SIZED • DANGEROUS • FOREST

Describe the sounds, smells and textures of the forest your party walk through for a sensory experience.

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Smoulderdown

Charred remains of a forest.

KNOWN FOR Once a tranquil glade, the Smoulderdown now blazes with unending fire. A red dragon, who sits at its heart, sparked the inferno and claimed the land as its home.

APPEARANCE Charred trees rise like matchsticks above the scorched earth. Magical flames flicker across the forest, filling the air with shimmering heat and thick, toxic smoke.

SECRET The dragon lit the forest to incubate her eggs, which require intense heat to hatch. Hidden in the ash, they remain safe. Her destructive act was driven by maternal instinct.

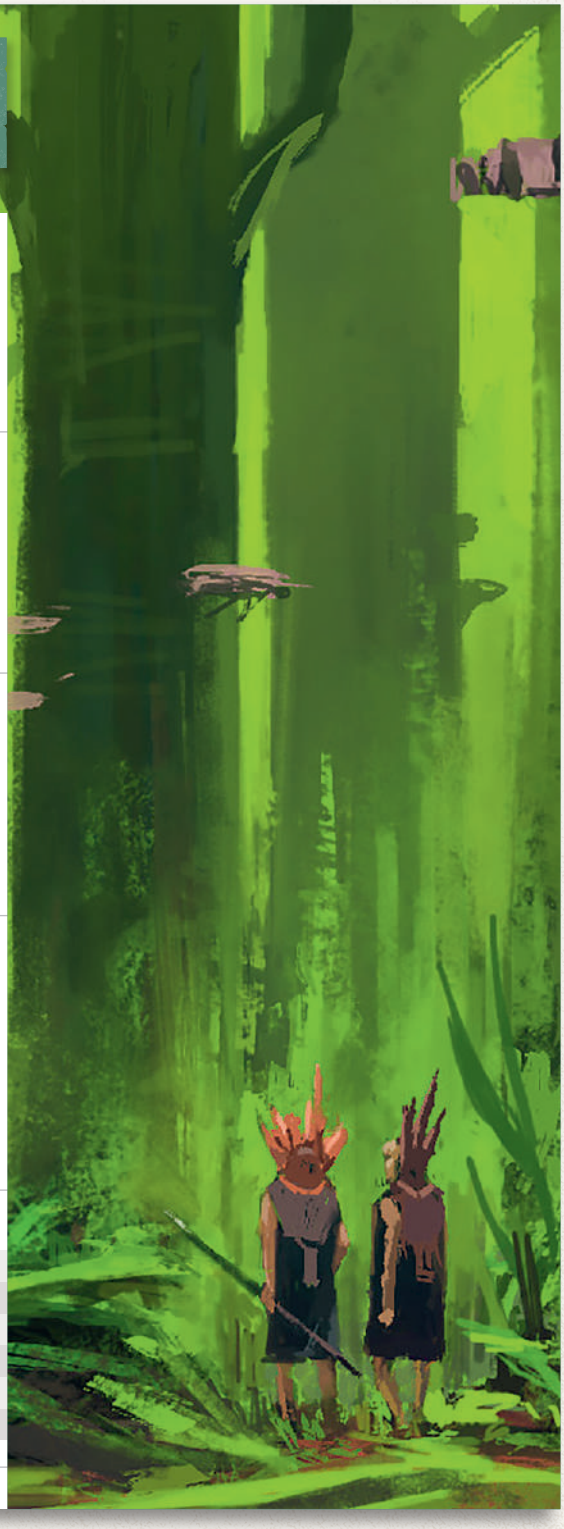
ENVIRONMENT • SMALL • DANGEROUS • FOREST

More Forests

1. **COPSE MAGI** Glade of magical trees used to make wands.
2. **AZURE PARK** Home to trees with distinctive blue foliage.
3. **ORBITAL WOOD** Trees cycle through the seasons each day.
4. **STARSHADE BAYOU** Swamp with bioluminescent plants.
5. **BAYING GLADE** Home to a large werewolf community.
6. **BRELEE BUSH** Lush rainforest, popular with bird spotters.
7. **PORTER'S END** Slowly being destroyed by illegal logging.
8. **THE TANGELLWALD** Time passes quickly within this wood.
9. **BRIGHTBLOOM** Fabled grove where rubies grow on trees.
10. **SAURIA WILDS** Jungle home to lizards and dinosaurs.

Rainforest Colossal

Jungle with giant trees and animals.



To describe the trees that stand before you as towering simply isn't accurate. They're taller than any tower you've seen and still growing. The canopy must be 500 feet above you.

KNOWN FOR Legend says that centuries ago, a giant passed through the land and accidentally dropped a pouch of enchanted acorns. These seeds grew into the oversized trees that now form the Rainforest Colossal. The immense vegetation gave rise to equally massive wildlife; poisonous horse-sized frogs and butterflies with wings as wide as bedsheets are common sights beneath the canopy.

APPEARANCE The Rainforest Colossal is tropical, meaning it's warm and misty year round. The grass here grows taller than the average human, and clearing a path through the thick undergrowth requires a sturdy cutlass or machete. Brightly coloured flowers and animals break up the greenery of the trees – but beware, many of these striking creatures have toxic stingers, fangs, barbs or spines.

INHABITANTS The incessant growth of the jungle puts off most permanent residents. However, a contingent of druids live here, and fiercely protect a "mega-oak" on the south-west edge of the forest.

LOOT Several potent poisons and medicines can be made from the plants of the Colossal, with the proper knowledge. Some of the druids walk around the jungle perimeters, and will barter with travellers.

SECRET Ancestors of the giant who dropped the seeds are journeying back to the Colossal, to claim it as their birthright. They have sent letters informing the druid caretakers, but were rudely ignored.

COMMON CREATURES

- Constrictor Snake
- Giant Boar
- Ape
- Giant Centipede
- Panther
- Dire Worg

ENVIRONMENT • VAST • RISKY • RAINFOREST

Have your party notice scars from old wildfires, half-buried ruins and ancient statues to show the forest's age.

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Arbor Memorum

Forest planted to honour fallen warriors.

A dove coos softly as it flutters through the oak tree canopy, looking for a safe spot to nest. One of its small white feathers floats down and lands on a simple slate tombstone, engraved with a shield.

Key Stats

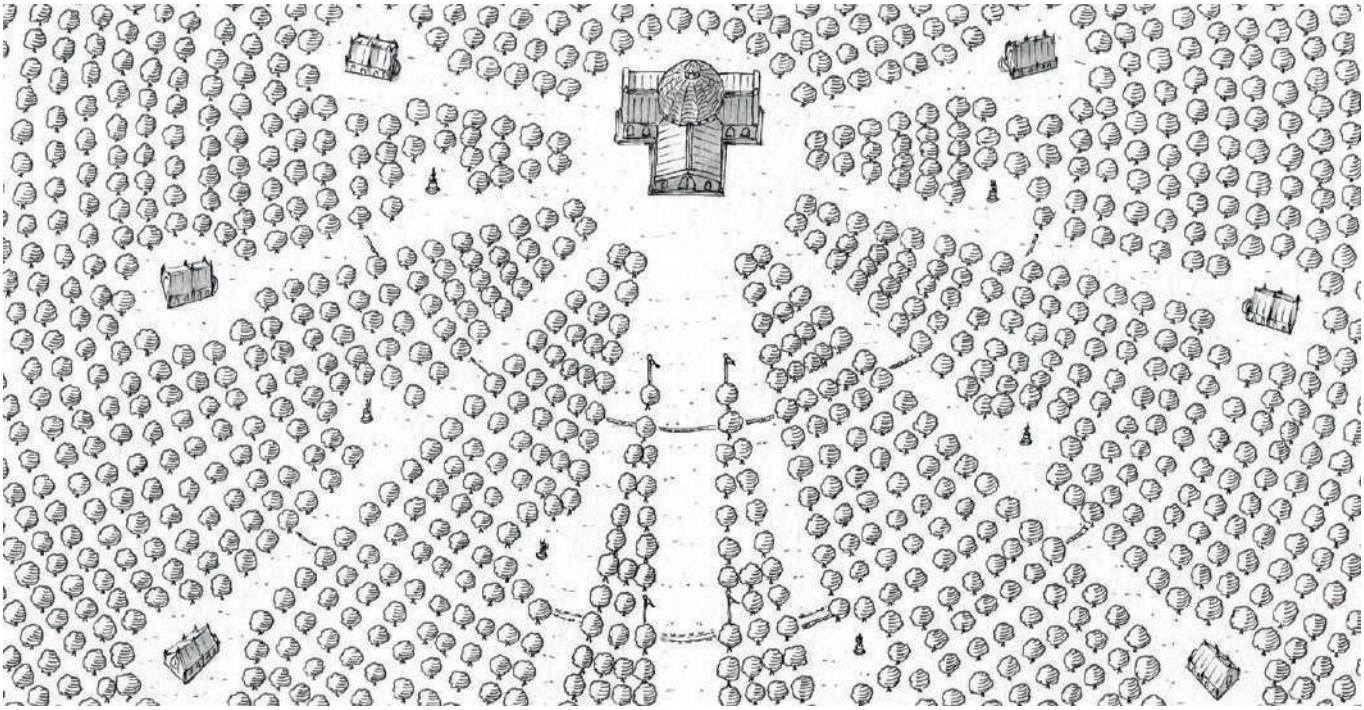
Area	25 sq. mi.
Climate	Temperate
Hazard Level	Safe
Visibility	Natural light
Ownership	Royal
Key Fauna	Mourning doves, rabbits
Key Flora	Oak trees, wildflowers

KNOWN FOR The Arbor Memorum was planted nearly 100 years ago to honour those killed in a devastating war. The former battlefield was planted with rows of oak saplings, so the land could nurture new life. The forest is now a site of remembrance and hosts annual events honouring the dead. A tradition has also developed for soldiers returning from other conflicts to bring back mementos of fallen comrades to lay in the forest.

APPEARANCE The original memorial oak trees were planted in long, uniform avenues. These key walkways are kept pruned to allow for regular processions, and allow soft light to filter onto the forest floor. Statues of senior military leaders have been erected in well-maintained glades in central locations. Elsewhere, more informal memorials can be found, such as a bunch of freshly picked wildflowers propped against a rusting battleaxe.

HISTORY This area of land was originally used as a corn farming settlement. However, an attempted takeover by a tyrannical pretender to the throne turned it into a battleground. After the war subsided, the surviving locals couldn't bring themselves to rebuild their homes on the site of such loss and turmoil. The monarch decreed that the land would become part of the royal estate and a memorial forest built. Survivors were gifted new land elsewhere, to build happier memories.

INHABITANTS During ceremonies, the forest is teeming with military personnel in full regalia. At other times, it is a quiet, peaceful spot tended to by a group of volunteer wardens and gardeners. Many of the wardens are veteran soldiers, proud to spend their retirement tending to the resting place of their peers. They are supported by a resident cleric who helps any restless souls move on peacefully. On any given day, there are also likely to be individual mourners who have come to honour a loved one.



LANDMARKS There are nine major tree-lined avenues leading through the forest, to mark the number of weeks the final battle endured for. Tombs to great leaders are positioned at the top of each avenue. A large temple in the centre of the forest hosts memorial services. Candles are also lit here to provide hope and blessings for those facing their own battles.

SECRET A powerful Vorpal Sword was buried in the forest by the family of its fallen owner, under a series of complex magical wards. A collector has recently offered a high price to any skilled (but unscrupulous) thieves willing to disturb this hallowed ground. The regular wardens have seen suspicious individuals scoping out the forest and are looking to recruit freelance security patrols.

Veteran soldiers make a solemn procession to commemorate those lost in war (right).

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Famous Burial Sites

THE SILENT DRUM Buried beneath an ancient oak, this is the final resting place of a war drummer who marched without pause through all nine weeks of the battle. Visitors often report hearing a faint rhythmic beat from the branches above when the wind is strong in this area.

BOWER OF VOWS Two soldiers, husband and wife, fell defending their comrades. Their well-tended graves lie in the shade of two twisted saplings that grew from both burial mounds. The bark bears many initials, carved by visiting couples.

HOLLOW REST Marked with a heavy tombstone but no name, this deep grave is left intentionally vacant to honour the unknown and unclaimed dead. Mourners write and throw notes into the pit, hoping that the souls of their lost loved ones might visit the site and read them.

THE UNBROKEN RING A circle of shells and stones mark this grave, where no plants grow. A battlemage is buried here, protected by lingering abjuration magic cast on them during their last stand. Mages honour them by placing a shell on the grave, but each offering is eventually drawn into the ring by unseen forces.

THE WEEPING ARCH A cluster of trees here gently weep amber sap from bubbling cracks in their bark. Below lies a stone grave with a magically sealed iron chest resting on its surface. The box's contents are locked away until a descendant of the fallen warrior returns to open it.

FALCON'S PERCH A wooden falcon statue watches over these graves. This is the final resting place of a battalion of scouts who were lost during a vital reconnaissance mission. Tweeting songbirds roost in nearby bird boxes.

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The Arboreal Knight

Celestial tree custodian.

KNOWN FOR This angelic warrior guards the forest's oldest tree with unwavering devotion. He has stood sentinel through the ages, watching in silence, always alert. His divine presence also helps the tree's growth.

APPEARANCE Wearing radiant plate armour, his face is obscured, only two glowing eyes shine from beneath his helm. Nearly eight feet tall, the Knight holds a gleaming halberd taller than himself, yet wields it effortlessly.

GOAL The Arboreal Knight must protect the ancient tree until it grows into a beacon for the heavens, a long-term quest given to him by his deity. He has stood vigil for millennia and does not know when his watch will end.

SECRET Though tireless, the Knight must return to the Celestial Realm once a year to renew his divine power. On that one day, the ancient tree is left unattended and vulnerable to damage and corruption.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • CELESTIAL • GUARD

KNIGHT / DEVA

Cinderwulf

Prowling wolf predator.

KNOWN FOR If a traveller goes missing in the woods, Cinderwulf is to blame – at least, that's what locals will tell you. This rabid, shadowy figure hunts travellers who linger for too long in its territory at night.

APPEARANCE Black fur covers the spindly humanoid frame of Cinderwulf. Drool trickles down its chin from the rows of canine teeth protruding from its mouth. The creature's eyes are pale-yellow, and bulge from its head.

TACTICS Cinderwulf's rugged form allows it to easily blend into the trees and stay hidden. The creature can easily overpower small groups, but it prefers to pick off travellers one by one, starting with the weakest.

SECRET The only way to destroy Cinderwulf is to find its hidden forest resting place during the day, and kill the creature while it slumbers. Other attempts to slay it will fail, and Cinderwulf will inevitably regenerate.

CREATURE • MEDIUM • HOSTILE • FEY

WEREWOLF / WEREBEAR

Fallow Guardians

Monks who steward the forest.

A golden talisman in the shape of an oak leaf dangles from the tight rope belt of a white-clad figure, and you notice fresh dirt under their fingernails.

KNOWN FOR Monks of the Fallow Guardians worship a nature god. They are peaceful wardens who spend many of their days foraging, planting trees and cultivating the land around the overgrown monastery ruins they call home. Under their care, forests bloom and multiply.

GOAL This group protects animals at risk, heals polluted environments and guides others in the ways of nature. Their objectives can cause them to clash with urban councils and leaders.

LEADERSHIP The monks are led by an elderly priest with the title Grand Archbishop. There are 10 bishops below him, and a handful of initiates underneath each of them.

FEATURE The Fallow Guardians wear white and brand their hands with the holy mark of their god. Symbols of permanent purity and devotion.

SECRET Only bishops know the Grand Archbishop died last year. They fear a leadership election will sow division and foster cliques.

FACTION • MEDIUM (20–49) • FRIENDLY • RELIGIOUS

How do travellers journey through the forest? Do they carve out new paths or stick to well-trodden dirt roads?

Benjamin Mast - 4benmast@gmail.com

Loggins Lumber

Fairy-run timber company.

KNOWN FOR This tiny timber company is run by the Loggins sisters, a pair of ambitious fairies. They harvest tree saplings as part of their small-scale operations, and turn the wood they chop into enchanted matchsticks.

GOAL Loggins Lumber hope to become a household name. Poster advertisements are pasted to trees within 10 miles of their logging sites, and fairy representatives can be found in most settlements.

FEATURE Employees of Loggins Lumber wear overalls in a variety of green shades, with holes cut out for their wings. Each set of overalls has the company's insect logo stitched on the front in intricate, gold threading.

SECRET The enchanted tip of their matchsticks is made from processed worg dung. The Loggins sisters hide this unhygienic truth from the public, and have bribed many over the years to stop this information getting out.

FACTION • LARGE (50–99) • NEUTRAL • INDUSTRY

Bhurj Wondergreen

Friendly fey merchant.

As Bhurj gives you a warm smile and wave, some of the objects in their overfilled backpack clang onto the floor. They shake their head and laugh.

KNOWN FOR Bhurj regularly travels to and from the Fey Realm to sell their wares and scout for new stock. Their unique inventory makes them a hit with mages and adventurers, but they're notoriously hard to track down. Anyone lucky enough to spot Bhurj can be sure of a smile and low prices.

APPEARANCE Their skin is the texture of rough tree bark, and a mass of auburn leaves sits on top of their head. Bhurj's overcoat and bags are stuffed with goods.

GOAL By happily showing off the wonderful merchandise the Fey Realm has to offer, Bhurj hopes to educate people on just how amazing their home plane can be.

SECRET A group of furious unseelie elves is hunting for Bhurj. They know Bhurj stole an artefact from a sacred site and sold it for profit.

LOOT

- Bag of holding*
- Feather token (tree)*
- Wand of magic detection*

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • FEY • MERCHANT

COMMONER / DRYAD

Creeping Maple Sap

Corrosive tree sap.

KNOWN FOR The creeping maple tree's sap is harmless when contained within its bark. When the tree is split, the sap takes on a life of its own and looks for food: humanoids.

APPEARANCE Creeping maple trees are almost identical to regular maple trees, although their leaves have marginally more rounded tips. The sap is dense and golden-brown.

SECRET If the sap can be contained, it can be boiled down into an almost-permanent adhesive. Because of this, the act of harvesting creeping maple sap is illegal in most areas.

CREATURE • MEDIUM • NEUTRAL • OOZE

Donner Rainer

Hermit who breeds flying snakes.

KNOWN FOR Donner breeds flying snakes in her chaotic forest cottage, and sells them as pets. She also sculpts art from the discarded eggshells the snakes are born from.

APPEARANCE The wrinkles in Donner's face show her age and wisdom, while the acorn shell on her head and feathery scarf proudly display her playful and eccentric personality.

SECRET Despite her unkempt hair and grubby clothing, Donner is actually incredibly wealthy. Her real name is Dr Rianne Nero, and she is a retired economics professor.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • DWARF • NATURALIST

The way your party interact with their forest surroundings may gain the support, or anger, of these characters.

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Blight Striders

Sentient trees corrupted by evil.

A shadow descends. As you raise your eyes, you notice long, gnarled legs and arms made from bark. A cracked ribcage reveals a core of purple light.

KNOWN FOR Once sentient trees, these creatures were twisted by necrotic magic into hulking engines of decay. Their lumbering footsteps rot the soil, corrupt nearby roots and spawn more undead plant horrors. These treants once spoke wisely, but now they rasp and howl in broken shouts. Their bad energy spreads fast, and if left unchecked they can destroy entire forests.

APPEARANCE Blight striders are hollowed from within by a swirling core of dark magic, their brittle bark shells barely holding together. Sickly purples, greens and blues churn in their chests. Dry leaves cling to their spindly limbs, and foul necrotic smoke trails behind them, reeking of decay. As the strider stumbles forward, claw-like fingers rake nearby trees, scratching bark and spreading corruption.

TACTICS Blight striders act purely on instinct. They either stagger towards the nearest life force to drain it, or attack the creature that most recently harmed them with violent fury. They are reckless and unstable.

LAIR Blight striders form when potent necrotic magic is used in a forest. These twisted treants thrive in shadowy glades and damp bogs. Their presence is marked by thick, rotting stench and rampant decay.

SECRET When a blight strider is felled, its broken body seeps necrotic magic into the soil, causing lasting corruption. Only a cleric's blessing can fully cleanse its remains and protect the forest's wildlife.

LOOT

- Necrotic bark
- Boomerang*
- Staff of the woodlands*
- Blighted resin
- Bundle of dry leaves
- Oil of sharpness*

CREATURE • HUGE • HOSTILE • PLANT — AWAKENED TREE / TREANT

Mych Underbark

Forest detective.

KNOWN FOR This detective investigates bandit activity in woodland areas. His name strikes fear into fake tollbooth operators, illegal loggers, highway robbers and gang leaders.

APPEARANCE A leaf-green poncho drapes over Mych's neat uniform and polished boots. His thick moustache hides his top lip, and his deep frown shades his tired hazel eyes.

SECRET Mych used to be part of an infamous bandit gang. His criminal past gives him valuable insights, but he would be immediately discharged if his superior officer found out.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • GNOME • GUARD

Janus Doe

Satyr with memory loss.

KNOWN FOR Janus wanders the forest and politely asks everyone she meets if they know anything about her, or her background. She'd especially like to learn her real name.

APPEARANCE This sturdy satyr wears a ruby-red tailcoat with engraved brass buttons. A raised swelling between her horns suggests her amnesia is linked to a blow to the head.

SECRET Janus was a fey court advisor, exiled after witnessing a seelie scandal. A spell to modify her memory was compounded when she fell out of a speeding carriage.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • FEY • OFFICIAL

The thick trees make it difficult to spot other creatures, so your party will need sharp eyes.

Benjamin Mast - 4benmast@gmail.com

Dryff Guinhop

Amiable firefly farmer.

KNOWN FOR Dryff tends to a number of firefly hives located in a quiet forest clearing. He collects the fireflies in glass jars, then sells them as lanterns.

APPEARANCE Dryff wears a large straw hat with a mesh hood to keep the buzzing fireflies away from his face. He hums and sings with contentment as he works.

GOAL He and his husband have three teenage children. Dryff hopes that one or more of his kids will volunteer to take over the family hives when he retires.

SECRET He subtly casts spells with his whistles and songs. This magic helps him to communicate with and calm down the swarming fireflies.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HUMAN • NATURALIST

COMMONER / PRIEST ACOLYTE

The Shadowtails

Flashy forest pirates.

KNOWN FOR This dashing troupe of forest bandits ambushes wealthy travellers using traps, then swoops down from rope bridges to snatch valuables. They flee through the trees to their canopy hideout, the Drey.

GOAL The Shadowtails stand for freedom and reject society's rules. They fund this lifestyle through theft. Every successful heist is followed by lively, wine-soaked celebrations in the Drey's central meeting room.

FEATURE They dress in stolen finery: silks, rings and hats. For stealth, they wear dark velvet cloaks clasped with squirrel brooches, which they dramatically discard when revealing their stylish looks to intimidate victims.

SECRET Surplus treasure is buried in marked sacks across the forest. Each sack is enchanted with a silent alarm spell, alerting the gang if disturbed — allowing them to intercept would-be thieves before they escape.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • NEUTRAL • CRIMINAL

More Forest Creatures

1. REDSNOUTS Giant badgers with constant, bloodthirsty rage.
2. BARKBOA Constrictor snake camouflaged like a tree stump.
3. SPOREFANGS Toxic mushroom creatures with nasty bites.
4. GHOSTHOPPERS Invisible tree frogs with healing blood.
5. PALEHOOF Limping white elk with an arrow in its back leg.
6. NULLPANTHER Tree-climbing big cat that casts no shadow.
7. GLUEWEAVERS Huge spiders that spin sticky web traps.
8. DIRTMANES Pack of soil-crusted worgs with leafy pelts.
9. FERNBAK Moss-covered bear, recently finished hibernation.
10. SLIME TYRANT House-sized snail that leaves acidic trails.

Silva Redhatch

Lumberjack doppelganger.

KNOWN FOR Living in a cabin deep in the woods, this reclusive figure toils away as a lone lumberjack. Every few weeks, Silva leaves his home to trade the timber he chops.

APPEARANCE Muscular shoulders, a sweat-drenched shirt and calloused hands show a life of hard labour. Silva's bushy beard obscures his charming smile and sharp teeth.

SECRET Silva is a shape-shifter who disguises himself as a human lumberjack to prey on passers-by. He offers weary travellers bed and board, then robs and butchers them.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • DOPPELGANGER • LABOURER

The Foal Union

Guardians of a forest library.

KNOWN FOR These scholarly centaur warriors protect an arcane library hidden within a spiralling, hollow tree. They fiercely guard their growing collection, defending it from thieves, rival collectors, and even rogue mages.

GOAL The Foal Union aims to amass the world's largest magical library. They acquire tomes through trade, excavation, or force — confiscating texts from careless adventurers and wizards who draw their attention.

FEATURE Each centaur wears a blue-and-white doublet with pockets for parchment and pens. Lined with thick leather armour, the uniforms blend academic function with battlefield readiness.

SECRET Beneath the tree library lies a dungeon where wayward mages are imprisoned. Conditions are harsh, but few speak about it after release; they fear The Foal Union's wrath, and a second far-worse punishment.

FACTION • MEDIUM (20–49) • NEUTRAL • ACADEMIC

These forest dwellers could be useful guides, if your party decide they can be trusted.

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Bay of Echoes

Secluded, whispering cove.

Sounds of the outside world fade away within this cool, damp space. Thick algae covers the heaps of smooth rocks, and water gently trickles down the walls.

KNOWN FOR Legend has it those who enter the Bay of Echoes may ask for answers to their questions. If their motives are pure, they will hear the answers whispered on the unnatural winds that shift around the bay. The site features in many historic accounts, but few people know of its exact location.

APPEARANCE A gentle waterfall hides the entrance to the bay, which is sheltered by large stone cliffs. The crescent-shaped interior amplifies the sound of any question asked.

INHABITANTS Some who enter the bay become obsessed with hearing the whispers. One such individual has made a ramshackle home in an elevated alcove.

LOOT Grateful visitors leave small offerings in the Bay of Echoes, such as flowers or food. It is considered bad luck to disturb these gifts.

SECRET A formidable spirit was trapped in the bay by paladins centuries ago. Although weakened, the spirit still whispers to travellers.

ENVIRONMENT • SMALL • SAFE • BAY

Serpent's Trail

Snake-shaped river.

KNOWN FOR When seen on a map, it's clear how this snake-shaped river got its name. The combination of its long, twisting path and calm currents make it slow to travel on, so it is mainly used for cargo and recreation.

APPEARANCE The river coils back and forth on itself in wide serpentine bends, until tapering into a thin tail. Glossy, black shale on the riverbed looks like snakeskin beneath the clear, slow-moving water.

LOOT Stones from the riverbed aren't valuable, but can be used to make scale armour. Locals also weave reeds that grow on the river banks, creating a strong and waterproof fabric that is often used instead of leather.

SECRET A rumour has spread that a sea serpent has been spotted in the river. This lie was started by a local boat company boss in an attempt to drum up business for his river tours, which were recently reviewed as "dull".

ENVIRONMENT • MID-SIZED • SAFE • RIVER

Shadowdeep Ocean

Monster-infested waters.

KNOWN FOR Most sensible captains avoid sailing in the Shadowdeep Ocean for fear of never returning to port. The ocean is famous for the gargantuan sea monsters that lurk within, and the ships that they have consumed.

APPEARANCE Watchful sailors scan churning waves on the horizon, but the ocean's inky black waters hide most monsters from sight. Abandoned vessels bob and drift through the all-too-quiet waters.

LOOT The carcass of a rare Shadowdeep monster can be worth a fortune. However, money can be more easily made by salvaging the scrap parts of shipwrecks and floating cargo lost at sea.

SECRET A mega-kraken dwells somewhere in the ocean, although no cartographers have ever lived long enough to chart its lair on a map. Other monsters are pushed into shallower waters by this territorial behemoth.

ENVIRONMENT • VAST • DANGEROUS • OCEAN

Do the oceans in your world act as vast borders between realms? Or do they offer opportunities for trade and travel?

Benjamin Mast - 4benmast@gmail.com

Crystal Creek

Sparkling gemstone stream.

KNOWN FOR This shallow stream is famous for its dazzling gemstone bed. However, taking a gem from the water causes an unusual magical side effect for the person who took it.

APPEARANCE The surface of the water sparkles in the sun as it cascades over rocky stacks of colourful gemstones. Rainbows and prismatic beams are cast onto the riverbanks.

SECRET Fey tricksters hide near the creek to watch mortals fish out gems. They curse anyone who reaches into the river, then giggle and run away.

ENVIRONMENT • SMALL • RISKY • RIVER

Golden Tides

Gulf favoured by wealthy tourists.

KNOWN FOR The gulf is famous for its glorious sunsets, excellent weather and luxury offerings. Rich tourists enjoy sailing regattas by day and lavish yacht parties by night.

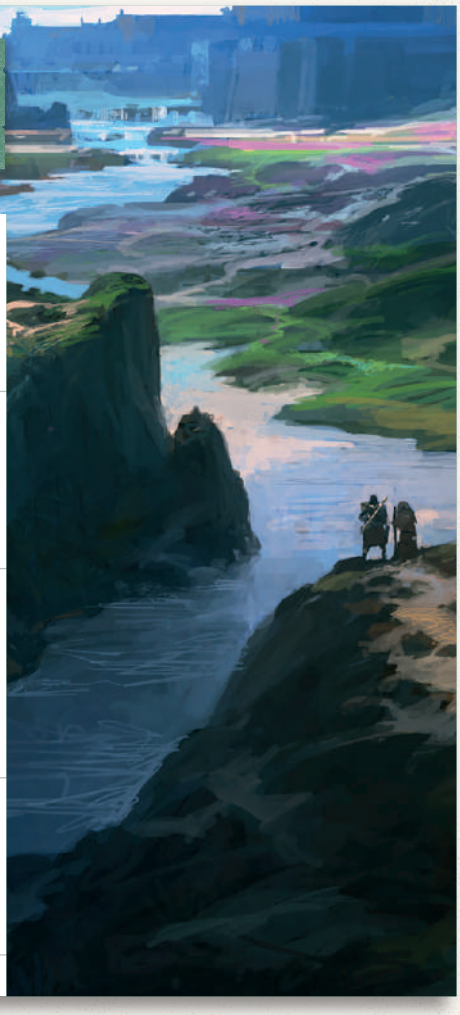
APPEARANCE This small inlet's bright-blue waters are warm, calm and clear. Huge numbers of staff are employed to keep the sandy beaches pristine and picturesque.

SECRET Those moored in the Golden Tides must pay a fee to the local government, which is then passed to a criminal family who have claimed ownership of the gulf for years.

ENVIRONMENT • MID-SIZED • SAFE • BAY

Bloodstone River

Treacherous, fast-flowing river.



The sound of crashing waves is deafening. A constant spray of ice-cold water stings your face as the river beats a relentless path over the rocks.

KNOWN FOR The Bloodstone River is notoriously hard to travel on. Sharp turns and sudden elevation shifts cause crashing waterfalls and dangerous rapids — like the ominously named Hero's End Cascade. Searching for a safe crossing point can add weeks to a journey, and is often in vain.

APPEARANCE This turbulent, fast-flowing river is the result of a melting glacier. Large chunks of ice smash against the rocky river banks as the water gushes downstream.

INHABITANTS Only one resilient salmon species has adapted to the glacial waters. These large fish have thick, bony scales that protect them from being pummelled on the rocks.

LOOT The river is littered with the bones and belongings of those who fell victim to the treacherous currents and unforgiving rocks.

SECRET A recent attempt to scale the glacier at the source of the river led to the disappearance, and presumed death, of a famed explorer.

ENVIRONMENT • VAST • DANGEROUS • RIVER

More Bodies of Water

1. **DRIFAFFÖN OCEAN** Freezes over once every four years.
2. **RIVER DUINE** Looping meanders spell out an Elvish phrase.
3. **THE DESCENT** New species are regularly found in its depths.
4. **SER ELRIK'S REST** Lake named to honour a fallen local hero.
5. **REDWAY** This river is famous for its blood-red sediment.
6. **BARDS' BASIN** Beautiful spot featured in many epic poems.
7. **HYDRA'S REACH** Waters above a dark, bottomless trench.
8. **THE MOREALUS SEA** Vast waters plagued by wild storms.
9. **SOULSNATCH TORRENTS** Rocky area with violent riptides.
10. **QUEEN'S CANAL** Engineered to connect two royal palaces.

Lake Moondrop

Sacred circular lake.

KNOWN FOR Many religious and druidic groups build shrines and conduct rituals here, believing the lake to have a strong connection to divine and natural powers.

APPEARANCE This perfectly circular lake sits in a shallow dip at the top of a mountain. Its peaceful, pale-grey waters are constantly shrouded in a thick layer of fog.

SECRET The lake's waters have minor healing qualities. These powers are significantly amplified if the liquid is collected or used during a full moon.

ENVIRONMENT • SMALL • SAFE • LAKE

If a river is a major landmark in your region, consider the placement and safety of each crossing point.

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Enchanter Umea Vrogies

Humble coastal mage.

KNOWN FOR Umea is a renowned creator of sea-themed magic items. All their products are made from items they find on the beach, like pearls, shells and driftwood.

APPEARANCE Umea's hair is worn in a short orange bob, and they paint their eyelids like shimmering fish scales with pigmented green make-up. They speak quietly and kindly.

SECRET The belt buckle Umea wears is made of lionfish spines and has a protective charm. They made it after their workshop was broken into and several items were stolen.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • ELF • SPELLCASTER

Gale Riders

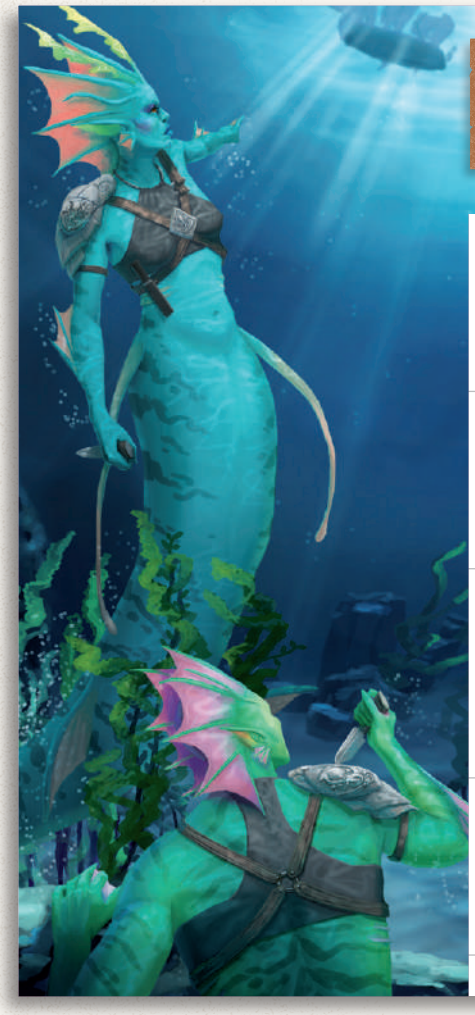
Up-and-coming surfing team.

KNOWN FOR They may be newcomers to the surfing scene, but the Gale Riders are famed for performing manoeuvres while staying on their boards using well-timed acrobatics.

GOAL The team are desperate to win the Longshore Invitational competition against their season-long rivals: the arrogant and well-established Whale Sharkz.

SECRET The Gale Riders' captain is hiding a serious knee injury. Her bad leg could greatly jeopardise the team's chances in the competition, and their own safety.

FACTION • MICRO (1–5) • FRIENDLY • SOCIAL



The Silent Scale

Covert merfolk operatives.

You notice the glint of a serrated knife in the merfolk's webbed hand. The weapon seems to be designed not for maximum efficiency, but to inflict maximum pain.

KNOWN FOR Though not publicly recognized by the undersea government, the Silent Scale has a long history of handling what is covertly referred to as "landfolk relations". Ships passing through their territory that are deemed suspicious or dangerous will be intercepted and, if necessary, sabotaged.

GOAL Silent Scale agents vow to protect the sea from land dwellers at all costs. Secrecy is vital, as exposure of the group's brutal actions would damage the government's reputation.

LEADERSHIP The agents are led by a director with the code name Cuttlefish. This severe individual has a particular taste for violence, and mistrust of all air-breathers.

FEATURE On acceptance into the group, merfolk are given a uniform harness and holster. Each agent is trained to move in complete silence.

SECRET An agent recently saved a human child from a sinking ship and took it to safety. The agent will be severely disciplined if found out.

FACTION • MEDIUM (20–49) • HOSTILE • MILITARY

Riverbanes

Aquatic shape-shifters.

KNOWN FOR These troublesome, aquatic fiends cause endless headaches for local fisherfolk. The creatures can shape-shift into blue-striped seagulls, crabs or fish, and arrive in a tornado of chaos and mischief.

APPEARANCE In their original form, riverbanes are stripy dog-like creatures that communicate with barks and whistles. They have shark-like teeth, fins on their legs and backs, and venomous stinging tails.

TACTICS Riverbanes have been seen clawing through fishing nets, sneaking into barrels of fresh fish to eat what's inside, and swooping down in gull form to harass fisherfolk. They dive into the water when caught.

SECRET Destroying a riverbane causes it to evaporate into steam, allowing it to rejoin the water system. Within a week, it reforms and returns with fury to ambush and torment the one who defeated it.

CREATURE • MEDIUM • NEUTRAL • FIEND

BLINK DOG / IMP

Ocean dwellers are likely to be more relaxed in calm water, and restless during a raging storm.

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Lowvale Trolls

River troll settlers.

KNOWN FOR An offshoot of a mountain troll clan, this small community has decided to establish a presence in the river valley below. They hope to take advantage of fresh water to nurture new farmland.

GOAL The number one priority for these hardworking homesteaders is to dig channels to divert water towards their new settlement. This will ensure the fields can be successfully irrigated in time for the growing season.

FEATURE Each worker carries a huge irrigation shovel, perfect for digging through the river banks. It is made with metals mined in the mountains and has a thick, roughly carved wooden handle.

SECRET The Lowvale Trolls are making good progress with their village, but diverting the river is affecting wetlands further downstream. River crocodiles are being forced to find new places to live and hunt.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • FRIENDLY • INDUSTRY

Gil Fathoms

Devotee of an undersea aberration.

You'd think you were talking to a corpse, if it wasn't for the man's shallow, gasping breaths. His pale blue skin is stretched over gaunt, skeletal features.

KNOWN FOR Gil is a practitioner of dark, aquatic magic. He lures beach tourists into his sea cave home by promising to show them beautiful coral, fish and anemones. Gil tries to keep these unfortunate souls distracted until the tide rises, and they become trapped in the caves.

APPEARANCE A magical disguise hides Gil's skeletal, amphibious traits. Without it, he appears soggy and ragged, with seaweed growing alongside his thin stringy hair.

GOAL Gil worships an ancient aberration called Maw. He traps victims as ritual sacrifices to sustain and renew his patron's dark magic.

SECRET Maw is not patient. If Gil fails to provide enough sacrifices each month, the being will attack and consume Gil instead.

LOOT

- Feather token (anchor)*
- Dagger*
- Hollowed octopus bag

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • FEY • SPELLCASTER

SEA HAG / ASSASSIN

Vion Murkarn

Cyclops boat transporter.

KNOWN FOR Vion is a well-known figure among sailors. He earns coin by safely lifting ships up over a waterfall. Vion is popular for his banter and friendly attitude while working.

APPEARANCE This cheerful cyclops has olive skin, a shaved head and a long black beard that flows like water. His muscular arms are the result of his daily boat hauls.

SECRET Ferrying ships up and down the waterfall is an easy job, but Vion is more interested in a career as an entertainer. He is currently trying to refine his stand-up comedy routine.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • GIANT • LABOURER

The Forsaken Howler

Wrathful lake spirit.

KNOWN FOR Swimmers are sent running by the piercing screams of the Forsaken Howler. Those who persevere soon find themselves struggling in unnaturally cold waters.

APPEARANCE The spirit is heard more than it's seen. When visible, it takes the translucent form of a bloated humanoid with bulging eyes and bedraggled hair clutching an oar.

SECRET The spirit was once an elf who drowned in the lake. They jumped in to try and recover a ring dropped by their unfaithful spouse. Destroying the ring will banish the spirit.

CREATURE • MEDIUM • HOSTILE • UNDEAD

You can find sailors and pirates on pp. 216–219.

Benjamin Mast - 4benmast@gmail.com

Kaelyr Reddin

Seaweed snack entrepreneur.

KNOWN FOR Kaelyr cheerfully tends Reddin Saltgrove, his kelp farm. He hands out samples of his latest roasted kelp chip flavours to curious passers-by.

APPEARANCE He wears waterproof waders and a navy-blue hood. His wind-swept hair and seaweed-scented clothes reflect a life spent by the sea.

GOAL The farm's last owner struggled to turn a profit. Kaelyr hopes he can turn the farm's luck around by baking the kelp into unusual new delicacies.

SECRET He grows kelp using an effective zig-zag trench method — patent pending. He plans to sell the technique to other kelp farmers once it's approved.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HUMAN • LABOURER — COMMONER / NOBLE

Bone Divers

Divers who explore haunted wrecks.

KNOWN FOR The Bone Divers are daring treasure hunters who explore haunted shipwrecks. Ghostly wrecks are often left untouched by other divers, so the only challengers the Bone Divers face are the undead.

GOAL They recover relics from sunken ships and sell them for profit. Half their earnings fund charities that build sea defences and rescue services, aiming to make ocean travel safer for future generations of sailors.

FEATURE Each Bone Diver wears a worn leather diving suit and spherical copper helmet that doesn't look fit for purpose. They all bear the same scar on their forehead, a ring of runes in an ancient and forgotten language.

SECRET A cursed gauntlet found a century ago made them immortal, yet undead. To finally find rest, they must recover the full ancient armour set. They've found most pieces — only the helmet and boots remain lost.

FACTION • MICRO (1–5) • FRIENDLY • SOCIAL

Crawley Tidpole

Strict coastguard.

KNOWN FOR Crawley patrols the beach enforcing rules he largely made up himself. His bird, Ruk, spots rule breakers and squawks loudly until Crawley arrives to punish them.

APPEARANCE A deep frown is ever-present on Crawley's thin face. His navy swimsuit is hand-embroidered with a decorative golden anchor, showing his status as coastguard.

SECRET Crawley searches for his mother's lost locket on the beach. He does it subtly, as unauthorized digging and removal of valuable items are both against his own rules.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • KOBOLD • GUARD

Sefanei

Talking octopus merchant.

KNOWN FOR Sefanei, a magically awakened octopus merchant, grasps the ankles of passers-by and asks them to trade. She startles some, but only wants to sell her wares.

APPEARANCE A vibrant green octopus with gold and red markings, Sefanei drapes shiny trinkets and rings over her tentacles. She is always eager to attract curious buyers.

SECRET Sefanei leads an underwater thieves' guild. One of her enchanted rings awakens other fishy associates, who steal from docks so she can sell the loot from her rock pool.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • BEAST • MERCHANT

More Ocean Dwellers

1. IMIL BAX Thrill-seeking cliff diver who claims to be immortal.
2. VAINON STARRL Merfolk dueller with swordfish-horn blade.
3. FETERRIN SILVERBOW Writer of a book about sea beasts.
4. THE INTERCESSOR Powerful champion of a mighty sea god.
5. LITA RANCH Scout sent to shore ahead of a coming armada.
6. MI'KAH Monk perfecting their mantis-shrimp fighting stance.
7. TERRS OLBRIT Collects driftwood and turns it into art.
8. JIAMI AWUA Young wish-granting djinni living in turtle form.
9. RYDAK VIG Pirate captain who was marooned by their crew.
10. MEL EWSWORTH Pilgrim walking a long coastal path.

Leviathan's Claw

Marine bounty hunting gang.

KNOWN FOR Leviathan's Claw are a group of ruthless merrow bounty hunters. After a capture, their hostage is tied up and pulled behind their rugged seahorse chariots.

GOAL The merrow gang aim to expand their coastal territory by taking on new members and contracts. This has already sparked clashes with rival gangs along the shoreline.

SECRET Leviathan's Claw don't know their most recent contract was ordered by a rival bounty hunter. If they find their supposed quarry, they'll be caught in a nasty ambush.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • HOSTILE • MILITARY

There are ideas for dock inhabitants on pp. 172–173.

Benjamin Mast - 4benmast@gmail.com

Tessara Vardyne

Conservationist aquarium owner.

KNOWN FOR Tessara runs a rescue facility for injured marine life. She's gentle and devoted, especially to her favourite patient — an orca with a broken fin named Spotty.

APPEARANCE Tessara's satchel and grey jacket is full of fish food and field gear. Her skin fades from indigo to navy, and she wears a hat painted to look like a turtle shell.

SECRET Though she can't stop ocean poachers, Tessara uses sabotage to hinder them. She damages boats, hoards supplies, and bribes dockhands to delay poachers at port.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • MERFOLK • NATURALIST

Swarm of Voraquill

Flesh-eating fish.

KNOWN FOR Voraquill are coin-sized fish with multiple heads that attack in frenzied, bloody schools. If they sustain an injury, a new head grows from the wound as it heals.

APPEARANCE Voraquill dart through water with red heads and silver bodies. They have up to three snapping jaws per fish, and their jagged teeth hold scraps of prey.

SECRET Telepathic alphas with glowing amber eyes lead each hive-minded swarm. Kill the alpha and the rest scatter, their bloodlust instantly broken by its death.

CREATURE • MEDIUM • HOSTILE • MONSTROSITY

Cara, Tide Daughter

Powerful aquatic druid.

Beneath a twisting coral headdress, Cara's hair cascades down her back in dark waves. As you look upon her unwavering stare, you notice her irises dance and spin like bottomless whirlpools.

KNOWN FOR Cara is among the world's most powerful druids. She is revered for her breathtaking command of water magic and her deep bond with sea creatures. She has halted tidal waves to save coastal towns and restored dry riverbeds during droughts. Travelling the world in her iconic hammerhead shark wildshape, Cara is a guardian of the water, and has earned global respect and awe.

APPEARANCE Cara's long hair flows in uneven waves, textured by the ever-present salt breeze that seems to follow her. She wears a shimmering aquamarine gown that pools at her bare feet and moves like water as she walks. A headdress of living coral crowns her head. Emotion rarely flickers across her face — her gaze remains fixed on matters far beyond the concerns of mortal life.

HISTORY Tide Daughter is a rare druidic title, bestowed on those who survive a perilous water elemental bonding ritual called the Immersion. Cara passed at just 14 years old, the youngest person ever to do so.

GOAL Cara leads underwater and coastal druidic circles. She views nature's power as sacred, and so, as part of her duties, punishes those who abuse it. Harming others on behalf of nature brings her no joy.

SECRET Cara now ignores government summons, after being asked to speed up shipping routes. Her refusal has sparked political tension and mounting resentment.

LOOT

- Living coral crown
- Pearl of power*
- Brooch of shielding*
- Message in a bottle
- Druidic focus*
- Ring of water walking*

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • HUMAN • NATURALIST — DRUID / ARCHMAGE

Underwater communities will have different languages and customs to their land-dwelling neighbours.

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Phineas Fielding

Hydropower visionary.

KNOWN FOR A mechanical whizz, Phineas has designed a river dam that could provide steam power for the entire region. However, councillors scoff at his "outlandish" plans.

APPEARANCE Phineas wears a blue and gold brocade waistcoat with a pattern of interlocking water droplets. Gauntlets on his hands whir with arcane machinery.

SECRET Phineas has hired an unscrupulous wizard to cast a spell to flood the local river. He hopes this will give his dam proposal a better chance of being taken seriously.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • ELF-HUMAN • ARTISAN

Torrentals

Draconic river guardians.

KNOWN FOR A sighting of a torrental is considered very lucky. These shy serpentine river-dragons glide beneath the water, seldom surfacing and almost never seen on shore.

APPEARANCE Torrentals look like large water snakes with antlers and dragon-like heads. Their muted green scales offer perfect camouflage in still, silty rivers.

SECRET Torrental scales sometimes wash ashore or get tangled in fishing nets. They're highly valuable – either sold for a high price or used in alchemy and potion-making.

CREATURE • MEDIUM • FRIENDLY • DRAGON

The Lone Harpy

Harpy trapped on an island.

She stands on a sea-soaked rock perch and looks at you, humming a melancholy song that's carried on the breeze. People call her the Lone Harpy, and no one has ever seen her leave the island.

KNOWN FOR The Lone Harpy appears in sailor tales, ship figureheads and nursery rhymes. Harpies fly in flocks, but she remains alone, with only jagged stones and a ruined lighthouse to keep her company. The island gets no visitors, so she lives in mournful solitude.

APPEARANCE She shares the colours of a magpie: black-and-white feathers with an oily blue sheen. Her limbs end in hooked talons, and her hair hangs in wet strands across a gaunt, salt-crusted face. The harpy's eyes are hollow and plead for friendship.

HISTORY The gods cursed the harpy, forbidding her to leave her island prison. Since then, she has watched years pass, tides rise and empires fall. Shipwrecks and skeletons litter the rocks, belonging to those who tried and failed to reach her in the past.

GOAL The Lone Harpy longs to escape. If a visitor can reach her, welcome her aboard their ship and ferry her from the island, her curse will be broken. Then, at last, she'll leave her wretched prison – finally free to hunt, to sing and to find a flock to belong to.

SECRET She was once an angel in the heavenly chorus, but she refused the gods' request to stop singing and lead their holy army. For defiance, the gods ripped away her angelic form and cast her into the world in mockery.

LOOT

Tear-shaped pebble	Philtre of love*
Ring of feather falling*	Small bag of pearls
Fish bones	Conch shell

HARPY TRICKSTER

Medium Monstrosity

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
12 (+1)	16 (+3)	14 (+2)	7 (-2)	12 (+1)	16 (+3)

Armour Class: 16
Hit Points: 130 (20d8 + 40)
Speed: 20 ft, fly 40 ft
Initiative: +3

Saving Throws: DEX +6, CHA +6
Skills: Deception +9, Insight +4, Perception +4
Passive Perception: 12
Languages: Common
Proficiency Bonus: +3

ABILITIES

Luring Song. The harpy sings a magical melody, which lasts until the harpy's Concentration ends on it. Wisdom Saving Throw: DC 14, each humanoid and giant within 300 ft of the harpy when the song starts. Failure: The target has the Charmed condition until the song ends and repeats the save at the end of each of its turns. While Charmed, the target has the Incapacitated condition and ignores the Luring Song of other harpies. If the target is more than 5 ft from the harpy, the target moves on its turn toward the harpy by the most direct route, trying to get within 5 ft of the harpy. It doesn't avoid opportunity attacks; however, before moving into damaging terrain and whenever it takes damage from a source other than the harpy, the target repeats the save. Success: The target is immune to this Luring Song for 12 hours.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The harpy makes three Claw attacks.

Claw. Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft, one target. Hit: 5 (2d4 + 1) slashing damage plus 10 (3d6) poison damage.

Spellcasting. The harpy casts one of the following spells, using Charisma as the spellcasting ability (spell save DC 14):

At Will: *Colour Spray, Disguise Self, Minor Illusion*

1/Day Each: *Fear, Major Image*

CHALLENGE RATING 7

You could alternatively use the stats of a Harpy CR 1, Manticore CR 3 or Wraith CR 5.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • HARPY • SPELLCASTER

The Lone Harpy (left) is stranded on her island home, with only a few seagulls for companionship.

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The Three Masters

Triple-summit mountain.

KNOWN FOR Each peak was once home to a druid of immense power. The lands were warped by the druids' magic, and three distinct and unnatural biomes were created.

APPEARANCE Each of the three peaks is marked by unique wildlife. One teeming with fey-touched flora, another shaped by wind spirits, and the third hosting prehistoric life.

SECRET Some of the trees and stones scattered across the peaks are carved with runes; evidence of ancient druidic spells that predate written language.

ENVIRONMENT • VAST • SAFE • RANGE

Mount Orting

Unpredictable volcano.

KNOWN FOR This once-dormant volcano erupted without warning a few months ago. It unleashed a violent surge of lava and mud that buried the three towns below in moments.

APPEARANCE Mount Orting is a colossal peak with a gently sloping cone and wide vent. At its base are ruined, empty ghost towns – grim reminders of the recent catastrophe.

SECRET The townsfolk below were flash-incinerated by the eruption, leaving behind ash statues. At night, their ghosts drift through the streets, repeating their former routines.

ENVIRONMENT • VAST • DANGEROUS • VOLCANO

Hollowed Mount

Depleted mountain quarry.

KNOWN FOR Rich in marble, this mountain was hollowed from within after laws banned external quarrying. Now, it is fragile, and propped up only by unstable internal scaffolding.

APPEARANCE Wildflowers bloom on the peak's scenic, striped marble slopes. Inside, unstable mine shafts are supported by crumbling beams that frequently collapse.

SECRET When excavation ended, companies set up traps across the Hollowed Mount to deter trespassers. Some have been tripped or disarmed already, but many still remain.

ENVIRONMENT • MID-SIZED • DANGEROUS • MOUNTAIN

Diamondbreath Ridge

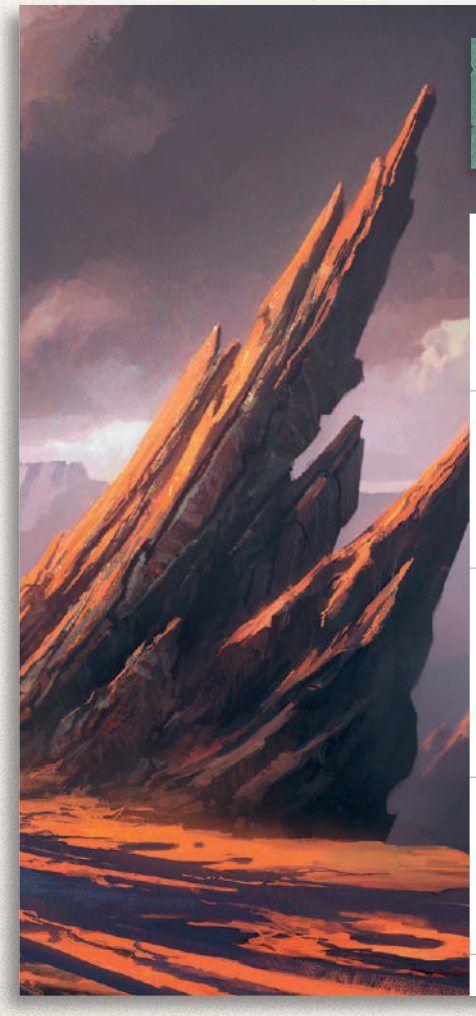
Mountain made from diamond.

KNOWN FOR A mighty dragon, seeking to display its power, unleashed its fire upon this carbon-rich mountain. Its flames were so intense, the peak crystallised into solid diamond.

APPEARANCE The mountain is both dazzling and terrifying. Its jagged peaks glint like dragon's teeth as sunlight catches their razor-sharp, diamond edges.

SECRET Though ages have passed, the dragon still sleeps deep within its diamond lair. Any who disturb or climb the mountain risk waking the ancient, legendary tyrant.

ENVIRONMENT • MID-SIZED • RISKY • MOUNTAIN



Sierra Schism

Mountain range shattered by magic.

Rock shards jut out at every step, humming faintly with magic. The mountain is torn apart, fractured by a violent arcane battle that still sizzles in the air.

KNOWN FOR This area once housed a scholarly arcane community. Bubbling disagreements over magic's origins escalated into a fierce battle that shattered the mountain. Lingering, fizzing arcane energy across the Sierra now causes wildly unpredictable magical surges.

APPEARANCE Sandstone gives the mountain range its rusty, red colour. Its shard-like peaks and unnatural fissures are scars left by the arcane battle that took place here.

INHABITANTS No one lives on the Sierra Schism; its wild, crackling magic makes it too dangerous. Babies born within 10 miles display innate magical powers from birth.

LOOT The ancient mages' magic items lie scattered across the mountains. Most are broken and valuable only to historians, but a rare few still work.

SECRET Hidden mage labs remain within the mountain. Some are strangely unlocked, others remain sealed by odd puzzles and sigils.

ENVIRONMENT • SMALL • DANGEROUS • RANGE

Mountain ranges are hazardous places. Prepare some rules to use if your party fall from high up.

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Wintergate Peaks

Labyrinthine mountain range.

The jagged peaks stretch across the skyline, gleaming with ice. Below, twisting mountain passes slither into dead-ends and forks: a frigid maze with no clear path.

KNOWN FOR The Wintergate Peaks form a natural barrier across the region. Travellers face two options when trying to cross the mountain range: a safer but longer path that risks exhaustion and ration shortages, or a shorter more perilous route plagued by deadly climbs and carnivorous beasts.

APPEARANCE Some craggy paths are wide enough for animals and carts, and others must be squeezed through in single-file. The mountain passes are plagued by snowstorms.

INHABITANTS Traders band together to travel the long, arduous route in communal caravans. Skilled guides can be hired to lead the way through the shortcuts for a hefty fee.

LOOT Traders abandon gear to lighten their load; they leave broken crates, torn packs, and lost supplies scattered along the mountain pass.

SECRET Parts of the mountain range are prone to avalanches, which can block a path entirely. Loud noises or magic use can trigger the collapses.

ENVIRONMENT • VAST • DANGEROUS • RANGE

Eversmoke Point

Volcano home to fire giants.

KNOWN FOR Eversmoke Point is home to a clan of territorial fire giants. They insist on tributes from the smallfolk settlers in the fertile valley below, threatening to let loose an eruption if their demands are not met.

APPEARANCE Dark plumes of ash continuously pour from the mouth of this tall, steep volcano. When the giants that reside inside fire up their forge, bright lava glows from the long cracks down its ridges.

LOOT The giants' trove of tributes contains many valuable items such as obsidian statues, gems and ingots. The giants each have well-made battleaxes, though they are too large for humanoids to use.

SECRET The giants are able to influence the volcano's activity, however they cannot actually cause eruptions. They are overstating their powers in order to exploit the villagers into giving them more elaborate gifts.

ENVIRONMENT • MID-SIZED • RISKY • VOLCANO

Oathrest Peak

Mountain burial site.

KNOWN FOR In accordance with local custom, legendary heroes are entombed on Oathrest Peak — the tallest and most sacred mountain in the region.

APPEARANCE The tombs carved into the rock become more ornate going up the mountain. The height at which heroes are buried relates to the greatness of their deeds.

SECRET The tomb at the summit, belonging to a great king, was looted last year. The route is treacherous and the tomb is rarely visited, so no one has noticed.

ENVIRONMENT • VAST • SAFE • MOUNTAIN

More Mountains

1. **MOUNT ODIUM** Overlooking foul-smelling sulphur springs.
2. **FELICITY SLOPES** A gentle skiing hill for beginners.
3. **MOUNT EBON** Dormant volcano covered in obsidian.
4. **MOURNERS' PEAK** Climbed as part of traditional death rites.
5. **ROOKERY RIDGE** Mountain range where magical birds nest.
6. **SEAMOUNT PRISM** Underwater volcano covered in coral.
7. **SENTINEL PEAKS** Identical mountains flanking a busy town.
8. **GLITCH HILL** Magical mound that disappears at random.
9. **THE DRACHENHORN** Lair of an enormous copper dragon.
10. **GOLDEN SUMMIT** The location of a yearly race to the top.

Characters can experience dizziness or fatigue from altitude sickness if they climb too high.

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Sygnun Logfaire

Anxious explorer on a deadline.

KNOWN FOR Sponsored by a mountain clothing company, Sygnun is trying to scale the realm's highest peak. He has had six failed attempts so far this year.

APPEARANCE Sygnun's hat, scarf, coat, boots and bag are all branded with the same logo: a pegasus cresting over a mountain. He often tugs nervously at his wispy, red beard.

SECRET Sygnun's sponsorship agreement requires him to complete the climb this season. If he fails, he must repay the upfront fee of 1,000 gold pieces, which he has already spent.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • HALFLING • WAYFARER

Aprahett Jentwip

Yak farmer plagued by predators.

KNOWN FOR The Jentwip family have bred, grazed and milked yaks for generations. In Aprahett's time as matriarch, the family have been regularly attacked by mountain lions.

APPEARANCE Aprahett has a muscular frame, despite her small stature, and has a thick fringe mimicking her yaks' hairstyles. She carries a tall staff and uses it to steer the herd.

SECRET Aprahett recently received a mortal wound when defending her yaks, but hides it well. She knows she is dying, so is preparing her son to take over the herd.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HUMAN • LABOURER

Amethyst Climbing Company

Daring ore extraction team.

KNOWN FOR The Amethyst Climbing Company (or ACC) specialises in extracting magical ore from sheer rock faces. Workers are trained to chip at the stone while dangling on ropes hundreds of feet in the air.

GOAL While the senior managers focus on profits and expansion, the workers are more concerned with surviving the brutal conditions. Climbers buddy-up and protect each other to make it through their tough shifts.

FEATURE Workers carry distinctive chisels with purple glass beads embedded in the hilt. The company was founded by the Amethyst family, and these beads are an inexpensive reference to the prolific original owners.

SECRET The company coffers are running low after a manager was discovered embezzling funds. Without the money to replace climber equipment, ore extractions are becoming more dangerous every day.

FACTION • LARGE (50–99) • NEUTRAL • INDUSTRY

Krista Snarltooth

Acrobatic bandit.

KNOWN FOR Krista stalks quiet mountain roads looking for unsuspecting travellers. Her knowledge of the peaks and supreme agility make her a devastating ambusher.

APPEARANCE A hooded cloak can be pulled low to hide her face. The light, leather armour she wears aids her acrobatic manoeuvres.

GOAL Krista wants to earn a good living, and considers underprepared travellers fair game. She sees herself as an able entrepreneur with a unique set of skills.

SECRET She runs a dance school in a big city, and robs from mountain travellers when the school closes for summer.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • ANIMALFOLK • OUTLAW

BANDIT / PIRATE CAPTAIN

Gloombeak

Frozen, undead roc.

KNOWN FOR Once a living roc, the beast known as Gloombeak was killed by locals and its body was left to freeze at the top of a mountain. Years later, it has reappeared, but now seems much harder to kill.

APPEARANCE Each of its 90-feet-wide wings are torn skin and bone, with only a few frosty feathers left. Frostbite has claimed its left eye and two talons on the roc's right claw, but it still strikes with deadly accuracy.

TACTICS Gloombeak got its name from the shadow it casts over prey as it swoops out of the clouds around the mountain peak. It targets the largest creature it can see and carries it back to its nest to feast.

SECRET The roc's corpse was revived by an ambitious necromancer, who was quickly devoured by the awoken beast. The zombie roc can only be defeated by piercing its black heart with a silvered weapon.

CREATURE • GARGANTUAN • HOSTILE • UNDEAD

VROCK / ROC

These mountain-dwelling NPCs could come to your party's aid, or ambush them.

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Solaris Janez

Pricey monster hunter.

After emptying a bulging silk purse into her gloved hand, Solaris gladly counts her gold coins. She turns to her pet falcon, and gives it a wink and a wry smile.

KNOWN FOR Solaris is a solitary monster hunter who specialises in tracking mountainous creatures, aided by her loyal falcon, Dart. She moves from town to town offering her expensive services. When Solaris is in-between jobs, you'll likely find her in a tavern listening for rumours.

APPEARANCE Solaris wears fitted, slate-coloured armour with a studded pauldron for Dart to sit on. Silvery, braided hair cascades down her back in a tight, functional ponytail.

GOAL There is little love between Solaris and the villagers she helps, she just wants their coin. Solaris squirrels away her payments, and hopes to retire in the next five years.

SECRET The only thing Solaris truly fears is the dark. She refuses to hunt anything nocturnal, and finishes all her contracts before dusk.

LOOT

- Coin purse
- Armour of acid resistance*
- Barbed chains

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • HUMAN • COMBATANT — BERSERKER / ASSASSIN

Little Wanderers

Young adventurers club.

KNOWN FOR Little Wanderers is a kids' adventure group. The leaders teach children survival skills in an enjoyable and safe way, and go on regular expeditions and camping trips around the mountain's lower slopes.

GOAL Cadets complete missions to earn colourful patches for their uniforms. Their activities aim to make the mountain region safer for all, while promoting the Wanderer's Code: "Wander, Wonder and Be Wary".

FEATURE Wanderers wear khaki button-up shirts, brown shorts and floppy red caps. Uniforms are proudly decorated with embroidered badges, each earned by finishing practical tasks or lessons taught by leaders.

SECRET A new cadet followed some enormous paw prints alone, hoping to earn a patch. Leaders are quietly preparing a rescue expedition, fearing the child may be in grave danger. The prints belong to an old manticore.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • FRIENDLY • SOCIAL

Maurey Clarah

Neighbourly hill giant.

KNOWN FOR This giant lives in a large wooden home a little way up a mountain. She helps clear the lower road of fallen boulders when they are too heavy for locals to move.

APPEARANCE Maurey has bright blue eyes and round, red cheeks with bowl-sized dimples. Her shy smile reveals slightly crooked, chipped front teeth.

SECRET Maurey defends local villages from territorial giants who live further up the mountain. The landslides and rockfalls are actually caused by these heated encounters.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • GIANT • LABOURER

Celestial Rams

Divine mountain sheep.

KNOWN FOR Said to have escaped from the gods' own fields, these ethereal mountain sheep now graze mortal hills. Seeing one is believed to bring good weather and safe travels.

APPEARANCE Much larger than a regular sheep, celestial rams have a pure white fleece and golden hooves. Four twisting, ivory horns form a glowing crown above their heads.

SECRET After being stalked by poachers for years, the rams distrust humanoids and will charge if they feel threatened. Their wool, although fluffy, is as hard as plated steel.

CREATURE • LARGE • NEUTRAL • CELESTIAL

What type of mountain home do these characters live in? Get ideas on pp. 228–230.

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Villius Inkridge IV

Wizard's overworked apprentice.

KNOWN FOR Villius is a student of a famous fire archmage. His tutor sends him on exhausting errands for reagents across treacherous volcanic terrain.

APPEARANCE The young spellcaster spends most of his allowance on stylish robes, but they inevitably get covered in soot or dirt by the end of his tasks.

GOAL Villius dreams of inheriting his tutor's obsidian tower. He's set on surpassing his peers and proving he's worthy of succeeding the archmage.

SECRET Villius has secretly mastered the devastating Fire Storm spell. He plans to unleash it during his next exam, hoping to impress and surprise his sceptical tutor.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • HUMAN • SPELLCASTER — MAGE APPRENTICE / MAGE

Brethren of the Hawk

Skilled surveillance operation.

KNOWN FOR This elite military troop are stationed at a remote mountaintop garrison, where they keep watch for the first signs of invasion or threat. Members are famed for their archery, surveillance and survival skills.

GOAL Those serving in the Brethren of the Hawk vow to serve a seven-year deployment without leave or contact with their families. They give their full attention and commitment to the safety of the realm.

FEATURE Brethren soldiers wear light-grey uniforms, including plate armour that has been dulled with matte grey paint to help with stealth. They also wear white berets with a hawk's head embroidered on the side.

SECRET A revered Brethren soldier recently died from suspected poisoning. Some fear enemy spies have infiltrated the troop, others suspect personal grudges over recent promotions have prompted the killing.

FACTION • LARGE (50–99) • NEUTRAL • MILITARY

Nolan Wrack

Undead trekker.

KNOWN FOR After climbing a peak with his best friend, Nolan was pushed off the summit during a heated argument. He now seeks revenge from beyond the grave.

APPEARANCE Nolan wrapped up warm for his trek with layers of coats, socks and jumpers. Now, the ripped layers peel back to expose Nolan's frozen, skeletal form.

SECRET The two friends fought over ancient jewellery they uncovered at the summit. The necklace was cursed and fell with Nolan. It now keeps him conscious despite his death.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • UNDEAD • WAYFARER

Avian Alpine Aid

Birdfolk mountain rescue.

KNOWN FOR The Avian Alpine Aid (or AAA) are a skilled squadron of mountaineers. The orange-clad birdfolk offer assistance to at-risk travellers in high-altitude terrain.

GOAL After being notified of an issue, the AAA aim to rescue those in need within an hour. Responders travel in pairs, so one can head back for more support if needed.

SECRET The birdfolk squadron help anyone who needs assistance. But, once safely back at one of their operation tents, the AAA charge a high fee to those who were rescued.

FACTION • MEDIUM (20–49) • FRIENDLY • CIVIC

Larrik Groo

Preparing for an apocalyptic flood.

KNOWN FOR Larrik dreamt that a flood would engulf the world, and believes it to be a prophecy. She is building a house in the mountains, and spreads the news to passers-by.

APPEARANCE Larrik doesn't dress in furs for the cold, she instead wears a diving suit and helmet. Fishing bait, nets and hooks hang from her big backpack, which is full of food.

SECRET The prophecy seems outlandish, but has some truth to it. A powerful water elemental is looking to break free from its confines, and talks to Larrik while she sleeps.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • KOBOLD • WORSHIPPER

More Mountain Creatures

1. SPITEFLUFFS Miniature alpacas that hold grudges for years.
2. MAULERS Spiked yeti that fight over territory and prey.
3. PHANTOMPAWS Mountain lions with chameleon-like fur.
4. BUSHWABS Long-necked yaks that eat from the treetops.
5. ALLPIKES Winged fish that fly upstream to a breeding lake.
6. JEWELGUARD Gemstone elemental that protects a mine.
7. PAWMATE Lonely immortal dog that craves company.
8. CASKHOOFS Sturdy goat breed with a barrel-shaped body.
9. OZWRAITH Undead grizzly bear that is always hungry.
10. AERIE QUEEN Matriarch wyvern with two juveniles.

Think about what mountain creatures could be used as a helpful mount for your party.

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The Starwatcher

Mountain-defending golem.

KNOWN FOR Positioned besides a mountain pass, this ancient golem looks like a statue of a stargazing man. If intruders approach the pass, it silently activates, hurling them away with overwhelming strength.

APPEARANCE Timeworn and moss-covered, the statue kneels on a cracked marble plinth and aims a brass telescope skywards. Its stone shell hides arcane gears and crystals that power its movements from within.

TACTICS The Starwatcher never moves when watched. It advances only when unseen, closing the distance in eerie silence. Upon reaching its target, it strikes with its telescope that crackles with electrifying magical energy.

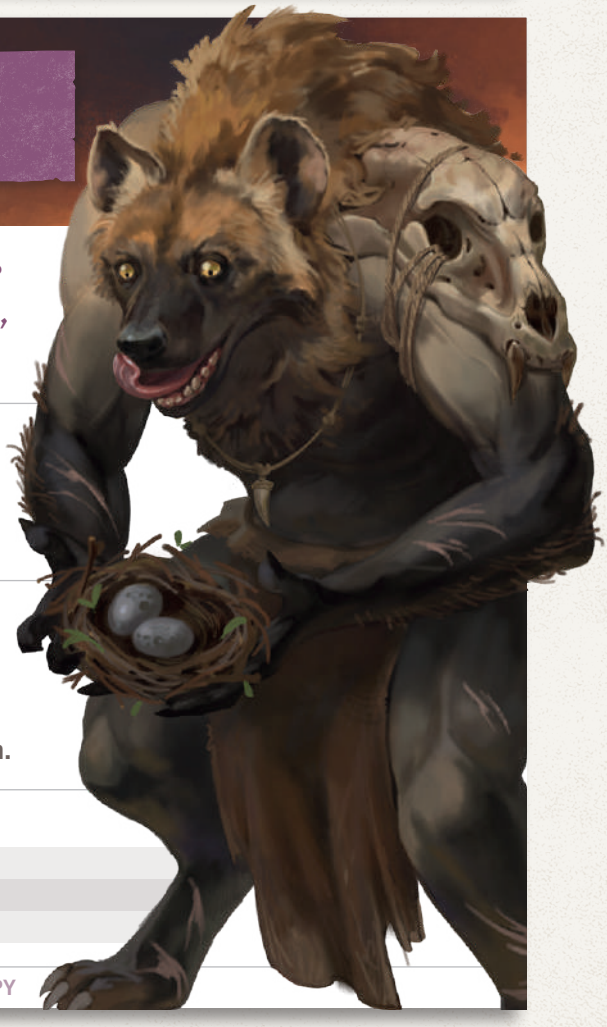
SECRET Buried deep within the pass is the legendary stargazer the statue honours. Their body rests besides exquisite tools and long-forgotten maps, once used to chart the heavens and guide ancient explorers.

CREATURE • LARGE • NEUTRAL • CONSTRUCT

CLAY GOLEM / STONE GOLEM

Hond Dongull

Prehistoric gnoll, displaced in time.



You smell wet dog on the wind, and notice Hond the gnoll. Dressed only in a loincloth and skull pauldron, he picks something out of his teeth with a stick.

KNOWN FOR Hond was frozen in time by primeval magic and woke up in the present day. He is a menace in the mountains. He attacks almost anything on sight, steals eggs from animal nests for food, and starts fires wherever he goes. Six bounties have been raised to capture Hond.

APPEARANCE Hond wears a dinosaur skull pauldron and an old loincloth. His brown fur is like a hyena's — tufted and mottled with uneven markings.

GOAL He lights fires as signals to the rest of his prehistoric clan. Hond firmly believes they are out there looking for him, and he hopes to track them down.

SECRET While frozen, Hond was semi-conscious. He could give insights into the region's history, if he were asked.

LOOT

- Bone shard collection
- Bag of beans*
- Hunting trap*

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • GNOLL • NATURALIST

GNOLL WARRIOR / SPY

Sapphire Knights

Secretive group of pilgrims.

KNOWN FOR The Sapphire Knights complete an annual pilgrimage to the top of a mountain, where they camp overnight. This religious order is secretive about the purpose of the trek and the rituals they perform.

GOAL Sapphire Knights are devoted followers of their obscure god. Their rituals sustain their unnatural powers, such as lightning breath and invisibility, which grow stronger with each successful visit.

FEATURE Members of the order wear distinctive blue cloaks over their climbing gear. Each member is given a title such as the Azure Knight or Cerulean Knight when they join the order. They never reveal their true names.

SECRET An ancient blue dragon sits at the top of the mountain and demands worship from the Knights. The order bring the dragon offerings of rare gems, gold, mirrors, and metal ingots to quench its wrath.

FACTION • MEDIUM (20–49) • NEUTRAL • RELIGIOUS

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Gwyndolin's Creep

Twisting tunnels beneath the world.

A vast canyon cuts through the wilderness like a deep scar. A gentle breeze draws you towards a narrow pass, where a carved stone door stands half-buried in the rock. Beyond it, a corridor descends into darkness.

Key Stats

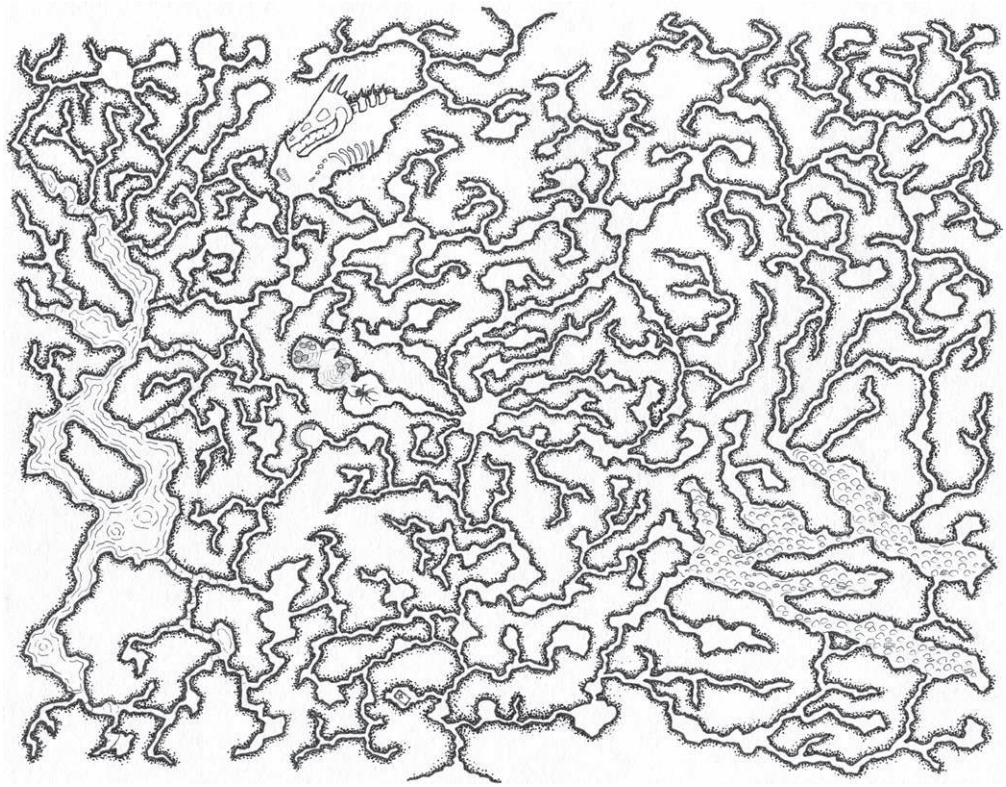
Area	2,000 sq. mi.
Climate	Humid
Hazard Level	Dangerous
Visibility	Dark
Ownership	Public
Key Fauna	Bats, giant spiders, oozes
Key Flora	Lichen, ferns, mosses

KNOWN FOR Gwyndolin's Creep is a network of winding tunnels and caverns linking two distant continents, accessible only by doors hidden within two colossal canyons. Though the Creep is considered a wonder of the world, it is not a viable passage; frequent cave-ins, hostile creatures, suffocating heat and stale air have claimed the lives of many. Even the boldest adventurers risk becoming hopelessly lost in its maze-like depths.

APPEARANCE Above ground, Gwyndolin's Creep appears as two mighty chasms on opposite sides of the world. One drives through a mountain range, the other shatters an otherwise a peaceful meadow. Below ground, the Creep's twisting tunnels are dark and musty, with stalactites and plant roots hanging from its moist ceilings. The caves vary from tight and suffocating crevices, to colossal and rocky chambers the size of small cities.

HISTORY Long ago, a poet named Gwyndolin fell deeply in love with a travelling soldier captain. They spent months together, before the warrior was deployed across the sea. Heartbroken, Gwyndolin turned to a powerful dao and wished for a way to reunite with her lost love. The dao complied and carved a vast passage through the earth, but the path was cursed, perilous, twisting and filled with monsters. Gwyndolin began the journey to reach her beloved, but was never seen again.

INHABITANTS The dark tunnels of Gwyndolin's Creep teem with creatures. Near the surface, travellers will encounter bats, rats, blind cave fish and translucent amphibians. Deeper down, the narrow halls become more dangerous, stalked by predatory oozes and massive yet silent arachnids. Some say even worse things dwell at its heart — lost explorers from past expeditions who never found an exit, warped by isolation and lack of sunlight. These broken souls now wander the tunnels, barely human.



LANDMARKS Only small sections of the tunnels have been mapped, but frequent landslides make existing maps unreliable. Still, travellers can watch out for yellow flags pinned to the walls, markers left by past expeditions that successfully crossed the Creep. Those who follow this trail may complete the journey between continents in about 12 weeks. But, the route is treacherous, and many never reach the other side.

Most expeditions into the Creep (right) start with an abseil down from Darkmaw Bridge.

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Known Sites Within the Creep

LOVERS' TOMB A quiet memorial to Gwyndolin and her soldier lover. It is debated whether their remains lie here or if the site is simply a manmade landmark. Regardless, travellers leave tokens on the two sarcophagi before going deeper.

EIGHT CORNERS This narrow, claustrophobic tunnel is thick with webs and slick mucus. At its end, the path splits into eight twisting passages. Two eventually rejoin and lead onward, five spiral into dead ends, and one descends into the lair of a monstrous spider. Choosing the wrong path here can cost precious time, or a life.

DAO'S DROP A long, vertical shaft plunges into the depths. There is a narrow ledge spiralling along its inner wall that can be descended like a staircase, though sections have crumbled and are now perilous. Around 1,000 feet down, a stone archway leads back into the main tunnels, but the shaft itself continues even further. Sound carries far in this hollow space, and the oozes clinging to the damp walls will stir at the noise.

THE GASP About three miles of winding cave passages are submerged in stale water. Travellers are required to dive, then emerge into the limited air pockets to catch their breath.

SMOKEBOX Rivers of magma flow down the walls and across the floors of this multistorey chamber. The air burns with volcanic heat and toxic sulphur.

THE KING'S REST Wide tunnels open into a colossal cavern with sharp grey crystals precariously hanging from its ceiling. Fossils line the uneven walls, and at the chamber's heart rests the old, gargantuan skeleton of a black dragon — known only as "King". Strangely, each expedition reports the bones in a different pose, sparking rumours that the beast isn't as dead as it seems.

SECRET The dao who carved Gwyndolin's Creep was banished by its kin, condemned to dwell forever within the cave system for violating natural law. Resentful, the elemental lurks in the Creep's deepest chambers and despises intruders. It considers the tunnel network an unfinished masterpiece, frequently shaping new chambers or collapsing old paths.

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Glowburrow

Cosy underground resting spot.

KNOWN FOR The Glowburrow is famous for its colourful, bioluminescent fungi and cosy atmosphere. Floating spores are shot from the tunnel walls like fireworks, creating an ever-changing underground display.

APPEARANCE The tunnels are lined with a soft moss carpet. The air is cool and damp, and the walls curve into natural alcoves – quiet spaces where weary travellers can safely rest undisturbed.

LOOT Herbalists prize the spore dust from the caves, and use it in powerful healing potions. If a Glowburrow mushroom is carefully harvested and preserved, it can be dried and eaten to give temporary vision in the dark.

SECRET At certain phases of the moon, the fungi hum soft, harmonic notes. If travellers hum back in tune, a hidden door opens to a secret chamber where a thriving community of mushroomfolk live.

ENVIRONMENT • SMALL • SAFE • CAVE

Tideshaft Mines

Submerged coral caves.

Light reflects off clear pools, casting ripples on the curved rock ceiling. Despite the echoing sound of miners and their tools, there's a sense of calm here.

KNOWN FOR This partially submerged cave is a coral reef that has been turned into a mineral extraction operation. Divers work side by side to harvest rare materials from the waterlogged caverns, while navigating the delicate aquatic ecosystem that continues to thrive in the caves.

APPEARANCE The rounded, volcanic tunnels are reinforced with wooden beams. Crates and torches line the edge of the water, which is home to rare coral and sea anemones.

INHABITANTS Miners swim through tunnels while tamed sea turtles haul crates of ore. Fish and coral flourish here, unfazed by the steady hum of excavation activity.

LOOT Valuable finds include golden pyrite, geodes and calcite. Disturbing the coral is forbidden; violators are fined and banned from the cave.

SECRET The work has woken an aboleth slumbering within the mine. Particularly sensitive to sound and motion, it is beginning to stir.

ENVIRONMENT • MID-SIZED • RISKY • MINE

Crystalum Sanctum

Magic-sensitive cavern.

KNOWN FOR This radiant cavern amplifies innate magic. Arcane pilgrims travel here to draw from its power, but it is only open to the public from dawn until dusk.

APPEARANCE The walls of the Crystalum Sanctum shimmer with power. Graceful archways and tiered balconies have been built throughout the hexagonal chamber.

SECRET Those who dare slip past the barricades at night are rewarded with a chaotic surge of raw magic. However, they are permanently transformed into crystalline beings.

ENVIRONMENT • SMALL • RISKY • CAVE

Echoheart Grotto

Ancient shrine to the gods.

KNOWN FOR Echoheart Grotto is a sacred and holy cave. It appears in many historic records and holy books as a place where the veil between mortals and the divine is thinnest.

APPEARANCE A towering marble statue of a robed woman stands at its centre in a pool of water. A beam of sunlight falls on the figure from above, regardless of the time or season.

SECRET Beneath the water, the statue's base is inscribed with an ancient prayer. Reciting it allows an individual to directly commune with the gods.

ENVIRONMENT • LARGE • SAFE • CAVE

Caves are full of hazards, like rising water or pockets of trapped poisonous gas.

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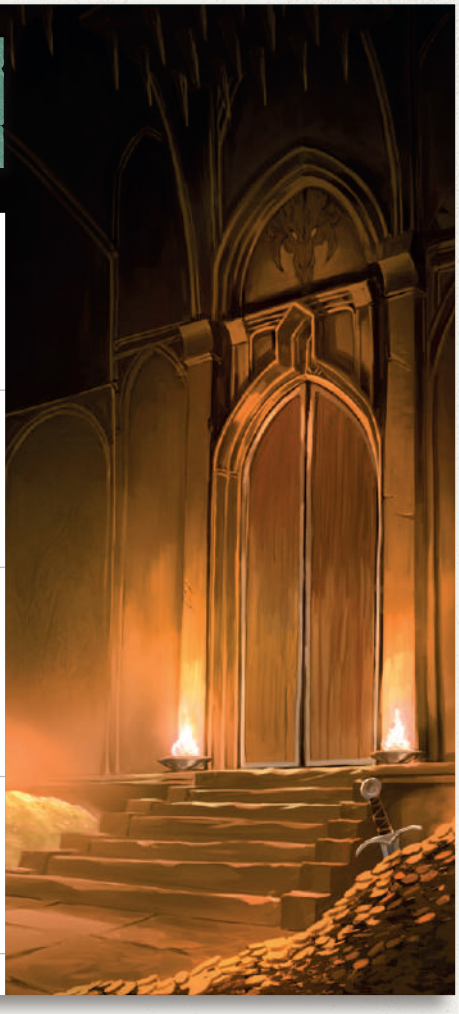
Goldwarden's Rest

Magically guarded dragon tomb.



A massive stone door bears shifting golden runes and the image of a sleeping dragon. The inscriptions promise wisdom and rewards to the pure of heart.

KNOWN FOR This underground catacomb is the resting place of a great golden dragon. Before their death, they set up tests that allow only honourable souls to pass inside. Acts of sacrifice, protection and generosity unlock paths forward, while immoral actions trigger dangerous arcane traps.

APPEARANCE Soft golden lamps light stone passages that slope gently deeper with each step. Faded inscriptions across the walls tell stories of past heroic deeds.

INHABITANTS The tomb is empty. Only the spirit of the dragon itself resides here, silently observing those who venture in. Very rarely, it will appear and speak to a worthy visitor.

LOOT Those who pass the tomb's trials can claim enchanted relics such as dragon scales, rune-etched artefacts and magical weapons.

SECRET The tomb presents bespoke trials based on the visitor's deepest regrets and failings. It also offers them a chance at redemption.

ENVIRONMENT • MID-SIZED • SAFE • TOMB

Stoneroot Forest

Subterranean woodland.

KNOWN FOR A strange underground grove blooms from a ceiling of black stone. The darkness has warped the plants' natural growth, creating an eerie upside-down woodland.

APPEARANCE Pale, twisted trees reach towards the cave's rocky floor, desperately seeking moisture. A mass of hardy brambles grow between the trees and blanket the ceiling.

SECRET Deep within the brambles, a ring of white thorns conceals a fey portal. Archfey use this gateway to banish those who displease them to the Material Plane.

ENVIRONMENT • VAST • DANGEROUS • CAVE

The Cauldrons of Emrys

Heated underground pools.

KNOWN FOR This cave network is filled with geothermal vents and hot springs. The hot, humid environment creates a rare location where elemental creatures thrive.

APPEARANCE Scolding pools brim with bubbling, mineral-rich water. Steam coils into the air, condenses on the cool cavern walls and trickles back down into the pools below.

SECRET The pools are named after Emrys, a clairvoyant who claimed the waters enhanced his visions. The fearful ruler of the time had Emrys drowned here to silence him.

ENVIRONMENT • MID-SIZED • RISKY • CAVE

Wearlands Mine

Site of a cave-in tragedy.

KNOWN FOR This closed-up mine is the site of an awful tunnel collapse that killed many. Locals claim to still hear the mournful songs of ghostly workers drifting from the mine.

APPEARANCE Weathered wooden boards block the mine entrance, daubed with faded warnings. Wind moans through the tunnels, creating echoes that sound like mortal cries.

SECRET The spirits of lost miners drift through the tunnels as will-o'-wisps, silently repeating their old routines. They would recognise loved ones, if any were to ever find them.

ENVIRONMENT • SMALL • DANGEROUS • MINE

More Underground Areas

1. **MISTWEAVER'S LAIR** Cave system filled with colourful fog.
2. **SCALED DEPTHS** Caverns home to reclusive reptile beings.
3. **TITAN'S VAULT** Chamber filled with ancient giant artefacts.
4. **LUNAGROTTO** Cave formed of white stone with large craters.
5. **ANGEL'S STEPS** Unstable rock bridges cross deep ravines.
6. **ECHOING GALLERY** Every sound creates tuneful harmonies.
7. **DREAMSTONE CAVES** Underground flora give weird visions.
8. **IRONSPINE WORKS** Old mine cluttered with rusted tools.
9. **ROIS CAVERN** Tourist attraction with historic cave paintings.
10. **STARFALL DROP** Sparkling gems line deep chasm walls.

Adventurers should think ahead. A smooth tunnel is fun to slide down, but will be much harder to climb out of.

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Petra Lith

Geologist looking for a new find.

KNOWN FOR The geological samples and fossil rubbings Petra collects from caves are displayed in the land's most prestigious museums. She is a leading mind in her field.

APPEARANCE The grey overalls Petra wears are brown with grime. Well-used hammers, chisels and measuring tape are clipped to the utility belt fastened around her waist.

SECRET Insecure Petra is desperate to make an impressive discovery. Her motivation has grown after watching her main academic rival receive a major award.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • HUMAN • SAGE

Voidtrail Company

Thrill-seeking cave divers.

KNOWN FOR This daring group explores deep, cramped cave systems for fun. Their shouts echo from the walls as they encourage each other to make risky manoeuvres.

GOAL The deeper your descent, the more respected you are in the Company's ranks. No cave or tunnel is considered too dangerous, regardless of official advice or signage.

SECRET A Voidtrail diver contracted a strange illness on a recent expedition. The group's leaders are hiding it, fearing authorities might find out and shut down their operations.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • FRIENDLY • SOCIAL

Syphapods

Translucent, giant octopuses.

KNOWN FOR These octopus-like creatures have slick, transparent skin that camouflages them on damp cave walls. A syphapod's soft body and dexterous tentacles allow it to squeeze through impossibly narrow gaps.

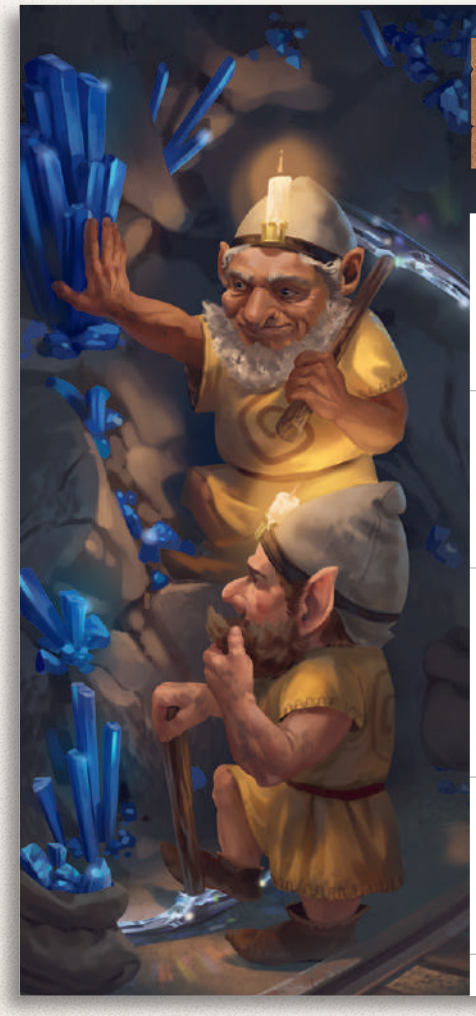
APPEARANCE Syphapods are 30 feet long, and have eight muscular limbs with suckers that grip to cave ceilings and walls. Their beaks are filled with curved barbs that hook their victims, making escape difficult.

TACTICS Syphapods have a guttural call that echoes through tunnels like echolocation, helping them find prey. They drop silently from above, suffocating and constricting victims with their slimy bodies.

SECRET A syphapod can regrow lost limbs, so cutting them off rarely stops it. Though covered in mucus, it is sensitive to water, which burns and blisters its skin by disrupting its natural coating.

CREATURE • LARGE • HOSTILE • BEAST

GIANT OCTOPUS / GRICK



Shardpick Syndicate

Miners with diamond pickaxes.

Cracking open the rock with a gleaming pickaxe, the miner picks up the debris and inhales. Recognition crosses their face, and they tuck the rock into their bag.

KNOWN FOR Renowned for their diamond pickaxes, the Shardpick Syndicate can carve through stone others see as impenetrable. Their miners are trained to read rocks with every sense – by sound, sight, smell, and even taste. Apprentices undergo years of training before earning their diamond pickaxe.

GOAL The faction reworks old mines, uncovering overlooked veins of ore and gems to sell for profit. Most miners join the crew to follow in the footsteps of older family members.

LEADERSHIP Each small crew is led by a seasoned project leader. Tradition dictates that the youngest apprentice is given the honour of breaking ground on any new veins.

FEATURE Workers wear yellow tunics with a swirling geode logo. Their diamond picks gleam, and candlelit hats light their path in the mines.

SECRET The Syndicate's leader is seeking a long-lost underground city. They trade for old maps and believe its discovery is within reach.

FACTION • LARGE (50–99) • NEUTRAL • INDUSTRY

Some cave-dwelling NPCs might only work underground, but others spend their whole life beneath the surface.

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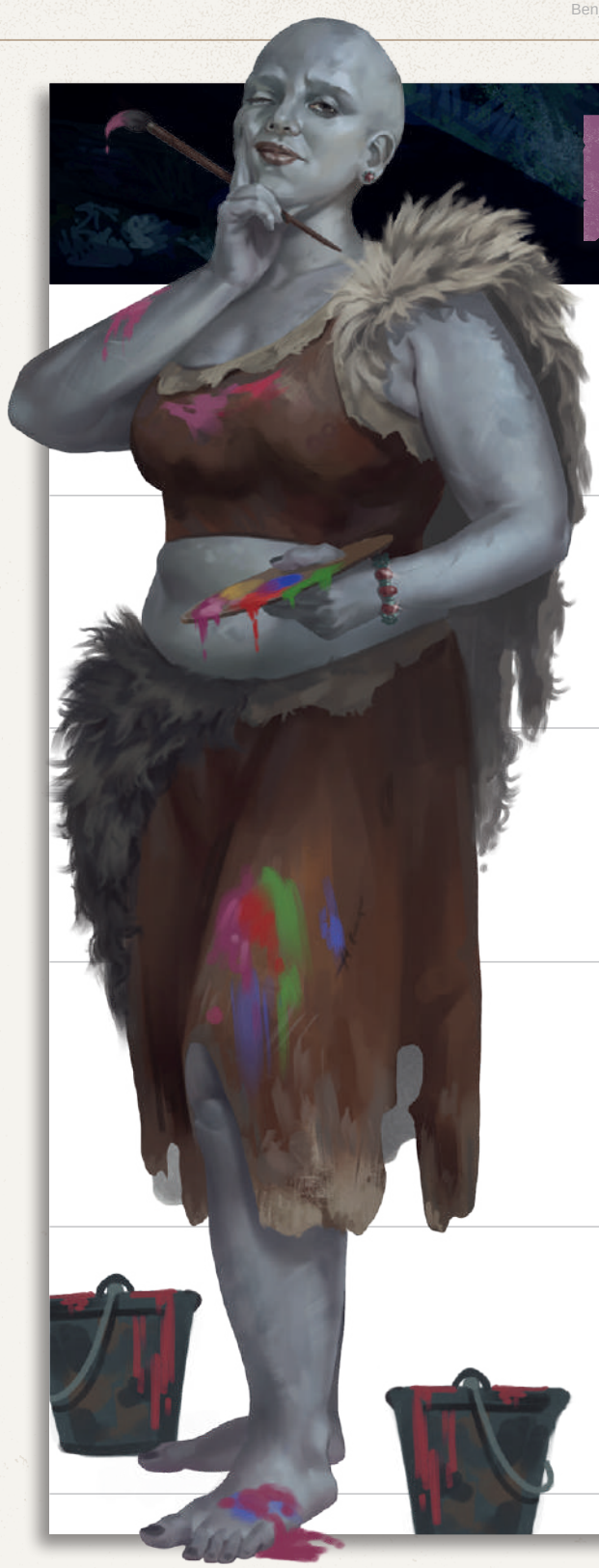

Cerulea Prim

Painter of cave murals.

The stone giant hums quietly as she daubs beautiful pigments onto the cave walls, adding detail to an immense mural. The vibrant scene shows figures dancing and celebrating.

KNOWN FOR Cerulea spends her days painting colourful murals onto the walls of her huge cave studio. Her masterpieces are not only for her own enjoyment; she happily beckons in anyone who passes by, sometimes inviting them to make their own additions to the pieces. She occasionally leaves her cave to paint murals in public spaces, but prefers the familiar surroundings of her home.

APPEARANCE Cerulea's grey skin, like the walls of her cave, is speckled with colourful blobs of pigment and chalk dust from a recent project. Her trusty wooden palette and brush are equally stained. She wears ruby earrings and a bracelet gifted by her mother, and carries herself with an easy grace, which lends a surprisingly chic edge to her otherwise simple fur attire.

HISTORY Cerulea was taught by an art professor from the capital city, and had collectors eager for her work even before graduating. After leaving her parents' home, she set up the cave studio where she still lives.

GOAL Sharing art with others is Cerulea's greatest joy, so she only accepts commissions for murals if they can be seen publicly. She is looking for an inspiring group of heroes to feature in her next piece.

SECRET Cerulea is very rich, having sold a famous painting of a satyr on a flaming horse for a large sum of platinum. With no need for the money, she buried a treasure chest beneath a dirt mound in her cave home.

LOOT

- Vial of magenta paint
- Grease-soaked rags
- Beads of Force*
- Marvellous pigments*
- Ruby earrings
- Painter's supplies*

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • GIANT • ARTISAN — OGRE / STONE GIANT

Nym

Nothic obsessed with the surface.

KNOWN FOR Nym is a violent aberration who attacks travellers and extracts their knowledge about the surface world. Giving secrets to Nym upfront can prevent conflict.

APPEARANCE The nothic drags her spiny, purple body along the ground with sharp claws, which screech on the rock. A lone, unblinking eye sits above her rows of shark-like teeth.

SECRET Once a human farmer, Nym was cursed by the gods to live forever underground as a monstrous being. She broke a promise to offer a portion of her miracle harvest as tribute.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • ABERRATION • SPELLCASTER

Tinkermoles

Mechanical mining assistants.

KNOWN FOR A tinkermole is a miniature mechanical mining construct that easily outpaces any humanoid. Its metal nose bores efficiently into the rock, seeking out precious gems.

APPEARANCE Curved metal paws carve through stone, while wheels churn the ground behind them. Their noses have armour plating to protect their internal mechanisms.

SECRET Tinkermoles have a slower "stealth mode" that reduces the noise and vibrations they produce. It lets them mine undetected in forbidden or heavily guarded locations.

CREATURE • SMALL • FRIENDLY • CONSTRUCT

Cave residents adapt to living in darkness and will be sensitive to bright light.

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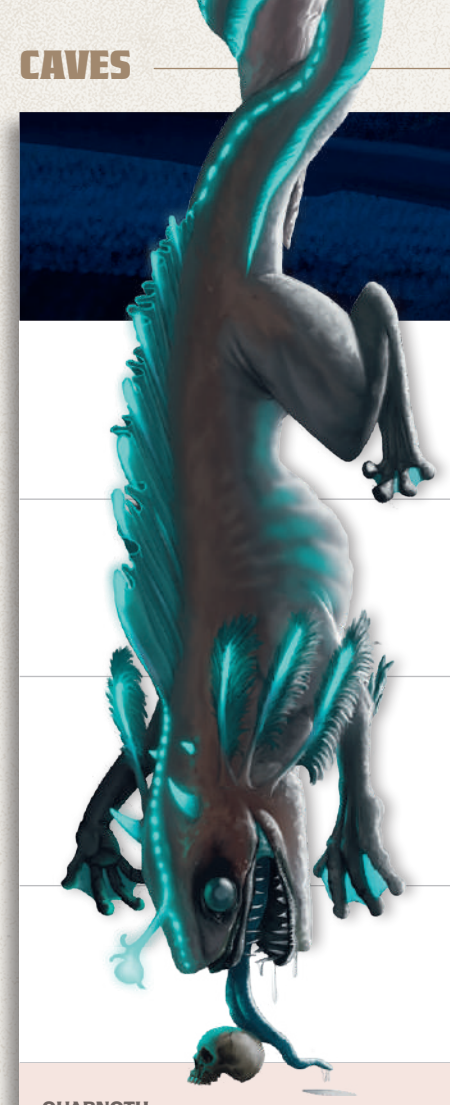

Quarnoths

Cave reptiles that feed on magic.

The intriguing, floating light suddenly darts upwards. Before you know it, a waft of putrid breath hits you and you're confronted with wide, slavering jaws.

KNOWN FOR These aberrations arrived when a wizard's planar experiment went awry, opening a portal to the Shadow Realm. Now living underground, Quarnoths feed on magical energy from other creatures. They use glowing lures and bioluminescence to attract and hunt prey in total darkness.

APPEARANCE Quarnoths have long, reptilian bodies with four webbed feet and a thick tail. Their glowing fins can vary in colour, dependent on diet and the acidity of their home.

TACTICS A quarnoth lies perfectly still, then extends its lit lure to bring in prey before pouncing. It siphons creatures' innate magical essence before feasting on them.

LAIR Quarnoths retreat into deep fissures and dark pools to sleep. They lay their eggs in sacs of sticky acidic slime on raised cave ceilings.

SECRET The best way to defeat a quarnoth is to take advantage of its powerful sense of hearing. Making loud noises will disorientate it.

QUARNOTH
Large Aberration

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
19 (+4)	13 (+1)	16 (+3)	2 (-4)	10 (+0)	4 (-3)

Armour Class: 13
Hit Points: 51 (6d10 + 18)
Speed: 40 ft, climb 40 ft, swim 40 ft
Initiative: +1

Skills: Stealth +3
Damage Resistances: Radiant, Necrotic
Senses: Blindsight 20 ft, Darkvision 60 ft
Passive Perception: 10
Languages: --
Proficiency Bonus: +2

ABILITIES

Amphibious. The quarnoth can breathe air and water.

Death Flash. When the quarnoth is reduced to 0 hit points, it detonates in an explosion of flesh and light. Each creature within 10 ft of the quarnoth must succeed on a DC 10 Dexterity saving throw or take 9 (2d8) radiant damage.

ACTIONS

Bite. Melee Weapon Attack: +6 to hit, reach 5 ft, one target. Hit: 10 (1d10 + 4) piercing damage plus 5 (1d10) necrotic damage.

Slamming Strike. Melee Weapon Attack: +6 to hit, reach 5 ft, one target. Hit: 8 (1d8 + 4) bludgeoning damage. If the target is a Large or smaller creature and was surprised by the quarnoth this round, the target has the Prone condition, and the quarnoth can make one Bite attack against it.

BONUS ACTIONS

Leap. The quarnoth jumps up to 30 ft by spending 10 ft of movement.

CHALLENGE RATING 2

You could alternatively use the stats of a Darkmantle CR 1/2, Phase Spider CR 3 or Roper CR 5.

CREATURE • LARGE • HOSTILE • ABERRATION

The Weavers

Underground religious commune.

KNOWN FOR The Weavers live in dark caves, threading as sacred scripture commands. Every tapestry contains spells or memories, and each finished piece is traded to the surface.

GOAL The group seek spiritual growth through weaving in silent meditation. They complete tapestries and send them out into the world, so that others might see and join them.

SECRET They don't advertise it, but the Weavers can also spin strong, organic armour. It is created from the same threads as their tapestries, and is imbued with divine magic.

FACTION • MEDIUM (20–49) • FRIENDLY • RELIGIOUS

Riktezzor

Monster-hunting drider.

KNOWN FOR Riktezzor is a hardened monster hunter, hired when settlements face dire threats. His latest contract is to purge a cave tunnel system overrun with ankhegs.

APPEARANCE Riktezzor is a drider, with a giant spider's abdomen, bristled legs and an upright human torso. He carries two swords, a rope lasso and a bag of supplies.

SECRET Feared as an abomination by the people he meets, Riktezzor hunts monsters to prove he is not one. Every kill and every contract is a plea for acceptance.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • DRIDER • COMBATANT

What do cave dwellers eat? Do they tend fungus gardens, domesticate subterranean animals, or scavenge from the surface?

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Bonedark Conclave

Cabal of flaming skulls.

KNOWN FOR This secretive arcane society is made up of floating, flaming skulls. Mages can only join after death, when their skull is delivered to the Conclave's hidden underground sanctuary.

GOAL Joining the Bonedark Conclave grants members immortality, and access to a powerful shared pool of magic. This allows the mages to continue and even complete their life's unfinished work after death.

FEATURE Each skull burns with a bright flame, coloured to match their specialised school of magic. When the mages are idle, they rest atop statues of their former bodies — positioned where their heads once were.

SECRET Only one living soul knows the location of the Conclave's headquarters at any time. This attendant is responsible for bringing the skulls of new members to the cave for resurrection in their new form.

FACTION • MICRO (1–5) • NEUTRAL • ACADEMIC

Grick Matriarchs

Giant worm queens.

KNOWN FOR Grick matriarchs are colony alphas that guard hoards of marble-like eggs. They will kill and eat anything they deem a threat to their clutch, including other gricks.

APPEARANCE Enormous, scaly worm creatures with 10 mouth tentacles and snapping beaks. Matriarchs' indigo bodies are bloated and muscular, making them slow-moving.

SECRET In cool, damp conditions, grick eggs take decades to hatch. With heat, they burst and give off a toxic gas that can be life-threatening to humanoids.

CREATURE • LARGE • HOSTILE • ABERRATION

Penryr the Butcher

Cursed, cave-dwelling ogre.

KNOWN FOR After raiding a village, Penryr was imprisoned in a cave and cursed by a druid; sunlight now burns him. He smashed his prison's walls and escaped into a tunnel.

APPEARANCE Penryr's ash-white skin is speckled with dirt and cave moss. He wears scraps of plaid fabric and carries a deadly flail made from bones he found in the caves.

SECRET Penryr discovered an ancient hoard buried in the tunnels beneath his cave prison — weapons, scrolls and bones of old kings. He's been protecting it ever since.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • GIANT • COMBATANT

Alrick Devlin

Mine surveyor and consultant.

KNOWN FOR Alrick is a highly respected independent consultant. He is hired by mines to advise on where lucrative ore seams are, and where is safe to dig.

APPEARANCE Alrick is a tall, gentle man of few words. He carries a pack of maps, his trusty pick, a clipboard and parchment to mark down his findings.

GOAL After losing members of his family to a cave-in, Alrick seeks to make the mining industry safer. He is exacting in his work and never cuts corners.

SECRET A mining company recently tried to bribe Alrick to fudge a safety report, and he refused. They are now plotting to discredit him to others in the industry.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • ELF • SAGE

COMMONER / SCOUT

More Cave Inhabitants

1. ZENEROTH V Cult leader who preaches in a bat-filled cave.
2. PENELUS WISEN Investor prospecting new mining sites.
3. BERNNAR DAIST Celestial in disguise; assists with rescues.
4. FILMI LONGE Soldier who fled underground during a battle.
5. POLAN FOUT Merchant running a subterranean supply shop.
6. HUFT Two-headed ettin stuck deciding which tunnel to take.
7. POSIE PHIMMS Bard using cave echoes as back-up vocals.
8. MULDA VARPSIN Cave druid with a giant mole companion.
9. GROTTONELL Ghost of a hag who was killed by adventurers.
10. TORJ MOORE Miner separated from their crew by a cave-in.

Lavadrop Corporation

Owners of a volcano forge.

KNOWN FOR Lavadrop workers refine precious metals into gleaming ingots in this company's huge, underground forge. Heat is provided by magma diverted from an active volcano.

GOAL The Lavadrop Corporation wishes to become the sole supplier of metal ingots in the realm. The company prides itself on creating pure products, and hallmarks every one.

SECRET The company didn't invent its refining technology; workers reverse-engineered tools from the ancient machines that already existed under the volcano.

FACTION • LARGE (50–99) • NEUTRAL • INDUSTRY

Narrow passages, vertical shafts, flooded tunnels, and echoing chambers can disorientate an underprepared party.

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Sugilite Sands

Lavender-coloured wasteland.

KNOWN FOR This desert draws many treasure seekers. The hopeful hunters believe vast deposits of purple sugilite and other precious minerals lie just beneath the surface.

APPEARANCE A gentle breeze sweeps lilac sand across the desert to form large dunes. The ground is soft and gently warming, so many people choose to walk barefoot.

SECRET The sand is actually the ground-up shed skin of purple worms that live under the Sugilite Sands. If disturbed, these creatures can suck prey down into their mighty mouths.

ENVIRONMENT • MID-SIZED • RISKY • WASTELAND

Whirling Plains

Flatlands with turbulent weather.

KNOWN FOR Tornadoes and fierce storms regularly sweep across the Whirling Plains. While not suited for all, the area is the perfect home for air elementals and their kin.

APPEARANCE Huge storm clouds roll through on a daily basis, bringing flashes of lightning and crashing thunder. Strong winds kick up hazardous dust and debris.

SECRET An endless tornado is tethered to a basin in the centre of the Whirling Plains. A reclusive genie family lives happily within the eye of the storm.

ENVIRONMENT • LARGE • DANGEROUS • PLAIN

The Barrens

Withered woodland remains.

Bundles of loose scrub and vines blow past dry, dead trees. Exposed roots clutch at the cracked earth, as if desperate to wring any last inch of moisture from it.

KNOWN FOR The Barrens was once a verdant forest, until an invading army began felling trees to build their temporary war barracks. In retaliation, a circle of druids drained the forest of all moisture and turned it into a desert. Left without shade, supplies or sustenance, the army was defeated.

APPEARANCE Dried husks of a few ancient trees still stand tall, yet their boughs are empty of fresh leaves. No signs of wildlife can be heard, just creaking bark.

INHABITANTS A shambling mass of dried twigs moves through the area, consuming any living matter that crosses its path. It rustles as it shifts across the dirt and dust.

LOOT The Barrens' oldest tree was the focus for the druids' magic. A branch taken from it and used as a staff has the ability to petrify people.

SECRET The circle of druids intended to restore the forest using water magic, but they were killed in the fight with the invading army.

ENVIRONMENT • MID-SIZED • DANGEROUS • WASTELAND

Godtear Flats

Drylands with holy pools.

KNOWN FOR Hardened sand spans as far as the eye can see, dotted with occasional freshwater springs. These tempting oases contain water imbued with divine power.

APPEARANCE Vibrant succulents, feathergrass and date palm trees grow in clusters near the rare pools of crystal-clear water. Elsewhere in the Godtear Flats, there is only dust.

SECRET Most oases hold water blessed with divine healing powers, but there are some that hold fiendish cursed water. It is impossible to know the outcome until the water is drunk.

ENVIRONMENT • LARGE • SAFE • OASIS

More Desert Locations

1. **VEILED LANDS** Cold desert with permanent, dense fog.
2. **SHADOWSPAN** Dusty plains around a mythical mountain.
3. **SPYGLASS VALLEY** White salt flats that are reflective.
4. **REGA'S CAULDRON** Volcanic black sands with lava geysers.
5. **LOG-REST BASIN** Canyon where time stands still.
6. **THE SLIPSANDS** Fey desert, home to rare glass creatures.
7. **ERIFUCUS** Dry habitat full of wandering undead humanoids.
8. **THE PUZZLE FIELDS** Naturally formed canyon labyrinth.
9. **ROSETE DESERT** Populated by awakened tumbleweeds.
10. **THE RISINGS** Soft sand dunes made from powdered bones.

From rolling sand dunes to flat salt pans, a desert can be any dry landscape without vegetation.

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Lost Lands of Trega

Desert with subterranean passages.

A scrawny bird of prey circles high in the blistering sky above. Shimmers of heat rising from ancient ruins allow it to drift on the thermals, patiently waiting for its next meal.

KNOWN FOR This sprawling desert was once home to an entire city state called Trega, but now only humid air is found in its ruins. Little research has been done into the ancient civilisation that lived here, as spending any time in the open leads to rapid heat exhaustion and sunstroke. Excavation is ongoing in the tunnels below the city, to investigate potential new trade routes that bypass the desert.

APPEARANCE The desert surface is made up of burnt-orange rock formations covered in red sand. These large stones and shaded archways were shaped by the desert's ancient inhabitants into buildings, now long-abandoned and destroyed. Among the ruins are vast entrance chambers with deep stone-lined recesses, leading to a carefully organised network of underground passages.

INHABITANTS Above ground, hungry vultures scavenge for burrowing rodents caught near the surface. Below ground, the tunnels shelter much larger predators, including creatures thought to be long-extinct.

LOOT The underground passages are better preserved than the ruins on the surface. Artefacts recovered here are of significant value to scholars, especially anything showing the ancient language of Tregan.

SECRET The underground passages were initially believed to be sewer systems. Recent research suggests mausoleums, shrines and vaults for wealthy individuals can also be found, each with their own traps.

COMMON CREATURES

- Camel
- Constrictor Snake
- Vulture
- Giant Rat
- Behir
- Carrion Crawler

ENVIRONMENT • LARGE • RISKY • WASTELAND

High Rock Mile

Desert with fuel stops.

KNOWN FOR Twelve stone mesas rise above the vast plains, each topped with an airship refuelling station. Voyagers can stretch their legs here and purchase rations for their journey.

APPEARANCE Each station is decorated with colourful flags to attract attention. Airships and flying mounts congregate in the clear skies above to wait their turn to dock.

SECRET Secret basements and hidden docks lie at the base of the bustling fuel stops. They allow smuggling of banned goods, rare artefacts and forbidden technologies.

ENVIRONMENT • SMALL • SAFE • PLAIN

Valley of Krakens

Dried-up ocean floor.

KNOWN FOR Layers of salt cover this parched landscape, once submerged beneath a huge ocean. Treasures and cargo from sea wreckages are littered throughout the area.

APPEARANCE The blinding salt flats crunch underfoot, and hiss as the wind hits them. Fossilised coral and the bones of a dragon turtle lie scattered across the desert's surface.

SECRET Each night beneath the stars, the ghost of the great dragon turtle swims across the sky. Those with a connection to the spirit world could attempt to communicate with it.

ENVIRONMENT • LARGE • SAFE • WASTELAND

Hot deserts cool rapidly at night, so travellers will need to deal with both extremes.

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Gulpus Aquimmus

Druidic hermit guarding an oasis.

KNOWN FOR Gulpus was tasked by his druid circle's leader to study and defend a strange oasis with cloudy water. The pool swarms with magic-sensitive fish.

APPEARANCE Gulpus is covered in shimmering dark-teal scales, and wears leather armour. He has webbed fingers and toes, and prominent frills running from ear to mouth.

SECRET Four days ago, curious Gulpus decided to cook and eat one of the magic-sensitive fish. Since then, his druidic spells have become more potent, but worryingly unstable.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • MERFOLK • NATURALIST

Terracotta & Silt

Clay brick masons.

KNOWN FOR The masons of Terracotta & Silt break termite mounds and harvest the naturally compacted clay within. The clay is then cooked into durable, patented bricks.

GOAL Terracotta & Silt bricks are resistant to fire and acid. The homes they build safeguard rural communities from common desert threats, like elementals and small dragons.

SECRET The two founders are in a dispute. One wants to export the bricks for profit, while the other fears scaling up production would be cruel to local termite colonies.

FACTION • LARGE (50–99) • NEUTRAL • INDUSTRY

Ludwia D. Caesar

Writer looking for inspiration.

The expensive jacket and tailored vest Ludwia wears are spattered with dust and dirt. Nevertheless, her smile is a beam of positivity, and she looks ready to seize the day.

KNOWN FOR Ludwia D. Caesar is famous for her series of crime-fiction books. *Blood on Fangs* was an instant hit, and its sequel *The Old Snake's Rune* was a follow-up success. The unwritten finale of the trilogy, *Couatl Calling*, involves a heist in a sandy tomb, so Ludwia has been living in a desert village to get some inspiration. It has been three years, and she fears she may have writer's block.

APPEARANCE To shelter from the scorching heat, Ludwia wears light-fitting garments and a floppy, wide-brimmed sun hat. She is rarely seen without her quill or ink, and travels with a bag of supplies and scroll cases on her back when heading out on one of her "inspiration trips". Ludwia's skin has become tanned and freckled after years spent in the sun.

HISTORY Ludwia was originally a gardener, but started writing *Blood on Fangs* after she fell off a ladder and broke her leg. The long recovery days helped her craft what would become a life-changing bestseller.

GOAL Desperate to write *Couatl Calling*, Ludwia takes hours-long treks into the arid wilderness. She hopes for a plot to develop, and draws inspiration from the places she visits and people she meets.

SECRET Three years ago, on one of her first few days in the desert village, Ludwia found a couatl egg resting in a dilapidated shrine. Since then, she has been trying to hatch it, hoping it will become her muse.

LOOT

- Scroll cases of spare parchment
- Hooded lantern*
- Crowbar*
- Notebook of crossed-out ideas
- Waterskin*
- Potion of climbing*

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HUMAN • ARTISAN — BANDIT / SCOUT

Travelling the desert without the right resources and rations could spell disaster for any expedition.

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Duneshredders

Carnivorous sand sharks.

KNOWN FOR Duneshredders are land sharks that swim in sand as freely as their aquatic relatives swim in water. They are bloodthirsty, dog-sized carnivores that attack for fun.

APPEARANCE These sharks have striped windsail-like fins that stay above ground as they swim. Their wide snouts help them detect the vibrations of their unsuspecting prey.

SECRET Duneshredder bodies are very sensitive to change. If they stop swimming, they quickly start to suffocate, and exposure to cold can make them sluggish and confused.

CREATURE • MEDIUM • HOSTILE • MONSTROSITY

Enclave of Dust

Cult gathering mummy parts.

KNOWN FOR The Enclave of Dust rob desert tombs to harvest mummy limbs and organs. Their horrific flesh golem creations patrol their stinking tent laboratory in the dunes.

GOAL The cult leaders are experimenting with ancient necromantic methods of achieving immortality. The flesh golems are a mix of mummy parts and willing volunteers.

SECRET Many locals know of the cult, but it remains active. Several members work as guards in a nearby desert town; they sabotage and cover up any real attempts to stop it.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • HOSTILE • CRIMINAL

Aneksi Manfred

Sun shrine high priest.

He bows his head in reverence, and touches a strong hand to one of the parchment ribbons that is stuck to his armour. His robes billow majestically.

KNOWN FOR Aneksi is the current high priest of a remote desert temple to a sun deity. He grew up as an orphan, given to the shrine by the nearby village to be trained as an acolyte. Aneksi impressed his teachers with his aptitude for scriptures, and was elected as high priest despite his young age.

APPEARANCE He wears the ochre vestments common in the temple, but is set apart by his gold diadem and staff. Aneksi's kind smile shows his warm personality.

GOAL The sun shrine is falling into disrepair. Aneksi plans to send out acolytes to gather donations, funding much-needed roof fixes and expanding the temple's influence.

SECRET On a recent missionary trip, Aneksi met and fell in love with a botanist. His order forbids him from forming relationships.

LOOT

- Staff of fire*
- Well-used holy book
- Holy water*

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HUMAN • WORSHIPPER

PRIEST / ARCHPRIEST

Draz "Whitesting" Dragoslav

Scorpion-keeping assassin.

KNOWN FOR The Whitesting is a desert assassin for hire. He uses the venom of his deadly pet scorpions in blow-darts, killing his victims before they can react or call for help.

APPEARANCE Draz is clad in a riveted tunic and a loose scarf, both the same colour as his stark-white hair. He wears bladed gauntlets that mimic scorpion pincers.

SECRET Razorpin is Draz's deadliest scorpion, but it recently vanished in a suspected theft. The scorpion has high monetary and sentimental value, and Draz wants it back.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • DRAGONBORN • OUTLAW

Redtail Bounders

Hopping desert marsupials.

KNOWN FOR Redtail bounders travel in large colonies of up to 50. These hungry, hopping marsupials strip crop fields in minutes, stuffing produce into their pouches and mouths.

APPEARANCE A bounder looks like a meerkat crossed with a kangaroo. They have large teeth and cheeks like hamsters, and cherry-coloured tails that flop behind them.

SECRET Unlike other marsupials, a bounder horde is ruled by a queen. The queen leads the group, and is the only one who breeds; other bounders act as workers or soldiers.

CREATURE • TINY • NEUTRAL • BEAST

Desert wanderers could find rare items like natural glass, fragrant spices, or uncut gems.

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Glitter Glass Caravan

Travelling caravan of glassmakers.

KNOWN FOR This troupe of artisan glassmakers packed up their homes and studios into a set of wagons and set out for the desert. They are open to trading pieces of intricate glasswork for rations and other resources.

GOAL The group are looking for a fabled source of magical sand they can use to create enchanted glassworks. They then plan to build a small commune close to the magical sand and a steady supply of water.

FEATURE Their sled-like, camel-pulled wagons travel slowly and have extra suspension to protect the fragile glasswork they carry. Dangling glass charms adorn the vehicles, creating a tinkling sound as they travel.

SECRET The leader of the Glitter Glass Caravan claims to have a map to guide the troupe to their final destination. In truth, they are navigating based on a hunch and rumours they picked up at a drinking spot.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • FRIENDLY • COMMERCE

Jacrok Portler

Lizard-riding postal worker.

KNOWN FOR It takes a special kind of postal worker to brave the harsh desert conditions, but Jacrok and his trusty giant lizard steed are up for the job.

APPEARANCE Jacrok wears light clothes that cover as much skin as possible, with reinforced leather patches to protect him from the rough hide of his lizard mount.

GOAL Jacrok delivers letters and parcels to settlements across the desert. He prides himself on his regional knowledge and navigation.

SECRET When Jacrok started his job, he was given a camel as a mount. He quickly discovered he had a severe camel allergy, so hand-reared a giant lizard instead.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • DWARF • WAYFARER — COMMONER / SCOUT

More Desert Creatures

1. MILESIGHT FOXES Foxes with large ears and great hearing.
2. DUNE EATER Living quicksand pit that sucks in its prey.
3. NOMAD'S MULE Undead camel with supplies but no rider.
4. NIXCLAWS Six-legged aardvarks; can be domesticated.
5. BLOODSTING Aggressive scorpion the size of a house.
6. HOOHOWLERS Coordinated, acid-drooling coyotes.
7. MOCKJACKS Hares with antelope horns and human voices.
8. CLEAVERBIRD Agitated axebeak, charges at moving objects.
9. BEGGERATS Rodents who flock to the smell of cooking meat.
10. PRICKLEDREAM Awakened cactus with toxic spines.

Disciples of Khorshid

Army of sand soldiers.

KNOWN FOR This inert construct army was created by a queen centuries ago. The warriors are made from hardened sand and resemble winged catfolk wielding swords and bows.

GOAL These emotionless soldiers fought for their queen with perfect obedience until her death. They have stood inactive ever since then, waiting patiently for their next commander.

SECRET An emerald-topped sceptre hidden in the queen's desert tomb allows any mortal to control this sand army for themselves. The sceptre is also cursed, and brings bad luck.

FACTION • LARGE (50–99) • NEUTRAL • MILITARY

Remedissa

Snakes with healing venom.

KNOWN FOR Remedissa are rare massive serpents that burrow under shallow sand by day, and feed at night. Their venom glands produce potent anti-toxins, highly sought after by healers in desert communities.

APPEARANCE Remedissa can grow up to 50 feet long. Their skin resembles sand with a rough, gritty texture. They have yellow eyes that glint in the night, and their mouths contain soft gums and tiny teeth.

TACTICS After dark, Remedissa move silently to ambush sand-dwelling mammals, constricting their prey with immense force before swallowing them whole. They use stealth and muscle rather than fanged strikes.

SECRET All vital organs are housed in a Remedissa's head, meaning they can survive being severed from their body. Over many years, and in the right conditions, a Remedissa can regrow its entire body from scratch.

CREATURE • HUGE • HOSTILE • MONSTROSITY — GIANT CONSTRICTOR SNAKE / PURPLE WORM

With heat shimmering off the sand, your party might not see a creature coming until it's too late.

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Snickershells

Pack hunters with armoured shells.

The sound of hysterical barking and laughter rings out across the desert dunes, getting closer and closer. A telltale sign of a nearby pack of hungry snickershells.

KNOWN FOR While travelling the dunes, watch out for snickershell packs. These canine predators are fast, coordinated and tough. Their armoured backs deflect weapons and their jaws easily shatter bones. Each pack is led by an alpha, though dominance is constantly contested through vicious internal battles that can result in injury or death of the previous leader.

APPEARANCE Snickershells look like hyena-armadillo hybrids; their backs have layered shells with patterns like dusty sandstone. Often smeared with blood and dirt, they drool thick strands of saliva when on the hunt – their serrated teeth and pronounced claws are visible warning signs to their prey. Snickershell fur comes in three tones: tan, grey and light-brown.

TACTICS Snickershells exhaust prey by chasing them, and are able to run for hours thanks to their heat-resistant shells and short fur. Once tired, prey are overwhelmed by coordinated strikes from the hunting pack.

LAIR They sleep in cool dens dug beneath the sand, or take over burrows left by other animals. Abandoned termite mounds, aardvark burrows or shaded rock crevices can serve as temporary shelters.

SECRET Though fierce, snickershells are opportunists. They'll always choose an easy kill or scavenged carcass over a hard fight. Packs can be distracted and lured by baiting them with raw meat.

LOOT

- Heat-resistant shell
- Animal bones
- Stale meat
- Serrated teeth
- Tuft of fur
- Acidic saliva

CREATURE • MEDIUM • HOSTILE • BEAST

WOLF / GIANT HYENA

Qamar, the Dead Herald

Ghost of a guardian sphinx.

KNOWN FOR In life, Qamar guarded sacred desert shrines where gods spoke to mortals. Though long dead, her vengeful spirit still protects the ancient standing stones.

APPEARANCE Qamar's ghostly lion body shows skeletal decay. Her falcon wings spread wide, her elven face screams with fury, and her blue aura flickers in the desert heat.

SECRET The gods eventually stopped using the shrines, and Qamar grew bitter. She became defiant, so the gods struck her down and forced her soul to guard the stones for eternity.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • UNDEAD • WORSHIPPER

Esmund Atashi

Bandit on the run.

KNOWN FOR Ignoring the code of honour among thieves, Esmund swiped a rare artefact from his gang's latest haul. He took off on camelback, with angry bandits in hot pursuit.

APPEARANCE Esmund is a weather-beaten gnome with long hair, patched leather armour and curled-toe sand boots. His eyes are ash-grey and peer from beneath his frayed hood.

SECRET Esmund recognised the artefact as a sacred relic of his people and plans to take it back to his home village. In return, he hopes to be pardoned for his previous crimes.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • GNOME • OUTLAW

In need of a desert bandit group? Check out the entries on pp. 114–117 for inspiration.

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Fox's Teeth

Animal hunting ground.

KNOWN FOR The Fox's Teeth is a deep arctic canyon, with steep ice walls and narrow passages. The area is notorious for animal ambushes, particularly by bears and snow leopards.

APPEARANCE The canyon is filled with tall, jagged ice formations. These frozen "teeth" create a winding maze of ravines, dotted with animal burrows and dens.

SECRET At night, the Fox's Teeth falls silent, and its many predators hide. Bold travellers risk disturbing its apex hunter, a pitch-black roc that strikes under cover of darkness.

ENVIRONMENT • MID-SIZED • DANGEROUS • PLAIN

Fjordane Field

Battlefield covered in frozen soldiers.

KNOWN FOR A bloody battle was waged here, during which a sorcerer cast a spell beyond her ability. The sudden blast of elemental magic froze every soldier where they stood.

APPEARANCE Hundreds of glittering soldiers span the former battlefield, frozen in combat. Light glints off their frosty forms and casts rainbows onto the snow around them.

SECRET The sorcerer that cast this spell is still alive, and lives in the surrounding snowy wilderness. She has not spoken since the day she cast the powerful spell.

ENVIRONMENT • SMALL • SAFE • WASTELAND

The Sleeplands

Featureless flat tundra.

KNOWN FOR Anyone who tries to cross this flat tundra gets disorientated by the lack of landmarks. Many walk in circles before losing their way entirely and succumbing to the cold.

APPEARANCE With no vegetation, no buildings and no features, this tundra is a sea of endless white powder. The wind brushes fresh snow over the tracks of past travellers.

SECRET An ancient dwarven civilisation installed metal strips through the Sleeplands. They act as wayfinders for any wizards who know the password to light them up.

ENVIRONMENT • LARGE • DANGEROUS • WASTELAND

Snowdrop Bayou

Slushy ice swamp.

KNOWN FOR Locals sail reinforced boats through the slushy waters of this frozen swamp. The area is home to hardy fish species, and peaceful blubber-coated mammals.

APPEARANCE Sludgy, half-frozen creeks weave through the mire in a maze beneath drooping willows. Icicles hang from tree branches, grazing the heads of those who pass below.

SECRET A lost artefact of great power lies in a swamp grotto behind a frozen waterfall. The grotto is inhabited by an unseelie fey fugitive, who has no idea the artefact is there.

ENVIRONMENT • LARGE • RISKY • PLAIN

Icewound Reach

Archaeological site in a glacier.

Frost-covered runes glisten along the walls in the light from your torch, but the flame cannot keep the cold and damp from penetrating your bones.

KNOWN FOR The retreat of the Icewound Reach glacier has recently revealed the site of several lost tombs belonging to a famous cabal of mages. Intrepid archaeologists or tomb raiders must brave freezing temperatures, deadly traps and the chilling spirits of the wizards who were laid to rest here.

APPEARANCE Only the tops of the stone tombs peek out from under the snow. Descending into the catacombs leads to icy caverns, full of sharp stalactites and dormant traps.

INHABITANTS A few eager archaeologists are camping in one of the tomb entrances, sheltering from the cold. Glowing centipedes scuttle about and provide dim light.

LOOT Magnificent artefacts are buried alongside their former owners. Magical armour, enchanted weapons, gold and tomes can all be found here.

SECRET The spirits of the mages who rest here are present, but they bear visitors no ill will. They only wish to have their stories heard.

ENVIRONMENT • SMALL • DANGEROUS • TOMB

How do seasons affect your icy location? Does snow melt and go slushy, or is it permanently frozen?

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Hydecker Pines

Tundra full of experimental beasts.

KNOWN FOR This remote area once housed a private laboratory, where maverick scientists conducted mutagenic experiments away from prying eyes. The monstrosities they created now roam the tundra.

APPEARANCE The twisted roots of tall alpine trees hide beneath the snow, waiting to trip up travellers. Occasionally, something more sinister cracks underfoot, like the bones of a scientist killed by its own creation.

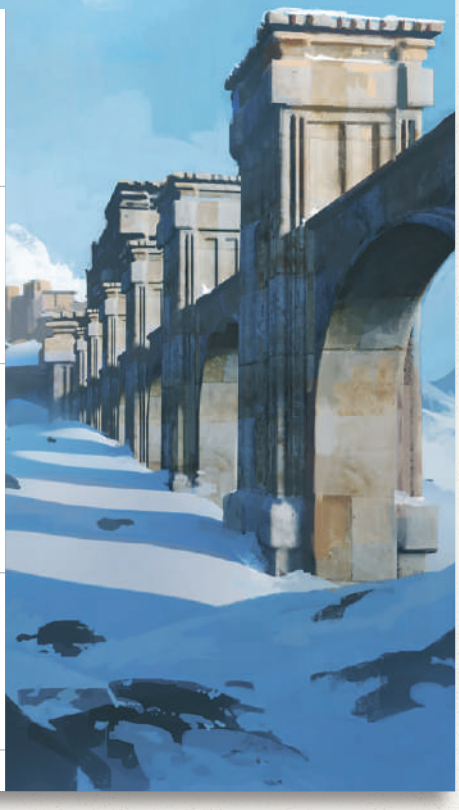
LOOT Around the ruined lab, scattered debris includes journals, crates and surgical tools. Bottles containing explosive and corrosive chemicals lie frozen on the ground, hinting at a violent abandonment of the site.

SECRET A network of escape tunnels runs beneath the tundra, leading to and from the laboratory. If their sealed doors can be opened, they grant safe passage away from the monster-infested ice.

ENVIRONMENT • MID-SIZED • RISKY • PLAIN

The Permafrost Divide

Contested land between two clans.



The battlements stretch all the way to the horizon, where pale snow and sky become one. A bird swoops past, but is shot down before it reaches the wall.

KNOWN FOR This frozen waste is the site of a fiercely contested border. In an attempt to quell skirmishes between rival clans, the realm's army built a long network of fortresses through the disputed land. The soldiers stationed here have simple orders — no one crosses the border, under any circumstances.

APPEARANCE Grey, stone walls run for hundreds of miles across the Permafrost Divide. Guard stations and watchtowers are positioned at optimum vantage points.

INHABITANTS Guards stationed here are vetted to ensure they have no loyalty to one of the rival clans. Scouts from either clan patrol as close to the border as they dare.

LOOT The frozen land surrounding the Divide is littered with armour, weapons and battle standards from decades of bloody conflict.

SECRET One of the clans has spies in the armed forces that guard the border. They influence shift patterns to their advantage when needed.

ENVIRONMENT • LARGE • DANGEROUS • WASTELAND

Thawheart Springs

Tundra with multiple hot springs.

KNOWN FOR The hot springs in this area are popular with tourists year-round. Lodges, cabins and holiday homes can be found throughout the snow-covered landscape.

APPEARANCE Thawheart Springs is an icy, craggy expanse. It is peppered by steaming, turquoise pools, where heavily laden fruit trees and blossoming shrubs grow.

SECRET Locals have an annual oasis festival to celebrate the land and its bounty. They don't realise eating the fruit growing here gives them lasting protection against the cold.

ENVIRONMENT • MID-SIZED • SAFE • OASIS

More Icy Environments

1. **FROSTBROOK** Hilly area popular with fans of winter sports.
2. **SHIVERWARY** Gleaming ice prison for dangerous criminals.
3. **RHYLLIAN COVE** Busy fishing port with ice-breaking ships.
4. **LOHAN'S BRIDGE** Glacial bridge between two communities.
5. **TERNHILL** Mountain that erases climbers' memories.
6. **SHARD PASS** Plains of dangerous, tectonic ice plates.
7. **THE WINTER ROAD** Pass that is only clear for a week a year.
8. **WITCH'S NEEDLE** Mysterious ice column said to be magical.
9. **SHREEK LOCH** Vast lake inhabited by vengeful snow sirens.
10. **THE VISTA** Explorer's shipwreck embedded in an iceberg.

Add a town (pp. 106–111) or village (pp. 118–119) to your arctic environment so your party can rest and restock.

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Ice Maiden's Bridge

Shattered ice path across water.

KNOWN FOR The Ice Maiden's Bridge is a shortcut of frozen water between two towns. Crossing the fractured ice saves days of travel, but the shifting icebergs and lurking aquatic creatures beneath make it treacherous.

APPEARANCE The waterway's icy platforms create a fragmented white sheet across the strait, which is home to seals, puffins and penguins. The sediment in the lapping cyan water blurs the view beneath the surface.

LOOT Remains of boats that were unable to navigate the frozen waters bob and knock into the ice. Their cargo drifts through the water and waits for anyone brave or foolish enough to swim out and claim it.

SECRET Sahuagin have been breeding arctic sharks in the strait to use as undersea mounts, making the area even more dangerous. The Sahuagin warriors attack anyone who threatens their animals.

ENVIRONMENT • SMALL • DANGEROUS • LAKE

Coldslate

Field with icy crop circles.

KNOWN FOR Nicknamed "Coldslate" by locals, this field flash freezes once a month, with strange patterns visible in the ice before it thaws. The land belongs to a lingonberry farmer who is too afraid to harvest it.

APPEARANCE The ice carves geometric shapes into the crops that look like swirling text, as if written by an unseen force. The patterns scar the square field for a week, until the ice melts and the plants regrow.

LOOT Hidden beneath the tangled brambles and tall grasses, ripe lingonberries wait to be picked. In the south of the field, the owner's abandoned sheds hold farming tools, harvesting knives and netting.

SECRET The icy symbols are a distress message from an aberration trapped in the Astral Sea. They don't realise their monthly plea for rescue isn't being sent to their extraterrestrial kin, but to a totally different plane.

ENVIRONMENT • MID-SIZED • RISKY • PLAIN

Whitewyrm Valley

Basin caught in a permanent blizzard.

The white, snow-capped hills looked beautiful from a distance, but that charm faded quickly. Since you got here, you've been battered by numbing snowstorms and howling winds.

KNOWN FOR Regardless of the season, a relentless blizzard sweeps through Whitewyrm Valley and blankets the area with deep snow and ice. This unnatural storm is driven by the migration patterns of icy air elementals that inhabit the neighbouring mountain peaks.

APPEARANCE Powder snow covers the trees and rocks of the picturesque valley, overlooked by frosted mountaintops. Every mile or so, red hospitality towers break through the white landscape and give travellers a warm place to rest and recover.

INHABITANTS The valley's non-stop snowstorms make it hard for most life to thrive, yet some hardy badgers, mountain goats and yetis manage to survive here. No permanent communities exist in Whitewyrm, except for the staff who operate and live in the hospitality towers.

LOOT The snow conceals plenty of forgotten treasures. Chests lie in icy caves, useful tools rest with travellers who didn't survive their journey, and rare frost crystals created by air elementals dot the landscape. However, the weather makes it almost impossible to explore.

SECRET Whitewyrm Valley is named after the legend of the white wyrm, an ancient predator who once ruled the peaks. The colossal dragon is very much real, and sleeping beneath the glaciers — it will wake if disturbed.

COMMON CREATURES

Goat	Badger
Abominable Yeti	Giant Owl
Air Elemental	Ancient White Dragon

ENVIRONMENT • LARGE • DANGEROUS • PLAIN

Towers in Whitewyrm Valley (right) are painted red to make them visible in thick snow.

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Frost

Snowman-shaped construct.

KNOWN FOR This Frozen Region Orientation Support Tool, nicknamed "Frost", is a sentient construct. He is designed to help polar researchers navigate the tundra, give survival advice, and assist with any physical tasks.

APPEARANCE Frost's body consists of three stacked metal spheres held together by magnets. His top sphere wears a woolly hat, and has a smiley face made from black buttons that were glued on by his teammates.

GOAL Frost's current goal is assisting a research team studying the aurora. He supports their work by collecting readings, tracking atmospheric patterns, and offering logistical aid across the frigid tundra terrain.

SECRET Frost likes to make sure everything around him is kept clean, especially his metallic spheres. He has a hidden compartment where he keeps a bottle of polish and rags, and he can't stand muddy boots in tents.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • CONSTRUCT • WAYFARER

SCOUT / CLAY GOLEM

The Fractal Court

Fey society exiled to the Material Plane.

The room and its inhabitants are truly dazzling. Moonlight bounces off every surface, creating prismatic light shows of green, pink and purple.

KNOWN FOR Scions of the Fractal Court are adept at ice magic — and cold-blooded scheming. Banished from the Fey Realm for treason against its ruler, the Fractal Court constructed a new palace in the coldest reaches of the Material Plane. Days are spent socialising, squabbling and tricking travellers.

GOAL Fractal Court members act on selfish desires and motivations. However, they will pull together in their attempts to return to the Fey Realm and take their revenge.

LEADERSHIP Twin siblings rule over the Fractal Court. One is loud and vivacious; the other reserved and thoughtful. Both can be equally calculating when needed.

FEATURE Members of the court are adapted to the cold and walk barefoot through their icy palace. Their skin sparkles like fresh frost.

SECRET The Fractal Court's power wanes the longer they spend exiled. They plot an imminent return, boosted by an army of bewitched mortals.

FACTION • MEDIUM (20–49) • NEUTRAL • CIVIC

Coldfang Beavers

Giant beavers adapted to the snow.

KNOWN FOR Coldfang beavers build massive dams high in the mountains to stop snow shifts damaging their lodges. Inadvertently, the barricades also defend people who live in the valley below from avalanches.

APPEARANCE Coldfang beavers grow up to seven feet tall, with thick white fur and heavy fat reserves to survive harsh winds. They bark and squeak to communicate, and constantly gnaw down their long teeth.

TACTICS These giant beavers are herbivores, but their large, muscular tail can land a crushing blow if a predator gets too close. They can fell whole trees and drag them long distances, including uphill.

SECRET If reared away from their own kind, a coldfang beaver can be tamed to act as a hardy mount and guide through the snow. However, locals believe it is bad luck to deliberately take a young beaver from its parents.

CREATURE • MEDIUM • NEUTRAL • BEAST

GIANT BADGER / BLACK BEAR

Communities in remote, challenging environments must be able to rely on each other for support.

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Leon Smiloson

Tiger-pulled sled driver.

KNOWN FOR Leon offers rapid transport across the inhospitable tundra using a sled pulled by sabre-toothed tigers. An expert guide, he's known for speed, reliability and navigating routes others wouldn't dare attempt.

APPEARANCE Leon wears a floor-length cloak made from a single grizzly bear's hide. His boots are spiked to grip the ice, and frost clings to his thick curled moustache and furrowed eyebrows.

GOAL Leon continues the family business of pulling sabre-toothed tiger sleds; it's a job that provides for him, his mother, father, wife and son. Recently, Leon started teaching his son to drive a tiger team of his own.

SECRET Leon's sabre-toothed tigers only obey him. Though calm under Leon's command, they distrust others. Any attempts to stroke or feed them without permission often end in bitten fingers or worse.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • GOLIATH • WAYFARER — SCOUT / PIRATE

Tundra Maw Collective

Illegal logging company.

KNOWN FOR This tree-felling gang are more like pirates than farmers. They plough through swathes of arctic forest on huge machines fitted with mechanical saws and axes.

GOAL The Collective boost profits by avoiding permit costs. Their vehicles are equipped with chains and tank tracks, so operate efficiently in harsh frozen conditions year-round.

SECRET The gang use their juggernaut vehicles to vandalise villages where locals have threatened to report them. Their brutal intimidation tactics keep others from speaking out.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • HOSTILE • INDUSTRY

Shard Basilisks

Reptiles that freeze prey.

KNOWN FOR A shard basilisk can lay completely unmoving for years at a time waiting for prey. Then, suddenly, its eyes snap open, and its glare freezes its victims into icy statues.

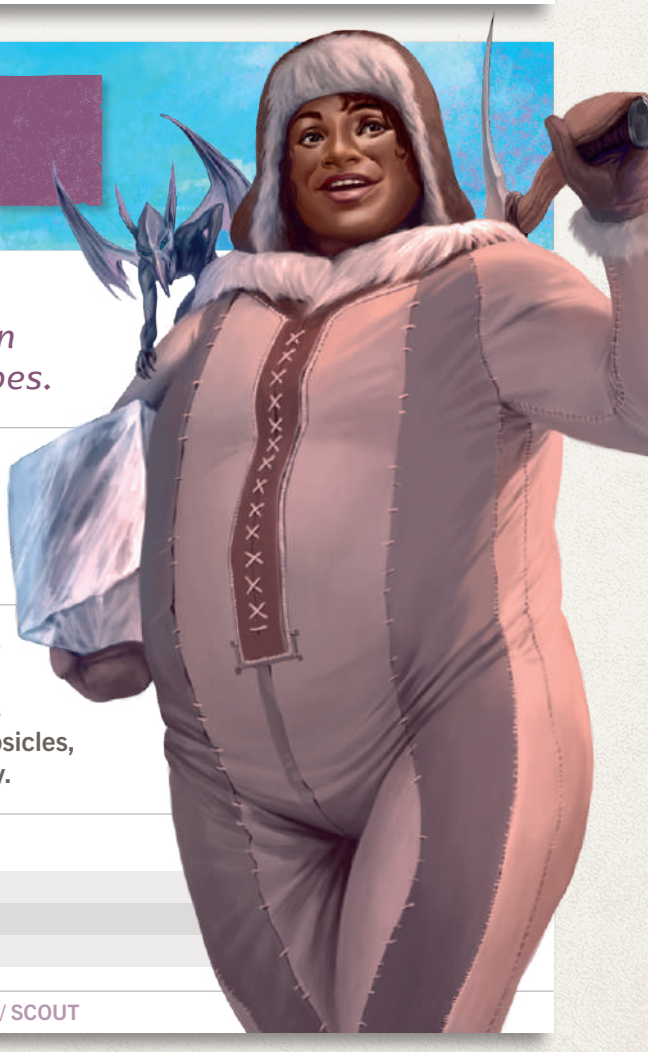
APPEARANCE When coiled and still, these reptiles look like snowy rocks. Blue blood slowly runs through their veins, their teeth are long and spine-like, and they breathe out cold air.

SECRET These basilisks were originally bred by a wizard to protect their icy lair, and were infused with frost magic. They escaped, multiplied and became a species of their own.

CREATURE • MEDIUM • NEUTRAL • MONSTROSITY

Clarys Glimmerfen

Travelling ice seller.



The merchant hops down from her wagon. She flashes you a grin, then claps her hands to shoo an impish creature off her glistening stacks of ice cubes.

KNOWN FOR Clarys hauls blocks of glacier ice to market, braving the frozen mountain roads. She's known for travelling with ice mephits, mischievous frost spirits most sellers avoid. But, Clarys values the mephits, as their chilly presence keeps her wares frozen for longer.

APPEARANCE A cosy, fur-lined jumpsuit and hat keeps Clarys snug on her long journeys. Her wagon is fitted with a music box, which plays a jaunty tune as she drives past.

GOAL Clarys currently sells ice to those wanting a safe way to store meat and fish. She wants to expand to sell flavoured popsicles, as she loves bringing others joy.

SECRET Clarys regularly swings by town so she can meet her crush. She always tries to time her route so they cross paths.

LOOT

- Music box
- Pickaxe
- Block of ice

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HUMAN • MERCHANT — COMMONER / SCOUT

Will these arctic-dwelling NPCs give your players a warm welcome, or a frosty reception?

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Chilbane

Cursed tundra wanderer.

KNOWN FOR This tall, humanoid-looking creature stalks the forests and peaks of the tundra. It watches its victims for days, before finally attacking them as they sleep.

APPEARANCE Chilbane has an elongated humanoid figure, which seems to be made of flesh and shadow. The only feature on its skin-wrapped face is a gaping, dribbling mouth.

SECRET Chilbane doesn't eat or kill its victims, it just gives them a bite then leaves them alone. Over the next few days, the victim starts to fade away, then no longer exists.

CREATURE • MEDIUM • HOSTILE • FIEND

Steren Argall

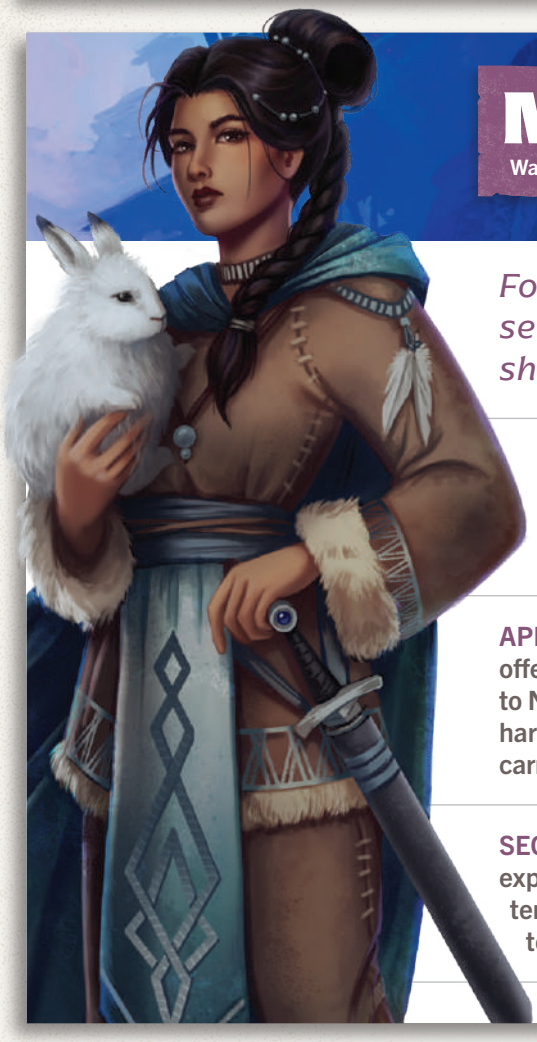
Perfectionist cartographer.

KNOWN FOR Steren is adamant that a rival's map of the geographic poles was created based on a false assumption. He has set off on an expedition to create his own map.

APPEARANCE Dressed for exploration, Steren wears a wool cap, a sweater under a canvas jacket and padded trousers. His thick mittens often make him fumble his compass.

SECRET Steren found his new, prized compass in the snow two months ago. The item is cursed, and is causing Steren's bitterness towards his rival and sudden bursts of anger.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • ELF-HUMAN • WAYFARER



Norne Rimesfolke

Warlock with ice powers.

For a moment, you sense her deep brown eyes searching your own for something more. The hare she carries twitches its nose with similar curiosity.

KNOWN FOR Since childhood, Norne has been granted magic through a bond with her region's celestial guardian. Folklore says that this magical patron has been hibernating, limiting the power it grants. With her village under threat, Norne wants to wake her patron and unlock new magic.

APPEARANCE A silken blue cloak offers a surprising amount of warmth to Norne and her ever-present arctic hare familiar, Selen. Norne also carries items that remind her of home.

GOAL Norne believes she could do more to protect her region and its people with greater magic. She is seeking out her patron, and wants to speak to them directly.

SECRET Norne may have a steely expression, but deep down she is terrified of her patron. She has been told stories of its almighty power.

LOOT

- Boots of the winterlands*
- Feather token (bird)*
- Silken blue cloak

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HUMAN • SPELLCASTER PRIEST / MAGE

Warriors of Winter's Way

Frost-disciplined monks.

KNOWN FOR These disciplined monks train in extreme cold. They submerge themselves in ice baths every morning, before spending hours out in the snow without thermal clothing to practise meditation and martial arts.

GOAL The monks pursue mastery over themselves and their environment through strong mental fortitude. Overcoming the freezing temperatures teaches them to take life slowly, and adapt to any situation.

FEATURE Winter's Way adepts wear wraps made of thick blue felt with white trim. Full warriors dress in white wraps with navy-blue trim. The order's elderly leader is the only one who wears pure white robes.

SECRET Through continued practice, Warriors of Winter's Way can harness the elemental energy of snow and ice and use it in combat. The exact channelling methods they use are a closely guarded secret.

FACTION • MEDIUM (20–49) • NEUTRAL • MILITARY

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The Scalewalkers

Arctic dragon hunters.

KNOWN FOR The Scalewalkers are a specialist group of monster hunters who cull the number of ice-powered dragons, wyverns and drakes in the region. They wear cold-resistant armour and use super-heated weapons.

GOAL This elite hunting group keeps the local draconic population low to make sure their settlements stay safe. They don't kill indiscriminately, and only target creatures who are violent or have encroached boundaries.

FEATURE The hunters wear white scale mail armour with horned helms and spiked gauntlets. Their armour is decorated with trinkets, gifts and good-luck charms given to them by the communities they protect.

SECRET Some members of the Scalewalkers have begun selling trophies from their hunts. The lucrative trade has upset other members of the group, but their arguments are kept private to keep a united front.

FACTION • MICRO (1–5) • FRIENDLY • MILITARY

Pyrrhos Everbronze

Fire elemental diplomat.

KNOWN FOR Pyrrhos is an azer diplomat who holds office in the arctic on behalf of her people. She has extensively studied the customs of frost giants and tundra dwellers.

APPEARANCE Pyrrhos resembles a molten bronze statue. Short, sparky flames flicker from her head, giving the look of a cropped hairstyle. She wears a riveted, metal corset.

SECRET After reading about the cold, Pyrrhos was eager to experience it for herself. It turns out she absolutely hates snow, but she cannot risk diplomatic tensions by saying so.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • ELEMENTAL • OFFICIAL

Blizzta and Druelle Nosebite

Hag siblings who lead travellers astray.

KNOWN FOR These spiteful hag siblings hunt in blizzards. They feast on disorientated travellers, draining their victims' life forces and leaving behind nothing but frozen husks.

APPEARANCE Blizzta and Druelle have pale, boil-covered skin and wear bloody goat hides. They shape-shift, posing as lost, shivering children begging for help to find their cabin.

SECRET The pair live in an ivory hut that is easily obscured during whiteout conditions. On closer inspection, their victims will see it is constructed from harvested bones.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • FEY • SPELLCASTER

More Arctic Characters

1. JAXI TUNUROTH Lonely off-season lodge caretaker.
2. HORST WILDWIND Unaware host to an aberration tadpole.
3. KULLER ORIOL Treasure hunter seeking an expedition team.
4. TRAFFORD LAGUNOV Ghost who died in an ice-fishing hole.
5. CALLY AFFLEST Charlatan tour guide who makes up history.
6. AGIF LUSKIG Prisoner escaped from an icy fortress.
7. CARETAKER X Sentient automaton tracking a lost child.
8. LORD NIMIA Bored merfolk, landlocked due to frozen seas.
9. STORVALD Frost giant hunting the beast that bit off their leg.
10. SISSYHITH Guardian naga waiting for an omen of change.

Runebreakers

Arctic guild of adventurers.

KNOWN FOR The Runebreakers is a guild of adventurers that welcomes anyone looking to prove their mettle and earn coin. Their current quest: find the lost city of Buar.

GOAL The guildmaster learnt ice tunnels to the east lead to the lost city, but the way is trapped and guarded by undead. The first adventurer to get to the city earns a promotion.

SECRET Equipment supplied is cheap and purchased in bulk. Weapon, armour, potions and tools taken from the Runebreakers stores may break or fail during an expedition.

FACTION • LARGE (50–99) • FRIENDLY • SOCIAL

Aeri Karpinnen

Weary traveller in search of aid.

KNOWN FOR Aeri runs supplies between his village and others in the region. He recently returned to find his home had suffered an awful wolf attack.

APPEARANCE Aeri wears thick pelts and furs that are matted with frost and ice. It is clear from the bags under his eyes that he's been travelling all night.

GOAL Riding his saddled reindeer, Aeri is racing to get urgent aid from a larger settlement miles away. He hopes the injured will survive until he returns.

SECRET The attackers were a pack of arctic werewolves. The next full moon will reveal many of the surviving villagers have been cursed with lycanthropy.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HUMAN • WAYFARER — COMMONER / SCOUT

Find inspiration for chilling ghost stories with the undead beings on pp. 192–193.

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CHAPTER 3

SETTLEMENTS AND COMMUNITIES

When a community gathers together, stories unfold. Build a city where the streets are filled with enough intrigue to inspire an entire campaign. Or, send your party travelling from town to town in the pursuit of their quest. Wherever they go, they'll need to learn to share the streets with influential local leaders, guards and gangs.

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Anukaran

Magical floating city in the sky.

Rolling hills and mountaintops pass below, as the enormous city you stand on effortlessly floats through the air. A cool breeze blows, whistling around the narrow towers above.

KNOWN FOR If you have an interest in arcane history, sorcery or magical artefacts, chances are you've heard stories about Anukaran. This floating metropolis is renowned for its groundbreaking research and magical innovation. Most of the spells used by wizards across the world today were either first conceived in Anukaran, or refined to perfection there, by the city's extraordinary wizarding scholars.

APPEARANCE Anukaran is a vast floating city. The 10-mile wide central island is surrounded by eight smaller airborne suburbs. Each island is packed with narrow spires, clocktowers, academies and terracotta-roofed homes – all adorned with gargoyles and fluttering flags. Residents dart between islands on flying carpets and brooms, creating a never-ending dance of colour and motion.

POPULATION Only a small part of Anukaran's population are wizards, sorcerers or scholars. Most citizens are magically awakened plants and sentient constructs, who now call the city their home.

LANDMARKS Each suburb island surrounding the central city is dedicated to a different magic school. Two of the most visited islands are the craggy Evocation Enclave and the narrow Illusion Ward.

SECRET The city forbids the practice of cloning. However, its leaders all have "back-up" clones of themselves stored in a hidden facility. Taxes pay for research and development into this outlawed technique.

LOCAL SERVICES

- Item enchantment
- Flying broom rentals
- Potion breweries
- Item identification
- Illusionist entertainment
- Spellcasting freelancers

SETTLEMENT • BUSY • NEUTRAL • ARCANE

Gildamerium

City with strict etiquette.

KNOWN FOR Many people apply to live in the picturesque utopia of Gildamerium. But, only a handful are accepted by the strict and exacting council after a series of interviews.

APPEARANCE The city's immaculate dwellings and civic buildings are set to a perfectly measured square grid. Each neighbourhood is pristine, and smells like fresh-cut grass.

SECRET Gildamerium, despite appearances, is anything but a utopia. The citizens live in fear of stringent council inspections, and can be banished if they do not comply.

SETTLEMENT • QUIET • NEUTRAL • RESIDENTIAL

Valcun's Hold

Isolated rebel city.

KNOWN FOR Years ago, this ramshackle city was exiled by the realm's ruling powers after declining to offer its citizens as war conscripts. Now, it's an anarchic haven for outlaws.

APPEARANCE Planks and steel panels form improvised shelters within the city's eroding walls. Older, nicer homes are claimed by those who can best defend them.

SECRET Basics like soap, candles and healing herbs are rare luxuries here due to scarcity and the city's isolation. They're traded at high prices in black market auctions.

SETTLEMENT • BUSY • HOSTILE • CRIMINAL

Your entire adventure could take place in one city state, or there could be multiple settlements in your realm.

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The Everweald

Remote city with odd traditions.

KNOWN FOR The Everweald is sometimes referred to as "The Everweird" by outsiders. Its reputation for frenzied festivals and bizarre rituals is widely known.

APPEARANCE The bulky buildings of The Everweald are generally one-storey tall. Animal bones, skulls and meat are nailed to the town's doors, following an ancient tradition.

SECRET Three gaunt, elderly hags have controlled the city as far back as records go. The coven siphon power from their adoring citizens through rituals to remain ageless.

SETTLEMENT • OVERCROWDED • HOSTILE • ARCANE

Oxenrock

Military mountain city.

KNOWN FOR This stone-carved city rests within an imposing mountain. Oxenrock sits on the border between two realms, and has been occupied by both throughout its history.

APPEARANCE A chiselled gate leads into the austere heart of the city, which spans nine layers of rock. Military officials run noisy drills, and war mammoths carry siege supplies.

SECRET Supposedly in a time of peace, Oxenrock's leaders are preparing for war. The city is running out of food, and its leaders aim to resolve the famine through conquest.

SETTLEMENT • BUSY • NEUTRAL • MILITARY

Port Nectar

Candy city created by a wish.

KNOWN FOR A child of the city's rulers once sneaked into Port Nectar's vaults to find new toys. They found an old lamp, and a genie within it. The child wished the city were made of candy, and the genie granted their wish.

APPEARANCE Gingerbread houses and fragrant lollipop trees line the marshmallow-cobbled streets. Citizens sit on the edges of caramel ponds and fish for gummies, while politicians squabble at the tops of liquorice towers.

LANDMARKS Port Nectar's leaders live in the Chocolate Palace at the settlement's gooey centre, accessible only through a candy-cane hedgerow maze. The Lemondrop Library and Toffee Teahouse are popular with tourists.

SECRET This year's candy parade could be cancelled. The usual organiser has fallen ill, but refuses to let anyone take over. The parade is a tradition in the city, and not having it would upset many who live there.

SETTLEMENT • BUSY • WELCOMING • ARCANE

Sotterraneo

Underground mining metropolis.

KNOWN FOR The underground city of Sotterraneo is famous for its grand mines. Most citizens work in the mining industry, and travel from place to place in the city's speedy, if rickety, cart-transit system.

APPEARANCE The people of Sotterraneo try to add splashes of colour to the crowded city streets with bunting and bright awnings. These inevitably get coated in a thick layer of inky black soot, which hangs in the air.

LANDMARKS The meandering and multi-layered streets are lined with cart tracks, which congregate in one of the many transit stations throughout the city. The carts link residential districts to the mines and quarries.

SECRET Sotterraneo's huge mines have been in use for generations, so much so, that they are becoming highly unstable. Safety concerns raised to the council have been ignored in favour of expansion plans.

SETTLEMENT • OVERCROWDED • NEUTRAL • INDUSTRIAL

Sanctum Opus

City with numerous temples.

KNOWN FOR Sanctum Opus is a sacred city for multiple faiths, and appears in many ancient holy texts. The city is full of chapels, shrines, temples and altars.

APPEARANCE The city's candle-lit temples come in lots of shapes and sizes. Winding stone streets lead past tall spires, domed roofs and ornate pillars.

LANDMARKS There are many sights in Sanctum Opus, but the stained glass of the Light Temple and the fire festivals in Casa Mori are a must-see for new visitors.

SECRET The dead are restless in the warren of catacombs below the city; an unintended side effect of the extensive divine magic used in Sanctum Opus.

SETTLEMENT • QUIET • WELCOMING • RELIGIOUS

Think about the hierarchy of settlements. Is there a capital city, and why was it chosen?

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Shroudkeep

Cursed, industrial metropolis.

Thick, acrid fumes from towering factories cling to the air and sting your throat. Cloaked figures in linen masks hurry past, boots splashing through puddles as relentless rain lashes the cobbled streets.

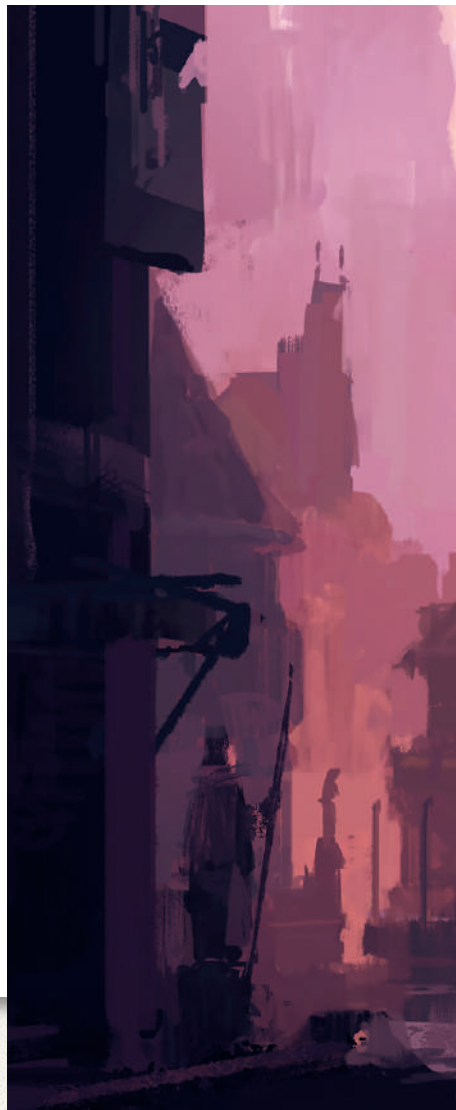
Key Stats	
Population	210,657
Density	High
Districts	Five
Economy	Stable
Main Export	Fabric
Main Import	Food
Technology	Average
Language	Common
Leadership	Council

KNOWN FOR Shroudkeep is famed for its fabrics and elegant fashions, which are exported far and wide. Beneath the glamour lies some dark truths: the city's appalling working conditions and an ongoing plague. The disease outbreak led to the removal of the city's religious leaders, giving rise to elite families and criminals who now run the city. These new powers built factories, pushed trade, and packed workers into industrial slums.

APPEARANCE Fog and smoke pervade the city streets. The settlement's position in a shallow basin surrounded by hills makes it almost impossible for the smog layer to disperse. Tall, rust-streaked iron buildings are closely crammed together and cast long shadows over the pavements below, which are often slick with rainwater or chemical waste. Arcane streetlamps are always on, and flicker with an unsettling purple light.

HISTORY Once a sacred city of priests and scholars, Shroudkeep's grandeur centred on a magnificent temple in the Old Town. However, as the city grew, its religious leaders grew pre-occupied with their own power and drifted from the old ways. After ignoring signs and prophecies, Shroudkeep was cursed by the gods. A plague swept through the city, killing swathes of the population. Religious orders were targeted by riots, and the grand temple is now abandoned and crumbling.

INHABITANTS Most of the city's residents work in the prolific fabric or garment workshops. This can include labour-intensive jobs such as bleaching or dying fabrics in harsh chemicals, operating heavy machinery, or loading up golem haulers. Those working in higher-paying roles, such as overseer, clerk or tailor, have completed lengthy apprenticeships and pricey qualifications. The city's wealth divide is visible in citizens' clothing, from factory workers in simple cotton, to administrators in fine silks.



LANDMARKS Shroudkeep's southern port provides vital trade and transport links to the wider country, and a cemetery to the north holds generations of plague victims. The city's western and southern quarters are dominated by industrial zones, with worker housing crammed into every gap. In contrast, the spacious east contains Shroudkeep's civic halls, decrepit temples and the mansions of its ruling families.

Villa Guillefort (right) is the home of one of Shroudkeep's most influential figures.

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The Districts of Shroudkeep

OLD TOWN The low, wooden buildings here are less cramped and imposing than elsewhere in the city. Weather-beaten statues honour the gods, rather than economic figureheads. A number of abandoned temples can be explored, although locals fear these derelict buildings are still haunted by souls who didn't receive a proper burial during the worst period of the plague.

CANALSIDE Warehouses, piers and dry docks line the waterway, along with narrow alleys and some unsavoury taverns. Pickpockets are common in this area.

SILK STREET This area hosts the city's wealthiest citizens, and is named after its most exclusive road. Its mansions and palatial homes are often gated. Entry to the upper echelons of Silk Street society is best achieved by securing an invitation to a fashionable evening soirée.

COTTON DISTRICT Bridging the gap between the Old Town and the luxury mansions of Silk Street is the relatively modern Cotton District. This area of Shroudkeep is home to fabric wholesalers, garment retailers, private offices and skilled tailors. The fashions made here are shipped to cities in this country and beyond.

THE HEMS The city's industrial quarter actually covers over half of the urban area. The Hems is the nickname given to the warren of residential streets that criss-cross between larger manufacturing facilities. Dust and fibres from the factories dance in the misty sky, further reducing visibility. The cheapest accommodation in the city is located in the Hems; simple offerings and haggard staff can be found in many inns and shops. The city's criminal gangs are also active here and they don't always take warmly to nosy new visitors.

SECRET The Guilleforts are one of the city's oldest and most powerful families. As well as shares in all the fabric companies, the family also controls political offices. The current patriarch, Elastair, was cursed with vampirism and has lived in the city for centuries under different aliases. His closest family members share his undead disposition, although occasionally mortals do marry into the family.

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Stoix

City divided by the four elements.

KNOWN FOR Founded by four elementals, Stoix is split into quadrants associated with fire, water, air and earth. Industries are found in their related districts; for example, stonemasons and carpenters in Terra Ward.

APPEARANCE Each district forms one quarter of a circle, with a shared central plaza. The architecture of each area is distinct, including abundant fountains and canals in Aqua Ward, and gothic buildings in Ignis Ward.

POPULATION When citizens turn 20, a ritual reveals their elemental alignment, a trait that normally runs in families. Stoixers can travel freely around the city, but are only allowed to live in their aligned quadrant.

SECRET A small, revolutionary group meets in the Aeris Ward. They wish to separate from the rest of Stoix, and build a new city in the sky. They are searching for magical ways to achieve this ambitious goal.

SETTLEMENT • BUSY • NEUTRAL • INDUSTRIAL

Grystone

Muddy, crime-ridden city.

KNOWN FOR Grystone is a makeshift wooden city built on the ruins of an older stone city that sunk into the swamp. Three criminal gangs feud openly for control of the streets.

APPEARANCE Mossy ruins slump into mud canals. Gang graffiti stains crumbling walls. Bosses rule from half-sunken manors, and citizens cower in their boarded-up homes.

SECRET A hidden fourth gang operates from the old city's forgotten sewers. They trade in secrets and sabotage, pulling the strings of the gangs squabbling above ground.

SETTLEMENT • OVERCROWDED • HOSTILE • CRIMINAL

Frivitopia

City in a carnival big top.

KNOWN FOR Frivitopia operates like a giant fairground. Flamboyantly costumed shop owners don't sell items, instead, they offer them as prizes for carnival-style games.

APPEARANCE Every inch of Frivitopia is festooned in bright lights and colours. A roller-coaster transit system and the mayor's huge helter-skelter office dominate the skyline.

SECRET Frivitopia runs on Frivcoins, a baffling currency that masks actual value. Tourists overspend, fuelling the economy, but may end up sweeping popcorn to pay off debts.

SETTLEMENT • BUSY • WELCOMING • ENTERTAINMENT

New Arcanum

Failed, rusted metropolis.

A half-built, spiralling metal frame stretches hundreds of feet into the sky. Panels have broken off in places and loose girders still swing from rusting chains.

KNOWN FOR New Arcanum was the dream of an ambitious architect: a city with arcane tech built into every facet of life. Construction began but was abandoned mid-project, due to safety concerns and skyrocketing costs. The current population moved in decades later to salvage scrap from the site.

APPEARANCE Rusting metal and peeling paint show the decay of the original city infrastructure. Newer buildings that have sprung up at its base are made from salvaged scrap.

POPULATION Families flocked to New Arcanum when high prices were offered for reclaimed magical material. Very few have made the fortunes that they were promised.

LANDMARKS Magic sparks around the spiralling metal frame. A usable, arcane elevator carries anyone bold enough to explore the ruins above.

SECRET The ageing architect still lives in the metal ruins as a hermit. They possess the original city plans and several prototype magic items.

SETTLEMENT • OVERCROWDED • NEUTRAL • ARCANE

Pick a mayor for your city from the characters on pp. 100–105.

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Eburnea

City famed for art and music.

KNOWN FOR Those passionate about music, art or other creative pursuits flock to Eburnea. They visit its world-class theatres and galleries, and study at its specialist colleges.

APPEARANCE White, limestone abodes are decorated by their owners with colourful murals and mosaics. Coiling gold spires mark amphitheatre entrances throughout the city.

SECRET Some artists in Eburnea will do anything to ensure their success. A shrewd dragon has been gaining power and influence by making deals with these desperate creators.

SETTLEMENT • BUSY • WELCOMING • ENTERTAINMENT

Deep Brinport

Underwater city in a glass globe.

KNOWN FOR Encased in a huge glass sphere, this city floats like a bubble in the ocean. It was built as a safe refuge when rising sea levels consumed the original city of Brinport.

APPEARANCE The sphere is anchored to the seabed by powerful tethering magic. An entrance portal at the city's base gives access for goods and visitors.

SECRET The structural integrity of the glass sphere has weakened over many decades. Arcane patches hold the water out for now, but leave the city vulnerable to attack.

SETTLEMENT • QUIET • NEUTRAL • ARCANE

Yamehe

Hillside city overlooking a jungle.

In the mist, it's hard to see where the city ends and the jungle begins. Distant animal howls echo, and colourful flocks of birds burst from the trees into the humid air.

KNOWN FOR The dense jungle surrounding Yamehe relentlessly encroaches on the city, bringing with it lurking predators, toxic spores and enormous vines capable of destroying building foundations. Over the course of the city's history, inhabitants have found ways to survive and remain vigilant.

APPEARANCE The city is built on a rocky hill overlooking thick forest. Both homes and watchtowers have arrow-slit windows and wooden spikes at their base to deter wildlife.

POPULATION While residents work hard to keep danger out of the city, they also respect the majesty of the natural world. Wanton destruction of the jungle is considered immoral.

LANDMARKS Yamahe's domed temples, pillared city hall and tall courthouse stand proudly at its summit, overlooking the city.

SECRET City elders speak of a hidden grove outside the walls where time flows differently. It was once used by druids to commune with jungle spirits.

SETTLEMENT • BUSY • HOSTILE • RURAL

Fivemarch

City on five busy trade routes.

KNOWN FOR Fivemarch sits at the intersection of a busy estuary and four major roads. A multitude of banks, markets and trade companies are based in this financial city hub.

APPEARANCE Deals are made in the palatial civic buildings and offices in the city centre. Meanwhile, goods are stored in crowded docks and warehouses on Fivemarch's outskirts.

SECRET Some council members believe Fivemarch should be an independent city state. These members have been amassing a private army and are planning a coup.

SETTLEMENT • OVERCROWDED • NEUTRAL • INDUSTRIAL

Valeria

Cursed city that never sleeps.

KNOWN FOR No one within the walls of this cursed city can get a wink of sleep. Visitors can leave to find rest, but residents must live in a perpetual state of exhaustion.

APPEARANCE Haggard citizens yawn as they shuffle along the city's cobbled streets. Buildings are dilapidated as residents don't have the energy to make necessary repairs.

SECRET The city was cursed 99 years ago by a petulant archfey, and the magic is weakening. Citizens who would have once died if they tried to leave, can now escape.

SETTLEMENT • BUSY • HOSTILE • ARCANE

What is the mood of your city? Are the people optimistic, mourning, fearful or angry?

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Ministry Municipia

Bewitched town council.

KNOWN FOR The Ministry has governed for years, but recent strange laws have raised suspicion. They banned wooden tools and made awnings on every building compulsory to increase shade throughout the settlement.

GOAL Members of the Ministry Municipia are elected to debate local matters and serve the town. Since meeting a mysterious stranger, however, they've begun voting in unanimous agreement on everything.

FEATURE Ministry members wear purple livery with gold details. All of them demonstrate slight sunlight sensitivity and have heavy bags under their eyes. They blame their tiredness on draining civic duties.

SECRET The Ministry met with a vampire who turned them all into its spawn. Each member is now compelled to do the vampire's bidding, including turning the town into a feeding ground for other undead.

FACTION • MICRO (1–5) • NEUTRAL • CIVIC

Captain Thorn Livingstone

War hero turned governor.

KNOWN FOR Thorn is a decorated war hero who entered local politics after retirement from the frontlines. He is very popular, and has won the three elections he has stood in.

APPEARANCE Thorn is a muscular, dark-skinned man with a firm handshake. He sports a buzz cut and wears his medals and leather armour, regardless of the occasion.

SECRET Though Thorn is legitimately popular with voters, his ambitious assistants have a major role in ensuring his success. They write all his speeches and plan his policies.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HUMAN • COMBATANT

Nessla McTarnish

Financially irresponsible mayor.

KNOWN FOR Nessla was elected because of her creative ideas. However, over-committing to dawn klaxons, rain collectors and a giant clock have drained the town coffers.

APPEARANCE Nessla is a short elf with thick, coppery hair that usually has several writing implements stuck in it. Her chubby cheeks are spattered with freckles.

SECRET Without question, Nessla agrees to any new ideas that her spoiled, darling daughter requests. Nessla would rather be bankrupt than let down Eelin, her pride and joy.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • ELF • OFFICIAL

Trinity Consortium

Dragons acquiring towns for profit.

Three women are engrossed in intense discussion. Each wears fine silks and accessories in different jewel shades: one ruby, one emerald and one onyx.

KNOWN FOR The Trinity Consortium is a powerful investment group that purchases debt-ridden towns from struggling councils. They treat their new communities as assets and quickly raise taxes, slash public services and install strict financial oversight — maximising returns for shareholders.

GOAL The Consortium's founders are all disguised dragons. They have teamed up to increase the value of their combined hoards through shrewd investments.

LEADERSHIP The Consortium only has three members: Zimara, Avorath and Vorgoth. They each have an equal vote in investment and management decisions.

FEATURE All public buildings in Consortium-owned settlements must display the company insignia, a dragon with three roaring heads.

SECRET One dragon wants to grow the group by accepting new board members. The Consortium has never been so divided on an issue.

FACTION • MICRO (1–5) • NEUTRAL • CIVIC

How are leaders selected in your homebrew world, and what responsibilities do they have?

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Lady Isolde Elyswood

Noble with a love of horses.

KNOWN FOR A respected noble responsible for acres of land, Lady Isolde is often seen on horseback. She gallops around her town, trains riders and leads countryside hunts.

APPEARANCE Lady Isolde is a petite, red tiefling. She is always ready to ride in boots, helmet and trousers. Her jacket features her horse-themed family coat of arms.

SECRET Lady Isolde lost her signet ring during a recent ride. Unable to authorise documents without it, she regularly retraces her route on horseback to recover it.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • TIEFLING • NOBLE

Snox Klackerwit

Accidental giant slayer turned mayor.

KNOWN FOR Snox was declared mayor after he appeared to slay a giant who had been terrorising the town. His fellow townsfolk are all in awe of his incredible, unexpected victory.

APPEARANCE Snox has bright blue scales and wears a ceremonial sash adorned with the words “giant slayer”. One of his sharp bottom teeth sticks out over his top lip.

SECRET The giant actually died from an allergic reaction to blueberry pie. Snox was meant to be on guard duty, and dropped a slice of pie when he was running away.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • DRAGONBORN • COMBATANT

Azren Zektan

Fierce warrior leader.

KNOWN FOR Azren seized power in his home town by killing his predecessor in a trial by combat. He rules with an iron fist, and will fight anyone who challenges him.

APPEARANCE Azren is a stoic, towering presence with skin as tough as frozen rock. His geometric tattoos represent the locations of battles he has fought in.

GOAL Azren wants the town’s population to be as strong and brutally competitive as he is. He insists on fighting contests to settle any civic matter, however small.

SECRET Azren’s older brother secretly poisoned an opponent in order to best him in combat. By Azren’s own rules, his brother should be executed for the deceit.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • GOLIATH • COMBATANT

BERKSERKER / GLADIATOR

The Longmires

Influential family with royal ties.

KNOWN FOR The self-important Longmires remind citizens of their royal ties. The family hosts grand parades celebrating themselves, emphasising their influence within the region.

GOAL They preserve their wealthy lifestyles by maintaining a royal reputation. Longmires adopt well-spoken accents to reinforce their noble image, but their speech sometimes slips.

SECRET The family’s royal bloodline traces to a disgraced, estranged branch descended from an illegitimate daughter. This fact is carefully hidden from their constituents.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • NEUTRAL • CIVIC

The Twin Councils

Dual governing committees.

KNOWN FOR Two councils maintain order. Curia Modesta handles minor infractions like unlicensed shops, while Curia Magna judges serious crimes such as murder or kidnapping.

GOAL The Twin Councils govern their town efficiently and impartially. They make sure daily court hearings start on the hour at midday, keeping order and stability in the town.

SECRET Many Curia Modesta judges treat their roles lightly. Some privately decide cases by flipping coins, undermining the supposed fairness of the minor infractions court system.

FACTION • MEDIUM (20–49) • NEUTRAL • CIVIC

Vespera Shadowmyst

Reclusive, clairvoyant leader.

KNOWN FOR This revered oracle lives alone beyond her settlement’s boundaries, and only travels into town when she has a grave warning to give. Although her arrival is an ill omen, Vespera’s word is law.

APPEARANCE Vespera is a young, bald dwarf who wears a dark cloak. She covers her eyes with a blindfold, but doesn’t seem to need any assistance in walking. Her cawing raven familiar sits on her shoulder.

GOAL Vespera was trained by her grandmother to use her gift of foresight to lead the local community. She was also taught to live separately from them, and not forge emotional connections.

SECRET Vespera has many visions, often about trivial matters in town. Through these divinations, she feels like she knows all the townsfolk well, but is aware they view her as an outsider. This can make her feel lonely.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • DWARF • SAGE

PRIEST / MAGE

Have the policies the current leaders put in place made them popular or hated among their people?

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Circle of Astromancy

Druidic leaders guided by the stars.

KNOWN FOR Locals have long looked to this druidic circle for wisdom and guidance. The druids use the movement of the moon, sun and stars to advise on community matters.

GOAL The Circle's weather forecasts and agricultural insights aim to boost local crop harvests. They lead through dedication, not ambition, and are trusted healers and sages.

SECRET The Circle has foreseen a devastating crop blight, but not told their community. Leaders are voting to decide whether to let nature take its course or try to prevent it.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • FRIENDLY • CIVIC

Court of Strings and Sinew

Fiendish council of manipulators.

KNOWN FOR The fiends of the Court of Strings and Sinew have used their manipulative powers to take control of the local council. Now, the citizens are their puppets.

GOAL The Court of Strings and Sinew issues rulings weekly, designed to spark conflict and fuel chaos. They will harvest souls from the unrest and violence they deliberately incite.

SECRET The bottom of the town's well connects to the Abyss. Destroying it will sever the fiends' link to their home realm, drain their power, and force them to flee.

FACTION • MICRO (1–5) • HOSTILE • CIVIC

Jacinde Starosta

Protective wizard overseer.

Lavender-scented air hums softly around Jacinde. Her staff glows faintly, and taps the floor every time she takes another calm and considered step forward.

KNOWN FOR Jacinde is widely respected as the community's de facto leader, thanks to her sage wisdom and powerful spellcraft. For years, she's protected the town with wards and magic. Her intelligence, calm nature and quiet strength have earned the trust of every grateful citizen.

APPEARANCE Jacinde dresses in elegant tailoring that accentuates her statuesque frame. Her spellbook and components are strapped to her belt, and she carries an heirloom staff.

GOAL Jacinde prioritises her town's safety above all else, and defends it from outside threats. As a renowned expert in defensive magic, she also writes seminal arcane textbooks.

SECRET Jacinde is running out of one of the spell components she uses for the town wards. She is desperate to secure more stock of ruby dust.

LOOT

- Ring of protection*
- Staff of the magi*
- Spellbook

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • ORC • SPELLCASTER — MAGE / ARCHMAGE

The Chroniclers

Council of elders who study the past.

KNOWN FOR The Chroniclers are respected elders who preserve ancestral tales. They pass stories down through spoken word, making sure important lessons are never lost.

GOAL The Chroniclers study history's patterns to guide their decisions. They correct and teach all citizens, no matter their age, using follies from the past to prevent new mistakes.

SECRET Some knowledge is too dangerous to share with the public, and is instead preserved confidentially. For example, every Chronicler becomes a weretiger on appointment.

FACTION • MICRO (1–5) • NEUTRAL • CIVIC

Eurig Trefor

Charismatic civic official.

KNOWN FOR Civic Officer Eurig Trefor thrives on politics and negotiation. He's loud, charismatic and especially enjoys the power and prestige involved in planning decisions.

APPEARANCE Eurig has shoulder-length black hair that he styles slicked back from his face. He wears a heavy gold chain of office over the top of his sandy beige robes.

SECRET Eurig just approved planning for a new guildhall on sacred ground. He's confident he can use his affable personality to smooth over any objections.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • HUMAN • OFFICIAL

Will the local leader see the party as a welcome resource or a nuisance?

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Sopheap Tkachuk

Councillor desperate to please.

KNOWN FOR Councillor Sopheap Tkachuk is amiable and polite, and goes to exaggerated lengths to please his constituents. He pays extra taxes out of his own pocket and does all the jobs no one else wants to do.

APPEARANCE Sopheap starts each day impeccably dressed in a green suit and mustard cravat. After long hours of solving problems, he returns home looking tired and dishevelled, often well past sunset.

GOAL Despising conflict, Sopheap always strives to find compromises that satisfy all parties. He patiently mediates neighbourly disputes, dedicating hours to brokering peace and preventing unnecessary arguments.

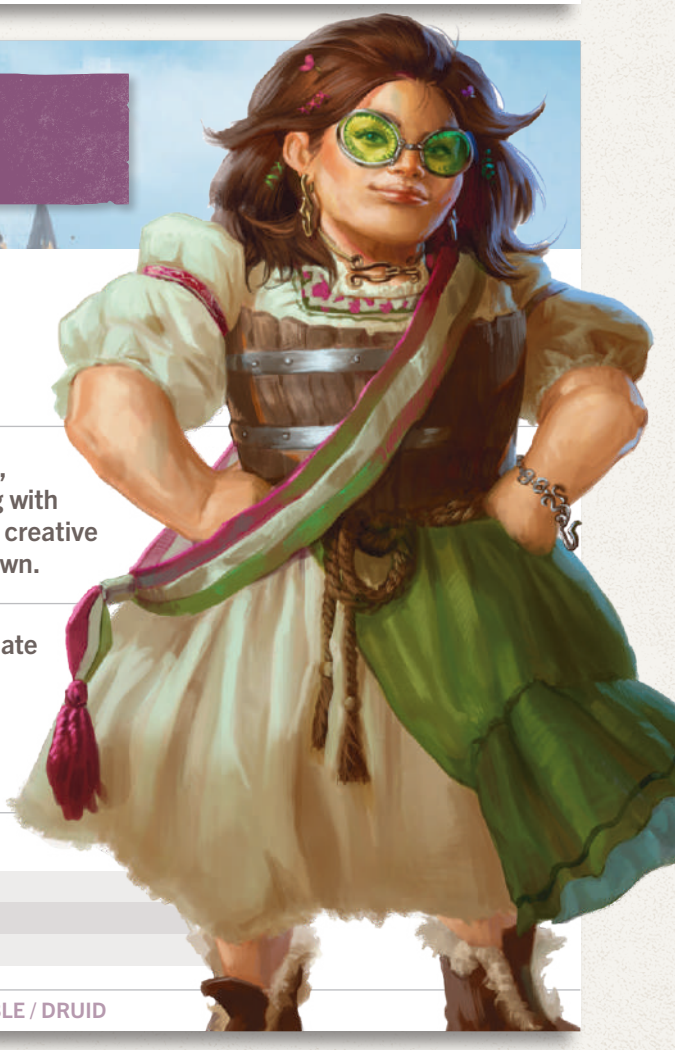
SECRET Constituents don't know Sopheap secretly performs as a masked bard at the local tavern to earn extra coin. After being scouted by a talent agent, he's seriously considering leaving politics.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HALFLING • OFFICIAL

COMMONER / PERFORMER

Wynna Amaranth

Resourceful, eco-conscious mayor.



Wynna's clothes are patched and sun-bleached. She rubs together her calloused hands and rolls up her cotton sleeves, ready to get to work.

KNOWN FOR Mayor Wynna is a cheerful and hard-working optimist, whose can-do attitude uplifts everyone around her. Despite working with a tight budget, she's determined to make every coin count. She finds creative ways to recycle discarded materials and reduce waste across the town.

APPEARANCE Wynna wears an old barrel breastplate, glasses from an old bottle, fishhook jewellery, a hand-me-down dress, rope belt, and boots she found on the road.

GOAL Wynna wants to eliminate waste and protect the local environment. She minimises production and champions seasonal, local farming.

SECRET Wynna secretly competes with a neighbouring mayor. When they see each other, the two bicker about whose town is more green.

LOOT

- Old barrel breastplate
- Mayoral sash
- Bag of beans*

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • DWARF • OFFICIAL

NOBLE / DRUID

Cybele Kallio

Monster-hunting mayor.

KNOWN FOR Once a travelling bounty hunter, Cybele defeated an aberration that was threatening the town and had killed the previous council dead. Desperate townsfolk turned to Cybele for continued leadership.

APPEARANCE Cybele wears tall boots, dark leather breeches and a field coat, with a white tiger's pelt draped over his shoulders. Cybele's chestnut hair is tied into a practical bun with a leather strap.

GOAL Cybele protects the town and its resources, teaching others to hunt and set traps. Though he longs for the freedom of travel, Cybele grudgingly remains to ensure the town's people survive against the wilderness.

SECRET Bitten during the battle with the aberration, Cybele now suffers blackouts and a painful, purple-veined infection. He hides these symptoms from the townsfolk as best he can.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • ELF-HUMAN • COMBATANT

KNIGHT / ABOLETH

You'll find more public officials, and the civic buildings they work in, on pp. 162–165.

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Austere Symposium

Council with a strict budget.

KNOWN FOR The Symposium holds a tight grip on public spending. It heavily taxes ale, reject frivolous spending on festivals, and imposes a curfew at dusk to make sure all citizens are accounted for at home.

GOAL The Austere Symposium makes sure its settlement generates a profit for its shareholders and stakeholders. Its strict tactics aren't popular with townsfolk, but any protests are quickly extinguished.

FEATURE Symposium councillors wear a tight-fitting, wine-coloured uniform with a coin brooch on the left of their chest. These coins show rank; bureaucrats wear copper and the directors wear platinum.

SECRET Council directors secretly use an enchanted amulet from the Shadow Realm to keep the town in check. Thick fog stops miserable citizens from leaving, and spectres enforce the Symposium's dusk curfew.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • HOSTILE • CIVIC

Darius Rhinohorn VI

Mayor who inherited the role.

KNOWN FOR Darius inherited the role of mayor after his tyrannical father died. For nine generations, leadership has always passed to the firstborn Rhinohorn child regardless of merit, popularity or the townsfolk's wishes.

APPEARANCE As tradition dictates, Darius wears the grey leather mantle passed down from mayor to mayor. His furrowed bronze brow and weary hazel eyes reveal the heavy toll of leadership.

GOAL No Rhinohorn wants to be remembered as the one who lost power. Darius hopes to restore public trust and leave a generous, charitable legacy that repairs the damage his selfish, dismissive father caused.

SECRET Darius recently found out his mother poisoned his father, so Darius could rise to power sooner. Though Darius has never confronted her, he has quietly begun distancing himself from his power-hungry family.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • GNOME • NOBLE

NOBLE / SPY

Willowbark Helmdew

Image-obsessed mayor.

A taller-than-average halfling walks towards you, his feathered hat swaying as he clip-clops on raised platform shoes. The rich perfume cloud that trails behind him smells of cinnamon and citrus.

KNOWN FOR Willowbark keeps his settlement in a near-constant state of celebration; its people are either preparing for a festival, revelling in one, or tidying up. Willowbark believes that happy citizens are voting citizens, and he intends to keep his position as mayor.

APPEARANCE Willowbark wears platform shoes that make up for his short stature. His bright tunic is almost as distracting as his laughter, which becomes even louder when chuckling at his own jokes. Willowbark's beard is styled, and his teeth are porcelain-white.

HISTORY In years passed, Willowbark was a local actor. He would listen to his troupe complain about the roads and taxes, and noticed that when he agreed with them they seemed to like him more. This sparked a chain reaction that eventually led him to run for mayor.

GOAL Willowbark grew up poor, but always believed he was destined for greatness. Now he basks in the mayoral spotlight, and clings to power obsessively. He is driven by ego and a deep need to prove he belongs at the top, no matter what it takes.

SECRET The ledgers in Willowbark's office tell a very different story than the one he sows to his citizens. He has driven the settlement into crippling debt, and there are many powerful people who are owed a lot of money.

LOOT

Cloak of billowing*	Perfume*
Gaming set (dice)*	Mayoral signet ring
Coin purse	Wand of pyrotechnics*

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HALFLING • ENTERTAINER

NOBLE / PIRATE CAPTAIN

Mayor Willowbark Helmdew (right) revels in the day's festivities, as townsfolk start preparing for tomorrow's.

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Sumista

Town at the top of a mesa.

KNOWN FOR The town of Sumista occupies the top of a narrow rock mesa. It is only accessible by a handful of rope bridges stretching to neighbouring plateaus, so townsfolk are used to providing for themselves.

APPEARANCE Sumista is built on a crescent-shaped rocky plinth. There are no handrails, and a sheer drop below. The town's low, flat-roofed buildings are made out of the same orange sandstone as the mesa itself.

POPULATION Residents survive on supplies carried across the bridges, or made on the mesa itself. Most food is delivered dry, held in storage, then rehydrated with carefully collected rainwater.

SECRET If local leaders suspect an invasion or threat, they can vote to drop the bridges and cut off the mesa. Sumista has enough provisions stored to survive in isolation for up to two years.

SETTLEMENT • QUIET • NEUTRAL • RURAL

Nastcrench

Town brainwashed by evil forces.

KNOWN FOR Visitors are rare in this remote lumber town, so no one has noticed that its people have been brainwashed. They now serve in the army of a despotic aberration.

APPEARANCE Empty homes have been stripped of glass and metal, allowing wind and rain through gaping windows. A new weapons forge fires day and night in the town square.

SECRET Businesses in nearby cities have noted delays in deliveries from Nastcrench. Some sent staff to investigate, but their representatives have not returned.

SETTLEMENT • QUIET • HOSTILE • RESIDENTIAL

Starwhim

Town with a large fey population.

KNOWN FOR Starwhim is built around a gateway to the Fey Realm. It is populated by fey beings wishing to experience the Material Plane, either as tourists or permanent residents.

APPEARANCE Starwhim's eclectic architecture mixes styles imported from the Fey Realm, with crude imitations of mortal designs. Fragrant flowers grow untamed throughout the town.

SECRET Mortals who spend two nights or more sleeping in Starwhim are magically bound to stay. However, they are only told about this curious law once it is too late.

SETTLEMENT • BUSY • WELCOMING • ARCANE

Gossamer Spindle

Town spun from spider silk.

It's a wondrous sight: silken structures hang in the sky like silent spirits, reflecting the dim glow of the sun. Delicate strands brush your face in a soft caress.

KNOWN FOR Nestled in an area of forest teeming with spider species, the town known as Gossamer Spindle is a true extension of its environment. Humanoid residents live peacefully alongside their eight-legged neighbours, treating the spiders' webs as respectfully as they do each other's homes.

APPEARANCE Locals bind branches for roofs and spiders weave webs to fill the gaps. The town's thick canopy blocks most sunlight. Fungi and ferns thrive in the damp, dark undergrowth.

POPULATION Most townsfolk descend from drow or drider ancestors, and wear dark, spider silk clothing. Visitors who fear spiders tend to leave quickly.

LANDMARKS The tallest silk spire belongs to the town temple. Clerics view spiders as divine messengers and search for symbolism in their webs.

SECRET Beneath the town lies a labyrinthine nest where a giant, powerful spider rests. They speak to their favoured chosen in visions.

SETTLEMENT • QUIET • NEUTRAL • RESIDENTIAL

Fill your town with residents from pp. 231–235.

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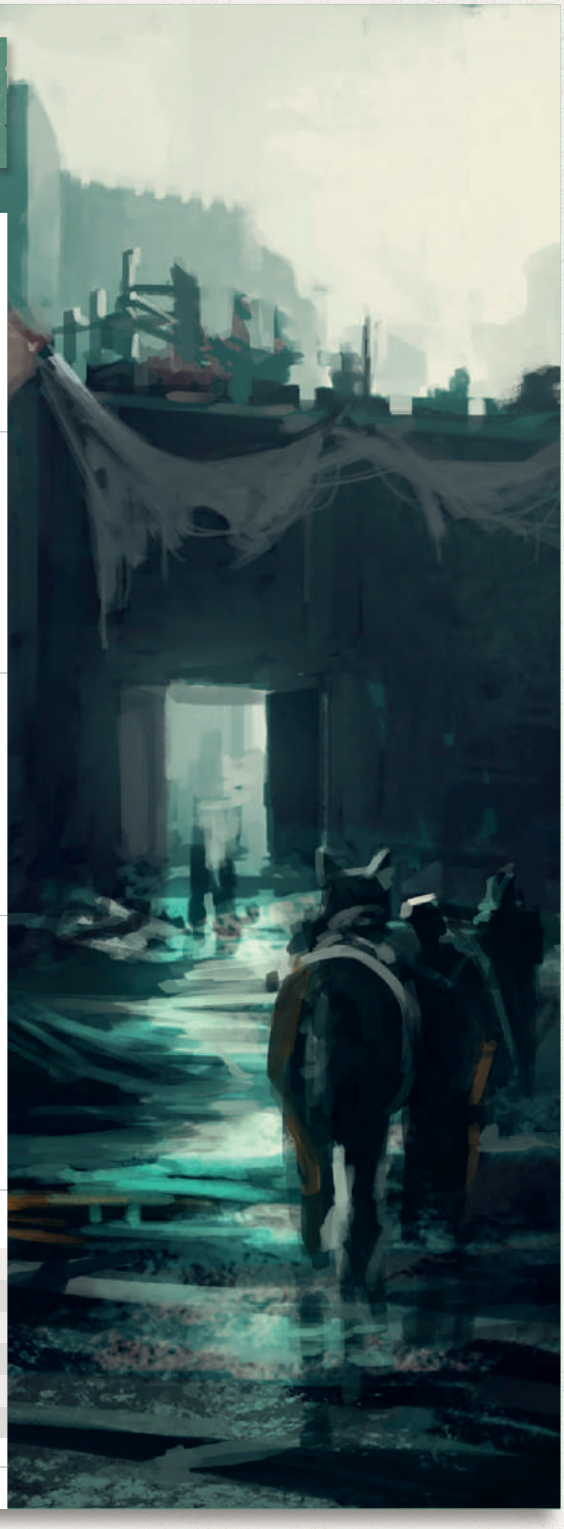
Whitetower

Declining, war-stricken town.



The structure in front of you is more intact than those around it, but is still half-destroyed. Bedraggled locals sift through the rubble, looking for anything they can salvage.

KNOWN FOR Once a thriving hub of commerce, Whitetower was devastated by a recent war that reversed decades of investment. Though technically on the winning side, the town lost everything. Now in ruin, its people shelter in damaged buildings and survive on foraged scraps or charitable aid. External trade has all but stopped and the town clings to life, while battling hunger and hopelessness.

APPEARANCE Smoke from torches and bonfires fills the grey, dust-choked air. Rubble clogs the streets, and faded war banners hang from shattered battlements and makeshift barricades. Every surface is marked by ash and soot. Whitetower feels eerily quiet and too empty for its size. Its wooden gates and portcullis lie open, not to welcome outsiders, but torn off their hinges during the conflict.

POPULATION Most fled during the war, and those who stayed suffered greatly. Survivors look weary, and avoid outsiders. Though morale in town is low, small groups have begun quietly working together to rebuild.

LANDMARKS The civic tower that gave the town its name lies in ruins. Its white stone is blackened by fire, and its fallen spire rests in a crater nearby. Locals gather at its foundations to trade meagre supplies.

SECRET A secret cache of supplies was hidden in a bunker by a noble who died during the war. If found, it will be enough to see Whitetower through the winter, provided it is able to be rationed out fairly.

LOCAL SERVICES

- Salvage yard
- Medic tent
- Community soup kitchen
- Bartering post
- Stonemasons' guild
- Stable

SETTLEMENT • QUIET • HOSTILE • INDUSTRIAL

Direditch

Backwater gambling town.

KNOWN FOR Direditch was forgotten about when county borders were drawn. With no official oversight, casinos have flourished and become the town's main economy.

APPEARANCE A muddy creek runs along the northern edge of town. Buildings are raised on stilts above the flood-prone marshes, but can't dodge the pervasive smell of damp.

SECRET Some casinos hold secret after-dark games for the dead. Spirits with unfinished business gamble away their last possessions, and try to make up for their deepest regrets.

SETTLEMENT • OVERCROWDED • HOSTILE • ENTERTAINMENT

Loufbrey

Circular arena town.

KNOWN FOR Loufbrey residents compete in public fights for the right to live in the best parts of town. Champions train hard to retain their position against regular challengers.

APPEARANCE Homes are built in six concentric rings, with the grandest mansions in the centre and ramshackle huts on the perimeter. Fences restrict access between the rings.

SECRET Recent illness in the "Champion's Circle" was linked to specific water fountains. A hushed inquiry has been ordered into related claims of sabotage and match fixing.

SETTLEMENT • BUSY • HOSTILE • RESIDENTIAL

Give your citizens specific jobs that match your town, to help it feel lived in and alive.

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Haystock

Idyllic town famous for dairy products.

A steady stream of carts flows in and out of town, rattling along simple track roads. On either side, cows graze on fields of dense yellow grass, like a thick layer of butter has been spread on the earth.

Key Stats

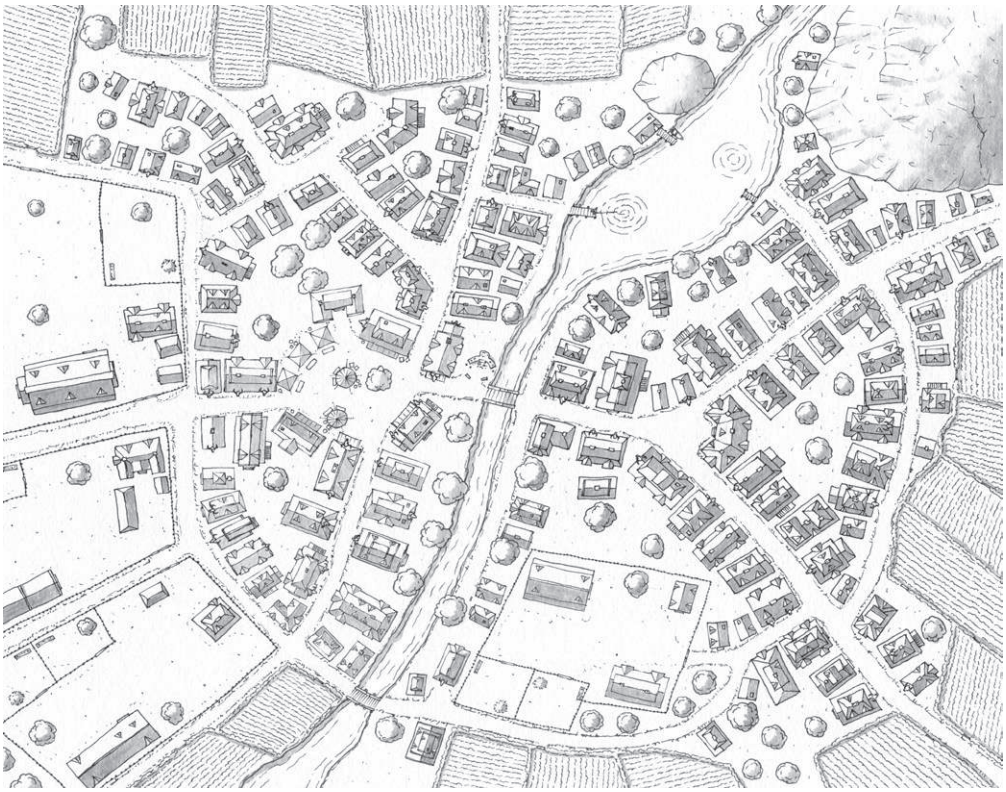
Population	1,435
Density	Low
Districts	Four
Economy	Booming
Main Export	Dairy produce
Main Import	Stone
Technology	Low
Language	Common
Leadership	Mayor

KNOWN FOR This idyllic farming town is flourishing, after gaining a reputation for high-quality dairy goods. Haystock prides itself not only on its fine produce, but also exceptional animal welfare. Cows, goats and sheep roam freely around the town. Although good-natured, the animals can slow down travel and deposit unwanted pungent droppings. Local citizens are used to this though, and barely notice any smell or inconvenience.

APPEARANCE Despite its booming economy, Haystock has retained the humble architectural style of its farming roots. Muddy dirt roads run from sprawling farm ranches into a bustling market square. Tourists are charmed by its clusters of grey stone buildings, and roof finials inspired by cow horns. The town's muted masonry is contrasted by golden fields of sweet-smelling grasses and grains, and sparkling blue river waters.

HISTORY Once a small riverside hamlet known as Barnbrook, Haystock was renamed in honour of the local farmer who brought the town fame. When a passing merchants' guild tasted the frothy, creamy milk Helda Haystock sold from her small homestead, they became obsessed. They brought her milk to nearby towns and business boomed. The hamlet quickly grew into a hotspot for dairy production and commerce, and tourists flocked to visit Helda's famous farm.

INHABITANTS Nearly all Haystock's citizens work on a dairy farm, where wages are good and staff are generally upbeat. There are also plentiful jobs in smaller support industries, whether that's as a wagon driver, manure collector, or one of the glassblowers who make Haystock's distinctive spherical milk bottles. Tourism is another growing source of income. Visitors should beware of the "Haystock Haggle" when shopping, as traders often up their prices if they spot an out-of-towner.



LANDMARKS The central market is a must-see; visitors can purchase all the cow-related merchandise they can dream of, as well as fresh milk and salty cheeses. Most of the town's industries operate near the market, with farms scattered around its outskirts. To the west of town is the historic Haystock Ranch, where tourists can walk through Helda's old farm, sample her famous produce and experience a bygone time.

The yellow grasses and leaves of Haystock (right) make it a scenic destination.

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Things to do in Haystock

MILKING CONTESTS Farmers regularly host open days, where townsfolk can make some extra coin by milking cattle. Turning ranch activities into competitions or races is a tradition enjoyed by both children and adults.

CALVING FESTIVAL This beloved celebration takes place as soon as the first calf is born each spring. It's a festival of feasting and thanksgiving for new life. The young cow is wreathed with flowers and paraded through the market square. Townsfolk then bid for the right to name the calf, with the highest bidder getting the honour.

BLESSING THE HERD Near the river bridge, there is a small candlelit shrine. It's commonplace in Haystock to throw a couple of coins into the shrine before crossing the bridge, to bless the cattle, and bring ranchers good harvests and fortune. There are images and carvings in the shrine of most major deities. The money is collected by the shrine's keeper, and is put towards ongoing bridge repairs and maintenance.

CHEESE MARKET Once a week, the market square is transformed into a cheese-lovers paradise. Artisan cheesemongers sell their wares alongside hot food stands offering melted treats. Local bards play live music throughout the day and set up a stage for dancing.

CATCH CINDYBELL Haystock is famous for its grazing animals, but one goat is more famous than the rest. Cindybell's broken horn and curly coat are easy to spot, but catching her isn't so straightforward. Cindybell is known for her quick running speed, agility and death-defying leaps from roofs, cliffsides and riverbanks. She is so difficult to catch, in fact, that anyone who brings her to the town hall gets a monetary prize.

SECRET Many dairy brands operate within the town, but the Helda Haystock brand is the market leader. The milk produced by this historic ranch is shaken after collection to create a creamy, frothy texture, then a small amount of molasses is added to give it that trademark taste. Helda's exact recipe has been kept secret for generations, and is now protected by her great-grandchildren.

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Rosemont

Town of peaceful zombies.

KNOWN FOR A failed necromantic spell created a graveyard full of zombies with no appetite for violence. These undead citizens built Rosemont so they could live in peace, away from angry mortals and their pitchforks.

APPEARANCE Meandering paths weave past crooked stone buildings, where neighbours chat amiably and tend to their gardens. Fragrant rose bushes are planted everywhere to mask the ripe stench of death and decay.

POPULATION Rosemont zombies are uncommonly intelligent and gentle for undead creatures. They live out a suburban existence, shuffling to and from work, and occasionally groaning about the weather.

SECRET A living human has been masquerading as a zombie to take advantage of the slow lifestyle and low cost of living in Rosemont. Most of their neighbours have realised, but are too polite to comment.

SETTLEMENT • QUIET • WELCOMING • ARCANE

Unterveil

Town lost to shadow.

Vines have almost entirely consumed the abandoned, derelict buildings. The dying light casts long shadows, which seem to stretch and contort before your eyes.

KNOWN FOR The town of Unterveil was seized by a malevolent extraplanar entity who transported the townsfolk to a dark replica of the settlement in the Shadow Realm. Now, only silent, lurking shadows remain. Anyone who gazes for too long at the shadows is dragged away, and suffers the same terrible fate.

APPEARANCE Unterveil's ruined wooden buildings are choked by ivy. Shadows move strangely, warping and shivering, and stay in fixed positions throughout the day.

POPULATION The townsfolk now dwell in a dark mirror of Unterveil. Only watchful shadows remain, lurking just beyond sight, at the edges of any unlucky visitor's vision.

LANDMARKS A hooded statue stands in the town square, untouched by ivy and the weather. It stays pristine while everything else crumbles around it.

SECRET The statue depicts the extraplanar entity. Through it, the being watches the town. Its head sometimes turns to follow visitors.

SETTLEMENT • QUIET • HOSTILE • ARCANE

Hijo De Fuego

Elemental town with lava canals.

KNOWN FOR The elementals native to Hijo De Fuego can navigate the town's lava canals with ease. Visitors are ferried on robust, stone-carved gondolas to avoid burns.

APPEARANCE One main lava canal runs through the town, splitting into smaller tributary side paths. Structures are built right on the lava's edge, with molten rock walkways.

SECRET At the bottom of the lava canal lies a sealed gate to the Elemental Plane of Fire. The gate can only be opened by a key that the town's ruling council have safely hidden away.

SETTLEMENT • BUSY • NEUTRAL • RURAL

More Towns

1. **ARCTON** Struggling town that is kept in an artificial winter.
2. **BERXLEY** Marsh settlement regularly cut off by the tides.
3. **EASTHOME** Townsfolk vote on where this tent town travels.
4. **AVAMOOR** Treetop settlement connected by rope bridges.
5. **TAUR MINOR** Built in an old abandoned labyrinth.
6. **BLEAKBURN** Continually destroyed by dragons and rebuilt.
7. **LANDOW** Ghosts reside peacefully amongst living residents.
8. **ATARATUS** Town where an ancient language is still spoken.
9. **ORILO** Houses are raised on stilts to avoid the swamp below.
10. **CRAYDOME** Shrunk to fit inside a sorcerer's snowglobe.

What amenities does your town have? Have a few venues prepared for your party to explore.

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Covehold

Unpopular port town.

KNOWN FOR Deserted year-round, Covehold is a haven for pirates during storm season. Their presence brings chaos and trouble whenever the winds blow them into port.

APPEARANCE Jetties float in a sheltered bay, ringed by the town's rustic wooden buildings. Inside, worn and dusty furniture shows its age with countless patchwork repairs.

SECRET Crews secretly mark their favourite lodgings with flags. If a rival crew trespasses, swashbuckling duels and fights to the death erupt and can escalate quickly.

SETTLEMENT • QUIET • HOSTILE • INDUSTRIAL

Wobblewise Spire

Huge library that functions as a town.

KNOWN FOR Once a library tower, Wobblewise is now a town within a library. Visiting academics were so reluctant to leave the archives, local amenities came to them instead.

APPEARANCE A huge central spire holds books and texts. Additional turrets and annexes have rooms for staff and visitors, supply shops, a post office, stables and two taverns.

SECRET The mayor hasn't been seen in weeks. Residents assume their leader must just be busy, but the mayor has actually been imprisoned in a basement by an angry scholar.

SETTLEMENT • OVERCROWDED • WELCOMING • ACADEMIC

Tilhausen

Town made famous by a mage.

The air rings with magic; distant bells chime without wind. The tiered town's cobblestones pulse faintly beneath you, as you wait for a lift to the second level.

KNOWN FOR Centuries ago, Tilhausen flourished under a legendary illusionist whose magic rapidly improved the town. The vibrant illusions faded and the town declined after the mage's death. Recently, a new generation of mages has begun restoring Tilhausen's magical buildings, drawing back tourists.

APPEARANCE The mage's colossal castle still towers above the town. Magical hands lift citizens between levels, and conjured guides offer directions and assistance.

POPULATION Only a few elderly residents remember life under the mage. The town's legacy lives on through stories, shared in regular puppet shows and re-enactments.

LANDMARKS The mage's castle opens to the public once a year on his birthday. The home where the mage was born is fenced off.

SECRET The mage was buried on the outskirts of Tilhausen in a simple grave. His descendants quietly maintain the secret site.

SETTLEMENT • BUSY • WELCOMING • ARCANE

Arcadian

Mercantile town on a bridge.

KNOWN FOR Merchants built shops and inns along the lengthy Arcadian bridge to cater to travellers. Homes and other businesses soon followed, creating a busy town.

APPEARANCE The bridge consists of two thoroughfares, both lined with multistorey buildings. Spare stock is hung in rope nets on the sides of the bridge to maximise space.

SECRET The central row of buildings gets the most traffic, making this area prime real estate. Shop owners secretly bribe town officials to secure favourable leases.

SETTLEMENT • OVERCROWDED • NEUTRAL • INDUSTRIAL

Fumber

Small town for big people.

KNOWN FOR Fumber is a charming port town built for giants. For smaller folk, life is a constant challenge; they daily navigate oversized doors, furniture and towering buildings.

APPEARANCE By giant standards, Fumber is a small and cosy town. Homes have sloped roofs with multicoloured shingles, and the gardens are filled with bright sunflowers.

SECRET The mayor of Fumber wears a magical cape that enlarges them to the size of a giant. Without the garment, they are an elf who is just under five feet tall.

SETTLEMENT • QUIET • WELCOMING • RESIDENTIAL

Every fantasy town needs a tavern! Find yours on pp. 128–133.

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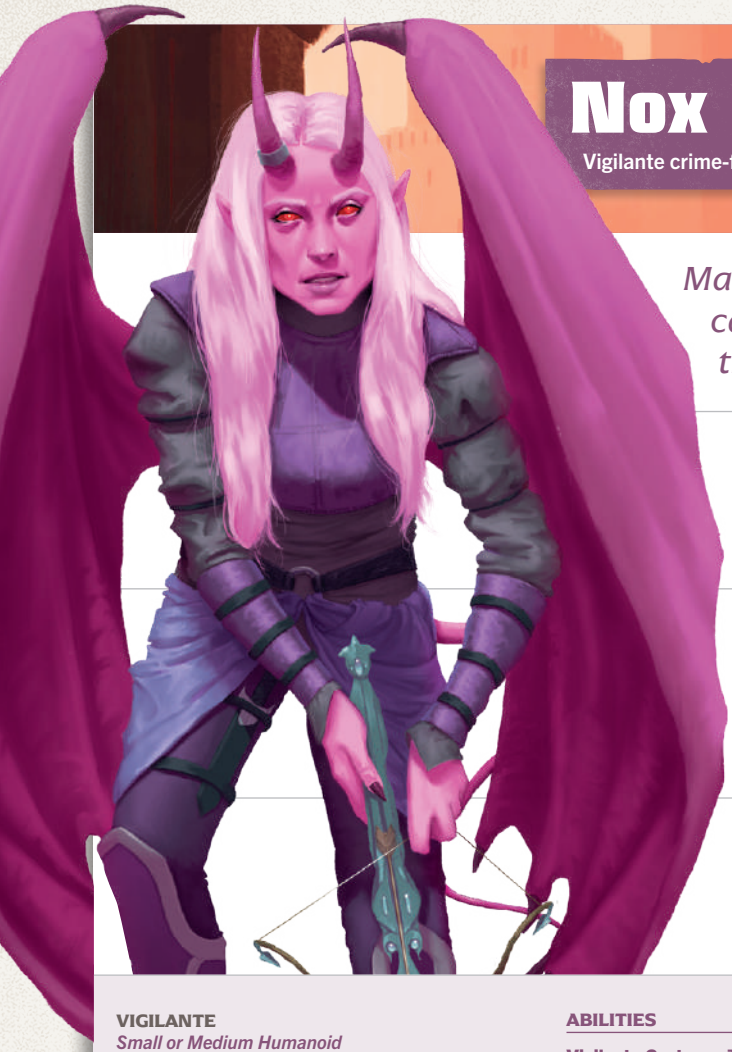

Nox Nightwringer

Vigilante crime-fighter.

Magenta wings unfurl with the barest of noises, casting dark shadows. Moonlight glints off the figure's loaded, silver crossbow.

KNOWN FOR Nox is a succubus, so can fly, easily influence people, and shape-shift. Her complicated moral compass led Nox to use these powers as a vigilante, targeting dangerous criminals. She has an uneasy truce with the town authorities.

APPEARANCE Nox wears dark armour to blend with the night sky. When she isn't shape-shifting, she has bright pink skin and flowing lilac hair.

GOAL Nox keeps her town safe, and has zero tolerance for crime. She feeds on the criminals she apprehends to boost her fiendish powers.

SECRET By day, Nox disguises herself as an apothecary. Her access to potions and poisons aids her vigilante work.

LOOT

- Hand crossbow*
- Dust of disappearance*
- Dagger*

VIGILANTE
Small or Medium Humanoid

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
8 (-1)	16 (+3)	13 (+1)	12 (+1)	19 (+4)	17 (+3)

Armour Class: 14
Hit Points: 75 (15d8 + 15)
Speed: 35 ft, climb 20 ft
Initiative: +3

Saving Throws: DEX +6, WIS +7
Immunities: Frightened
Skills: Acrobatics +6, Insight +7, Perception +7, Stealth +9
Passive Perception: 17
Languages: Common plus one other language
Proficiency Bonus: +3

ABILITIES

Vigilante Costume. The vigilante can spend 1 minute to don their costume, changing their look as per the *Disguise Self* spell. Anyone studying the vigilante up close can discover their true identity by succeeding on a DC 15 Investigation check. The vigilante can spend 1 minute to take off their costume.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The vigilante makes two Iconic Blade or Trademark Crossbow attacks.

Iconic Blade. Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft, one target. Hit: 13 (3d8 + 1) piercing damage and the vigilante has advantage on the next attack roll it makes before the end of this turn.

Trademark Crossbow. Ranged Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 80/320 ft, one target. Hit: 12 (2d10 + 1) piercing damage.

REACTIONS

Parry. Trigger: The vigilante is hit by a melee attack roll while holding a weapon. Response: the vigilante adds 3 to its AC against that attack.

CHALLENGE RATING 5

You could alternatively use the stats of a Bandit Captain CR 2, Pirate Captain CR 6 or Assassin CR 8.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • FIEND • COMBATANT

Autofrank Prime

Sentient automaton guard.

KNOWN FOR Autofrank Prime is a sentient guard golem prototype created by artificers. He rigidly follows his original command to protect the town, and patrols the settlement's perimeter once at dawn and once at dusk.

APPEARANCE Shining gold armour houses Autofrank Prime's magical core, which grants him sentience. His helm lifts to show a metal faceplate with a childlike, smiling expression drawn crudely on it.

GOAL Autofrank Prime defends his town without question. He strives for absolute perfection in his duties, but often causes trouble by misjudging threats or interrupting harmless activities like busking or building.

SECRET Recent magical updates have sparked deeper emotions in Autofrank Prime. He is still obedient, although sometimes experiences guilt or confusion when carrying out his standard guard programming.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • CONSTRUCT • GUARD

ANIMATED ARMOUR / SHIELD GUARDIAN

How strict is law and order in your homebrew world? What happens if your party break the rules?

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Woolguard

Town guard volunteer group.

KNOWN FOR Woolguard members maintain a regular watch over their sleepy village. Their monthly training often results in bruises and accidents through lack of weapon experience.

GOAL Armed with sharp sticks and good intentions, the volunteer group works to protect local families. They safely assume the lack of local crime is a sign of their success.

SECRET The members of the Woolguard take counsel from an anxious, awakened sheep who believes a flock can never be too careful in a world full of wolves.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • FRIENDLY • MILITARY

Eggron Jaxi

Lonely beacon keeper.

KNOWN FOR Eggron is the lone warden at a remote outpost. He is tasked with spotting threats and lighting the signal beacon should danger approach from the wilderness.

APPEARANCE Eggron keeps a clean uniform, short hair and shaven face. He maintains discipline, despite only seeing others during rare resupplies and even rarer inspections.

SECRET He accepted the remote, five-year assignment after suffering a romantic heartbreak. Now, he sorely misses his home and is desperate for a letter from his former love.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • DRAGONBORN • GUARD

More Town Guards

1. HALI KELLACK Overzealously reports on every little detail.
2. XORNISLOV MANANA Indulges in too many snack breaks.
3. THEODARD VOSS Elder guard with many words of wisdom.
4. TOYNI RYUSSO Overworked second-in-command captain.
5. ALVARUS TOLJAV High ranking officer who likes to gamble.
6. FEREN COLOMBERA Incompetent recruit on final notice.
7. ROTHGAR MIRKWOOD Veteran who can't wait to retire.
8. MERTIJN DREKS Reckless watchman who ignores the law.
9. NEMISA CULCHARNY Whistleblower in a corrupt guard unit.
10. EUNOMI ZIETAK Wears a shiny uniform and polished boots.

Sentinels

No-nonsense city protectors.

KNOWN FOR This strict group of law enforcement agents patrols the streets, enforces curfews and imposes order. The Sentinels dish out harsh and immediate punishments.

GOAL The overseer of the Sentinels has a vision for a city where no laws are ever broken. The group employs severe methods to scare the population into compliance.

SECRET The agency includes a covert mage division that uses arcane surveillance to uncover plots. Sentinels will happily punish people before a crime has even occurred.

FACTION • LARGE (50–99) • HOSTILE • MILITARY

Strike Wardens

Town guards trained in martial arts.

Out of nowhere, a figure lands deftly on the ground in front of you and assumes a defensive stance. They raise a hand to stop your passage onward.

KNOWN FOR Trained in unarmed and unarmoured combat, the Strike Wardens don't need weapons to keep order. They patrol rooftops silently, using stealth and surprise to subdue criminals with efficient fighting techniques. Their constant presence is both respected and feared.

GOAL Wardens focus on non-lethal justice. They favour rehabilitation over punishment and proudly recruit reformed offenders, giving them niche insights into the city's criminal scene.

LEADERSHIP The Strike Wardens were founded by a mercenary, who saw a way to keep the peace without the use of deadly force. He still vets all new recruits personally.

FEATURE Strike Wardens wear loose linen tunics with the city crest on. They wear no armour, just supportive leather bracers and reinforced boots.

SECRET The group secretly funds an orphanage with confiscated gold. It offers the city's children shelter, and a chance at a better future.

FACTION • LARGE (50–99) • NEUTRAL • MILITARY

Guards handing out fines and prison sentences make a fantasy settlement feel more grounded.

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Rebel Raptors

Poachers and fur traders.

KNOWN FOR Rebel Raptors are poachers who hunt in protected parks, sacred groves and noble estates. They kill rare animals, then sell the furs, meat and other harvested parts on the black market.

GOAL The Raptors are driven by profit and sell to the highest bidder. For extra coin, they can also smuggle live beasts to collectors, alchemists or nobles who have special interests or requirements.

FEATURE Each Raptor goes by a bird of prey nickname and has a matching claw tattoo. All members can mimic bird calls, using them as a coded language to signal danger or mark meeting points.

SECRET Several official groundskeepers are secretly paid by the Rebel Raptors. These informants share guard rotations, trap locations and ideal hunting windows, allowing the group to evade capture time and again.

FACTION • MEDIUM (20–49) • HOSTILE • CRIMINAL

Knights of Fortune

Anonymous gambling ring.

The sharp clang of metal fills the room as knights serve drinks, roll dice and lay cards. Their well-polished armour shines, reflecting the freshly collected coins taken from excited patrons.

KNOWN FOR After being banished from court, a disgraced knight realised that their heraldic plate armour still commanded respect among criminals. They founded a gambling ring, dressing themselves and their new gang in armour to keep their real identities a secret. Nobles and townsfolk alike attend the Knights of Fortune's popular anonymous gaming nights in taverns across the land.

GOAL The Knights of Fortune front as a travelling casino, but are an illegal gambling ring aimed at draining customers' wealth. They run two to three events in different towns every night – encouraging high-stakes gambling, and offering easy-to-obtain loans to keep players betting all night long. Those who cannot repay debts face threats of violence or crippling interest rates.

FEATURE All members wear full suits of armour with visors closed for complete anonymity. Junior staff wear silver, captains gold, and the founder dons distinctive platinum to mark their high status within the gang.

LEADERSHIP The Knights' founder leaves the day-to-day running of the gang to captains. Each captain oversees a small group of staff, and is trusted to handle unruly customers or prying town guards.

SECRET In the early days, the founder violently eliminated dissent to regain control of the gang. Knights of Fortune are warned never to mention this dark past; anyone who does faces severe consequences.

KEY MEMBERS

Sir Chance – Unscrupulous knight founder of the gang.

Captain Felicia – Oversees croupiers and card games.

Captain Boone – Oversees security and loan repayments.

FACTION • MEDIUM (20–49) • FRIENDLY • CRIMINAL

Will your party team up with a criminal gang, or work to dismantle them?

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Wolfpack Gang

Bickering bandit siblings.

KNOWN FOR These seven dwarf siblings believe in strength in numbers, which is why they always attack travellers as a team. They typically strike on quiet roads, just before dawn.

GOAL Each sibling believes themselves to be the leader of the Wolfpack and is constantly trying to prove it. Their bickering distracts them from properly securing their targets.

SECRET The wolf pelt hoods that the siblings wear were made by their mother and have cute messages sewn into them. They get very defensive if people notice this.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • HOSTILE • CRIMINAL

Thorned Roses

Activist art thieves.

KNOWN FOR These young, politically minded thieves target galleries and private collections. They steal valuable art and replace it with propaganda marked with a rose symbol.

GOAL The Thorned Roses hope to embarrass the wealthy elite into redistributing their money. They aim to embolden the general population to take their own political action.

SECRET A well-known rumour claims the Roses' ringleader is from a noble family. This is a lie the group itself spreads to tarnish that family's reputation.

FACTION • MICRO (1–5) • NEUTRAL • CRIMINAL

Gardeners Inc.

Knowledge brokers.

KNOWN FOR This innocuously named gang has a file of sordid secrets for every notable figure in the region. They are happy to dispose of the files, for a price.

GOAL As their name suggests, the Gardeners dig up dirt on individuals, to be sold or used as blackmail. They can also investigate or observe on request.

FEATURE To gather information, the group's spies disguise themselves. They dress as town guards, nobles, merchants, jesters, or whatever helps them blend in.

SECRET The Gardeners keep a file on each of their freelance informants, too. If they betray the gang, the information will be leaked to ruin their reputation.

FACTION • MEDIUM (20–49) • NEUTRAL • CRIMINAL

The Double Vow

Skilled assassins who work in pairs.

KNOWN FOR Assassins of the clandestine Double Vow work in pairs. Agents know only their partner and contract handler. Their deadly services cost double the standard rate, but promise double the chance of success.

GOAL Double Vow agents see themselves as skilled artisans offering a service worthy of rich compensation. Every contract must be fulfilled with flawless precision. No mess, no witnesses, no failures.

FEATURE Each agent wears a ring that interlocks with their partner's. If an agent dies on a mission and their partner returns to a contract handler with both rings, the surviving agent is retired with a generous pension.

SECRET An agent's first vow is to the guild. The second vow is to their partner. These promises of unfaltering loyalty are enforced by a secret geas spell stored in their rings, which can immediately terminate defectors.

FACTION • LARGE (50–99) • NEUTRAL • CRIMINAL

Tricklings

Young pickpocketing mages.

KNOWN FOR The Tricklings are led by a washed-up wizarding professor. This group of novice illusionists distract passers-by with flashy magic while picking their pockets.

GOAL Tricklings are mainly teenagers who are unable to attend magic school. They hope to make enough money to provide for themselves and their families.

SECRET The gang's leader truly enjoys teaching magic. They care as much about the young students' academic progress as they do about the loot the Tricklings bring back.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • FRIENDLY • CRIMINAL

The Firm

Corrupt financial advisors.

KNOWN FOR Even felons need financial advice from time to time. From tax evasion to money laundering, the Firm specialises in the financial needs of those outside the law.

GOAL The Firm strives to provide professional and discreet services. Each questionable accountant is directed to go to any lengths necessary to aid their criminal clientele.

SECRET The realm's rulers occasionally use the Firm's services. In return, there is an unwritten rule that the organisation should be left alone by local law enforcement.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • NEUTRAL • CRIMINAL

For individual outlaws, check out the criminal characters lurking on pp. 208–209.

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Root Mob

Gang of awakened plants.

KNOWN FOR This gang of awakened plants terrorises rural settlements. They go from farm to farm, wrecking tools, trampling crops and toppling fences. Their leader, the Stem Mother, is a vengeful sentient scarecrow.

GOAL The Root Mob despises neat agriculture; rows of tilled soil and harvested grain enrage them. They sow destruction wherever they go, hoping to let plant life grow untamed and free, away from restrictive humanoids.

FEATURE The Mob's organic forms make them skilled in stealth and disguise. Some plants take on humanoid shapes to help them hijack farm equipment, and paint on fierce facial expressions using sticky berry juice.

SECRET The Stem Mother owns a magical, ceramic pot that can awaken plants placed into it. She stole it from the garden of the mage who first brought her to life, fleeing before they could reclaim or control her.

FACTION • MEDIUM (20–49) • HOSTILE • CRIMINAL

The Silver Lining

Secret network of thieves.

KNOWN FOR Most citizens live their lives without ever hearing of the Silver Lining. Even those who do rarely suspect the breadth of its influence, or that most of the world's famous heists were pulled off by its thieves.

GOAL All takings and profits are shared among the group for common wealth. The Silver Lining offers its diligent thieves a safehouse in every city and training, as well as access to intel, protection and bespoke tools.

FEATURE Members use a language of hand signals to identify each other and spread messages through the guild. Fences, forgers, artificers, jewellers, arcanists and more can all be found in one of their many safehouses.

SECRET This thieves' guild maintains a long-forgotten network of teleportation circles in the sewers of the realm's major cities. Most are disguised as oval-shaped wells or rune-marked grates.

FACTION • HUGE (100+) • NEUTRAL • CRIMINAL

Screech Blades

Bandits with axe beak mounts.

In an instant, chaos erupts. Dust billows as bird-mounted riders tighten into a closing ring. Wings beat, weapons clash and riders shout commands to one another over the deafening squawks.

KNOWN FOR Travellers are warned to surrender at first sight of the Screech Blades bandit gang. Trying to fight back against these highly skilled warriors is a mistake few people live to tell of. Trying to outrun the bandits and their fast-footed avian steeds is equally foolish.

GOAL Mostly former soldiers or mercenary fighters, the Screech Blades have banded together to earn a living outside the rigid rules of military life. Their knowledge of local terrain, skilled weapons mastery and practised manoeuvres make them a fierce and effective team.

FEATURE Each bandit rides a powerful axe beak mount, allowing them to cover great distances at speed and lending a height advantage in combat. The bandits typically wear scarves to protect against the dust kicked up by their axe beaks' mighty clawed feet.

LEADERSHIP The Screech Blades' commander earns their title by gaining the respect and vote of their comrades. Key skills needed to lead the Screech Blades include tactical experience, dominance in combat, and being able to keep a cool head during an ambush.

SECRET The gang's base camp is an unassuming farmhouse, surrounded by cornfields. The Screech Blades store loot in the farm outhouses and incubate axe beak eggs in oversized chicken coops.

KEY MEMBERS

Commander Idvis Ignar – Cunning and ambitious boss.
Meina Grat – Confident deputy wielding a curved sabre.
Erik Hauch – Fierce brawler who helps rear birds.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • HOSTILE • CRIMINAL

The Screech Blades (right) descend on unsuspecting travellers in a blur of swords and talons.

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Rookridge

Cliffside village built by birdfolk.

KNOWN FOR This village's birdfolk founders took advantage of rarely used real estate – a sheer, vertical cliff face. Shops and dwellings are built into alcoves and caves in the rock.

APPEARANCE Each nest home has wooden frontages decorated with moss, flowers and trinkets. Rope ladders provide access to non-flyers but are badly maintained.

SECRET Unstable rock formations in Rookridge's cliff face are prone to sudden deadly landslides. Locals carefully conceal this to avoid scaring visitors.

SETTLEMENT • BUSY • WELCOMING • RURAL

Elderwallow

Village run by a cult.

KNOWN FOR Elderwallow is the village home of a well-known cult devoted to a charismatic leader called the Everman. Outsiders rarely visit, but locals actively seek more members.

APPEARANCE Cottages and shops line the dirt streets. A large gothic temple dedicated to the Everman dominates the village centre, built painstakingly by cult members.

SECRET Visitors who spend the night in Elderwallow are taken from their beds to a secret midnight meeting. They are given two choices, join the cult or leave the village forever.

SETTLEMENT • QUIET • HOSTILE • RELIGIOUS

Sauramota

Village on the back of a great beast.

KNOWN FOR Twice a year, the nomadic folk of Sauramota village pack up and hitch a ride on a massive brachiosaurus. They take advantage of its migration to seek warmer weather.

APPEARANCE Sauramota is made from tents and scaffolds that can be quickly dismantled when it's time to move. The canvas structures are built on the ground or dinosaur's back.

SECRET Unknown to the villagers, Sauramota elders take it in turns to commune with the giant dinosaur mount to ensure its cooperation. Migrations are very draining for them.

SETTLEMENT • BUSY • NEUTRAL • RURAL

Cottoncrawl

Fairy village in a rabbit's warren.

KNOWN FOR Sharp eyes might spot a small wooden door nestled in the grass. It marks the entrance to a tiny fairy village called Cottoncrawl built in an uninhabited warren.

APPEARANCE The tunnels of the old warren are lit with tiny lanterns creating a warm glow. More tiny doors line each tunnel and lead to fairy homes, taverns and shops.

SECRET Knocking on Cottoncrawl's main door three times causes a larger being to shrink down and enter the village. The magic only lasts for a day before the visitor is expelled.

SETTLEMENT • BUSY • NEUTRAL • ARCANE

Addlewater

Village built on a lake island.

Stone towers rise from the lake's jagged island, their slick walls dotted with windows. Ferry ropes creak, and a cool wind carries the sound of lapping waves.

KNOWN FOR Addlewater is a village built in the middle of lake on a small island; an isolated settlement accessible only by ferry. Anglers, traders and travellers speak of its dramatic stone towers, and the self-reliant villagers who call it home. Its remoteness makes it ideal for privacy and secrecy.

APPEARANCE The village consists of four aged stone towers linked by bridges; iron ladders climb to homes and shops. Every window has impressive views of the water.

POPULATION Addlewater has a dutiful population who tend to the village's maintenance. They provide a warm welcome to travellers, but only have basic amenities to share.

LANDMARKS The north tower has a tavern and supply shop, the south and west towers are residential, and the east tower holds a large workshop.

SECRET The workshop has two ledgers, one public, one private. The hidden book records items that were smuggled on or off the island.

SETTLEMENT • QUIET • NEUTRAL • RESIDENTIAL

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Bluffton

Village that was formerly a town.

KNOWN FOR Bluffton used to be a busy transport hub on a road around a mountain. When a new tunnel gave travellers a route through the mountain instead, Bluffton's importance and population shrank overnight.

APPEARANCE Remaining residents have gathered in the centre of the former town to create a small village. The quiet streets and buildings around the village's edges show faded signs of Bluffton's former prosperity.

POPULATION Bluffton's declining prospects have pushed many younger residents to move away, looking for excitement and work elsewhere. A population of a few hundred older residents remains in the village.

SECRET Anyone who investigates, wanders around or sleeps in the abandoned town outskirts suffers a gruesome fate. This fact terrifies the villagers, so they choose to avoid speaking about it entirely.

SETTLEMENT • QUIET • NEUTRAL • RESIDENTIAL

Sunpetal Oaks

Village of strict druids.

As the treehouses of Sunpetal Oaks come into view, you spot a cluster of caravans and a small campfire right outside of the village boundary.

KNOWN FOR Nestled in the heart of a sacred forest glade, Sunpetal Oaks is a druidic community that prizes balance above all else. Exactly 150 people reside in the village at any given time. If a visitor wishes to cross into Sunpetal's boundaries, a resident must agree to wait or camp outside.

APPEARANCE Makeshift houses are built into the boughs and trunks of large trees. There are no paved roads, only paths made by villagers walking through the lush grass.

POPULATION A core group of druids have lived in Sunpetal for decades, while others stay for only a little while. Starting a family often necessitates leaving the village.

LANDMARKS A ring made of mossy stones marks Sunpetal's boundary. A border warden ensures no one crosses without permission.

SECRET Having too many people in the village breaks an ancient agreement with local spirits. Blight starts to spread as punishment.

SETTLEMENT • QUIET • HOSTILE • RURAL

Halcyon

Popular holiday village.

KNOWN FOR Halcyon is known for its sunny weather all year round, and its quiet hills are ideal for off-trail riding and skiing. It's also famous for its dense, maize-based bread.

APPEARANCE Outdoor diners and taverns set tables in the sun overlooking the market square. Opposite the square is a small stable, and rows of modest homes and hostels.

SECRET Halcyon's perfect weather is no accident. Beneath the market square lies a hidden chamber with a forgotten magical device that manipulates the village's climate.

SETTLEMENT • BUSY • WELCOMING • ENTERTAINMENT

More Villages

1. **SHEEPSHED** Humble birthplace of a famous adventurer.
2. **LANDOW** Officially elected a pet dog as their mayor.
5. **CANNEL** Built over continually burning magma rivers.
3. **BUBBLEBROOK** Brews drinks from local carbonated springs.
4. **SCORCHFORT** Formed by a group of dragons long ago.
6. **HENHURST** Famed for its yearly poultry festival.
7. **OLDE CLAYBORN** Historical village hosting reenactments.
8. **DUNCASTER** Sorcerer haven of wild magic and fey power.
9. **KILGARD** Populated by sentient steampunk automatons.
10. **LIRA** A developer has bought all the houses except one.

In a small village, neighbours are more likely to know each other's business.

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Binnoch Homestead

Farm with automaton workers.

The fields are abundant with plump pumpkins, and metallic workers dressed in matching straw hats. The diligent workforce harvest in total synchronisation.

KNOWN FOR Every harvest season, vegetables from this idyllic homestead scoop first prize at the local county fair. The farm grows its objectively perfect crops with the help of meticulously programmed inventions; they identify what each crop needs and when to harvest it for optimum results.

APPEARANCE The sun glints off the metal-skinned farmers as they comb through the fertile fields. Mechanical harvesters, sprinklers and mulchers work alongside them in harmony.

INHABITANTS Clockwork-powered machines carry out farming jobs in the fields. Sentient automaton overseers own the farm, and repair their inventions when needed.

LOOT The workshop barn is full of pistons, wheels, machine parts and tools. There are also a dozen bladed attachments used for reaping.

SECRET The automatons celebrate the machines with a monthly party in the farmhouse. The inventions are given accolades and oil baths.

ENVIRONMENT • LARGE • SAFE • FARM

Twilight Boughs

Orchard that only blooms at night.

KNOWN FOR This orchard looks bare during the day, but comes alive at night. Blooming trees are pollinated by moths, and produce sweet fruit with thrumming magical power.

APPEARANCE The orchard's trees are twisted and thick with age. A mudbrick wall wraps around the Twilight Boughs, full of small cracks and holes used by nesting birds and bugs.

SECRET Pale, silent sprites emerge at dusk to harvest fruit, their skin caked in old pollen and dirt. They know how to brew a forbidden poison that can kill even the mightiest beast.

ENVIRONMENT • MID-SIZED • SAFE • FARM

The Elysium Project

Research farm with rare crops.

KNOWN FOR Part farm, part research centre, the Elysium Project grows and researches rare and magical crops from around the world. It is run by a group of graduate botanists.

APPEARANCE Each of their five fields are neatly divided into sections, which receive subtly different care. Barns have been converted into laboratories and organised seed stores.

SECRET Researchers have developed a new corn strain that could triple yields. Fearing theft, they've employed a team of security guards who regularly patrol the farm's perimeter.

ENVIRONMENT • SMALL • RISKY • FARM

Bogland Fields

Underwater berry farm.

KNOWN FOR This farm grows waterberries – tasty fruit that burst with red, sticky juice. The berries grow underwater, float to the surface when ripe, before being scooped into nets by wading workers.

APPEARANCE Bogland Fields sits in a floodplain, nourished by rainfall and river overflow. Waterberries thrive here among dense brambles, tall reeds and white mangroves that tangle together along the water's edge.

LOOT Abundant waterberries hold no magical or medicinal value, but they are delicious. Sodden storage sheds house waterproof waders, boots, berry nets and sharp machetes for navigating the dense, thorny terrain.

SECRET Generations ago, the farm's founders struck a deal with a swamp fey for rich harvests. In return for protection, one crate of a thousand waterberries must be left by a marked mangrove each solstice.

ENVIRONMENT • SMALL • RISKY • FARM

Break up long journeys by having your party pass one of these distinctive farms.

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Copperbean Farm

Farm powered by lightning.

KNOWN FOR Potent weather spells keep the never-ending thunderstorm above this farm in motion. Lightning discharges into the enchanted beanstalk crops, helping them grow.

APPEARANCE The skies above the farm are dark, and rain lashes down. Conductor rods on greenhouse roofs feed into shiny copper lattices that weave throughout the magic beans.

SECRET A shambling mound has appeared in the farm, and is growing stronger each time it is struck by lightning. The farm's owner is terrified it will destroy the whole operation.

ENVIRONMENT • MID-SIZED • DANGEROUS • FARM

Pan's Cornucopia

Unoccupied, cursed farm.

KNOWN FOR Pan's Cornucopia appears only to lost, tired travellers desperate for food. Locals warn its tempting feast is a cruel trap, luring victims to their doom.

APPEARANCE A bend in the road reveals a little homestead with a pigsty, and fields full of ripe fruit and vegetables. There are no fences and the cottage seems unoccupied.

SECRET Taking even a single bite from the Cornucopia will trigger a curse. Hungry thieves are transformed into pigs and left to wander the farm for eternity.

ENVIRONMENT • SMALL • DANGEROUS • FARM

Boutique Blooms

Large-scale flower farm.

KNOWN FOR Boutique Blooms supplies florists across the land with its famous pink sunflowers. The farm's huge production creates thick pollen clouds that pose health risks to workers, and harm the nearby environment.

APPEARANCE Eleven on-site glass houses glow with red-tinted lantern light, housing rows and rows of sunflower seedlings. The farm fields are packed with magenta flowers that gently sway in the warm breeze.

LOOT As well as sunflowers in all sizes, the farm has a colossal stock of strong fertilizer that can be turned into explosives. Sacks of sunflower seeds are stored in silos, alongside empty sacks made from hard-wearing canvas.

SECRET The farm is much more dangerous than it looks. There are swarms of angry buzzing pollinators, disorientating pollen clouds, grasping vines, and a colony of diseased rats that live in the muddy soil.

ENVIRONMENT • LARGE • SAFE • FARM

Geryon's Ranch

Ranch of giant animals.

The enormous mammoth lowers its head in curiosity, then lets out a snort and deep sigh. The rumbling vibrations spread through your entire body.

KNOWN FOR Geryon's Ranch is a sprawling livestock farm, with pastures big enough for its mighty animals. The creatures who graze here include woolly mammoths, aurochs and catoblepas, which are extinct in most parts of the realm. There are also oversized species of cows, sheep and goats.

APPEARANCE The ranch spans hundreds of acres of grass and woodlands. Animals tower over the trees, and their broad backs blend in with the hills beyond.

INHABITANTS Livestock graze freely, under the watch of a farm team. The giant animals are normally shy, passive creatures, but can charge or stampede if startled.

LOOT Storage barns dot the fields. They hold sturdy crates of wool, milk, cheese and meat that are ready for freighting.

SECRET The ranch owner made a lucrative deal with the realm's ruler. Each year, two giant beasts are taken to be trained and used in war.

ENVIRONMENT • LARGE • RISKY • RANCH

Labouring on a farm for a day gives adventurers an easy way to earn money, or a bed for the night.

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Circle of Seasons

Crop-nurturing druids.

KNOWN FOR The Circle of Seasons are revered as nomadic guardians of nature. Members of this circle are often paid by farmers to revive crops and barren fields.

GOAL The Circle of Seasons helps people live in harmony with nature's cycles. They conjure water in times of drought, and thaw frost in harsh winters.

FEATURE Druids in this circle can be distinguished by their vibrant, living cloaks. These ceremonial robes bloom, wilt, and change colour with the seasons.

SECRET The circle's archdruids guard a secret ritual that can draw immense power from the land. It is enough to resurrect humanoid life, at a cost.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • FRIENDLY • INDUSTRY

Amara Meridia

Farmer with a beautiful singing voice.

KNOWN FOR Amara's melodic voice can be heard all throughout the valley of her family's vineyard, singing as she collects and crushes grapes. The harmonious sound is rumoured to be what makes the wine so delicious.

APPEARANCE Working outdoors in the fields has given Amara a sun-kissed face and calloused, grape-stained hands. She wears a wide-brimmed hat decorated with ribbons, and a silver necklace with a music note pendant.

GOAL Amara would love to travel the world, but her duty to her family's farm keeps her from straying too far. She loves to learn more about other countries and cultures, especially their songs.

SECRET Amara's parents made a desperate deal with a celestial when their vineyard suffered from blight. The angelic being heard baby Amara crying, and blessed her with an enchanted voice that helped the vines recover.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • ELF-HUMAN • LABOURER

COMMONER / PERFORMER

Pasturix

Livestock hybrid.

KNOWN FOR A pasturix is a prized agricultural anomaly, also known as a "barnyard chimera". These rare creatures provide an unparalleled bounty of milk, wool and eggs.

APPEARANCE Pasturix have chunky bovine frames covered in dense curls of off-white wool. They have the feathered head of a chicken and small, flightless wings.

SECRET The appearance of a pasturix on a farm is said to bring good luck. The truth is they are fiends, and often appear when an abyssal presence is manifesting nearby.

CREATURE • LARGE • FRIENDLY • MONSTROSITY

Torrin Halion

Shepherd with hippogriff helpers.

KNOWN FOR This rancher manages the largest and most prosperous sheep farms in the region. He keeps track of the flock with the help of two expertly trained hippogriffs.

APPEARANCE Torrin wears a belted leather tunic over trousers tucked into boots. A bone whistle used to direct the hippogriffs hangs from a string around his neck.

SECRET The eldest of Torrin's hippogriffs is past her prime and needs to retire. Torrin will pay a large sum to anyone who can source a young hippogriff (or two) that he can train.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HUMAN • LABOURER

Swift Sickle Company

Freelance farm workers.

KNOWN FOR Farmers in need of workers on short-term contracts turn to the Swift Sickle Company. This army of for-hire labourers helps complete harvests swiftly and efficiently, before moving on to the next job.

GOAL The Swift Sickle Company offers flexibility to both farmers and workers. Farmers get support in their busiest times, and labourers can take on as much work as they'd like between other jobs.

FEATURE After being vetted by the Swift Sickle Company's founder, workers are given overalls with an emblem of three hands holding up a golden apple. They wear these on jobs to help advertise the Company.

SECRET The golden emblem on worker overalls is more than symbolic. It's an enchanted sigil that allows the Swift Sickle Company's founder to track, scry or even speak through any worker wearing it if needed.

FACTION • HUGE (100+) • NEUTRAL • INDUSTRY

Farmers are good sources of knowledge about local terrain, wildlife and weather patterns.

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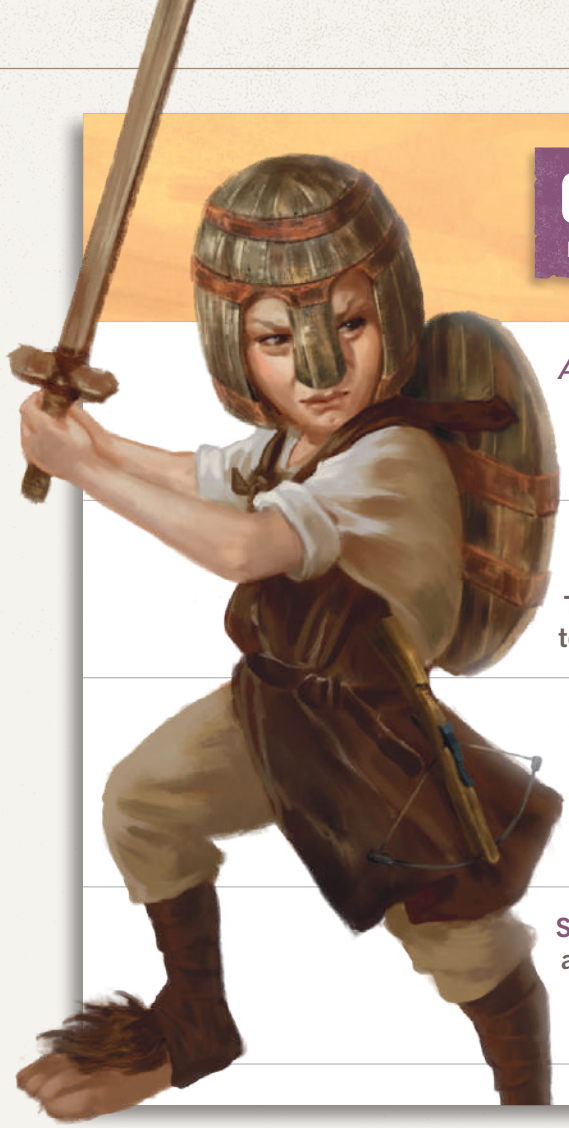

Gershin Woodmere

Farmhand with heroic dreams.

A wiry adolescent courageously swings a wooden sword. A battered scarecrow bears the brunt of their strikes, its straw-filled arms swaying with each blow.

KNOWN FOR After a long day's work helping out on their family farm, Gershin tirelessly hones their sword skills against hay bales and scarecrows. Though their technique is unrefined, their raw strength and unyielding drive to prove their mettle as an adventurer makes them a formidable foe.

APPEARANCE Gershin carries a wooden sword, with sharp sanded edges and a leather-bound hilt. Their shield is made from barrel staves reinforced with iron nails.

GOAL Gershin is determined to leave the confines of farm life and become a heroic adventurer. They are in desperate need of a mentor to train and guide them.

SECRET Gershin volunteered to hunt a roc that is eating local sheep, but elders forbade it. Gershin has a bag packed and plans to set off alone.

LOOT

- Wooden sword
- Hand crossbow*
- Lucky turnip

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HALFLING • COMBATANT — BANDIT / SCOUT

Mallivar Briar

Warlock beekeeper.

KNOWN FOR Mallivar Briar tends to her hives without rest; she stays outside harvesting honey day and night. Her jars of hexed, red honey glow faintly in the moonlight, and hold potent magical power.

APPEARANCE Bees crawl freely over Mallivar's skin and tattered clothing, including a long coat stitched with tiny runes. She has dark rings under her bloodshot eyes, and a wide grin full of tarnished-yellow teeth.

GOAL She seeks to draw power from the Skitter Queen, a legendary hive-mother buried deep underground. Each taste of hexed, mind-altering honey grants her a brief window to commune with the mysterious entity.

SECRET Mallivar isn't just communing with the Skitter Queen, she's becoming a vessel for it. Her veins are growing darker with thick, honey-like blood, and her mind blurs between human and hive consciousness.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • HUMAN • WORSHIPPER — CULTIST / CULTIST FANATIC

Harvest Aid Collective

Farmers' union.

KNOWN FOR The Harvest Aid Collective is the realm's largest farming guild. It gives members a social network during good harvests, and financial aid during bad ones.

GOAL The union provides a safety net for farmers, and hosts community events. Members pay in a generous monthly fee to support others (and themselves) in times of need.

SECRET Farmers who fall too far into debt aren't helped, they're absorbed. Their land is taken under a "stewardship clause" and they're forced to work it for meagre pay.

FACTION • LARGE (50–99) • FRIENDLY • SOCIAL

More Farm Workers

1. BRAN THISTLOCK Shepherd claiming their flock is haunted.
2. TIBBY NORWICK Tends to injured wildlife in their farmhouse.
3. JONA UFFO Farmer reporting strange symbols in their crops.
4. STITCHFELL Animated sack who helps out on the farm.
5. PAT CHURNWEY Cheery dairy farmer who makes ice cream.
6. TARN WHIST Labourer, forager and local mushroom expert.
7. ALDWIN GEARSPROCK Grows and mills wheat for flour.
8. ELLIS TIDINS Orchard owner struggling with tree blight.
9. GWENYN WHITE Muscular farmhand skilled with a plough.
10. KALLIN EMBERSTRID Rears rare species of axe beaks.

A player character with a rural upbringing could include one of these NPCs in their backstory.

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Gulthras

Sewer-dwelling reptiles.

Rats scurry away from you as a low, rattling growl echoes through the tunnel. In the gloom, you see a gaping jaw open, revealing far too many teeth.

KNOWN FOR Gulthras stalk the sewers and tunnels beneath cities and towns, feasting on anything that strays into their domain. They are highly territorial and solitary creatures. Young gulthras hatch without a parent present, and must immediately learn to fend for themselves in the dark.

APPEARANCE Gulthras have thick scales, bony spurs and ferociously sharp teeth, all of which can regenerate if damaged. Their wide-set eyes give good peripheral vision.

TACTICS These reptiles can lay still on walls or ceilings, and float in fetid water for hours before lunging at their prey. Their claws tear their victims apart.

LAIR Gulthras build nests out of solidified saliva, leaves, and fur from their prey. They lay eggs in these nests then abandon them.

SECRET Dense gulthra claws are durable and make sturdy climbing hooks. They fetch a high price among mountain climbers and thieves.

GULTHRA

Huge Monstrosity

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
24 (+7)	10 (+0)	19 (+4)	4 (-3)	12 (+1)	8 (-1)

Armour Class: 13
Hit Points: 136 (13d12 + 52)
Speed: 40 ft, swim 40 ft
Initiative: +0

Saving Throws: STR +10
Skills: Perception +4
Resistances: Acid, Poison
Senses: Darkvision 60 ft
Passive Perception: 14
Languages: --
Proficiency Bonus: +3

ABILITIES

Magic Resistance. The gulthra has advantage on saving throws against spells and magical effects.

Regeneration. The gulthra regains 10 Hit Points at the start of each of its turns if it has at least 1 Hit Point remaining.

Cold-Blooded Killer. The gulthra has advantage on melee attack rolls against any creature with less than half its hit points.

Coat of Filth. While underwater, the gulthra is surrounded by sticky mud and mucus. Constitution Saving Throw: DC 14, each creature within 5 ft of the gulthra at the end of the gulthra's turn. Failure: the target becomes soiled. Until the target is washed, it takes 6 (1d12) acid damage at the end of every 10 minute period.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The gulthra makes one Clamping Bite attack and two Claw attacks.

Clamping Bite. Melee Weapon Attack: +10 to hit, reach 10 ft, one target. Hit: 33 (4d12 + 7) piercing damage. If the target is a Large or smaller creature, it has the Grappled condition (escape DC 17). While Grappled, the target has the Restrained condition. The gulthra can only grapple one creature in this way at a time.

Claw. Melee Weapon Attack: +10 to hit, reach 5 ft, one target. Hit: 25 (4d8 + 7) damage.

LEGENDARY ACTIONS: 2 USES

Immediately after another creature's turn, the gulthra can expend a use to take one of the following actions. The gulthra regains all expended uses at the start of each of its turns.

Claw Strike. The gulthra makes one Claw attack.

Body Shake. The gulthra shakes its body, sending filth spattering across the area. Constitution Saving Throw: DC 14, each creature within 10 ft of the gulthra. Failure: the target becomes soiled. Until the target is washed, it takes 6 (1d12) acid damage at the end of every 10 minute period.

Roar (Costs 2 Uses). The gulthra lets out a terrible, hissing roar. Wisdom Saving Throw: DC 14, each creature within 60 ft of the gulthra. Failure: the target gains the Frightened condition until the end of the gulthra's next turn.

CHALLENGE RATING 9

You could alternatively use the stats of an Allosaurus CR 2, Giant Crocodile CR 5 or Adult Black Dragon CR 14.

CREATURE • HUGE • HOSTILE • MONSTROSITY

Ridding a town of pests can be a good way for the party to earn coin.

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Erstwhilers

Mischievous air elementals.

KNOWN FOR When hats are blown off by a surprise wind, or carts are tipped over by a gust on a still day, an erstwhiler is at work. Erstwhilers are invisible creatures of raw elemental chaos, who live to cause havoc.

APPEARANCE Erstwhilers are humanoid-sized masses of swirling air. They are transparent, but are revealed by items that get caught in their whirling bodies — whether that's dust, dirt or something larger.

TACTICS Erstwhilers whip up small tornadoes, use gusts of air to move heavy objects, and spread terrible smells through a crowd. They don't have any malice towards others, just a natural instinct to cause chaos.

SECRET If too many erstwhilers congregate in one place, they may accidentally fuse into a larger, violent air elemental. This unstable fusion can spark turbulent storms and tear open rifts to the Elemental Plane of Air.

CREATURE • SMALL • NEUTRAL • ELEMENTAL

ICE MEPHIT / AIR ELEMENTAL

Trespusses

Territorial felines.

KNOWN FOR Trespuss is a misleadingly cute name given to spined, feral felines that move into abandoned buildings. Attempts to drive the cats out are met with clawed attacks.

APPEARANCE Trespusses are bony creatures, covered in visible signs of previous fights. The savage felines often have mangled ears, crooked tails and heavy scarring.

SECRET It isn't easy to spook a trespuss. If they are seen scampering away from an old warehouse or dark alley, there's something much worse waiting inside.

CREATURE • TINY • HOSTILE • MONSTROSITY

Thatch Bats

Giant bats that live in roofs.

KNOWN FOR A family of giant thatch bats can easily damage and bring down roof rafters. They are destructive, noisy and often appear without warning.

APPEARANCE Each thatch bat is a rotund ball of brown fur, with leathery wings at least six feet long. They have long, twitchy snouts, and their eyes are like bulbous black globes.

SECRET Thatch bats brought down the spire of a holy building by nesting in its rafters. Since then, the creatures have been seen as a terrible omen by religious people.

CREATURE • LARGE • NEUTRAL • BEAST

Swarm of Mud Piskies

Elementals that spread dirt.

KNOWN FOR Waking up to a thick layer of mud on the streets is a sure sign of mud piskies. These tiny, nocturnal earth elementals can travel in populations of over a hundred.

APPEARANCE Each piskie is a few inches tall and drips with organic sludge. They have long, spade-like hands and nails that allow them to claw through soil and get into buildings.

SECRET Using enchanted tools like magic brooms to clean mud piskie messes always backfires. Piskies are drawn to magic, and can quickly turn the items against their owners.

CREATURE • MEDIUM • NEUTRAL • ELEMENTAL

More Urban Pests

1. SCALE RATS Small and vicious half-rat, half-lizard creatures.
2. CHUTEWEED Fast-growing ivy that has toxic flower pollen.
3. SPARKBUGS Hatched in hearths, these bugs spread fire.
4. WRETCHLINGS Swarm of skeletal rodents who move as one.
5. SPARROWGHASTS Spectral birds that peck at the living.
6. OOZE MOSS Extremely sticky moss that clogs up wheels.
7. PENNYGUISE Poisonous insect that looks like a copper coin.
8. FUPPIES Fast-breeding, magical pigeon-fish hybrids.
9. HEDGEBAIT Carnivorous amphibian that looks like a shrub.
10. SKULL BURROWERS Lice that control their host's mind.

Arcanarot Pile

Animated pile of trash.

KNOWN FOR An arcanarot pile is made when magical waste is dumped into a regular garbage heap. They absorb more trash to make themselves stronger.

APPEARANCE Rotting, stinking mounds of magical waste, arcanarot piles change and shift constantly. Their stench makes breathing very difficult.

TACTICS Arcanarot piles see enemies as they see all trash — something to consume. When they are still, they are indistinguishable from regular garbage.

SECRET Arcanarot piles thrive on decay. Necrotic magic doesn't harm them but instead fuels their growth, making them even harder to destroy.

CREATURE • LARGE • NEUTRAL • CONSTRUCT

SHAMBLING MOUND / CLAY GOLEM

Using a swarm of smaller creatures instead of one big boss can make combat unpredictable.

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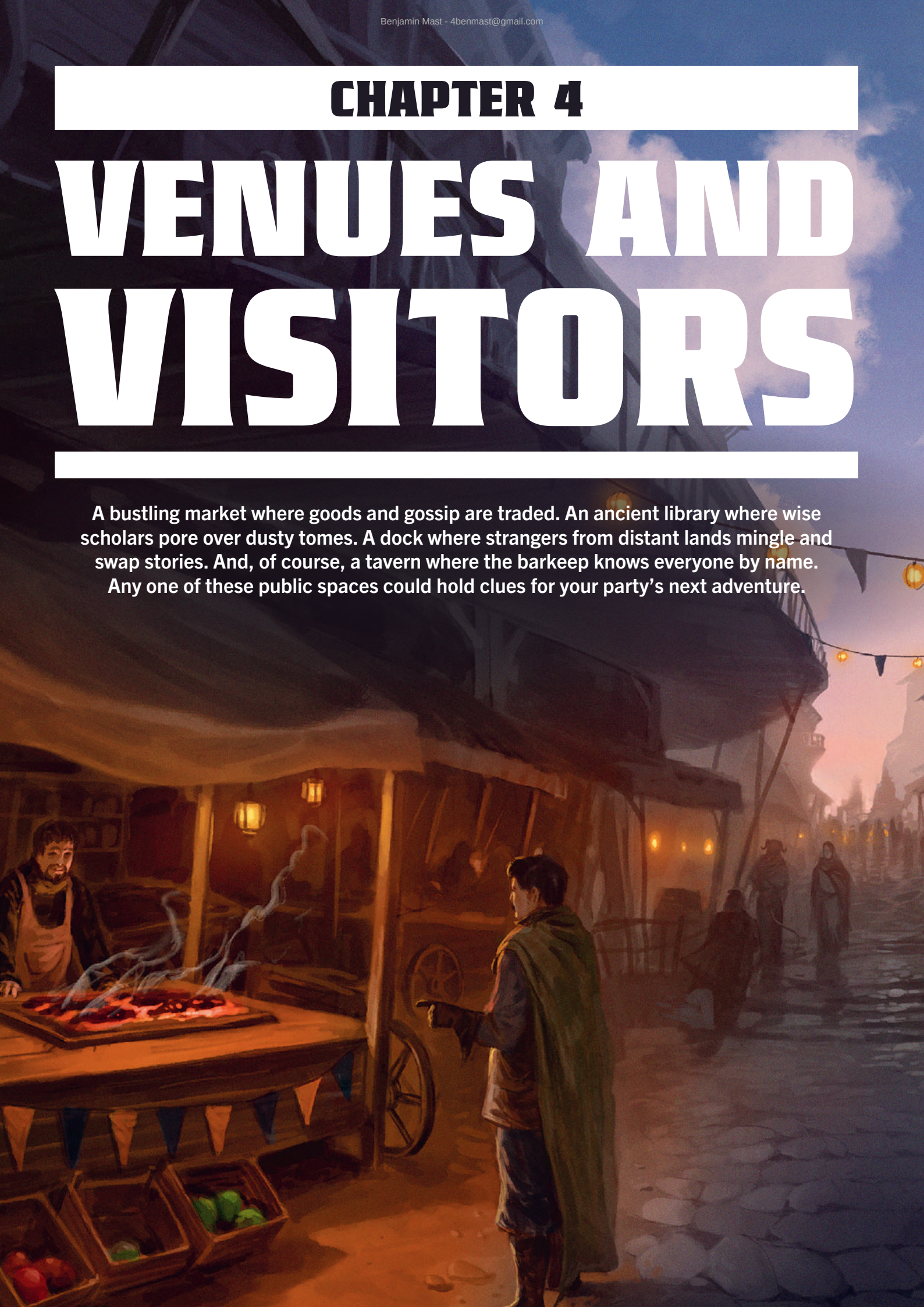
CHAPTER 4

VENUES AND VISITORS

A bustling market where goods and gossip are traded. An ancient library where wise scholars pore over dusty tomes. A dock where strangers from distant lands mingle and swap stories. And, of course, a tavern where the barkeep knows everyone by name. Any one of these public spaces could hold clues for your party's next adventure.



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The Guard and Gate

Inn built into a city wall.

KNOWN FOR Built on both sides of the city wall, this inn is a common first stop for visitors. If you arrive before the gates close, you can grab a room inside the city. If not, the bar outside the wall stays open until sunrise.

APPEARANCE This long building started as a simple timber-framed hole-in-the-wall. Over time, awnings, copper-plated bars, bedrooms and drink cabinets were added. Its worn, rustic features give it a lived-in charm.

LAYOUT On the outside of the wall, the Guard and Gate has one big bar room, a kitchen and a stable block. The tavern within the city has another bar and kitchen, along with 13 reasonably priced guest bedrooms.

SECRET Key-carrying gate wardens drink at the popular outdoor bar after their shifts most nights, ignoring their captains' orders to stay away. After drinking, they unlock the gates and quietly slip back into the city.

BUILDING • LARGE • BUSY • TAVERN

Knotwise Lodge

Wretched accommodation.

KNOWN FOR Cheap prices are the only thing that keeps this venue in business. Guests tolerate filthy rooms and vile food, but vacancies are always available, no matter the hour.

APPEARANCE The creaking front door opens to a bar area, where tallow candles fill the room with smoke and the smell of old meat. The rotten roof leaks into most bedrooms.

SECRET The foul stench of Knotwise Lodge isn't just mould or neglect. Its barbaric chef is cooking constantly, using up rancid steaks and meat from missing travellers.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • QUIET • TAVERN

The Chambers of Valour

Exclusive members-only lounge.

KNOWN FOR Only famous adventurers and nobles are permitted at this elite club. A unique, embossed coin allows members to teleport to the otherwise inaccessible interior.

APPEARANCE Built within the repurposed skeletal remains of a dragon, its sculpted metal building exterior shimmers like scales. Fireplace smoke emerges from the dragon's nostrils.

SECRET A recent extension has disturbed a magical ley line. Some members are experiencing unpredictable magical effects when they enter the club.

BUILDING • SMALL • QUIET • TAVERN

Oriel's Oasis

Beach cocktail bar.

The beach thrums with music. Lanterns flicker around a straw-roofed hut, where cocktails are poured and laughter spills into the warm night air.

KNOWN FOR The drinks at Oriel's Oasis are shaken and stirred with alcohol and magical reagents. The bartender spends their mornings at the docks, bartering for ripe fruit and rare ingredients from distant lands. At night, they create zesty cocktails, with a bespoke concoction for every customer.

APPEARANCE Driftwood beams hold up a roof of palm leaf fronds. The Oasis is adorned with colourful lanterns, and drinks are served from mother-of-pearl cups.

LAYOUT Oriel's Oasis is a simple square bar with stools on each side. Empty bottles are piled into wooden barrels next to crates overflowing with fresh fruit.

LOOT The imported fruit is expensive. The rarest, octoranges, are held in a chest behind the bar.

SECRET A drunk pirate gave the bartender a treasure map as a tip. The map leads to the lost fortune of the Theydon Boys crew.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • BUSY • TAVERN

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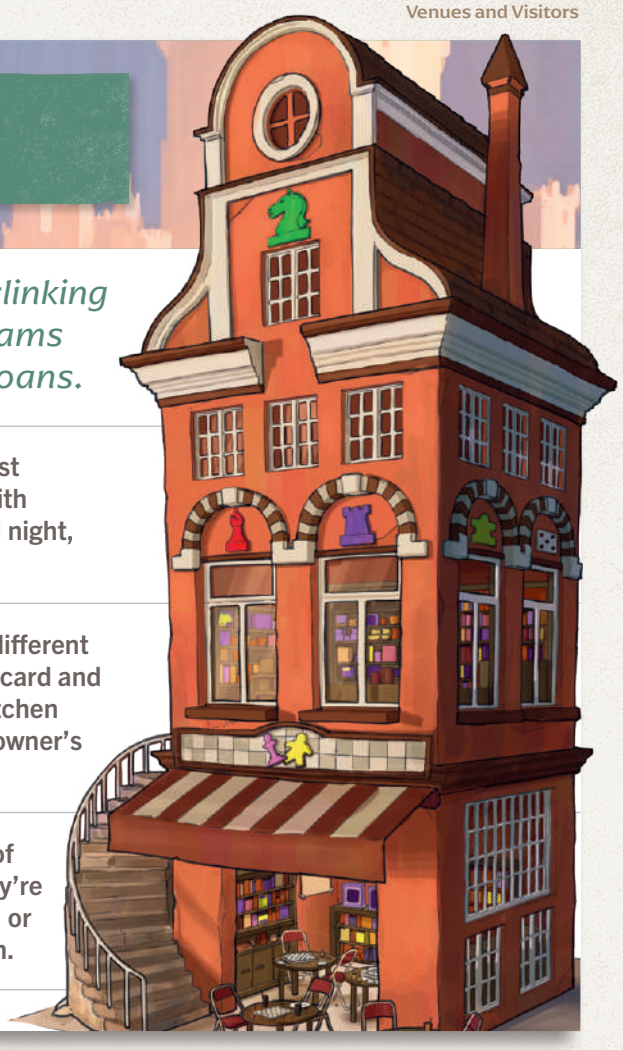
Dice of Life

Tavern and games parlour.



The gaming tables buzz with conversations and clinking mugs; mead flows and crumbs scatter. An orc slams down a wooden token, to a mix of cheers and groans.

KNOWN FOR This tavern offers a modest food menu alongside a vast collection of board games. Locals come here to unwind, catch up with friends and enjoy gaming competitions. Dice of Life is open day and night, and it welcomes people of all ages into its warm, lively atmosphere.

APPEARANCE Painted, wood-cut signs brighten the sandstone walls. Shelves packed with games fill each room, while foldable wooden chairs create a flexible and open layout.

LAYOUT Each floor hosts a different gaming type: strategy, dice, card and role-playing. The tavern's kitchen is in the basement, and the owner's office is in the attic.

LOOT Someone mistakenly put a Figurine of Wondrous Power back in a board game box along with the regular miniatures and tokens.

SECRET The owner of Dice of Life is retiring next year. They're quietly scouting for a person or group to take over the tavern.

BUILDING • LARGE • OVERCROWDED • TAVERN

Forty Winks Inn

Chain of budget-friendly inns.

KNOWN FOR This chain of inns prides itself on giving the same reliable offering in every location. No matter which inn you visit, you'll find the same budget-friendly prices, basic furnishings and potato-based menu.

APPEARANCE All Forty Winks inns have the same sign, a sheep jumping over a fence made of stars. Guest rooms and furnishings are simple but sturdy, keeping within the chain's famous blue and yellow brand colours.

LAYOUT Each inn has the same amenities, including a reception desk, dining room, bar, and a small general store selling items travellers might have forgotten. Identical guest rooms are arranged on long corridors.

SECRET In the basement of each Forty Winks inn is a metal doorway with many levers. Pulling a lever and opening the door allows managers to seamlessly travel to any other Forty Winks location across the world.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • BUSY • INN

The Cracked Lantern

Rough drinking spot.

KNOWN FOR Fights are so common at this after-hours alehouse that the owners have stopped bothering to replace the glass windows. It's a favourite tavern for criminal gangs.

APPEARANCE Bar staff serve wooden flagons of drink from behind a retractable latticed metal shutter. Fresh sawdust is sprinkled on the floor each night to soak up spills and blood.

SECRET Table lanterns glow with will-o'-wisps; spirits of once-regular patrons who wished to rest at their favourite tavern. Their spirits flare brighter when fights break out.

BUILDING • SMALL • OVERCROWDED • TAVERN

Heart to Hearth

Romantic restaurant.

KNOWN FOR The dimly lit atmosphere of the Heart to Hearth restaurant makes it the perfect spot for a romantic dining experience. Prices are steep, but well worth it.

APPEARANCE Branches filled with cherry blossoms are tied to the ceiling, and globes of magical light dance through the air. Close tables give an intimate ambiance for diners.

SECRET Silence spells on each table ensure conversations are kept private. Magical disguises are not permitted, but enchantments in the air make every patron look their best.

BUILDING • SMALL • QUIET • TAVERN

Taverns can make familiar home bases or bastions for your party to return to time and again.

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The Copperpot Arms

Welcoming and always expanding tavern.

Laughter bubbles out of the open windows, mingled with the mouth-watering smell of freshly baked pie and sweet mead. Even before you step inside, this bustling tavern somehow feels like home.

Key Stats

Function	Commercial
Size	78,000 sq. ft
Capacity	Approx. 500
Crowd Density	Comfortable
Noise Level	Moderate
Proprietor	Individual
Prices	Affordable
Amenities	Beds, stables, dining, bar

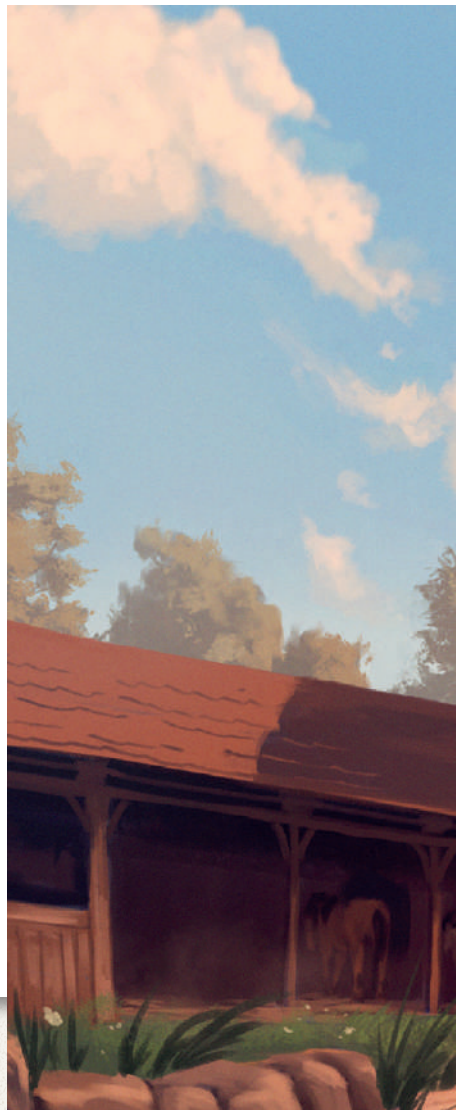
KNOWN FOR "There's always more room in the pot" is the unofficial motto of this spacious tavern and its happy regulars. There are more than 100 rooms on offer, catering for any budget. However busy the tavern gets, the friendly bar staff always seem to find space to squeeze in more patrons. The Copperpot Arms prides itself in making sure everyone goes to bed with a full stomach and a full heart.

APPEARANCE The timber-framed walls of the Copperpot Arms are given a fresh lick of paint once every couple of months to keep them looking bright and clean. Tavern rooms are decorated in rich, earthy greens and oranges that welcome patrons in like a warm hug. Round tables in the central bar encourage visitors to sit and chat with strangers. A fiery hearth keeps the tavern cosy in winter, and big barn doors open to a back garden in the summer.

INHABITANTS The tavern is a melting pot. Locals stop by for a drink with friends after work, or to enjoy the live music and occasional dancing. Some guests only need to stay a night, taking advantage of the tavern's comfortable beds and safe stables before continuing their journeys. Others extend their stay for weeks or months, delighted to have discovered this home away from home. There are many familiar, friendly regulars among the tavern's long-serving bar staff.

HISTORY The Copperpot Arms began as a humble shelter built by cook Elsbeth Laury. Passing travellers traded their skills for boarding – masonry from labourers, woodwork from carpenters. Slowly, the inn's mismatched wings and inviting nooks were built. As the inn expanded, so did its reputation for warmth, generosity and good company. The original copper kettle used to brew Elsbeth's first drinks still hangs above the bar, and every new guest is warmly invited to share their story by the fire.

LAYOUT The Copperpot Arms has undergone several extensions to cater to more and more guests. Adjoining the main tavern area, there are several long guest wings that offer rooms of every size and comfort level. There are also well-equipped stables, private function rooms and a games parlour. A small brewery room is attached to the back wall of the tavern's busy kitchen.



The Copperpot Arms (right) has grown significantly since its humble beginnings.

Benjamin Mast - 4benmast@gmail.com

Room and Board Options

FREE Even visitors without a penny to their name will find themselves looked after at the Copperpot Arms. The stables are kept warm and dry, and staff will bring out a bowl of stew or porridge to keep the hunger away.

POOR The tavern's low-budget option costs just one silver coin and gives access to a bunk in a shared attic dormitory. Simple but hearty meals are taken to-go, and include a single free drink.

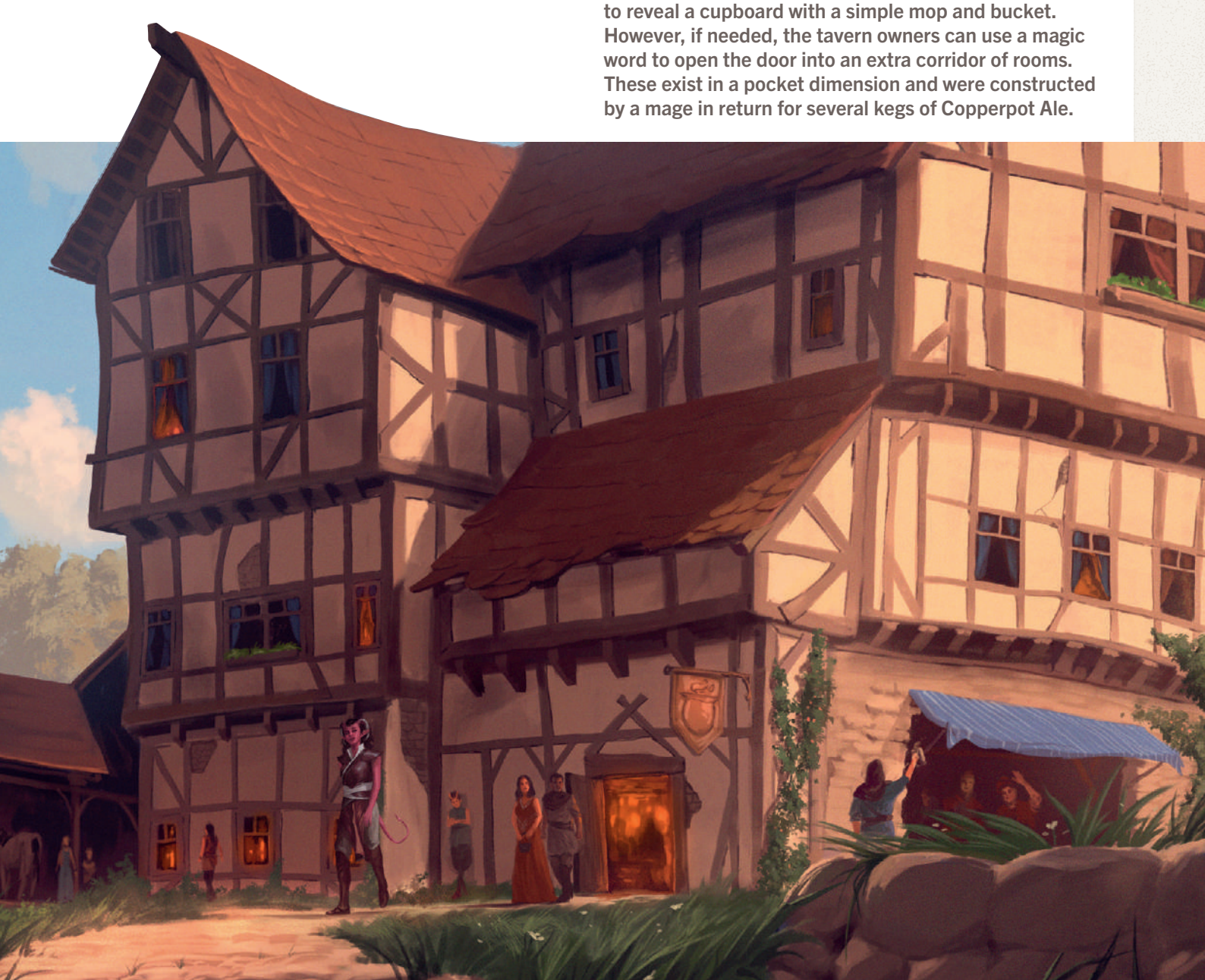
MODEST For five silver pieces each, multiple guests can share a room with four to six single beds. These rooms are typically on the ground floor of the tavern, which can be noisy late at night or early in the morning. These rooms don't have their own plumbing, but there is a shared washroom at the end of each corridor. Meals are eaten at the bar, with room service costing extra.

COMFORTABLE Spend a few silver more for a double room on a quieter upper floor. These rooms all have an armchair, desk and in-room sink. Guests get complimentary room service, or can sit and enjoy their meal in the tavern's dining room. As a final perk, these guests are all gifted a souvenir tankard.

WEALTHY Splashing gold coins at the Copperpot Arms buys an entire suite with a private bathroom and living space. These guests can opt to eat in a private dining room. They are gifted a copper tankard, which entitles them to unlimited free refills during their stay.

ARISTOCRATIC The finest suite in the tavern is reserved for nobility and, on one occasion, even royalty. The owners of the Copperpot Arms have also been known to give the suite to brave heroes who have done them a good deed in return.

SECRET At the end of one long, attic corridor, there's a locked storeroom. On general inspection, it opens to reveal a cupboard with a simple mop and bucket. However, if needed, the tavern owners can use a magic word to open the door into an extra corridor of rooms. These exist in a pocket dimension and were constructed by a mage in return for several kegs of Copperpot Ale.



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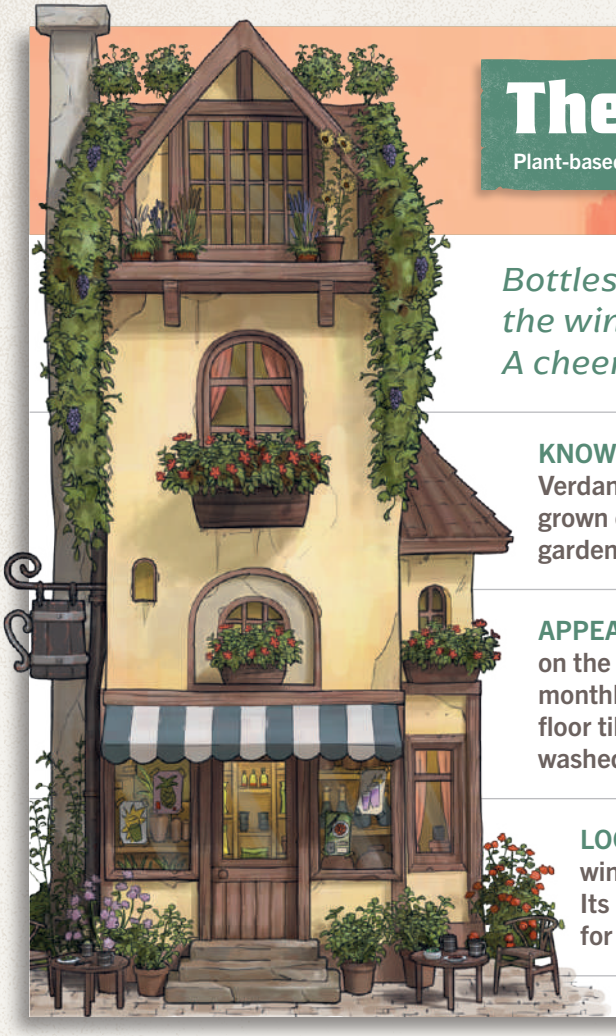

The Verdant Vine

Plant-based tavern.

Bottles of wine and curious herbal cordials glint in the window, sheltered beneath a striped awning. A cheerful bell jingles overhead as you push the door.

KNOWN FOR It's hard to argue that any tavern has fresher food than the Verdant Vine. All the ingredients for its unique, plant-based dishes are grown on-site. Patrons are welcome to take a stroll through the kitchen garden and pluck the produce needed for their meals right off the vines.

APPEARANCE Greenery in and on the tavern is kept neat with monthly pruning. Moist terracotta floor tiles have been recently washed with lemon-scented water.

LAYOUT The tavern's ground floor is a deli shop, with dining and drinking areas on the upper floors. A large terrace seating area at the back is filled with long tables.

LOOT The Verdant Vine makes wines using their own grapes. Its Golden Vine vintage goes for 1000 gold pieces a bottle.

SECRET An awakened tree lives in the rear garden. They spend most of their time dozing, but will join in on interesting conversations.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • BUSY • TAVERN

The Unicorn's Horn

Inn with spa facilities.

KNOWN FOR This unicorn-themed inn offers magical healing and rejuvenating treatments, perfect for an off-duty adventurer. The spa is famous for its rainbow clay facials.

APPEARANCE Butterflies dance in the pleasant, cooling mist that surrounds the charming cottage hotel. Warm freshwater ponds make for a delightful outside dip.

SECRET The inn's proprietor is a unicorn, trapped in elven form by a curse inflicted by an evil sorcerer. They're actually much happier in their new life, and don't want to go back.

BUILDING • SMALL • QUIET • INN

Black Sail Inn

Nautical-themed inn.

KNOWN FOR When Captain Mizzenmast's galleon ran aground, he decided it was as good a time as ever to retire from seafaring. He turned his ship into a shoreside inn.

APPEARANCE A dry dock has been built around the ship to stop it drifting back out to sea. White sails mean there are vacancies below decks; black sails mean the inn is full.

SECRET Before the ship was turned into an inn, the crew was planning a mutiny. Many of the crew still work as inn staff and are still plotting to overthrow the captain.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • OVERCROWDED • INN

Hopewell Hostel

Prison turned hostel.

KNOWN FOR The Hopewell Hostel is a donation-funded, charity-run inn that welcomes anyone for a free meal and warm bed, no questions asked. The only rule is that there's no violence within the hostel walls.

APPEARANCE Built in a renovated prison, the hostel's grey bricks look stark and intimidating from the outside. Multicoloured bunting has been draped inside and out to try and cheer up the original pale walls.

LAYOUT The Hopewell Hostel makes use of the existing prison architecture. Cells are converted into small rooms, the cafeteria is in use as a central dining room, and a small garden in the yard grows fresh vegetables.

SECRET More than half of the hostel's funding comes from an anonymous donor. The donor is a local crime boss who stayed there for months as a child. They also hire muscle to protect the venue from other criminals.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • BUSY • INN

Think about how the atmosphere of a tavern might change throughout the day.

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The Waltzing Hippogriff

Open-air tavern.

KNOWN FOR Rain or shine, The Waltzing Hippogriff serves up cold brews, big smiles and live music in the open air. A rotating roster of acts draws in big crowds every weekend.

APPEARANCE A canvas awning shelters the semicircular bar and stools. Patrons lounge on crates and hay bales around a wooden stage and dance floor, lit by glowing lanterns.

SECRET Many of the realm's greatest bards started their careers at the Waltzing Hippogriff. A few still drop by for surprise performances when passing through.

BUILDING • LARGE • BUSY • TAVERN

More Taverns and Inns

1. **THE CALF AND EGG** Known for its delicious savoury pies.
2. **THE MISTY MAGPIE** Haunted inn staffed by its ghosts.
3. **THE TIPSY WEASEL** Mage-run tavern with magical drinks.
4. **THE GOLDEN SHELL** Hosts a famous siren lounge singer.
5. **IRONSHOULDER ARMS** Has pit fights in its large basement.
6. **THE BLOODY BOW** Guests get a free stay by killing rats.
7. **THE LAST STAND** Converted from an old military fort.
8. **BABEL'S BREWS** Beverages allow speech in other tongues.
9. **THE REFORMED RACCOON** Employs former criminals.
10. **THE BRIGHT SPOT** Tavern taken from the Infernal Realm.

Hotel Absentia

Mysterious motel.

The boarded-up windows, flaking paint and dark interiors don't look inviting. But the cold night air bites at your skin, and this is the only building you've seen for miles.

KNOWN FOR Just as travellers realise they're lost, they might spot a sign for the Hotel Absentia. The scent of a hot meal drifts from within, and a single lantern glows in an upstairs window. As they approach, something about the place feels odd and crooked. The staff are friendly, but no one can quite recall how long they've been here, or when they last left.

APPEARANCE The building's interior is a contradiction. From the outside, it looks like the hotel is in darkness, but candles flicker along every wallpapered corridor and room. The floral carpets are thick with dust, but footsteps don't seem to disturb it or leave prints. There are many spiralling stairs to climb, but none lead to the hotel's topmost floor.

LAYOUT The small lobby has stairs leading up to a sizeable dining room and lots of guest bedrooms. Stairs leading down to a kitchen and basement are signposted as off-limits.

LOOT The kitchen has no supplies, yet hot meals still appear. In the basement, a scruffy pile of mismatched luggage and belongings from past guests is neatly labelled as lost property.

SECRET Guests who enter the hotel become trapped in a shadowy dimension ruled by its vampire owner. They feed on some guests and turn others into their spawn to work as staff.

ENCOUNTERS

- Sudden eerie music
- Passage routes changing
- Vanishing guests
- Screaming at midnight
- Mirrors being removed
- Staff standing still

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • QUIET • INN

Giving your tavern a unique dish or drink will help your party remember it.

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Renata Patsiavos

Refined sommelier.

As you settle in for a lavish feast, Renata greets you softly. She's ready to help choose wines that will make this evening unforgettable.

KNOWN FOR Renata has a skilled nose, an encyclopedic knowledge of wines and serves patrons with a confident smile. She also runs a "Bottle of the Month" club for her fellow wine enthusiasts, delivered to their doorsteps along with her tasting notes and food pairing recommendations.

APPEARANCE Renata wears a crisp white shirt and tailored trousers, with a draped napkin to catch any stray drips. Her burgundy glasses ease her light sensitivity.

GOAL Renata dreams of visiting the faraway vineyards that she sources her exotic wines from. To pay for her trip, she has saved a small fortune in an old wine cask.

SECRET Renata once served wine at a crime boss' banquet. She fled when violence broke out, and now fears being recognised in the open.

LOOT

- Pearl-topped corkscrew
- Coin purse
- Necklace of adaptation*

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HUMAN • MERCHANT

NOBLE / PIRATE

Lucann Nightfire

Fiendish tavern owner.

KNOWN FOR Lucann takes IOUs from tavern patrons who can't pay their tab. Each signed note secretly binds their souls to him, granting Lucann terrible power in return. His victims don't realise the cost until it's too late.

APPEARANCE Lucann appears as an unremarkable human in a plain suit, carrying a briefcase of blank contracts. His true form is a slender crimson fiend with barbed bat wings and sharp horns.

GOAL Lucann has a quota of deals that he must make each quarter. In his very long lifetime, he's never missed his target, even though his fiendish bosses set it higher each time. In fifty years, he'll be in line for a promotion.

SECRET Patrons who tried to escape their contracts are held in a secret dungeon under the tavern — bodies and souls trapped for eternity. It's an awful fate, but it was outlined in Section 55.4c of the contract they signed.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • FIEND • MERCHANT

INCUBUS / HORNED DEVIL

Marijke Ossa

Gossiping bartender.

KNOWN FOR Working behind the bar means Marijke is never short of stories and gossip. If it's been a quiet day, Marijke will happily stir up fresh drama. She's known to embellish the details of stories when retelling them.

APPEARANCE Marijke's bold look demands attention. Dramatic eye make-up, heavy perfume, ornate hanging earrings and vibrant scarves make her impossible to miss. Her laugh and voice are even louder than her style.

GOAL Marijke thrives on scandal and intrigue. She writes an advice column in the local news bulletin, and dreams of penning a romance novel one day. Marijke loves hearing exciting stories, and means no harm.

SECRET Marijke's fingers are covered in glittering rings; some are real gemstones, others are fake, and one is magical. She says they're gifts from admirers, but they were actually bought by her at the jewellers' market.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • ORC • MERCHANT

TOUGH / SPY

Strangers flashing surprising amounts of gold will alert sharp-eyed tavern owners.

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Barrel Sludges

Ooze that feeds on leftover ale.

KNOWN FOR Usually found in damp tavern basements, barrel sludge is a type of miniature ooze that sneaks its way into the bottom of casks to lap up any remaining ale. Its oily secretions are very poisonous.

APPEARANCE Barrel sludges are watery, gold oozes that resemble ale; their bubbly spots are actually thousands of tiny, sucking mouths. If they slip into a keg, they may be accidentally be served to customers.

TACTICS Barrel sludges rely on camouflage, but fiercely resist being consumed themselves. Anyone who tastes a sludge, or ale from an infested barrel, becomes violently ill. The oozes' poison acts quickly and painfully.

SECRET When boiled with saffron and lemon juice by a skilled apothecary, barrel sludge can be distilled into a fragrant antitoxin. It creates a warming, delicious drink that cures even the deadliest of poisons.

CREATURE • SMALL • NEUTRAL • OOZE

GREY OOZE / OCHRE JELLY

Nana Kanata

Stern tavernkeeper.

KNOWN FOR Nana Kanata has been managing her tavern (and its regulars) for decades. Her terrifying glare shuts down most bar fights before they even begin.

APPEARANCE Nana's knitted shawl, floral apron and spectacles might lull you into thinking she's kind and cuddly. Her brass knuckledusters beg to differ.

GOAL Nana refuses to retire until she believes her children or grandchildren can run the tavern to her standards. Only then will she consider stepping aside.

SECRET Despite her tough exterior and expression, Nana adores sunflowers. Offering her a freshly picked bloom is a sure way to get on her good side.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • HALFLING • MERCHANT

BERSERKER / TOUGH BOSS

Davelin "Dash" Bushell

Prank-loving tavern regular.

KNOWN FOR An evening at the tavern is never dull if Dash is around. Regulars are too savvy to be sucked into his games, bets, competitions and pranks – so he targets newcomers instead.

APPEARANCE A tall, young man with mischievous eyes, Dash's broad smile never leaves his lips. His patchwork tunic is layered with hidden pockets, and matches the colours of the magpie feather he keeps behind his ear.

GOAL Dash rarely thinks beyond the present. He'd love to be a rich and successful magician or entertainer one day, but for now, he's content to earn a few coins in his local tavern and have some laughs along the way.

SECRET Though he acts the fool, Dash quietly sends money each month to his younger sister in the next town over to support her education. She believes it comes from his daring deeds as a heroic adventurer.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • TIEFLING • ENTERTAINER

SPY / BANDIT CAPTAIN

Félix Galileo

Artificer making tavern gadgets.

KNOWN FOR Young Félix puts his love of tinkering to good use, making gadgets for his family's bar. His inventions include a mechanical mop and crank-operated ice machine.

APPEARANCE Small for his age, Félix looks younger than his 14 years. His dark hair sticks up at odd angles, thanks to the motor grease and oil lubricant that also stains his clothes.

SECRET His latest and most ambitious invention is a small, crystal-powered hot-air balloon. He dreams of flying it to a big city and joining an artificer academy.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • GNOME • ARTISAN

Argus Allport

Shady inn concierge.

KNOWN FOR Hotel concierge Argus can put you in touch with anyone or anything, for the right price. But beware, he'll happily sell you out if someone offers him more.

APPEARANCE Argus has chiselled, attractive features, but his green eyes are cold and emotionless. His uniform has been tailored, and he wears an expensive silver signet ring.

SECRET Argus grew up in luxury as a noble's second son, but was exiled for consorting with criminals. He always preferred outlaws to his family's stuffy aristocratic friends.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • ELF • OUTLAW

Tavern staff overhear lots of conversations, so can be good sources of local lore and secrets.

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Suds

Water elemental dishwasher.

KNOWN FOR Suds is a water elemental bound by runic seals. It efficiently cleans anything placed within its metal bucket home and feeds on leftover food scraps from dishes, making it a reliable dishwasher.

APPEARANCE When inactive, Suds looks like still water sitting in a bucket. Once an item is placed inside, it stirs to life with bubbly whirlpools, swirling energetically until the object is thoroughly cleaned and spotless.

TACTICS Anyone on the wrong side of Suds will be blasted by a surge of water, or dragged into its bubbly bucket and spun around in a whirlpool. Suds is generally calm, though, and hasn't attacked kitchen staff for days.

SECRET The runic seals on Suds' bucket were washed away weeks ago, so Suds is no longer tame. However, Suds enjoys its work as a dishwasher, and has chosen to remain. It shows no desire to leave its bucket home.

CREATURE • MEDIUM • NEUTRAL • ELEMENTAL

GELATINOUS CUBE / WATER ELEMENTAL

Gina "Cat Whisker" Akiko

Brooding local assassin.

KNOWN FOR The assassin known as Cat Whisker waits alone in quiet tavern corners, watching for clients to approach. If she's not drinking in silence, she's out completing one of her deadly contracts.

APPEARANCE She wears dark, hooded robes and steel-plated leather armour; her face is hidden behind a smashed cat mask. Each of her fingers ends in a claw-like dagger that she never removes, even when eating.

GOAL Cat Whisker dreams of retiring in peace. She hopes her next job will come with a handsome enough reward that she can afford to vanish into a life totally free from violence and crime.

SECRET Cat Whisker's real name is Gina Akiko, and she's bound by a geas spell cast on her by a lamia crime boss. She fulfils contracts without question, sending all profits back to her cruel boss.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • ORC-HUMAN • OUTLAW

PIRATE CAPTAIN / ASSASSIN

Alduss Lanternshark

Magical tavern chef.

Alduss beams with joy as he fillets fish and stirs bubbling pans, lost in his craft. Ghostly arcane hands swirl around him, each expertly chopping, seasoning or plating with graceful precision.

KNOWN FOR Alduss is an award-winning chef who prepares delicate meals using aquatic ingredients; his flambéed salmon and citrus butter nigiri are to die for. Alduss prefers to work alone, and employs conjuration magic and arcane staff instead of commis chefs.

APPEARANCE This passionate satyr takes his job seriously, and never enters a kitchen in anything but his crisp, double-breasted chef whites. His horns curl back over his groomed hair, and the sweat on his brow is evidence of his hard work and focus on his active spells.

HISTORY Alduss grew up in a village that neighboured a wide river. His father was the community's cook, and taught Alduss how to fish for high-quality ingredients and turn them into seasoned meals. Alduss fell in love with cooking, and has been preparing meals ever since.

GOAL After finding fame, Alduss relocated his parents from their rural village to a comfortable estate in the city. He now caters for private events, competes in contests, and earns well — all while regularly sending food and money back to support his quaint, riverside hometown.

SECRET Alduss lacks innate spellcasting abilities. On a fishing trip years ago, he met a fey water spirit who promised him renown, riches and magic. He agreed, but now fears the spirit may ask for something in return.

LOOT

Filleting knife set	Alchemy jug*
Chef uniform	Sushi rolling mat
Soy sauce (bottle)	Dancing sword*

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • FEY • ARTISAN

SATYR / BERSERKER

Chef Alduss Lanternshark (right) conjures a team of spectral hands to help him in the kitchen.

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Naa Varjash

Draconic bartender.

KNOWN FOR Naa Varjash is a dragonborn bartender famed for using her ice breath to chill cocktails. Living on the road, she sets up in each new tavern for a few weeks at a time to craft icy, theatrical drinks for excited patrons.

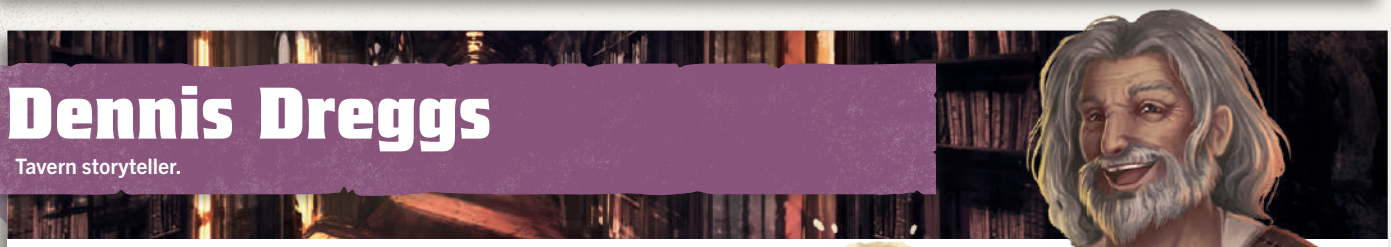
APPEARANCE Naa wears a paisley waistcoat with six gold-edged pockets. She is tall and graceful, with shimmering white scales and bright green eyes. Vials clink on her belt, and her tail curls like a coiled ribbon.

GOAL Naa wanders from tavern to tavern, learning about local delicacies and sharing her own recipes as she goes. Naa is building a menu for the dream bar she hopes to open, one that fuses mixology and magic.

SECRET Naa is from another land, but was kicked out of her country for refusing conscription. Although she has learnt to enjoy travelling, she secretly misses her family and would love to return home.

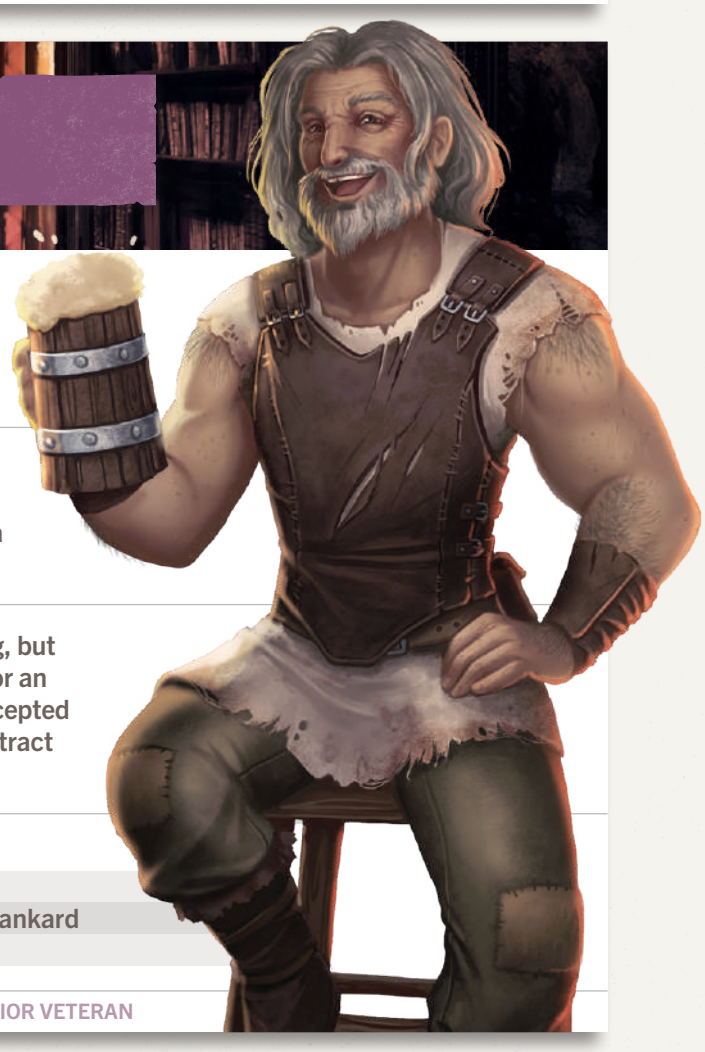
CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • DRAGONBORN • ARTISAN

PIRATE / HALF-DRAGON



Dennis Dreggs

Tavern storyteller.



Dennis waves a flagon as he relives a daring tale. His wide grin and lively storytelling quickly draw you into the crowd.

KNOWN FOR One spot at the bar is always set aside for Dennis. He is a regular at the tavern, and popular for the thrilling stories he tells of his youth. Now enjoying his retirement, he always has a tale to share, from werewolf wrangling to epic troll takedowns.

APPEARANCE Dennis' patched and well-loved clothing has clearly been on many adventures with him. Lines crinkle around his eyes as he throws back his hair and laughs.

GOAL He loves storytelling, but deep down Dennis longs for an adventure. He recently accepted a daring boar-hunting contract to prove he's still got it.

SECRET Dennis has an emerald amulet hidden in his boot. He was supposed to return it to a goblin royal, but never got around to it.

LOOT

- Breastplate*
- Initial-engraved drinking tankard
- Emerald amulet

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HUMAN • ENTERTAINER

TOUGH / WARRIOR VETERAN

Kaikor Tierhelfer

Tavern keeper with animal helpers.

KNOWN FOR Tavern keeper Kaikor relies on his animal companions to keep an eye out for trouble. A mastiff sniffs patrons as they walk in, a crow watches for thieves and pickpockets, and a fox stops people lurking out back.

APPEARANCE Kaikor slouches his shoulders and walks with shuffling feet. He mumbles when asked a question and focuses on wiping down the bar. A ferret peeks out from the neck of his thick woolly hat.

GOAL Unusually for a tavern keeper, Kaikor doesn't particularly enjoy talking to customers, or other staff. He prefers the company of animals and would one day like to convert the tavern into an animal sanctuary.

SECRET Kaikor lost trust in his humanoid staff after catching his chef stealing from the cash box. He now does the cooking himself, with help from a family of rats. The rodents' involvement isn't shared with diners.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • GNOLL • MERCHANT

SCOUT / DRUID

Make a tavern feel like home with a group of regulars; this could include your favourite NPCs from previous quests.

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Santiago Plunkett

Fashionable inn ghost.

KNOWN FOR This spirit haunts the inn's upper floors. He tries on any clothing that catches his eye; guests should be wary of leaving their bags, or they'll come back to their room and find Santiago twirling in their best cloak.

APPEARANCE Santiago's ghostly form is translucent, so he seeks out bold colours in the clothes he steals. His look depends on who is staying, but his keen eye is drawn to patterned or embellished fabrics.

GOAL In life, Santiago was a professional tailor and costume designer. In death, he's still driven to finish his masterpiece: dazzling costumes for a fey ballet. He insists he's not a thief, just a collector.

SECRET He keeps a hidden wardrobe in a forgotten section of the attic above the tavern. Stolen garments spin on spectral mannequins, and each one is labelled for a character in his ballet production.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • UNDEAD • ARTISAN

SPECTRE / GHOST

Amblin Halbert

Magical luggage porter.

KNOWN FOR Luggage items of all sizes can be transported by Amblin and her magical, bottomless trolley. Some cases do go missing now and then though.

APPEARANCE Amblin's smart uniform is creased, and her round cap is totally askew. She looks like she's had back-to-back long shifts and hasn't slept.

GOAL Amblin is working double shifts to save up money for her magic tutor. She can't afford the pricey lessons, but has enrolled on the course anyway.

SECRET The disappearing luggage is the fault of giant moth creatures living in her trolley. They feed on items placed inside and are growing bigger each day.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HUMAN • LABOURER

MAGE APPRENTICE / MAGE

Antimon Harpweather

Novelist tavern owner.

KNOWN FOR Antimon bought a tavern to use as a writing sanctuary. He intended it to be a brief distraction, but he's been here for 10 years, living comfortably off the fortune inherited from his mother.

APPEARANCE Antimon is a dapper gentleman with a curling moustache and black apron. He often has ink on his hands, and spends his time writing in the candlelit corners of the tavern while his bar staff see to customers.

GOAL Above all, Antimon longs to finish his novel's final draft and see it published. Worries that his writing isn't good enough hold him back from finding the satisfying ending his story needs.

SECRET If read, Antimon's crime fiction novel reveals a thinly veiled, accurate record of the rich Harpweather family's dealings with shady gangs. Such knowledge could be priceless to the local law enforcement.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • GOLIATH • ARTISAN

NOBLE / PIRATE CAPTAIN

Swarm of Crackle Bugs

Glowing bed bugs.

KNOWN FOR The scourge of all second-rate taverns, crackle bugs nest in moist old mattresses. When the lights are turned out, the bugs start to glow, swarm and bite.

APPEARANCE Smaller than a fingernail, these critters are invisible in daylight. At night, they shine with dazzling white and blue light. Their powerful little jaws clamp onto skin.

SECRET A crackle bug infestation is hard to shift. If the swarm is attacked, some bugs will hide in nearby clothing and continue to plague their owners for days to come.

CREATURE • MEDIUM • NEUTRAL • BEAST

More Tavern Customers

1. MAXIM FORD Cursed bard who can only sing, never speak.
2. CERID LANWILL Drunk mayoral candidate asking for votes.
3. MAURY MILLER Fortune-teller who reads the foam on beer.
4. GARLIC Resident tavern dog who follows anyone with food.
5. KIP LEAFYEAR Runs card games in the tavern's attic.
6. WEN DARKAND Mercenary fighter looking for new allies.
7. ELOIS DECOUR Local noble, come to observe "peasant life".
8. TELVAR HURKWATER Pickpocket pretending to clear tables.
9. BILBERT GHENT Thatcher and aspiring stand-up comedian.
10. FUDLARK WEEL Salesperson from a local brewery.

Any of the NPCs in this book could be staying at the same inn as your party.

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Cloud Galleon

Unpredictable hot-air balloon.

A proud flying galleon bursts from behind a cloud, held aloft by a balloon. It suddenly drops, swaying wildly before regaining its balance.

KNOWN FOR For generations, the Cloud Galleon has been popular with townsfolk and travellers who want to admire bird's eye views over the region, or need a romantic setting to profess undying affection to their lover. In its day, the balloon is said to have flown higher than any airship in history.

APPEARANCE A badly weatherworn balloon hoists a galleon-shaped, wooden basket. The ship sails through the sky, bobbing with air currents and sudden movements of its passengers.

LAYOUT The basket comfortably holds 20 people plus picnic supplies. It also carries the pilot's tools and a burner system, which heats the air for the balloon.

LOOT An onboard toolbox holds a barometer and altimeter. The burner system is an arcane flamethrower powered by evocation magic.

SECRET One part of the complex burner system is faulty. It works most days, but could fail at any time and cause the balloon to plummet.

VEHICLE • SMALL • BUSY • VENUE

Magical Marionettes

Enchanted puppet theatre.

KNOWN FOR The acclaimed Magical Marionettes show uses invisibility magic to conceal its puppeteers. Their performances captivate children and sceptical adults alike.

APPEARANCE A painted stage unfolds from an unassuming crate, along with five puppets: a stubborn princess, a foolish king, an evil dragon, a clever donkey and an ogre paladin.

SECRET The puppeteers enjoy staying invisible after the show to eavesdrop on the crowd's honest reviews. One has been known to trip up those who make fun of the show.

BUILDING • SMALL • OVERCROWDED • SHOW

The Pyramid

Multi-level fighting arena.

KNOWN FOR The Pyramid is the site of a brutal annual fist-fighting tournament. Combatants race their way to the top of its many steps, battling obstacles and each other as they go.

APPEARANCE The Pyramid has six segmented stone levels. Crowds root for and bet on their favourites, cheering on the bloodshed from the surrounding amphitheatre-style seats.

SECRET The obstacles on each layer of the arena change annually. Plans for the next event, including a complete competitor list, are held in a vault under the Pyramid.

BUILDING • LARGE • OVERCROWDED • VENUE

Speaker's Post

Busking spot for entertainers.

KNOWN FOR Orators, bards, poets and musicians wait by this plinth for their chance to perform. Crowds ebb and flow as locals stop to listen, but quickly move on if they get bored.

APPEARANCE The old oak plinth stands proudly in the town square, with no need of signage or decoration. Its surface has been worn smooth by years of constant use.

SECRET Over time, hundreds of passionate orators have infused Speaker's Post with energy. It makes performers feel stronger and more confident whenever they step onto it.

BUILDING • SMALL • BUSY • SITE

Purity Well

Judgemental wishing well.

KNOWN FOR Travellers come from all over to throw a gold coin into this well and make a wish. Legend says the waters spit the coin back out at those with truly good intentions.

APPEARANCE This eroded stone well is so deep that its water is hidden from view. A rusted bucket and chain draw fresh water with a faint metallic tang.

SECRET While it is believed to be magical, the well returns coins completely at random. There is a gravitational anomaly in the well that boomerangs back roughly one in 50 coins.

BUILDING • SMALL • QUIET • SITE

Your party could visit an attraction to blow off steam after completing a quest.

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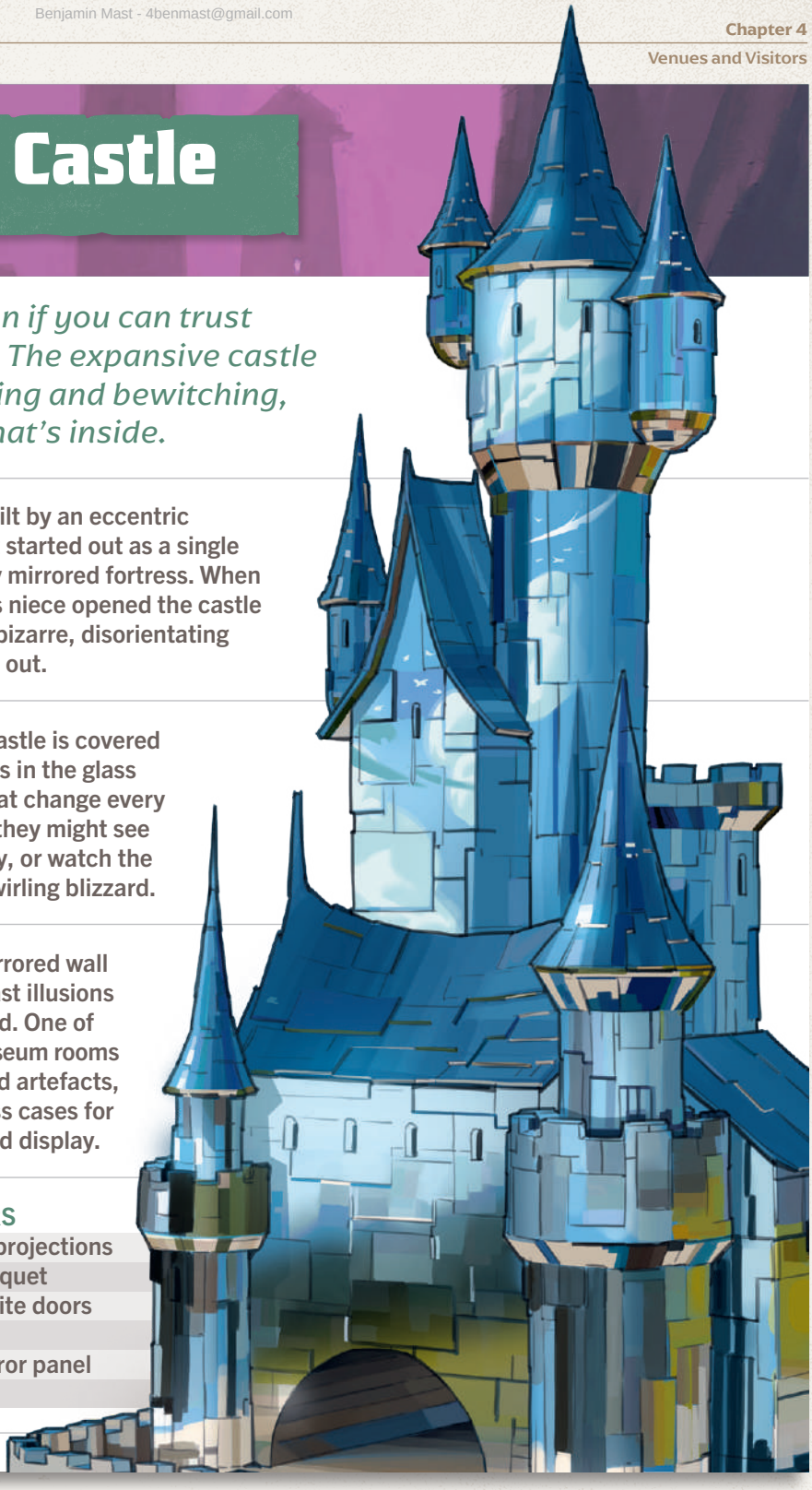
The Curiosity Castle

Illusory house of mirrors.



As you approach, you question if you can trust your eyesight, or your sanity. The expansive castle of mirrors is equally bewildering and bewitching, and you can't help wonder what's inside.

KNOWN FOR The Curiosity Castle was built by an eccentric aristocrat for their own amusement. What started out as a single hall of mirrors, eventually grew into a fully mirrored fortress. When the aristocrat passed away years later, his niece opened the castle to the public. Now, anyone can enjoy the bizarre, disorientating wonder of the Curiosity Castle, inside and out.

APPEARANCE The outside of Curiosity Castle is covered with mirrored panels. However, the images in the glass are enhanced with magical projections that change every hour. Depending on when visitors watch, they might see a mighty dragon swooping through the sky, or watch the environment be blanketed by a sudden swirling blizzard.

LAYOUT The castle's ballroom holds a vast mirror maze, and smaller rooms display comical reflections. One turret functions as a giant walk-in kaleidoscope.

LOOT The mirrored wall panels still cast illusions when removed. One of the many museum rooms holds mirrored artefacts, locked in glass cases for protection and display.

SECRET The mirrors absorb thoughts from those who linger in the castle for too long. They sometimes show the viewer other visitors' forgotten memories.

ENCOUNTERS

- Magical wall projections
- Ballroom banquet
- Room of infinite doors
- Lost guests
- Smashed mirror panel
- Mimic chests

BUILDING • LARGE • BUSY • VENUE

Windhold Aerodrome

Arena for flying broom sports.

KNOWN FOR This octagonal aerodrome is the top venue for competitive broom sports. It hosts everything from speed trials and endurance relays to aerial obstacle courses and fast-paced airborne team games.

APPEARANCE During a racing event, the Windhold Aerodrome is packed with excited supporters in bright jerseys and scarves. Vendors hawk souvenirs and the venue's signature snack — cheese-dunked breadsticks.

LAYOUT The sleek, angular stadium has an open roof. Wealthier spectators sit in raised stands around the flying circuit, while others lay on picnic blankets in the grassy central oval to gaze up at the action.

SECRET Ticket sales are slowing, forcing management to expand beyond broom sport. Pegasus chariot races, a levitating circus, and flying carpet conventions are all on next year's packed-out calendar.

BUILDING • LARGE • OVERCROWDED • VENUE

Have festivals, superstitions or pilgrimages tied to the attraction so it feels integrated into the wider world.

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Fountain of Worlds

Tiered elemental fountain.

KNOWN FOR The towering Fountain of Worlds was built to honour a historic peace treaty. Its grandeur draws visitors from across the world to marvel at its elemental beauty.

APPEARANCE At the fountain's top, lava jets pour onto stone, and crystals are formed. The crystals vanish into a whirlwind suspended above a water-filled pool.

SECRET Beneath the fountain's pool lies the slumbering heart of a primordial elemental. The fountain's cycles of lava, crystal, wind and water keep the being dormant.

BUILDING • SMALL • BUSY • SITE

Old Livibell Street

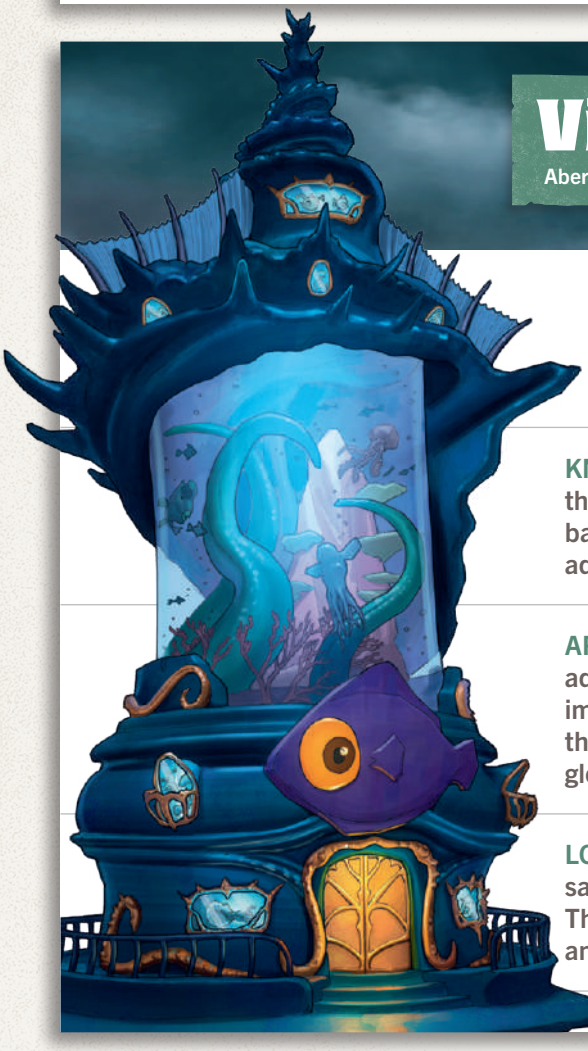
Interactive history site.

KNOWN FOR Old Livibell Street is a restored row of homes and shops based on a distant time period. Visitors can interact with actors who tell stories of life long ago.

APPEARANCE The cobbled streets and wooden houses are full of historical artefacts, some authentic, some well-made replicas. Visitors can pay extra to hire period costumes.

SECRET An actor working behind the bar in the street's tavern is a stranded time-traveller. Unable to get back to their period, they find this site a welcome reminder of home.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • BUSY • VENUE



Viltanks Aquarium

Aberration aquarium.

As you pass the tank, a slick tentacle taps the glass. A huge shadow shifts, then an unblinking, monstrous eye emerges from the murky depths.

KNOWN FOR Viltanks Aquarium houses creatures that normally lurk in the deepest and darkest recesses of the ocean. Visitors should respect the barriers that stop them from getting too close to the tanks; some of the aquarium's residents can hypnotise in-range prey.

APPEARANCE Most of the vast aquarium lies deep underground, immersing visitors in a world under the surface. Lanterns cast a dim glow over the curved glass tanks.

LAYOUT A central tank runs from the surface through all the aquarium's lower floors. Passages lead to smaller exhibit halls and cordoned-off staff access areas.

LOOT Specimens and scientific samples are secured in a locked lab. The gift shop sells branded shirts and novelty hats with purple fins.

SECRET A young aboleth has disappeared, and is hiding in another tank. It is attempting to recruit an army of fishy followers.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • QUIET • VENUE

The Ferris Flow

Floating river carnival.

KNOWN FOR Every autumn, the Ferris Flow carnival parade drifts through town. It's a flotilla of games, performances and food stalls run by guilds and travelling troupes.

APPEARANCE Each boat in the flotilla is festooned with lights and fluttering flags. When docked, the boats are roped together and planks laid to create wobbly walkways.

SECRET Fed-up merfolk plan to sabotage this year's Ferris Flow parade in retaliation for rubbish dropped by carnival goers. Mediation is urgently needed before things escalate.

VEHICLE • MID-SIZED • OVERCROWDED • SHOW

More Entertainment Venues

1. **SIREN'S SONG HALL** Opera house with a merfolk chorus.
2. **ELDTREE ARCHIVE** Museum of the land's natural history.
3. **THE MOLTEN RUSH** Roller coaster that circles a volcano.
4. **BLOODTUSK COLOSSEUM** Towering gladiatorial arena.
5. **BYGONE INSTITUTE** Morbid display of necromantic curios.
6. **HERO SQUARE** Street performers busk next to real statues.
7. **SALON ROUGE** Candlelit cabaret venue run by vampires.
8. **STONEBEARD STADIUM** Hosts strength-based contests.
9. **THUNDERSTRIDE CIRCUIT** Racecourse for magical beasts.
10. **COLOSSUS PLAYHOUSE** Home of classical giant theatre.

Describe whether the venue is well maintained, or past its prime. How does that make your players feel about their visit?

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Society of Celestial Tribute

Troupe of live action role-players.

KNOWN FOR This group of live action role-players attracts crowds to their reenactments of ancient battles. They dress as celestial warriors and their fiendish foes, and perform real magic during shows.

GOAL The Society of Celestial Tribute has transformed their passion project into a thriving business. They vow to reinvest all profits to increase the show's production value, and honour the sacred history they commemorate.

FEATURE Members wear accurate, sometimes original, luminescent armour and wield weapons modelled on legendary artefacts. In battle scenes, celestial characters wear blue robes, while fiends are clad in striking crimson.

SECRET True angelic beings know of the Society's existence, and even sit in disguise within the audience. If they are particularly impressed by a performer, they may offer them a sacred quest in earnest.

FACTION • MEDIUM (20–49) • NEUTRAL • ENTERTAINMENT

Dustin "Crestal" Coalbarrel

Bard on a record-breaking tour.

KNOWN FOR Crestal's epic love ballads have gained him an army of fans around the world. He has been performing sold-out shows on tour for two hundred years.

APPEARANCE Crestal's fans believe his dwarven features just get better with age. They swoon as he swaggers on stage in his trademark tight leather vest.

GOAL Crestal wants to be the longest-touring bard in history. He has two months of shows to go before he smashes the record, and can finally take a vacation.

SECRET Crestal's security team plans to kidnap him after his next show, demanding the tour's profits as a ransom.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • DWARF • ENTERTAINER

PERFORMER / MAGE

Remscal Perce

Fiendish ticket tout.

KNOWN FOR Remscal can get tickets to any event his patrons might desire, but he sells them at horrifically inflated prices, or for a favour. Remscal's calculating, wicked mind is as sharp as his greedy, clawed fingers.

APPEARANCE Long, hooded black robes disguise most of Remscal's form. Glinting bronze fangs and claws catch the light as he reaches out from the cloak to seize someone's coin or shake on a deal.

GOAL Remscal buys tickets in large quantities from box offices and sells them for a huge profit. For him, this fulfils two diabolical goals: making people unhappy, and getting filthy rich in the process.

SECRET Centuries ago, Remscal experimented with living a mortal life and fell in love with a playwright. She was killed, and so he cursed the arts in a rage. He swore out of spite to strangle happiness from the industry.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • FIEND • MERCHANT

NIGHT HAG / BONE DEVIL

Roaring Boars

Competitive jousting squad.

KNOWN FOR The Roaring Boars are used to dominating their jousting league. However, poor performances at their last two tournaments could see them relegated this season.

GOAL The Boars are desperate to avoid demotion from the league. Ideally, they'd also like to stop their bitter rivals, the Gallant Griffons, from seizing this year's trophy.

SECRET The Boars' loyal squire, Jeffrey, has been lacing the squad's drinks with confusion potions. He's accepted a bribe and the promise of new job from the Gallant Griffons.

FACTION • MEDIUM (20–49) • FRIENDLY • ENTERTAINMENT

Pennyspinner

Fairground octopus who tells fortunes.

KNOWN FOR Curious revellers can slip Pennyspinner a coin and ask her a question about the future. She places the coin in one of three glass jars labelled "yes", "no" and "maybe".

APPEARANCE This elderly octopus lives in a spacious tank decorated with plants and crystals. Her long, dexterous tentacles are deep orange with pale yellow suckers.

SECRET Pennyspinner does have slight telepathy, which helps her to read customers' emotions. This impacts the jar she chooses, making her more accurate than expected.

CREATURE • SMALL • FRIENDLY • BEAST

Can your party do a better job than these entertainers? Have players roll a performance check and find out!

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Wilborn Stoutstump

Small but mighty strongman.

KNOWN FOR Wilborn comes from a long line of circus performers. His small gnomish body is much stronger than it appears. He can crush boulders with his bare hands, and juggle his much larger co-workers with ease.

APPEARANCE If you count his spiky black hair, Wilborn just about grazes three feet in height. He wears a bright red unitard cinched with a thick leather belt. The belt's silver buckle is shaped like a clenched fist.

GOAL Wilborn upholds the Stoutstump weightlifting legacy with pride. A beloved strongman and household name, he regularly invents new feats to thrill crowds, and dreams of one day passing the spotlight to his children.

SECRET Wilborn's disproportionate strength comes from his magical belt, which has been passed down through his family. Once he passes it to his oldest child, the belt's magic will become unusable to him forever.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • GNOME • ENTERTAINER

TOUGH / TOUGH BOSS

Rhoda McFadden

Bulette rodeo rider.

KNOWN FOR Forget bucking broncos and bulls, Rhoda raises the rodeo bar by riding a bucking bulette. To the audience's delight, she expertly clings to the creature's back as it leaps through the air and through the dirt.

APPEARANCE Rhoda is tall, with muscular arms and legs. She's deeply tanned with a spray of freckles across her face. Beneath her wide-brimmed hat, her blonde hair is worn braided into two twin plaits.

GOAL Rhoda wants to use her performances to spread an important message about bulette conservation. After the show, she returns the bulette to its enclosure, and invites the audience to come and learn more about it.

SECRET Rhoda got lost in the wild as a toddler and was raised by a herd of bulettes. She has vague memories of being protected in their tunnels as a child, and still occasionally hums their low, rumbling lullabies.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HUMAN • ENTERTAINER

BERSERKER / GLADIATOR

Maximus Wylde

Daredevil stunt performer.

Rising from the crash net, Max licks two fingers and extinguishes the flame at the tip of his moustache. He spins and gives a deep bow to the cheering crowds.

KNOWN FOR Performing as "Max Velocity", this daredevil stunt artist amazes crowds with his human cannonball act. There are runes inside his cannon that blast out force and fire magic for spectacular explosions, as Max soars dramatically overhead.

APPEARANCE Max is a dashing figure with a handlebar moustache. As well as a costume tabard and cape, he dons a dented helmet and a few pieces of leather padding.

GOAL Max is planning his riskiest stunt yet, "the Triple" – being fired between three cannons, then landing flawlessly without a safety net.

SECRET Max mistakenly thinks a lucky coin protects him from death. He doesn't know a ring gifted by his daughter actually contains wards.

LOOT

- Leather armour*
- Lucky platinum coin
- Ring of fire resistance*

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HUMAN • ENTERTAINER

GUARD / MAGE

How long has your NPC been performing, and what was their life like before they stepped into the spotlight?

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Vox Regnum

State-sponsored bards.

KNOWN FOR Vox Regnum, or "the kingdom's voice", is a prestigious, state-run bardic guild. They sing government-approved songs of the kingdom's greatest rulers and heroes.

GOAL The guild entertain citizens and visitors with songs that paint the kingdom in a favourable light. Inspiring loyalty and patriotism is the goal, not necessarily telling the truth.

SECRET Vox Regnum members who defy official narratives vanish, are quietly reassigned to a faraway region, or are discovered days later with wiped memories.

FACTION • LARGE (50–99) • NEUTRAL • ENTERTAINMENT

Onyx Security

Event security professionals.

KNOWN FOR This team of security guards specialises in managing event crowds. They wear sleek black armour and use discreet short-range sending stones to communicate.

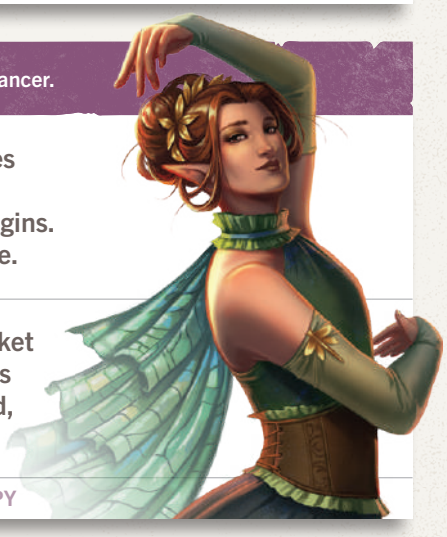
GOAL However small the event, Onyx Security takes its job deadly seriously. Their reputation is of the utmost importance to the company's founder. Mistakes are not an option.

SECRET Onyx Security's founder used to be a knight. They were stripped of their title after being unfairly blamed for failing to prevent the assassination of a noble.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • NEUTRAL • MILITARY

Elodie Wildwish

Enchanting fey ballet dancer.



KNOWN FOR This fey ballet dancer is able to lull watching mortals into a deep calm through her movements. Her performances receive glowing reviews.

APPEARANCE In her gold accessories and iridescent emerald dress, Elodie draws eyes even before her dance begins. She moves with a truly hypnotic grace.

GOAL After being deemed "average" in her native Fey Realm, Elodie was driven to seek out more appreciative audiences. She lives for acclaim and applause.

SECRET Elodie works with a pickpocket accomplice. The thief snatches jewels and purses from the entranced crowd, then splits the takings with Elodie.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • ELF • ENTERTAINER

PERFORMER / SPY

Stygian Hounds

Infernal canines.

KNOWN FOR These smouldering, infernal canines are feared creatures in the underground dogfighting circuit. They are much bigger than other mastiffs, and they breathe intense white-blue flames.

APPEARANCE Stygian hounds are as large as wolves with tough, matted fur that looks like chunks of cooled lava. When they are about to breathe fire, their bony chests glow with hot light.

TACTICS In the wild, stygian hounds follow the cues of their pack alpha. When used in pit fighting, they follow the commands of their owner. Their incredibly strong oversized jaws can clamp down and restrain foes.

SECRET These hounds are extremely loyal to their leader, following orders and protecting them with their lives. If their leader is defeated, the dog's allegiance quickly switches to the being who bested them.

CREATURE • MEDIUM • HOSTILE • FIEND

WOLF / HELL HOUND

More Performers

1. FERNANDO IRONHIDE Undefeated minotaur wrestler.
2. THE 4SWORN Popular knight-themed boy band.
3. COVE SPIZZLESPARK Actor with shape-shifting abilities.
4. ZAMP VANOLA Dancer with a career-threatening injury.
5. NELLIE IFORMA Commentator with enchanted megaphone.
6. THON BOZGAR Famous chef who gives live demonstrations.
7. YELPHR KEELING Disgruntled and petty backing singer.
8. MORDRAM BROADKIND Comic who riffs on adventuring life.
9. MAYDAY FINCH Political bard who writes protest songs.
10. THADEUS DROGON Fire-breathing burlesque performer.

Gigglebiz the Clown

Undead zombie juggler.

KNOWN FOR Gigglebiz is one of six performers created by a necromancer ringmaster for a circus of the undead. He shuffles around juggling eyeballs, brains and other organs.

APPEARANCE He is bald, except for a tuft of bright red hair at the centre of his rotting scalp. Gigglebiz's open torso can be seen through a ripped red-and-white harlequin costume.

SECRET Gigglebiz rallied the undead performers against the necromancer, killing him with his own magic. Now, the ringleader's flaming skull performs in the circus as well.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • UNDEAD • ENTERTAINER

Check out pp. 196–200 for castles and other grand entertainment venues.

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Intrinity Trapeze

Triplet acrobat troupe.

KNOWN FOR Intrininty Trapeze are a world-famous trio of aerial acrobats. Each silver-clad triplet swings, leaps and tumbles through the air, putting full trust in their siblings.

GOAL Chasing fame, Intrininty Trapeze seek out larger stages. They constantly push their daring stunts further to dazzle and captivate every audience they perform for.

SECRET The act isn't actually a trio. There are 10 cousins who switch in and out to increase the speed of the show. The stand-ins hide in the wings in case of falls or injuries.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • FRIENDLY • ENTERTAINMENT

Rik Goduard

Actor and wannabe detective.

KNOWN FOR Rik is a successful touring actor famed for playing Inspector Victor Twedston, a genius detective. The Inspector is the lead in a series of popular mystery plays.

APPEARANCE Rik always wears his costume, a tweed suit in a lurid shade of lime-green, and carries a prop pipe. Sweat causes thick stage make-up to slip down his cheeks.

SECRET Rik has spent so long playing a detective, he thinks he is one. He's convinced his theatre manager to let him investigate backstage thefts rather than calling in guards.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HALFLING • ENTERTAINER

Ellien Wrensen

Spiteful fey artist.

The artist welcomes you with a flamboyant wave of his cap. His billowing white sleeves are rolled up, revealing paint-streaked arms. He wipes his hands on a rag before offering one with a warm smile.

KNOWN FOR This charming painter travels with fairs and circuses selling small sketches as souvenirs of the event. However, Ellien's drawings hold a dark secret. He uses the captured image to drain the life out of the model, in order to maintain his own youthful looks.

APPEARANCE Ellien uses magic to present himself as a young, handsome human man with lustrous dark hair and a shy smile. Beneath this alluring illusion, Ellien's true form is that of a green-skinned hag, with long yellow fingernails, rotten teeth and straggly white hair.

GOAL Bent on looking young forever, Ellien constantly seeks out new victims. He never stays with one troupe for more than a few weeks. He also creates a different disguise for each new job, so rumours of his deception rarely catch up with him.

HISTORY Ellien practised magic as part of a hag coven, until he drained all of their power for himself. Portraits of his old coven hang on ropes in his tent. If asked, he tearfully claims he was kidnapped by a hag in childhood and paints to deal with lingering bad dreams.

SECRET Ellien cannot be truly defeated until each and every piece of his artwork is destroyed. Ellien's victims grow increasingly exhausted after being drawn, and can only be saved when the art of them is set on fire.

LOOT

Paintings of green hags	Mirror of life trapping*
Marvellous pigments*	Spare parchment
Painter's supplies*	Fine clothes*

SOULPAINTER
Small or Medium Fey

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
12 (+1)	13 (+1)	14 (+2)	11 (+0)	12 (+1)	18 (+4)

Armour Class: 15
Hit Points: 48 (8d8 + 16)
Speed: 30 ft
Initiative: +1

Saving Throws: CHA +6
Skills: Deception +8, Insight +3, Persuasion +6
Immunities: Charmed, Frightened, Poisoned
Senses: Darkvision 60 ft
Passive Perception: 11
Languages: Common, Elvish, Sylvan
Proficiency Bonus: +2

ABILITIES

Magic Resistance. The soulpainter has advantage on saving throws against spells and magical effects.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The soulpainter makes two Paintbrush Swipe attacks.

Paintbrush Swipe. Melee Weapon Attack: +3 to hit, reach 5 ft, one target. Hit: 5 (1d8 + 1) slashing damage plus 10 (3d6) poison damage.

Still Life Sketch (Recharge 6). The soulpainter chooses a creature that it can see within 30 ft. The target must succeed on a Wisdom saving throw (DC 14) or become a sketch and have the Paralyzed condition for 1 minute. At the end of each of its turns, the target repeats the save, ending the spell on itself on a success.

Spellcasting. The soulpainter casts one of the following spells, using Charisma as the spellcasting ability (spell save DC 14, +6 to hit with spell attacks):

At Will: *Bane, Dancing Lights, Disguise Self*

1/Day Each: *Hypnotic Pattern, Major Image, Summon Fey*

CHALLENGE RATING 4

You could alternatively use the stats of a Satyr CR 1/4, Green Hag CR 3 or Djinni CR 11.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • FEY • ENTERTAINER

Ellien Wrensen (right) prepares for his next commission, surrounded by clues to his true identity.

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The Chocolate Cauldron

Shop made from chocolate.

The intoxicating scent of molten chocolate around the shop hints at the delicious treats within. The exterior looks good enough to eat.

KNOWN FOR The Chocolate Cauldron specialises in sweets disguised as everyday objects – coins, keys, toys and even weapons. The shop itself is impressively built from chocolate bricks and other delicious, edible construction materials.

APPEARANCE The brown roof tiles and bricks are chocolate, the white walls are nougat, and the delicate windows are spun sugar.

LAYOUT The shop floor has a counter and shelving to display specials. Cocoa and sugar are in the basement, and the kitchen is upstairs.

LOOT Sticky-fingered thieves might target the chocolate stock, or valuable tools like the shop's famous golden cauldron.

SECRET Magical chocolate rabbits and marshmallow mice are kept in a cupboard labelled "Not For Sale".

BUILDING • SMALL • FOOD • SHOP

Rainbow Renaissance Market

Second-hand clothing market.

KNOWN FOR Popular with fashion-forward folk who love a bargain, each of these clothing stalls only sell items of one colour. They are strictly arranged in rainbow order.

APPEARANCE Each stall is overflowing with garments in different styles, sizes and fabrics, but all in shades of the same colour. Canvas awnings match the goods on sale.

SECRET The owner of the red stall quietly spreads rumours about the violet stall. They claim the violet fabrics are enchanted to cause misfortune and their dyes fade quickly.

BUILDING • LARGE • CLOTHING • MARKET

Porcelain Hollow

Shop with unsettling dolls.

KNOWN FOR Children hurry past this toy shop, averting their eyes from its dusty window and the dolls that sit inside. Despite a lack of visitors, the shop remains open every day.

APPEARANCE Stepping through the creaky door reveals a maze of locked cabinets, filled with dolls and puppets. The toys' unblinking, realistic eyes follow customers around.

SECRET Porcelain Hollow is a museum of former customers transformed by the shop's owner into dolls. They sit still, waiting for powerful restoration magic to break the spell.

BUILDING • SMALL • TOYS • SHOP

Letterheads

Calligraphy supply shop.

KNOWN FOR Maps, family trees, spell scrolls – if it's made out of parchment, Letterheads sell it. Or, they would if its artisans weren't buried by new commissions. Opening hours are currently limited to reduce orders.

APPEARANCE Situated above other shops, Letterheads has no shop window to promote their goods. A striking hand-lettered sign hangs above a locked door, along with a heavy bronze bell to ring for entry.

LAYOUT The shop floor is lined with heavy wooden cabinets, full of flat drawers to store unfolded maps. Work desks in the middle of the room are illuminated by magic lanterns, as flames are expressly forbidden.

SECRET The owners make time for adventurers who can provide them with new information for their maps. Those with inside knowledge of the area's caverns and castles may be rewarded with unique spell scrolls.

BUILDING • SMALL • CRAFTS • SHOP

Markets are noisy and chaotic. Use smells, snippets of conversation and calls from vendors to immerse the party.

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Sorcerer's Stockpile

Wizarding supply shop.

Antique oak tables groan under the weight of textbooks, stacked in tall, orderly columns. Hand-lettered signs advertise bulk deals on parchment and free quills with every purchase.

KNOWN FOR A trip to Sorcerer's Stockpile is an exciting rite of passage for any beginner spellcaster. Its reliable products and reasonable prices make it the perfect place to stock up on components, wands, staves, blank spellbooks and other magical necessities. Knowledgeable attendants in navy waistcoats are happy to help young or uncertain customers find what they need.

APPEARANCE Despite being crammed with stock, everything in this quaint, orange-bricked building is organised and clearly signed. Items rarely stay on the shelves long enough to collect dust, and the whole shop smells of new parchment. Behind the tills, glass cabinets keep gemstone dust, crystal orbs, enchanted figurines and other curios tantalisingly out of reach.

LAYOUT A brass elevator takes customers between floors. Potion supplies are stored safely in the cool cellar, while rarer arcane textbook rentals are tucked away in the attic.

LOOT The shop's inventory includes books, writing tools, potion-brewing tools and basic ingredients. There is also a limited supply of expensive spell components and rare spell scrolls.

SECRET The Sorcerer's Stockpile is warded. Any thefts trigger deafening alarms, and squawking books fly away if handled by anyone with bad or mischievous intentions.

ENCOUNTERS

- Magic tutoring class
- Visiting wizard celebrity
- Long queues during a sale
- Wand malfunctions
- Loose owl in the attic
- Book club lock-in

BUILDING • LARGE • MAGIC ITEMS • SHOP

Oca Garden Post

Plant and flower market.

KNOWN FOR The Oca Garden Post is the best place to shop for plants and flowers, whether you're looking for a bridal bouquet, a floral gift, tree saplings or a pack of seeds.

APPEARANCE The market is a permanent fixture, with an expansive glass greenhouse roof. Many of the stalls have brick-built storefronts with carved wooden signs.

SECRET Some sellers offer illegal carnivorous plants and toxic toadstools. They only sell to buyers who know their stall's password, to avoid trouble with the authorities.

BUILDING • LARGE • PLANTS • MARKET

Scythe and Dagger

Dangerous weapon shop.

KNOWN FOR Scythe and Dagger's lethal wares are only available to registered customers. Two references, a deposit and a thorough search by a guard are required before entry.

APPEARANCE This angular tower has a thick metal door and no windows. Inside, weapons are stored in locked cabinets secured with heavy chains and padlocks.

SECRET Weapons possess sentient magic and quietly judge their wielders. Blades go blunt and bows refuse to be drawn if they deem their wielder unworthy or dangerous.

BUILDING • SMALL • WEAPONS • SHOP

Find magical staff for an arcane shop on pp. 223–225.

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Oxcart Exchange

Market made from disused wagons.

The market before you is unlike any other. Towering stacks of wagons create multistorey shops, cleverly balanced and tightly packed. Vendors call out, proudly displaying their curious wares to passing visitors.

Key Stats

Function	Commercial
Size	10 acres
Capacity	40,000
Crowd Density	Packed
Noise Level	Loud
Proprietor	Multiple
Prices	Cheap
Amenities	Stalls, seating, takeaway food

KNOWN FOR The Oxcart Exchange (commonly referred to as the "Oxchange") is a large, multistorey market built around a central courtyard. Each trader operates from one of the modular retail units, constructed from reengineered wagons and stacked freighting carts. Some stalls face out onto the busy trade roads, and others face into the heaving central courtyard. Vendors come and go, so there's always something new to discover.

APPEARANCE Each market vendor is free to decorate their stall however they like, which makes the Oxchange a kaleidoscope of colour. Fluttering bunting is strung from cart to cart, bright logos are painted on the pathways, and steam rising from sizzling grilled meat gives the enclosed areas a savoury-smelling haze. A cobbled courtyard sits in the centre of the crowded market, where the public can rest on bench seating and enjoy their purchases.

INHABITANTS There really is a stall for everything in the Oxchange, making it a hit with both locals and tourists. City locals love the market because it serves as a lively community hub, and the affordable produce and unique handmade goods beat what's on offer at the larger established stores. Tourists love the market because they can sample local spices and delicacies, find rare trinkets and curiosities, and enjoy the performers and street entertainers.

HISTORY It's hard to believe but the Oxcart Exchange began as a simple wagon repair shop. Years ago, a local gnome named Harold Skiddlewick was fixing broken cartwheels out of his ramshackle garage. To attract more customers, he converted an old oxcart into a makeshift shop, where his brother Filchin started selling grilled squirrel kebabs. The idea caught on, and soon merchants were requesting retail units of their own. The brothers built more stalls, and the Oxchange has grown ever since.

LANDMARKS If you're new to the Oxchange, there are a few eye-catching spots that you shouldn't miss. If you enter from the east side, you'll be welcomed in by wooden statues of the Skiddlewick brothers, the market's founders. For a great viewpoint, climb the rainbow steps in the south side up to the rooftop balcony. The central courtyard can be busy, but it's the perfect place to enjoy the street entertainers and eat your food.

Squirrel kebabs are just one of the delicacies you'll find in the Oxcart Exchange (right).

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Market Divisions and Districts

PAINTER'S PARADE The cobbles in the north of the Oxchange are splattered with bright pigments, and tapestries flap in the breeze. This area is known for its art communities and pop-up galleries.

THE MEAT QUARTER Northeast of the market you'll find butchers, barbecues and rotisseries. Meals dripping with flavour wait for those who wade through the smoke.

TEXTILE WARD To get to the east of the Oxchange, you'll have to splash through puddles of colourful dye runoff. Here you'll meet tailors, outfitters and print-makers.

ANVIL ALLEY The southeast of the market is by far the loudest. Clattering metal and the hiss of cooling steel reverberate from the blacksmiths, armourers and weapon forges.

CHICKEN TUNNEL If you're looking for livestock, or the most chaotic part of the Oxchange, head to the south. Its shaded passages are covered in canvas to protect animals from bad weather, giving the tunnel its name.

ARCANA ENCLAVE Aspiring mages and enchanters should head to the southwest of the market. Stalls here sell magic items, as well as common spell components and parchment.

THE NOOK Furthest away from the main trade roads, western stalls benefit from limited city guard visits. In the shadowy alleys, you'll find the hushed dealings of illicit merchants.

CRAFTER'S STEPS The retail units in the northwest are the newest. Potters, jewellers and carpenters show their wares on tables that spill into the streets.

CENTRAL COURTYARD Rest on the benches here in the centre of the Oxchange and watch the street performers. That's if you can find a seat, of course.

SECRET The Oxcart Exchange expanded rapidly after the Skiddlewick brothers received an investment from a group called RH Venture Capital. Posing as philanthropists, RH were in fact the Red Hand — an infamous thieves' guild in disguise. Today, the Exchange doubles as their pickpocket playground, with signs written in thieves' cant hidden throughout the market to guide their operatives.

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The Quiet Carriage

Subterranean funeral parlour.

KNOWN FOR This underground mortuary offers grieving families coffins, rites and embalming services for their loved ones. The chambers remain ice-cold at all times, ensuring pristine preservation of the deceased.

APPEARANCE Only the domed tile roof of the stone building is visible from the street. Inside, water-stained, grey walls are lined with stacked coffins and rows of overlapping burial slabs, ready to be engraved.

LAYOUT A gloomy stairwell leads from the street to the white-painted entrance of the Quiet Carriage. Fifteen dim, cramped studios and storerooms connect through a maze of twisting corridors and cramped tunnels.

SECRET The Quiet Carriage is kept cool by restless ghosts haunting its tunnels. Their mournful cries can be heard in the early hours, adding to the building's eerie reputation in the neighbourhood.

BUILDING • SMALL • FUNERAL • SHOP

Dead Man's Arsenal

Shop selling battlefield loot.

KNOWN FOR The vendors scavenge battlefields and sell the armour, weapons, arrows and trinkets they find. Buyers get a bargain, if they're willing to overlook the items' grim origins.

APPEARANCE A scrap metal roof and driftwood walls surround a scruffy desk. Tarnished blades, blood-stained tunics and mismatched leather boots are sat in a messy pile.

SECRET During peacetime, the stall's owners hire cheap mercenaries to ambush travellers and steal their belongings. It brings in new items and keeps their stock levels topped up.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • WEAPONS • SHOP

Novel Scenes

Bookshop with magical displays.

KNOWN FOR Hidden magic helps customers browse the shelves of this bustling bookstore. Touching a book spine triggers an illusory scene from the book to appear in the air.

APPEARANCE Stacks of enchanted books press against Novel Scenes' cracked windows, almost bursting them open. A ceramic cat near the door softly glows with security wards.

SECRET Some books trigger illusions that reveal hidden messages and cryptic clues. They guide worthy readers to buried treasure, hidden tomes or forgotten knowledge.

BUILDING • LARGE • BOOKS • SHOP

Chipper Critters

Magical pet supply shop.

It is impossible to ignore the cacophony of animal calls as the stone building comes into view, and the pungent aroma of the creatures' food and bedding.

KNOWN FOR This shop caters to the needs of all magical creatures, big and small. Tasty treats for familiars are on offer by the tills, while dragon scale polish and griffon talon trimmers are on the top floor. Animal care classes are also given for the untrained, or those who need a refresher.

APPEARANCE An ageing wooden ladder climbs up to Chipper Critters. Cages float overhead, aquariums bubble with colourful fish, and red butterflies flutter freely throughout.

LOOT The store's signature dry treats can tame some of nature's wildest beasts. Crates of magically strengthened leashes and collars are piled in a rear storeroom.

LAYOUT Larger animals live on the ground floor, which isn't normally open to customers. Supplies and small critters are sold upstairs.

SECRET A cloaking spell conceals the cellar, where a chimera cub is hidden and being secretly trained.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • PETS • SHOP

If you're planning for your party to go shopping, prepare shop inventories before the session.

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The Hunter's Satchel

Outdoor supply shop.

The smell of wood smoke and charred meat fills your nostrils. Traps, hides and animal skulls dangle from the wooden structure's robust beams.

KNOWN FOR The Hunter's Satchel has everything a trapper might need, from pocketknives and crossbows to hard-wearing boots and waterproof leathers. If you ignore the high risk of accidental injury, this is a one-stop-shop for anyone with a passion for outdoor survival.

APPEARANCE The weather-worn lodge is clad in wooden planks, which give off splinters if touched. The shop's only signage is a huge antlered skull on the thatched roof.

LOOT Snares of all sizes dangle from the ceiling, while shelves are filled with traps. Handwritten labels hint at ideal baits or warn of hidden toxins and poisons.

LAYOUT Stock is held on the lower two floors of the building. The shop's owners live in the top two floors, which are kept locked.

SECRET To protect their private quarters, the owners set traps, though they frequently spring them by mistake.

BUILDING • SMALL • TOOLS • SHOP

Fortune Alley

Market of seers and diviners.

KNOWN FOR Fortune Alley is a destination for all those seeking to learn what the future holds. Seers offer readings from loose tea leaves, crystal balls and divination magic. Coins and favours are currency here.

APPEARANCE Shops fight for space and attention along the narrow avenue. Painted adverts lure curious townsfolk with promises of answers, while enchanted entry bells chime softly before their doors even open.

LAYOUT Tucked away off the main path, this quiet dead-end alley sees little passing trade. Chunky stone storefronts line each side, while temporary carts and stalls fill the cobbled centre.

SECRET The magical entry bells are not just for show. They respond to the aura and thoughts of market visitors, chiming different melodies to reveal hidden intentions or even warn of impending danger.

BUILDING • SMALL • DIVINATION • MARKET

The Nine Strings

Musical instrument shop.

KNOWN FOR Musicians from across the realm travel to the Nine Strings. The shop sells the very best instruments, from grand harps to piccolo lutes, and offers high quality repairs.

APPEARANCE Instruments hang on the walls like works of art; grand pianos and harps are placed proudly in the middle. Everything has been polished to a high shine.

SECRET The Nine Strings hosts an annual private concert featuring promising musicians and composers. The guest list is limited to only the wealthiest patrons of the arts.

BUILDING • LARGE • INSTRUMENTS • SHOP

More Shops and Stalls

1. **ORCHARD'S BOUNTY** Sells jams, seasonal fruit and berries.
2. **SID'S VIVARIUM** Humid shop selling rare reptile pets.
3. **THE GRAB 'N' GO** Cramped outlet offering shoddy supplies.
4. **GLIMMER GOODS** Boutique selling luxury cosmetic potions.
5. **WHEYS DELI** Piled high with crates of stinking, rotting meat.
6. **THE CAVERN** Basement store stocking strange carved idols.
7. **ALL SOLES** Sell shoes of all sizes, from tiny to gargantuan.
8. **FEY BAKES** Bakery whose sweet treats are out of this realm.
9. **CIMA HARDWARE** Cluttered shop of tools, traps and gear.
10. **HAIR HAVEN** Emporium of fine toupées and beard wax.

In troubled times, shops might not have enough basic stock to keep up with demand.

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Brablin C. Appleson

Shopkeeper who offers sage advice.

KNOWN FOR Brablin's shop is always full of townsfolk seeking the centuries-old dwarf's wisdom and advice. The community turns to Brablin for counsel on anything from furniture restoration to romance to remedies.

APPEARANCE Brablin is bald, but his thick silver beard is woven into several long, looping braids. He is slightly taller than average for a dwarf and one of his eyes is covered with a handmade, gem-encrusted eyepatch.

GOAL Over the years, Brablin has grown to see all his neighbours as family. He gives his advice freely and would do anything to protect those around him. He hopes to inspire the same kindness in others.

SECRET In his younger days, Brablin had a successful stint as an adventurer. It's the one thing he rarely talks about, but some of the precious items he sells are from his tomb-raiding, bounty-hunting past.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • DWARF • MERCHANT

PRIEST ACOLYTE / WARRIOR VETERAN

Flitwing Express

Cutting-edge shipping company.

All around you, sets of artificial dragonfly wings whir to life. Gleaming brass drones lift heavy crates up into the air, ready for transit to their final destinations.

KNOWN FOR Flitwing Express is a fast-expanding wholesale supplier run by two gnomish inventors. Their patented clockwork ornithopters enable same-day stock deliveries to shops across the city. Their low prices and rapid turnaround have made them a favourite among independent traders.

GOAL Within five years, they plan to build warehouses in every major city to expand their reach. They promise all partner shops will receive reliable, same-day restocks.

LEADERSHIP The founders started the business after graduating from an artificer's academy. They share responsibility for the technical and commercial sides of the business.

FEATURE Each ornithopter's wings change colour to show its delivery stage: green for loaded, blue for en route, red for delivered or unloaded.

SECRET Ornithopters are powered by pale crystals secretly mined beneath a sacred mountain. Locals are unaware of where the fuel comes from.

FACTION • LARGE (50–99) • NEUTRAL • COMMERCE

Maggie "Magpie" Jones

Profit-focused shopkeeper.

KNOWN FOR Savvy dealer Maggie earned the nickname Magpie due to her uncanny skill for spotting treasures in trash. She picks up bargains at flea markets, then resells the items for extortionate mark-ups.

APPEARANCE Magpie is a small, elven woman wearing thick-rimmed spectacles. Her eclectic clothing includes layers of skirts in silk, velvet and lace, a metal corset, and a flowing white blouse with billowing sleeves.

GOAL Magpie haggles with her customers and suppliers relentlessly, refusing to sell for a discount or overpay by a single copper. She prides herself on never leaving a deal without squeezing out the best possible profit margin.

SECRET As a child, Magpie stole shiny things and sold them to care for her ill father. Quickly gaining a knack for turning a profit, she was able to stop thieving. She still occasionally fences stolen goods for old friends.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • ELF • MERCHANT

BANDIT / PIRATE CAPTAIN

Does your shopkeeper haggle, or fix their prices in advance?

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Murall Lindisse

Cat-enthusiast shopkeeper.

KNOWN FOR Murall's cluttered shop is filled with stray cats she's rescued. Their temperaments range wildly, from loving and gentle to vengeful and mischievous.

APPEARANCE Murall's dark overalls are covered in cat hair. She wears handmade false cat ears on her white hair, which she also sells alongside her stock.

GOAL A recent influx of strays and a lack of space at the shop has meant Murall is looking to rehome some of the cats. She will only sell to responsible new owners.

SECRET For fear of being mocked, Murall has not told anyone of her ability to talk to cats. Many of the strays have told her of a growing wererat presence in town.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • ELF • MERCHANT — COMMONER / DRUID

Clint & Co.

Family of franchise owners.

KNOWN FOR The "Co" in Clint & Co. doesn't stand for company, it stands for cousins! This hard-working family has multiple franchise stores across the region, each staffed by a different cousin or family member.

GOAL Every family member is dedicated to growing the business and upholding its excellent reputation. They hope to pass on success and wealth to the next generation of Clint children.

FEATURE Members of the Clint family are typically stout with red hair, flushed skin and a bulbous nose. In a tradition dating back to the family patriarch, Culdwell Clint, they all have names that start with the letter C.

SECRET A changeling has disguised themselves as a family member and opened their own franchise store. They are trading on the Clints' good name, but selling shoddy merchandise for cheap.

FACTION • MEDIUM (20–49) • FRIENDLY • COMMERCE

Thalax Coralshell

Shopkeeper with a charmed shell.

KNOWN FOR How many merchants can say they carry their warehouse on their back? Thalax stores his entire inventory inside his enchanted shell; it's a strange but secure way to protect his goods.

APPEARANCE This turtlefolk vendor wears a wide straw hat over his pale, green-spotted face. A parchment scroll hangs from the top of his shell, with a list of the items he has in stock and their prices.

GOAL Thalax sells most of the trinkets he carries in his shell, but he's also an avid collector. Currently, he is trying to collect a matching set of dragonchess pieces. He has 73 pieces, so just needs 11 more to complete it.

SECRET A charmed necklace Thalax wears allows him to use his shell as extradimensional storage space. If the magical item is removed, all of his wares will spill onto the floor around him.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • ANIMALFOLK • MERCHANT — NOBLE / BANDIT CAPTAIN

Mineral Mice

Coin-eating rodents.

KNOWN FOR These metal-eating rodents have a particular taste for coins. Their ability to chew through a cash box and its contents makes them a shopkeeper's worst nightmare.

APPEARANCE Mineral mice look like ordinary mice at a glance. However, their fur has a metallic sheen that glints in the light and feels coarse to the touch, like fine iron filings.

SECRET Mineral mice can be tamed as thieving companions. When released in a mansion, they swiftly sniff out hidden treasure stashes and secret compartments with precision.

CREATURE • TINY • NEUTRAL • MONSTROSITY

Shop Aesthetic Department

Hard-to-please sign regulators.

KNOWN FOR The Shop Aesthetic Department (or SAD) sets exacting rules for shop displays and signage. Their volunteer inspectors hand out long lists of recommended upgrades.

GOAL The Department claims to promote shop visibility and town harmony. Its members enjoy bossing around other shopkeepers and enforcing their own petty preferences.

SECRET Shops that refuse to comply are added to a secret registry. Once listed, the shops suffer mysterious issues like supply delays, sudden roach infestations, or break-ins.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • HOSTILE • CIVIC

Is there a task the party could do for the shopkeeper to get a permanent discount?

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Winks

Teleporting guard dog.

KNOWN FOR This blink dog uses his teleportation talent to guard his owners' premises. He moves around the shop and keeps an eye out for suspicious activity, howling at strangers.

APPEARANCE Winks has a muscular body, short fur, pointed ears and double-rows of sharp teeth. His striped coat gives him a natural camouflage in dim light, perfect for night patrol.

SECRET Winks has a weak spot for pastries. Even a few croissant crumbs can placate him, as it brings back pleasant memories of romping through markets as a pup.

CREATURE • MEDIUM • NEUTRAL • FEY

Bazzil Broomdusk

Juvenile shop assistant.

KNOWN FOR When his mother is out for deliveries or works in the back, Bazzil is left front-of-house. The precocious, chatty boy eagerly greets every customer.

APPEARANCE Not quite grown to his full gnomish height, Bazzil sits on top of a stepladder so he can see over the front desk. His big, brown, inquisitive eyes judge customers.

SECRET If alarmed, Bazzil has a spell scroll that can summon spirit guardians. The spirits manifest as his ancestral aunts who scold the troublemakers until a living adult arrives.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • GNOME • MERCHANT

Leksander Sundstrom

Shopkeeper with a thieving pet.

A pink-tongued, wrinkled creature with stumpy wings whirls excitedly around a young dwarf in dirty overalls and steel-toed boots.

KNOWN FOR Leksander's easy charm and disarming chatter draws customers in, as do the distracting dog-like antics of his homunculus, Acorn. Shoppers leave smiling, until they realise something's missing — Acorn's nimble paws make short work of coin purses and trinkets, funding Leksander's generous deals and half-price bargains.

APPEARANCE Clothed in scuffed, brown leather overalls, Leksander moves with the overconfident swagger of someone who's never been caught. His dark locs swing with each step, weighed down by shining golden rings gifted to him by his father. Acorn trails behind, yelping and panting. The pet's clumsy attempts at flying and running distract from his real goal of stealing coins.

HISTORY Leksander studied at a mage college, but was expelled for failing to control Acorn. His disapproving parents bought him a shop, which he now runs, happily far away from stuffy academic rules.

GOAL Leksander wants loyal, happy, returning customers. His strategy is to offer bargains and low prices, then let Acorn secretly swipe a little extra coin. It's illegal, but the smiling faces and profits keep rolling in.

SECRET Leksander didn't craft Acorn from scratch at mage's college. He stole a partially bound homunculus from another student and finished the ritual using a forbidden, blood-based catalyst.

LOOT

- Eyes of charming*
- Tinker's tools*
- Coin purse
- Steel-toed boots
- Handful of dog kibble
- Component pouch*

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • DWARF • MERCHANT PIRATE / MAGE

You can find more magical companions and familiars on pp. 226–227.

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Presto Peddlers

Teleporting on-demand vendors.

KNOWN FOR Presto Peddlers can teleport to sell goods, wherever and whenever an adventurer needs them. A special token can be used to summon a merchant and their goods with the click of a button.

GOAL Presto Peddlers provide ad hoc sales solutions to adventuring problems. The on-demand nature of their selling, and the risks associated with teleporting, means they charge extremely high prices for ordinary items.

FEATURE Merchants wear green-and-brown striped doublets over a matching forest-green underlayer. Each vendor carries a purse of teleportation tokens, which are engraved with a compass and coin logo in the centre.

SECRET As soon as a customer summons a Presto Peddler, they incur a 100 gold piece fee, even if they don't buy anything. Failure to pay will result in the group's revenue enforcement team collecting it.

FACTION • MEDIUM (20–49) • FRIENDLY • COMMERCE

Ruby Flutterflap

Magically hastened shopkeeper.

KNOWN FOR Ruby runs around her shop in a blur of energy, thanks to a haste spell boosting her outputs. If the spell fades, she dozes behind the counter.

APPEARANCE Ruby is a gnome cloaked in lime green. She has orange, curly hair that bounces with every hurried step.

GOAL On the side, Ruby is experimenting with a more potent haste potion. She aims to reduce its side effects and increase its duration to achieve peak productivity.

SECRET Ruby doesn't have an alchemy licence. Her potions are not only disgusting, they're dangerous and untested.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • GNOME • MERCHANT

MAGE APPRENTICE / MAGE

Gruuthok Wainstone

Distrustful shopkeeper.

KNOWN FOR Unusually for a merchant, Gruuthok hates seeing customers in his shop. He assumes everyone is trying to rob or scam him. Social niceties and attempts at friendly chatter just make him extra suspicious.

APPEARANCE This gruff bugbear sits behind a thick, magically reinforced glass pane to distance himself from customers. He wears a three-piece suit and judges customers over wire frame spectacles.

GOAL Gruuthok is hoping to make his business mail-order only, so he can close the shop entirely. He's made all the catalogues, but now needs to find someone he trusts enough to make the deliveries.

SECRET Strapped to the underside of Gruuthok's desk are two daggers, a Dust of Disappearance pouch, and a Sending Stone paired with one carried by the town sheriff. He also wears a Ring of Protection.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • GOBLINOID • MERCHANT

TOUGH / SPY

Fair Price Association

Trade auditing guild.

KNOWN FOR The Fair Price Association inspects shops and stalls to standardise market prices. They also aid owners with auditing ledgers, filing taxes and counting stock.

GOAL This guild of accountants aims to regulate merchant finances. They provide training courses to shop owners to educate them on specialised accounting systems.

SECRET Some inspectors accept bribes to overlook inflated prices or falsified accounts. They secretly favour wealthy merchants, and squeeze out smaller competitors.

FACTION • LARGE (50–99) • NEUTRAL • COMMERCE

More Merchants

1. BROM FROSTFORGE Conceals wares under a long coat.
2. NILLA MOLNA All items for sale are meticulously organised.
3. EDMEE JAGODA Sells dodgy goods that are easily broken.
4. LUCINE NAOUMOVA An enthusiastic street vendor.
5. EUDOXOS KOKKONEN Buys more items than they sell.
6. GARRICK OAKENBOW Sells ideas and intangible things.
7. BOHUMIR ELWIN Merchant on a travelling boat shop.
8. VENJI KIRALY Chaotic vendor with no prices on anything.
9. WEN OLAJSEN Sells only teacups, in odd sizes and colours.
10. CIP AKHMETOV Makes everyone whisper in their shop.

Swindling shopkeepers or stealing from markets might save your party coin, but they won't be welcomed back.

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Blazehammer Smithy

Mephit-powered forge.

KNOWN FOR The astounding heat within the Blazehammer Smithy is caused by a team of elemental mephit helpers. The temperature allows the smith to work with rare materials.

APPEARANCE A roaring furnace shaped like a dragon's mouth fills the busy workshop with heat. Molten metal flows through floor grooves and leads to individual workstations.

SECRET The furnace acts as a portal to the Elemental Plane of Fire. Creatures other than mephits are trying to break through, and could explode from the furnace at any moment.

BUILDING • SMALL • BUSY • FORGE

Butterfly Kiln

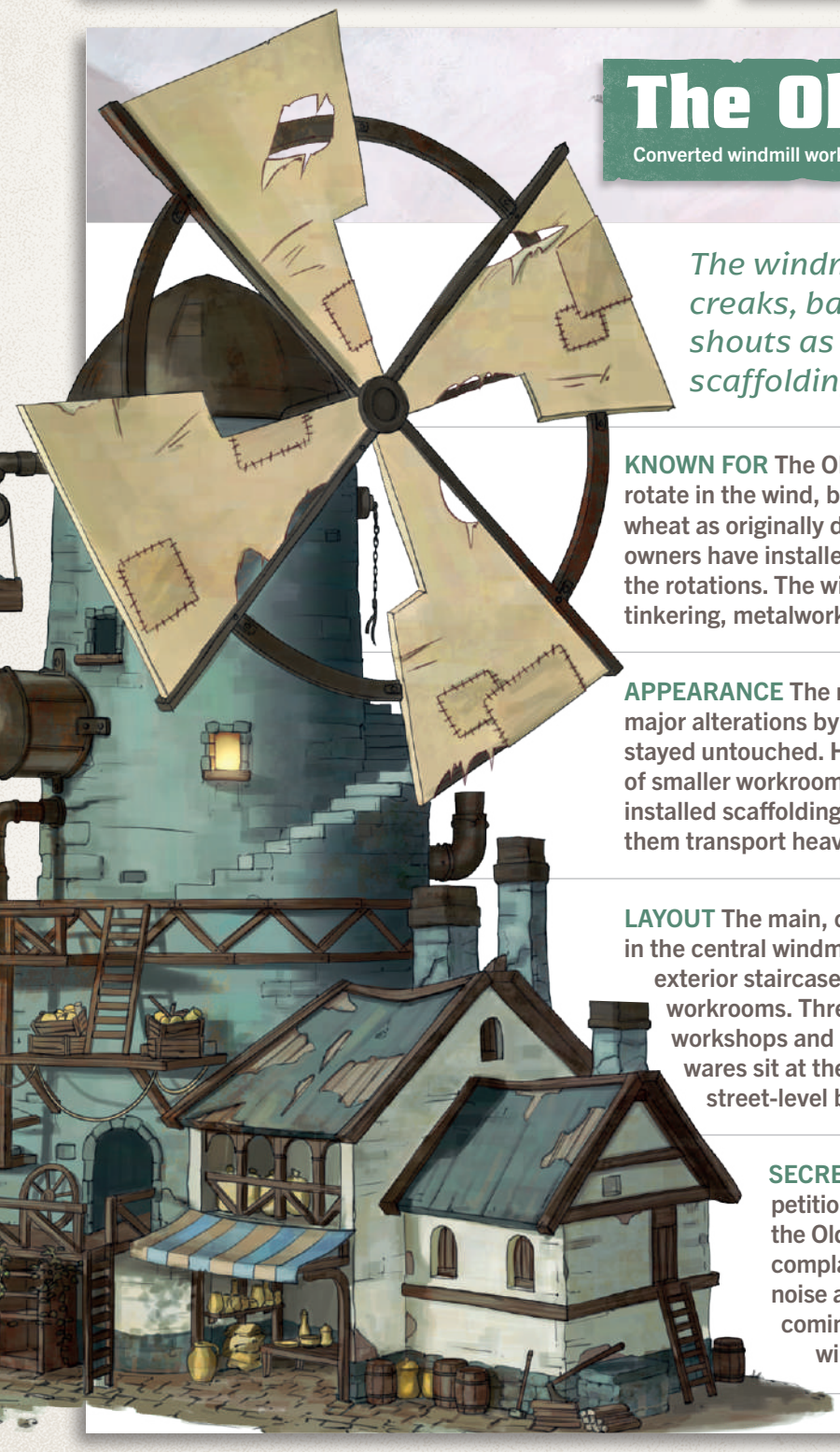
Greenhouse glassblowing workshop.

KNOWN FOR Tucked behind a white cottage in a secluded orange grove, the Butterfly Kiln creates enchanted glass sculptures and animated stained-glass windows.

APPEARANCE Ivy climbs the workshop's wonky greenhouse walls. Inside, glass butterflies flutter, scattering coloured light across shelves of half-finished magical creations.

SECRET An enchanted glass dog and a cat recently escaped the kiln. The pair are causing chaos, stealing from butchers and fishmongers, and the owner is desperate to catch them.

BUILDING • SMALL • QUIET • WORKSHOP



The Old Ironmill

Converted windmill workshop.

The windmill's sails turn slowly with weary creaks, barely heard over the labourers' shouts as they haul supplies up the wooden scaffolding. Bright lights flicker inside.

KNOWN FOR The Old Ironmill is a local landmark. Its sails still rotate in the wind, but no longer to turn a grindstone or to mill wheat as originally designed. Instead, the building's artificer owners have installed a device that harnesses the kinetic energy of the rotations. The windmill has become a hub for arcane invention, tinkering, metalworking and extraordinary enchantments.

APPEARANCE The mill's new owners were instructed not to make major alterations by the local council, so the building has largely stayed untouched. However, the artificers have built a number of smaller workrooms at the Old Ironmill's base. They have also installed scaffolding and pulley systems around the exterior to help them transport heavy materials around the protected structure.

LAYOUT The main, circular workshop is in the central windmill tower; a twisting exterior staircase leads to the upper workrooms. Three other brick-built workshops and a stall for selling wares sit at the Old Ironmill's street-level base.

LOOT Wooden benches in the busy workshop hold unfinished repairs and enchanting tools. Magic items are stored away in locked chests and acidic curing kegs.

SECRET Angry locals are petitioning to shut down the Old Ironmill. They complain about constant noise and arcane pollution coming from the bustling windmill tower.

ENCOUNTERS

- Debris falling off pulleys
- Sudden explosion
- Golem obedience class
- Windmill sail repairs
- Protesting locals
- Workshop open day

BUILDING • LARGE • OVERCROWDED • FORGE

Big cities are likely to have multiple workshops that offer different services.

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The Gearspire

Workshop in a clocktower.

Sunlight glints off a highly polished brass pendulum as it swings effortlessly back and forth. Beyond, you can see a whirring mass of interlocking metallic cogs.

KNOWN FOR If your pocket watch breaks, your armour dents, or your wagon spokes snap, the Gearspire is the place to go. However, access to the finest tinkerers in the land comes at a risk, as the clocktower's stairs are unstable and its loud chimes can be sudden and deafening.

APPEARANCE A tall, stone-built tower sticks up above the residential houses around it. The tower's golden clockwork mechanism is on display through small arched windows.

LAYOUT A central spiral staircase leads past storage rooms to the living quarters above. A final set of rickety ladders heads to the belfry workshops at the very top.

LOOT Loose cogs litter the dusty stairwell. Schematics and pricey tools are carefully mounted along the belfry's inner walls.

SECRET The owners enjoy living above the rest of town. They spy on their neighbours from on high, so are good sources of local gossip.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • QUIET • WORKSHOP

Wyvernhead Press

Local printing press.

KNOWN FOR Wyvernhead Press uses steam-powered letterpresses to make leaflets at speed. Printed materials are quickly distributed to homes and businesses across town.

APPEARANCE Wyvernhead operates from a red-brick warehouse, expanded to house its enormous press. Thick pipework snakes through the walls to support the machine.

SECRET The owner of Wyvernhead Press takes quiet bribes from the local council. In return, no posters or papers are allowed to say anything remotely negative about them.

BUILDING • LARGE • BUSY • PRINTER

More Workshops

1. **BOX COMMONS** Warehouse full of small workshops for rent.
2. **STEEL GAUNTLET** Factory manufacturing iron golem limbs.
3. **MOONTHREAD STUDIO** Attic atelier with large skylights.
4. **RUNEFIRE FORGE** Trusted spot for magical weapon repairs.
5. **THE LAIR** Gadget workshop, accessed by a hidden trapdoor.
6. **GILDED ARCADE** Grand row of bespoke jewellery studios.
7. **SCUPTOR'S SHELTER** Open-sided shed for statue repairs.
8. **TRAVELLER'S ANVIL** Cart that folds out into a work bench.
9. **GRAIN WORKSHOP** Woodwork room covered in sawdust.
10. **THE VAULTERY** Stacked with quality safes and vault doors.

Hitch & Ruts

Garage for modified wagons.

KNOWN FOR A locked warehouse on the edge of town offers high-end wagon enchantments and racing cart prototypes to those with the right amount of coin. Only patrons who know the secret knock can gain entry.

APPEARANCE The rusted exterior of Hitch & Ruts makes the building appear derelict and empty. There's no sign, just a thick bolted doorway with a small, grimy window. The shiny steel interior is a surprising contrast.

LAYOUT The garage has a row of four service bays for repair jobs, each with tool stations, hoists and wagon parts storage. There is also a showroom for new models and a mezzanine office that overlooks the work area.

SECRET Hitch & Ruts employees steal unoccupied carts from quiet streets at night, disguised as town guards. They use the stolen wagons for spare parts, or as scrap to test their latest enchantments on.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • QUIET • GARAGE

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Fabriz Feumain

Blacksmith with flaming powers.

From afar, the markings on the dwarf's arms resemble tattoos. Up close, they're spiralled blisters like cooling magma, stretching from his fingertips up to his chest.

KNOWN FOR While shovelling coal in a local smelting plant, Fabriz tumbled into a vat of molten metal. To the wonder of his co-workers, a celestial being rescued faithful Fabriz and lifted him to safety. Since his accident, Fabriz has been blessed with the ability to shape metal with his bare hands.

APPEARANCE When he prays, Fabriz can channel white-hot heat to his fingers. The effort causes his muscles to painlessly char and the tips of his red hair to go up in flames.

GOAL Fabriz feels deeply indebted to the deity who saved his life and granted him power. Everything he crafts and creates is to honour and repay the gods.

SECRET Fabriz has visions of a mace wreathed in flames. He believes the gods will give him a sign when he meets the hero destined to wield it.

LOOT

- Smith's tools*
- Holy symbol (emblem)*
- Staff of fire*

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • DWARF • ARTISAN AZER SENTINEL / WARRIOR VETERAN

Dispatch Supplies Limited

Criminal merchants' guild.

KNOWN FOR Skilled weaponsmiths, poison brewers and explosive experts register with the shady Dispatch Supplies Limited in return for coin. The guild sells their goods on to bandits, assassins and thieves.

GOAL The guild prides itself on providing exemplary equipment to its clients quickly and quietly at one of their many drop-off locations. They know upsetting one of their customers could prove to be a deadly mistake.

FEATURE Dispatch Supplies Limited couriers wear light-blue tunics and navy chaperon hoods embroidered with a flying pigeon logo. They nail parchment to posts in dangerous parts of town to advertise their wares.

SECRET Registered workshops can pay a surcharge to have a mage perform memory erasure spells on those who made the tools. The procedure ensures maximum privacy and limited traceability.

FACTION • MEDIUM (20–49) • NEUTRAL • COMMERCE

The Eightfold Etchers

Magical tattoo artists.

KNOWN FOR The Eightfold Etchers are famed for their intricate magical tattoos, drawn with enchanted needles and arcane inks. Their designs grant everything from elemental resistance to an increase in natural charisma.

GOAL The Eightfold Etchers seek to preserve ancient body-magic traditions, believing skin to be the ultimate spell scroll. They aim to create a complete lexicon of eight forgotten tattoo runes, and have yet to find four.

FEATURE Etchers normally wear sleeveless tunics and short, rolled-up breeches to show off their extensive body art. Each artist has a geometric octagon tattoo on their left hand, making them easy to identify.

SECRET Their signature arcane inks are brewed using alchemically preserved blood from extraplanar beings; some give it willingly, others do not. Each pigment is taken from a different kind of creature.

FACTION • MEDIUM (20–49) • FRIENDLY • INDUSTRY

Some craftspeople may be willing to work overnight to get the job done, especially if it means a rushed order fee!

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Albert Haitch

Sinister clothier and stylist.

KNOWN FOR Known simply as Mr H, this distinctive tailor is fully committed to his macabre signature style. A dismembered animated hand assists him in his work.

APPEARANCE Dressed from head to toe in his own creations, Mr H languidly refers to his dapper silk shirt as a shroud, and his black cravat as a garrotte.

GOAL Mr H dreams of founding a fashion brand defined by elegance and gloom. He wants to make essential attire for nobles, royals, assassins and cult leaders alike.

SECRET Mr H's mentor bequeathed him her right hand in her will to use as an animated assistant. It still double-checks all his patterns and measurements.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • HUMAN • ARTISAN

COMMONER / CULTIST FANATIC

Daron Grelser

Scrap-metal armourer.

KNOWN FOR If you want care and precision, Daron isn't the armourer for you. They may be quickly bashed together from scrap metal, but his finished breastplates always do the job.

APPEARANCE Daron's cheeks are flushed with exertion and metal filings are lodged in his stubble. Dusty, glass safety goggles hang at his belt – though he never wears them.

SECRET Daron applied for a scholarship with a prestigious armouring guild, but was rejected. His self-taught approach earns him far more coin than most guild members.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HALFLING • ARTISAN

Elgin and Withers

Pricey woodwork company.

KNOWN FOR Elgin and Withers hold of a royal warrant for palace furnishings, so charge extortionate fees. The proud firm is notoriously selective about accepted commissions.

GOAL The studio's two elven co-founders believe their creations should only be supplied to the realm's elite. They are obsessed with elevating the status of their brand.

SECRET One of the studio's most skilled junior carpenters often accepts commissions refused by their snobby bosses. They secretly complete the work in the studio late at night.

SMALL (6–19) • HOSTILE • INDUSTRY

Erika Coggleswig

Tiny clockwork tinkerer.

KNOWN FOR Erika inherited the family business from a long line of sprite tinkerers who came before her. She specialises in fine clockwork repairs, as her nimble fingers can handle the most delicate cogs and gears.

APPEARANCE Erika's shiny black hair is tightly pinned up with a pair of metal combs. Her fluttering, translucent wings look like frosted glass panels, criss-crossed with thin copper veins.

GOAL Losing the Coggleswig family business is Erika's greatest fear. Larger mechanical consortiums have been undercutting independent traders, but Erika refuses to let the business fail under her stewardship.

SECRET Erika recently accepted a request from an infamous thief who offered a lucrative fee. The job requires Erika to unlock a safe box, and to keep quiet about the contents inside after she cracks it.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • FEY • ARTISAN

SPRITE / SPY

Shirl Bannerlea

Saddler for magical steeds.

KNOWN FOR People travel vast distances to commission custom leatherwork from Shirl. Working from her humble studio, she specialises in saddles for rare or magical steeds.

APPEARANCE Shirl wears a loose, white cotton shirt and a handmade leather corset, with bracers and boots. She is softly spoken and takes long pauses to consider her words.

SECRET Shirl can enchant items with minor charms to enhance the protection they offer. She only helps those who show genuine kindness and care towards their animals.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • ORC-HUMAN • ARTISAN

More Artisans

1. HAKOO SANDS Veteran dragonborn glassblowing artist.
2. ARI LACH Weaver who spends years creating each tapestry.
3. ROWAN MILN Clumsy but keen carpenter's apprentice.
4. SAMI CRAUD Stonemason who doesn't speak while carving.
5. ASPITH ESTÉ Perfume maker who distils one-off fragrances.
6. PIETR DUN Artist secretly responsible for satirical graffiti.
7. LEU FLAGEE Makes soot inks using traditional techniques.
8. CONNY EMBART Thin upholsterer who does basic repairs.
9. DOT PLETON IV Perfectionist who makes grand hats.
10. AXL HILL Home brewer whose beers keep exploding.

Items made by an artisan should have a trademark feature, like swirling patterns or wolf motifs.

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Hall of the Bold

Adventurers' assembly point.

Signs of the tower's former glory linger. The walls are covered in yellowing letters, written by grateful locals, and paintings show heroes toasting their victories.

KNOWN FOR Once a vital stronghold in a terrible war, this dilapidated outpost now serves as a gathering place for adventurers. Here, they hone their skills, borrow weapons and armour, rest, and await new quests. It is renowned for the many famous heroes who began their journeys here.

APPEARANCE The prestigious Hall of the Bold shows its age. Faded banners hang limp from battlements, and the monster heads on display are moth-eaten.

LAYOUT The caretaker's office is on the ground floor by a covered courtyard with basic seating. There is space upstairs to rest, restock and train for a new quest.

LOOT Weapons and armour are available to borrow on an honour system. They aren't fancy, but they are sturdy.

SECRET The shy caretaker is secretly a retired legendary hero. They watch new adventurers, guiding the brave and hardworking.

BUILDING • LARGE • BUSY • HALL

Glossvale Bank

Currency exchange.

KNOWN FOR Glossvale Bank can exchange currency from any realm, including other planes of existence. They also offer high-interest loans for those making big purchases.

APPEARANCE The bank is an ancient building with high, vaulted ceilings made of silver. Staff wear delicately detailed ceremonial robes and speak in hushed, respectful voices.

SECRET The bank's basement vault contains the realm's crown jewels, while replicas are on display at the palace. The treasures are only moved before a great state event.

BUILDING • LARGE • QUIET • BANK

Lumine Washhouse

Public bathing area.

KNOWN FOR Lumine Washhouse is a government-funded, indoor bathhouse promoting public health and cleanliness. It serves as a social hub where citizens meet and share news.

APPEARANCE Sunken wash tubs are heated by basement furnaces, filling the white-tiled space with fragrant steam. Taps gush loudly, as people shout to be heard over the noise.

SECRET An anarchist revolutionary group secretly meets within the Washhouse. The government is aware, and sends spies to eavesdrop on their plans and conversations.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • OVERCROWDED • BATH

Urrasmaw Court

Courthouse of truth.

KNOWN FOR The enchanted pillars within Urrasmaw Court radiate a powerful zone of truth. Defendants must represent themselves, and often confess to more crimes than they were originally accused of.

APPEARANCE The courthouse is a red timber structure with towering, carved-oak doors. Its 10-feet-wide marble pillars are engraved with old runes, and were first raised to settle a dramatic royal divorce centuries ago.

LAYOUT Urrasmaw Court is a circular chamber with tiered, ornate jury seats facing a raised central dock where the accused stand. A curtained antechamber nearby allows jurors to deliberate in private.

SECRET If the jury cannot reach a verdict, the judge secretly flips a platinum coin in the antechamber to decide. This tradition dates back to the court's founding and ultimately decided the outcome of the royal divorce.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • BUSY • COURT

A lively town meeting is a great way to dish out multiple plot threads your party could explore.

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The Hearthstead

Multipurpose community hall.

KNOWN FOR This community centre hosts local events and meetings. It can also be hired for private functions, from birthday parties to wedding banquets to memorial wakes.

APPEARANCE People decorate the simple barn space with wildflowers and streamers made from scrap fabric. A serving hatch opens to a kitchen and heaving crockery cupboard.

SECRET There is an iron pot in the Hearthstead that has been divinely blessed. Meals prepared within it can stretch to feed dozens, and the food gives a small boost of heroism.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • BUSY • HALL

More Civic Buildings

1. **THE GREY STALL** Austere offices for transport authorities.
2. **PIXIE POST NOOK** Tiny post office operated by sprites.
3. **MARINA EMBASSY** Used by visiting underwater diplomats.
4. **SOULVAULT** Holds records of every local birth and death.
5. **OPEN FORUM** Lofty, marble debating hall with no roof.
6. **STONEY HALL** Gothic city hall run by living gargoyles.
7. **FATE'S WALK** Civic square where bloody duels are held.
8. **AMBLIN'S WATCHPOST** Town guard surveillance station.
9. **THE DRACOCEUM** Solid-gold embassy for draconic affairs.
10. **TAXSPIRE** Multistorey tax office stretching to the clouds.

Coterie Chambers

Underground parliamentary chambers.

KNOWN FOR This cavernous underground chamber houses political debates and votes. Representatives are forced to remain in the chambers until a decision is made, at any cost: no food, no water, no sunlight.

APPEARANCE All benches and tables are hewn from granite, and the only light comes from flickering, blue lanterns. The presiding minister sits in a blocky grey throne under an engraved crest.

LAYOUT Politicians use mechanical lifts to descend to the subterranean space. Small ministerial offices and meeting rooms are built off the main hall. There are also medical huts, in case not all politicians make it through.

SECRET The lifts, activated by levers in the grey throne, are meant to be the only way to enter or exit the chambers. However, one office has a secret passage that can be used for escape or to contact the outside.

BUILDING • SMALL • QUIET • HALL

The Messenger's Roost

Carrier pigeon post office.

Floorboards muffle the soft coos and wing beats of the birds in the rafters above. Straw slips through the ceiling cracks and lands on a huge pile of envelopes.

KNOWN FOR The Messenger's Roost offers one of the swiftest and most reliable postal services in the region. Customers can pay for express delivery for small items using pigeon couriers. Larger goods must be sent by horse and cart, unless they have been shrunk in advance by a verified mage.

APPEARANCE Pigeons dart in and out of small openings in the post office roof. They each have a name tag, and some carry small leather pouches.

LAYOUT Chutes from the upstairs sorting room drop mail into baskets behind the ground-floor counter. Pigeons rest in nooks and perches on the building's rooftop.

LOOT Mail sent through this post office ranges from everyday parcels and letters to urgent deliveries that could hold vital information.

SECRET One cursed, immortal pigeon carries an undelivered message. Bound by its hex, it tries to deliver the letter every single day.

BUILDING • LARGE • BUSY • POST OFFICE

Spending a day delivering packages is a fun way for your party to get to know multiple NPCs.

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Penny Merryweather

Scribe aided by magical hands.

KNOWN FOR This startlingly efficient office scribe is always surrounded by spectral, magical hands. The hands mimic everything she writes, creating tidy stacks of perfect copies.

APPEARANCE Penny uses pastel-pink hair combs to push her tight brown curls out of her face as she works. Her brows furrow as she concentrates on her work and spells.

SECRET As well as impeccable grammar and spelling, Penny has a photographic memory. She can recall detailed information from forms she made copies of months ago.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • GNOME • OFFICIAL

Terrince Koban

Lost property attendant.

KNOWN FOR Terrince is a familiar face to the settlement's most forgetful folk. He takes pride in keeping meticulous records of all the lost property in his safekeeping.

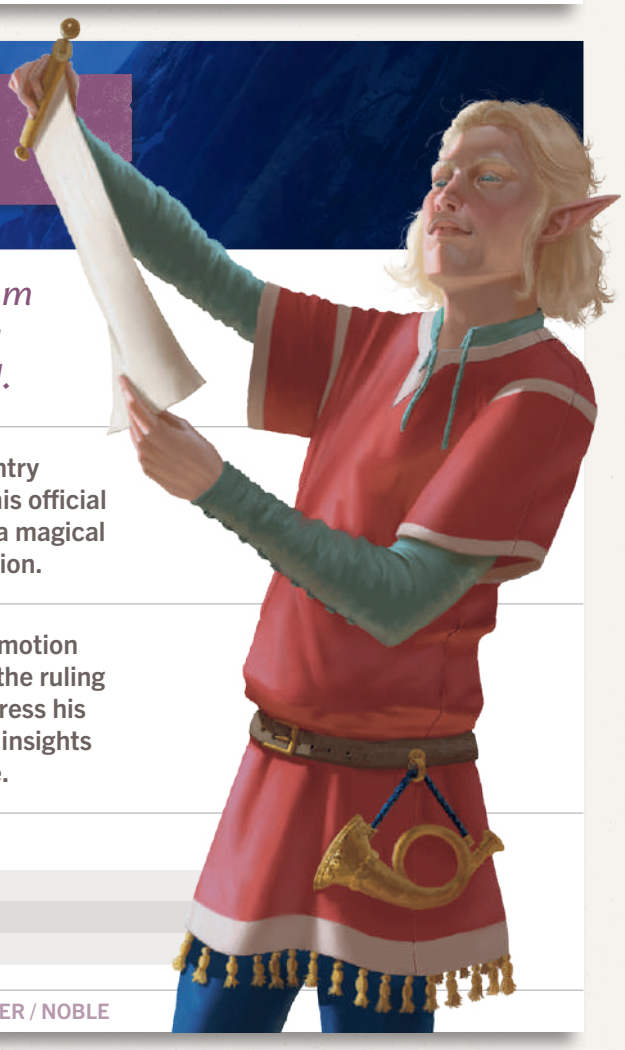
APPEARANCE This tall, thin young man has freckles, sandy hair and a big smile. He wears a neat, navy uniform and carries a clipboard detailing the most recently arrived items.

SECRET Terrince has made a fortune by turning in stolen goods, contraband items and criminal evidence that passed through his office. The reward money has set him up for life.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HUMAN • OFFICIAL

Zaher Eral'han

Official herald of public news.



The herald flicks the wispy blonde hair away from his face and unfurls a scroll of parchment with a flourish. He clears his throat, and begins to read.

KNOWN FOR Zaher is one of 13 heralds who travel around the country making proclamations on behalf of the realm's leaders. He makes his official speeches from each settlement's main civic centre. Then, he dons a magical disguise to go to the local tavern and eavesdrop on the public reaction.

APPEARANCE Zaher wears crisp robes in the realm's colours and speaks with perfect pronunciation. In disguise, he favours woolly coats, floppy hats and comfortable boots.

GOAL Zaher is eager for promotion to a more senior position in the ruling household. He hopes to impress his bosses with the impeccable insights he brings back to the palace.

SECRET Zaher also writes a tavern guide under a pseudonym. He rates ales on offer, bedbug count and bardic entertainment out of 10.

LOOT

- Proclamation scroll
- Brass bugle
- Hat of disguise*

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • ELF • OFFICIAL

COMMONER / NOBLE

Magnus Morningstar

Coin designer.

KNOWN FOR Talented artist Magnus designs coins for the national mint. He is particularly gifted in portraiture and looks for inspirational figures to immortalise in his art.

APPEARANCE Magnus is never seen without a pinstripe suit, tie and a bowler hat, which has holes for his hairy bugbear ears. He carries sketching supplies in a briefcase.

SECRET Magnus dreams of releasing special-edition coins celebrating bugbear heroes. The final hero Magnus wants to sketch is avoiding all his requests to organise a sitting.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • GOBLINOID • ARTISAN

More Civic Workers

1. MENDRY ROLZON Dragonborn fire marshal with ice breath.
2. CECYS LEHOM Helpful archivist of public record stores.
3. GWILL BOREVELL Pixie courier with a tiny satchel of letters.
4. SCUNA HATTER Assistant managing the mayor's calendar.
5. SOLIX UGON Leads a crew of trolls who make road repairs.
6. HEMCH DEIND Councillor advocating for species equality.
7. JADA ACHIMMES In charge of civil gardens and parks.
8. MELUS LEALSAI Pedantic notary of official paperwork.
9. KILGA DESSORK News reporter and vocal political activist.
10. OSSNIE STORM Civil engineer at odds with planning office.

These NPCs will have more information about tasks on the local quest board.

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Aurelian Nathair

Wealthy and influential banker.

KNOWN FOR Aurelian rose to the top of the banking world by backing risky ventures, sabotaging rivals and making ruthless decisions that earned him immense wealth.

APPEARANCE Aurelian's hair is side-parted with thick wax. He has a short beard, with sharp cheekbones and an equally sharp fitted suit. He appears no more than 25 years old.

SECRET The riches Aurelian was able to amass in such a short space of time drew the attention of a lamia. The lamia has befriended Aurelian and is starting to manipulate him.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • ELF-HUMAN • OFFICIAL

Sophronia Cacatua

Memo taker with mimicry ability.

KNOWN FOR Sophronia is able to perfectly repeat anything she's heard, in the original speaker's voice. She is employed to pass messages between offices and take meeting minutes.

APPEARANCE She has bright-red and yellow feathers, a stubby rounded beak and grey eyes. The skirts of her navy-blue dress swish at her ankles as she hurries around.

SECRET Sophronia works in public office, but her estranged twin sister, Kateen, earns a living sourcing intel for a ruthless gang. Sophronia doesn't trust anyone who knows her sister.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • ANIMALFOLK • OFFICIAL

Hariette Spectre

Famed lawyer.

KNOWN FOR A brilliant legal mind with an unshakeable work ethic, Hariette is a highly sought-after lawyer. She works on both prosecution and defence cases.

APPEARANCE Hariette wears formal court robes whenever she's working. The navy and burgundy colours show her qualifications and seniority.

GOAL Hariette has an unbroken record for winning cases. Rather than taking safe jobs to extend her streak, she seeks out tough cases to challenge herself.

SECRET By night, Hariette supplies a vigilante group with intel. She makes sure the group puts a stop to the criminal activity in her city.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HUMAN • OFFICIAL

NOBLE / SPY

Bil Lechever

Cheerful and charming receptionist.

KNOWN FOR Bil greets everyone who walks by his administration desk with a smile. His tuneful whistling and natural charisma quell tensions and calm emotions, even when queues are long or meetings are delayed.

APPEARANCE Bil has curling satyr horns and auburn ringlets tied in a bun. When he stands up, his muscular goat legs are covered in fur of the same colour, and his shiny black hooves clip-clop loudly on the floor.

GOAL Bil aims to make every interaction he has during the day a good one. It's not an entirely altruistic goal though – dealing with negative people is no fun for him, and filing complaint paperwork is boring.

SECRET As well as working at the reception desk, it is Bil's job to get meeting rooms and offices ready for the day's business. He has a full set of building keys, but doesn't keep track of them very carefully.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • FEY • OFFICIAL

COMMONER / SATYR

Laranya Noor

Magical security guard.

KNOWN FOR This bored guard searches visitors for hidden magical items. She's employed to spot illusory disguises, and to stop forbidden magic entering the premises.

APPEARANCE Laranya is equipped with a wand-like tool that can detect magic. She lazily waves it over people who pass by, often while yawning or rolling her eyes.

SECRET Laranya was once part of a powerful magical order, but her memory was erased. She occasionally experiences strange flashes of spells she shouldn't know.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • TIEFLING • GUARD

Moriss Wickerweave

Overstretched judge.

KNOWN FOR Moriss Wickerweave presides over dozens of court cases a day. The scale of his workload means he often gets details muddled, and even falls asleep during hearings.

APPEARANCE Moriss has curly white hair and a beard, both of which reach his waist. His thick glasses slowly slip down his nose when he starts to doze off.

SECRET During a particularly dull trial, Moriss forgot who the accused was and condemned a court scribe to life in the palace dungeons. He now keeps forgetting to grant a pardon.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • HALFLING • OFFICIAL

Officials work alongside the town guards on pp. 112–113 to keep their region safe.

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Jorrakee Speerbight

Mind-reading prison warden.

The cruel glint in his razor-sharp smile leaves no doubt, he's just as brutal as the prisoners he guards.

KNOWN FOR Jorrakee relishes the power that his prison warden job affords him. He stalks the halls, using his innate mind-reading abilities to learn the secrets and fears of every inmate. If anyone even thinks of defiance, Jorrakee responds with immediate and often brutal punishment.

APPEARANCE Jorrakee is a hulking, reptilian humanoid with a taunting smile. His backwards-facing palms and razor-sharp claws are indicators of his infernal rakshasa bloodline.

GOAL Jorrakee wants to stop bad behaviour before it occurs. He keeps prisoners in a constant state of fear and grinds down any hopes they may have escaping.

SECRET Jorrakee blackmailed local leaders into giving him the job as warden. They dare not challenge his cruel management of the jail.

LOOT

- Set of master keys
- Mariner's armour*
- Hooded lantern*

RAKSHASA RUNT

Medium Fiend

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
14 (+2)	15 (+2)	18 (+4)	10 (+0)	14 (+2)	18 (+4)

Armour Class: 15
Hit Points: 192 (24d8 + 96)
Speed: 30 ft
Initiative: +2

Skills: Deception +7, Insight +5, Perception +5,
Vulnerabilities: Piercing damage from weapons wielded by creatures effected by the Bless spell
Immunities: Charmed
Senses: Darkvision 60 ft
Passive Perception: 15
Languages: Common, Infernal
Proficiency Bonus: +3

ABILITIES

Magic Resistance. The rakshasa has advantage on saving throws against spells and magical effects.

Unseen. Without the rakshasa's permission, no spell can observe the rakshasa remotely or detect its thoughts, creature type, or alignment.

Runt Form. The rakshasa exists in a humanoid-animal hybrid form, and gets the following benefits depending on its lineage:

Bear-hybrid: the rakshasa deals double damage to objects and structures.

Bird-hybrid: the rakshasa gains Truesight 60 ft.

Canine-hybrid: the rakshasa's Baleful Roar recharges on a 5–6.

Cat-hybrid: the rakshasa's movement speed is 40 ft.

Goat-hybrid: the rakshasa can communicate with Beasts as if they share a common language.

Reptile-hybrid: the rakshasa gains advantage on Initiative rolls.

Squid-hybrid: the rakshasa can cast *Darkness* once a day as part of Spellcasting.

Fiendish Restoration. If the rakshasa dies outside the Infernal Realm, its body turns to sludge. It gains a new body instantly, reviving with all its Hit Points somewhere in the Infernal Realm.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The rakshasa makes two Withering Touch attacks.

Withering Touch. Melee Weapon Attack: +9 to hit, reach 5 ft, one target. Hit: 7 (1d6 + 4) slashing damage plus 12 (4d6) necrotic damage. If the target is a creature, it is cursed. While cursed, the target gains no benefit from finishing a Short or Long Rest.

Baleful Roar (Recharge 6). Wisdom Saving Throw: DC 15, each enemy within 30 ft of the rakshasa. Failure: 24 (6d8) psychic damage, and the target has the Incapacitated condition until the start of the rakshasa's next turn. Success: half damage only.

Spellcasting. The rakshasa casts one of the following spells, requiring no material components and using Charisma as the spellcasting ability (spell save DC 15):

At Will: *Detect Magic, Detect Thoughts, Disguise Self, Mage Hand, Minor Illusion*

1/Day Each: *Arcane Lock, Fly, Invisibility*

REACTIONS

Counterspell (2/Day). The rakshasa casts *Counterspell* in response to a spell's trigger, using the same spellcasting ability as Spellcasting.

CHALLENGE RATING 8

You could alternatively use the stats of a Warrior Infantry CR 1/8, Cultist Fanatic CR 2 or Rakshasa CR 13.

HOSTILE • FIEND • GUARD

Jailbreaks are adrenaline-pumping sessions with high stakes. What will happen if your party gets caught?

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Shadowgate Hall

Prison between the planes.

KNOWN FOR This eerie prison stands where the barrier between the Material Plane and Shadow Realm is weakest. Twisted magic and restless spirits seep into its haunted halls.

APPEARANCE No matter how many torches are lit, the prison is always shrouded in magical darkness. Barbed iron cages look like they've grown out of the obsidian floors.

SECRET Even after death, prisoners cannot leave. Their spirits remain bound to their filthy cells as shadowy echoes, whispering their life's regrets or faintly screaming.

BUILDING • LARGE • BUSY • JAIL

Stocks Row

Market square jail.

KNOWN FOR Bordering the market square, Stocks Row has a block of cells exposed to passers-by. Town locals are encouraged to throw rotten produce at the prisoners within.

APPEARANCE Half of the jail's cells have an outer wall of metal bars that face the market square. Prisoners are at risk of bad weather, and humiliation from the townsfolk.

SECRET Distractions in the market can easily draw guards from their watch, giving prisoners a brief chance to conspire with outside allies, or smuggle contraband into Stocks Row.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • OVERCROWDED • JAIL

Parker Hoghollow

Patiently plotting prisoner.

KNOWN FOR Parker was betrayed by her partner and took the fall for a heist. Now, she has meticulously mapped the prison and is ready to escape.

APPEARANCE Parker's blonde hair is dirty and matted from years in a cell. The charcoal smudges on her fingers and face blend in with other grime.

GOAL Parker wants to get revenge on her former partner and recover her share of the heist profits in the process. Once she's escaped her prison cell, of course.

SECRET Unknown to Parker, her former partner has been arrested for a different crime. They are both now imprisoned in separate blocks of the same jail.

NEUTRAL • ELF • OUTLAW

BANDIT / ASSASSIN

Ironplate Scaffold

Gallows with automated executioners.

KNOWN FOR Instead of living executioners, the Ironplate Scaffold is staffed by armoured constructs. The emotionless iron golems perform their role with absolute efficiency.

APPEARANCE The scaffold is a metal platform outside the city walls. It has a stained brass block for beheadings, and five nooses hung from iron piping with trapdoors below.

SECRET If a condemned prisoner escapes, the clockwork golem assigned to the execution relentlessly hunts them. Three of the 10 golems are currently tracking down fugitives.

BUILDING • SMALL • QUIET • GALLOWS

New Leaf Correctional Facility

Prison on the edge of a dump.

KNOWN FOR New Leaf claims inmates harvest crops on a quaint farm. In reality, they are forced to dig through reeking trash mounds for salvageable scrap under armed watch.

APPEARANCE This remote prison is built around a former quarry, now filled with refuse from nearby settlements. The constant stench is eye-watering, with high levels of toxicity.

SECRET The trash heaps hide barrels of volatile alchemical waste. Cracked and leaking, the metal kegs release fluids that could warp prisoners' bodies with arcane mutations.

BUILDING • SMALL • BUSY • JAIL

Cyra Thacoria

Prison warden with bardic dreams.

KNOWN FOR An aspiring bard, jailer Cyra takes advantage of her captive audience to practise her awful, self-penned ballads. She asks prisoners to help her think of new rhymes.

APPEARANCE Cyra is a brass-scaled dragonborn. Her long fingernails scrape across her lute with a painful screech. Her singing voice sounds like metal grinding on stone.

SECRET Cyra's strict father is also a prison warden, and doesn't know about her musical dreams. The pair work different shifts, so she stops her singing when he arrives.

FRIENDLY • DRAGONBORN • GUARD

Osric Guilder

Necromantic prisoner.

KNOWN FOR Osric was sentenced to languish in solitary confinement for crimes against magic. To fight boredom, he has animated the skull of a former inmate as a companion.

APPEARANCE His gaunt frame is inked from head to toe with necromantic sigils. Years in a dark cell have left Osric's skin as pale as bone.

SECRET The skull Osric animated belonged to a serial killer. The killer's spirit is trying to convince Osric to break out and continue the bloody work they were both convicted of.

HOSTILE • DWARF • SPELLCASTER

The party shouldn't just look out for guards, other prisoners might raise the alarm or muscle in on an escape attempt.

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Everdawn Ward

Holy emergency hospital.

The building's cracked walls and faded carvings show its old age. Banners of divine orders and healing guilds hang from newly fitted brackets and flutter in the wind.

KNOWN FOR Everdawn is a makeshift ward that occupies a centuries-old chapel, repurposed after a plague outbreak. Clerics from multiple faiths joined forces and transformed the hall into rows of cots. Wounded townsfolk are treated here with sigils, prayers and potent divine blessings.

APPEARANCE Pews have been pushed together and topped with straw mattresses to create bedding. Freshly washed sheets and dressings dry outside in the sun.

LAYOUT The central hall is used as a ward, with side rooms repurposed into triage centres. Between shifts, exhausted clerics sleep in the dusty, cramped belfry tower.

LOOT Everdawn Ward has a small tincture cabinet with Elixirs of Health, Potions of Healing and Potions of Vitality.

SECRET The sudden concentration of divine power in one spot has drawn the ire of an archfiend, who is plotting to destroy the hospital.

BUILDING • LARGE • OVERCROWDED • HOSPITAL

Doctor Gojko Babic

Aberrant infection expert.

KNOWN FOR Doctor Babic's macabre outfit doesn't set his patients at ease. However, his arcane methods are the best hope for anyone suffering lasting damage after an encounter with a chuul, slaad or other aberration.

APPEARANCE The doctor's face is hidden behind a beaked ebony mask, which is etched with glowing purple runes and doubles as a breathing apparatus. He wears a leather coat and gloves over a red-stained robe.

GOAL Doctor Babic splits his time between two research strands: capturing and experimenting on aberrations to map their strange physiologies; and developing cures for the injuries the creatures cause.

SECRET Each day, Doctor Babic submerges himself in a tank of enchanted brine to treat wounds he received in a near-fatal aboleth encounter. The liquid slows the spread of infection, and briefly numbs his pain.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • ELF-HUMAN • SPELLCASTER

PRIEST ACOLYTE / NOTHIC

Zira Thistlebrook

Healthcare entertainer.

KNOWN FOR This former patient now tries to bring cheer to hospital wards through her volunteer work. She tells fantastical stories of magic and monsters to amuse patients.

APPEARANCE To bring some sparkle to the wards, Zira dresses in dazzling beaded robes that she has sewn herself. Bells on her slippers jingle as she walks between beds.

SECRET Zira previously caught a strain of fey fever called bullyblight. The lingering side effects include surreal dreams, which she uses to inspire her bizarre fairy stories.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HALFLING • ENTERTAINER

Solaria Spire

Wizard's tower treating magical injuries.

KNOWN FOR The mage medics in this tower specialise in treating hexes, arcane misfires, elemental burns, wild magic surges and lingering effects from unstable enchantments.

APPEARANCE Each floor of Solaria Spire has a different colour-coded speciality. Bobbing rainbow orbs drift along the corridors, casting light that guides visitors to the right ward.

SECRET Treatments here are costly, due to the rare spell components needed. Student mages sometimes perform cheaper procedures in the Spire's basement classrooms.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • QUIET • HOSPITAL

Healing from damage doesn't need to be just a game mechanic, it can also be part of the story or downtime activities.

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Beneath the Balm

Cosy apothecary.

KNOWN FOR This quaint, one-healer clinic sells herbal salves, soothing teas and natural remedies. Locals stop by for health advice or scheduled consultation sessions.

APPEARANCE Latticed windows showcase tidy shelves of labelled bottles and dried herbs. Patients wait quietly in a curtained side room lined with framed medical sketches.

SECRET A hidden latch behind an iron sconce reveals a stairwell. A long-forgotten lab lies below, filled with dusty research tomes, medical equipment and elixir recipes.

BUILDING • SMALL • QUIET • APOTHECARY

Cogsblade Infirmary

Hospital using artificer technology.

KNOWN FOR In this pioneering institution, healing magic intertwines with clockwork technology. Patients receive treatments using innovative steam-powered tools.

APPEARANCE Cogsblade Infirmary is an ornate brass edifice with six clocktowers. In the centre, a well-pruned courtyard offers a spot of serenity in the middle of the efficient facility.

SECRET A recent magic surge cracked a clocktower. It was caused by a rogue artificer conducting secret arcane surgeries, ignoring safety protocols and containment rules.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • BUSY • HOSPITAL

Elderbough Sanctuary

Druidic healing centre.

KNOWN FOR Druidic healers harness nature's magic to tend to the Sanctuary's ill and dying. Potent spells and restorative rituals heal most patients. The spirits of those who can't be cured are drawn back to the flow of nature.

APPEARANCE Elderbough Sanctuary rests high in the canopy of a wide tree, its rooms carefully carved into the living trunk. Inside, furniture is shaped from woven roots, and beds are lined with fragrant moss.

LAYOUT Vine bridges connect different wards and departments around the tree. Every patient has their own small room, with a spherical design that feels reminiscent of a nest or cocoon.

SECRET A terrible, creeping blight has begun to blacken the bark and wither the leaves of the Sanctuary tree. The natural rot is stopping at nothing, and the druidic healers worry it will soon reach their weary patients.

BUILDING • SMALL • QUIET • HOSPITAL

Lioran Starveil

Miracle-working nurse.

KNOWN FOR Lioran is a softly spoken nurse whose steady hands and calming presence ease his patients' pain. His care has led to recoveries clerics have called miraculous.

APPEARANCE He exudes an air of peace and majestic strength. Lioran wears a crisp, white linen uniform accented with muted green embroidery and a gold medallion.

SECRET Lioran is an angel who is being tested. He must live as a mortal; each time he uses his divine powers for good, the gods return a small portion of his celestial strength.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • CELESTIAL • WORSHIPPER

Jemferriun Duskwilder

Patient under observation.

KNOWN FOR As a ranger, JD hates being stuck inside. After being bitten by a bear, he was told to stay in hospital for two weeks of observation. He's never been more bored.

APPEARANCE JD's leather armour has been replaced by simple, loose-fitting hospital garments. One leg of his drawstring breeches is raised to reveal a bandaged shin.

SECRET Doctors haven't told JD that they suspect he was bitten by a werebear. They're planning on isolating him during the next full moon and hiring guards to keep watch.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • GNOME • WAYFARER

Pibben Kardwall

Alchemist with custom cures.

KNOWN FOR This healer has developed a unique method of customising healing potions to each patient she meets. Each brew she concocts is highly effective.

APPEARANCE Pibben's worn-out black apron bulges with fungi, mandrake roots, bottled catalysts, old bones and powders. Her round spectacles sit low on her nose.

GOAL Pibben is slowly building up the confidence to share her methods with other healers. She dislikes attention, but knows doing so could help more people.

SECRET Pibben's potions use a vial of the patient's blood. If used by someone else, the healing power is reduced and there can be negative side effects.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • GOBLINOID • NATURALIST

DRUID / MAGE

A character injury or curse will feel more significant if the party can't heal it by normal means.

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Multi-Mount Lodge

Stable of many steeds.

Inquisitive beaks, snouts and muzzles poke out of openings in the timber building. The animals sniff the air at your approach and whinny in greeting.

KNOWN FOR The steeds for hire at the Multi-Mount Lodge are cared for and well-trained. Diligent staff pair customers with the right mount for their journey, based on the animal's stamina and temperament. They require a hefty deposit before agreeing a hire.

APPEARANCE The three-floor building is clad in roughly painted timber and thatched straw. Saddles, reins and feedbags hang inside.

LAYOUT Horses are stabled on the ground floor, with wyvern roosts on upper levels. The highest levels have perches and nests for winged steeds.

LOOT If you're very lucky, you might find a wyvern or griffin egg hidden in the straw of their nest.

SECRET If separated from their rider, the stable's trained mounts instinctively begin the journey back home alone.

BUILDING • LARGE • BUSY • STABLE

Erica Flagstaff

Well-travelled airship pilot.

KNOWN FOR Erica is an experienced airship pilot who has travelled several times around the world during her career. She takes her responsibility to her passengers very seriously.

APPEARANCE Erica wears a brown leather flying jacket and trousers, trimmed with fur. Her grey mane is bound in a long braid, and she walks with a slight limp on her left side.

SECRET Erica is due to lead her first flight since a flock of harpies crashed into a large cargo vessel she was flying a few months ago. She's feeling more nervous than usual.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • ANIMALFOLK • WAYFARER

Alberry "Al" Richter

Ticket-selling spy.

KNOWN FOR Working at a ticket office in the local transport hub means Al always knows who is coming and going from town. He pays particular notice to loud adventuring parties.

APPEARANCE Al wears a threadbare waistcoat and crooked tie. When presented with paperwork, he squints through a handheld magnifying glass and takes his time to inspect it.

SECRET If Al thinks a customer's whereabouts might be of value, he gives them a special ticket that can be magically tracked. He sells the information to the town guard.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • GNOME • OFFICIAL

Everglade Waypoint

Teleportation station.

KNOWN FOR The Everglade Waypoint is staffed by dozens of mages. For a fee, visitors can be teleported to another location through one of the station's archways. The longer the distance of the trip, the higher the price.

APPEARANCE The station is a vast labyrinth of ancient stone archways, each carved with glowing runes. Mages in crisp white robes patrol the halls, guiding travellers and maintaining the complex enchantments.

LAYOUT The entrance opens into a bright atrium ringed with black stone counters for booking travel. Beyond, the tangled warren of archways and thin corridors is unnavigable without a trained mage to lead the way.

SECRET Some travellers try and save on teleportation fees by smuggling more people through the arch than were quoted for, or by bribing a junior mage. This comes with extra risks, and their travel often goes awry.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • BUSY • STATION

Travel methods can give a distinct flavour to your homebrew world. Stagecoaches are very different to saddled dinosaurs!

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The Concord Gate

Registration embassy.

KNOWN FOR Visitors to the area must pass through this administrative centre to register their details and reasons for travel. The paperwork is very thorough and time-consuming.

APPEARANCE Crowds of bored travellers sit on wooden benches in a long, echoey hall, waiting for their number to be called. Equally bored staff sit at desks in the room next door.

SECRET People joke that the Concord Gate's workers are a form of vampire that feeds off boredom. There's truth in the joke, however, as over half the staff are incubi or succubi.

BUILDING • LARGE • OVERCROWDED • OFFICE

More Transport Workers

1. RENGAR OTHSWORT Goblin with a bicycle-hire business.
2. MIMI MORRIL Train refreshment seller and assassin's scout.
3. DOREEN GILL Grumpy wagon driver transporting chickens.
4. XENTRIX FRELDAR Dashing young stagecoach outrider.
5. FREYIL STOKES Friendly elven stagecoach conductor.
6. JEMIM GORGAST Strong but easily confused luggage porter.
7. EMILE ASHTON Taxi carriage driver with a fiendish steed.
8. LENNO SWIFT Flustered signaller carrying a pocket watch.
9. YUMI RADARO Carriage mechanic offering arcane upgrades.
10. GRASTOR TRIGRUNT Chatty orcish rickshaw driver.

Ursan Laungard

Shape-shifting cart driver.

The cart halts in front of you. The sturdy donkey that was pulling the vehicle shakes its head and shimmies free of its straps, transforming into a man with bushy brown ears.

KNOWN FOR Travellers speak highly of Ursan, a dependable escort with the rare ability to shape-shift into useful beasts. He'll become whatever best suits the journey: a strong ox to pull cargo, a giant eagle for flight, or a sure-footed camel for desert travel. At night, he rests in the form of a wolf or bear, keeping watch and guarding his travelling companions from predators.

APPEARANCE In human form, Ursan is lanky, with tousled grey-brown hair and gentle brown eyes. His animal forms always share his fur colouring. Years of frequent donkey transformations have left him with permanent mule ears and large, square teeth. Though he seems distant at first, Ursan quickly becomes talkative once he gets to know his clients.

GOAL Ursan enjoys using his abilities to help others, and getting paid to see the world. He prides himself on never giving up on a job, and insists on only taking payment when the journey is complete.

HISTORY Ursan comes from a long line of shape-shifters. He was bullied at school for his gift, but embraced it after becoming a multi-functional escort. Ursan has helped travellers for twenty years, and earned good coin.

SECRET Last year, Ursan was hired to escort a nervous wizard to a remote tower, but they disappeared while Ursan slept one night. Now, a guild of mages hunt and attack Ursan, and he doesn't know why.

LOOT

- Spare horseshoes
- Dried meat and fish
- Vicious dagger*
- Coin purse
- Boots of striding and springing*
- Spell scroll (create food and water)*

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HUMAN • WAYFARER DOPPELGANGER / MAGE

Planning encounters to break up travel time makes the journey as exciting as the destination.

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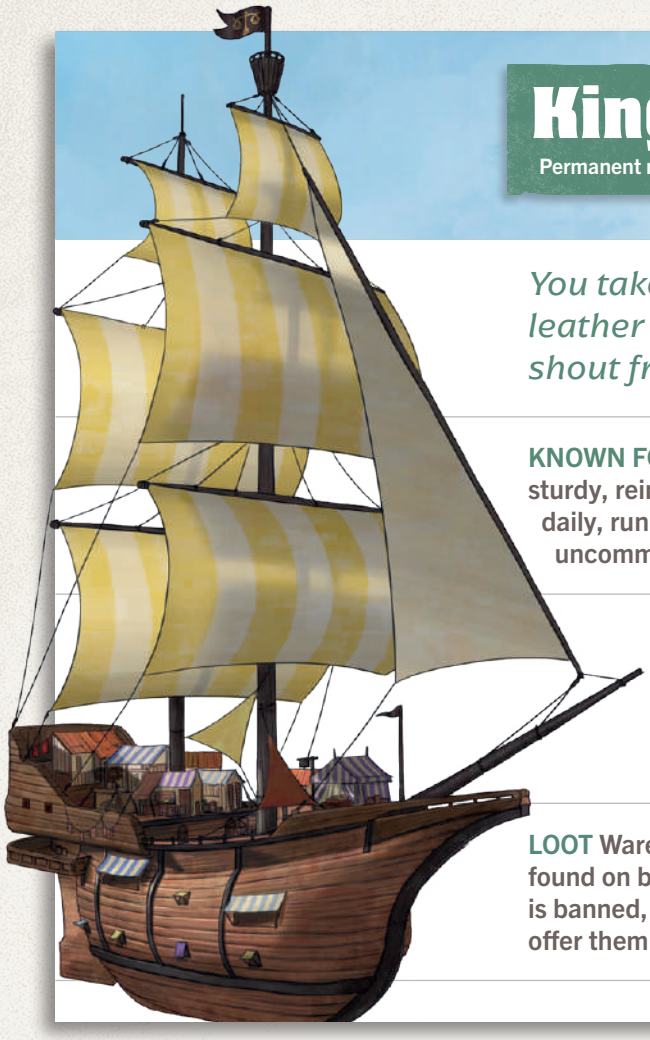

Kingscoin Galleon

Permanent market boat.

You take in the smells of grilling meat and tanned leather as you walk across the wooden deck. Traders shout from their striped marquees and call out offers.

KNOWN FOR The *Kingscoin Galleon* is permanently moored at the end of a sturdy, reinforced pier. More than just a ship, it hosts over 60 market stalls daily, run by traders from distant lands. The market offers exotic goods, uncommon components and handmade wares in a vibrant trade hub.

APPEARANCE The *Galleon's* proud, striped sails can be seen from miles away. Market stall marquees and awnings cover the top and lower decks.

LAYOUT Each deck sells different goods, with items increasing in value and rarity as you descend into the ship. The storage hold is for stock.

LOOT Wares from all nations can be found on board. Selling magic items is banned, but some merchants do offer them to interested buyers.

SECRET An etched platinum piece, known as a "kingscoin", is given to big spenders. Showing it grants access to discounts and rare items.

VEHICLE • MID-SIZED • MARKET • BOAT

Coastal Courier Co.

Arcane customs office.

KNOWN FOR These energetic couriers handle imports and parcels that come into the harbour. Its sorting bays use teleportation runes to get packages delivered in a literal flash.

APPEARANCE The leaning customs tower overlooks the busy docks. Pulleys on the outside manage heavier crates, and are a favourite perch for local squawking gulls.

SECRET Some of its older sorting bays only have a 70 per cent delivery success rate. The couriers select these bays when a customer is rude or has underpaid for postage.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • BUSY • POST OFFICE

Junior Marina Pavilion

Sailor recruitment centre.

KNOWN FOR Captains can hire young, newly qualified sailing cadets from the Junior Marina Pavilion (or JuMP). Novices are cheap, but often lack expertise and experience.

APPEARANCE A wooden boardwalk leads to the JuMP, a square building that stands out of the water on barnacled stilts. Spiral stairs lead down to docked boats bobbing below.

SECRET The owners of the JuMP let any sailor pass their limited, two-week training course. Having more cadets in their roster means more potential sailing contracts.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • BUSY • OFFICE

Transiteer Express

Ten-deck passenger ferry.

KNOWN FOR This cheap local shuttle is crammed with creaky, wooden deck chairs for passengers. The boat circles the coast daily from dawn til dusk, refuelling at night.

APPEARANCE The *Transiteer Express* has an orange, metal-plated exterior peppered with portholes. It is nine storeys high, so casts long shadows onto any port it harbours at.

SECRET The lower decks are infested with rats, but the operators refuse to acknowledge it. Worried wardens break protocol and pay those who are willing to tackle the vermin.

VEHICLE • LARGE • TRANSIT • BOAT

More Docked Vessels

1. **LA BELLE FLEURIE** Canal boat used as a flower shop.
2. **THE CHATEAU** Houseboat owned by an eccentric noble.
3. **THE SEABEAR** Floating fight club; it would be illegal on land.
4. **THE BARRACUDA** Old pirate ship, now a museum.
5. **THE HESIOD** Opulent cruise ship ready for its first voyage.
6. **BILGEWATER BREW** Industrial cargo ship turned tavern.
7. **APOLLO'S DREAM** Luxury yacht, seized by local authorities.
8. **QUEEN VEGA** Launders stolen goods through customs.
9. **THE MACE** Damaged naval vessel undergoing heavy repairs.
10. **ELODIE MAY** Abandoned fishing boat, said to be haunted.

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Goldfoam Pier

Run-down wharf.

KNOWN FOR Fairground games and fish fritters on Goldfoam Pier are a local highlight. However, visitors should keep their purses close by, as pickpockets operate in the area.

APPEARANCE Once, the pier was full of colour and bright lights. Now, it is rusted, and the old signs hang at awkward angles. Gaming booths with noisy attendants line the edges.

SECRET When the sun sets, Goldfoam Pier operates as a prolific black market. Anything can be bought or sold here, making it a haven for gangs and thieves.

BUILDING • SMALL • QUIET • PIER

Himdall's Barracks

Repurposed naval accommodation.

KNOWN FOR Named after a heroic navigator, this boisterous barracks is now open to any ocean travellers needing a place to rest. Ale, food and sea shanties are served all day.

APPEARANCE The barracks' four buildings are wide with tall archways and slim windows. The paved courtyard was once used for training drills, but now acts as a meeting spot.

SECRET A group of journalists disguised as sailors have lived in Himdall's Barracks for some time. They gather up rumours and gossip to turn into headlines and articles.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • BUSY • BARRACKS

The Gallivant

Non-stop fey party boat.

Laughter and music blasts from a double-decker boat moored at the dock. Blooming lavender and honeysuckle cover its terraces, and give a sweet smell to the winds that whip its sails.

KNOWN FOR The *Gallivant* is a lavish boat that stays docked, setting sail only for a few weeks a year. It welcomes revellers who are wealthy enough to afford its admission tickets. Guests can enjoy lively satyr music concerts, enchanting fairy plays, mysterious hag magic shows, sumptuous soirées, and extraordinary fey feasts. The experience culminates in a dazzling fireworks show every evening.

APPEARANCE The boat has three floors with a spiral staircase and slide connecting them; this construction makes the boat top-heavy, but complex enchantments keep it upright. The main deck's floral arrangements are always in bloom, so blossoms cover its wooden floor all year round. Instead of cannons, musicians blast their trumpets and brass instruments from the ship's gunports.

LAYOUT There are multiple live music venues below deck, with shows and entertainment above. On the upper deck, guests can take part in games and grand feasts. The crow's nest hosts exclusive wine tastings.

LOOT Entry tickets include food and drink for a guest's entire stay. A lost-and-found locker operates at the portside of the upper deck, where all kinds of trinkets can be recovered if you can get past the cyclops guard.

SECRET Non-fey guests who spend too long aboard the *Gallivant* become disoriented by its powerful planar magic. Many have lost track of time, but are having too much fun to check. They unintentionally party for weeks, months or even years beyond their original plans, trapped in never-ending revelry.

VEHICLE • SMALL • ENTERTAINMENT • BOAT

For ships you might find sailing out at sea, check out pp. 214–215.

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Fleet Menders Consortium

Artisan shipwrights.

KNOWN FOR The Fleet Menders Consortium is known for their flawless ship repairs and upgrades, with speedy turnaround times. Their services come at a high price and are affordable only for wealthy or sponsored ship owners.

GOAL The Consortium upholds its reputation for swift, top-tier ship repairs by operating cutting-edge, steam-powered machinery and automation tools. They aggressively poach elite engineers from rival firms.

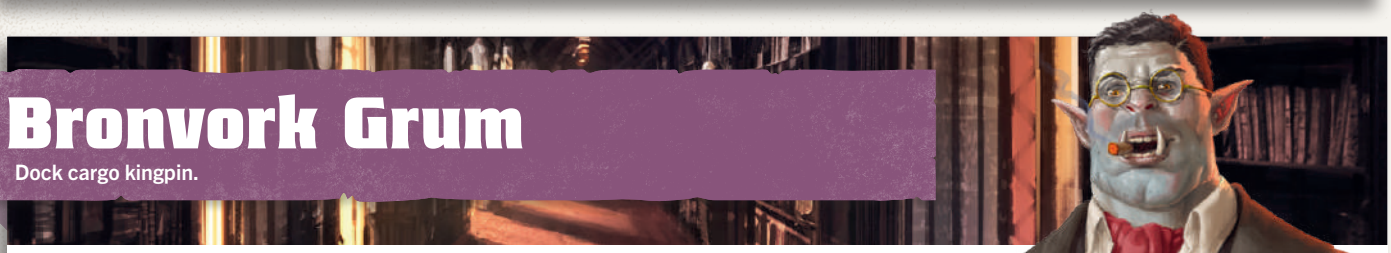
FEATURE There are Consortium workshops in ports across the realm. Each one has a sign showing a dragon turtle holding a wrench in its mouth. The seal can also be seen on staff uniforms and paperwork.

SECRET A senior engineer from the Consortium plans to break away and establish a new shipwrights' guild. Behind closed doors, they're persuading other mechanics to join them with lucrative contracts.

FACTION • HUGE (100+) • NEUTRAL • INDUSTRY

Bronvork Grum

Dock cargo kingpin.



A lit cigar droops from the figure's tusked mouth, veiling his stern features in thick smoke. His heavy brows are furrowed in silent concentration.

KNOWN FOR As the region's most powerful shipping magnate, nothing leaves or enters Bronvork's territory without him taking a generous cut. Though physically imposing, he prefers striking deals and issuing threats, leaving the physical violence to his lackeys.

APPEARANCE Bronvork's dark suit has been tailored to fit his broad shoulders, and his hair is combed neatly to one side. He speaks with a low and often sarcastic drawl.

GOAL Bronvork believes his power depends on strict control of his operations. Anyone who disrespects him faces swift and severe consequences.

SECRET Five years ago, Bronvork was engaged, but his fiancée vanished. Ever since, he's thrown himself obsessively into his work.

LOOT

- Golden pocket watch
- Folding boat*
- Diamond engagement ring

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • ORC • NOBLE

TOUGH BOSS / BANDIT CRIME LORD

Kellby Whelk

For-hire hull scraper.

KNOWN FOR Kellby Whelk is a merfolk hull scraper with a unique approach: she chats to barnacles and politely asks them to return to the sea. These negotiations can last hours, but eventually leave ship hulls spotless.

APPEARANCE Kellby has teal skin and vibrant-green frills along her cheeks that twitch when she's annoyed. She wears a tool belt stocked with chisels and scrapers, though she prefers diplomacy over force.

GOAL Kellby earns coin using her animal-speaking gifts, and charges premium rates for her gentle methods. She's diligently saving up to attend an elite underwater university course specialising in interspecies relations.

SECRET She once argued with an aggressive seagull, which now attacks her whenever she's dockside. The bird hurls insults only animal-speakers can hear, but Kellby does her best to stay professional.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • MERFOLK • NATURALIST

MERFOLK SKIRMISHER / DRUID

Player characters with sailor or pirate backgrounds will have a rapport with NPCs at the docks.

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Cargo Moulds

Shipment mimics.

KNOWN FOR Cargo moulds infest ship holds, consuming and replacing items until the entire deck is taken over. They often arrive disguised as harmless objects like coins or boxes.

APPEARANCE These mimics disguise themselves as items within the ship's hold. They transform into an amorphous, sinewy blob with sharp, gnashing teeth when attacked.

SECRET Cargo moulds have a hard time maintaining their false appearance in high temperatures. Applying heat is a good way to check for an infestation.

CREATURE • MEDIUM • NEUTRAL • MONSTROSITY

Constance Keele

Pedantic customs officer.

KNOWN FOR Sailors hope that Officer Keele isn't on duty when they come into port. If there's the slightest error in their paperwork, she'll gleefully pull out her "denied" stamp.

APPEARANCE Constance keeps her hair in a tight, fishtail braid and carries a clipboard. Although not a sailor herself, she wears a blue naval coat, which is a size too big for her.

SECRET Constance's father was in the navy until he was injured by poorly maintained equipment. His superior officers covered up their mistakes by falsifying paperwork.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • HUMAN • OFFICIAL

Keiran Summersong

Stranded student.

KNOWN FOR After boarding the wrong ship on the way to his new school, Keiran was left marooned on the other side of the world with no money for a return trip.

APPEARANCE Unable to afford a barber, Keiran's hair has grown shaggy beneath his school cap. His worn satchel is bulging with books.

GOAL As well as trying to get home, Keiran keeps a journal of his travels. He hopes his tutors will accept his notes in place of all the school work he's missed.

SECRET Keiran's journal details the ships that pass through the docks. It contains evidence that would expose illegal fishing operations.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • ELF • SAGE

COMMONER / NOBLE

Codex Cartel

Smugglers of forbidden knowledge.

KNOWN FOR Members of this secretive group arrive into port under the cover of darkness. They trade banned publications and propaganda out of sight of the authorities.

GOAL The Codex Cartel stands firmly against censorship of information. They smuggle rare books to fund and distribute a free, radical newsletter — *The Black Sail Almanac*.

SECRET A schism is growing within the group. Some want to begin spreading misinformation about the authorities, while others remain loyal to sharing only hidden truths.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • NEUTRAL • CRIMINAL

Morhua Aguefin

Eldritch angler.

KNOWN FOR Morhua runs a fishmonger's stall by day and fishes at sea all night, never sleeping. She sells aberrant fish and marine oddities used for spell components.

APPEARANCE She is tall for a dwarf and wears a patched, purple anorak. Her pale-green eyes bulge slightly, and rarely blink, making her look fishy in more ways than one.

SECRET Morhua refers to herself as "we" due to a psychic connection with an eldritch anglerfish kept in a tank at her stall. It's hard to tell who is in control, Morhua or the fish.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • DWARF • MERCHANT

More Dock Dwellers

1. MONA BENDIS Vendor selling hearty eel pies to travellers.
2. FENTOS TAFAN Chatty satyr who lives on a houseboat.
3. JANA ROSER Halfling smuggler looking for their next job.
4. LANCE GRIMSHAW Naval recruiter working for the crown.
5. MISTY DAWN Catfolk navigator enjoying some shore leave.
6. TARON CUTT Sailor kicked off their ship for insubordination.
7. GRIZA SMOCK Dries and smokes fresh fish in a small shed.
8. BRANDIS CAMP Fleeing thief hoping to stowaway on a ship.
9. ARA NZEL Tiefling artist sketching the ships that come in.
10. SAF LIGHTFALL Cryptozoologist looking to charter a boat.

Silt Scouts

Shoreline treasure trawlers.

KNOWN FOR This group of werewolves are found under piers at low tide. They use their keen senses to dig through muck by the light of the moon in search of hidden treasures.

GOAL Silt Scouts were formed as a way for local werewolves to sate their canine impulses in a fun, social way. Finding valuable items is a perk, but not the purpose of their meets.

SECRET A member recently found a rusty cursed necklace, but kept it to themselves. The individual who found it has skipped two meetings and the group is growing worried.

FACTION • MICRO (1–5) • FRIENDLY • SOCIAL

One of these dock dwellers could be a useful contact if your party needs passage on a ship.

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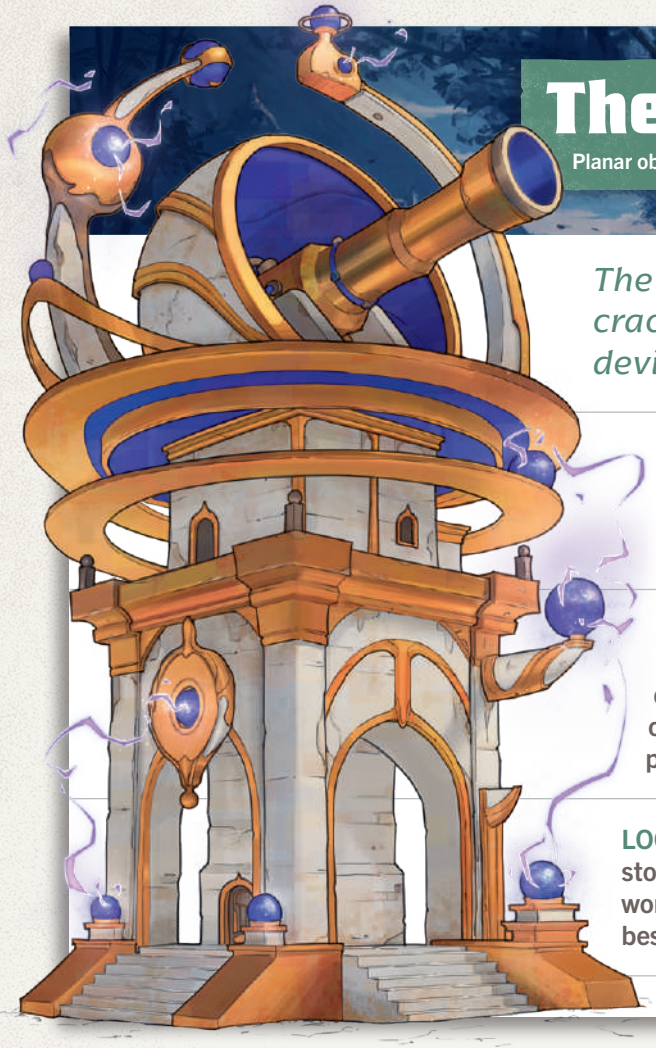

The Erulean Eye

Planar observatory.

The observatory rises in white marble and gold, crackling with violet arcs from charged arcane devices. Above, a vast telescope watches the stars.

KNOWN FOR Originally built to chart constellations, this golden observatory changed purpose after its mages developed a new type of telescope with transplanar sight. The observatory, called the Erulean Eye, now peers into distant realms beyond our own.

APPEARANCE The planar scope rests under a retractable dome. Magically charged astral orbs channel arcane energy to power its complex mechanisms.

LAYOUT The central chamber contains the astral core, which produces the energy needed to see into other planes. A map room sits below the scope.

LOOT The astral core and orbs store huge arcane power. Mage workers leave belongings in trunks beside their dormitory beds.

SECRET The planar windows that the Erulean Eye opens are two-way. Scope users are often being watched in return.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • ARCANE • OBSERVATORY

Gilderly Hall

Architect training college.

KNOWN FOR Gilderly Hall is an elite school of architecture, and hosts the realm's most promising designers. Its sprawling campus has a library, museum and six lecture halls.

APPEARANCE The campus is always under construction, as each new head of department tries to put their stamp on it. This has led to an ugly mismatch of architectural styles.

SECRET An unsecured basement archive contains detailed blueprints of notable buildings, from prisons to palaces. However, the disorganised records are tricky to sort through.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • ACADEMIC • SCHOOL

Satchel Cottage

Enchanted library.

KNOWN FOR This quaint library specialises in tomes on conjuration, evocation and illusion. Books scuttle forward when called, despite the lack of any formal ordering system.

APPEARANCE The stone cottage has three floors connected by a spiral staircase. Shelves go all the way to the roof, while a side room houses the owner's bedroom and kitchenette.

SECRET Awakened books perform chores for the owner like cooking meals and sweeping floors. They even assist with digging trenches in the vegetable garden.

BUILDING • SMALL • ARCANE • LIBRARY

Centre for Animal Trials

Unethical animal lab.

KNOWN FOR The Centre for Animal Trials, or CAT, is the realm's leading institution for zoological research. It is renowned for new species discovery, and infamous for permitting unrestricted and unethical experiments.

APPEARANCE The building is made from dark volcanic rock, with a glass roof and grey columns. Thirteen strange feline statues decorate the grassy courtyard. They are the petrified victims of an escaped cockatrice.

LAYOUT Inside, a black-and-white tiled entrance hall shows off taxidermy monkeys frozen mid-climb across a chandelier. Four corridors stretch outward, each lined with dozens of windowless labs lit only by the glass roof.

SECRET Beneath the main laboratories lies a sealed level that isn't marked on any floor plans. It is home to failed experiments and whimpering hybrids that are too unstable to release, yet too valuable for destruction.

BUILDING • SMALL • ZOOLOGICAL • LABORATORY

There's no better place for a big lore drop than in a library or other centre of learning.

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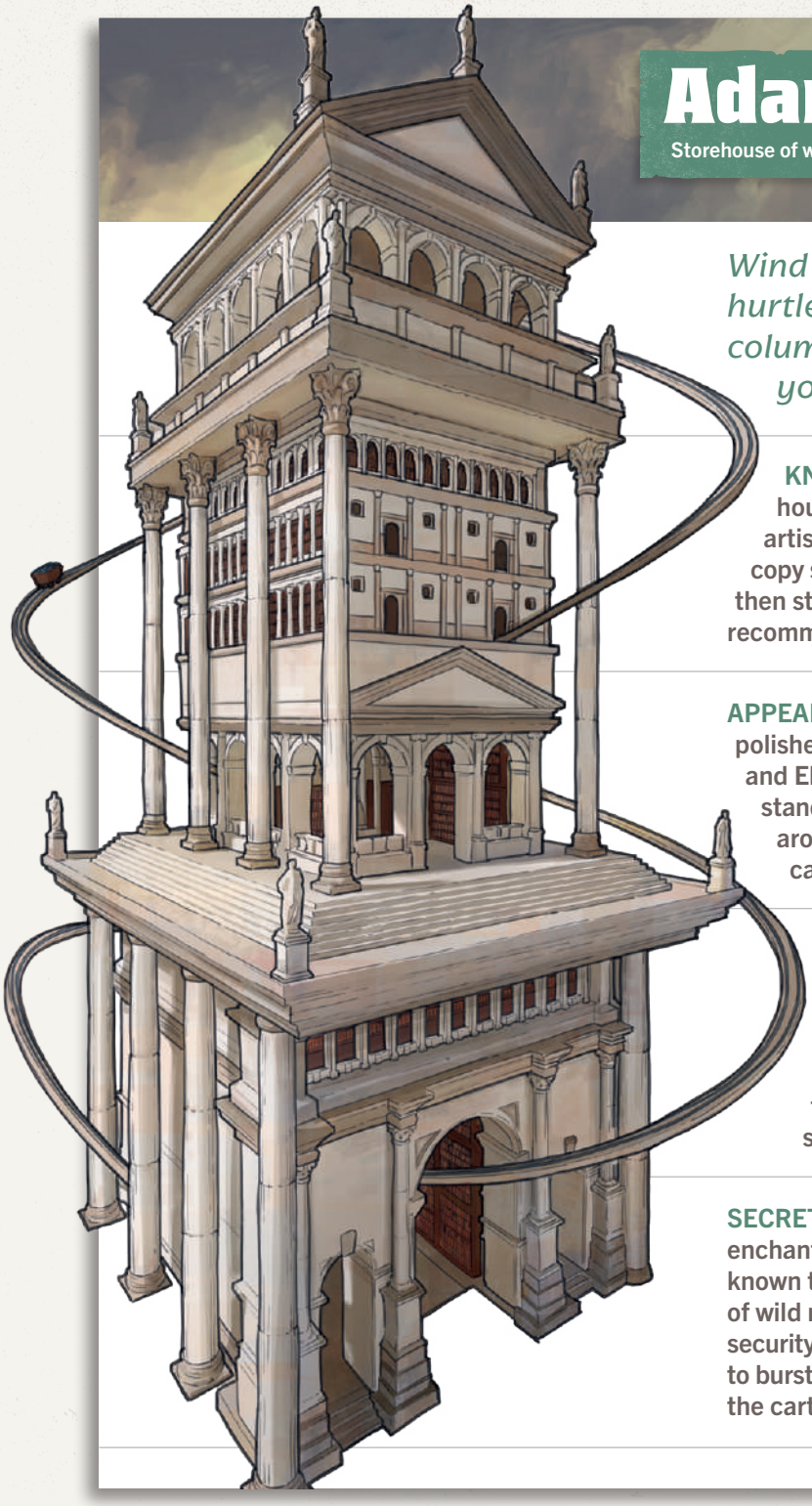

Adamaster Archives

Storehouse of written knowledge.

Wind lashes your face as the rickety cart hurtles forward. Before you hit a marble column, the track twists with a jolt, plunging you screaming back into the darkness.

KNOWN FOR The Adamaster Archives were created to house and catalogue the world's historical, insightful or artistic texts. Whenever a new written work is created, a copy should be sent to the Adamaster Archives, where it is then stored in perpetuity. Visitors must provide a letter of recommendation from an approved college to gain access.

APPEARANCE Visitors approaching the Archives are met by polished white marble walls with intricate carvings of runes and Elvish scripts. Life-sized statues of famed scholars stand in every corner. Cart tracks weave throughout and around the Archives, occasionally sending book-laden carts and giddy researchers whizzing past.

LAYOUT A grand desk dominates in the lobby. Beyond it, transport carts line up to carry visitors to shelf-filled floors lined with endless scrolls and books.

LOOT Adamaster holds countless tomes, valued either for their knowledge or extreme rarity. The most precious texts are locked in vaults deep within the building's core.

SECRET When overloaded with enchanted tomes, carts can be known to emit unstable bursts of wild magic. This can cause security wards to fail, documents to burst into flames, or throw the cart into another plane.

ENCOUNTERS

- Imp hiding in the shelves
- Construct security patrol
- Scholars refused access
- Hidden door opens
- Cart traffic jam
- Philosophers debating

BUILDING • LARGE • ACADEMIC • LIBRARY

Lilioid Hothouse

Greenhouse laboratory.

KNOWN FOR The Lilioid Hothouse is equipped with arcane temperature controls. Precise botanical research can be carried out here year round, no matter the weather outside.

APPEARANCE The Hothouse is a long, glass building with multiple sections. Each zone has its own microclimate suited to the magical flora planted inside.

SECRET If the climate spellcraft fails, or is tampered with, greenhouse temperatures can quickly reach extreme highs or lows. This can be deadly for both plants and humanoids.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • BOTANICAL • LABORATORY

Atticus Dormitory

Levitating dormitory block.

KNOWN FOR Nicknamed "the Attic", this floating dormitory hovers above a university. It houses hundreds of students, without taking up space on the school grounds.

APPEARANCE This stately mansion block hovers 40 feet above the ground. An enormous flying carpet offers shuttle rides back and forth for students unable to fly themselves.

SECRET Students from a rival school have graffitied over the runes keeping the dorm aloft. If they aren't cleaned soon, the Attic could sink and crush the buildings below.

BUILDING • LARGE • ACADEMIC • DORMITORY

Spellcasters should think carefully before throwing a fireball in a venue filled with paper!

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The Olivford Museum

Showcase of extinct animals.

KNOWN FOR The Olivford Museum is a favourite spot for tourists and field trips. It's known for its dioramas of extinct animals that have been enchanted to move realistically.

APPEARANCE The brick-built museum has four cavernous galleries with vaulted ceilings. Each room is themed around a specific prehistoric biome, with creatures from that habitat.

SECRET The rainforest gallery's enchantments have been known to distort time. A child once vanished for 10 minutes but returned as a teen – an event denied by the museum.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • ZOOLOGICAL • MUSEUM

Mrs Mellor's Academy

Charity-run school.

KNOWN FOR Children who attend Mrs Mellor's Academy receive an education plus books, uniforms and three meals a day. This school is totally funded by charitable donations.

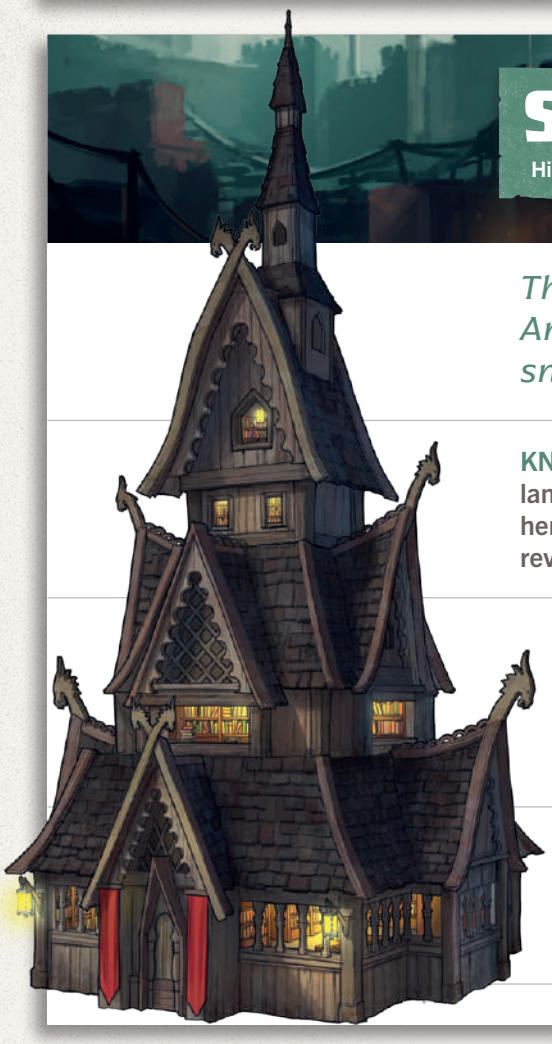
APPEARANCE The timber school building is showing signs of wear and tear, and its textbooks have clearly been used multiple times. Students study in one of three classrooms.

SECRET Children have complained about a poltergeist splashing water in the bathrooms. Unable to afford experts, the school has asked the janitor to investigate.

BUILDING • SMALL • ACADEMIC • SCHOOL

Sprakkonda Centre

Historic hall of languages.



There is none of the normal hush of a library here. Amid the swell of chatter, you catch overlapping snippets of languages both familiar and unknown.

KNOWN FOR The Sprakkonda Centre's records note every known mortal language spanning millennia. Skilled scribes and translators study tirelessly here, mastering forgotten dialects and evolving speech. Visiting scholars revere the centre as a sacred place of profound linguistic knowledge.

APPEARANCE The Centre has ebony latticework and pointed roofs with carvings of dragons. Its shutters can lower to shield scrolls and papers from sunlight.

LAYOUT The oldest, rarest stone tablets are stored in the basement to reduce strain on the floorboards. Private study spaces are found on the east side of all floors.

LOOT The Centre charges a hefty entrance fee. Collected funds are stored in the administrator's office in an iron chest.

SECRET A dictionary of infernal legal terms has been permanently locked away, after multiple scribes lost their souls while translating it.

BUILDING • LARGE • ACADEMIC • LIBRARY

Aronnax College

Underwater university.

KNOWN FOR Aronnax College is located at the bottom of the ocean, and teaches amphibious students. Exchange programmes offer land-dwellers courses in elemental magic.

APPEARANCE Built on a sandy sea floor, students swim past kelp sports fields on their way to class. A coral-lined courtyard has a statue of Aronnax College's fishfolk founder.

SECRET The plaque on the founder's statue gives cryptic clues that lead to their secret storeroom. They hid a chest of platinum and magic items for a worthy student to find.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • ARCANE • SCHOOL

More Scholarly Buildings

1. **VERBOT VAULTS** Locked library full of banned books.
2. **CRANKCASE COLLEGE** Goblin-founded artificer's academy.
3. **BUNKER C** Secretive centre specialising in psionic research.
4. **SPARKS NURSERY** Crèche for magically gifted babies.
5. **SCHOOL OF NEEDLES** Leading textiles and fashion college.
6. **FREYJA HALLS** Tactical learning base for military cadets.
7. **HIGHMORE SPIRES** Exclusive private boarding school.
8. **THE BARN** Rustic lecture theatre hosting touring professors.
9. **SPHERE OF THE DEVOUT** Ancient theological college.
10. **TERRAN LIBRARY** Archive of every map ever produced.

Is access to knowledge restricted in your homebrew world?

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Doctor Bellicity Candlewick

Vigilante art historian.

KNOWN FOR Bellicity is a well-known art history lecturer who gives humorous, hands-on lessons. Her expertise in brushwork and pigments has made her a valuable consultant for local town guards tackling forgery cases.

APPEARANCE Bellicity wears mustard robes and large pieces of beaded jewellery, including earrings and a statement collar. When she inspects a piece of art, she swaps her regular spectacles for a magnifying glass.

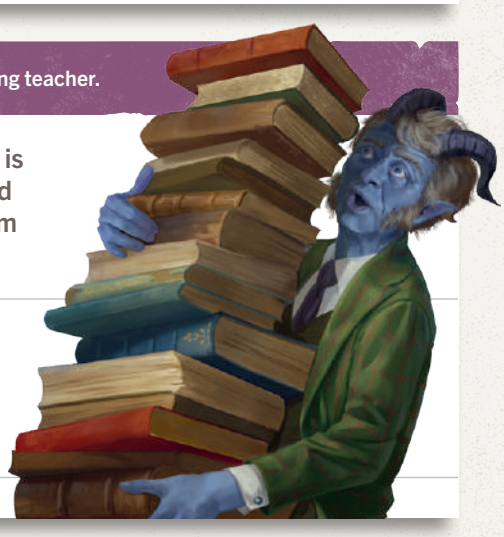
GOAL Driven by justice, Bellicity is keen to dismantle the criminal network of art forgers she discovered while aiding the town guard. She has sacrificed many of her work hours and evenings to help crack the case.

SECRET The university dean dislikes Bellicity's growing law enforcement involvement, and has warned her twice already. If Bellicity doesn't return her focus to teaching soon, she faces losing her prestigious position.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • DWARF • SAGE — SPY / WARRIOR VETERAN

Professor Solen Elthir

Magically multitasking teacher.



KNOWN FOR Solen is always polite, calm and happy to help despite his workload. Magical duplicates help him with his admin and lesson plans.

APPEARANCE Solen's nutmeg hair is streaked with silver, and punctuated by two curling horns. His simulacrum duplicates shimmer at the edges.

GOAL Solen's institution is understaffed and underfunded, but that won't stop him teaching. He finds magical workarounds to his problems.

SECRET To manage his impossible workload, Solen uses forbidden chronomancy. He pulls extra hours from his own future lifespan.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • TIEFLING • SAGE — MAGE / ARCHMAGE

Society of the Ruby Chalice

Elitist student society.

KNOWN FOR Behind thick velvet curtains and locked doors, the Society of the Ruby Chalice hosts their famous candlelit banquets. Its members are chosen for their poisonous charm and cut-throat ambition.

GOAL Every banquet is a ritual; bloody pacts sealed with laughter and wine. Members are bound together beyond friendship and beyond death. The Society is a network that benefits its members long after graduation.

FEATURE Members wear a visible ruby-encrusted pin, necklace or cufflinks. At events, everyone present sips from a blood-filled goblet, in honour of the society's original vampiric founder.

SECRET A student paper claims some of the school's professors are enthralled by the Society's alumni. One editor disappeared after printing the story, and their locked dormitory room is now considered off-limits.

FACTION • HUGE (100+) • NEUTRAL • SOCIAL

Happily Ever Afters

Romance book club.

KNOWN FOR This book club holds its monthly meetings in a cosy library corner. They read a variety of romance subgenres, but generally prefer stories with a happy ending.

GOAL The club gather to discuss their reading, but also to spend time with like-minded romantics. Between them, this chatty and welcoming group know all the local gossip.

SECRET One of the members is a mild-mannered wereboar. They get quite flustered whenever someone suggests reading a book with a lycanthrope as the brooding love interest.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • FRIENDLY • SOCIAL

Folioflies

Book-eating caterpillars.

KNOWN FOR Folioflies, also known as bookworms, lay eggs in book spines. They hatch and munch paper in caterpillar form, then emerge as butterflies when the pages are opened.

APPEARANCE A foliofly's dull, papery chrysalis is hard to spot on dusty parchment. They grow delicate, translucent wings with inky markings lifted directly from the page.

SECRET Folioflies can destroy a whole library if the collection is not well-maintained. Criminals release these insects as a clever way to destroy incriminating paper records.

CREATURE • TINY • NEUTRAL • BEAST

Educated NPCs may already know the information your party seeks, or know how they could find it.

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Waddlesworth

School mascot automaton.

The cheerful, feathered automaton waddles forward with a clank, lets out a spirited honk, then gives two big thumbs-up.

KNOWN FOR This costumed clockwork duck was built to boost school spirit. Nicknamed Waddlesworth, it rallies crowds at athletic events and soothes anxious students by parading through halls before exams.

APPEARANCE A tunic in school colours is worn over Waddlesworth's feather-coated brass frame. The construct's eyes change colour to reflect its programmed mood.

TACTICS Waddlesworth cycles through five pre-recorded rallying quacks, each magically boosting energy in nearby students.

LAIR Between events, the construct powers down in the school trophy room. It is motion-activated, and wakes when someone enters.

SECRET Waddlesworth stores archived recordings of school history, and is a treasure trove of heartfelt stories and triumphant victories.

CLOCKWORK MASCOT
Medium Construct

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
18 (+4)	8 (-1)	18 (+4)	6 (-2)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)

Armour Class: 17 (natural armour)
Hit Points: 126 (14d10 + 56)
Speed: 30 ft
Initiative: -1

Immunities: Poison; Charmed, Exhaustion, Frightened, Paralyzed, Petrified, Poisoned
Passive Perception: 10
Languages: Understands commands given in any language but can't speak
Proficiency Bonus: +3

ABILITIES

Cheerleader. Any allies within 30 ft of the mascot have advantage on attack rolls and saving throws, unless the mascot has the Incapacitated condition.

Fragile Machinery. If the mascot takes lightning damage, it has disadvantage on attack rolls and ability checks until the end of its next turn.

Magic Resistance. The mascot has advantage on saving throws against spells and magical effects.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The mascot makes three Fist Bump attacks.

Fist Bump. Melee Weapon Attack: +7 to hit, reach 5 ft, one target. Hit: 20 (5d6 + 4) bludgeoning damage.

Anthem Blast. Wisdom Saving Throw: DC 11, each enemy within 20 ft of the mascot. Failure: 20 (3d10 + 4) thunder damage, and the target has the Charmed condition until the end of the mascot's next turn. Success: Half damage only.

CHALLENGE RATING 6

You could alternatively use the stats of an Animated Armour CR 1, Hobgoblin Captain CR 3 or Stone Golem CR 10.

CREATURE • MEDIUM • FRIENDLY • CONSTRUCT

Creer Serpentscale

Accident-prone student.

KNOWN FOR Creer is famously unlucky; he's failed his exams three times and constantly causes accidents. Everyone at school knows the phrase "Oh dear, oh Creer!", which follows his every fall, mistake or misstep.

APPEARANCE Creer's uniform is untidy with an untucked shirt, crooked tie and scuffed shoes. His wool pullover bears the school crest, but is covered in crumbs. A blue streak runs through his messy black hair.

GOAL He believes he's destined to help a hero defeat a terrible dragon — his father told him so. Creer is waiting patiently for the adventurer's arrival, hoping each new friend he makes might finally be the one.

SECRET Creer is a shape-shifted couatl in disguise. His bumbling nature is an act to hide his divine knowledge and power. He purposely underachieves to stay hidden, until he meets the hero and his real purpose begins.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • CELESTIAL • SAGE

PRIEST / COUATL

Encourage your players to think about their character's education as part of their backstory.

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The Bestiarum Arcanum

Scholars dedicated to studying magical beasts.

KNOWN FOR Bestiarum Arcanum members venture into cursed forests, volcanic mountains and forgotten ruins to document magical beasts in the wild. They gather samples, and avoid becoming prey themselves.

GOAL The group's mission is to expand and preserve their massive tome, which catalogues every known magical creature. They have discovered all kinds of animals, from emerald stirges to snub-nosed krakens.

FEATURE Members carry a "bestiary beacon", an enchanted compass that points towards the nearest uncatalogued creature in range. The compass face glows with different colours depending on the creature type.

SECRET The bestiary beacon doesn't just detect nearby creatures, it marks them with a magical sigil. In some cases, the beacon agitates the target, making it easier to track but more likely to lash out.

FACTION • MEDIUM (20–49) • NEUTRAL • ACADEMIC

Professor Gralkin Chalk

Mathematics tutor.

KNOWN FOR Gralkin is known for his creative lessons. He uses comedy, puppet shows and real pie diagrams to make complex mathematics equations simple and fun.

APPEARANCE This small, copper-scaled kobold builds his students up with kind words. The pockets of his dusty cardigan are brimming with writing tools and crumpled notes.

SECRET Gralkin is secretly building a brand-new escape room experience. He tests each puzzle carefully on his students to refine challenges before the final design is ready.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • KOBOLD • SAGE

The Crucibilists

Aspiring alchemists.

KNOWN FOR The Crucibilists are a joke among the rest of the academic community. To date, their alchemical efforts to turn iron into gold have resulted in dramatic failure.

GOAL The Crucibilists' objective is to master the art of alchemy. Under new leadership, they also want to transform their reputation by conducting experiments more carefully.

SECRET They did transmute iron into gold once, but the gold rapidly decayed into rust within hours. They're hiding the breakthrough while working to stabilise the experiment.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • NEUTRAL • ACADEMIC

More Scholars

1. SION QUIKSHAND Historian who knows many obscure facts.
2. RYNAR RATHMIR Archaeologist who bullies their dig crew.
3. ORAX VOLTWYND Young inventor with a big announcement.
4. THELRIC VERSFERD Linguist specialising in ancient riddles.
5. SORRAL WEALD Biologist who smuggles rare plant species.
6. ERYNDOR BRIGHS Rune expert obsessed with an old book.
7. RAVINA MITHAL Scholar of myths about rare magic items.
8. ZAYN LAFARNE Cheery geographer and field trip leader.
9. VITO RALISON Astronomer predicting a rare celestial event.
10. LYN ELGAR Poetry professor and head of college events.

Principal Evelaine Duskwell

Frightening headteacher.

KNOWN FOR For over two centuries, Principal Evelaine has ruled her school with iron-fisted discipline. Staff and students obey her without question, those who don't tend to vanish.

APPEARANCE She glides silently through the halls cloaked in heavy, high-collared black robes. Evelaine speaks in a slow, monotone voice that lulls her listeners into boredom.

SECRET A cracked portrait in her office shows Evelaine hasn't aged in 250 years. An oni in disguise, she devours rebellious children to sustain her monstrous immortality.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • FIEND • SAGE

Gaetana Lumere

Planar philosopher.

KNOWN FOR Gaetana recently published a groundbreaking essay, challenging the current beliefs about the planes. They are on a lecture tour to share their ideas.

APPEARANCE During lectures or book talks, Gaetana likes to pace rather than sit. They wear their gold pince-nez glasses for reading and signing autographs.

GOAL Gaetana wants to make their work accessible. They focus their talks on practical applications, such as reliable travel and communication across realms.

SECRET Gaetana is planning a study to test their theories. The recruitment process is secretive, as participants risk being forever stranded on another plane.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • HUMAN • SAGE — NOBLE / MAGE

Certain knowledge might be dangerous to share. The party could be hunted for what they know.

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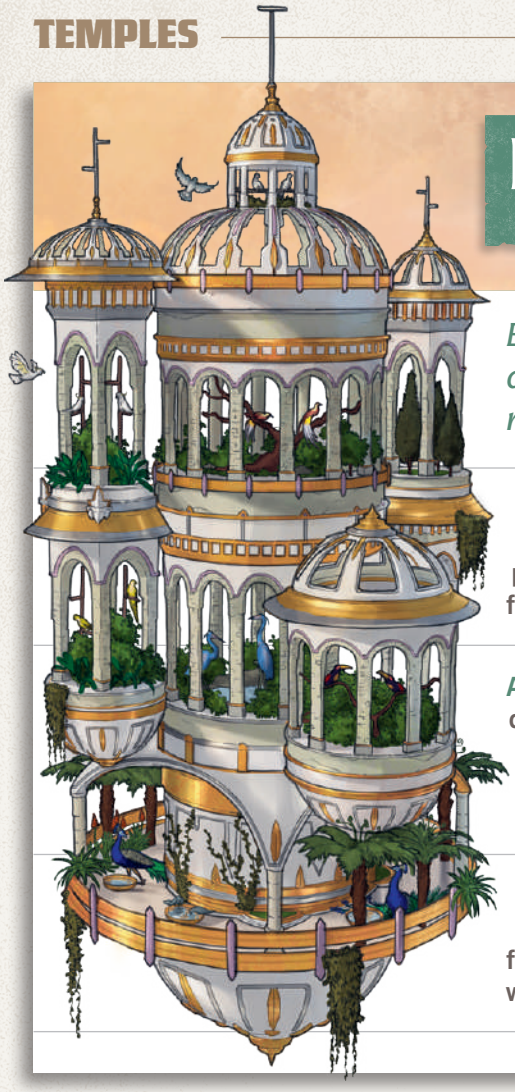

Prayer Roost

Aviary of divine messengers.

Birds flit in and out of the aviary, a blur of movement and colour. You're sure they can't all be native to the region and yet they fly together, perfectly at ease.

KNOWN FOR The birds of the Prayer Roost are holy messengers, bridging the gap between the mortal and the divine. People hoping to have their prayers answered bring an offering of food for the animals; if a bird eats the food, the message is received and will be passed on to the gods.

APPEARANCE The aviary is a tiered, domed building with open panels to let the birds move freely. Perches and bird baths are dotted around, along with plinths for offerings.

LAYOUT The Prayer Roost has four tiers populated by herons, toucans, doves and more. Each domed nest represents a different god, with their own unique messenger birds.

LOOT Birds can shed feathers that bestow divine blessings. However, forcibly taking a feather from a bird will inflict a curse on the perpetrator.

SECRET On very rare occasions, a messenger bird will take an angelic, humanoid form to offer direct aid to a worthy believer.

BUILDING • LARGE • RURAL • TEMPLE

Lastlight Spire

Tower of spirits.

KNOWN FOR Pilgrims visit the Lastlight Spire to speak with the dead. Most leave weeping, others grateful, and some are taken by the spirits and never leave at all.

APPEARANCE The crooked tower leans westward and its rusted gate creaks open by itself. Inside, the air is cold and stale, filled with flickering lights and whispering shadows.

SECRET When the moon turns blood-red above Lastlight, the veil thins. Spirits summoned on these nights may return fully formed, wholly alive, but not quite who they were.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • ISOLATED • SHRINE

Sunhollow Sanctuary

Shrine to the sun.

KNOWN FOR Sunhollow Sanctuary lies in a rocky sandstone ravine. Hot winds whistle through its natural arches, as devoted keepers tend the shrine beneath a scorching sky.

APPEARANCE The walls are covered with fragments of terracotta pottery and glass, forming mosaics of radiant suns. Pilgrims wedge beads and bone charms between the cracks.

SECRET Deep in the Sanctuary are the remains of a prophet. This divine champion was buried with a Wand of Fireballs, only usable by a true follower of the shrine's god.

BUILDING • SMALL • ISOLATED • SHRINE

The Broiling Maw

Volcanic temple.

KNOWN FOR The Broiling Maw is carved into the side of an erupting volcano. Molten rivers flow beneath its stone floors; only divine wards protect inhabitants from the heat.

APPEARANCE Worshippers follow a circular path from the volcano mouth down into its core. A platform floats on the bubbling magma, topped with an obsidian altar.

SECRET Those who pray for too long near the altar are changed. Their eyes glow, and they mutter in a forgotten tongue. Clerics say the volcano speaks through them.

BUILDING • SMALL • RURAL • TEMPLE

More Temples and Shrines

1. **SPIRAL OF SENSES** Each floor honours a different sense.
2. **CORAL HOLLOW** Underwater temple, lit by glowing plants.
3. **THE BLADED PIT** Blood sport arena dedicated to a war god.
4. **PATHLESS SHRINE** Hidden temple that pilgrims must find.
5. **GARDEN OF VOWS** Shrine to a god of happy marriages.
6. **HAVENSTORM** Traditional place of refuge from danger.
7. **MIRACULUM** Grand temple building with illusory ceiling.
8. **BAREWORD TEMPLE** Space where only truth can be spoken.
9. **WISEDOM HALL** Temple that doubles as a historical archive.
10. **THE DIVINE ROOT** Tiny shrine built into an ancient tree.

Is this temple the only one in the area? Or does each settlement have shrines to multiple deities?

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Temple of the Eternal Slither

Temple dedicated to serpents.

KNOWN FOR The Temple of the Eternal Slither is hidden deep within a dense jungle. It's reachable only after a six-day trek through thick mud, tangled vines and buzzing insects.

APPEARANCE This tunnel-like stone temple is shaped like a winding serpent, with wide jaws providing an entrance. Green moss and vines coat the outer walls, like slick scales.

SECRET The world's deadliest collection of snake venom and antivenom is stored at the tail end of the temple. Diligent temple clerics keep the stores under heavy lock and key.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • ISOLATED • TEMPLE

Whisperstone Pools

Temple surrounded by hot springs.

KNOWN FOR Visitors to this serene outside temple are asked to take cleansing baths to purify themselves before entering. Water in its pools comes from sacred hot springs.

APPEARANCE Teardrop-shaped basins circle the stone temple, each large enough for one bather. Inside, a central spring-fed pool is illuminated by several lit braziers.

SECRET Only temple clerics are allowed to bathe in the inner pool's wisdom-granting water. They prevent outsiders from bathing in it to hoard the pool's power for themselves.

BUILDING • SMALL • URBAN • BATH

Caprinae Retreat

Precarious mountain temple.

In the distance, you see a cluster of tiled roofs. The building is balanced so treacherously close to mountain's edge that it seems to hang in mid-air.

KNOWN FOR Perched atop jagged cliffs, this remote monastery can only be reached by scaling a perilous mountain path. Surviving the ascent proves a pilgrim's devotion, granting them entry. Residents sleep in austere stone cells, where they receive vivid and prophetic visions from the gods.

APPEARANCE A white, five-storey building clings to the top of a rocky mountain outcrop. It overlooks sheer cliffs on all sides, with slippery rock and limited footholds.

LAYOUT Each part of the journey features a different danger: harsh climbs with no space to catch your breath, landslide-prone slopes, and gradually thinning air.

LOOT Pilgrims drop ropes, broken pitons and dried food along the climb. Stone talismans are given to pilgrims who reach the temple.

SECRET A narrow escape chute hides below a trapdoor in the lowest temple building. It slides through the mountain to the valley below.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • ISOLATED • TEMPLE

Blizenkirth

Temple of storms.

KNOWN FOR Blizenkirth is hit by deadly lightning hundreds of times a day. It is built on a metal platform a few miles out to sea, in a spot known for constant rolling storms.

APPEARANCE The blue temple is fortress-like in its design. It has 10 large turrets, each topped with a lightning rod, chunky ramparts and tiny arrow-slit windows.

SECRET Blizenkirth is built on the back of a colossal, chained sea titan pinned to the ocean floor. The titan is barely alive, and trembles with each painful lightning strike overhead.

BUILDING • LARGE • RURAL • TEMPLE

Benediction Theatre

Space for worshipful performances.

KNOWN FOR No matter the time of day, Benediction Theatre is bright and lively with song. Its performers dance, give speeches and recite scriptures in honour of the gods.

APPEARANCE Benediction Theatre is an emerald-painted, wooden hall with a roaring central hearth. At its heart, a polished circular stage welcomes worshippers to perform.

SECRET Gods sometimes visit Benediction Theatre in disguise to enjoy a front row seat to mortals singing their praises. They bless performers who please them.

BUILDING • LARGE • URBAN • HALL

Causing damage to a temple can attract the anger of priests, worshippers, or even the gods themselves.

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The Sanctified Chord

Choir that channels the divine.

KNOWN FOR The Sanctified Chord is a choral group with flawless vocals. Their worship is so powerful, it can draw divine energy into those who listen. After joining, each member vows to only use their voice for singing.

GOAL The group was created to further the presence of the gods on the Material Plane through music. Vocalists are all fervent believers in their deity, and happily attend daily rehearsals to perfect their performances.

FEATURE Uniforms consist of green robes, sage slacks and lime neck ruffs. The choir director wears an over-the-shoulder yellow sash. Vocalists wear sacred masks to cover their mouths in between performances.

SECRET Leaders of the group are currently investigating a vocalist who spoke outside of choral training. The member's voice was filled with such holy power that it shattered the windows of their small home.

FACTION • LARGE (50–99) • NEUTRAL • RELIGIOUS

Rizenghuls

Fiends trapped in censers.

KNOWN FOR Rizenghuls are spiteful, bear-like fiends. All 50 in existence were trapped in censers by paladins years ago, but still whisper telepathically to underprepared acolytes.

APPEARANCE A warped, grey carapace covers a rizenghul's pustule-ridden, bloated body. Their censer prisons are bladed to deter anyone from touching them or getting too close.

SECRET Saying the word "rizenghul" near a censer shatters its magical seals. This ancient secret has been lost to time, risking the release of the fiends within.

CREATURE • LARGE • HOSTILE • FIEND

Bogiss Bladderwick

Incompetent temple caretaker.

KNOWN FOR Bogiss has been the temple's gardener and caretaker for years. Despite this, he always forgets where things go and tidies at the most inappropriate of times.

APPEARANCE Bogiss wears a long coat that drags along the floor, sweeping behind him. His straight moustache matches the shape of his old broom's bristled head.

SECRET After spilling soapy water on a mural and dropping a sacred sceptre into a pot of stew, Bogiss is on his final warning. One more misstep and he will be fired.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • HUMAN • LABOURER

Lady Uliver Greybench

Retired paladin.

KNOWN FOR After decades of battle across distant lands, Lady Uliver earned fame as a holy warrior. Now, she uses her influence to campaign for lasting peace.

APPEARANCE Lady Uliver refuses to don her armour. Instead, she wears vestments and jewellery with sacred symbols. A pale pink scar travels from her eye to her jaw.

GOAL Lady Uliver protests for peace outside temples she believes enable wars, joined by a chattering rabble of picketing villagers.

SECRET During a battle, Lady Uliver received a shocking vision from her god. She saw that an apocalypse will come to pass, unless global wars end for good.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HUMAN • WORSHIPPER — TOUGH / KNIGHT

More Temple Workers

1. FIARA SPOKES Prints hymn sheets on the temple press.
2. WAT TAGRAN Carpenter restoring wooden pews and statues.
3. VITORI HEYES Noble who gave up a fortune to be a priest.
4. MICKON FRY Temple guard specialising in unarmed combat.
5. ISHUN ROI Gathers fresh decorative foliage each morning.
6. ENID QUAYRUN Well-meaning acolyte who always runs late.
7. BROTHER GREY Cleric who has taken a vow of solitude.
8. REY LOTHA Undercover thief, plotting to rob the temple.
9. URIAN EDERSON Head cleric who demands strict obedience.
10. ZADI LUKAS Visiting religious orator spreading new ideas.

Murk Boyl

Young leader of high authority.

KNOWN FOR Murk is strict and exacting; he has no issue reporting clerics who slack or cut corners. This diligence earned him a promotion to High Seeker at a young age.

APPEARANCE He wears embroidered black vestments, a falcon brooch and feathered crown to show his lofty station. A smoking censer necklace leaves a scented trail behind him.

SECRET Murk reported clerics who were good friends of his for neglecting temple duties. These actions earned him a key promotion, but left him isolated and lonely.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • HALFLING • WORSHIPPER

Someone working in a temple is likely to have deep knowledge of its belief system.

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Chime-eaters

Invisible belfry spirits.

KNOWN FOR Chime-eaters are invisible air spirits that nest in temple belfries to feed on loud, rhythmic noise. They absorb power from the bells, muting the sound entirely as they draw strength from the resonance.

APPEARANCE While dormant, they are unseen. They shimmer in the shape of wispy, clawed gibbons when feeding on noise. Their presence is often given away by an unnatural hush and a sharp electric tang in the air.

TACTICS Chime-eaters lie still for hours, unless drawing power from bells. If disturbed, they erupt with stored sonic energy in a thunderclap, disorienting and injuring temple workers before vanishing into thin air.

SECRET Once bloated with sound, a chime-eater splits into two. These duplicates can turn hostile towards each other, triggering brutal fights and chaos. Chime-eaters should be dealt with before they begin duplicating.

CREATURE • LARGE • NEUTRAL • ELEMENTAL — AIR ELEMENTAL / INVISIBLE STALKER

Mother Bartsue

Revered deva priest.

You force your eyes to look upon Mother Bartsue's divine form. Your natural instinct is to avert your gaze from her celestial splendour.

KNOWN FOR Mother Bartsue is a revered figure whose legendary healings across the world inspired countless pilgrims. Today, faithful followers journey to the global shrines that marked her path, culminating in a sacred visit to her personal sanctuary.

APPEARANCE Bartsue wears a blue headdress and white, ceremonial robes. The flowing veil covers her eyes to shield mortals from the power of her gaze.

GOAL Acting for her patron deity, Mother Bartsue heals visiting pilgrims. She is driven to banish illness from the world and its people.

SECRET A fiend badly damaged her left wing and right leg in a fight long ago. She finds travelling much harder than she used to.

LOOT

- Amulet of health*
- Ceremonial mace
- Holy water*

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • CELESTIAL • WORSHIPPER — DEVA / PLANETAR

Silverglaze Sect

Priests who purify with ice.

KNOWN FOR The Silverglaze Sect believes purity lies in frozen stillness. They use powerful, divine ice magic to purge what they deem corrupted — land, homes and people. Their ruthless cold leaves everything lifeless.

GOAL They seek out desecrated places and heretics, swiftly extinguishing evil with their god's frosty wrath. The merciless group spreads the brutal but virtuous silence of winter, leaving nothing but broken ice behind.

FEATURE Sect members dye their hair bright blue with harsh chemicals, as a mark of purity. Clad in stiff cyan robes that crackle with freezing cold, they radiate frost, and chill the very earth beneath their feet.

SECRET Recently, they struck down a smith accused of heresy, only to discover their grim act was based on bad information. Silverglaze Sect refuses to admit their mistake, burying the truth beneath layers of denial.

FACTION • MEDIUM (20–49) • HOSTILE • RELIGIOUS

Using NPCs as conduits for divine messages can be a creative alternative to dreams and visions.

Jonchar Raymond

Temple historian and guide.

KNOWN FOR No one knows the history of the temple like Jonchar, not even the religious leaders who work there. He is a walking encyclopedia, and offers paid tours to passers-by.

APPEARANCE Jonchar's salt-and-pepper hair is combed to the side, and he wears a chunky cardigan made from sheep's wool. His notes and fact cards are stuffed into his top pocket.

SECRET Jonchar knows more than he should. He uncovers intriguing details by climbing into the eaves of the temple roof and listening to the priests' conversations.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HUMAN • SAGE

Scripture Circle

Elder priests who run training courses.

KNOWN FOR Scripture Circle is a rigorous training course led by elder priests. They test acolytes on their memory recall, discipline and spiritual aptitude before final examinations.

GOAL Scripture Circle elders teach acolytes a lengthy course of 40 lessons. They aim to shape the next generation of respected temple leaders through difficult trials.

SECRET Priests report gifted acolytes to religious leaders. These chosen few are taken to a secretive, cloistered temple in the capital city for advanced training.

FACTION • MICRO (1–5) • NEUTRAL • RELIGIOUS

Tobin Hosie

Busy temple steward.

KNOWN FOR A whirlwind of energy, Tobin takes charge of all ceremonies and events at the temple. As well as keeping the temple's daily schedule running smoothly, he's always preparing for the next big celebration.

APPEARANCE Tobin bustles around the temple, keys jangling at his hip and robes hitched up to keep his long stride unencumbered. He calls out a stream of instructions and encouragements as he goes.

GOAL No matter the size of the event, Tobin works tirelessly to make the details perfect. He believes this devotion pleases the gods and uplifts his community, making every hour of effort feel sacred.

SECRET Tobin enchanted the temple doors to hum different melodies depending on the occasion, without permission. Sometimes the spells misfire and play inappropriate tunes to Tobin's embarrassment.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • GOBLINOID • WORSHIPPER

NOBLE / PRIEST ACOLYTE

The Flamesworn

Wardens of a sacred flame.

Sweat gathers on the sentries' brows in the blistering heat, but the grip on their sword hilts never falters. Firelight flickers and dances across their blades, casting light that dazzles your eyes.

KNOWN FOR A small order within a larger religious group, the Flamesworn stand watch over an eternally lit brazier. Working in shifts, these devoted warriors keep vigil to ensure the sacred fire never goes out. Members are recruited based on their faith and fighting ability.

GOAL Clerics use the brazier, known as the Divine Mouth, as a conduit to commune with the gods. Each member of the Flamesworn would lay down their life to ensure this divine link is not extinguished by those with a grudge against the gods.

FEATURE The Flamesworn wear orange cloaks similar to those of priests. However, their robes have a leather lining to protect against the flames that lick at their back as they stand guard. They also wear burnished breastplates, with a brazier engraved on the front.

LEADERSHIP The longest serving member of the Flamesworn is appointed as the Torchwielder and acts as the group's leader. They are responsible for setting shift patterns, assessing new members and are trusted to speak on behalf of the other Flamesworn.

SECRET A few weeks ago, the flame almost flickered out entirely. The Flamesworn on duty were able to revive it with a mixture of fuel and prayer, but believe it was an omen of a growing unholy power in the region.

KEY MEMBERS

Torchwielder Dask Twill – Grey-haired, muscular leader.
Ama Twill – Dask's daughter, who wants to be in charge.
Cerin Elbers – Shaken after seeing the flame dwindle.

FACTION • MEDIUM (20–49) • NEUTRAL • RELIGIOUS

Members of the Flamesworn (right) keep a constant watch around their sacred brazier.

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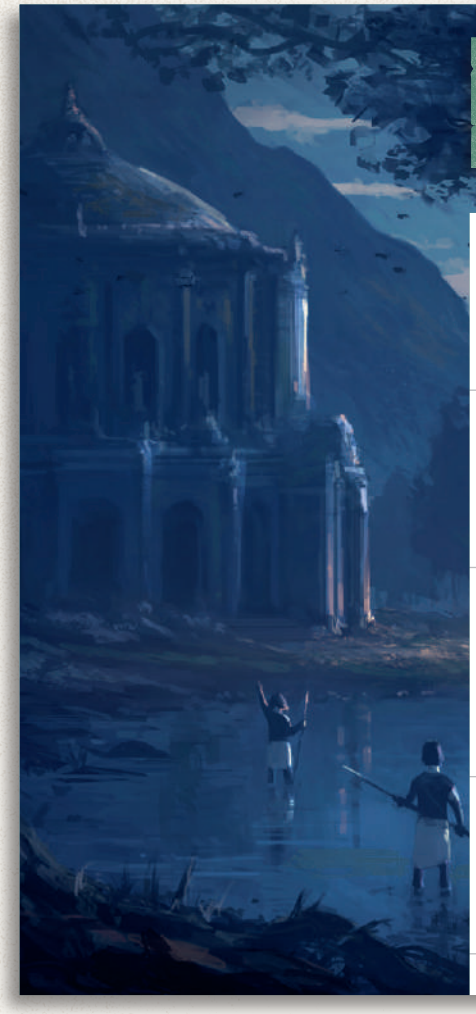

The Pillar of Skyglass

Ruins of an elemental forge.

The algae-covered water surrounding the grand stone ruins is still and peaceful. As a dragonfly skims across the surface, you make out a slight ripple of fish below.

KNOWN FOR The Pillar of Skyglass was an elemental forge used during an ancient war. It created powerful water-infused weapons and relics, but as the war ended, the forge was abandoned and left to decay. The site is still inhabited by the eternal water spirits it was originally built to honour.

APPEARANCE One huge forge and 17 workshops encircle a dark, steaming lake. Inside, humidity clings to the walls, with some chambers fully submerged in warm water.

INHABITANTS Skyglass has no permanent inhabitants. Slumbering water spirits drift through flooded chambers, their sleep undisturbed by the thriving schools of fish below.

LOOT The site has been mostly picked clean, but a handful of water-infused axes and greatswords remain. They are chained to rusted weapon racks.

SECRET The spirits have been weakened by centuries of mortal neglect. A simple offering will boost their strength, and win their loyalty.

ENVIRONMENT • MID-SIZED • SAFE • RUIN

Muskgrove Amphitheatre

Former open-air theatre.

KNOWN FOR The Muskgrove Amphitheatre was once a thriving showcase for lauded performers and promising newcomers. Now, the seats and stage are quiet and empty.

APPEARANCE Semi-circular stone seating arcs around a central timber stage. Weeds grow between cracks, and long grass chokes the stage, hiding its once clear markings.

SECRET A local theatre troupe plans to perform a new play at the amphitheatre, to spark interest in restoring the site. Technically trespassing, they must rehearse late at night.

ENVIRONMENT • MID-SIZED • RISKY • RUIN

Forgotten Souls' Keep

Decommissioned gallows.

KNOWN FOR The grim remnants of a despotic ruler's reign, this dungeon keep was used to house those accused of treason. Cells were located directly below the gallows.

APPEARANCE Frayed ropes creak softly as they sway from weathered wooden gallows. Below, the foul-smelling cells are dark, damp and teeming with hungry rats.

SECRET Townspeople suspect that the prison is haunted by the ghosts of those wrongfully convicted. It is actually haunted by the vengeful spirit of the evil ruler.

ENVIRONMENT • SMALL • DANGEROUS • RUIN

Brokenlance Field

Abandoned jousting grounds.

KNOWN FOR When a new jousting arena was built, shabby Brokenlance Field was closed down. It's now an abandoned meeting spot for bandits, assassins and smugglers.

APPEARANCE The once manicured grass of the field has been overtaken by unruly weeds. The colourful spectator tents are faded, and the fabric is ripped in places.

SECRET Underground fights are hosted at Brokenlance Field on the first day of every month, and pack out the tired stands. The fights alternate between physical and magical.

ENVIRONMENT • MID-SIZED • RISKY • PLAIN

More Abandoned Ruins

1. **MOSSVILLE MOUND** Mysterious, ancient standing stones.
2. **GRAZTOPIA** Ziggurat the local council want to knock down.
3. **KILMARN CAVE** Caves with drawings of extinct animals.
4. **ARMSKIRK RUINS** Underground temple prone to cave-ins.
5. **MAWILL MANOR** Opulent mansion covered in thick dust.
6. **CONFUNDUS STEPS** Unfinished staircase leading nowhere.
7. **ARC DE LUSTRE** Golden arch split in two, allegedly by a god.
8. **LEYFORD KEEP** Ruined fort where a hippogriff herd nests.
9. **SANGUINE ROCK** Altar once used for divine sacrifices.
10. **SILENT MENAGERIE** Former zoo, now lies empty.

Think about what kinds of hazards in a derelict environment could affect combat.

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The Bronze Unicorn

Lucky statue head.

KNOWN FOR This bronze unicorn head once sat at the top of a great statue. Thieves stole the body and legs, leaving only the cumbersome head abandoned near the riverbank.

APPEARANCE The metal head lies at a slight angle in the mud and has weathered to a deep brown colour. The horn still gleams brightly, as it is polished by frequent touch.

SECRET In order to grow the legend of the statue's good fortune, locals sometimes plant coins to be found nearby. They hope the money will then be spent in local shops.

ENVIRONMENT • MID-SIZED • SAFE • STATUE

Promontory Tower

Crumbling watchtower.

KNOWN FOR This old watchtower belonged to a famed explorer. It's thought to contain treasures from their travels, but few have survived the perilous cliffside climb to find out.

APPEARANCE Promontory Tower is built on a steep cliff with few footholds. The watchtower is made of sanded, windowless stone with an entrance trapdoor at the very top.

SECRET The watchtower doesn't contain treasure. Instead it offers clues that point towards a planar gateway, hidden away in an icy cave that is equally as dangerous to get to.

ENVIRONMENT • LARGE • DANGEROUS • TOWER

Hollowfall

Eerie uninhabited village.

Thick, gnarled roots snake through the empty village, crushing foundations and shattering windowpanes. The air stinks of rotten earth, wet bark and organic decay.

KNOWN FOR The secluded forest village of Hollowfall is absent from most maps, overlooked or forgotten by cartographers. Those who discover it find crumbling wooden houses choked by thick vines and t trees. Moss carpets the cracked stone paths, and the air is silent. The village appears to have been abandoned for decades, swallowed by relentless forest growth.

APPEARANCE Though the thick tree growth suggests Hollowfall has been empty for years, several buildings have fresh paint — the rapid spread of roots and vines clearly forced a sudden evacuation. Deep, jagged cuts scar many branches, evidence of desperate villagers hacking through the encroaching forest to flee quickly before nature fully consumed their home.

INHABITANTS Discarded tools and worn lumberjack gear lie scattered in abandoned homes. Those lingering too long in Hollowfall might feel a cold, malevolent presence lurking unseen throughout the village.

LOOT Shards of wood, shattered pottery and ripped journals lie on the floor. A locked wooden box on the side of the road contains dried herbs and a worn, heirloom dagger; it must have fallen from a hurrying cart.

SECRET Lumberjacks cut down two of three trees that were imprisoning a malicious green hag; the cause of the village's rapid destruction. If the third tree is destroyed, the hag will be free to leave the town.

COMMON CREATURES

- Twig Blight
- Giant Toad
- Blink Dog
- Grick
- Shambling Mound
- Green Hag

ENVIRONMENT • MID-SIZED • DANGEROUS • RUIN

Show the party signs of what the ruin once was, who built it, and how it fell into disrepair.

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Woodwards

Posse of wild children.

KNOWN FOR This self-sufficient group of kids live in a treehouse in the boughs of a treant called Decidu. The Woodwards look out for each other, forage for food, take care of the ageing treant, and make up fun new games.

GOAL The Woodwards swear to remain children forever and hate the idea of adult laws and rules. Delighted by their company, the elderly treant's magic helps keep the children eternally young.

FEATURE Each of the Woodwards wears a friendship bracelet woven from the leaves of the treant. Their clothing is dirty and roughly patched, and most of their tools look like they were stolen from other travellers.

SECRET If a Woodward spends too long away from Decidu, they begin to lose memory of their time in the treehouse. After a year away, they would forget about their stay with the Woodwards entirely.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • FRIENDLY • SOCIAL

Silas "Skulk" Redmayne

Grave-robbing bounty hunter.

A flash of torchlight reveals the cloaked figure, just for a moment. Before their hood drops back down, you glimpse a cascade of red hair and a furious scowl.

KNOWN FOR No ordinary graverobber, Silas digs up corpses, reanimates them to learn their secrets, then uses the information to blackmail the living. Lurking in graveyards gained him the nickname Skulk; he has no qualms about disturbing the dead, or the sacred ground they rest in.

APPEARANCE Skulk's darting hazel eyes are flecked with gold. Necromantic runes and symbols are embossed on his armour, and spiked chains hang from his waist.

GOAL Skulk has learnt that secrets are more valuable than the trinkets he could dig up. The victims of his blackmail pay in gold, platinum and sometimes more secrets.

SECRET A former blackmail victim recently discovered the location of Silas' wife and sons. He is fearful that they might hurt his family.

LOOT

- Greatsword of life stealing*
- Spell scroll (speak with dead)*
- Leather-bound notebook

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • HUMAN • OUTLAW — BERSERKER / GUARD CAPTAIN

Murrough

Fierce, musical eagles.

KNOWN FOR These enormous eagles patrol the skies above cliffside towers and keeps. The murrough build their nests high in the ruins, and are fiercely territorial against anyone who dares approach them.

APPEARANCE When murrough soar high in the sky, holes in their hollow bones whistle and create ethereal, melodic music. The tunes abruptly stop when they let out a mighty screech and dive-bomb their prey.

TACTICS These adept hunters try to separate their prey, and narrow their focus on the weakest or smallest in a group. If their eggs are elsewhere they will avoid danger, but they will fight to the death in defence of their nests.

SECRET Murrough collect eggs from the nests of other predators they defeat. Their clutch of eggs could have wyvern, murrough, griffon or sometimes even dragon eggs. They raise each chick as their own.

CREATURE • GARGANTUAN • HOSTILE • MONSTROSITY — GIANT EAGLE / ROC

If an NPC lives a solitary life, how will they react to the party?

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Gullivette

Home improvement gargoyle.

KNOWN FOR This ancient gargoyle lives within a crumbling ruin that she is desperate to see restored before it all falls down. She asks passers-by for aid and building materials.

APPEARANCE Time has not treated Gullivette kindly, and her stone skin is pockmarked with age. Her face is fixed in an expression of disbelief, regardless of her emotions.

SECRET If the ruin collapses fully, the magic that animates Gullivette ends. Even if the stone pieces of her body were to be repaired, she would simply be a statue without a soul.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • CONSTRUCT • LABOURER

Shenjian

Loyal flying sword.

KNOWN FOR This double-edged shortsword belonged to a famous paladin. Blessed with divine power upon its owner's death, Shenjian now stands guard over the warrior's tomb.

APPEARANCE A phoenix-shaped handguard protects the blade's burnished cherry-wood pommel. There is a slight hum as Shenjian hovers in the air defensively, ready to strike.

SECRET The power granted to the sword was a gift from the gods, in honour of the paladin's service. Anyone who destroys the sword would have to face the wrath of the gods.

CREATURE • SMALL • HOSTILE • CONSTRUCT

Sacha Korreb

Caretaker who loves pranks.

KNOWN FOR This young caretaker loves to play tricks on unsuspecting visitors. He dresses up as a monster and rigs traps around the historic stone folly he protects.

APPEARANCE When he's not in a costume, Sacha wears shabby brown overalls and a sweater. He's friendly, and highly apologetic if caught.

GOAL Sacha creates his elaborate hoaxes to cure his boredom. He also hopes the stories will encourage curious visitors to buy a ticket to a folly tour.

SECRET Sacha has glimpsed a spindly figure lurking in the shadows twice. He has brushed it off as his own imagination, but can't be sure.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HUMAN • LABOURER

COMMONER / SCOUT

Disciples of the Wreath

Followers of a sentient crown.

KNOWN FOR This cult is devoted to a sentient crown that has the power to grant immortality. The followers take it in turns to wear the crown each day, and brutal fights break out over who gets to wear it next.

GOAL Followers vie for the honour of wearing the crown and being gifted its power. The crown prioritises those who bring in the most new disciples — it wants to grow its following, and found its own kingdom.

FEATURE Disciples dress in the colours of the seasons, and those without the crown wear circular headpieces made from dried flowers. For initiation rituals, they wear black robes with veils that obscure their faces.

SECRET The sentient crown grants its wearer magical wisdom, not immortality. The crown drains the wearer's life force and wearers feel exhausted, but exhilarated, after their day spent with the crown.

FACTION • LARGE (50–99) • FRIENDLY • RELIGIOUS

Baylee Vengochea

Castle ruin guard.

KNOWN FOR Baylee is one of seven soldiers stationed at a derelict military outpost. He patrols the castle perimeter to stop trespassers triggering traps, pitching tents or looting.

APPEARANCE Baylee wears a standard-issue chain mail shirt and a metal helmet with red plumage. Viewed up close, his dark-green eyes have shimmering white pupils.

SECRET Baylee is possessed by the spirit of an artificer who wants to recover a tool buried in the castle's rubble. He is struggling to fight the spirit's incessant commands.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • GNOME • GUARD

Yarrowken

Wandering scarecrow.

KNOWN FOR Yarrowken is an unusual sight — a scarecrow wearing wizard robes and a pointy hat. It hops through fields on its shaft; no one knows why it travels or where it's going.

APPEARANCE Bits of dried plant stalks poke out from rips in its robes, and its hat is flecked with mud. Yarrowken's head is a hay-stuffed sack with a simple painted smiley face.

SECRET Its tattered hat has an extradimensional space inside. The hat carries a brass compass, a mirror shard, a sketch of Yarrowken, and a letter from its former owner.

CREATURE • MEDIUM • FRIENDLY • CONSTRUCT

The cave dwellers on pp. 74–77 could make an appearance in underground ruins.

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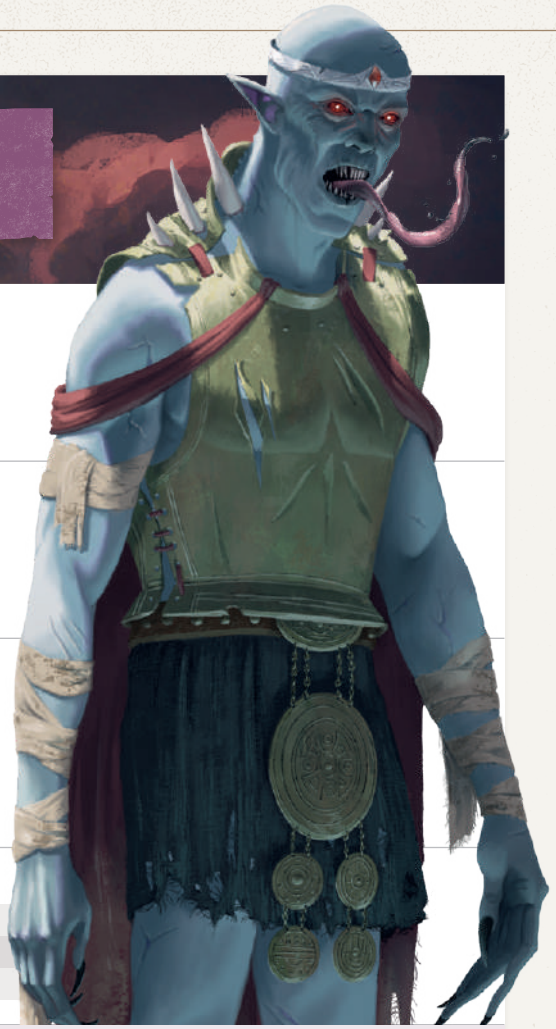
General Ulygarth Dorn

Intelligent ghast leader.



Posture rigid, head raised and eyes blazing, the general addresses his minions. His rasping voice scratches painfully on the inside of your skull.

KNOWN FOR General Ulygarth was a tyrannical army leader, feared by his enemies and his own soldiers. His blood-soaked military career should have ended when he was felled in battle by a stray arrow. Instead, he was revived in a new, inhuman form to lead a great army of the undead.

APPEARANCE His armour shows the scars of previous battles. Black veins bulge under sickly blue skin, and stinking grey spittle sprays from his fang-filled mouth.

GOAL Ulygarth desires the same in death as in life, to destroy his enemies and stamp out any dissent within his troops. But now his enemies include anyone alive.

SECRET Before his death, Ulygarth seized a crown from a slain king. The item makes him much more intelligent than most other undead.

LOOT

- Headband of intellect*
- Adamantine breastplate*
- Medal of honour belt

GHAST MONARCH
Medium Undead

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
18 (+4)	17 (+3)	18 (+4)	19 (+4)	14 (+2)	8 (-1)

Armour Class: 17
Hit Points: 196 (21d8 + 112)
Speed: 30 ft
Initiative: +3

Saving Throws: CON +8, WIS +6
Skills: Athletics +12, Intimidation +3
Immunities: Necrotic, Poison; Charmed, Exhaustion, Frightened, Poisoned
Senses: Darkvision 120 ft
Passive Perception: 12
Languages: Abyssal, Common
Proficiency Bonus: +4

ABILITIES

Stench. Constitution Saving Throw: DC 15, any creature that starts its turn within 5 ft of the ghast. Failure: The target has the Poisoned condition until the start of its next turn. Success: The target is immune to this ghast's Stench for 24 hours.

Leader of the Undead. Undead creatures of the ghast's choice (excluding itself) within 60 ft of it have advantage on attack rolls and saving throws, unless the ghast has the Incapacitated condition.

Unholy Endurance. When the ghast is reduced to 0 HP, roll 1d4. On a 4, it returns to life with 10 HP instead of falling Unconscious.

Necrotic Feedback. The ghast is immune to being Charmed, Frightened or Poisoned. If a creature tries to apply one of these conditions to the ghast, the creature takes 4d4 necrotic damage.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The ghast makes three Necrotic Sword attacks. It can replace one attack with a Horrific Necrosis attack.

Necrotic Sword. Melee Weapon Attack: +8 to hit, reach 5 ft, one target. Hit: 12 (2d8 + 4) slashing damage plus 10 (3d6) necrotic damage.

Horrific Necrosis. Melee or Ranged Weapon Attack: +8 to hit, reach 5 ft or 120 ft, one target. Hit: 26 (4d10 + 4) necrotic damage and the target has the Frightened condition until the end of its next turn.

Spellcasting. The ghast casts one of the following spells, using Intelligence as the spellcasting ability (spell save DC 16):

At Will: *Bane, Speak with Dead*

1/Day Each: *Contagion, Create Undead*

LEGENDARY ACTIONS: 3 USES

Immediately after another creature's turn, the ghast can expend a use to take one of the following actions. The ghast regains all expended uses at the start of each of its turns.

Lash Out. The ghast moves up to half its speed, and it makes one Necrotic Sword attack.

Unsettling Leader. The ghast uses Spellcasting to cast *Bane*. The ghast can't take this action again until the start of its next turn.

Belch of Flies. Dexterity Saving Throw: DC 16, one creature the ghast can see within 60 ft. Failure: 22 (4d10) poison damage, and the target has disadvantage on saving throws to maintain Concentration until the end of its next turn. Failure or Success: The ghast can't take this action again until the start of its next turn.

CHALLENGE RATING 11

You could alternatively use the stats of a Ghast CR 2, Wraith CR 5 or Mummy Lord CR 15.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • UNDEAD • COMBATANT

Some undead beings retain more of their living memories than others. What does your undead NPC remember?

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Yaslova Krawl

Revenant shepherd.

KNOWN FOR Yaslova Krawl appears every night to watch for prowling wolves. Locals tolerate the shepherd's undead presence in return for her vigilant protection of their flocks.

APPEARANCE In the moonlight, Yaslova's rustic clothes and shepherd's crook look as real as they did in life. However, as the sun rises, her form slowly fades away.

SECRET Yaslova and her brother were both killed by wolves, which attacked as they slept. Yaslova was meant to be on watch, and her guilt keeps her tethered to this world.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • UNDEAD • LABOURER

Quibblefists

Mischievous animated hands.

KNOWN FOR Quibblefists terrorise locals. These animated hands deface statues, push over fruit crates, loosen bolts on cart wheels, and push roof tiles onto passers-by.

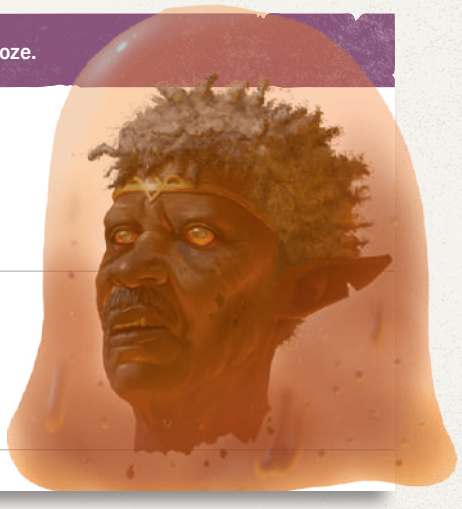
APPEARANCE The hands have pale-purple skin and yellow fingernails. Spots of thick, coagulated blood and drops of pungent chemicals trail behind them.

SECRET The hands were donated to a magical university for training use. The animated hands weren't properly secured after a seminar, and have been on the loose ever since.

TINY • HOSTILE • UNDEAD

Mario G. Evansley

Immortal noble in an ooze.



KNOWN FOR In life, Mario used his huge wealth to ensure his immortality. He paid an arcanist to develop an ooze to preserve his head and mind for eternity.

APPEARANCE Mario now exists as a severed head in an amorphous blob of orange ooze. A circlet gives him the ability to communicate telepathically.

GOAL After achieving his life's goal of never dying, Mario is without purpose in the afterlife. He spends his days berating his heirs for mismanaging his fortune.

SECRET Mario's other attempts at immortality all failed. He also had a werewolf bite him, ate a phoenix egg and drank unicorn blood.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • UNDEAD • NOBLE

MAGE / LICH

Mourning Crows

Birds that feed on the undead.

KNOWN FOR Also known as "corvus alba", these pure white birds are primarily found in graveyards and have a haunting screech. Mourning crows peck the flesh from shambling ghouls and zombies.

APPEARANCE Mourning crows have feathers of pure white, with jet-black eyes, claws and beaks. Their caw rings in the minds of those who hear it like the screams of departed loved ones.

TACTICS These birds are unlikely to attack the living, unless provoked. However, their presence at a burial site is a harbinger of danger. A flock of mourning crows always means undead creatures lurk nearby.

SECRET The birds are immune to necrotic damage. Their feathers retain a trace of this magic; when worn as a necklace, they grant the wearer mild resistance to necrotic spells and effects.

CREATURE • TINY • NEUTRAL • UNDEAD

RAVEN / COCKATRICE

More Undead Beings

1. ELK RIDER Skeletal knight who rides an undead deer.
2. LORELEI BLACKREEF Banshee merfolk who devours sailors.
3. TALLOWGHAST Zombie who sculpts their memories in wax.
4. HIGH DUSTBRINGER Lich cleric preaching the end of days.
5. THE WARDEN Ghost who blows debris from forgotten graves.
6. ERI LOVE Undead child who uses entrails as a skipping rope.
7. DOC CHIMERA Lich doctor who experiments on other dead.
8. XEHROL THE THIEF Aberration zombie who eats memories.
9. KOT HARDSTARK Fun-loving vampire who parties all night.
10. HECA INSREN Wraith fortune-teller who sees horrific fates.

The Plintagos Dynasty

Ancient rulers planning a new reign.

KNOWN FOR These mummies hail from an ancient dynasty. Locked in a shared tomb, they plot their return to glory, unaware of the time that has passed since their deaths.

GOAL The mummies plan to possess whichever mortals eventually reopen their tomb. Each mummy secretly plots to claim the strongest body, in order to rule over the others.

SECRET The mummies' funeral robes have disintegrated, leaving desiccated flesh and bone exposed. The priceless jewels they were buried with are dusty, but otherwise intact.

FACTION • MICRO (1–5) • HOSTILE • SOCIAL

Planning a horror campaign? Check out p. 242 for more advice and inspiration.

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CHAPTER 5

DWELLINGS AND RESIDENTS

Meet the everyday folk who will bring your homebrew world to life, simply by living in it. Some might even invite you into their homes, and offer you a spare bed or hammock for the night. Whether it's a grand castle, a pirate ship, a bandit lair or a magical cottage, home is often where a great story begins and ends.

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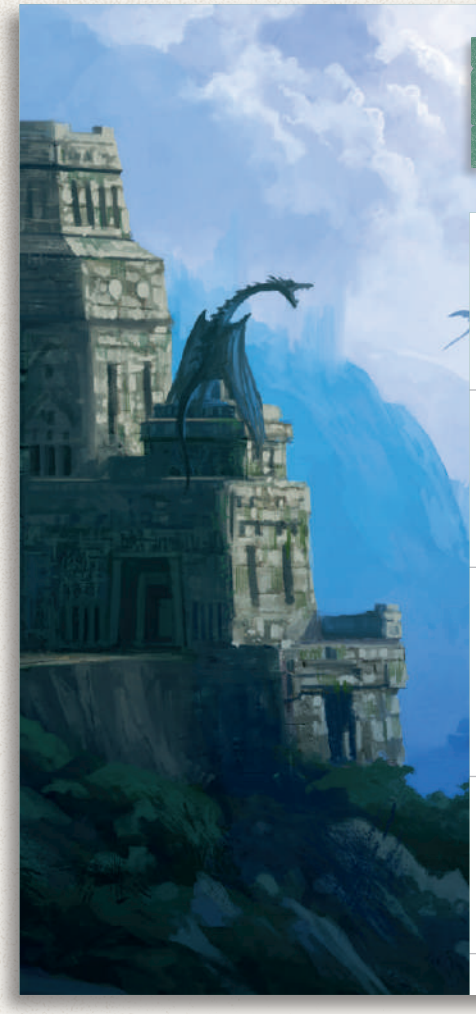

Dragonvale Castle

Castle haven for dragons.

The castle's weathered towers bear deep claw marks. Wind carries distant roars through cracked ramparts, and the air is thick with a sharp, sulphurous tang.

KNOWN FOR This crumbling complex of stone halls and sunken courtyards were built by an ancient civilisation, but has been claimed by blue dragons for generations. The valley below is scarred by lightning and fire, and now serves as the dragons' hunting territory.

APPEARANCE Blue dragons roost on cracked domes and battlements, their talons scraping the ancient stone. Below, a misty forest valley stretches as far as the eye can see.

LAYOUT Smaller dragons occupy the guard turrets built along the estate's outer wall. The central throne room is the most coveted nesting spot in Dragonvale.

LOOT Lost scales, claws and teeth are scattered around the ruins. Most artefacts from the old civilisation have been destroyed by the dragons.

SECRET Six ancient, ornamental gargoyles whisper to one another at night. They collect secrets and trade gossip about the dragons.

BUILDING • LARGE • DRACONIC • LAIR

Rediron Rock

Daunting iron castle.

KNOWN FOR The realm's oldest surviving castle, Rediron Rock has a dark, bloody history. The castle has never been passed down by peaceful succession, only forcefully taken through treason or bloodshed.

APPEARANCE This massive, looming presence stands upon a high, dark-slate hill. Rediron Rock was originally built of black iron, but over the centuries its walls and towers have turned a sinister, rusty red.

LAYOUT No one has explored the entire iron castle. Its sprawling dungeons stretch far beyond the outer walls, winding like a labyrinth – though many passages were bricked up long ago by fearful former owners.

SECRET A reddish mist of creeping rust meanders through the castle halls; it corrodes iron, metal and even flesh. Superstitious locals say it is a living curse born of the castle's violent past.

BUILDING • LARGE • ROYAL • CASTLE

Shipgrave Citadel

Castle made from shipwrecks.

KNOWN FOR This underwater fortress has been built from the scavenged wreckage of countless sunken vessels. Shipgrave Citadel is precarious, but fiercely defended by its territorial merrow inhabitants.

APPEARANCE Rising from the ocean floor, Shipgrave Citadel is a chaotic tangle of splintered hulls and masts. Tattered sails drift like ghostly banners in the currents, barely visible in the deep and murky waters.

LAYOUT The wreck of a naval galleon forms the main structure, with jagged turrets and walls pieced together from smaller shipwrecks. Trenches weave beneath it, providing hidden entrances to the Citadel's interior.

SECRET At the citadel's rear, an upturned ship hull has a small air pocket. The cramped, claustrophobic space is used to hold air-breathing prisoners. Some have been confined here in pitch-black darkness for many months.

BUILDING • LARGE • NAUTICAL • CASTLE

Think about how old your castle is, and how that fits into the history of your homebrew world.

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Gidleon Seat

Treasure-laden palace.

KNOWN FOR This mansion is full of treasure vaults, designed by a paranoid noble. After the owner's death, many have tried to crack the puzzles and passcodes, with little success.

APPEARANCE Massive, unlocked golden doors open into a gleaming marble atrium. Deeper inside, each room is sealed behind thick vault doors etched with glowing magical wards.

SECRET Each vault contains riddles and puzzles that unlock a key to another vault. Clues on the main entrance doors hint at which order the rooms should be searched in.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • ARCANE • PALACE

Lumina's Ascent

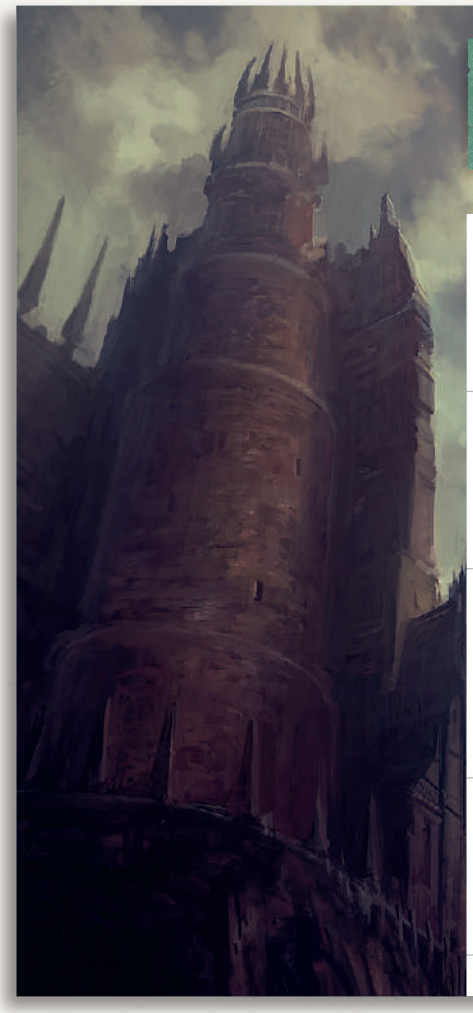
Palace in the clouds.

KNOWN FOR Lumina's Ascent is a floating palace nestled among the clouds. This celestial wonder is entirely woven from light and air, to the bafflement of its mortal visitors.

APPEARANCE Crafted from ever-shifting clouds, the palace fluctuates in form. Walls ripple to reveal fleeting corridors and archways that dissolve as quickly as they appear.

SECRET Moving with the winds, the Ascent's location is hard to predict. A feather teleportation token can act as a return key, but it is a rare honour to be granted such a gift.

BUILDING • SMALL • CELESTIAL • PALACE



Harrowmere Hall

Castle owned by vampires.

Like a jagged stake, the stark stone edifice rises up out of the earth to pierce the turbulent clouds above. The entrance looms above you like a gaping, fanged mouth.

KNOWN FOR Locals won't even say the name of this gothic castle, let alone step into its looming shadows. Stories differ as to what terrors lurk within, as the residents are never seen. The only clues are the mournful cries that echo from its halls and the occasional flicker of candles.

APPEARANCE Wind whistles through dark, twisting corridors, filling the space with a bitter chill. Chandeliers and other fine furnishings are coated with thick dust and cobwebs.

LAYOUT A high-ceilinged entry hall has doors leading to a library, study and dining room. Twisting staircases ascend to dark hallways, and descend into catacombs.

LOOT A map of the hall's passages is tucked behind a false panel in the library. Chained, leather books detail ancient rituals to banish the dead.

SECRET Portraits in every room allow the castle's illusive vampire owners to watch intruders from afar, and help them avoid detection.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • UNDEAD • LAIR

Everfreeze Crown

Giant ice palace.

KNOWN FOR Once home to a frost giant dynasty, the palace reaches high into the sky above the mountain it crowns. Since the frost giants' sudden departure, no one has managed to breach its gates and gain access.

APPEARANCE Everfreeze Crown's blue-grey exterior glitters at sunrise, as cool light reflects off huge slabs of compacted snow and flint shards. From some angles, it blends seamlessly into the nearby mountains.

LAYOUT Nine jagged ice towers rise in a spiral, each taller than the last; treacherous ice bridges link them. The interiors are cracked, slick, and full of traps like powerful ice-magic glyphs and swinging guillotines.

SECRET Deep in the central spire lies a massive crystal of trapped elemental cold — a terrible storm frozen by magic. If disturbed, the staggering blizzard would erupt once more, engulfing the mountain and world below.

BUILDING • LARGE • ROYAL • PALACE

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Mellegrove Estate

Vine-covered palace.

KNOWN FOR This idyllic palace is covered in grape vines that continue into a vast vineyard estate. The wines made here are delicious, and served at banquets across the realm.

APPEARANCE Vines heavy with red grapes tumble over the palace's timber arches and brick balconies. The air hums with bees, and smells of sweet ripening fruit.

SECRET Mellegrove's extensive cellar includes a private stash of magical vintages. Some grant visions of the past, others are said to bind together the fates of those who sip it.

BUILDING • LARGE • COMMERCIAL • PALACE

Triton's Point

Cliffside coastal palace.

KNOWN FOR With panoramic ocean views, Triton's Point has a rich maritime history. When enemy ships approach, the manor is first to launch forces to defend the realm.

APPEARANCE The manor juts dramatically from a cliffside, its whitewashed walls curving like waves. Large windows look out to sea, and all the decoration has a nautical theme.

SECRET Triton's Point connects to a network of cliff caves, which are used for smuggling. The manor's owner overlooks the smugglers' crimes, in return for a cut of the profits.

BUILDING • SMALL • NAUTICAL • PALACE

Craniax Keep

Castle in a titan's skull.

KNOWN FOR Millennia ago, an archmage beheaded a titan and claimed its colossal skull as a home. Infused with thrumming primordial magic, the skull remains a formidable and contested stronghold for arcanists.

APPEARANCE Heavy wood and granite architecture have transformed the skull's organic curves and hollows into a habitable structure. Few rooms have natural light, and there is a grim austerity in the furnishings.

LAYOUT The skull lies on its side. The lower eye socket forms the castle's main entrance, while the upper socket serves as a window for a cavernous banqueting hall. A war room is built into the skull's nasal cavity.

SECRET Within the cranial vault of Craniax Keep, remnants of the titan's thoughts still linger. Mages who meditate or sleep here experience haunting visions, glimpses of the ancient world or flashes of the future.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • ARCANE • CASTLE

Château Tirelle

Scenic palace popular with sightseers.

The steady sound of water lapping over smooth stone fills you with calm. You inhale the crisp air and gaze up at the magnificent château, its honey-coloured towers glowing in the sunlight.

KNOWN FOR Built a century ago into a picturesque hillside, Château Tirelle is famed for its serene beauty. Artists flock to paint its cascading views, but access beyond the outer grounds is forbidden. The sprawling estate is heavily patrolled to deter curious trespassers.

APPEARANCE Gracefully built around the natural path of a waterfall, Château Tirelle sits modestly in its surroundings. A constant fine haze of water softens the scene further, making the curved sandstone walls and warm terracotta roof tiles look like a painting.

LAYOUT The Château spans three tiers of a cascading waterfall. Long halls and slim towers link its various levels and wings. A low, iron fence rings the estate and is patrolled daily by alert guards and trained hounds who take the palace's security very seriously.

LOOT Within its grand gallery rooms lie priceless relics: gilded harps, ancient jewellery, masterpiece paintings and enchanted armour. Several pieces are legendary artefacts that are considered missing or destroyed, now hidden in plain sight behind velvet ropes and glass.

SECRET The Château hires a group of reasonably priced fey beings as security. Blink dogs and bullywugs patrol the site with rigorous coordination. They appear seemingly out of nowhere with firm warnings to leave.

ENCOUNTERS

Artists painting on canvas	Wagon unloading art
Bears catching salmon	Roof tile repairs
Camp of bullywugs	Rowboat rental seller

BUILDING • LARGE • HISTORIC • PALACE

The quiet serenity of Château Tirelle (right) has inspired many artists and bards over the years.

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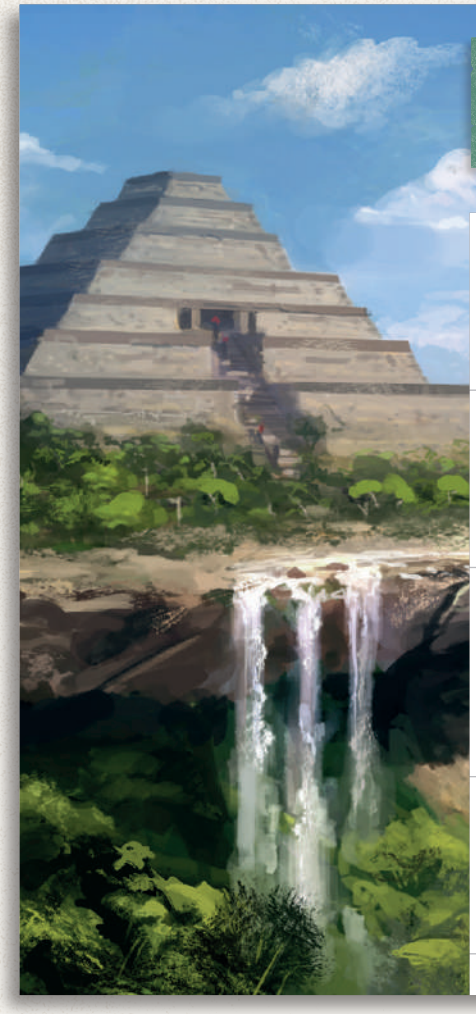

Steps of the Sovereign

Stepped pyramid palace.

Staggered stone layers climb from the verdant jungle cliffs below. Incense drifts from the palace's windows, and distant music echoes through the humid air.

KNOWN FOR The seat of a royal household, the Steps of the Sovereign palace grows with each generation. Every new ruler adds a floor to the top of the pyramid and fills its rooms with items reflecting their personal passion or legacy – whether that's astronomy, art, war, exploration or beekeeping.

APPEARANCE Formed of seven solid square platforms stacked atop each other, the pyramid is an imposing site. An enormous staircase leads to an entrance halfway up the structure.

LAYOUT The ground floor is for public and official use, including a throne room and banquet hall. The top levels are reserved for family and specially invited guests.

LOOT Each floor has its own treasures, from maps and weapon prototypes, to works of art, rare books and scientific instruments.

SECRET Roots encase a forgotten study at the base of the pyramid. Sap preserves enchanted books, strange devices and spell scrolls.

BUILDING • LARGE • ROYAL • PALACE

Fleetwood Fort

Cursed swamp castle.

KNOWN FOR Cursed centuries ago by an evil night hag, Fleetwood Fort slowly rots away, eroding into its own toxic moat. The air here is poisonous and stinks of decay.

APPEARANCE Fleetwood's moss-eaten timber walls lean inward around a sunken square courtyard. Its black moat is still and opaque, full of reeds, and mirrors nothing.

SECRET A withered stump in the courtyard pulses with dark magic. The night hag bound her soul there; destroying it might end the curse, but could also summon her return.

BUILDING • SMALL • DERELICT • CASTLE

The Pellucidia

Glass palace for public functions.

KNOWN FOR This stunning palace is made almost entirely of stained glass. As well as being beautiful, the functional space hosts audiences, assemblies and public events.

APPEARANCE Delicate glass turrets and a huge windowed roof are marvels of engineering. Stained-glass wall panels depict historic moments from the realm's past.

SECRET Some stained-glass panels shift when moonlight hits them. They reveal hidden symbols that create a map, leading to ancient artefacts once owned by the palace's lost heir.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • COMMERCIAL • PALACE

Havenside

Palace of eternal summer.

KNOWN FOR Havenside was built on the edge of a great lake by a talented magical architect. It was designed for a fey ruler who wanted to enjoy a never-ending summer.

APPEARANCE Havenside's chambers are linked by breezy arches and wide stone walkways. With no roof and wide-open windows, sunlight floods every room from dawn until dusk.

SECRET The palace's enchantments steal warmth from a sun-soaked desert on the other side of the world. As its halls glow brighter, the desert's climate gets colder and colder.

BUILDING • SMALL • ARCANE • PALACE

More Castles and Palaces

1. **BEAKWINTER** Ice fortress guarded by armoured penguins.
2. **ECHOES' END** Eccentric mansion built deep within a cave.
3. **CASTLE NEVERNAP** Stronghold taken over by children.
4. **SOLAR ESTATE** Golden manor house, home to a lonely king.
5. **PINNACLE SPIRE** Citadel atop a tall peak in the clouds.
6. **PALE ROOST** Lavish villa carved into a limestone cliff.
7. **VERDANCE HOLD** Fortress made of living, interwoven plants.
8. **SHARDCASTLE** Cursed castle trapped in a floating bubble.
9. **SALTSPIRE** Tall palace perched on a tidal island.
10. **HOUSE OF SPADES** Paper mansion made of playing cards.

How comfortable are your player characters in the imposing surroundings of a palace?

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Nessa Cardui

Fairy housekeeper.

KNOWN FOR This fairy housekeeper loves her job. She flies around the stately home where she works, scrubbing everything until it shines. Her tiny size allows her to dust even the smallest nooks and crannies.

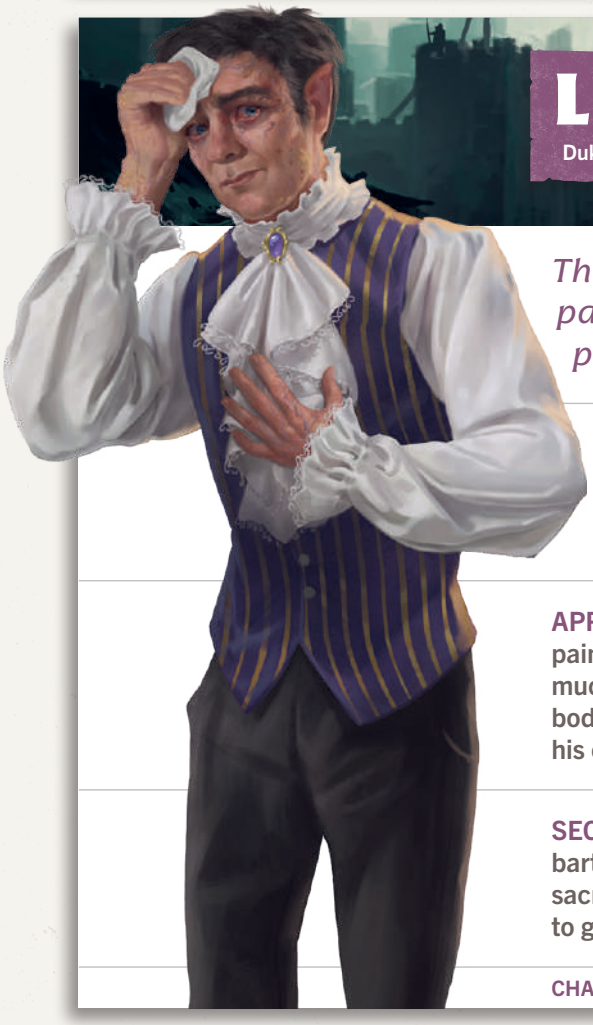
APPEARANCE Nessa is only six inches tall. She wears her blonde hair in a neat bun away from her face. There is a jar of "Pixie Polish" in her apron pocket at all times, which gives wood, metal and glass a magical sheen.

GOAL Nessa is meticulous, and enjoys beautifying the world around her. She also hand-stitches clothes, children's toys and cushions, and hopes to one day sell them at the bustling market in town.

SECRET Nessa doesn't need much sleep, so she sneaks out of the house every night. If she spots a home where she could lend a helping hand, she'll fly down the chimney, clean it up and spread a little magic.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • FEY • LABOURER

SPRITE / MAGE



Lord Priam Trobedour

Duke suffering with illness.

The duke's skin is marbled with angry purple veins and painful pus-filled abscesses. Though bloodshot, his pale-blue eyes look at you with a desperate hope.

KNOWN FOR Lord Priam Trobedour was once best known for his philanthropy. More recently, people speak in hushed tones about the terrible illness that devours him and has confined him to his castle home. It's rumoured his wealthy family would pay any price for a cure.

APPEARANCE Portraits of the duke painted before his illness show how much the disease has affected his body. He still dresses smartly, but his clothes hang from his frail form.

GOAL Though unwell, Priam urges his family to not seek a cure, but to continue to grow the Trobedours' wealth and influence. He has begun drafting his will, just in case.

SECRET The disease is a lie. Priam bartered with a fiend for power, and sacrifices his life force in dark rituals to grow richer as his body withers.

LOOT

- Tanzanite cravat pin
- Unfinished last will and testament
- Enspelled staff (summon fiend)*

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • ELF-HUMAN • NOBLE

NOBLE / CULTIST FANATIC

Drewen Boubacar

World-famous private chef.

KNOWN FOR Drewen is a private chef who creates showstopping meals for nobles and royalty. A true visionary in the kitchen, Drewen is equal parts feared and admired by his staff, and sometimes his employers.

APPEARANCE Drewen is a broad-shouldered man with neat salt-and-pepper hair, and deep furrows that crease his brow. He wears pristine, sleeveless chef's whites; their spotless fabric reflects his pride and perfectionism.

GOAL This chef's entire life is food. He wakes up in the morning with new dish ideas to try, works all day and night in the kitchen, then falls asleep and dreams of perfecting his signature saffron risotto recipe.

SECRET To ensure his high standards are met, Drewen personally tastes every dish prepared in his kitchen. He is unaware that one of the truffles in his storeroom has been swapped with a poisonous toadstool.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • HUMAN • LABOURER

COMMONER / SCOUT

Leaders of the realm, like those found on pp. 32–39, could also serve as heads of a grand household.

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Murray Stormfold

Protective castle steward.

KNOWN FOR Murray has sworn an oath to protect the castle's inhabitants until his dying day. He distrusts all visitors and patrols the halls in constant readiness. He keeps his guards on a strict schedule.

APPEARANCE Murray wears a navy kilt and a thick armoured chest plate with the castle crest engraved upon it. A large bunch of keys swings from his belt as he walks. He is rarely seen smiling, and talks in curt orders.

GOAL Murray wants to make the castle completely safe. He will go to any extreme to make sure the family residing there never come to any harm, including keeping them all under constant supervision.

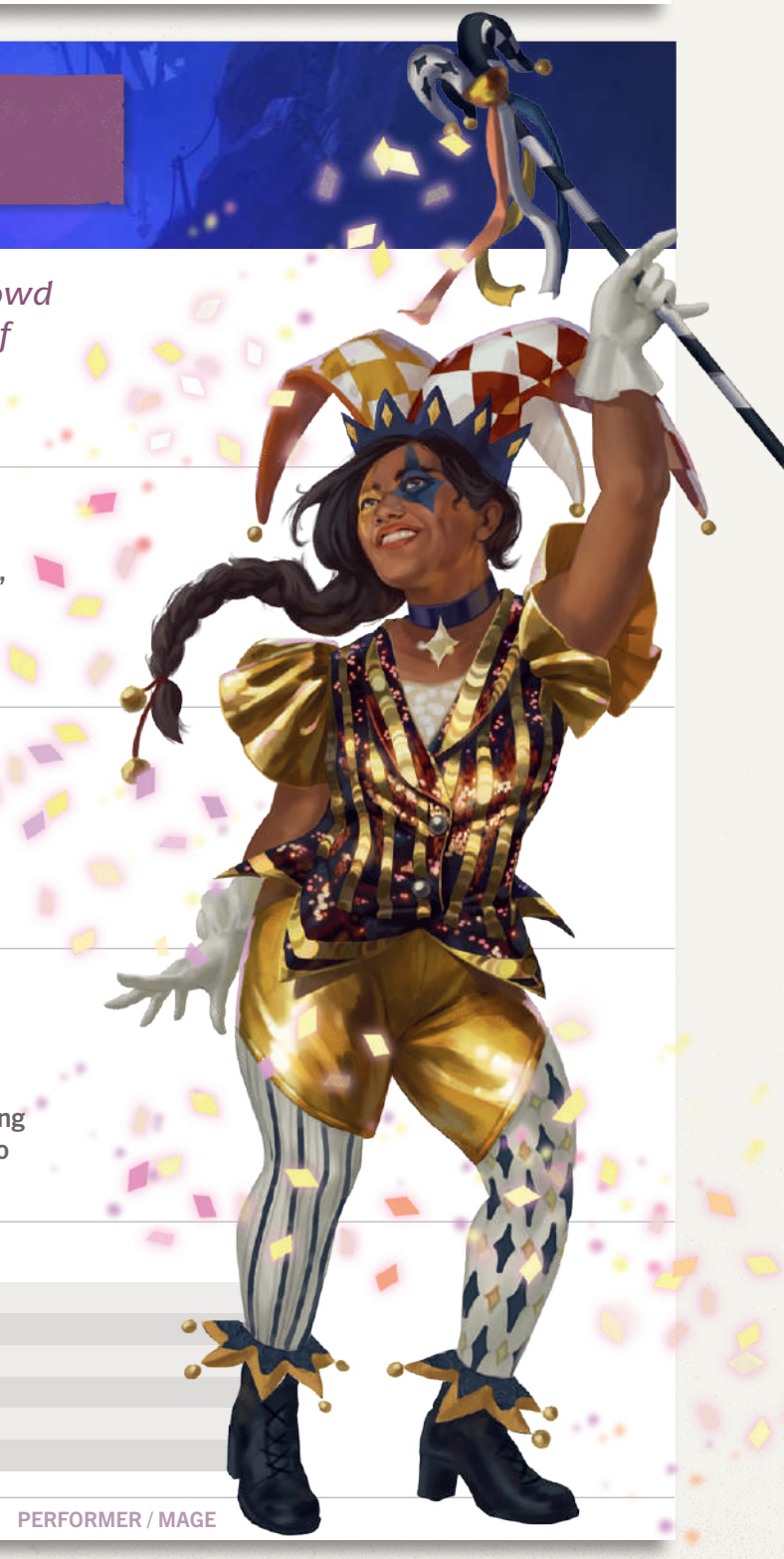
SECRET Murray has the family imprisoned in the east wing of the castle. The guards under Murray's command obey his orders without question. Each guard has sworn a magical, unbreakable oath of loyalty to him.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • GOLIATH • GUARD

BERSERKER / GUARD CAPTAIN

Ghalia Glimmerstaff

Illusionist jester.



Ghalia puts a finger to her lips, and the crowd go silent. She waves a hand and a vision of a thousand mice dancing a jig along the tabletop draws raucous laughter.

KNOWN FOR A whirlwind of glitter, glamour, comedy and magic, Ghalia delights guests at castle banquets. Effortlessly, she pulls glowing strands of magic from the air, and weaves them into illusions that send her patrons and their guests into fits of giggles. Her most famous trick is conjuring up a goat with the face of a ruling monarch.

APPEARANCE Her infectious smile and enchanting sense of humour allow Ghalia to get away with making fun of even the grumpiest members of her elite audience. She dazzles the crowd in a gold spangled costume. The bells on her jester's hat and anklets jingle as she leaps around the room performing tricks.

HISTORY Ghalia tells wild stories of her past – pirate ships, fey kidnappings and world tours, but none are true. In reality, she studied illusion magic at college and built her career through skill, charm and self-promotion.

GOAL Ghalia craves bigger crowds and applause. During each show, she watches the audience closely, seeking patrons or contacts who could boost her career.

SECRET Ghalia lived in her family's mill until, one morning, she wished for a change. Then, she was sent a sealed crate of magical items and a surprise acceptance letter to a distant college. She left immediately.

LOOT

- Staff of charming*
- Hat of many spells*
- Deck of illusions*
- Bag of tricks*
- Jester baton
- Face painting set

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HUMAN • ENTERTAINER

PERFORMER / MAGE

A big castle needs an army of staff to maintain it, especially during large events or celebrations.

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Uriah Gelch

Mysterious dungeon keeper.

KNOWN FOR Other castle staff say dungeon keeper Uriah was born in the prison and has never left. He's rumoured to survive by eating the rats that live in the dank cells.

APPEARANCE Uriah's eyes are yellow like an owl's, and he wears a low-hanging hood. The thick layers of grey rags he wears make him blend in against the dungeon's walls.

SECRET Uriah encourages the rumours about him to scare those held in the dungeons. He actually sleeps and eats in a local tavern, which is connected to the dungeon by a tunnel.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • DWARF • LABOURER

Ruden Kurt

Perceptive valet.

KNOWN FOR As valet, Ruden tends to the clothes of castle residents and guests. He has keen ears and is always the first to hear of any juicy secret or sordid affair on the estate.

APPEARANCE Ruden carries a small bag that holds a notebook, a brass sewing kit, a monogrammed handkerchief and a lint brush. His shoes and buttons are perfectly shined.

SECRET Ruden is the only person who has noticed the heir to the castle sneaking out every night. He's keeping quiet for now, while he plots how best to exploit this knowledge.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • ANIMALFOLK • LABOURER

Baron Boone Hosta

Baron who loves to garden.

KNOWN FOR Baron Hosta's vast gardens are his life's work, and the envy of all his neighbours. He spends his days pruning, watering and sketching different plants.

APPEARANCE He wears a teal waistcoat, silk cravat, rose-pink overcoat and straw hat while tending his gardens. The Baron greets all with a thoughtful compliment.

GOAL The Baron is preparing to host a garden party in honour of his niece's marriage. He wants the gardens to be perfect, and for nothing to spoil her day.

SECRET Part of the garden was recently destroyed by vandals, which has deeply upset the baron. His only clue is a scrap of fabric found in a carnivorous plant.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HALFLING • NOBLE

NOBLE / DRUID

Ser Wilfric Retgar

Enthusiastic new knight.

KNOWN FOR Ser Retgar's family were only made nobles this year. He feels he has much to prove both at tournaments and in society. He approaches this with relish.

APPEARANCE Soft curls frame Ser Retgar's face, and his chin has a few whiskers of a beard. His energetic spirit raises eyebrows at court, as does the fact he always wears armour.

SECRET Ser Retgar carries a ferret named Prince Nibble in his saddlebags. He takes the creature to every tournament and event, as he believes it is his lucky mascot.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HUMAN • NOBLE

Georgiana Missly

Luxury event planner.

KNOWN FOR Georgiana Missly is in high demand among the nobility. The lavish balls and parties she arranges are unforgettable affairs, packed with surprises and delights.

APPEARANCE Georgiana moves gracefully, draped in sweeping mauve silks. She is never without her spectacles, team of assistants and a thick folder of moodboard ideas.

SECRET Georgiana is facing bankruptcy after a lord didn't pay her for a lavish tournament she organised. She's out for revenge, and to get her money back.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • TIEFLING • ENTERTAINER

More Castle Staff

1. GRAYCE SMITHINS Sinister, chuckling kitchen assistant.
2. BILJO EMERALD Tutors the castle's children in history.
3. GORGUS TIBALT Intimidating warden of the castle armoury.
4. HARRY HEMBLEBY Happy-go-lucky poison tester.
5. MIK BONECLEAVER Ogre housekeeper with a heart of gold.
6. ASHFELD WINDCHASER Centaur falconer and hunt leader.
7. ORINYA HAFUINE Groundskeeper who lives in a lakehouse.
8. EVAN WITTERMUCH Castle archivist, librarian and scribe.
9. REITH PINE Housekeeper who sneaks treats from the pantry.
10. LARAH GRALMIR Organised steward of the castle cellars.

Eldemar Firstlight

Long-serving midwife.

KNOWN FOR Eldemar has helped deliver every child born in the castle for over 500 years. Eldemar has also offered spiritual guidance to many generations of residents.

APPEARANCE A slender elf with a bald head, Eldemar is softly spoken and often seems lost in thought. They wear deep blue robes and have a tattoo of their sacred symbol.

SECRET Eldemar is awaiting the fulfilment of a prophecy told 1,000 years ago. They were told they would help deliver a baby that would one day lead their holy order.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • ELF • WORSHIPPER

What jobs might your party be hired for in a castle? Is the pay proportionate to the wealth on display?

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Crenel Keepers

Gargoyles bound to their owners.

You hear stone scraping behind you. Turning, you see the same proud gargoyle, but you're certain it was facing a different direction.

KNOWN FOR No mere decorations, these stalwart guardians are bound to defend their castle. The same magic binds them to the castle's owner, and all of their heirs. For this reason, destroying crenel keepers is often the first action an invading force will take.

APPEARANCE Crenel keepers are designed to intimidate intruders and display fealty to the family they serve. They often have unsettling features and carry large weapons.

TACTICS The gargoyles stand atop castle walls, perfectly still until called upon. They attack with their stone weapons, or drop down and crush their target.

LAIR Crenel keepers use rooftops and turrets for high vantage points. However, these exposed positions leave them vulnerable to erosion.

SECRET A high, reverberating note can cause cracks to occur in their stone bodies, making them more susceptible to damage.

CREATURE • MEDIUM • NEUTRAL • CONSTRUCT GARGOYLE / STONE GOLEM

Evercorgis

Dogs from the Fey Realm.

KNOWN FOR Evercorgis are six-legged dogs that are prized among royals for their orange, fluffy coats. They lounge in castle hallways and bedrooms, and love belly rubs.

APPEARANCE Evercorgis have pointy ears, dark eyes and orange fur with a white underbelly. Their six legs end in black, webbed feet that allow them to walk up walls.

SECRET These yappy dogs are pests in the Fey Realm, but a clever archfey realised humanoids adore them. Evercorgis being highly coveted means the archfey makes good coin.

CREATURE • SMALL • FRIENDLY • FEY

Rune Wardens

Arcane crystal constructs.

KNOWN FOR Rune wardens are placed at entrances and in large halls of castles. When magical attackers are near, they activate, march into the fray and absorb arcane energy.

APPEARANCE Rune wardens have faceted crystal bodies, shaped like suits of armour. They are covered in runes that flare with light when they absorb magical energy.

SECRET After absorbing magical attacks cast around them, the wardens become charged with unstable energy. If hit with enough force, they may explode.

CREATURE • LARGE • NEUTRAL • CONSTRUCT

Bordercats

Giant guard lions.

KNOWN FOR Bordercats are giant lions that can be trained, saddled and ridden as mounts. They are often used as guard animals that prowl around castle borders at night; a deterrent to all but the bravest trespassers.

APPEARANCE These lions are fearsome to behold. Bred for purpose, they are three times larger than an average lion, but most are kept lean for riding. They have dull copper coats and naturally serrated teeth.

TACTICS At night, the lions stalk and hunt for prey. If they spot something, the whole pride works together to bring it down. Their wickedly sharp, hooked claws are strong enough to tear through basic chain mail.

SECRET The lions are nocturnal hunters by nature, so they are slower to react to intruders in daylight hours. It's also said that nightshade plants can make them drowsy and confuse their sense of smell.

CREATURE • LARGE • HOSTILE • BEAST LION / SABRE-TOOTHED TIGER

Having non-humanoid guards as part of castle security will make for a memorable encounter.

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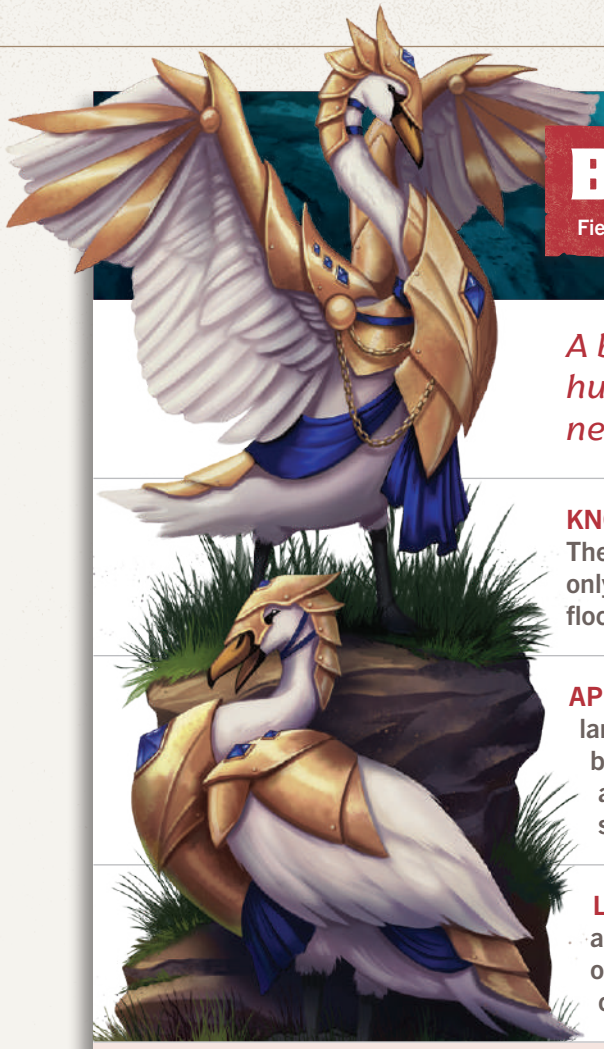

Battle Swans

Fierce fowl guardians.

A blur of white feathers and glinting gold armour hurtles towards you at breakneck speed. Wings and neck outstretched, the swan lets out a loud squawk.

KNOWN FOR Battle swans are bred to be loyal and vigilant guard creatures. Their powerful wings and snapping beaks deter any intruder. By tradition, only royals can breed battle swans and gift the birds to others. Owning a flock of battle swans is therefore seen as a status symbol by noble families.

APPEARANCE Battle swans are larger than average swans, with beady, watchful eyes. Their custom armour showcases the heraldic symbols of their owners.

TACTICS Battle swans work in pairs to attack at speed. After catching up with intruders, the swans will lash out with their beaks and wings to force a retreat.

LAIR The swans patrol gardens and grounds close to palaces. When off-duty, they rest in luxurious coops or on large ponds.

SECRET Graceful in water and air, but battle swans are awkward on stairs. They trip, get wedged or honk loudly until help arrives.

BATTLE SWAN
Medium Beast

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
14 (+2)	15 (+2)	11 (+0)	3 (-4)	12 (+1)	8 (-1)

Armour Class: 13
Hit Points: 16 (3d10)
Speed: 30 ft, fly 30 ft, swim 20 ft
Initiative: +2

Skills: Perception +3
Passive Perception: 13
Languages: --
Proficiency Bonus: +2

ABILITIES

Pack Tactics. The swan has advantage on an attack roll against a creature if at least one of the swan's allies is within 5 ft of the creature and the ally doesn't have the Incapacitated condition.

Flyby. The swan doesn't provoke an opportunity attack when it flies out of an enemy's reach.

ACTIONS

Beak. Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft, one target. Hit: 4 (1d4 + 2) bludgeoning damage. If the target is a Medium or smaller creature, it has the Grappled condition (escape DC 12). While Grappled, the target has the Restrained condition.

Wing. Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft, one target. Hit: 6 (1d8 + 2) bludgeoning damage.

CHALLENGE RATING 1/2

You could alternatively use the stats of a Giant Vulture CR 1, Griffon CR 2 or Cockatrice Regent CR 8.

CREATURE • MEDIUM • NEUTRAL • BEAST

Siege Ghasts

Lingering spirits of soldiers.

KNOWN FOR Siege ghasts are the trapped souls of soldiers who died besieging a castle. They remember nothing but their orders, and continue their attacks in perpetuity.

APPEARANCE The vengeful ghasts have hollow, skull-like faces and give off an eerie green glow. They are clad in the armour and weapons they perished with.

SECRET The presence of potent necromancy causes siege ghasts to occur. This can be either at the time of death, or years later, when the magic pulls back long departed souls.

CREATURE • MEDIUM • HOSTILE • UNDEAD

More Castle Critters

1. PICKLES Large, mean cat who patrols the castle kitchens.
2. PIPE WEEVILS Metal-devouring pests that live inside drains.
3. BELFRY Stubborn werebat who is squatting in a turret.
4. COBBRIELS Pixies that hide under flagstones to trip victims.
5. LADY WILMA Spaniel that inherited a title and a castle.
6. HAY GNATS Stable-dwelling bugs that regenerate when hurt.
7. ASHLITS Irksome imps that live in hearths and spread soot.
8. SIGHING SOULS Shapeless ghosts that cause cold draughts.
9. DUSTLOKS Piles of sentient dust that enjoy making mischief.
10. SOFTTOOTH Lazy chimera who guards the castle gate.

Looking for a side quest? Clearing a castle of an unwelcome creature makes for a great one-shot adventure.

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The Art Forge

Derelict art studio hideout.

The art gallery isn't what you expected. Canvases are propped against walls with little care or consideration, and sculpted busts are chipped and dusty.

KNOWN FOR The Art Forge was taken over by a gang of thieves when the old gallery owner moved to new premises. They've tried to maintain the facade of an artist's studio and gallery as a front for their criminal operations, but almost everyone in town knows what's really going on.

APPEARANCE The thieves ignore the building's crumbling walls. They hide contraband under dust sheets and place buckets to catch the rainwater.

LAYOUT Stairs from the gallery space lead up to an artist's studio. A hidden panel in the fireplace reveals a ladder going down to the cellar and into the sewers.

LOOT The paintings in the gallery are of no value. Stolen tools and boxes of diamonds are hidden in the studio.

SECRET The town guards have the gallery under surveillance and are planning a raid. They will strike when multiple suspects are on site.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • URBAN • FRONT

Moonstone Ballroom

Elegant ballroom bunker.

KNOWN FOR When sewer renovations made this overflow chamber redundant, it was repurposed into a secret ballroom. It is now frequented by the elite in criminal society.

APPEARANCE High ceilings are inlaid with glowing stones that light the grand room like stars. An upper balcony wraps around the walls, overlooking a long table and dance floor.

SECRET An annual masquerade ball is normally a chance for rival criminal families to put aside their differences for a night. This year, one gang boss is planning to kill another.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • URBAN • HIDEOUT

The Wood Shed

Infinite storage warehouse.

KNOWN FOR This plain, timber barn contains a pocket dimension, allowing its interior to stretch without limit. Bandits store stolen loot here, until it is safe to sell on.

APPEARANCE Without a magic key, the Shed's door opens to a small space filled with garden tools. With the key, the door opens to expansive storage racks, shelves and crates.

SECRET Divination magic used outside the warehouse cannot locate creatures or objects within it. Once inside, the Shed's wards against location spells are useless.

BUILDING • SMALL • RURAL • WAREHOUSE

Bloodtide Escape

Hidden pirate cave.

KNOWN FOR Bloodtide Escape is a hidden sea cave where pirates and smugglers meet to parley. It's only reachable by rowboat, because of the razor-sharp rocks that lead up to it.

APPEARANCE Jagged reefs guard the rope ladder entrance, and the nearby wreck of *The Sea Mustang* ship gives cover. Inside, volcanic holes spit seawater when the waves crash in.

SECRET Harpies nest high in the cave's ceiling. They silently snatch lone visitors who are left waiting for their meeting, but avoid attacking large groups of pirates.

BUILDING • SMALL • ISOLATED • MEETING PLACE

More Bandit Hideouts

1. **THE CUT ABOVE** Speakeasy located above a butcher shop.
2. **GANDALL HALL** Abandoned manor taken over by crooks.
3. **UMBRAL CRYPTS** Nestled within catacombs below the city.
4. **OLD TOLL HOUSE** Shabby structure marked for demolition.
5. **THORN CAVE** Once home to a dragon and its hoard.
6. **LUNAR HIDE** Underwater caves accessible during low tide.
7. **EMBER SANCTUM** Private club for outlaw entrepreneurs.
8. **BRIMSTONE ALEWORKS** Front for shipping illicit goods.
9. **ROCKBOTTOM FARM** Place to lie low and dispose of bodies.
10. **SANGUINE SIREN** Ship repurposed as a gambling tavern.

A bandit hideout isn't going to be labelled on a map, so how will your party find their way there?

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Relic Rooms Inn

Supposedly fully booked inn.

KNOWN FOR The "No Vacancies" sign at this inn is always on display, which is odd, as there are no horses or other signs of guests. Two guard dogs roam around outside.

APPEARANCE The squat stone inn has external doors for each room. The gruff innkeeper lives next to the reception, keeping watch through a narrow slit in the shutters.

SECRET A thieves' guild uses Relic Rooms Inn as a hidden base. Saying the password gets you a room, and a key to access a meeting room and guildmaster's office in the cellar.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • RURAL • HIDEOUT

Shrine of a Thousand Eyes

Temple of swindlers.

KNOWN FOR It was built so the gods could witness prayers, but the Shrine of a Thousand Eyes has secretly been a bandit hideout for years. Disguised as monks, they rob pilgrims.

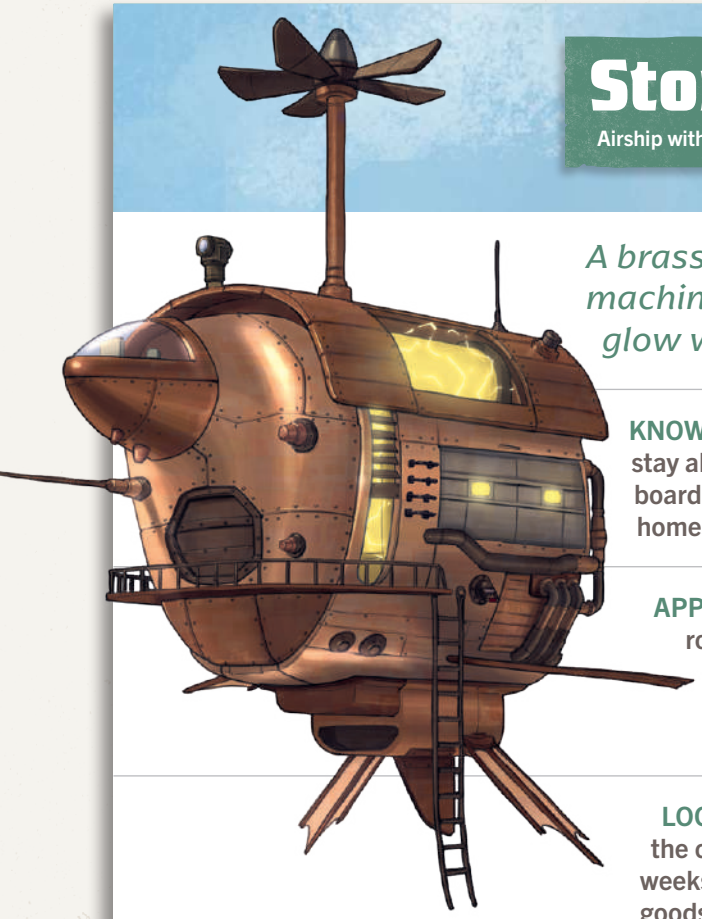
APPEARANCE The shrine's round chamber is lined with sculpted eyes, some of which act as spy-holes. Offerings of gold, food and gemstones lie at the feet of towering idols.

SECRET A high priest will visit next week as part of a sacred tour. The bandits plan to rob the holy jewels hanging from the high priest's neck mid-ceremony.

BUILDING • SMALL • ISOLATED • FRONT

Storm Dragon's Revenge

Airship with cloaking magic.



A brass airship covered in bizarre instruments and machinery flickers into view. Reinforced glass panels glow with crackling arcane light.

KNOWN FOR This compact airship uses its steam-powered propeller to stay aloft and arcane engine to cloak itself. Each night, the criminals on board fly the invisible airship above a new town, then drop down to rob homes and warehouses. They make a swift, flying getaway before dawn.

APPEARANCE The airship's round, metallic form is covered in chunky pipes. A propeller sticks out the top, and there are rudders at the rear.

LAYOUT The steam and arcane engines take up most of the ship. Crew quarters and a cargo hold are found in the base, with a navigator's chamber in the nose.

LOOT The airship has rations for the crew to stay airborne for two weeks. They typically steal bulk goods, like spices or fabrics.

SECRET The airship is a stolen military prototype. The previous owners are slowly catching up to the bandits.

VEHICLE • SMALL • ISOLATED • HIDEOUT

The Trails

Loot caves, caches and chutes.

KNOWN FOR Tunnelling oozes and their acidic slime created this network of passageways and caves. Bandits cleared the oozes and use the space to stash stolen goods.

APPEARANCE The circular tunnels twist and turn in all directions, including up and down. Perfectly smooth walls and ceilings create slippery chutes to drop loot down.

SECRET The bandits cleared out most of the oozes, but have kept the largest one captive. Trespassers are fed to the ooze, along with stolen goods too recognisable to sell on.

BUILDING • LARGE • RURAL • WAREHOUSE

The Olive Branch

Restaurant where deals are made.

KNOWN FOR Due to the brawny owner's strict no-fighting policy, this orchard-themed restaurant provides a neutral location for criminals to negotiate peaceful deals.

APPEARANCE Greasy lanterns swing from old beams, and grime coats the tables and walls. The roots of a central olive tree split the floor tiles, and its fruit is used as garnish.

SECRET Criminals don't only communicate at the Olive Branch's tables-for-two. The tree's hollow trunk holds rolled up secret messages and coded letters for collection.

BUILDING • SMALL • URBAN • MEETING PLACE

Hideouts will be full of traps, lookout points, hidden escape routes and natural hazards.

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Visk and Trisk Schwarzfeld

Twin mastermind chess champions.

KNOWN FOR These ruthless twins are part of a notorious gang. Visk and Trisk won multiple chess tournaments as kids, and use their wits to stay two steps ahead of the law.

APPEARANCE The pair wear matching black suits, white shirts, and grey side-partings. The colour of their ruffs is the only way to tell them apart — Visk's is black, Trisk's is white.

SECRET Trisk is preparing to get rid of Visk and steal his brother's money, influence and following. He doesn't know that Visk is planning the exact same thing.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • ORC • OUTLAW

Lord Knut Malefec

Crime boss noble.

KNOWN FOR Knut's corrupt influence spreads around his city like twisting ivy. He lives as a wealthy noble, but operates as a crime kingpin with an army of informants.

APPEARANCE He is tall and thin and wears tight, tailored clothing. Gold chains hang from his pointed, pierced ears, and his outfit is finished with a gaudy elk-head belt buckle.

SECRET There is only one person who Knut fears — his cruel father, a crime boss who operates in a nearby city. His father mentioned he would visit soon, which has Knut stressed.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • ELF • OUTLAW

Suseen Swab-Jones

Smuggler who bakes plunder into pies.

KNOWN FOR Suseen conceals stolen items in the fillings of her tasty blueberry pies. This clever technique lets criminals easily smuggle things out of the city.

APPEARANCE At first glance, Suseen's plain robes are inconspicuous. But, if you look closely at her, you'll notice her pricey bangles and thieves' guild brooch.

GOAL Suseen owes a lot of money to loan sharks after making a bad deal. She saves every coin she gets from criminal pie sales and hopes to clear her debts.

SECRET The pies she bakes contain a powerful sleeping potion — an added protection for the criminals she helps, in case guards decide to taste the pies.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HUMAN • OUTLAW

BANDIT / PIRATE

Manjano Skink

Unlicensed magic items dealer.

KNOWN FOR Unscrupulous merchant Manjano runs a secretive magic item shop hidden behind a false storefront. Entry requires a password that changes daily. All sales are final — no refunds, no questions.

APPEARANCE Manjano wears dark, threadbare robes over faded bright-pink overalls. Her chestnut hair is tied up in uneven pigtails. A worn pendant shaped like a lizard's face swings as she coldly negotiates deals.

GOAL Desperate to pay for her mother's costly medicine, Manjano peddles illegal and often stolen magical trinkets. She scours scrapyards and visits black-market auctions to fuel her underground trade.

SECRET Nine angry buyers have suffered violent accidents after purchasing Manjano's goods. The items spontaneously combusted or cursed their owners. She's on edge, hiding from guards and vengeful customers.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • KOBOLD • OUTLAW

BANDIT CAPTAIN / HALF-DRAGON

More Lawbreakers

1. IVO "FAST PALMS" PALMER Illusionist and pickpocket.
2. SAWYER COAL Youngest sibling of a notorious crime family.
3. SAUL NETON Expert poker player who illegally counts cards.
4. HERON SAXX Muscle enforcer for a shady nightclub.
5. SHADOW CAT Kidnapper of luxury pets for ransom.
6. LEN THE SALAMANDER Forger of rare religious books.
7. THE KNIFE Anonymous assassin who never turns down a job.
8. TIMOTHY BRIAR Mild-mannered accountant and embezzler.
9. LADY MEG ELVIN Thieving noble who only steals teaspoons.
10. DERBY CASKS Safe cracker with steady hands and nerves.

Faramond Fazzoletto

Doppelganger who runs romance scams.

KNOWN FOR This doppelganger has gone by many names, Faramond being his most recent. He lures in partners, bleeds their bank accounts dry, then shape-shifts and flees.

APPEARANCE Currently, he looks like an elven bard, with a crimson tunic, defined cheek bones and ice-blue eyes. Next month, he'll be a tattooed dwarf barman called Gravitz.

SECRET The doppelganger is old, and it hurts every time he shape-shifts. He hopes to gather enough money to buy a mansion in town, giving him a fixed place to recuperate.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • DOPPELGANGER • OUTLAW

You could use these outlaws to populate your city's bounty board or a town guard wanted list.

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Tillabella Pombé

Poison specialist.

KNOWN FOR Tillabella owns a poison brewery filled with toxic nightshade, wolfsbane and hemlock plants. She carefully distils their nectar and essences to craft potent poisons in her dimly lit workshop.

APPEARANCE Tillabella's hands are stained from handling toxins. Her tangled black hair is streaked with white. She wears a patched leather apron, and her sharp eyes glint behind cracked, smoky goggles.

GOAL She has had her eye on an idyllic cottage at the top of a hill for years, and she almost has enough to buy it. Selling toxins has made her steady coin, but now she is stepping up production for a major black market rollout.

SECRET An antidote to every poison Tillabella makes is stored in a steel chest in her office. It's kept there in case she accidentally spills or ingests anything during the dangerous distilling process.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • HUMAN • OUTLAW — SPY / ASSASSIN

Pippa Puddlejumper

Fearless getaway driver.

KNOWN FOR Pippa is the go-to getaway driver for bank heists and city raids. Formerly a stunt driver, her daring spins and wheelies thrill townsfolk, though sometimes they draw unwanted attention during escapes.

APPEARANCE Pippa has pale skin and bleach-blonde hair, usually pulled back. She wears leather gloves, a sleeveless shirt, shorts and sturdy boots, ready to leap from her black wagon at a moment's notice.

GOAL She earns far more driving for criminals than performing in stunt shows. Thrill-seeking and ambitious, Pippa invests every coin into upgrading and maintaining her beloved, custom-built black wagon.

SECRET Pippa's wagon has three reins; two for guiding her horses and a hidden third red rein. Pulling it triggers an arcane self-destruct mechanism under her cart; the ultimate fail-safe to avoid the cart's capture by guards.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • GNOME • OUTLAW — BANDIT / SPY

Skyro "Slayer" Fawkes

Nocturnal bandit who ambushes campers.

Slayer's broad shoulders bear the weight of a thick bear pelt, and a hefty morningstar with wickedly sharp spikes.

KNOWN FOR Few know the name Skyro Fawkes, yet tales of Slayer travel far and wide — a ruthless, night-haunting raider who attacks victims as they sleep. Wealthy nobles and merchants fear him most, but all who roam the wilderness after dark must stay vigilant.

APPEARANCE Slayer wears a bear hide to defend himself from the elements, and a scarf to conceal his face. He hauls his morningstar over his right shoulder as he walks.

GOAL Slayer steals from the rich to fund the search for his missing son, Eskee. He dedicates everything to finding clues on his whereabouts.

SECRET Slayer's hidden treehouse sits at the top of the forest canopy, shielding him from sight. Inside, he conceals incriminating evidence.

LOOT

- Morningstar*
- Boots of elvenkind*
- Thieves' tools*

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • ELF • OUTLAW — BERSERKER / ASSASSIN

Does your criminal character offer their services to an organisation, or do they prefer to work alone?

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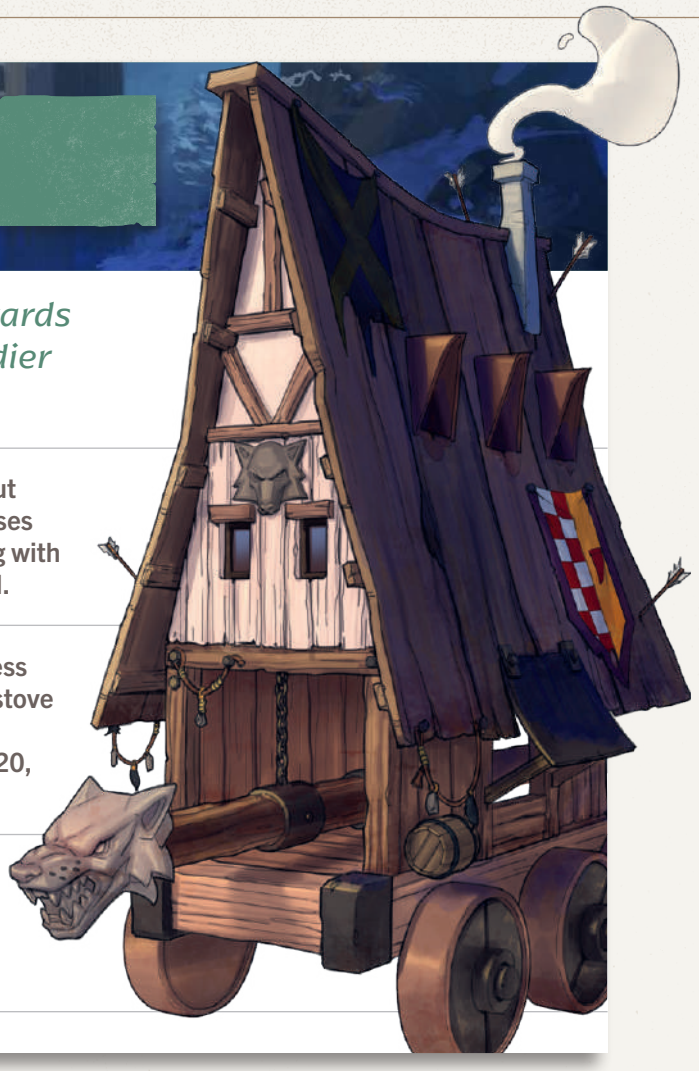
The Iron Snout

Battering ram base.



What looks like a small house starts to roll towards you. Before you have time to question it, a soldier yells at you to get out the way, fast.

KNOWN FOR A clever solution to drawn-out sieges, the Iron Snout can be hired to bolster attacking forces. The wooden vehicle houses a battering ram with a sharp steel cap to smash open gates, along with a dozen sell-swords who will help storm the castle once breached.

APPEARANCE The top half of the vehicle looks like a timber-clad cottage. A long wooden battering ram swings on rattling chains in the open area below.

LAYOUT A ladder gives access to the cottage, which has a stove and bunks for 12 soldiers to sleep comfortably (or up to 20, uncomfortably).

LOOT Each soldier stationed here has a footlocker of personal effects. A cache of weapons and armour sits near the stove.

SECRET The steel cap of the ram is enchanted, but poorly. Each strike risks a wild magical surge.

VEHICLE • SMALL • QUIET • BARRACKS

Chameleon Command Post

Mirrored military post.

KNOWN FOR Designed to be impossible for enemies to find, the Chameleon Command Post is as close to invisible as a building can get. It uses well-placed mirrors to perfectly reflect its environment.

APPEARANCE The Post's lightweight wooden walls and flat roof are designed to be rapidly assembled where needed. They are draped with weather-proof fabric, then the mirror panels are nailed into place over the top.

LAYOUT The Chameleon Command Post has two rooms. The main war room has a large map table where tactical meetings are held. The smaller room is an office for the commanding officer's private use only.

SECRET There are also mirror panels in the office. These are scrying devices and let the commanding officer spy on nearby areas, send visual reports to distant allies, or hold meetings with their superiors.

BUILDING • SMALL • QUIET • OUTPOST

Camp Big Top

Circus requisitioned for military use.

KNOWN FOR Once filled with laughter, Camp Big Top now bristles with weaponry, barricades and barked orders. Colourful tents conceal armouries and training barracks.

APPEARANCE Soldiers occupy the main striped tent and blacksmiths work in the caravans. Trenches ring Camp Big Top, reinforced with jagged iron spikes and lookout posts.

SECRET The original circus performers have been enlisted to serve the incoming military forces. Most work in the mess hall, but the juggler is being retrained as a crossbow sniper.

BUILDING • LARGE • OVERCROWDED • BARRACKS

Circe Arena

Training facility with illusory magic.

KNOWN FOR The illusions in the Circe Arena can be altered to replicate various battle scenarios. This allows cadets to prepare for different locales, enemies and types of danger.

APPEARANCE Outside, the arena is an unremarkable warehouse building. Inside, arcane crystal devices project realistic illusory scenes across every inch of space.

SECRET Circe Arena's existence is highly classified to ensure cadets don't know they are in a simulation. Only the most perceptive may spot tiny discrepancies in the illusion magic.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • BUSY • OUTPOST

Whichever side of the barricades your party is on, it's worth thinking in advance about the site's defences.

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Frogsbottom

Bunker hidden beneath a swamp.

KNOWN FOR Frogsbottom bunker lies submerged in a swamp. Recite a secret coded message while stood on a hidden runic circle, and it will rise out of the murky waters.

APPEARANCE Even when raised to the surface, Frogsbottom still blends into the swamp. Its slimy, domed walls and thick porthole windows are covered in aquatic plants and algae.

SECRET The bunker hasn't ever been used during an actual emergency. The bunker's commander still takes their job very seriously, and changes the passcode weekly.

BUILDING • SMALL • QUIET • OUTPOST

More Military Encampments

1. **REDCREST FIELDS** Fenced-off range for training exercises.
2. **COMMANDANT'S HALL** Exclusive academy for officers.
3. **SUNSTONE QUARTERS** Beige barracks for soldiers' families.
4. **FLAGFALL CAMP** Sprawling holding camp for reserve troops.
5. **LAST STAND** Camp that has been under siege for 10 years.
6. **EAGLE'S NEST** Base for combatants with flight capability.
7. **ISLE OF BLADES** Island base of elite naval commandos.
8. **THE BARN** Dusty warehouse of military uniforms and maps.
9. **PORT GREEN** Seaside barracks that defend against invaders.
10. **CROWN QUARTERS** Tactical safehouse for military leaders.

Whispering Pines Barracks

Forest martial arts barracks.

KNOWN FOR This woodland retreat shelters an elite martial arts unit. Its grounds stretch deep into the forest, where fighters practise flowing, precise techniques beneath towering pine trees and rustling leaves.

APPEARANCE Recruits are trained on raised sparring platforms in open-air courtyards. Lime green banners ripple in the breeze as the warriors learn to channel the energy of the forest around them.

LAYOUT Whispering Pines is made up of 14 barracks, a communal dining area, and classrooms for briefings and theoretical teaching. Complex obstacle courses wind their way through the surrounding trees.

SECRET Whispering Pines Barracks is said to safeguard a Deck of Many Things to stop it falling into the wrong hands. Everyone on site is prepared to defend the deck, but no one is aware that it is merely a decoy.

BUILDING • LARGE • BUSY • BARRACKS

Amaranthine Outpost

Undead defence tower.

The tower stands in the gloom, stone-cold and lit up with power. The ground vibrates as arcane cannons pulse, crackling with raw energy.

KNOWN FOR Superstitious soldiers shudder at the idea of being stationed at the Amaranthine Outpost. Built in an area of heightened paranormal activity, the tower emits regular pulses of magical energy to subdue the spirits that haunt the region.

APPEARANCE Day and night, the Outpost's tall, white walls give off a faint glow. When its arcane weapons are powered up, blue light crackles around the structure.

LAYOUT Weapons and arcane generators are housed in the main tower structure. Soldiers and mages bunk in underground dormitories when not on duty.

LOOT Outpost soldiers use magical silvered weapons, specially made to deliver powerful blows to undead creatures, ghosts or vampires.

SECRET Soldiers are frequently possessed by malevolent spirits. This creates an atmosphere of distrust and paranoia.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • QUIET • OUTPOST

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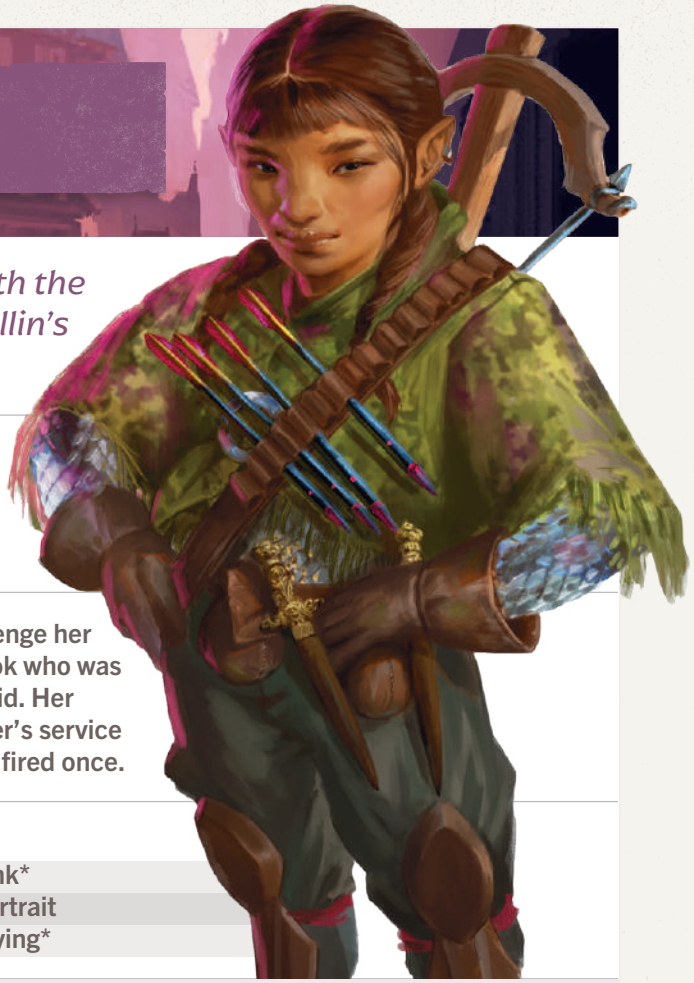
Ellin Cindermouse

Crossbow sniper.



Her round face and playful pigtails contrast with the calm precision in her grip. Each movement of Ellin's crossbow is smooth and perfectly poised.

KNOWN FOR Ellin is the most skilled sniper in the realm, and has repeatedly proven her accuracy at impossible distances. Small by halfling standards, she can hide in tight spots that others can't. Ellin is often referred to as the "Kid Assassin".

APPEARANCE Ellin's long hair is braided in two loose pigtails and cut short above her eyes to keep her vision unobstructed. Her green fabric poncho is daubed with mud.

GOAL Ellin fights to avenge her father, a battlefield cook who was killed during a camp raid. Her crossbow was her father's service weapon, which he only fired once.

SECRET Ellin has a superstitious attachment to her crossbow. If she is forced to shoot with another bow, her accuracy is negatively affected.

LOOT

- Cape of the mountebank*
- Locket with father's portrait
- Arrow of humanoid slaying*

ASSASSIN INITIATE
Small or Medium Humanoid

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10 (+0)	16 (+3)	13 (+1)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	9 (-1)

Armour Class: 15
Hit Points: 40 (8d8 + 8)
Speed: 30 ft
Initiative: +3

Saving Throws: DEX +5, INT +4
Skills: Acrobatics +5, Perception +2, Stealth +7
Damage Resistances: Poison
Passive Perception: 12
Languages: Common, Thieves' Cant
Proficiency Bonus: +2

ABILITIES

Evasion. If the assassin is subjected to an effect that allows it to make a Dexterity saving throw to take half damage, the assassin instead takes no damage if it succeeds on the save and only half damage if it fails. It can't use this trait if it has the Incapacitated condition.

ACTIONS

Multiattack. The assassin makes two attacks, using Shortsword or Light Crossbow in any combination.

Shortsword. Melee Weapon Attack: +5 to hit, reach 5 ft, one target. Hit: 6 (1d6 + 3) piercing damage plus 2 (1d4) poison damage, and the target has the Poisoned condition until the start of the assassin's next turn.

Light Crossbow. Ranged Weapon Attack: +5 to hit, range 80/320 ft, one target. Hit: 7 (1d8 + 3) piercing damage plus 3 (1d6) poison damage.

BONUS ACTIONS

Cunning Action. The assassin takes the Dash, Disengage, or Hide action.

CHALLENGE RATING 2

You could alternatively use the stats of a Scout CR 1/2, Assassin CR 8 or a Bandit Crime Lord CR 11.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • HALFLING • COMBATANT

Private Graha Gable

Artist conscript.

KNOWN FOR Graha was drafted into the infantry days before starting her art apprenticeship. She now boosts army morale by sketching playful caricatures of her fellow soldiers.

APPEARANCE Graha is dark skinned with expressive brown eyes and a buzz cut. She seems too tall for any chair and awkwardly perches her sketchbook on her raised knees.

SECRET While stealing scrap paper to sketch on, Graha accidentally came into possession of very sensitive military intelligence that she doesn't know what to do with.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HUMAN • COMBATANT

Corporal Jeminus Ripley

Heavily armoured battle cleric.

KNOWN FOR Jeminus fearlessly walks onto the battlefield to heal the injured and recover fallen bodies. Arrows ping harmlessly off his oversized armour as he marches forth.

APPEARANCE This brave medic's bulky, silver plate armour includes a boxy helmet, oversized shoulder pauldrons and hefty gauntlets embellished with the holy symbol of his god.

SECRET Jeminus' armour is imbued with a divine blessing that helps shield him from blows. However, wearing such a powerful item is making Jeminus age at an increased rate.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • ORC • WORSHIPPER

Soldiers can travel the realm as part of an army or mercenary force.

Benjamin Mast - 4benmast@gmail.com

The Adrenaline

Super-soldier experiment.

KNOWN FOR The Adrenaline is an unstoppable force of nature with seemingly endless stamina. Once a soldier, a failed "upgrade serum" transformed it into a raging brute. It is unleashed from its cage as a last resort in war.

APPEARANCE This creature's massive frame is swollen with twitching, purple muscle that visibly expands during combat. The longer it fights, the more its size increases, driven by an unstoppable violent momentum.

TACTICS Adrenaline is a mindless husk of its former self and lacks any real strategy. It charges at any visible threat, relying on pure brute force. The more injuries it suffers, the fiercer and stronger it becomes in battle.

SECRET Psychic attacks weaken the Adrenaline, and disrupt its focus and stamina. Prolonged exposure to psychic magic can chemically alter the serum in its blood, and cause its body to fail.

CREATURE • LARGE • HOSTILE • GIANT — OGRE / ETTIN

Nirav Steelheart

Veteran weapons expert.

KNOWN FOR After a career on the frontlines, Nirav now spends his days training new recruits with the weapons they will one day use in battle.

APPEARANCE Nirav never cracks a smile, and bellows at recruits who don't take training seriously. His trusty halberd is always at hand.

GOAL Nirav insists every recruit he trains masters at least one melee weapon and one ranged weapon, so they can adapt to any situation.

SECRET Nirav is a harsh critic of himself. He is determined no recruit will be as unprepared as he was when he became a soldier.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • DWARF • COMBATANT — GUARD CAPTAIN / GLADIATOR

Captain Callahan Golightly

Miraculously lucky cavalry officer.

KNOWN FOR Good weather, a surprise surrender of enemy troops, locals happy to supply food when rations are running low; wherever Callahan rides, good fortune follows.

APPEARANCE Callahan's shining armour remains flawless, just like his perfect smile. He rides Fortunata, a majestic golden unicorn with a flowing mane that sparkles in sunlight.

SECRET Callahan unknowingly has divine ancestry on both sides of his family. His celestial ancestors try to out-do each other by granting him frequent, generous blessings.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • CELESTIAL • COMBATANT

Janah "Scales" Fossey

Experienced swamp soldier.

KNOWN FOR Janah became an expert at navigating swamp environments after getting caught behind enemy lines. She was forced to spend months alone in the muddy wilderness.

APPEARANCE Janah gets her nickname Scales from the crocodile-skin armour she wears. She made a sickle out of the same crocodile's jawbone, right after it attacked her.

SECRET During her time in the swamp, Janah grew tired of her military's goals. She now follows her own moral compass, and will sabotage missions she disagrees with.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • HUMAN • COMBATANT

More Spies and Soldiers

1. ENID CROW Speaks with insects to gather intelligence.
2. BELLE HOLWAY Ghost spy who is even more useful in death.
3. IRIS GORN Medic cleric who helps all injured, even enemies.
4. BAXTER REDLEAF Bard spy who sings coded messages.
5. FREN ARCUS Prolific arsonist, drafted as a munitions expert.
6. REGGIE KNOTTS Underappreciated rations coordinator.
7. STERLING LARK Working undercover in foreign government.
8. DORAN ERHIDE Injured soldier who cares for cavalry horses.
9. FLINT GRENGE Drummer who sets a steady marching pace.
10. ALMA HARON Officer with a dislike of scruffy uniforms.

Marshal Ludan Shadowspark

Spy and disguise expert.

KNOWN FOR This slippery spy creates realistic wax masks that allow him to mimic other people's faces, and hide his own. His methods are effective, but uncanny and unsettling.

APPEARANCE In public, Ludan rarely wears the same face twice. He only peels off his disguise when alone in his workshop, revealing raw and blistered skin underneath.

SECRET Ludan spent years deep undercover, living in a rival regime where magic was banned. This led him to develop his unique method for long-lasting, non-magical disguises.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • ELF • OUTLAW

Think about what your soldier NPC was doing before they joined the military, and what their plans are for the future.

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Rootrider

Boat made from a living tree.

KNOWN FOR This vessel was crafted from a single tree by a desperate circle of druids. They cast remarkable magic to save their island's population from a tsunami, and give themselves a new floating home.

APPEARANCE The tree's expansive roots were knotted and woven together by the druids to form *Rootrider*'s hull. The original tree trunk stands proudly in the centre of the large, round vessel as its mast.

LAYOUT Below decks, there are 11 cosy cabins decorated with items the islanders saved from their home. There are also supply stores and an area where organic waste is recycled back into the living vessel.

SECRET The volume of magical power absorbed by the tree has kickstarted the process of it becoming a treant. *Rootrider* is slowly developing sentience, and the ability to steer its own course across the ocean.

VEHICLE • SMALL • ARCANE • BOAT

The Shellspiker

Fortified military boat.

KNOWN FOR The first of a new wave of military combat vessels, the *Shellspiker*'s design is inspired by the natural armour of dragon turtles. It is crewed by elite armed forces.

APPEARANCE Overlapping metal plates cover the ship's deck and sides, creating an armoured shell. Protruding iron spikes are designed to pierce any ramming enemy ship.

SECRET The *Shellspiker* is fearsome and effective, but has proved outrageously expensive to build and maintain. Naval commanders have agreed to scrap it after its next voyage.

VEHICLE • LARGE • COMBAT • BOAT

The Sanguine

Cursed ship with a trapped crew.

KNOWN FOR After angering a kraken, this pirate vessel is under a powerful curse. The *Sanguine*'s crew cannot leave the ship, as seawater fills their lungs if they disembark.

APPEARANCE The ship's planks are rotted, its mast is broken and its sails hang in tatters. It has been unable to dock for repairs, as winds swiftly drive it back out to sea.

SECRET The crew believe sacrificing other sailors will appease the kraken and lift the curse. They try to injure anyone who boards the ship, then throw them to the waves.

VEHICLE • MID-SIZED • UNDEAD • BOAT

Pax Oceana

Sacred temple ship.

The sapphire temple ship calmly glides through the sea. Silver trim gleams along its rails, spire-masts rise like steeples, and a central shrine radiates incense.

KNOWN FOR The clerics of *Pax Oceana* believe that proper worship of their sea god must be done at sea. Therefore, they built their temple on a ship and set sail. They complete rowing shifts as part of their daily meditation, and never stay docked for longer than is strictly necessary.

APPEARANCE Its sails are fastened to ornate spires rather than masts. There is a tall shrine at its centre with elegant, decorated glass doors.

LAYOUT There is a lookout post within the spire of the main shrine. Below deck are simple crew quarters, and benches for rowing clerics.

LOOT The clerics eat seafood, so the ship has fishing gear. In the main shrine there are talismans and prized gems.

SECRET By divine will, lost vessels often drift towards the *Pax Oceana* and its devout crew members.

VEHICLE • LARGE • RELIGIOUS • BOAT

If you're setting sail on a nautical campaign, p. 241 has more ideas to get you started.

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Beach Bounty

Oyster shell raft.

KNOWN FOR When the top half of an enormous oyster shell washed to shore, a skilled angler took it home. They converted it into a small fishing raft for their personal use.

APPEARANCE The inside of the shell is smooth and shiny mother-of-pearl, while the outside is a rough, green-grey. The shell has been outfitted with oars and a makeshift sail.

SECRET *Beach Bounty*'s owner uses the vessel to fish and gather seaweed. They are also secretly looking for the other half of the shell, hoping it contains a giant pearl.

VEHICLE • SMALL • COMMERCIAL • BOAT

Surf Zipper

Steam-powered yacht.

KNOWN FOR A marvel of artificing, this speedy yacht is stuffed to the gills with new technology. It has sleek rudders and propellers, a lightweight hull and a loud steam engine.

APPEARANCE *Surf Zipper* doesn't have any sails, it relies entirely on its steam engine and propellers for propulsion. Its tall chimney belches dark smoke when at max speed.

SECRET *Surf Zipper* was built to be fast, so safety features were removed to save weight. In a crash, its hull would immediately crumple and its steam engine would explode.

VEHICLE • SMALL • MECHANICAL • BOAT

Shadowcrest

Mercenary stealth ship.

The ship carves through the water like a sharp dagger, waves cleaved in half by its tapered bow. The deck is shrouded in shadows, and you see no crew.

KNOWN FOR The ultimate stealth vessel, *Shadowcrest* transports skilled assassins and mercenaries into port under the cover of darkness. During the day, the ship's distinctive black sails and mast are lowered and the deck is draped in ripped white sails, to resemble a drifting wreck.

APPEARANCE Jagged, black sails cut through the air like fins of a terrifying beast. The crew work by moonlight, only lighting lamps on foggy nights.

LAYOUT A combat training room fills most of the deck, covered in thin crash mats. Below deck, hammocks are crammed in close together.

LOOT The ship has an immense weapons cache. The captain's desk contains top secret orders and intelligence documents.

SECRET Beneath the floor is a locked ledger of completed assassinations, and names still marked for death.

VEHICLE • LARGE • COMBAT • BOAT

The Cirrus Strider

Cloud-powered boat.

KNOWN FOR This steel boat has a cloud magically tethered to its deck, in place of sails. The cloud's elemental power propels the ship at high speeds, even in low winds.

APPEARANCE The roiling cloud is caught in a magical net, strung to tall masts at the bow and stern. Depending on the day, the cloud can look soft and calm, or dark and stormy.

SECRET Many of the ship's crew know elemental magic. If under attack, they are able to channel their powers into the cloud, and send the ship airborne for short periods of time.

VEHICLE • MID-SIZED • ARCANE • BOAT

More Boats and Ships

1. **THE VIVARIUM** Ship for transporting live flora and fauna.
2. **ABYSSIA** Submersible built to hunt an elusive sea monster.
3. **THE MACAW** Colourful pirate ship crewed by birdfolk.
4. **THE CRYSTAL PEARL** Ice ship that patrols polar waters.
5. **ROYAL HALSTEAD** Part of an intercontinental mail fleet.
6. **THE AMBROSE** Military support ship providing medical aid.
7. **THE ENDEAVOUR** Exploratory ship, making maps as it goes.
8. **CIRQUE DE LA MARÉE** Transports touring entertainers.
9. **THE FIRE MAIDEN** Half-burned ship crewed by the undead.
10. **THE GILDER** General supply ship offering at-sea restocks.

How common is ocean travel in your homebrew world? Is it safe or dangerous to sail the seas?

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Captain Ren Oshiro

Noble on a world cruise.

KNOWN FOR This arrogant young captain inherited a huge fortune, and is spending it on a world tour. Ren pays his crew well, but his lack of sense and experience means they don't respect his authority.

APPEARANCE Ren wears a diamond-studded, golden breastplate over flowing silk robes dyed luxurious purple. His manicured hands have no calluses, and his perfectly styled orange curls glisten with scented oil.

GOAL Ren is obsessed with seeing the world and showing off his accomplishments to his peers. He buys a ceramic animal at every port, and plans to display these trophies in a curated gallery when he returns home.

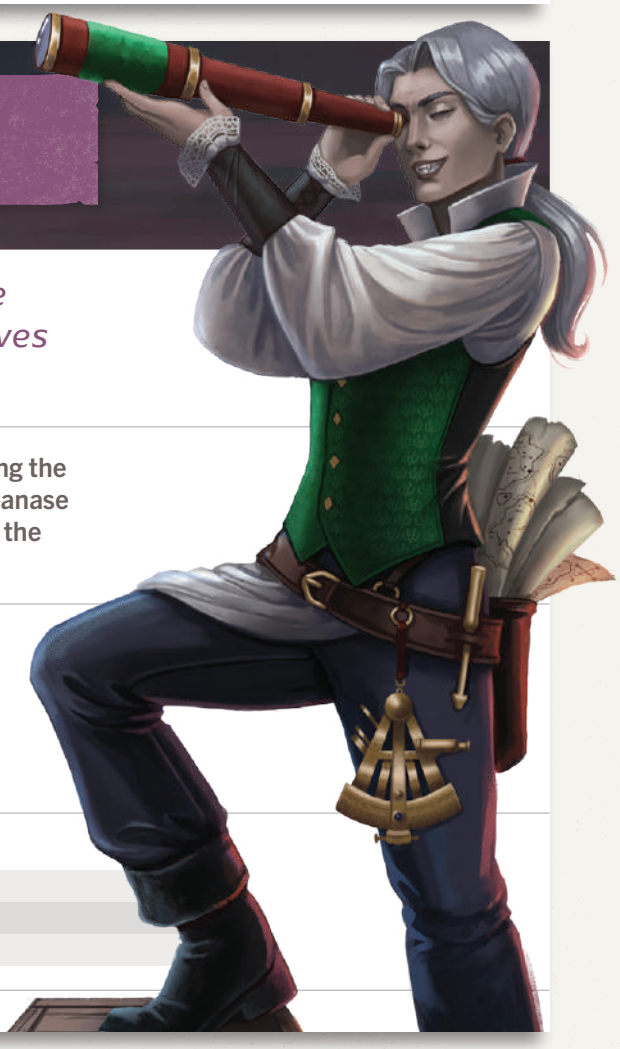
SECRET Ren inherited his fortune from his uncle, whose wife and child were thought to have been lost at sea decades ago. The child survived, and is working on Ren's crew, waiting to reveal their claim to his wealth.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • GOLIATH • NOBLE

NOBLE / NOBLE PRODIGY

Atanase Ciobanu

Vampire navigator.



Beneath the moonlight, a lone sailor stands on the main deck. They are scanning the shimmering waves with a brass, leather-wrapped telescope.

KNOWN FOR This vampiric sailor has spent hundreds of years travelling the world's seas and has become an expert in navigation. As a vampire, Atanase must slumber in the cargo hold by day, before rising at dusk. They use the stars to deftly chart the ship's course.

APPEARANCE Pale with lustrous silver hair and smooth skin, Atanase is ageless. Their elegant attire is somewhat old-fashioned, but they carry it off with dashing charm.

GOAL After centuries on land, Atanase grew restless and left for the sea. Now, the ocean bores them; they crave new experiences and adventures.

SECRET Years ago, Atanase created vampiric spawn who have since become full vampires. Atanase can summon them as an undead army.

LOOT

- Eyes of the eagle*
- Lantern of revealing*
- Spyglass*

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • UNDEAD • WAYFARER

PIRATE / VAMPIRE

Saltclaw Fishing Co.

Family-owned fishing company.

KNOWN FOR This fishing business is operated by a family of catfolk sailors. They specialise in catching lobsters and other crustaceans, and possess a deep knowledge of their family's historic fishing waters.

GOAL Younger members of the family are trying to diversify the business. They want to offer deep-sea fishing trips and sightseeing harbour tours. The elders agree, and are looking for ways to make the change.

FEATURE Each of the Saltclaw Fishing Co. vessels is painted with a mural of a sea beast. The family marks their crustacean trap positions using barrel buoys with painted whiskers and pointed cat ears.

SECRET For the past week, the family have been pulling up increasing numbers of empty, damaged lobster pots. A large predator seems to be stalking the local waters. The family want it gone, but don't want to spread panic.

FACTION • LARGE (50–99) • FRIENDLY • INDUSTRY

Most boats need a basic crew including a captain, first mate and navigator.

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Fintan Grimteeth

Dreadful ship's cook.

The cleaver slams through bone and deep into the butcher block, sending half the joint skidding across the blood-soaked floor.

KNOWN FOR Fintan serves as both the ship's cook and occasional surgeon. Short-tempered and stubborn, he tolerates no complaints. His food is bland at best and straight-up revolting at worst, but no one dares speak up.

APPEARANCE Fintan's filthy apron, crusty dishcloth and chipped cleaver are all stained with dried blood and grease. Stray hairs from his long, unwashed black beard often turn up in the meals he cooks.

GOAL Fintan took a job at sea to avoid debt collectors. He's saving every coin to pay off a massive gambling debt.

SECRET A broken nose caused Fintan to lose his sense of taste and smell. This left him unable to properly season any food.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • HUMAN • LABOURER

TOUGH / TOUGH BOSS

Captain Pearl McCaw

Awakened parrot pirate.

KNOWN FOR This awakened parrot was a pirate captain's pet, until she successfully led a mutiny against her owner. Now this remarkably persuasive bird controls a large crew.

APPEARANCE Pearl is a large grey parrot with a white face, black beak and a flash of crimson tail feathers. Pearl wears ruby rings on each leg and two golden necklaces.

SECRET She perches on a golden sceptre stolen by the old captain. It is a cursed Rod of Rulership that gives Pearl great influence, but is also slowly corrupting her soul.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • BEAST • OUTLAW

Silver Seadogs

Retired pirate support group.

KNOWN FOR This union of pirates bands together to fund members who can no longer sail. Members wear a silver pin or locket with an engraved symbol of a docked ship.

GOAL Silver Seadogs promises those who pay their dues a comfortable retirement. They are expanding to offer support for pirates who are injured, or find themselves unemployed.

SECRET A quiet, simple life on land doesn't suit many of the retired pirates. One group is plotting to commandeer a ship and set out on a risky heist to boost the union's coffers.

FACTION • MEDIUM (20–49) • FRIENDLY • SOCIAL

More Seafaring Folk

1. BO ALLEY Deckhand who is secretly a royal heir on the run.
2. AZIMUTH Construct first mate who speaks many languages.
3. ZEPHANIA NAAJI Tattooed with a magical map of the seas.
4. CELMUN GOFF In charge of inventory for a huge cargo hold.
5. MARINA QUIN Ambassador sent to negotiate with merfolk.
6. GID SANDER Lost a hand to a kraken that hungers for more.
7. VAHIRE WATANA Marine life researcher; constantly seasick.
8. ZALO PORRAS Captain of a vessel smuggling explosive loot.
9. MAZ BLOODSAILS Pirate leader, feared by other captains.
10. FEVEN WINTHER Naval officer undercover as a pirate.

First Mate Essie Hanwalé

Prophetic sailor.

KNOWN FOR Visions take hold of Essie without warning, causing her eyes to cloud over. She witnesses events and weather patterns hours before they affect her ship.

APPEARANCE Essie dresses in heavy woollen sailor's garb. Her blonde hair is cut short and tucked under a feathered cap. When she has visions, tears fall silently down her cheeks.

SECRET Essie can sometimes manipulate the weather during her strange visions, but doing so drains her life force. Each vision leaves her physically exhausted and weakened.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • ORC-HUMAN • WAYFARER

If something was to happen to the ship's captain, could your party step up and take the lead?

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Meridian Surveyor's Fellowship

Renowned cartographers' guild.

KNOWN FOR The Meridian Surveyor's Fellowship is known to hire and train the best marine cartographers from around the world. They also have divisions that offer certification and verification of boat charters or records.

GOAL The Fellowship aims to redraw its sea maps every five years to keep them as up-to-date as possible. Their motto is *velarim estiir ma'laniel*, an Elvish phrase that translates to "the seas don't stop, so neither will we".

FEATURE Fellowship cartographers and record keepers are easily spotted by the scroll case storage packs on their backs. Members wear a signet ring with the guild's ray emblem engraved on its face and motto on its band.

SECRET There is a remote archipelago that the Fellowship is yet to map. The guild lost six members to a fierce whirlpool near the island last year, but still defiantly sends cartographers there on assignments.

FACTION • LARGE (50–99) • NEUTRAL • ACADEMIC

Wavebinders

Naval spellcasting specialists.

KNOWN FOR The Wavebinders are an elite guild of naval spellcasters assigned to warships. They reinforce rigging with magic, clean decks with simple charms and calm storms. They can also throw fireballs in ship combat.

GOAL Their mission is to upgrade and protect naval fleets with enchantments. Trained at yearly summits, Wavebinders are deployed across the world to serve aboard warships as arcane specialists.

FEATURE Wavebinders wear storm-blue robes, with shimmering grey sigils on heir cuffs and collars. Most shave their hair or wear it in a tight bun, to ensure their vision is clear while casting spells on blustery decks.

SECRET Wavebinders can capture storms in arcane containers and unleash them during battles. However, storing them disrupts natural weather patterns, causing heatwaves and droughts back on shore.

FACTION • SMALL (6–19) • NEUTRAL • MILITARY

Captain Nichelle Vandven

Naval pirate hunter.

The gilded chains around Nichelle's horns and medals on her naval jacket clink ominously as she walks. Their chilling chimes accompany the captain's unyielding glare and the deadly cutlass at her side.

KNOWN FOR Pirates fear the name Captain Vandven. She has a stellar record for buccaneer and rogue trader arrests, as well as contraband confiscation. She has sent countless pirates behind bars, or to the gallows, with the help of her diligent and hand-picked crew.

APPEARANCE Nichelle is a ruby-skinned tiefling with sharp horns that curl away from her stern face and flowing hair. Her blue naval coat is adorned with medals that show both rank and honour, and is customised with purple paisley lining and gold chain accessories.

HISTORY Growing up, Nichelle wanted to be a pirate. She helped at her father's coastal bar as a teen, and enjoyed the wild stories from the seafaring patrons. When a pirate kidnapped her sister, however, she swore revenge and joined the navy when she was old enough.

GOAL Until she finds her sister, Nichelle will not rest. She ruthlessly hunts for pirates, interrogates them for information on her sister's whereabouts, then throws them into one of her ship's holding cells. Recently, her leads have been dead ends, and news has been thin.

SECRET Nichelle has been fined twice for not using a naval standard-issue rapier. Instead, she wields her father's machete. He used it to open coconuts and pineapples, but it cuts down pirates just fine too.

LOOT

Mariner's armour*	Medals of honour
Annotated map	Vorpal scimitar*
Sister's locket	Custom tricorn hat

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • TIEFLING • COMBATANT

BANDIT CAPTAIN / GUARD CAPTAIN

Captain Nichelle Vandven (right) demands excellence from all who sail with her.

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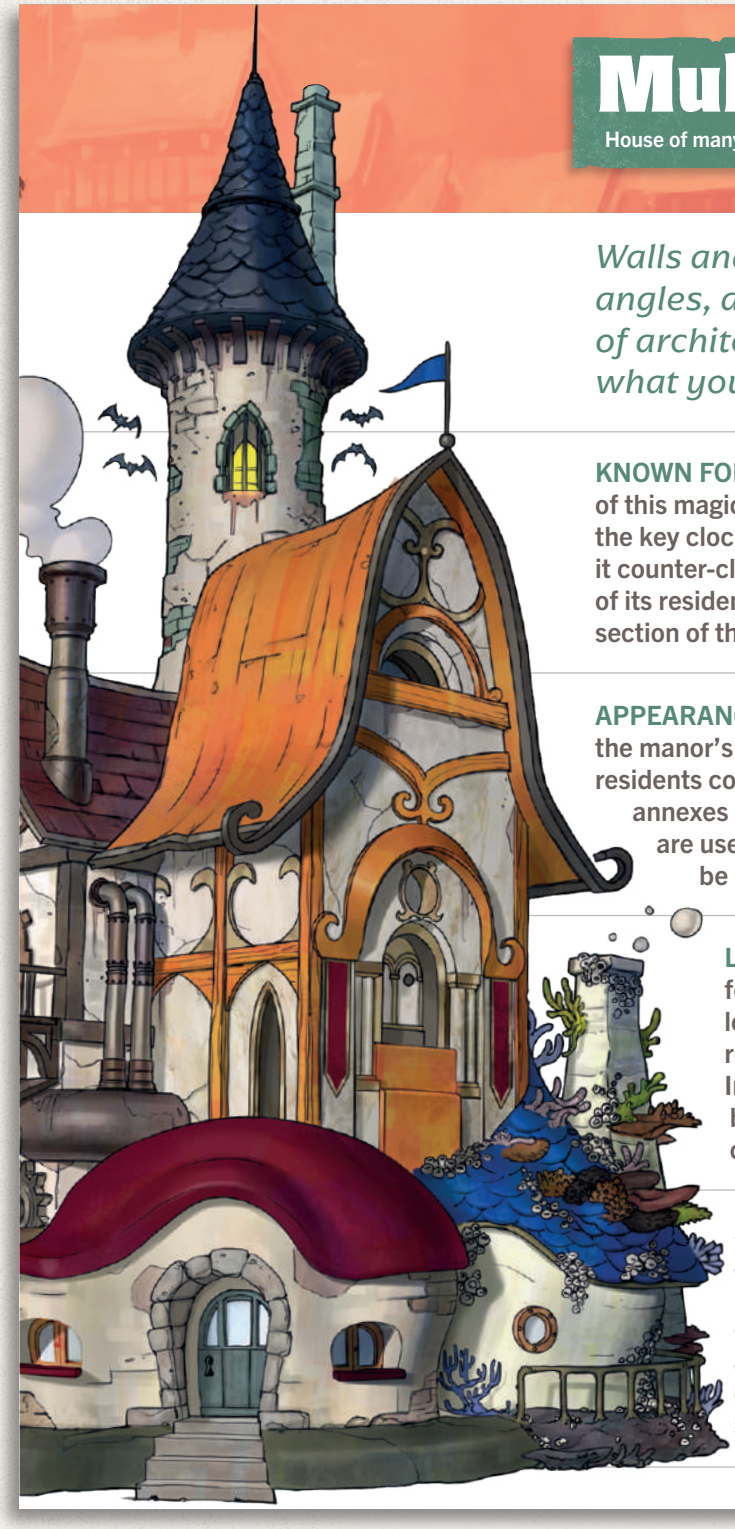

Multitude Manor

House of many planes.

Walls and roofs slot together at impossible angles, and there's a bewildering hodge-podge of architectural styles. Just when you grasp what you're looking at, the house starts to shift.

KNOWN FOR This is a house-share with a difference. Each tenant of this magical abode carries an ornate gold front door key. Twisting the key clockwise opens a door to a small entrance lobby, twisting it counter-clockwise reveals a unique annex that reflects the magic of its resident. If the tenant hails from a different plane, their section of the manor can also serve as a portal to their home world.

APPEARANCE A product of complex interdimensional sorcery, the manor's exterior shifts to reflect who is currently at home. As residents come and go, the building shifts and creaks, and new annexes pop out at unexpected angles. The manor's neighbours are used to seeing a gothic turret in the morning, only for it to be replaced by a tethered hot-air balloon in the afternoon.

LAYOUT The consistent feature of the manor is its lobby, which has a domed roof and rounded door. Inside, dozens of letter boxes allow tenants to contact each other.

LOOT A key to Multitude Manor can be used as a token for teleportation spells to any plane of existence, making it a valuable tool for intrepid interplanar adventurers.

SECRET Two residents are in a quarrel. Both believe that the presence of the other's magical annex in the manor is a danger to the health and safety of other residents.

ENCOUNTERS

- Arguing merfolk diplomats
- Landlord evicting tenants
- Arcane maintenance work
- Loud party on upper level
- Sudden weather change
- Locked-out tenant

BUILDING • LARGE • URBAN • ESTATE

Brewer's Folly

Tower that descends.

KNOWN FOR Who says a tower needs to go upwards? Certainly not the contrary wizard and potion-maker who engineered this subterranean tower. The structure descends hundreds of feet down into the earth.

APPEARANCE The uneven walls of Brewer's Folly are made from raw, compacted earth. The only decorative details are naturally occurring: small pieces of glinting gravel and intricate nesting patterns formed by insects.

LAYOUT A spiral staircase descends from the surface to a handful of inhabited floors at the tower's deepest points. With no natural light, it's hard to see which of the damp, wooden steps are completely rotted.

SECRET The reclusive mage who lived here died last year. Since then, the tower's living quarters have been overrun by worm creatures, which increased in size and power after consuming old potion supplies.

BUILDING • LARGE • ISOLATED • TOWER

Have any of the spellcasters in your party visited these magical homes before?

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Tanglehold Cottage

House with abundant flora.

Mingling scents of honeysuckle and lilies waft through the air. The purple-clad house is a verdant paradise of flora. Leaves and vines drip from its every surface.

KNOWN FOR This narrow townhouse stands out from its drab neighbours. Ivy creeps up the walls, poppies bloom from the gutters, and herbs sprout on the windowsill flower boxes. Plant growth is so unnaturally fast here that pruning shears are needed almost daily to keep paths clear.

APPEARANCE Tanglehold Cottage's exterior is made from stone, timber and purple-painted wood. Roots have formed cracks in the brickwork, but the home is well looked after.

LOOT The seeds of rare flowers growing here are valuable to plant collectors. There are also herbs with healing properties; some have already been made into salves.

LAYOUT The ground floor holds a sitting room and kitchen, two floors of bedrooms sit above. The cellar and attic are used as potting sheds.

SECRET Plants grow abundantly in Tanglehold Cottage due to fey magic, which flows through a tiny rift under the cellar's floorboards.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • URBAN • HOUSE

X Laboratory

House with a laboratory.

KNOWN FOR The ownership of this newly constructed home is a mystery to its neighbours. A gossiping postal worker has spread word that parcels are addressed to X Laboratory, and have a lot of hazardous warning signs.

APPEARANCE The building has reinforced metal walls, no windows and a high, barbed wire fence. There is also a lightning conductor on the roof. On some nights, loud whirring and clanking echoes from inside the lab.

LAYOUT A stark, clinical laboratory takes up most of the downstairs; a metal table sits in the centre, hooked up to strange, bloody machines. The floor above has a pantry and kitchen, and the top floor has rows of bunks.

SECRET The owner insisted that the building's blueprints be kept confidential. Shortly before completion, builders working on the lab were involved in a freak workplace accident. They now work as undead test subjects.

BUILDING • SMALL • RURAL • HOUSE

Spellville Show Home

House enchanted to be clean.

KNOWN FOR Every magical mod-con is on display in this showroom of arcane appliances. Objects in the home are all enchanted to perform household tasks for the resident.

APPEARANCE Slippery, self-polishing floorboards glisten underfoot as you step into the home. Soap bubbles float through the air from the sparkling self-cleaning kitchen.

SECRET The efficiency of the home's enchantments make it impossible to live in. The animated brooms and mops have been known to attack guests who complain about them.

BUILDING • SMALL • URBAN • HOUSE

Granite Rook

Arcane library tower.

KNOWN FOR Granite Rook was built by a paranoid mage to protect their extensive spell library. It has powerful magical and non-magical defences to protect against break-ins.

APPEARANCE The surface of this round tower is perfectly polished black stone. An anti-magic shield is projected from a humming device on the crenellated roof platform.

SECRET The library, located at the heart of the tower, is filled with books of forbidden magic. Select apprentices are permitted to study at the Granite Rook by invitation only.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • ISOLATED • TOWER

If your campaign's villain is a magic user, their home could be the site of a spectacular final showdown.

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Casa Riposo

House with its own time zone.

KNOWN FOR Handy for those on a deadline, stepping into this home places visitors in a time bubble. However long they spend inside, no time passes outside.

APPEARANCE Each brick of the cottage is scrawled with transmutation runes. Opening the curtains reveals the time-locked outside world, where clouds and trees stand still.

SECRET The cottage has no clocks or calendars, so it is easy to lose track of time. A young scholar accidentally spent 60 years revising here, emerging for his exam as an old man.

BUILDING • SMALL • RURAL • HOUSE

Stonehoof Hall

House of magical creatures.

KNOWN FOR No stray or injured magical creature gets turned away from Stonehoof Hall. There's a pegasus in the pantry, a blink dog in the bathtub and 20 talking toads.

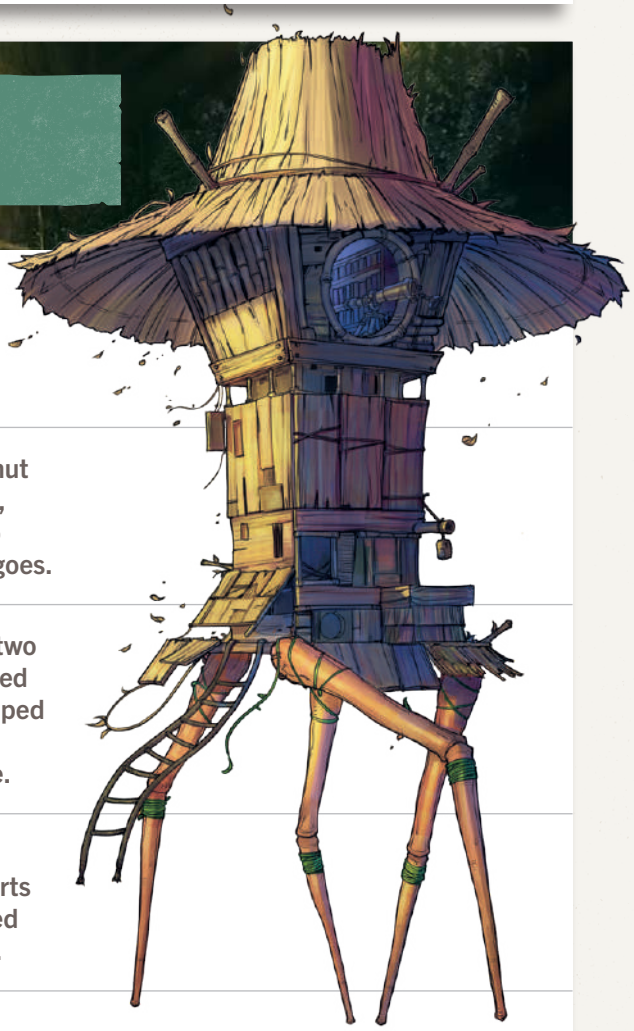
APPEARANCE Animals roam freely in two-floor townhouse and its timber outbuildings. The halls are filled with clucks, barks, grunts and pungent droppings.

SECRET A clutch of reptile eggs have mistakenly been placed in the chicken coop to incubate. The flying snakes inside could hatch at any moment.

BUILDING • SMALL • URBAN • ESTATE

Scuttlesquat

Tower on enchanted legs.



A wide, circular roof shades the tower beneath. With a bamboo exoskeleton and stilted legs, the spindly house resembles an insect.

KNOWN FOR Once seen, never forgotten, this multistorey bamboo hut has four long, thin legs that look like stilts when stationary. However, these wooden legs have been enchanted — when the owner wants to relocate, the hut simply scuttles away, creaking and clattering as it goes.

APPEARANCE The oddly shaped structure is clad in rough wooden panels, strapped together with coarse rope. The panels can be pushed open to let in a breeze.

LAYOUT The attic study has two round windows and a shuttered skylight in the roof. The cramped lower floors house a simple kitchen, bedroom and lounge.

LOOT The study has many tools for divination, including a telescope and star charts. There are also diaries recounting future events.

SECRET The hut has a self-preservation charm. It teleports to a random, previously visited location if severely damaged.

BUILDING • SMALL • ISOLATED • TOWER

Acorn Hideaway

House disguised in a tree trunk.

KNOWN FOR Built into the trunk of an oak tree, this hidden home lies behind thick ivy. Magical wards repel anyone with harmful intent, keeping its inhabitants safe and unseen.

APPEARANCE Inside, low lamps cast shadows on the uneven wooden walls. Shabby fabric curtains separate a small sleeping area from the main living space.

SECRET The charms shielding Acorn Hideaway fail if someone sees a resident enter or leave, or if the hidden door is directly shown or described to them.

BUILDING • SMALL • ISOLATED • HOUSE

More Magical Homes

1. **WITHERHALL** Manor that drains the life force of those inside.
2. **GRAND FOLD** Interdimensional tent, bigger inside than out.
3. **LATCHKEY LODGE** Size-shifting townhouse the size of a key.
4. **SILKFANG NEST** Pale home made from strands of spider silk.
5. **DRIFTROCK** Stone hut that hovers just above the ground.
6. **WYRDGALLEY** Alchemist's home, surrounded by sandbags.
7. **GLOAMHOUSE** Talking portraits of mages line the walls.
8. **DICESPIRE** Tower with a 20-sided glass orb at the top.
9. **EVERFROST** Cottage carved from magical non-melting ice.
10. **DWELOUISE** Sentient house that talks to its residents.

How does the magical home's owner interact with the building's enchantments?

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Digby Ditchwater

Spellcaster attuned to decay.

KNOWN FOR Locals have nicknamed Digby "Duke of the Dungheap". A regular in the settlement's stinkiest spots, he happily communes with rats, flies and other so-called pests.

APPEARANCE Digby's large grey overcoat is stiff with mud, soot and foul-smelling stains. He cackles loudly at his own jokes, revealing his a few remaining teeth.

SECRET Digby specialises in nature magic focused on death and decay. He's revived the dead more than once, though most locals dismiss his claims as nonsense.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HUMAN • NATURALIST

The Iron Wand

Arcane bounty hunters who capture mages.

KNOWN FOR This specialist mage sect can be hired to track and apprehend other spellcasters, on behalf of those without arcane abilities. Their steep upfront fees are non-negotiable.

GOAL The Iron Wand was originally set up to stop only those committing illegal magic. Now, most members are focused more on the pay cheque than on the reason for the capture.

SECRET Under their black robes, Iron Wand members wear a necklace that counters the effect of the anti-magic handcuffs they all carry. This stops the cuffs being used against them.

FACTION • MEDIUM (20–49) • HOSTILE • MILITARY

Cadence R. Willington

Lich awaiting full powers.

A tattered, red-velvet gown clings to the lich's skeletal frame. With each creaking step, dust rises from the layered lace and frayed silk of her outdated clothing.

KNOWN FOR Cadence was an unremarkable academic, presumed dead after vanishing two centuries ago. In truth, she attempted a ritual to become a lich, but instead fell into a magical coma; she has recently awakened. Though she dreamed of spellcasting prowess and unlimited power, her transformation is incomplete, and she is a pale imitation of the mage she wanted to become.

APPEARANCE Cadence speaks with an old-fashioned accent and dresses in outdated finery – a velvet corset, high-collared blouse, and frilled lace skirts. Her skin is corpse-pale, drawn tight across her bony features. When she moves, her bead jewellery rattles like bones. The air left behind her is ice-cold and faintly scented of dried lavender and rosemary.

HISTORY Born into a famed family of spellcasters, Cadence struggled to keep up with her siblings. Cadence was the only family member who avoided duelling, choosing instead the path of an arcane scholar.

GOAL While she waits for her full powers to grow, Cadence hunts down the scholars who dismissed or disproved her magical theories. She sabotages their reputations, and leaves hexes scrawled on their work.

SECRET Cadence could only succeed with the lich ritual because of the secret guidance of her professor, who detailed the process in coded footnotes. She guards this truth obsessively, terrified of ridicule.

LOOT

- Spellbook
- Brooch of shielding*
- *Mage Works* by C. R. Willington
- Crystal ball of telepathy*
- Skull of her professor
- Circlet of blasting*

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • UNDEAD • SPELLCASTER MAGE / LICH

What is the source of your spellcaster's power, and how experienced are they at using magic?

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Bronwen Whittlewood

Urban druid.

KNOWN FOR This young druid is dedicated to rewilding, urban gardening, and protecting wildlife within the city. At least, that is when she's not distracted by shiny things.

APPEARANCE Bronwen's shabby coat and trousers are covered in mismatched trinkets. As she speaks, she idly plays with her many rings, brooches and dangling charms.

SECRET Bronwen is the first to know about new goings-on in the city, thanks to her flock of crow companions. She is willing to trade the birds' information in return for trinkets.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • DWARF • NATURALIST

Zephyr Emberglint

Dragon trying to fit in.

KNOWN FOR Sociable Zephyr loves talking about how he acquired his vast hoard of magic items, but gets flustered when he shares a little too much about his own abilities.

APPEARANCE Zephyr wears long orange robes and a velvet cap over his bald head. His perfectly coiffed, brassy beard disguises his sharp fangs and the scale markings on his chin.

SECRET Though he does his best to hide it, Zephyr is a brass dragon who prefers to live as a human. Sometimes a metallic glint in his eyes or a smoking cough give him away.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • DRAGON • SPELLCASTER

League of Magebreakers

Secret arcane fight club.

You're hit by a wall of searing heat and choking smoke. Blinding flashes of green, orange and pink erupt as two robed figures hurl spells in a chaotic duel.

KNOWN FOR This secretive group gathers after hours in a library basement. Mages engage in ruthless spell duels, sometimes causing serious injury or death. Membership is tightly controlled due to the illegal, dangerous nature of these fights – guards have closed the basement down more than once.

GOAL Mages join the League of Magebreakers to push their spells to the limit, settle rivalries or train rigorously to prepare for more dangerous battles yet to come.

LEADERSHIP The group values equality among members. Every new recruit requires a current member's personal recommendation before joining the League of Magebreakers.

FEATURE Members are given a marked coin when they join. The coin glows to indicate an upcoming meet, and allows them entry.

SECRET An undercover guard has infiltrated the League, and is gathering intel on group members ahead of a planned raid.

FACTION • LARGE (50–99) • NEUTRAL • SOCIAL

Nicomedeas "Nico" Drunch

Agent who exploits spellcasters.

KNOWN FOR Nico earns a fortune selling powerful, cutting-edge spell scrolls. In truth, she can barely cast a cantrip, and relies on contract-bound mages to create everything for her.

APPEARANCE Nico flaunts her success by wearing slick, bespoke suits. Her salt-and-pepper hair is worn in a neat twist, secured with an ornate and deadly sharp hairpin.

SECRET Nico tricked the mages working for her into binding apprenticeship contracts. Anyone who threatens to leave is polymorphed into a fish, as per the contract.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • HALFLING • MERCHANT

More Arcane Folk

1. TAKAR KURODA Magical clay artist with runes on their skin.
2. BRAE LENNOX Time-travelling mage from the future.
3. LILEMOR RUE Druid carrying a scaly egg of unknown origin.
4. TERRY TWINKLEGEM Fairy who steals teeth for use in spells.
5. CARLROTTA COBBLETOOTH Matriarch of a coven of hags.
6. MERRIGAN STRYFE Struggles to control their chaotic magic.
7. SERIN SHADELARK Stole from a lich and is now in hiding.
8. GOLOMIR WYND Warlock trying to save their dying patron.
9. BEORATIO BOGLE Translator of obscure spell scrolls.
10. NEVE CALDECOTT Absorbs their power from magic items.

These magical individuals likely have a personal library of rare books and spell scrolls.

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Antiquaries Archivum

Society of magical artefact collectors.

KNOWN FOR Antiquaries Archivum is an ancient institution, a small group of wealthy collectors brought together by a passion for arcane artefacts. They hold exclusive private auctions to grow their collections.

GOAL The Antiquaries Archivum helps its members expand their collections of artefacts. It also acquires dangerous items destined for destruction, securing them safely for preservation and future study.

FEATURE Each member wears a silver ring etched with a spider perched on an open treasure chest. All official letters, contracts and artefact sale documents must bear its wax-stamped imprint.

SECRET One of the group's regular auctioneers has been replacing auction lots with forgeries and selling the real artefacts on the black market. So far only two forgeries have been spotted, but suspicions are growing.

FACTION • MEDIUM (20–49) • NEUTRAL • COMMERCE

Xenocrates

Extraterrestrial mage.

KNOWN FOR A recent arrival on this world, Xenocrates has quickly become a respected expert on all matters related to astronomy and planar magic.

APPEARANCE Xenocrates has wide, completely black eyes, which sparkle like the night sky. Beneath his red, conical hat, his skull is unusually elongated.

GOAL He eagerly shares his knowledge of the stars. In return, he seeks insights into other magic, especially long-distance communication spells and techniques.

SECRET Xenocrates was banished from his home world after questioning its war-hungry leaders. He fears his people will one day launch an invasion on this world.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • ABERRATION • SAGE

MAGE / ARCHMAGE

Pakpao Horcust

Hobbyist wizard with a supportive familiar.

KNOWN FOR A former botanist, Pakpao has taken up magic in her retirement. She can be found practising spells in her greenhouse, or making tiny clothes and hats for her frog familiar Syrus.

APPEARANCE Pakpao wears a colourful crocheted cardigan over a smock dress embroidered with intricate geometric patterns. Her frog companion, Syrus, is dressed in a formal button-up shirt and tie.

GOAL Pakpao works hard to advance her spellcasting talents, cheered on by Syrus with croaks and grunts. Pakpao's never disheartened when a spell goes wrong, believing it's simply an opportunity for improvement.

SECRET Syrus isn't a real frog or a true familiar. He's Pakpao's husband, permanently polymorphed during a magical mishap. Despite her efforts, Pakpao hasn't yet managed to undo the transformation.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • GNOME • SPELLCASTER

DRUID / MAGE

Sibyl's Hands

Powerful divination group.

KNOWN FOR Members of Sibyl's Hands are found across the realm, from government leaders to village healers. They share an ability to see into the past, present and future.

GOAL This clairvoyant group regularly gathers to chant in unison and sharpen their foresight; especially when the planes and stars align with long-prophesied configurations.

SECRET A member who was believed to have died of old age has recently materialised at a reading. She revealed she was murdered and that other members are in danger.

FACTION • HUGE (100+) • NEUTRAL • RELIGIOUS

Otoxa Potten

Magical foster parent.

KNOWN FOR When children display unpredictable magical powers, Otoxa offers short-term room and board on a vast estate where they can learn to control their abilities safely.

APPEARANCE Otoxa is a green-skinned orc with a tusked grin. This cheerful sorcerer lives for the simple joys in life and dresses in overalls that change colour with the seasons.

SECRET Otoxa's noble family rejected him when he initially struggled to control his own powers. When he inherited the family manor, he opened its doors to help others.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • ORC • SPELLCASTER

Magic users can provide healing, research space, storage, planar travel or protection to the party.

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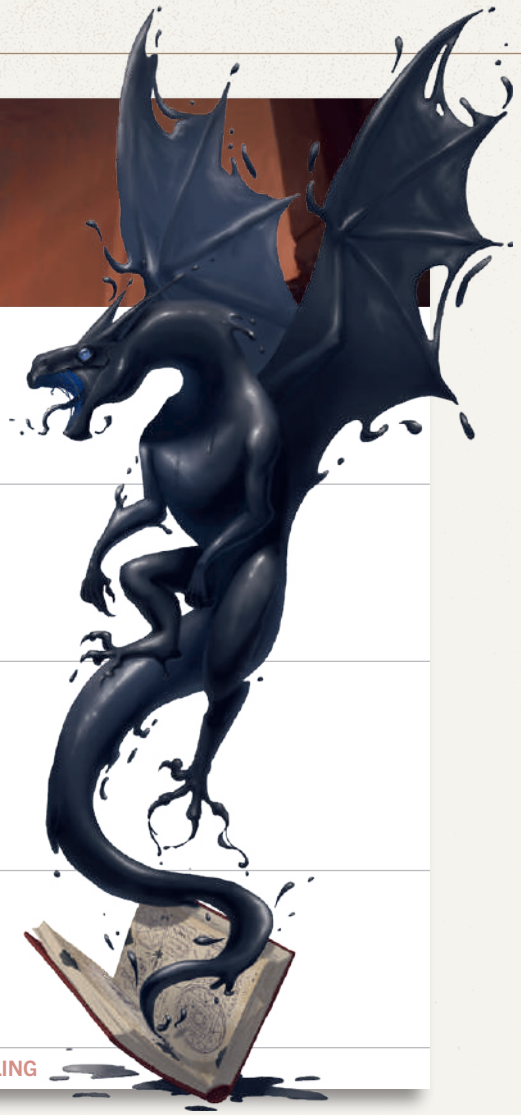
Inkwell Dragons

Pseudodragons made from ink.



The ink begins to shimmer and rise off the page. Black liquid pools amorphously in the air, before settling into a small, but unmistakably draconic form.

KNOWN FOR Formed from enchanted ink, inkwell dragons are favoured by scholarly spellcasters. These small, serpentine creatures can slip into journals, becoming indistinguishable from the writing itself. While hidden, they can overhear conversations, read information or remove text.

APPEARANCE Inkwell dragons are typically black or very dark blue. This helps them blend in with most written text when they are hiding in books and documents.

TACTICS Not inherently combative creatures, inkwell dragons typically hide in a book if a fight breaks out. However, they can use their sharp stinging tail nib in an emergency.

LAIR They are most at home in a library or study full of books and parchment. They curl up in an inkpot to rest, totally camouflaged.

SECRET A poorly hidden inkwell dragon appears as garbled text, or a passage that is clearly taken from another document.

CREATURE • TINY • NEUTRAL • CONSTRUCT PSEUDODRAGON / BLACK DRAGON WYRMLING

Lumberwings

Domesticated donkey pegasi.

KNOWN FOR A cross between a mule and a mighty winged pegasus, lumberwings can pull carts for long distances through the air, and float over rough or unstable terrain.

APPEARANCE Lumberwings have the stamina and short, stocky build of a donkey. Their stone-coloured wings have fewer feathers than those of a purebred pegasus.

SECRET Even domesticated lumberwings maintain the proud nature of their pegasus ancestors. If mistreated, they will purposefully buck their cargo and rider mid-flight.

CREATURE • LARGE • FRIENDLY • CELESTIAL

Compalicus

Unseen servants made permanent.

KNOWN FOR Compalicus are long-lived, shimmering beings born from altered unseen servant spells. They silently assist their conjurer with day-to-day chores and duties.

APPEARANCE Compalicus are humanoid figures of light. Conjurers normally give them clothing – some wear top hats and suits, others bright and playful clown costumes.

SECRET The light of a Compalicus fades slightly with each completed task, until it one day vanishes. Their average lifespan is around 30 years.

CREATURE • MEDIUM • NEUTRAL • CONSTRUCT

Pudge

Owl assistant who can read.

KNOWN FOR As a fledgling owl, Pudge was taught to read by her owner. Now, she uses that skill to fetch books from the highest shelves on command and neatly return them.

APPEARANCE Pudge is a round, brown owl with a striped white belly and fluffy feathers. She has bright, spectacle-like markings around her large and inquisitive yellow eyes.

SECRET As her owner transcribes spell scrolls, Pudge pecks at errors with uncanny precision. Few suspect the owl is a co-author, as her owner keeps it a closely guarded secret.

CREATURE • TINY • NEUTRAL • BEAST

More Magical Helpers

1. STRATUS Nature spirit in the form of a friendly raincloud.
2. SCRIBBLE Sentient quill; communicates by writing in the air.
3. BANSHEER Talking cat with white fur and a terrifying meow.
4. VISCY Ooze used to dispose of sensitive documents.
5. GALLANT Magical sword with a loud, opinionated spirit.
6. AMURA Sphinx kitten that serves as a wizard's familiar.
7. VEXANA Plane-hopping nightmare with a flaming blue mane.
8. BRAMBLE Small awakened shrub that acts like a puppy.
9. FANG Reanimated taxidermy squirrel; surprisingly cute.
10. MIM Domesticated mimic trained for home security.

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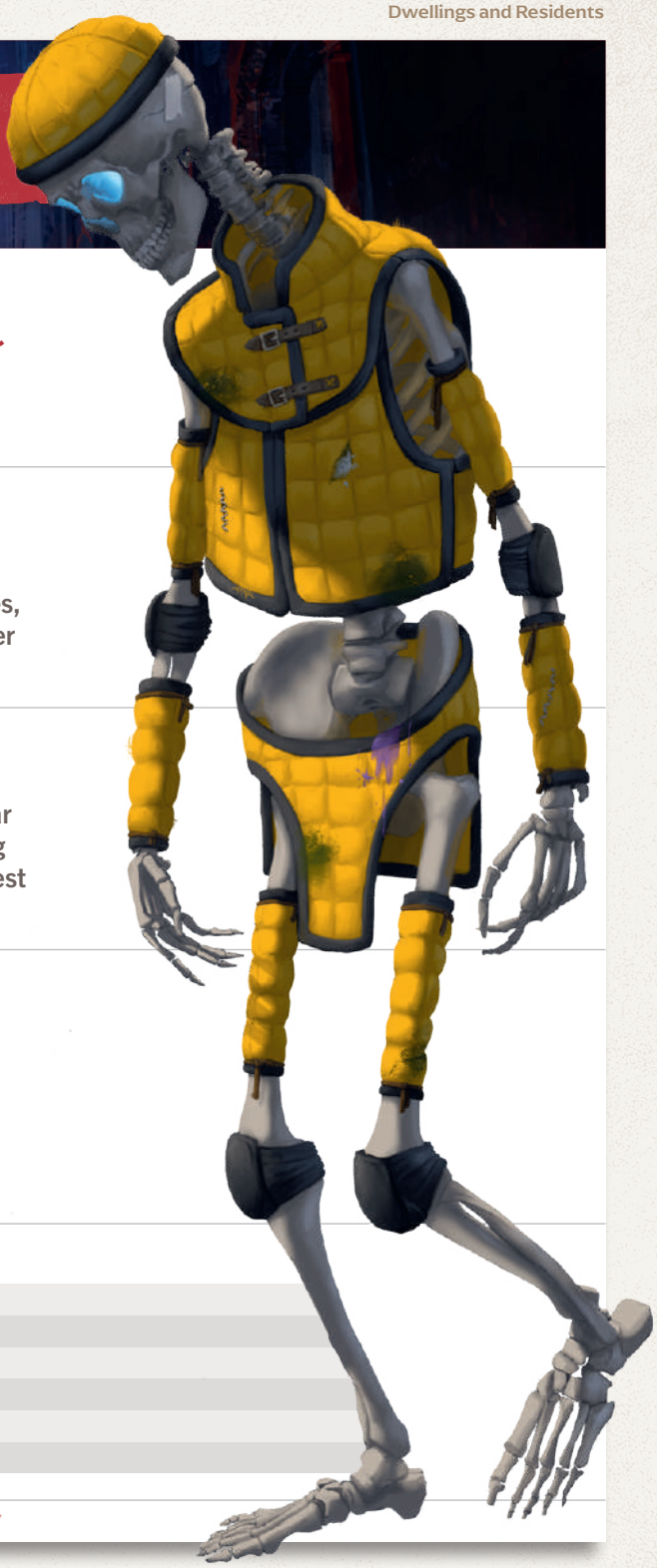
Spell Trial Skeletons

Skeletal constructs used to test spells.



As the blast of green light hits the skeleton, it explodes into pieces, bones flying everywhere. A nearby wizard tuts and scribbles a note in their spellbook, before the skeleton reforms.

KNOWN FOR Also known as "Spelletons", Spell Trial Skeletons are an arcane alternative to living test subjects. These undead constructs are used to test or demonstrate spells on a simulated body. The simplest Spelletons are little more than animated bones, while more sophisticated models can reassemble themselves after damage and record data about the spells cast on them.

APPEARANCE A Spell Trial Skeleton is identifiable by their post-mortem burns, scrapes and fractures. Runes on their bones help with reassembly, durability or damage resistance. Spelletons wear anything from light fabric padding to full plate armour, depending on the trial. Their eyes glow with blue light, a signal that a living test subject would be surviving the current simulation.

TACTICS Spelletons behave as programmed. Typically, they take unprovoked attacks without reacting. However, they can also be instructed to defend themselves, or even fight back, in order to test combat spells.

LAIR Spell Trial Skeletons are only found in leading arcane laboratories or mage colleges, where new spells or magical inventions are being tested. They rest in a jumbled pile of bones, normally in a chest.

SECRET The long-dead bones of Spelletons aren't always sourced ethically. Unscrupulous mages have been known to rob graves to make their own, which can result in a resentful, irate or haywire Spelleton.

LOOT

- Padded leather armour*
- Fire-resistant femur bone
- Elbow and knee pads
- Cracked skull
- Dust of dryness*
- Mantle of spell resistance*

CREATURE • MEDIUM • FRIENDLY • UNDEAD SKELETON / MUMMY

Zep

Imp bound in rat form.

KNOWN FOR After causing too much trouble, even compared to other fiends, the imp Zep was bound in rat form and forced to act as a wizard's familiar. Ever resentful, he provides as little help as possible.

APPEARANCE Zep is a scrawny rodent with red-brown fur, large ears and jagged yellow teeth. On closer inspection, two scabs on his head are actually a pair of tiny horns. His milky white eyes glow in the dark.

TACTICS Zep is able to squeeze through tight gaps, and has a nasty bite. Although he must follow direct commands, he does his best to find loopholes in his orders and try to sabotage them.

SECRET In order for Zep to be freed from his rat form and be an imp once more, someone must accurately guess his full name, Zepheous Zellamime Zedbetter. He desperately squeaks and hisses to try and give clues.

CREATURE • TINY • NEUTRAL • FIEND IMP / WERERAT

A flying familiar can scout locations that the party can't easily infiltrate.

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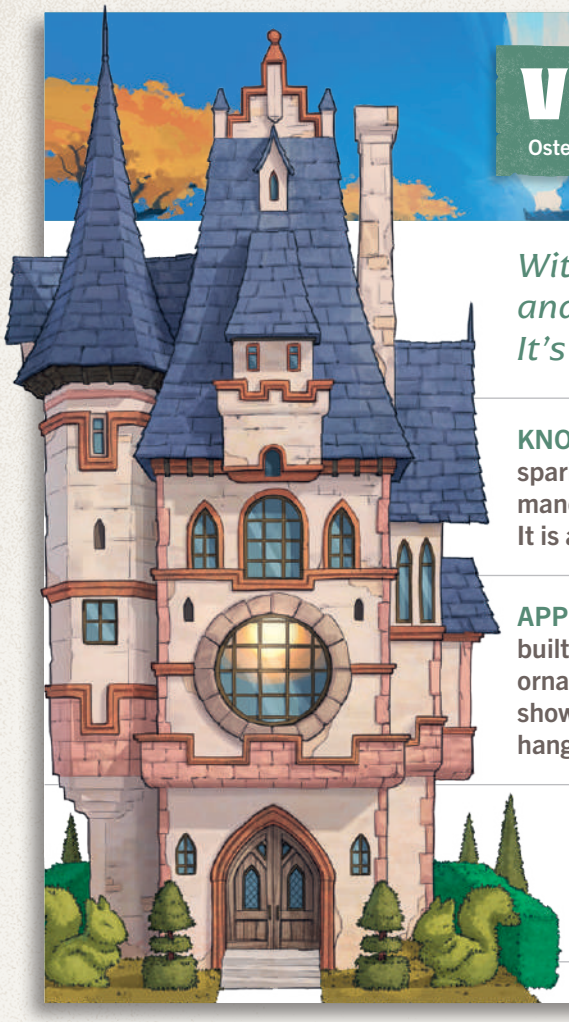

Villa Azure

Ostentatious manor house.

With its bright-blue crenellated roof, gilded windows and sculpted hedges, the manor radiates splendour. It's a noble's dream, and demands admiration.

KNOWN FOR Villa Azure was built with remarkable speed, its wealthy owner sparing no expense to hasten construction. Now complete, the towering manor dwarfs its neighbours and has become a landmark in its own right. It is a symbol of the ambition, extravagance and power that money can buy.

APPEARANCE The elegant manor is built from stone with castle-inspired ornamentations. A round window shows off an elaborate chandelier hanging in the double-height foyer.

LAYOUT The villa has a dining room, gallery, study, games room, primary suite, and four double guest bedrooms. It is surrounded by neatly manicured hedges.

LOOT An oil portrait in the study swings back to reveal a hidden safe where residents store their platinum and enchanted items.

SECRET Villa Azure's builders cut corners so that they could pocket more profit. The house is beautiful, but not structurally sound.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • URBAN • ESTATE

Wraithmoor Estate

Supposedly haunted house.

KNOWN FOR A string of misfortunes caused the owners of this home to abandon it. It has since fallen into disrepair, encouraging more speculation that the house is haunted.

APPEARANCE Shingles fall from the roof and crash down onto the overgrown, weed-infested lawn. Boards cover the windows, but an eerie light sometimes flickers within.

SECRET A local band of smugglers is using Wraithmoor Estate as a base of operations. They are stoking the rumours of the home being haunted to keep prying guards at bay.

BUILDING • LARGE • RURAL • ESTATE

The Telling Tent

Storyteller's yurt.

KNOWN FOR The Telling Tent offers a warm sleeping space and gathering spot for storytellers. When needed, it can be dismantled, packed onto carts and relocated.

APPEARANCE Wooden support beams are covered with treated furs that keep the yurt insulated and cosy. The inner walls are draped with embroidered tapestries and silks.

SECRET The tapestries appear purely decorative at first glance. On closer inspection, viewers could find hidden histories of the realm, subtly woven by storytellers of old.

BUILDING • LARGE • RURAL • HALL

Paintpot Place

Colourful house of art.

KNOWN FOR Paintpot Place is home to a family of eccentric artists. Known for its ever-changing rainbow exterior, the building is caked with bold paint and garish designs that reflect its residents' imaginations.

APPEARANCE The outside is covered in overlapping animal murals, cityscapes and patterns. Indoors, floral wallpaper peeks between canvases, and the floors are covered in rugs splattered with accidental spills.

LAYOUT The ground floor has a mixing room with vats of pigment and stained sinks. Upstairs, three bedrooms overflow with supplies. At the top, the studio has a wide window offering a panoramic view of the city skyline.

SECRET Although the house attracts artists and tourists, the city council prohibits unlicensed exterior repainting. The residents repaint under cover of night to avoid fines, a tradition they call the "Moonlight Makeover".

BUILDING • SMALL • URBAN • HOUSE

A home's design and decorations can reveal its owner's social class, profession and personality.

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Selkie Point

Lighthouse battered by the elements.

KNOWN FOR This stark lighthouse stands at the very edge of a sheer cliff face. It is isolated and inaccessible for all but two weeks a year, when the storms and floods briefly calm.

APPEARANCE Wind and waves thrash relentlessly against the lighthouse walls, and rain lashes down upon its glass lantern. The lighthouse keeper lives in an austere bedroom.

SECRET A lighthouse keeper must keep the lantern lit to honour a pact with a sea djinni. The deal has kept the nearby village safe from storms for decades.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • ISOLATED • TOWER

Sprucefold Cottage

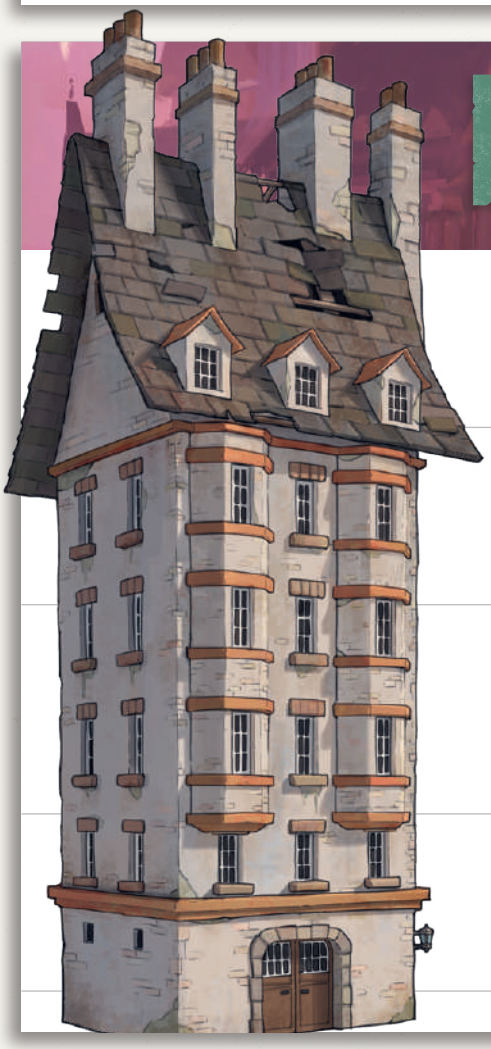
Self-sufficient rural house.

KNOWN FOR This cottage is completely self-sufficient. As well as an abundant vegetable garden, there is a fishing pond, millstone, fruit trees and a spring for freshwater.

APPEARANCE Sprucefold Cottage is made of wood with a turf-covered roof. Matching outbuildings are filled with cured fish, jars of honey and other homesteading supplies.

SECRET A trellis behind the cottage supports runner, broad, green and lima beans — and magic beans. Planting these magic beans could result in all kinds of wild, chaotic effects.

BUILDING • SMALL • RURAL • HOUSE



Crestwood Court

Shabby apartment houses.

From a distance, the windowsills and tall chimney pots appear pristine. But close up, flaky paint and grimy glass reveal years of neglect and wear.

KNOWN FOR Crestwood Court houses those without much coin to spare. Though it lacks space, cleanliness and basic amenities, Crestwood's bargain rents and town-centre location draw in desperate tenants. Residents must put up with cramped apartments that are stained with mould and damp.

APPEARANCE Heavy doors lead into a dark lobby with faded carpet. Ominous, damp stains creep down the walls from the communal bathrooms above, which are riddled with bugs.

LAYOUT Thin walls separate single-room homes. Each has space for a small bed, a table and a stool. A central staircase gives access to all floors, and to a basement furnace.

LOOT The manager's office holds a locked box full of rent money. The attic stores repossessed trinkets confiscated from evicted tenants.

SECRET The mayor bribes guards to release rats into Crestwood. They hope vermin will force its closure, and allow a casino to take its place.

BUILDING • LARGE • URBAN • HOUSE

Journey's End

Retired hero's house.

KNOWN FOR An adventurer built this rustic home as a place to enjoy their well-deserved retirement. Armchairs and a stone hearth make it a cosy place to reminisce with old allies.

APPEARANCE The wooden cabin is large and welcoming, with a pantry stocked with homemade chutneys. Every wall and surface is decorated with trophies of past victories.

SECRET The most magical treasure in Journey's End is also the most unassuming. It is a wooden Vorpal Sword with incredible power; the hero wishes for it to find a new home.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • RURAL • HOUSE

The Smartcart

Metallic caravan powered by steam.

KNOWN FOR This gleaming metallic caravan wheezes and splutters from town to town, transporting its owner and their eclectic collection of gadgets and gizmos.

APPEARANCE The caravan has a curved roof made from hammered brass sheeting. Its walls are punctuated by four valves that emit frequent spurts of steam and hot ash.

SECRET A hidden vent system can flood the area around the Smartcart with thick smoke. Triggering the vent system allows the caravan to vanish whenever its owner is in danger.

VEHICLE • SMALL • URBAN • HOUSE

Asking a player character what type of home they grew up in will help deepen their backstory.

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Rampart's Home for Children

Orphanage that looks like a castle.

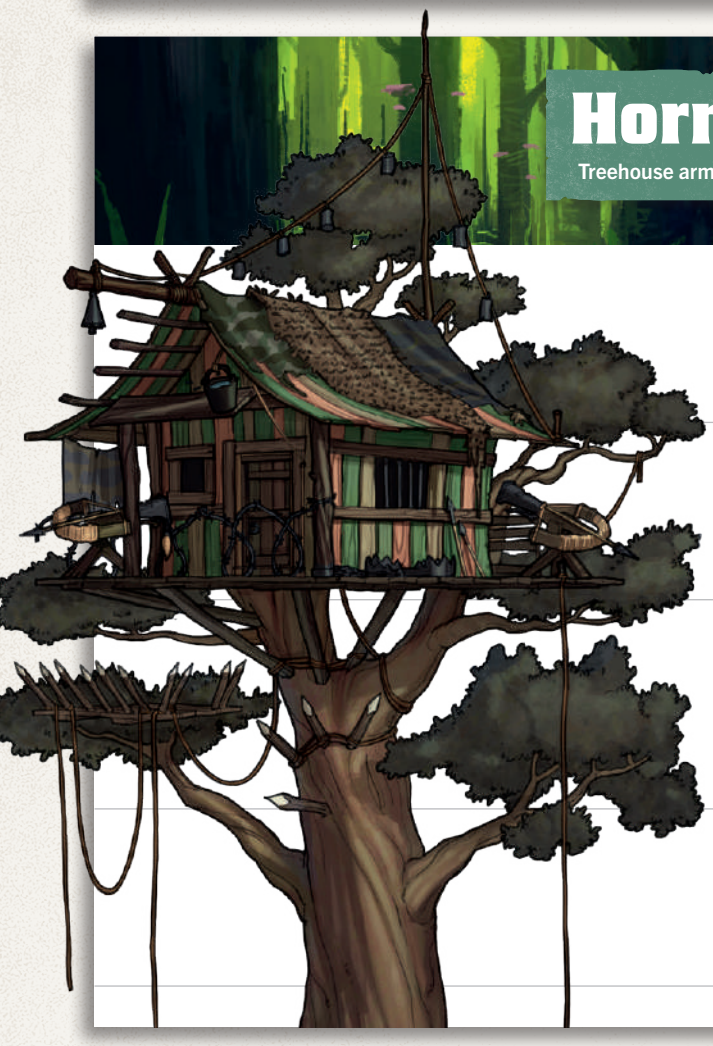
KNOWN FOR This charming structure resembles a fairy-tale castle, complete with turrets and flags, but it is built from scrap wood and child-sized. Every design choice was made with input from its creative young residents.

APPEARANCE The multicoloured walls of Rampart's have been painted with youthful enthusiasm, rather than finesse. Handmade flags fly from every turret, and the largest tower has a metal slide winding around it.

LAYOUT Every child has their own room in the castle, as do their guardians. There are also three playrooms, a dining hall, kitchen and library. A working drawbridge crosses a shallow moat and leads out to a large garden.

SECRET A red dress-up box was anonymously donated for one of the children's playrooms. Unknown to the caretakers of Rampart's, it contains real and valuable pieces of jewellery, including two lost royal tiaras.

BUILDING • LARGE • URBAN • ESTATE



Hornet's Lodge

Treehouse armed with traps.

A metallic click slices through the rustling leaves. You turn just as a crossbow bolt hisses past, striking a tree with a solid thud.

KNOWN FOR Hidden in foliage and bristling with defences, Hornet's Lodge is a fortress in disguise. Mounted bows guard key spots, rope snares lie in wait, and crates of live snakes hang above the doors, ready to drop on unwelcome guests.

APPEARANCE Draped in dried leaf nets and painted in dark greens and browns, the treehouse vanishes into the canopy of trees around it.

LAYOUT The only entrance is a rope ladder, dropped from within. One main room connects to smaller lookout platforms above the trees.

LOOT Hornet's Lodge holds weapons, a month's worth of dried food, and a gutter device that collects fresh rainwater.

SECRET A hidden signalling device alerts its mercenary owners whenever trespassers gain access to the Lodge.

BUILDING • SMALL • ISOLATED • HOUSE

Château Chapeau

House made from a giant hat.

KNOWN FOR This enormous top hat once belonged to a passing giant. Smaller humanoids claimed it and upgraded it into a cosy three-storey home unlike any other in the area.

APPEARANCE The purple hat house is made from dyed wyvern hides. It has a carved wooden door, square windows and delicate balconies. A garden surrounds the entire base.

SECRET The giant has been missing their prized hat for years. Now, having finished their business in a distant storm giant citadel, they're returning to reclaim it.

BUILDING • MID-SIZED • URBAN • HOUSE

More Homes

1. **SKY'S COTTAGE** Has a hot-air balloon tethered to its roof.
2. **WANDERLOST HUT** Remote cottage in wild moorlands.
3. **THE BOOK NOOK** Communal living space for scribes.
4. **GRIMSHAW MANOR** Infamous site of three violent murders.
5. **SUMMERFALL LODGE** Winter home of a wealthy family.
6. **THE RAMBLESHACK** Simple shack built from old junk.
7. **BASTIAN'S SANCTUARY** Home for reformed criminals.
8. **THE GEARS** Factory-owned apartment block for workers.
9. **SPECTRUM HOUSE** Stained glass windows cover all walls.
10. **THE HIDEYHOLE** Cramped underground burrow home.

Homes found in cities (pp. 94–99) will be different to those in villages (pp. 118–119).

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Mabel Marchworth

Town crier with an amplified voice.

KNOWN FOR Mabel's magically boosted voice echoes through the entire town. It allows her to bellow the latest news into every home, street and alleyway with ease.

APPEARANCE Clad in a scarlet robe with gold brocade, Mabel is a tall and imposing figure. She carries a scroll with the town's news, and a small crate for standing on.

SECRET Mabel's voice is permanently magnified for the duration of her term as town crier. She's desperate to share some recent town gossip, but knows everyone will hear her.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • ELF-HUMAN • OFFICIAL

Lord Cornellius Trent

Overbearing landlord.

KNOWN FOR Cornellius owns half the buildings in town and insists on collecting rent from his tenants in person. He is known for inviting himself in for dinner at the same time.

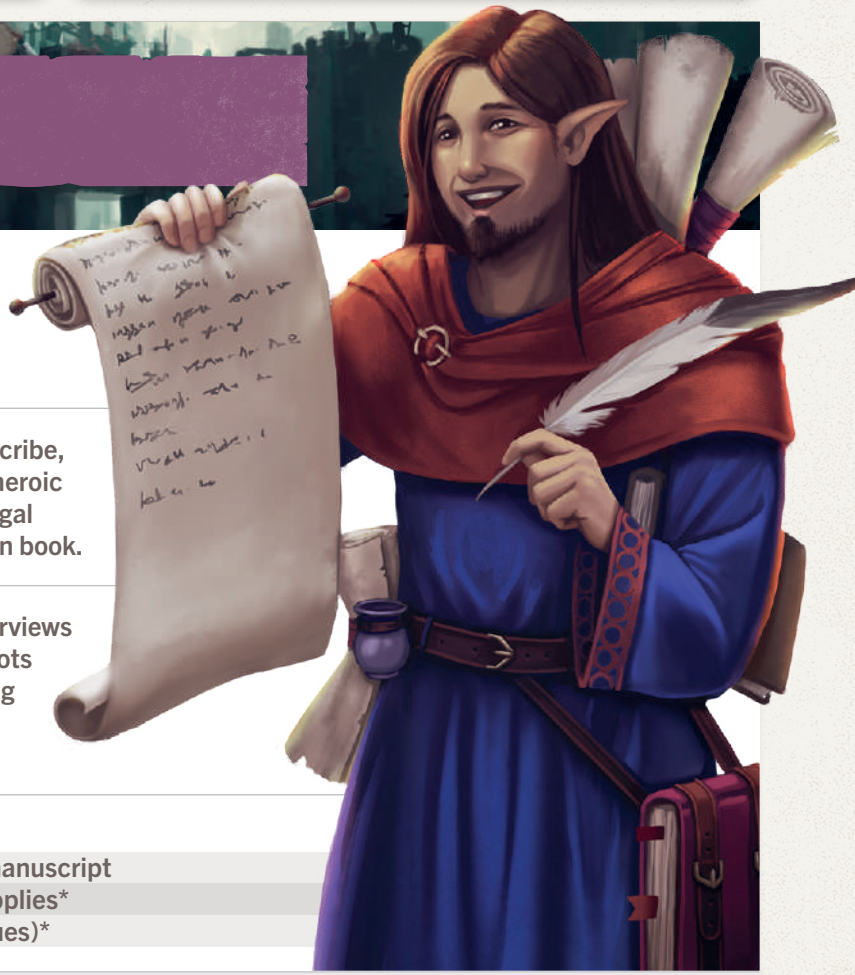
APPEARANCE Short and muscular, Cornellius wears a tight waistcoat over a shirt with rolled-up sleeves. He carries a blue ledger, and fusses if his shiny shoes get scuffed.

SECRET Cornellius is lonely and invested in property so that he'd have people to visit regularly. He drags out repairs for weeks on end to allow for more conversations with tenants.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • DWARF • NOBLE

Gerard Mignault

Scribe writing a book about heroes.



The young elf fumbles through his neat robes, searching for a quill that's clearly hidden behind his ear.

KNOWN FOR Gerard spent years apprenticed as a scribe, dreaming of crafting illustrated manuscripts about heroic quests. Instead, he mostly copied tax ledgers and legal treaties. Now freelancing, he's researching for his own book.

APPEARANCE Gerard has an endearing smile and kind eyes. With an inkpot on his belt and scrap parchment on his back, he's always ready to write.

GOAL Gerard interviews adventurers and jots down their exciting stories for future inspiration.

SECRET Gerard was expelled from the scribes' guild after his tutor discovered prank names in official documents.

LOOT

- First draft book manuscript
- Calligrapher's supplies*
- Spell scroll (tongues)*

SCRIBE
Small or Medium Humanoid

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10 (+0)	14 (+2)	12 (+1)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)

Armour Class: 13
Hit Points: 11 (2d8 + 2)
Speed: 30 ft
Initiative: +2

Skills: History +4, Investigation +4
Passive Perception: 10
Languages: Common plus one other language
Proficiency Bonus: +2

ABILITIES

Perfect Recall. The scribe can remember almost anything it has read or heard. It has advantage on checks to recall lore, decipher scripts or spot forgery.

ACTIONS

Book Slam. Melee Weapon Attack: +2 to hit, reach 5 ft, one target. Hit: 2 (1d4) bludgeoning damage.

Spellcasting. The scribe casts one of the following spells, using Intelligence as the spellcasting ability:

At Will: *Illusory Script*, *Light*, *Mage Hand*, *Message*.

Ink Splash (2/Day). One creature the scribe can see within 10 ft must succeed on a DC 12 Constitution saving throw or become Blinded for 1 minute. The target repeats the save at the end of each of its turns, ending the effect on a success.

CHALLENGE RATING 1/4

You could alternatively use the stats of a Spy CR 1, Mage Apprentice CR 2 or Noble Prodigy CR 10.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • ELF • SAGE

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Orey Jakobs

Pilgrim wandering the world.

KNOWN FOR Three years ago, Orey packed a small bag with bread and cheese, left home and began walking. He didn't know where or why, only that some divine force urged him ever onwards.

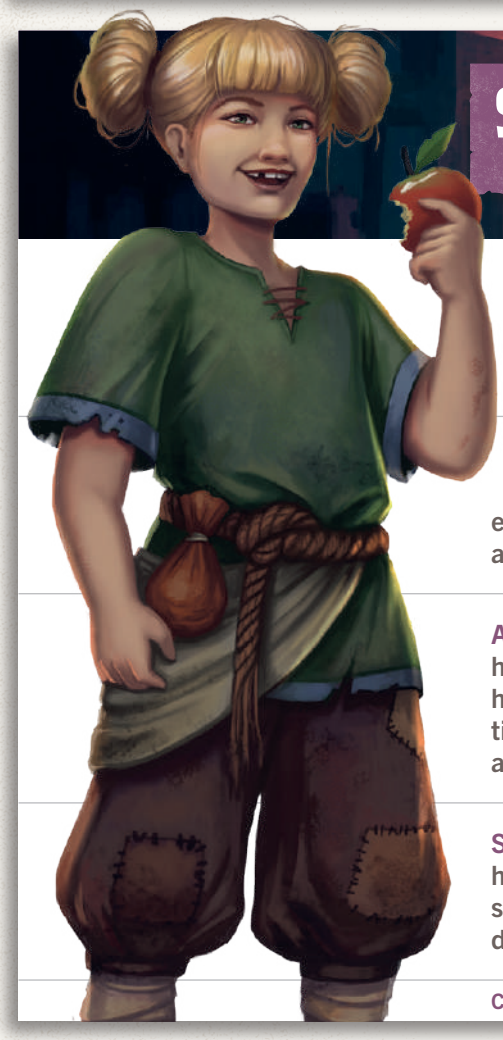
APPEARANCE A long, red beard makes Orey look older than he is. His clothes are worn but kept clean with regular dunks in ponds and pools. He picks flowers from local gardens and weaves them into his hair.

GOAL Orey has faith that his journey's purpose will reveal itself when the time is right. He wanders the world with little concern of where he is on a map, knowing he is being led by his ever-watchful deity.

SECRET Life on the road can be lonely for Orey, but he has noticed a small robin following him at a distance. The bird is a disguised celestial guardian, who has been guiding Orey towards a temple ruin he must rebuild.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • ORC • WORSHIPPER

PRIEST ACOLYTE / PRIEST



Svanhild Clearwater

Inquisitive child.

The child looks at you, eyes sparkling with interest. Her head tilts quizzically to one side, and her gapped-tooth grin opens to ask yet another question.

KNOWN FOR Little Svanhild may only be seven years old, but she seems wise beyond her years. She strikes up bright conversation with anyone and everyone who passes her by. Her relentlessly inquisitive nature is endearing at first, but can start to feel overwhelming and a little intrusive.

APPEARANCE Svanhild is small for her age and has just started to lose her baby teeth. Her blonde hair is tied in two messy bunches to keep it away from her cheerful face.

GOAL Already cleverer than both her parents, Svanhild is desperate to learn about the world from others. Her favourite word is "why", and she uses it repeatedly.

SECRET Svanhild's parents are highway robbers. She acts as their scout, reporting back on every last detail about the people she meets.

LOOT

- Trinket pouch
- Tin cans connected with string
- Thieves' tools*

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • HUMAN • OUTLAW

COMMONER / SPY

Matti Hewell

Shepherd with a suspicious sheepdog.

KNOWN FOR An isolated shepherd of few words, Matti only leaves his fields to take his sheep to market. He is always accompanied by his prowling dog, Brock, who he credits for the safety of his flock.

APPEARANCE Matti's clothing is simple, but his twisted ebony shepherd's crook is much more elaborate. Brock is a hefty black-and-white sheepdog who wears a thick black collar, set with several glowing rubies.

GOAL Matti prides himself in never loosing a sheep in his care, and would stop at nothing to maintain his reliable reputation. That ambition has previously driven him to sabotage other shepherds in the area.

SECRET Brock is a hellhound. Matti sold his soul to summon the fiend, and the crook needed to control it. Brock scares predators away from Matti's flock, before feasting on sheep belonging to other herders.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • GNOME • LABOURER

CULTIST FANATIC / BARBED DEVIL

If you're running a campaign with just one or two player characters, NPCs can become helpful sidekicks.

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Ranulf Chandler

Undercover investigator.

KNOWN FOR Working as a window cleaner allows this undercover town guard to eavesdrop and observe without suspicion. The cleaner the windows, the easier it is to snoop.

APPEARANCE As part of his disguise, Ranulf wears white overalls and pushes a trolley holding ladders, buckets and rags. He also wears round glasses he doesn't need.

SECRET Having worked as a guard all his adult life, Ranulf enjoys the simplicity and safety of window cleaning. He is considering a career change when his investigation is done.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • HALFLING • GUARD

Ser Siron Crokpoth

Bodyguard for hire.

KNOWN FOR This fearsome knight can be hired at the town gates as muscle for dangerous journeys. A true mercenary, his loyalty goes to the highest bidder.

APPEARANCE Siron's face and body are deeply battle-scarred, as is his armour. He wears a specially cut helmet that accommodates his tall, pink mohawk.

SECRET Despite his gruff manner, Siron loves campfire songs that remind him of his homeland. They stir memories of his distant family, and sometimes bring him to tears.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • DRAGONBORN • COMBATANT

Carlotta Delines

Reclusive weaver.

KNOWN FOR Normally involved in village matters, weaver Carlotta has recently become reserved and distracted. She is often seen wandering the marshes alone.

APPEARANCE Carlotta's usual energy has drained away, leaving her pale and trembling. Sweat gathers at her temples, and she keeps her eyes fixed on the floor.

GOAL Carlotta had been busy planning her upcoming wedding, but she's now avoiding her betrothed. Instead, she has become obsessed by the marshes.

SECRET When gathering reeds, Carlotta was infected by a tiny tadpole aberration. The creature is growing, and slowly taking control of her body and mind.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • ELF • LABOURER

NOBLE / NOTHIC

Trin Ushrall

Martial arts teacher.

KNOWN FOR Trin was a monk for an order sworn to defend the vulnerable. Now, they teach locals self-defence tips and manoeuvres, based on the training they were once given.

APPEARANCE Clad in robes of plain brown cotton, Trin's lithe body moves with speed and strength through their exercises. A thick plait swings behind them as they go.

SECRET Trin's monastery was infiltrated by a warlord who convinced the monks to fight in battle. Trin left the order when they realised that they were no longer helping others.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • TIEFLING • COMBATANT

Eaves Steadfast

Construction site manager.

KNOWN FOR Eaves is a creative and practical problem solver. She manages construction sites for the land's most prestigious homes, making her highly sought after.

APPEARANCE On site, Eaves is never without her bright-blue wooden helmet and steel-toed boots. She wears a thick canvas work jacket, and a heavy tool belt around her waist.

SECRET Eaves has a faded tattoo identifying her as a member of an illegal lumber guild. After being caught, she fled, changed her name and retrained in construction.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • ORC-HUMAN • LABOURER

Nanny Astrid Perrins

Kind-hearted childminder.

KNOWN FOR Beloved Nanny Astrid tells the children she looks after there is space in her huge heart for them all. She looks after children of all ages and species, and pushes them along in one giant-sized pram.

APPEARANCE Astrid has to stoop to enter most dwellings; as a goliath, she is much taller than the average humanoid. An apron covers her flowing skirts, and her pockets are full of toys, snacks and muslins.

GOAL Astrid is always looking for something new to entertain the little ones. She takes them to the woods to build dens, to her chicken coop to collect eggs, or reads books to them on rainy days. She is happy if they are.

SECRET While Astrid cherishes the time she spends with the young children, she relishes the quiet and solitude of her evenings. She is currently doing a night course in basic wizarding studies.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • GOLIATH • LABOURER

COMMONER / MAGE

Small details like hobbies, fears or superstitions will make your locals memorable.

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Jessa Tamdan

Friendly gaming enthusiast.

KNOWN FOR Jessa runs game nights at the venues around town. She has a huge collection of games and loves bringing locals and newcomers together to share in the fun.

APPEARANCE This cheery halfling uses a wheelbarrow to cart around a chest of games that's as tall as she is. She has auburn pigtails, striking turquoise eyes and swinging earrings.

SECRET Jessa charges one copper piece to join the game night. It's her own little joke; no one knows she is a copper dragon in humanoid form, and has a fortune back in her lair.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • DRAGON • ENTERTAINER

Caleb Gulcave

Night forager.

KNOWN FOR Caleb knows the local plants and fungi better than anybody in the area. He goes out every night after work to forage in woods and meadows by the light of the moon.

APPEARANCE Cuts and grazes cover Caleb's arms and shins, given to him by brambles and thorny berry bushes. His large, blue eyes tend to look surprised or confused.

SECRET Caleb often ignores town notices, so hasn't heard about an urgent curfew. Townsfolk have been asked to stay inside during this full moon after recent werebear attacks.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • DWARF • NATURALIST

Rachelle Dubuisson

Door-to-door perfume distributor.

KNOWN FOR Rachelle is notorious for exploiting hopeful entrepreneurs. She pushes overpriced perfume crates, and convinces people to start businesses that rarely succeed.

APPEARANCE Rachelle is a slight blonde elf who wears loud colours and stacks of beads and bangles. She carries a crocodile-skin case full of jangling perfume bottles.

SECRET The perfumes are supplied by a fiend who is looking to harvest souls through a cunning pyramid scheme. Each perfume enchants the victim it is sprayed on.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • ELF • MERCHANT

Vendel Winkworth

Prankster quest-giver.

KNOWN FOR Vendel is a mischief maker; he pins quests to the noticeboard that are either very lucrative or wild goose chases. A quest once involved actually chasing geese.

APPEARANCE Always perched beside the road, Vendel is a slight man with a mane of brown hair spilling from beneath his straw hat. He wears a scruffy linen tunic and a gold chain.

SECRET Vendel is a fey aristocrat, and his outrageous quests are his version of diplomacy. If travellers complete the tasks he sets, he may invite them to the Fey Realm.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • FEY • NOBLE

Tawn Whitecrest

Thatcher and roofer.

KNOWN FOR If a house's thatched roof needs mending, or a tall spire requires a new weathervane, Tawn can fly up and fix it instantly — no ladder needed.

APPEARANCE Tawn has soft brown and white feathers and a shy expression. Her leather tool pouch is always strapped securely to her back for quick repairs.

GOAL Tawn dreams of earning enough to build a large thatched treehouse. It would comfortably house her siblings, all their children and her together.

SECRET She hides magical tools she stole from a rival thatcher in a small twig nest near her house.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • ANIMALFOLK • LABOURER

COMMONER / SCOUT

Glaucus Heraklion

Violent debt collector.

KNOWN FOR Glaucus is a muscular, snorting minotaur dressed in a council tabard. He is the city's most feared tax collector. If payment is overdue, he simply lowers his horns and breaks down the doors of cowering residents.

APPEARANCE Glaucus towers over trembling debtors, his brown hide rippling with muscle and sinew. Thick veins bulge along his neck, and his curved razor-sharp horns stretch high above his chiselled face.

GOAL Years of thankless work have left Glaucus bitter. He no longer sees citizens, only problems to remove. Glaucus has started punishing people pre-emptively, despite not having sign-off from his superiors.

SECRET After making unwise investments, Glaucus is drowning in debt himself. Frustrated in himself, he takes out his anger on the petty criminals and other debtors who cross his path or get in his way.

CHARACTER • HOSTILE • ANIMALFOLK • GUARD

BERSERKER / MINOTAUR

Every NPC is the main character of their own story, with their own goals and motivations.

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Zentri Elidar

Sorcerer struggling with new powers.

As you take a step forwards, a gust whips around the young man and pushes his hair back. You can't tell if he's shivering from the cold, or out of pure fear.

KNOWN FOR A few weeks ago, Zentri unexpectedly manifested incredible elemental magic in the middle of a busy market. He couldn't control the icy force that rushed out of him, and accidentally destroyed half the stalls. He has been banished from town until he can safely control his new powers.

APPEARANCE Zentri wears a baggy shirt and vest; he tugs his green cap low to hide his face and messy hair. When he uses magic, crackling flashes of power swirl and dance around him.

GOAL Zentri is desperate to regain the trust of his community, so he can return home. He wants to find a way to control his power and use it as an asset for his people.

SECRET A mage has offered to tutor Zentri in how to control his magic. The mage is a lich, and wants to siphon Zentri's power for themselves.

LOOT

- Woolly mittens
- Postcard from his mother
- Spell scroll (cone of cold)*

BURGEONING SORCERER
Small or Medium Humanoid

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10 (+0)	12 (+1)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)	14 (+2)	18 (+4)

Armour Class: 12
Hit Points: 22 (5d8)
Speed: 30 ft
Initiative: +1

Skills: Persuasion +6, Intimidation +6
Passive Perception: 12
Languages: Common plus one other language
Proficiency Bonus: +2

ABILITIES

Magic Resistance. The sorcerer has advantage on saving throws against spells and other magical effects.

Bioluminescence. Whenever the sorcerer chooses to, it can shed bright light in a 10 ft radius and dim light for an additional 10 ft.

ACTIONS

Energy Release. Melee or Ranged Weapon Attack: +6 to hit, reach 5 ft or range 120 ft, one target. Hit: 6 (1d4 + 4) fire damage plus 6 (1d4 + 4) cold damage and roll 1d6 to trigger one of these effects:

1. The sorcerer radiates bright light in a 30 ft radius and is Blinded until the end of its next turn.

2–3. The sorcerer teleports up to 60 ft to an unoccupied space it can see.

4–5. The sorcerer regains 5 HP.

6. The sorcerer casts *Magic Missile*, and is transported to the Astral Plane until the end of its next turn. It returns to the space it previously occupied or the nearest unoccupied space if that space is occupied.

Spellcasting. The sorcerer casts one of the following spells, using Charisma as the spellcasting ability (spell save DC 14, +6 to hit with spell attacks):

At Will: *Mage Hand, Message, Prestidigitation*

1/Day Each: *Burning Hands, Mirror Image, Shield*

CHALLENGE RATING 1

You could alternatively use the stats of a Priest Acolyte CR 1/4, Mage Apprentice CR 2 or Mage CR 6.

CHARACTER • NEUTRAL • ELF-HUMAN • SPELLCASTER

Fergus Aisling

Bored lumberjack with an injury.

KNOWN FOR Fergus is currently nursing a broken leg after rescuing a deer from a fast-flowing river. As a lumberjack, he's used to being active, and is growing bored of resting.

APPEARANCE Fergus sits with his bandaged leg propped up, his grey overalls cut at the knee. Lifting his wide-brimmed hat, he greets passers-by and warmly invites them to chat.

SECRET When he was rescuing the deer, Fergus saw a terrifying river spirit, and the shock made him slip. He's convinced himself that his mind was just playing tricks.

CHARACTER • FRIENDLY • DRAGONBORN • LABOURER

More Locals

1. MERTON MURRAY Baker who makes delicious fruit tarts.
2. ORA GORLAC Architect designing a new temple building.
3. ENRYA HARPLAND Suspects their new lodger is a vampire.
4. GISP YARA Lamplighter with faint draconic heritage.
5. NIKOLA SIGURDSSON Hand-paints signs and adverts.
6. PIPER NENNIS Mill owner who employs most of the town.
7. LIS PENGEL Goatherd and respected justice of the peace.
8. RYE OINSLIP Warden who tickets badly parked carts.
9. LAVAH KOLLINS Schoolteacher with only six students.
10. TEENA O'COL Gardener who tends public and private land.

Villagers will have their own opinions on the events of the campaign so far.

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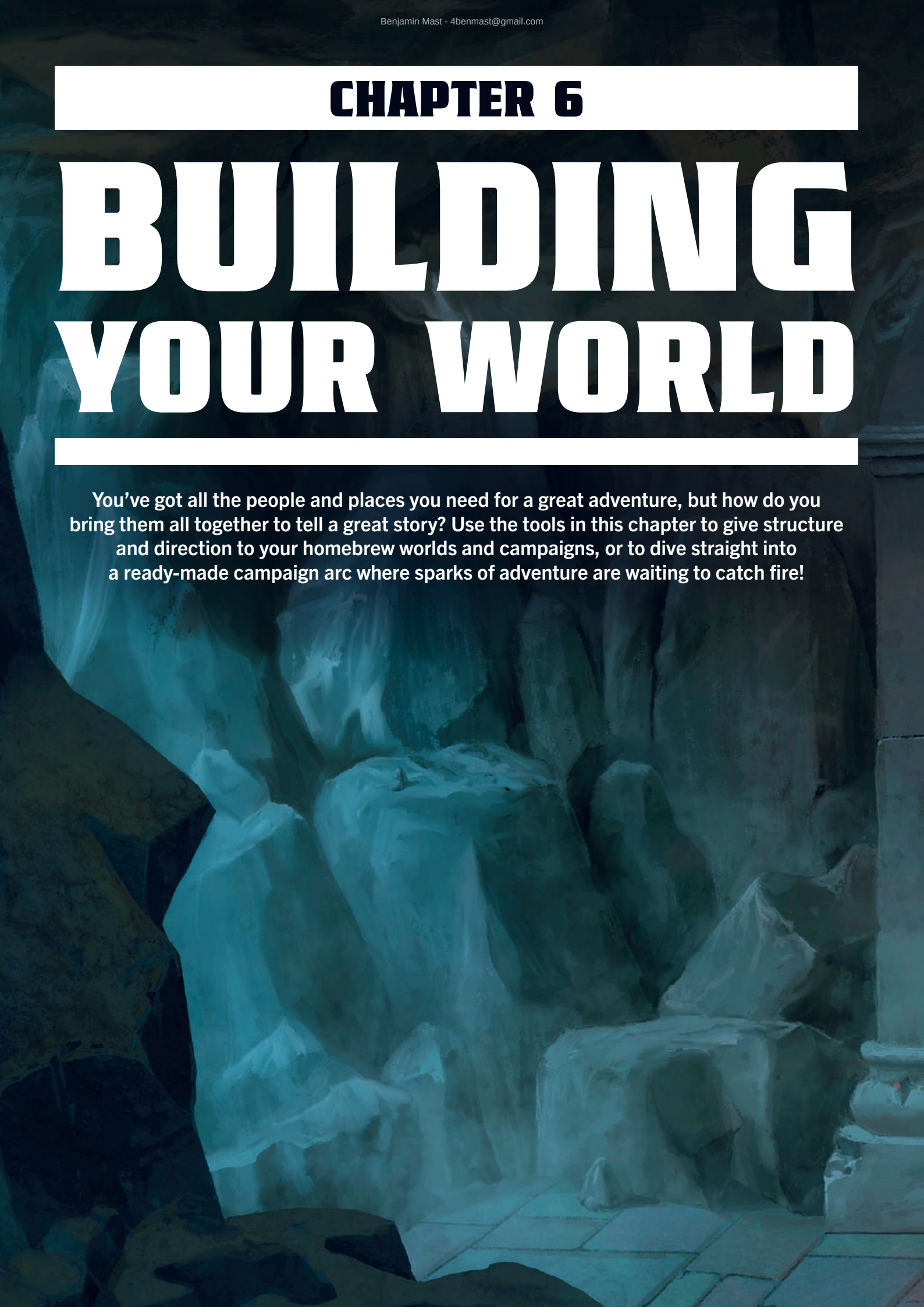
CHAPTER 6

BUILDING YOUR WORLD

You've got all the people and places you need for a great adventure, but how do you bring them all together to tell a great story? Use the tools in this chapter to give structure and direction to your homebrew worlds and campaigns, or to dive straight into a ready-made campaign arc where sparks of adventure are waiting to catch fire!



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Homebrew World Builder

Creating your own campaign setting is easy with *No Place Like Homebrew*. Start by reading the example World Builder below. Then, use the printable worksheet on the next page to build your own world, flicking through the book to find ideas to fill in the gaps!

World Basics

WORLD NAME Seleth (p.7) MAGIC LEVEL: ☑ Abundant ☐ Common ☐ Rare

BRIEF OVERVIEW Highly magical world shrouded in perpetual state of dusk and twilight.

WORLD AGE: ☐ New ☑ Ancient ☐ Eternal SHAPED BY: ☐ Gods ☑ Magic ☐ Mortals ☐ Nature

Divine Pantheon

KEY DEITIES Stellunde - Moon and Stars, The Veiled Knave - Dreams (p.13-14)

GODS ARE: ☐ Present ☑ Distant ☐ Dead

INFLUENCE: ☐ Daily ☑ Occasional ☐ Rare

Planes

MAJOR PLANES Material Plane, Malstora and the Lostlands (p.20)

RIFTS ARE: ☐ Abundant ☑ Common ☐ Rare

PLANAR TRAVEL IS: ☐ Easy ☐ Difficult ☑ Deadly

Major Nation

THE NATION OF Dolowroth (p.30) IS RUN BY Emperor Lextrice Grasphall (p.33)

IT IS KNOWN FOR Natural magic is being corrupted by its ruler. Cut off from the outside world.

ITS NEIGHBOUR Bansheeran IS KNOWN FOR Rigid society and firm control of magic.

GLOBAL RELATIONS: ☐ Peaceful ☐ Cordial Borders ☐ Uneasy Truces ☑ Tense Hostilities ☐ All-out War

Starting Environment

AREA NAME The Dreadwood (p.48) SIGNIFICANCE A refuge for the enemies of the ruler.

TERRAIN TYPE: ☐ Arctic ☐ Arid ☐ Coastal ☑ Forested ☐ Mountainous ☐ Other

NOTABLE SITES Fleetword Fort - the crumbling remains of a former civilisation. (p.200)

COMMON CREATURES Blight Striders (p.54) and other corrupted plants. Packs of wolves.

INFLUENTIAL FACTION The Foal Union - Keepers of local history and knowledge. (p.55)

TRAVEL CONDITIONS: ☐ Paved Roads ☐ Dirt Tracks ☐ Rough Terrain ☑ Perilous Routes ☐ Impassable

THE NEARBY AREA Lake Moondrop (p.57) IS KNOWN FOR Source of increasingly scarce healing magic.

Starting Settlement

SETTLEMENT NAME Gossamer Spindle (p.106) SETTLEMENT TYPE: ☐ City ☐ Town ☑ Village

MAIN DEMOGRAPHIC Drow Elves MAIN INDUSTRY Weaving and silk production

LEADERSHIP Cybele Kallio (p.103) LOCAL THREAT Creeping magical corruption

THE TAVERN The Verdant Vine (p.132) IS OWNED BY Antimon Harpweather (p.139)

POPULAR SPOT NEARBY Lake Moondrop (p.57), people visit to fill vials of its healing water.

DANGEROUS AREA NEARBY Abandoned neighbouring villages like Hollowfall (p.189)

FIRST SESSION QUEST HOOK Village supplies are running low; the party must collect basic healing herbs.

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NO PLACE LIKE HOMEBREW WORLD BUILDER WORKSHEET

World Basics

NPLH PAGES 8–11

WORLD NAME _____ MAGIC LEVEL: ☐ Abundant ☐ Common ☐ Rare

BRIEF OVERVIEW _____

WORLD AGE: ☐ New ☐ Ancient ☐ Eternal SHAPED BY: ☐ Gods ☐ Magic ☐ Mortals ☐ Nature

Divine Pantheon

NPLH PAGES 12–19

DEITY NAMES _____

GODS ARE: ☐ Present ☐ Distant ☐ Dead

INFLUENCE: ☐ Daily ☐ Occasional ☐ Rare

Planes

NPLH PAGES 20–25

MAJOR PLANES _____

RIFTS ARE: ☐ Abundant ☐ Common ☐ Rare

PLANAR TRAVEL IS: ☐ Easy ☐ Difficult ☐ Deadly

Major Nation

NPLH PAGES 26–39

THE NATION OF _____ IS RUN BY _____

IT IS KNOWN FOR _____

ITS NEIGHBOUR _____ IS KNOWN FOR _____

GLOBAL RELATIONS: ☐ Peaceful ☐ Cordial Borders ☐ Uneasy Truces ☐ Tense Hostilities ☐ All-out War

Starting Environment

NPLH PAGES 46–91

AREA NAME _____ SIGNIFICANCE _____

TERRAIN TYPE: ☐ Arctic ☐ Arid ☐ Coastal ☐ Forested ☐ Mountainous ☐ Other _____

NOTABLE SITES _____

COMMON CREATURES _____ INFLUENTIAL FACTION _____

TRAVEL CONDITIONS: ☐ Paved Roads ☐ Dirt Tracks ☐ Rough Terrain ☐ Perilous Routes ☐ Impassable

THE NEARBY AREA _____ IS KNOWN FOR _____

Starting Settlement

NPLH PAGES 92–117 & 148–235

SETTLEMENT NAME _____ SETTLEMENT TYPE: ☐ City ☐ Town ☐ Village

MAIN DEMOGRAPHIC _____ MAIN INDUSTRY _____

LEADERSHIP _____ LOCAL THREAT _____

THE TAVERN _____ IS OWNED BY _____

POPULAR SPOT NEARBY _____

DANGEROUS AREA NEARBY _____

FIRST SESSION QUEST HOOK _____

Scan the QR code for a free printable version on our website, and start creating your own world today

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Campaign Primers

A homebrew world comes to life when you start playing in it. If you want to jump straight into a game, these three starter campaign settings have both the worldbuilding background and plot ideas you'll need to get going. As the adventure progresses, add more characters and locations from the book and make it your own.

Glossary of Terms

TONE, INSPIRATION and PITCH Get a brief summary of the campaign vibe and its influences in the top banner of each primer.

CAMPAIGN OVERVIEW Dig into the background of the setting, and what lies in store for the party if they embark on their quest. The people, places and factions marked in blue are all entries you can find in the book.

KEY LOCATIONS The settlements and buildings in this section include starting spots for the adventure, and memorable sites for big boss battles.

IMPORTANT CHARACTERS Find quest givers, helpful allies and notable enemies in this section of the primer. These characters will be key to your party successfully achieving their goals.

LORE AND MECHANICS Add specific play mechanics to your game that support the tone of your adventure. These aspects will enhance your worldbuilding and make the setting feel even more real for players.

INCITING INCIDENT How does the story begin, and how are the party drawn into the action?

SESSION ZERO QUESTIONS Ask your players these questions as they build their characters, to get them thinking about their place in the world.

Choose your campaign setting based on genre, or the play style that interests you most:

Pirate Campaign
KING OF THE BLUE

A nautical setting for a classic fantasy quest.

Sail uncharted waters, battle fearsome foes and uncover hidden treasures in a world of danger and piracy.

Perfect for players who enjoy combat, adventure, action and monster hunting. Ideal for short-to-medium length campaigns.

Horror Campaign
BLOOD AND SMOG

A grim, industrial world where intrigue festers in the shadows.

Unravel conspiracies, forge uneasy alliances and survive the toxic city streets in a mission with far-reaching consequences.

Perfect for players who enjoy role-play, investigation and careful planning. Suited for slow-burn, medium-length campaigns.

Fey Campaign
THE LONG ROAD SOUTH

A whimsical, magical realm of endless horizons and wonders.

Journey through strange lands, meet eccentric characters and uncover the secrets of the Fey Realm at your own pace.

Perfect for players who enjoy sandbox exploration. Ideal for open-ended, long-lasting campaigns filled with discovery.

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Pirate Campaign: King of the Blue

TONE Epic and daring, with high risks and high rewards. **INSPIRATION** *One Piece* meets *Monster Hunter*.

PITCH Gather your crew, sail treacherous waters, battle sea monsters and race to claim the lost treasure of the King of the Blue. Fortune, fame and possibly doom await in the murky depths of the Shadowdeep Ocean. Sailors beware!

Campaign Overview

This is a campaign set in and around a port city, full of naval combat and swashbuckling sword fights. Players will forge their own pirate crew, build alliances and sail the high seas. But will their daring crew sink or swim?

Welcome to **Osadra**, a world of drifting island nations and perilous seas. In its southern hemisphere floats **Theotalis** – an island rich with silver deposits and supposedly governed by the bureaucratic **Chamber of One Voice**. While its noble houses revel in riches, political gridlock has made Theotalis a haven for smugglers and sea scoundrels. The **Shadowdeep Ocean**, a place of gargantuan sea monsters and sunken ships, surrounds the island and hides both danger and opportunity.

Right now, every pirate in Theotalis is searching for a single prize: the wreck of the **Sanguine**. The flagship galleon was owned by **Skyro Fawkes**, also known as the "King of the Blue". The boat was destroyed by a surfacing mega-kraken somewhere off the Theotalis coast, and its wreck is rumoured to be laden with treasure. The party face stormy weather, vicious beasts and rival pirate crews in a race to be first to find the ship, and be crowned the new rulers of the waves.

Lore and Mechanics

- **CREW REPUTATION** As the party gather a crew and vessel, they will start to gain a reputation. Track the party's favour and infamy among pirates and the navy as they complete quests and sink ships.
- **SHIP UPGRADES** Treat the party's ship like a mobile bastion. They can invest silver and components salvaged at sea into upgrades when they next dock.
- **OCEAN CONDITIONS** Design random tables for weather, pirate and monster encounters – then get the party to roll every time they set sail. Monsters should be relatively rare, but have a huge impact.
- **MONSTER BATTLES** To make monster battles more epic, you could distribute the creature's health across its body parts, give it hidden weak spots, or allow the party to climb onto the beast to deal extra damage.
- **COINS MEAN MORE** Silver is Theotalis' currency, stamped with the naval seal; but pirates often use electrum knock-offs. Giving the wrong coin to the wrong person could land the party in serious trouble.

Key Locations

- **FIVEMARCH** The major port city of Theotalis. All silver mined on the island passes through its docks, most of it in the hands of cut-throat smuggling gangs.
- **JUNIOR MARINA PAVILION** This recruitment centre offers novice sailors opportunities to find work. The pay is often low, to reflect their lack of experience.
- **THE SANGUINE** This destroyed galleon lies at the bottom of the ocean, about 40 miles west of Fivemarch. A giant squid has made the boat its lair.

Important Characters

- **BRONVORK GRUM** This smuggler boss is the dock's main authority figure, with the power to crush the party.
- **CAPTAIN NICHELLE VANDVEN** An intimidating Theotalis naval officer who tracks and hunts pirates.
- **SKYRO FAWKES** This notorious captain and his crew all sunk with the Sanguine. The cursed vessel is still keeping them alive at the bottom of the ocean.

Inciting Incident

The party meet at the Junior Marina Pavilion in search of work. A simple job transferring cargo off a ship soon goes awry, and they find themselves in the debt of smuggling boss Bronvork Grum. To clear their debts, he challenges them to bring him Skyro Fawkes' pirate crown from the wreck of the Sanguine. He assumes they'll fail, and the monsters and pirate crews of the Shadowdeep Ocean will serve as their actual punishment.

Session Zero Questions

- Are you new to Fivemarch, or lived here all your life?
- Why did you seek out work at the Junior Marina Pavilion? What appeals to you about life at sea?
- Have you ever sailed across the Shadowdeep Ocean?
- Do you have links to the Theotalis navy, any prolific pirate crews, or another guild altogether?
- What would you do with a hoard of treasure?

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Horror Campaign: Blood and Smog

TONE Rebel uprising against oppressive powers. **INSPIRATION** *Blade* meets *Resident Evil*.

PITCH In plague-ridden Shroudkeep, four vampire families control the city's factories. Magic is outlawed and workers are suffering. However, rebellion brews in secret, and you're the spark that can burn the vampires down.

Campaign Overview

This slow-burn, grim horror campaign relies on the party balancing subtlety with action. Stealth, sabotage and careful alliances will help them evade notice for a time. But if they delay too long, they'll find themselves caught in the vampires' merciless grip.

Life is hard in the industrial city of **Shroudkeep**. The city's textile factories are booming, but the plague-ridden slums show signs of worker exploitation and unrest. The city guard, the **Sentinels**, stalk the streets for signs of rebellion and magic. Here, like everywhere in the country of **Desolamus**, magic is outlawed.

The city's power lies with four ancient vampire families, whose wealth and influence permeate every layer of the city's fabric trade. They fund factories, own housing and employ mortal intermediaries to manage their affairs.

The party begin as downtrodden locals, but they're soon drawn into a resistance. Their mission seems impossible: dismantle the vampires' stranglehold on the city by disrupting production, empowering the underground **League of Magebreakers** rebel group, and giving factory workers the hope to fight back.

Lore and Mechanics

- **PLAGUE CONTAGION** The awful virus affecting the city spreads from worker to worker, especially in the factories of the Hems. Players must test their constitution every day – on a failure, they receive a point of exhaustion as the virus takes hold.
- **MAGIC IS BANNED** If the party use magic in public, they will be reported to the Sentinels by locals.
- **HOPE AND INFAMY** Track the players' influence around the city. Helping those who are suffering will bring hope to others, and encourage locals to help them in the future. Destroying city property will gain the party infamy, and draw the notice of the Sentinels.
- **CURSE OF SHROUDKEEP** The presence of the city's vampiric rulers brings with it an unholy curse. When a character drops to 0 HP, there is a chance they might rise as a zombie, ghast, or even vampire spawn.
- **TRUST NO ONE** Vampire spawn hide in plain sight across Shroudkeep. The party should expect to be betrayed by NPCs, even those who seem trustworthy.

Key Locations

- **SHROUDKEEP** The city stretches from the weather-worn Old Town, to the overpopulated warren of the Hems, up to the luxurious mansions of Silk Street.
- **SUNHOLLOW SANCTUARY** Once the Old Town's most prolific cathedral, now derelict and abandoned. Its crypt serves as a meeting spot for the rebel group.
- **HARROWMERE HALL** The influential vampire families meet here once a month for a blood-soaked banquet. It's a dour, stone building with a haunting reputation.

Important Characters

- **RANULF CHANDLER** A spy working for the city guard, Ranulf is trying to infiltrate the rebel group.
- **DOCTOR GOJKO BABIC** The leader of Shroudkeep's secret resistance movement is also a prominent physician, who can help treat plague symptoms.
- **LADY ULIVER GREYBENCH** Vocal critic of the city's leaders. Meeting with her draws the ire of the vampires.

Inciting Incident

After a factory collapse in the Hems kills dozens, the party are framed by the Sentinels, Shroudkeep's brutal city guards. The party manage to escape, but with their faces on wanted posters around the city, they are forced into hiding. In the slums, they meet Doctor Gojko Babic, an expert on the plague affecting the city; he offers them a safehouse, and lets them in on his plan to fight back against Shroudkeep's oppressors.

Session Zero Questions

- What is your job, and how does it bring you grief?
- Why would the city guards have their eye on you?
- Do you have magic? If so, how do you hide it?
- Who do you know who has been affected by the plague? Have you lost anyone through illness?
- When travelling home late at night, what is the one thing you dread you might see?

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Fey Campaign: The Long Road South

TONE Wondrous exploration in an uncharted world.

INSPIRATION *The Hobbit* meets *Breath of the Wild*.

PITCH Explore a lush open world that has become overrun by fey magic. Navigate the wilderness, befriend strange creatures and characters, and uncover the truth behind a growing natural imbalance in Jaroslava.

Campaign Overview

This is a campaign of expedition and survival – exploring the open road and finding what's over the next hill. It will take wit and willpower for the party to navigate the wilderness and achieve their goals, but they'll encounter incredible people and places as they go.

Jaroslava is a young world, still alive with divine magic. The god **Autumnus** recently tore the Fey Veil after a disagreement with his siblings, unleashing chaos and mischievous fey beings across the Material Plane. As a result, the world is transforming around its citizens and even familiar journeys have grown unpredictable.

In the north, the villagers of **Sauramota** are nervous about their next migration south, which is due to begin in two months. They decide to send out an advance scouting party, charged with forging a new path to the distant southern capital city, **Stoix**. On their journey, the party must traverse the mighty **Rainforest Colossal**, and the treacherous **Diamondbreath Ridge**, mapping the changes to the landscape and any unexpected obstacles. Once in Stoix, they can seek wisdom and blessings from the **Panthropos Assembly**, before returning home with knowledge to guide their people.

Lore and Mechanics

- OPEN WORLD The wilds of Jaroslava are vast and uncharted. The land is full of caves, rivers, valleys, forests and shrines, each with their own secrets.
- RESOURCE MANAGEMENT To make the wilds feel real, the party must manage food, water and weapon durability. Their gear will degrade over time and supplies won't last forever. Encourage a sense of adaptability and scavenging, they'll need to rely on what they find in the world, rather than hoarding equipment. Without restocking, they'll face exhaustion.
- FEY INFLUENCE The tear in the Fey Veil has had a huge influence on the world. Mischief makers will try to trick the party and dangerous creatures with bizarre abilities roam the wilds. Strange fey shrines have appeared, and will reveal magic items to those with the patience to complete their puzzles.
- SIDE QUESTS Most people the party meet in the wilds will have jobs that they need help with. The party can be rewarded with supplies, knowledge or coin for completing side quests, aiding their onward journey.

Key Locations

- RAINFOREST COLOSSAL A warm and misty forest inhabited by enormous redwoods, massive wildlife and a knowledgable group called the **Fallow Guardians**.
- GERYON'S RANCH A farm of giant animals between the Rainforest Colossal and Diamondbreath Ridge. Geryon's Ranch is a great rest stop for a weary party.
- DIAMONDBREATH RIDGE Jagged mountain peaks made of both rock and solid diamond. It is supposedly the home of a fire-breathing red dragon.

Important Characters

- DRYFF GUINHOP Sauramota's chief elder, and keen firefly keeper. He makes the tough decision to send a group of villagers on the long road south to Stoix.
- BHURJ WONDERGREEN A travelling fey merchant, Bhurj has many rare magical trinkets to trade.
- VENDEL WINKWORTH This trickster quest-giver finds ways to intercept the party's path again and again.

Inciting Incident

In Sauramota, villagers are noticing bizarre changes to the natural world. Insects in nearby hives grow ten sizes bigger overnight, and locals fall ill after ordinarily edible fish develop strange rainbow-hued scales. The elders fear the community's upcoming migration will be a deadly journey without knowledgeable guides. They gather the party and ask them to act as scouts, mapping a new, safe path for their people to follow.

Session Zero Questions

- What is your role in Sauramota? How do you help the village thrive and gather resources?
- Have you ever spent time away from Sauramota?
- What strange thing did you recently see in the forest, that you felt shouldn't have been there?
- Who are your closest friends in Sauramota?
- What stories have you heard about the Fey Realm?

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Entry Keywords

Throughout the book, each entry is marked with keywords to help you quickly find what you need. These same keywords are used as categories in the book's index.

Character

These entries all start with the **CHARACTER** label, followed by three more keywords:

CHARACTER • ATTITUDE • SPECIES • ROLE

The character's **ATTITUDE** is either FRIENDLY, NEUTRAL or HOSTILE. This indicates how they interact with the party, how willing they are to help, and how easy they are to persuade.

The character's **SPECIES** describes their lineage. This could be a humanoid species such as HALFLING, DWARF or ELF. In some cases, the species given is a creature type, such as DRAGON, FEY or CELESTIAL. The character's **SPECIES** gives your players a physical description, and determines in-game abilities, features and resistances.

The character's **ROLE** explains what skills or tasks they specialise in. There are 14 options:

1. ARTISAN – Known for making or crafting specific items.
2. COMBATANT – Demonstrates significant fighting skill.
3. ENTERTAINER – Performs for or entertains an audience.
4. GUARD – Provides security for a person or place.
5. LABOURER – Employed in manual work.
6. MERCHANT – Sells or trades goods to make a living.
7. NATURALIST– Has a close affiliation with nature.
8. NOBLE – Holds an elite position of influence.
9. OFFICIAL – Carries out administrative work or duties.
10. OUTLAW – Regularly commits acts that break the law.
11. SAGE – Has specialist knowledge or wisdom to share.
12. SPELLCASTER – Has honed their magical abilities.
13. WAYFARER – Is a frequent traveller, scout or guide.
14. WORSHIPPER – Has a connection to divine forces.

Creature

These entries all start with the **CREATURE** label, followed by three more keywords:

CREATURE • SIZE • ATTITUDE • TYPE

Creature **SIZE** ranges from TINY to GARGANTUAN.

The creature's **ATTITUDE** is either FRIENDLY, NEUTRAL or HOSTILE. This indicates how likely they are to attack the party on sight.

Creature **TYPE** relates to a monster category from the 5E Basic Rules, such as BEAST, OOZE, or UNDEAD.

Deity

These entries all start with the **DEITY** label, followed by two more keywords:

DEITY • ALIGNMENT • PRESENCE

Deity **ALIGNMENT** is either LAWFUL, NEUTRAL or CHAOTIC. Deities are not given a good or evil alignment, and can be followed by characters of any alignment.

The deity's **PRESENCE** is either DISTANT or INVOLVED. This indicates how likely they are to meddle in the affairs of mortals and the Material Plane, and how easy it is for worshippers to commune with them.

Faction

These entries all start with the **FACTION** label, followed by three more keywords:

FACTION • SIZE (RANGE) • ATTITUDE • PURPOSE

Faction **SIZE** ranges from MICRO (1–5 MEMBERS) to HUGE (100+ MEMBERS).

The faction's **ATTITUDE** is either FRIENDLY, NEUTRAL or HOSTILE. This indicates how open the group are to new joiners, and the general attitude of its members.

The faction's PURPOSE relates to the interest or goal its members share. There are nine categories:

1. ACADEMIC – Societies of knowledge and learning.
2. CIVIC – Groups who look after public services.
3. COMMERCE – Trade organisations and merchant guilds.
4. CRIMINAL – Organised crime networks and gangs.
5. ENTERTAINMENT – Troupes of performers and players.
6. INDUSTRY – Manufacturing companies.
7. MILITARY – Armed forces following shared orders.
8. RELIGIOUS – Groups who share spiritual beliefs.
9. SOCIAL – Recreational and shared-interest groups.

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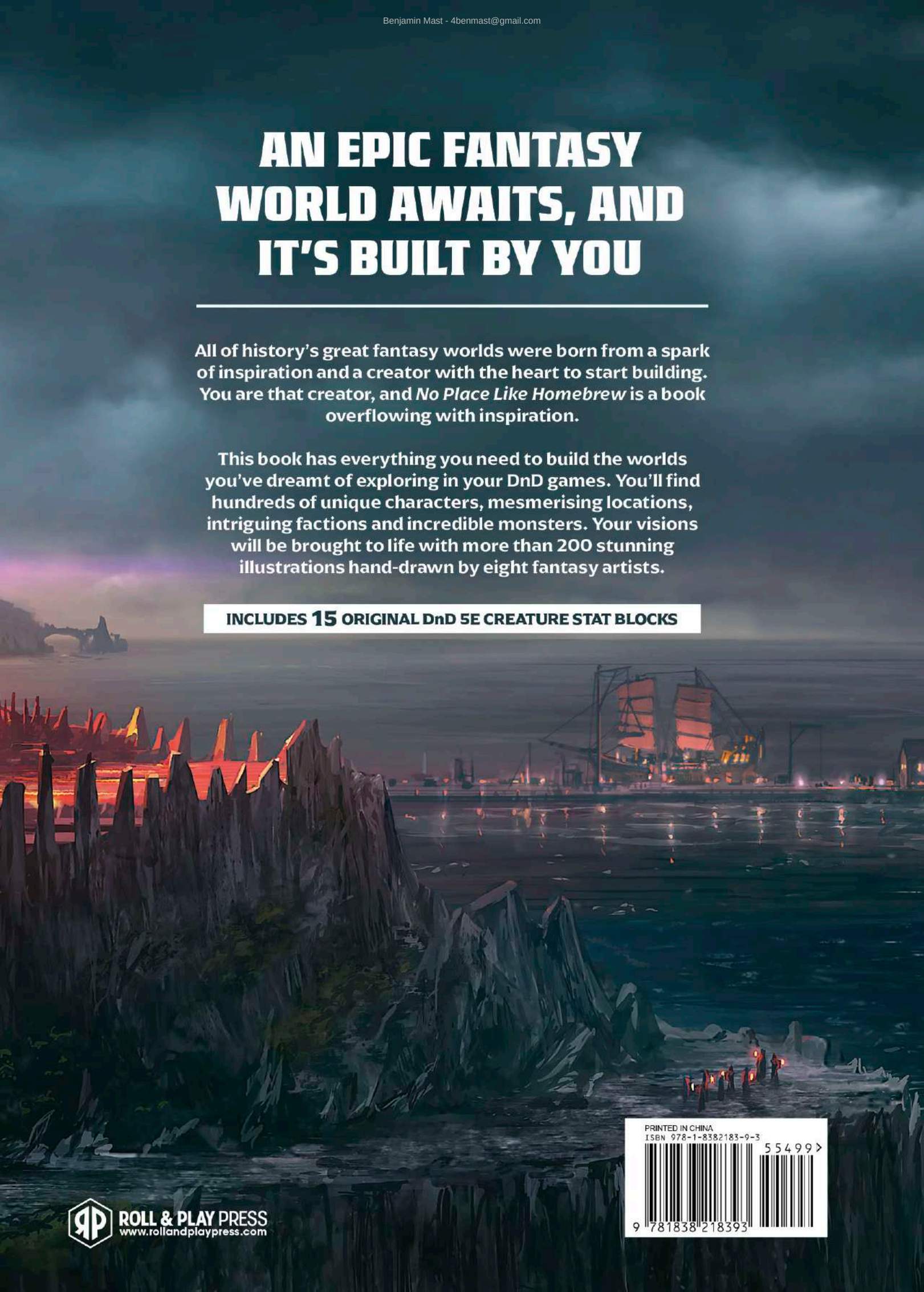

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